Statistical Supervised Machine Learning

Master MIASHS & MALIA

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Abstract

These lecture notes introduce supervised machine learning, from its mathematical foundations to the algorithms that are used in practice and to the theory that explains why they work. *Part I* gathers the mathematical background needed throughout the course: norms, derivatives, convex sets and convex functions, and convex optimization, with the optimality conditions, the gradient descent algorithms and the Lagrangian duality that underlie most learning methods.

Part II sets up the supervised learning problem. It describes the data and the main learning tasks, introduces the framework of statistical learning theory: empirical risk minimization and generalization bounds, and details the learning procedure: how to train a model, how to tune its hyper-parameters and how to evaluate it with performance measures adapted to regression and classification. It then presents the main supervised algorithms: surrogate losses, k-nearest neighbours, support vector machines, linear and logistic regression, multinomial logistic regression, kernel regression, decision trees and neural networks. For each of them, we describe the model, the optimization problem it solves and the way it is used in practice.

Part III goes one step further. It comes back to statistical learning theory through the decomposition of the error into bias, variance, approximation and estimation terms, and uses it to explain why combining models works: bagging and random forests, boosting, stacking and gradient boosting. Metric learning and practical advice on learning with real data complete this part.

Part IV presents PAC-Bayesian theory, a framework whose object of study is a distribution over models, that is, precisely what an ensemble method learns. It derives generalization bounds that certify the risk of majority votes, explains the role of the diversity of the voters, and shows how minimizing these bounds leads to *self-bounding* algorithms, which output a model together with a guarantee on its risk.

Each notion is illustrated with examples, figures and exercises with their solutions. For neural networks but also for all other basic topics we are dealing with in these notes, we warmly recommend the video lectures of Hugo Larochelle, an excellent complement to the corresponding section.

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How to read these notes

The notes are organized in four parts, which can be read in order. We warmly recommend the reader to start with Part I which can be seen as a toolbox: readers familiar with convex optimization can skip it and come back to it when a result is needed. It also contains some basics or required results in Probability with the main inequalities that are going to be used in the remaining parts. Part II is the core of the course, mainly for the first year of master students, presenting the general setting of (supervised) learning and the main algorithm the reader is going to meet it the future. Part III is devoted to ensemble methods with the presentation of three mains algorithms: **bagging, boosting and stacking** and Part IV develops the PAC-Bayesian theory of ensemble methods. This part offers a new vision of the learning process. The last part is mainly for Master 2 students due its theoretical aspect. It requires to feel comfortable with basics in probability and statistical learning.

Prerequisites. Basic linear algebra (vectors, matrices, inner products), differential calculus in several variables, and probability (expectation, variance, independence, the law of large numbers).

Part I

Mathematical background

Machine learning algorithms are, for the most part, solutions of optimization problems: a model is learned by minimizing a criterion that measures how badly it fits the data, often with a penalty on its complexity. This first part recalls the mathematical tools needed to write, understand and solve such problems. Since models are learned from random data, Section 1 first recalls the probability needed to describe this randomness: expectations, conditional expectations, limit theorems and the concentration inequalities that turn an error measured on a sample into a guarantee on unseen data. Section 2 gathers the notions of linear algebra and convexity (norms, derivatives, convex sets and convex functions); Section 3 studies unconstrained smooth convex optimization, its optimality conditions and the gradient descent algorithms that underlie most learning methods; Section 4 deals with constrained problems, Lagrangian duality and the Karush–Kuhn–Tucker conditions, which are the key to support vector machines. These reminders are essential to understand the calculations and properties of the algorithms presented later, and the way solvers work. For further details on convexity and convex optimization, we refer to Boyd and Vandenberghe (2004).

1 Probability Essentials and Concentration Inequalities

Machine learning is about learning from *data*, and data are random: the examples that we observe could have been different, and the examples on which our model will be used are not known yet. Probability theory is the language that allows us to describe this randomness, to define precisely what a "good" model is, and, above all, to quantify how much we can trust what we measure on a finite sample. This first section gathers the notions of probability used throughout the notes. It starts from scratch, with intuition and examples (a very readable complement is the book of Wasserman (2004)), so that it can be read by students who have not practised probability for a while, but it remains rigorous, since the results stated here are used in the proofs of the following sections.

About this section

Guiding question. *A classifier makes* 12% *of errors on* 1000 *examples: what does this tell us about the errors it will make on new examples, and how confident can we be?*

In this section you will learn to:

- *describe a random experiment with a probability space, random variables and their distributions (probability mass functions, densities, cumulative distribution functions), and use the i.i.d. assumption that underlies supervised learning;*
- *compute expectations, variances and conditional expectations, and recognize that the risk of a predictor is an expectation and the empirical risk an average;*
- *state the law of large numbers and the central limit theorem, and explain why they are not sufficient to certify a learning algorithm;*
- *prove and use the union bound and the inequalities of Markov, Chebyshev, Chernoff and Hoeffding, use those of Bernstein and McDiarmid, and turn them into statements "with probability at least* $1-\delta$*" and into sample sizes.*

In a nutshell

The true performance of a model is an *expectation* over the unknown distribution of the data; what we can compute is an *average* over a finite sample. The law of large numbers says that the average converges to the expectation; *concentration inequalities* say how far apart they can be for a given sample size m, with a given confidence. Typically, the deviation is of order $\sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)/m}$: to halve the uncertainty, one needs four times more data, whereas a much higher confidence costs very little.

Throughout the section, we use the following running question: a classifier h has been fixed (for instance, it was trained on other data), and we evaluate it on m new examples on which it makes $\widehat{p}$ errors in proportion. What can we say about its true error rate p? We will meet this question again and again, with sharper and sharper answers.

1.1 Probability spaces, random variables and distributions

Random experiments

A *random experiment* is an experiment whose outcome cannot be predicted with certainty: rolling a die, drawing a customer at random in a database, observing tomorrow's

temperature, or drawing a training sample. Its mathematical description is a probability space.

Definition 1.1: Probability space

A probability space is a triple $(\Omega, \mathcal{F}, \mathbb{P})$ where

- Ω is the set of all possible outcomes ω of the experiment (the *sample space*);
- $\mathcal{F}$ is a collection of subsets of Ω, called *events*, which contains Ω and is stable under complement and countable unions (a σ-algebra);
- $\mathbb{P} : \mathcal{F} \to [0,1]$ is a *probability measure*: $\mathbb{P}(\Omega) = 1$ and, for every sequence $(A_k)_{k\geq 1}$ of pairwise disjoint events,

$$\mathbb{P}\Big(\bigcup_{k\geq 1} A_k\Big) = \sum_{k\geq 1} \mathbb{P}(A_k) \qquad (\sigma\text{-additivity}).$$

The σ-algebra is mathematical tool that we will not discuss further since it is not essential for the remaining sections. The axioms immediately give the rules that you already know for several years such as: $\mathbb{P}(\emptyset) = 0$, $\mathbb{P}(A^c) = 1 - \mathbb{P}(A)$, $\mathbb{P}(A) \leq \mathbb{P}(B)$ if $A \subseteq B$, and $\mathbb{P}(A \cup B) = \mathbb{P}(A) + \mathbb{P}(B) - \mathbb{P}(A \cap B)$.

Example 1.1. For a fair die, $\Omega = \{1, \ldots, 6\}$, every subset is an event and $\mathbb{P}(A) = |A|/6$. The event "the result is even" is $A = \{2, 4, 6\}$ and $\mathbb{P}(A) = 1/2$. For two independent tosses of a coin with probability p of heads, $\Omega = \{HH, HT, TH, TT\}$ and $\mathbb{P}(\{HT\}) = p(1-p)$.

The *conditional probability* of A given an event B with $\mathbb{P}(B) > 0$ is $\mathbb{P}(A \mid B) = \mathbb{P}(A \cap B)/\mathbb{P}(B)$: it is the proportion of the outcomes of B that also belong to A. If $(B_k)_k$ is a partition of Ω into events of positive probability, we get the *law of total probability* and *Bayes' formula*:

$$\mathbb{P}(A) = \sum_k \mathbb{P}(A \mid B_k)\, \mathbb{P}(B_k), \qquad \mathbb{P}(B_j \mid A) = \frac{\mathbb{P}(A \mid B_j)\, \mathbb{P}(B_j)}{\sum_k \mathbb{P}(A \mid B_k)\, \mathbb{P}(B_k)}. \tag{1.1}$$

Random variables and their distributions

In practice, we are not interested in the outcome ω itself, but in numbers computed from it: the size of a customer, the label of an image, the number of errors of a classifier.

Definition 1.2: Random variable, distribution, cumulative distribution function

A (real) random variable is a function $X : \Omega \to \mathbb{R}$ such that $\{X \leq t\} = \{\omega \in \Omega : X(\omega) \leq t\}$ is an event for every $t \in \mathbb{R}$. The distribution (or *law*) of X is the probability $\mathbb{P}_X$ on $\mathbb{R}$ defined by $\mathbb{P}_X(B) = \mathbb{P}(X \in B)$, and its cumulative distribution function (cdf) is

$$F_X(t) = \mathbb{P}(X \leq t), \qquad t \in \mathbb{R}.$$

A cdf is non-decreasing, right-continuous, tends to 0 at $-\infty$ and to 1 at $+\infty$, and it characterizes the distribution: two random variables with the same cdf have the same distribution, which we write $X \sim Y$ (or $X \sim \mathbb{P}_X$). Two kinds of distributions will cover all our needs.

- X is discrete if it takes its values in a finite or countable set $\{x_1, x_2, \ldots\}$. Its distribution is described by its *probability mass function* (pmf) $p_X(x_k) = \mathbb{P}(X = x_k)$, with $\sum_k p_X(x_k) = 1$, and $\mathbb{P}(X \in B) = \sum_{k:x_k \in B} p_X(x_k)$.
- X is continuous (or *has a density*) if there exists a nonnegative function f_X with $\int_{\mathbb{R}} f_X(x)\,dx = 1$ such that $\mathbb{P}(X \in [a,b]) = \int_a^b f_X(x)\,dx$ for all $a \le b$. Then $F_X(t) = \int_{-\infty}^t f_X(x)\,dx$ and $f_X = F_X'$ wherever f_X is continuous.

> **Pitfall** A density is *not* a probability: $f_X(x)$ can be larger than 1 (see the density of $\mathcal{N}(1, 0.25)$ in Fig. 1), and for a continuous variable $\mathbb{P}(X = x) = 0$ for every x. Only areas under the density are probabilities.

The following distributions will appear everywhere in this course.

- Bernoulli $\mathcal{B}(p)$, $p \in [0,1]$: $X \in \{0,1\}$ with $\mathbb{P}(X = 1) = p$. It models any yes/no outcome; in particular, the indicator $\mathbb{1}_{\{h(\mathbf{x}) \neq y\}}$ that a classifier h errs on a random example $(\mathbf{x}, y)$ is a Bernoulli variable whose parameter is the error rate of h.
- Binomial $\mathrm{Bin}(m,p)$: the number of successes in m independent Bernoulli trials of parameter p, with $\mathbb{P}(X = k) = \binom{m}{k} p^k (1-p)^{m-k}$ for $k \in \{0, \ldots, m\}$. The number of errors of a fixed classifier on m independent test examples is binomial.
- Uniform $\mathcal{U}([a,b])$, $a < b$: density $f(x) = \frac{1}{b-a}$ on $[a,b]$ and 0 elsewhere. All the sub-intervals of $[a,b]$ of the same length have the same probability.
- Gaussian (or normal) $\mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$, $\mu \in \mathbb{R}$, $\sigma > 0$: density $f(x) = \frac{1}{\sigma\sqrt{2\pi}} \exp\left(-\frac{(x-\mu)^2}{2\sigma^2}\right)$. If $X \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$, then $(X - \mu)/\sigma \sim \mathcal{N}(0,1)$, whose cdf is denoted by Φ.

There exist several other distributions, discrete or continuous ones, some of them will be presented later such as the Beta or the Dirichlet distribution that will be introduced in the PAC-Bayesian part of this document.

Random vectors, joint distributions and independence

A random vector $\mathbf{X} = (X_1, \ldots, X_d)$ is a vector of random variables defined on the same probability space; its distribution on $\mathbb{R}^d$ is called the *joint distribution* of $X_1, \ldots, X_d$. In supervised learning, the pair $(\mathbf{x}, y)$ made of a description $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and of a label y is a random vector, whose joint distribution is the (unknown) distribution $\mathcal{D}$ of the data.

The distribution of a single component is called a *marginal distribution*; it is obtained by summing (or integrating) the joint pmf (or density) over the other components. For instance, for two discrete variables,

$$\mathbb{P}(X = x) = \sum_y \mathbb{P}(X = x, Y = y), \qquad \text{and, with densities,} \quad f_X(x) = \int_{\mathbb{R}} f_{X,Y}(x,y)\,dy.$$

The marginals do *not* determine the joint distribution: knowing the distribution of the heights and the distribution of the weights of a population does not tell us how heights

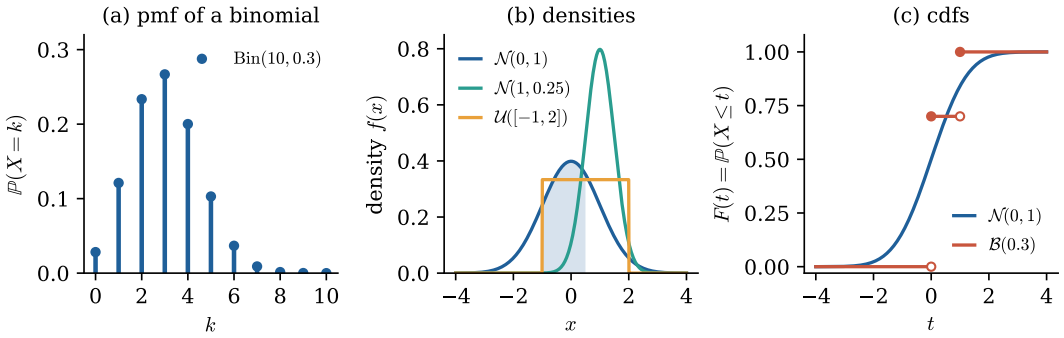


Figure 1: (a) The pmf of the binomial distribution $\mathrm{Bin}(10, 0.3)$, e.g. the number of errors on 10 test examples of a classifier with error rate 0.3. (b) Densities of two Gaussian distributions and of a uniform distribution; the shaded area is $\mathbb{P}(-1 \leq X \leq 0.5)$ for $X \sim \mathcal{N}(0,1)$, and a density can exceed 1. (c) The cdf of $\mathcal{N}(0,1)$ is continuous, while the cdf of the Bernoulli distribution $\mathcal{B}(0.3)$ is a step function, which jumps by $\mathbb{P}(X = x)$ at each value x (filled dots: value of the cdf at the jump).

and weights are related. Independence is the special case where there is no relation at all.

Definition 1.3: Independence

Random variables $X_1, \ldots, X_n$ are (mutually) independent if, for all sets $B_1, \ldots, B_n$,

$$\mathbb{P}(X_1 \in B_1, \ldots, X_n \in B_n) = \prod_{i=1}^{n} \mathbb{P}(X_i \in B_i).$$

Equivalently, the joint pmf (or the joint density) is the product of the marginal ones. They are independent and identically distributed (*i.i.d.*) if, moreover, they all have the same distribution.

If $X_1, \ldots, X_n$ are independent, then so are $g_1(X_1), \ldots, g_n(X_n)$ for any functions $g_1, \ldots, g_n$, and so are functions of disjoint groups of variables, such as $X_1 + X_2$ and $X_3 X_4$.

Pitfall Independence of all pairs does not imply mutual independence. Let X_1, X_2 be independent and uniform on $\{-1, +1\}$, and $X_3 = X_1 X_2$. Each pair is independent, but X_3 is a function of (X_1, X_2): knowing X_1 and X_2, we know X_3.

The i.i.d. assumption in machine learning

Throughout the notes, we assume that the examples of the learning sample $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ are drawn *independently* from the *same* distribution $\mathcal{D}$ over $\mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{Y}$, and that the future examples on which the model will be used are drawn from $\mathcal{D}$ as well. We write $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$, where $\mathcal{D}^m$ denotes the product distribution: the sample S is itself a random object, and every quantity computed from it (the empirical risk, the learned model, its accuracy on a test set) is a random variable.

This assumption is what makes learning possible at all. "Identically distributed" means that the past is representative of the future: the examples we learn from look like the examples on which we will predict. "Independent" means that each new example brings new information: the empirical risk then becomes an average of independent variables, and all the tools of this section apply to it.

Remark The i.i.d. assumption is a model, and it can fail in practice: time series (today's stock price depends on yesterday's), groups of correlated examples (several images of the same patient, several sales of the same customer), duplicates between training and test data, or a distribution that changes over time (*distribution shift*). In these cases, the guarantees of this course do not apply as such, and the evaluation protocol must be adapted, for instance by splitting the data by patient or by date (see Section 6 and the following sections).

1.2 Expectation, variance and conditional expectation

Expectation

The expectation of a random variable is its mean value, where each possible value is weighted by its probability. It is the "centre of mass" of its distribution.

Definition 1.4: Expectation

Let X be a random variable.

- If X is discrete with values $x_1, x_2, \dots$ and $\sum_k |x_k|\, \mathbb{P}(X = x_k) < +\infty$, its expectation is $\mathbb{E}[X] = \sum_k x_k\, \mathbb{P}(X = x_k)$.
- If X has a density f_X and $\int |x| f_X(x)\, dx < +\infty$, its expectation is $\mathbb{E}[X] = \int_{\mathbb{R}} x\, f_X(x)\, dx$.

More generally, for a function $g : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ (and in the same way for a random vector $\mathbf{X}$ and $g : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}$),

$$\mathbb{E}[g(X)] = \sum_k g(x_k)\, \mathbb{P}(X = x_k) \qquad \text{or} \qquad \mathbb{E}[g(X)] = \int_{\mathbb{R}} g(x)\, f_X(x)\, dx,$$

whenever the sum or the integral converges absolutely. The expectation of a random vector is the vector of the expectations of its components.

The last formula (sometimes called the *transfer theorem*) is very convenient: to compute $\mathbb{E}[X^2]$ or $\mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda X}]$, we do not need the distribution of X^2 or of $e^{\lambda X}$, only that of X. When the expectation is taken with respect to a variable whose distribution must be made explicit, we write it below the symbol, as in $\mathbb{E}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}[\ell(h(\mathbf{x}), y)]$ or $\mathbb{E}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}[\cdot]$.

Example 1.2.

- If $X \sim \mathcal{B}(p)$, then $\mathbb{E}[X] = 0 \times (1-p) + 1 \times p = p$.
- If $X \sim \mathcal{U}([a,b])$, then $\mathbb{E}[X] = \frac{1}{b-a} \int_a^b x\, dx = \frac{a+b}{2}$.

- If $X \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$, then $\mathbb{E}[X] = \mu$ (the density is symmetric around μ), and $\mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda X}] = e^{\lambda\mu + \lambda^2\sigma^2/2}$ for every $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$ (complete the square in the exponent).
- For the indicator $\mathbb{1}_A$ of an event A (equal to 1 on A and 0 elsewhere), $\mathbb{E}[\mathbb{1}_A] = \mathbb{P}(A)$.

Even they are some basic examples, they can be considered as exercises for those who need to manipulate the expectation.

Proposition 1.1: Properties of the expectation

Let X, Y be random variables with finite expectations, and $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$.

(i) Linearity: $\mathbb{E}[aX + bY] = a\,\mathbb{E}[X] + b\,\mathbb{E}[Y]$, whether or not X and Y are independent.

(ii) Monotonicity: if $X \geq 0$ almost surely, then $\mathbb{E}[X] \geq 0$; hence $X \leq Y$ implies $\mathbb{E}[X] \leq \mathbb{E}[Y]$. Moreover, $|\,\mathbb{E}[X]| \leq \mathbb{E}\,|X|$.

(iii) Indicators: for every event A, $\mathbb{E}[\mathbb{1}_A] = \mathbb{P}(A)$.

(iv) Independence: if X and Y are independent, then $\mathbb{E}[XY] = \mathbb{E}[X]\,\mathbb{E}[Y]$; more generally, $\mathbb{E}[g(X)k(Y)] = \mathbb{E}[g(X)]\,\mathbb{E}[k(Y)]$ for all functions g, k such that these expectations are finite. In particular, for independent $X_1, \ldots, X_n$ and $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$, $\mathbb{E}\left[e^{\lambda \sum_i X_i}\right] = \prod_i \mathbb{E}\left[e^{\lambda X_i}\right]$.

(v) Tail formula: if $X \geq 0$, then

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \int_0^{+\infty} \mathbb{P}(X > t)\, dt,$$

and, if X takes values in $\mathbb{N}$, $\mathbb{E}[X] = \sum_{k \geq 1} \mathbb{P}(X \geq k)$.

Proof. (i)–(iii) follow from the linearity and the monotonicity of sums and integrals. For (iv) in the discrete case,

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}[XY] &= \sum_{x,y} xy\ \mathbb{P}(X = x, Y = y) = \sum_{x,y} xy\ \mathbb{P}(X = x)\,\mathbb{P}(Y = y) \\ &= \Big(\sum_x x\ \mathbb{P}(X = x)\Big)\Big(\sum_y y\ \mathbb{P}(Y = y)\Big),\end{aligned}$$

and the case of densities is identical, with integrals; the product formula for $e^{\lambda \sum_i X_i} = \prod_i e^{\lambda X_i}$ follows by induction on n. For (v), write $X = \int_0^X dt = \int_0^{+\infty} \mathbb{1}_{\{t<X\}}\, dt$ and exchange the expectation and the integral (this is allowed for nonnegative integrands, by Tonelli's theorem):

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \mathbb{E}\Big[\int_0^{+\infty} \mathbb{1}_{\{t<X\}}\, dt\Big] = \int_0^{+\infty} \mathbb{E}\left[\mathbb{1}_{\{t<X\}}\right] dt = \int_0^{+\infty} \mathbb{P}(X > t)\, dt.$$

For an integer-valued variable, $\mathbb{P}(X > t) = \mathbb{P}(X \geq k)$ for $t \in [k-1, k)$, which gives the sum. □

Remark Linearity holds *without any independence assumption*, and this is what makes it so useful: the expected number of errors of a classifier on m examples is m times its error rate, even if the examples were not independent. On the contrary, the product rule (iv) requires independence: if $X \sim \mathcal{B}(1/2)$, then $\mathbb{E}[X \cdot X] = 1/2 \neq 1/4 = \mathbb{E}[X]^2$.

Variance and covariance

The expectation tells us where a variable is on average; the variance tells us how much it fluctuates around this average.

Definition 1.5: Variance, covariance

Let X, Y be random variables with $\mathbb{E}[X^2] < +\infty$ and $\mathbb{E}[Y^2] < +\infty$. The variance of X and the covariance of X and Y are

$$\begin{aligned} \operatorname{Var}(X) &= \mathbb{E}\left[(X - \mathbb{E}[X])^2\right] = \mathbb{E}[X^2] - \mathbb{E}[X]^2, \\ \operatorname{Cov}(X, Y) &= \mathbb{E}\left[(X - \mathbb{E}[X])(Y - \mathbb{E}[Y])\right] = \mathbb{E}[XY] - \mathbb{E}[X]\,\mathbb{E}[Y]. \end{aligned}$$

The standard deviation of X is $\sigma_X = \sqrt{\operatorname{Var}(X)}$, which has the same unit as X.

Proposition 1.2: Properties of the variance

Let $X, X_1, \ldots, X_m$ be random variables with finite second moments and $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$.

(i) $\operatorname{Var}(aX + b) = a^2 \operatorname{Var}(X)$, and $\operatorname{Var}(X) = 0$ if and only if X is almost surely constant.

(ii) $\operatorname{Var}\left(\sum_{i=1}^{m} X_i\right) = \sum_{i=1}^{m} \operatorname{Var}(X_i) + 2 \sum_{i<j} \operatorname{Cov}(X_i, X_j)$.

(iii) If $X_1, \ldots, X_m$ are independent (or only pairwise uncorrelated), the variance of the sum is the sum of the variances. In particular, if they are i.i.d. with variance σ^2, the empirical mean $\bar{X}_m = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m} X_i$ satisfies

$$\mathbb{E}[\bar{X}_m] = \mathbb{E}[X_1] \qquad \text{and} \qquad \operatorname{Var}(\bar{X}_m) = \frac{\sigma^2}{m}.$$

(iv) Bounded variables: if $a \leq X \leq b$ almost surely, then $\operatorname{Var}(X) \leq \frac{(b-a)^2}{4}$.

Proof. (i) and (ii) follow from the definition by expanding the squares and using the linearity of the expectation. (iii) Independence implies $\operatorname{Cov}(X_i, X_j) = 0$ by Theorem 1.1 (iv); then $\operatorname{Var}(\bar{X}_m) = \frac{1}{m^2}\sum_i \operatorname{Var}(X_i) = \frac{\sigma^2}{m}$. (iv) For every $c \in \mathbb{R}$, $\mathbb{E}[(X-c)^2] = \operatorname{Var}(X) + (\mathbb{E}[X] - c)^2 \geq \operatorname{Var}(X)$; with $c = \frac{a+b}{2}$, $|X - c| \leq \frac{b-a}{2}$, hence $\operatorname{Var}(X) \leq \mathbb{E}[(X-c)^2] \leq \frac{(b-a)^2}{4}$. □

The formula $\operatorname{Var}(\bar{X}_m) = \sigma^2/m$ is the first quantitative statement about averages in this course: the standard deviation of an average of m independent measurements

decreases as $\sigma/\sqrt{m}$. This $1/\sqrt{m}$ rate will appear in every generalization bound.

Example 1.3. If $X \sim \mathcal{B}(p)$, then $X^2 = X$, so that $\mathrm{Var}(X) = p - p^2 = p(1-p) \leq \frac{1}{4}$, with equality for $p = \frac{1}{2}$. If $X \sim \mathrm{Bin}(m, p)$, it is a sum of m independent Bernoulli variables, hence $\mathbb{E}[X] = mp$ and $\mathrm{Var}(X) = mp(1-p)$. For $X \sim \mathcal{U}([a,b])$, $\mathrm{Var}(X) = \frac{(b-a)^2}{12}$, and for $X \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$, $\mathrm{Var}(X) = \sigma^2$.

> **Pitfall** Independent variables are uncorrelated, but the converse is false. If X is uniform on $\{-1, 0, 1\}$ and $Y = X^2$, then $\mathrm{Cov}(X, Y) = \mathbb{E}[X^3] - \mathbb{E}[X]\,\mathbb{E}[X^2] = 0$, although Y is a function of X. The covariance only measures *linear* dependence.

Jensen's inequality

Expectation and nonlinear functions do not commute: in general $\mathbb{E}[g(X)] \neq g(\mathbb{E}[X])$. For convex functions, the two quantities are nevertheless always ordered. Recall (Definition 2.7 in Section 2) that f is convex if every chord of its graph lies above the graph.

Proposition 1.3: Jensen's inequality

Let X be a random variable with values in an interval I, with $\mathbb{E}\,|X| < +\infty$, and let $f : I \to \mathbb{R}$ be a convex function such that $\mathbb{E}\,|f(X)| < +\infty$. Then

$$f\big(\mathbb{E}[X]\big) \leq \mathbb{E}\,[f(X)].$$

If f is concave, the inequality is reversed: $\mathbb{E}[f(X)] \leq f(\mathbb{E}[X])$.

Proof. We give the proof for a differentiable convex function (the general case uses a supporting line instead of the tangent). Let $\mu = \mathbb{E}[X] \in I$. A differentiable convex function lies above its tangents (Theorem 2.6): $f(x) \geq f(\mu) + f'(\mu)(x - \mu)$ for every $x \in I$. Applying this with $x = X$ and taking the expectation, by monotonicity and linearity,

$$\mathbb{E}[f(X)] \geq f(\mu) + f'(\mu)\,\big(\mathbb{E}[X] - \mu\big) = f(\mu).$$

For a concave f, apply the result to the convex function $-f$. □

Jensen's inequality is used constantly in learning theory. With $f(x) = x^2$, it gives $\mathbb{E}[X]^2 \leq \mathbb{E}[X^2]$, i.e. $\mathrm{Var}(X) \geq 0$. With the concave functions $\sqrt{\cdot}$ and $\ln$, it gives $\mathbb{E}\,[\sqrt{Z}] \leq \sqrt{\mathbb{E}[Z]}$ and $\mathbb{E}[\ln Z] \leq \ln \mathbb{E}[Z]$ for $Z > 0$; with the convex function $\exp$, it gives $e^{\mathbb{E}[X]} \leq \mathbb{E}[e^X]$. The last two inequalities are the heart of the change of measure inequality of PAC-Bayesian theory (see Section 1.4).

> **Pitfall** $\mathbb{E}[1/X] \neq 1/\,\mathbb{E}[X]$ in general. For X uniform on $\{1, 3\}$, $\mathbb{E}[1/X] = \frac{2}{3}$ whereas $1/\,\mathbb{E}[X] = \frac{1}{2}$: by Jensen's inequality applied to the convex function $x \mapsto 1/x$ on $(0, +\infty)$, $\mathbb{E}[1/X] \geq 1/\,\mathbb{E}[X]$ for every positive X.

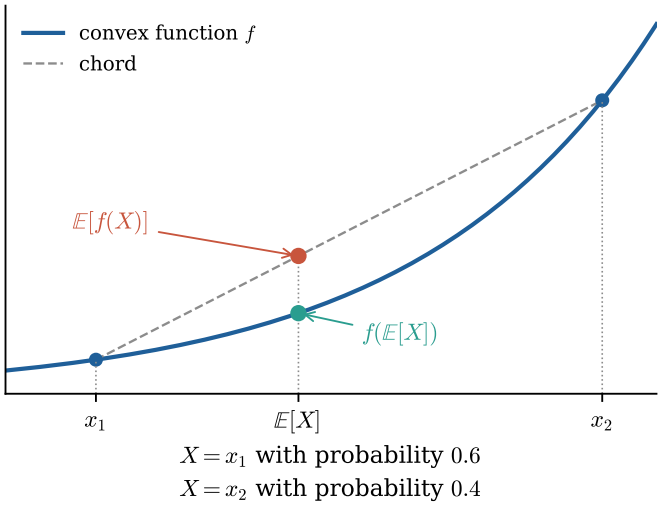


Figure 2: Jensen's inequality for a variable taking two values. $\mathbb{E}[f(X)]$ is a weighted average of $f(x_1)$ and $f(x_2)$, i.e. a point of the chord (red), while $f(\mathbb{E}[X])$ is the point of the graph (teal) at the same abscissa. For a convex f, the chord lies above the graph.

Conditional expectation

In supervised learning, we want to predict a label Y from a description X. The natural object is then the average value of Y *when* X *is known*: this is the conditional expectation.

Definition 1.6: Conditional expectation

Let X be a discrete random variable and Y a random variable with $\mathbb{E}\,|Y| < +\infty$. For every x such that $\mathbb{P}(X = x) > 0$, the conditional expectation of Y given $X = x$ is

$$\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X = x] = \frac{\mathbb{E}\left[Y\, \mathbb{1}_{\{X=x\}}\right]}{\mathbb{P}(X = x)} \left(= \sum_y y\, \mathbb{P}(Y = y \mid X = x) \quad \text{if } Y \text{ is discrete} \right).$$

Setting $g(x) = \mathbb{E}[Y \mid X = x]$, the conditional expectation of Y given X is the random variable $\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X] = g(X)$. When (X, Y) has a joint density $f_{X,Y}$, we define in the same way $g(x) = \int y\, f_{Y|X}(y \mid x)\, dy$ with the conditional density $f_{Y|X}(y \mid x) = f_{X,Y}(x, y)/f_X(x)$.

In words, $\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X = x]$ is the mean of Y over the sub-population of the outcomes for which $X = x$, and $\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X]$ is a *function of* X: it is the best guess of Y that we can make once we know X (we make this precise below). Conditional expectations are manipulated with the following rules.

Proposition 1.4: Properties of the conditional expectation

Let X, Y, Z be random variables with $\mathbb{E}\,|Y|, \mathbb{E}\,|Z| < +\infty$.

(i) Linearity: $\mathbb{E}[aY + bZ \mid X] = a\,\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X] + b\,\mathbb{E}[Z \mid X]$.

(ii) Tower property (law of total expectation): $\mathbb{E}\left[\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X]\right] = \mathbb{E}[Y]$, i.e. $\mathbb{E}[Y] = \sum_x \mathbb{E}[Y \mid X = x]\,\mathbb{P}(X = x)$ in the discrete case.

(iii) Taking out what is known: $\mathbb{E}[k(X)\,Y \mid X] = k(X)\,\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X]$ for every function k such that $\mathbb{E}\,|k(X)Y| < +\infty$.

(iv) Independence: if X and Y are independent, then $\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X] = \mathbb{E}[Y]$.

Proof. In the discrete case. (i) is the linearity of the expectation applied to $Y\mathbb{1}_{\{X=x\}}$ and $Z\mathbb{1}_{\{X=x\}}$. (ii) Since the events $\{X = x\}$ form a partition of Ω, $\sum_x \mathbb{1}_{\{X=x\}} = 1$ and

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}\left[\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X]\right] &= \sum_x \mathbb{E}[Y \mid X = x]\,\mathbb{P}(X = x) = \sum_x \mathbb{E}\left[Y\mathbb{1}_{\{X=x\}}\right] \\ &= \mathbb{E}\left[Y \sum_x \mathbb{1}_{\{X=x\}}\right] = \mathbb{E}[Y].\end{aligned}$$

(iii) On $\{X = x\}$, $k(X)Y = k(x)Y$, so $\mathbb{E}[k(X)Y \mid X = x] = k(x)\,\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X = x]$. (iv) By independence, $\mathbb{E}[Y\mathbb{1}_{\{X=x\}}] = \mathbb{E}[Y]\,\mathbb{P}(X = x)$. □

The tower property is a "divide and conquer" rule: to compute an expectation, first average within each group defined by X, then average the group means, weighted by the size of the groups. Applied to $Y = \mathbb{1}_A$, it gives back the law of total probability (1.1).

Risks are expectations

We can now write the central objects of supervised learning in the language of probability; they are studied in detail in Section 6, where they are denoted by $\mathcal{R}^\ell(h)$ and $\mathcal{R}^\ell_S(h)$ (we drop the loss ℓ from the notation in this section and we spend more time on it in Part II). Let $\ell(h(\mathbf{x}), y)$ be the loss incurred by a predictor h on an example $(\mathbf{x}, y)$.

- The true risk of h is the expected loss on a new example drawn from $\mathcal{D}$:

$$\mathcal{R}(h) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\left[\ell(h(\mathbf{x}), y)\right].$$

  For the 0-1 loss $\ell(h(\mathbf{x}), y) = \mathbb{1}_{\{h(\mathbf{x})\neq y\}}$, Theorem 1.1 (iii) shows that $\mathcal{R}(h) = \mathbb{P}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\left(h(\mathbf{x}) \neq y\right)$ is the probability of error of h.

- The empirical risk of h on the sample $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ is the average loss on the sample:

$$\mathcal{R}_S(h) = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \ell(h(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i).$$

If h is *fixed*, i.e. chosen independently of S, the variables $Z_i = \ell(h(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i)$ are i.i.d. with mean $\mathcal{R}(h)$, and Theorems 1.1 and 1.2 give

$$\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\mathcal{R}_S(h)\right] = \mathcal{R}(h) \qquad \text{and} \qquad \operatorname{Var}\left(\mathcal{R}_S(h)\right) = \frac{\operatorname{Var}(Z_1)}{m} \leq \frac{(b-a)^2}{4m} \quad \text{if} \quad \ell \in [a, b]. \tag{1.2}$$

The empirical risk is an *unbiased* estimator of the true risk, and its fluctuations decrease as $1/\sqrt{m}$. For the 0-1 loss, $m\,\mathcal{R}_S(h) \sim \mathrm{Bin}(m, \mathcal{R}(h))$ is the number of errors on the sample.

> **Pitfall** Equation (1.2) holds for a predictor fixed *before* seeing S. The predictor h_S returned by a learning algorithm depends on S, the losses $\ell(h_S(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i)$ are no longer independent of h_S, and in general $\mathbb{E}[\mathcal{R}_S(h_S)] < \mathbb{E}[\mathcal{R}(h_S)]$: the training error is optimistic. This is why we evaluate a model on a test set that was not used to learn it, and why generalization bounds must hold *uniformly* over all the predictors that the algorithm could have chosen (Section 1.4).

Conditional expectations also describe the best possible predictors, called *Bayes predictors*, which minimize the true risk over *all* functions; their risk is the Bayes risk $\mathcal{R}^\star$ of Section 6.

Proposition 1.5: Bayes predictors

Let $(X, Y) \sim \mathcal{D}$.

(i) Regression with the squared loss. Assume $\mathbb{E}[Y^2] < +\infty$ and let $f^\star(x) = \mathbb{E}[Y \mid X = x]$ be the *regression function*. For every function g with $\mathbb{E}[g(X)^2] < +\infty$,

$$\mathbb{E}\left[(Y - g(X))^2\right] = \mathbb{E}\left[(Y - f^\star(X))^2\right] + \mathbb{E}\left[(f^\star(X) - g(X))^2\right].$$

Hence $f^\star$ minimizes the quadratic risk, and the excess risk of g is its mean squared distance to $f^\star$.

(ii) Classification with the 0-1 loss. Let $\eta_k(x) = \mathbb{P}(Y = k \mid X = x)$ for each class k. The classifier $h^\star(x) \in \arg\max_k \eta_k(x)$ minimizes $\mathbb{P}(h(X) \neq Y)$ over all classifiers h, and its risk is $\mathcal{R}^\star = 1 - \mathbb{E}\left[\max_k \eta_k(X)\right]$. For two classes with $\eta(x) = \mathbb{P}(Y = +1 \mid X = x)$, $h^\star(x) = +1$ if and only if $\eta(x) \geq \frac{1}{2}$ (ties broken arbitrarily), and $\mathcal{R}^\star = \mathbb{E}\left[\min(\eta(X), 1 - \eta(X))\right]$.

Proof. (i) Write $Y - g(X) = (Y - f^\star(X)) + (f^\star(X) - g(X))$ and expand the square. The cross term vanishes by the tower property and by taking out what is known:

$$\mathbb{E}\left[(Y - f^\star(X))(f^\star(X) - g(X))\right] = \mathbb{E}\left[(f^\star(X) - g(X))\left(\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X] - f^\star(X)\right)\right] = 0.$$

(ii) Conditionally on $X = x$, the classifier h errs unless $Y = h(x)$, so $\mathbb{P}(h(X) \neq Y \mid X = x) = 1 - \eta_{h(x)}(x) \geq 1 - \max_k \eta_k(x)$, with equality for $h = h^\star$. Taking the expectation over X (tower property) gives $\mathbb{P}(h(X) \neq Y) \geq 1 - \mathbb{E}[\max_k \eta_k(X)] = \mathbb{P}(h^\star(X) \neq Y)$. □

In words, the best possible regressor predicts the mean of Y given X, and the best possible classifier predicts the most probable class given X. Neither can be computed in practice, since $\mathcal{D}$ is unknown: learning algorithms try to approximate them from data. The Bayes risk is not zero as soon as the label is not a deterministic function of $\mathbf{x}$ (two patients with the same description may have different diagnoses): it is the irreducible error of the problem.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q1.1. True or false? If X and Y are two random variables with $\mathbb{E}[XY] = \mathbb{E}[X]\,\mathbb{E}[Y]$, then X and Y are independent.

Q1.2. A classifier with error rate $p = 0.2$ is evaluated on $m = 400$ independent test examples. What are the expectation and the standard deviation of its test error?

Q1.3. Why can a density take values larger than 1, whereas a probability mass function cannot?

Q1.4. Use Jensen's inequality to compare $\mathbb{E}[\sqrt{Z}]$ and $\sqrt{\mathbb{E}[Z]}$ for a nonnegative variable Z, and $\mathbb{E}[e^X]$ and $e^{\mathbb{E}[X]}$.

Q1.5. Is the training error $\mathcal{R}_S(h_S)$ of the predictor h_S learned on S an unbiased estimator of its true risk? Is the error on an independent test set?

1.3 Limit theorems: law of large numbers and central limit theorem

We now let the size of the sample grow. Let $X_1, X_2, \dots$ be i.i.d. random variables with mean μ and variance σ^2, and let $S_m = \sum_{i=1}^{m} X_i$ and $\bar{X}_m = S_m/m$. We know that $\mathbb{E}[\bar{X}_m] = \mu$ and that $\mathrm{Var}(\bar{X}_m) = \sigma^2/m \to 0$: the empirical mean becomes less and less random. The two classical limit theorems make this precise.

Theorem 1.6: Strong Law of Large Numbers; Kolmogorov, 1933

Let $(X_n)_{n\in\mathbb{N}^\star}$ be a sequence of independent and identically distributed random variables, and let $S_n = \sum_{i=1}^{n} X_i$. Assume that they have a finite moment of order 1, *i.e.* $\mathbb{E}\left[|X_1|\right] < +\infty$.
Then the empirical mean S_n/n converges almost surely to $\mathbb{E}[X_1]$:

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\lim_{n\to+\infty} \frac{S_n}{n} = \mathbb{E}[X_1]\right) = 1.$$

The law of large numbers justifies the use of empirical averages (such as the empirical risk) to estimate expectations (such as the true risk), as well as the frequentist interpretation of probabilities: the frequency of an event in independent repetitions converges to its probability. It is illustrated in Fig. 3. A weaker version, the *weak law of large numbers*, states that $\mathbb{P}(|\bar{X}_m - \mu| \geq \varepsilon) \to 0$ for every $\varepsilon > 0$ (*convergence in probability*); we will prove it in two lines with Chebyshev's inequality (Theorem 1.11).

The law of large numbers tells us that $\bar{X}_m - \mu \to 0$, but not at which speed. Since the standard deviation of $\bar{X}_m$ is $\sigma/\sqrt{m}$, it is natural to zoom in by a factor $\sqrt{m}$: the central limit theorem describes the distribution of the rescaled fluctuations.

Theorem 1.7: Central Limit Theorem

Let $(X_n)_{n\in\mathbb{N}^\star}$ be i.i.d. random variables with mean μ and finite variance $\sigma^2 > 0$.

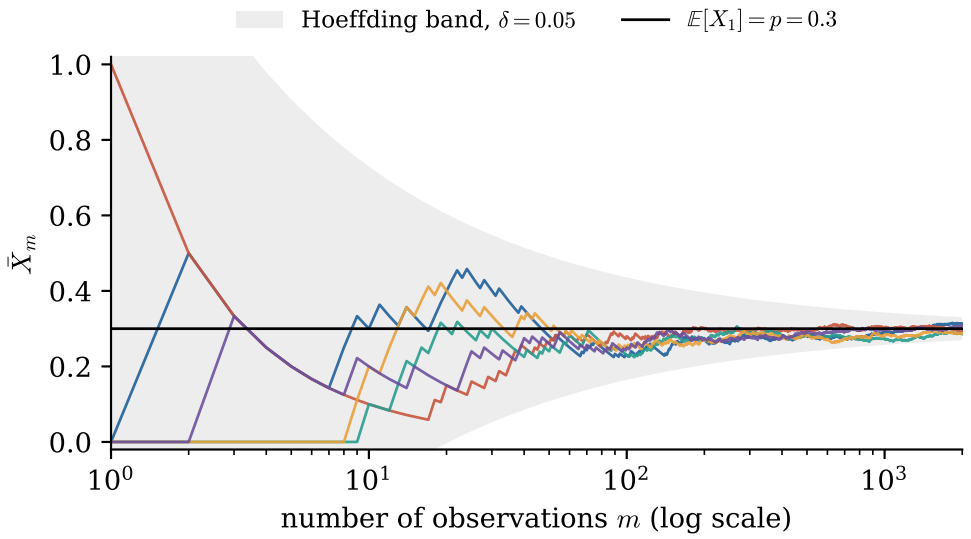


Figure 3: The law of large numbers: five trajectories $m \mapsto \bar{X}_m$ of the empirical mean of i.i.d. Bernoulli variables $\mathcal{B}(0.3)$ (think of the test error of a classifier with error rate 0.3, computed on more and more examples). All trajectories converge to 0.3, but for small m they wander far away from it. The grey band, given by Hoeffding's inequality (Theorem 1.15), contains $\bar{X}_m$ with probability at least 95% for each m.

Then $\sqrt{m}\,(\bar{X}_m - \mu)/\sigma$ converges in distribution to $\mathcal{N}(0,1)$: for every $t \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$\lim_{m \to +\infty} \mathbb{P}\left(\frac{\sqrt{m}\,(\bar{X}_m - \mu)}{\sigma} \leq t \right) = \Phi(t) = \int_{-\infty}^{t} \frac{e^{-u^2/2}}{\sqrt{2\pi}}\, du.$$

Whatever the distribution of the X_i's (provided that it has a finite variance), the average of many of them is approximately Gaussian, with mean μ and standard deviation $\sigma/\sqrt{m}$ (Fig. 4). This explains the ubiquity of the Gaussian distribution, and it gives the classical *asymptotic confidence interval*: since $\mathbb{P}(|Z| \leq 1.96) \approx 0.95$ for $Z \sim \mathcal{N}(0,1)$, for large m,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(|\bar{X}_m - \mu| \leq 1.96\, \frac{\sigma}{\sqrt{m}} \right) \approx 0.95. \tag{1.3}$$

Why limit theorems are not enough for learning

The limit theorems are statements about $m \to +\infty$; a learning algorithm works with a fixed, finite sample. This makes them insufficient for our purpose, for several reasons.

- They are asymptotic. The law of large numbers says nothing about $\bar{X}_{1000}$, and the central limit theorem says that the Gaussian approximation is good *for m large enough*, without telling us how large. The answer depends on the distribution: in Fig. 4, $m = 30$ is enough for exponential variables but not for Bernoulli variables with a small parameter. Yet, a classifier with a small error rate is precisely what

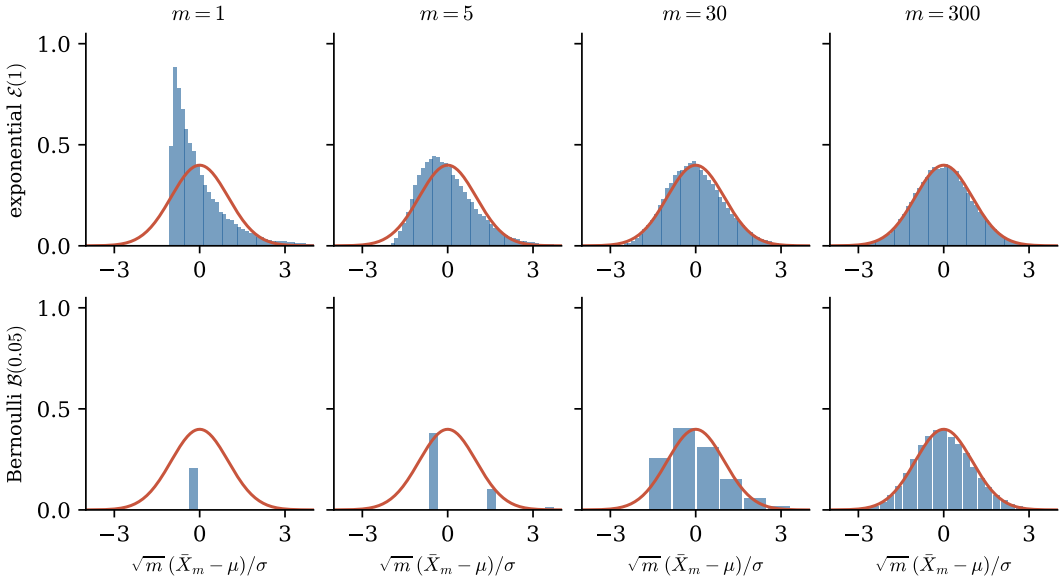


Figure 4: The central limit theorem: histograms of the standardized mean $\sqrt{m}(\bar{X}_m - \mu)/\sigma$ over 50 000 samples, for exponential variables (top) and for Bernoulli variables $\mathcal{B}(0.05)$ (bottom), compared with the density of $\mathcal{N}(0, 1)$ (red). For a skewed distribution the convergence is slow: for $m = 1$ and $m = 5$, the Bernoulli mean only takes a few values (for $m = 1$, the bar of the value $\bar{X}_1 = 1$ lies outside the window), and even for $m = 30$ the histogram is clearly asymmetric.
[code: `make_figures_prob.py: fig_prob_clt`]

we hope to learn: for $p = 0.01$ and $m = 100$, the "95%" interval (1.3) computed with the estimated variance contains p only 63% of the time (exercise 1.14).

- They are inaccurate for small probabilities. Even when the Gaussian approximation is good in the bulk of the distribution, its *relative* error in the tails can be large. Yet, we need very small probabilities as soon as we want guarantees for many predictors at once: with the union bound, certifying 1000 classifiers at confidence 95% requires each individual statement to fail with probability at most 5×10^{-5}.
- They involve unknown quantities, such as σ, which must itself be estimated.

What we need are *non-asymptotic* statements: explicit upper bounds on $\mathbb{P}(|\bar{X}_m - \mu| \geq \varepsilon)$, valid for every m and every distribution in a given class (e.g. bounded variables). These are the concentration inequalities.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q1.6. What is the difference between the information given by the law of large numbers and by the central limit theorem?

Q1.7. Why does the Gaussian approximation work badly for the test error of a classifier with error rate $p = 0.01$ evaluated on $m = 100$ examples?

Q1.8. True or false? By the central limit theorem, for every $m \geq 30$, $\mathbb{P}(|\bar{X}_m - \mu| \geq 1.96\sigma/\sqrt{m}) \leq 0.05$.

1.4 Concentration inequalities

A concentration inequality bounds the probability that a random variable (typically an average) deviates from its expectation by more than a given amount. We present them from the crudest to the sharpest; remarkably, all of them derive from the first one, Markov's inequality, applied to well-chosen functions of the variable. We start with an even simpler tool, which is used to combine several bounds.

The union bound

Proposition 1.8: Union bound (Boole's inequality)

For every finite or countable family of events $(A_k)_k$,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_k A_k\right) \leq \sum_k \mathbb{P}(A_k).$$

Proof. For every outcome, the number of events A_k that occur is at least 1 if at least one of them occurs, so $\mathbb{1}_{\bigcup_k A_k} \leq \sum_k \mathbb{1}_{A_k}$. Taking expectations (monotonicity, linearity, and monotone convergence for a countable sum) gives the result. □

The union bound is crude, since it counts several times the outcomes where several events occur, but it requires no assumption at all on the dependence between the events. It is used as follows: if each of K statements fails with probability at most δ/K, then, with probability at least $1-\delta$, *all* of them hold simultaneously. This is the simplest way to obtain guarantees that are valid for all the predictors of a finite class at once (Section 1.4).

Markov's and Chebyshev's inequalities

Proposition 1.9: Markov's Inequality

Let X be a nonnegative random variable. Then, for all $t > 0$,

$$\mathbb{P}(X \geq t) \leq \frac{\mathbb{E}[X]}{t}.$$

Equivalently, for every $\delta \in (0, 1]$, with probability at least $1-\delta$, $X < \mathbb{E}[X]/\delta$.

Proof. Since $X \geq 0$, we have $X \geq t\,\mathbb{1}_{\{X \geq t\}}$: when $X \geq t$, the right-hand side equals $t \leq X$, and otherwise it is $0 \leq X$. Taking the expectation (Theorem 1.1 (ii) and (iii)) gives $\mathbb{E}[X] \geq t\,\mathbb{P}(X \geq t)$. The second form follows with $t = \mathbb{E}[X]/\delta$. □

Markov's inequality only uses the mean, and it cannot be improved without further information: for the variable X equal to t with probability $\mathbb{E}[X]/t$ and to 0 otherwise, it is an equality. In words, a nonnegative variable cannot often be much larger than its mean: at most 10% of a population can earn more than ten times the average income. It is weak (it decreases only as $1/t$), but it becomes powerful when applied to $g(X)$ for a well-chosen nonnegative increasing function g, since $\mathbb{P}(X \geq t) \leq \mathbb{P}(g(X) \geq$

$g(t)) \leq \mathbb{E}[g(X)]/g(t)$. With $g(x) = x^2$, we get Chebyshev's inequality; with $g(x) = e^{\lambda x}$, Chernoff's method.

Proposition 1.10: Chebyshev's (Bienaymé–Chebyshev) Inequality

Let X be a random variable with a finite variance $\mathrm{Var}(X)$. Then, for all $\varepsilon > 0$,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(|X - \mathbb{E}[X]| \geq \varepsilon\right) \leq \frac{\mathrm{Var}(X)}{\varepsilon^2}.$$

Proof. Apply Markov's inequality to the nonnegative random variable $(X - \mathbb{E}[X])^2$ with $t = \varepsilon^2$:

$$\mathbb{P}\left(|X - \mathbb{E}[X]| \geq \varepsilon\right) = \mathbb{P}\left((X - \mathbb{E}[X])^2 \geq \varepsilon^2\right) \leq \frac{\mathbb{E}\left[(X - \mathbb{E}[X])^2\right]}{\varepsilon^2} = \frac{\mathrm{Var}(X)}{\varepsilon^2}.$$

□

Corollary 1.11: Weak law of large numbers

Let $X_1, \ldots, X_m$ be pairwise uncorrelated (e.g. independent) random variables with the same mean μ and the same variance σ^2. Then, for every $\varepsilon > 0$,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(|\bar{X}_m - \mu| \geq \varepsilon\right) \leq \frac{\sigma^2}{m\varepsilon^2} \xrightarrow[m \to +\infty]{} 0.$$

Proof. Apply Chebyshev's inequality to $\bar{X}_m$, whose variance is σ^2/m (Theorem 1.2). □

Example 1.4 (Running question, first answer). A classifier is evaluated on m test examples; the losses are i.i.d. $\mathcal{B}(p)$, with variance $p(1-p) \leq \frac{1}{4}$. Setting $\frac{1}{4m\varepsilon^2} = \delta$, Chebyshev's inequality shows that, with probability at least $1 - \delta$, $|\widehat{p} - p| < \frac{1}{2\sqrt{m\delta}}$. To get a precision $\varepsilon = 0.05$ with confidence 95% ($\delta = 0.05$), it suffices to have $m \geq \frac{1}{4\delta\varepsilon^2} = 2000$ test examples; for a confidence of 99.9%, we need $m \geq 100\,000$.

The dependence in $1/\delta$ of Chebyshev's sample size is a problem: high confidence becomes very expensive. The reason is that Chebyshev's inequality only uses the variance, and must therefore hold for distributions with heavy tails. For bounded variables, much more is true.

Chernoff's method

The idea of Chernoff's method is to apply Markov's inequality to the exponential $e^{\lambda X}$, and then to choose the best value of the free parameter λ. The function $\lambda \mapsto \mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda X}]$ is the *moment generating function* (MGF) of X.

Proposition 1.12: Chernoff's bound

For every random variable X and every $t \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$\mathbb{P}(X \geq t) \leq \inf_{\lambda \geq 0} e^{-\lambda t}\, \mathbb{E}\left[e^{\lambda X}\right].$$

Proof. For $\lambda = 0$, the right-hand side equals 1. For $\lambda > 0$, the function $x \mapsto e^{\lambda x}$ is increasing and positive, so Markov's inequality gives $\mathbb{P}(X \geq t) = \mathbb{P}\left(e^{\lambda X} \geq e^{\lambda t}\right) \leq e^{-\lambda t}\, \mathbb{E}\left[e^{\lambda X}\right]$. The bound holds for every $\lambda \geq 0$, hence for the infimum. □

Chernoff's method is particularly well suited to sums of independent variables, because the MGF of a sum of independent variables is the product of their MGFs (Theorem 1.1 (iv)): bounding the MGF of each term is enough.

Example 1.5 (Gaussian tails). If $X \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$, then $\mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda X}] = e^{\lambda^2\sigma^2/2}$, so $\mathbb{P}(X \geq t) \leq \inf_{\lambda \geq 0} e^{-\lambda t + \lambda^2\sigma^2/2} = e^{-t^2/(2\sigma^2)}$ for $t \geq 0$ (the infimum is reached at $\lambda = t/\sigma^2$). The tail decreases like $e^{-t^2/(2\sigma^2)}$, much faster than the σ^2/t^2 of Chebyshev.

Example 1.6 (Bernoulli variables and the binary kl). Let $X_1, \ldots, X_m$ be i.i.d. $\mathcal{B}(p)$ and $q \in (p, 1)$. Since $\mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda X_i}] = 1 - p + pe^{\lambda}$, Chernoff's bound applied to $S_m = \sum_i X_i$ and $t = mq$ gives

$$\mathbb{P}(\bar{X}_m \geq q) \leq \inf_{\lambda \geq 0} e^{-\lambda m q}(1 - p + pe^{\lambda})^m = \exp\Big(- m \sup_{\lambda \geq 0} \left[\lambda q - \ln(1 - p + pe^{\lambda})\right]\Big).$$

The supremum is reached where the derivative vanishes, i.e. at $e^{\lambda} = \frac{q(1-p)}{p(1-q)}$, and a direct computation shows that its value is the **binary Kullback–Leibler divergence**

$$\mathrm{kl}(q\|p) = q \ln \frac{q}{p} + (1 - q) \ln \frac{1 - q}{1 - p}.$$

Hence $\mathbb{P}(\bar{X}_m \geq q) \leq e^{-m\ \mathrm{kl}(q\|p)}$ for $q > p$, and symmetrically $\mathbb{P}(\bar{X}_m \leq q) \leq e^{-m\ \mathrm{kl}(q\|p)}$ for $q < p$. This is the sharpest bound that can be obtained by this method, and it is the form used in PAC-Bayesian theory (Lemma 13.4 in Section 13).

Hoeffding's inequality

For a general bounded variable, we do not know its MGF, but we can bound it.

Lemma 1.13: Hoeffding's Lemma

Let X be a random variable such that $a \leq X \leq b$ almost surely. Then, for all $s \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$\mathbb{E}\left[e^{s(X - \mathbb{E}[X])}\right] \leq \exp\left(\frac{s^2(b-a)^2}{8}\right).$$

Proof. Replacing X by $X - \mathbb{E}[X]$ (and a, b by $a - \mathbb{E}[X], b - \mathbb{E}[X]$), we can assume that $\mathbb{E}[X] = 0$, so that $a \leq 0 \leq b$; we can also assume $a < b$, the case $a = b$ being trivial. Let $s \in \mathbb{R}$.

Step 1: convexity. Every $x \in [a, b]$ is the convex combination $x = \frac{b-x}{b-a}\, a + \frac{x-a}{b-a}\, b$, so the convexity of $x \mapsto e^{sx}$ gives $e^{sx} \leq \frac{b-x}{b-a}e^{sa} + \frac{x-a}{b-a}e^{sb}$. Applying it to X and taking the expectation, with $\mathbb{E}[X] = 0$,

$$\mathbb{E}\left[e^{sX}\right] \leq \frac{b}{b-a}e^{sa} - \frac{a}{b-a}e^{sb} = (1 - \theta)e^{sa} + \theta e^{sb}, \qquad \text{where } \theta = \frac{-a}{b-a} \in [0, 1].$$

Step 2: change of variable. Let $u = s(b-a)$. Since $sa = -\theta u$, the right-hand side equals $e^{-\theta u}(1-\theta+\theta e^u) = e^{\varphi(u)}$, with

$$\varphi(u) = -\theta u + \ln\left(1-\theta+\theta e^u\right).$$

Step 3: Taylor expansion. We have $\varphi(0) = 0$, $\varphi'(u) = -\theta + \frac{\theta e^u}{1-\theta+\theta e^u}$, so $\varphi'(0) = 0$, and

$$\varphi''(u) = \frac{\theta e^u(1-\theta)}{(1-\theta+\theta e^u)^2} = \rho(1-\rho) \le \frac{1}{4}, \qquad \text{where } \rho = \frac{\theta e^u}{1-\theta+\theta e^u} \in [0,1].$$

By Taylor's theorem, there exists ξ between 0 and u such that $\varphi(u) = \varphi(0) + u\varphi'(0) + \frac{u^2}{2}\varphi''(\xi) \le \frac{u^2}{8} = \frac{s^2(b-a)^2}{8}$. □

The lemma says that a bounded centred variable has an MGF dominated by that of a Gaussian variable with variance $(b-a)^2/4$: bounded variables have (at least) Gaussian tails. Combined with Chernoff's method, it gives the most used concentration inequality of learning theory.

Proposition 1.14: Hoeffding's Inequality

Let $X_1, \dots, X_n$ be independent random variables such that, for all i, $a_i \le X_i \le b_i$ almost surely, where $a_i < b_i$ are real numbers, and let $S_n = \sum_{i=1}^n X_i$. Then, for all $\varepsilon > 0$,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(S_n - \mathbb{E}[S_n] \ge \varepsilon\right) \le \exp\left(-\frac{2\varepsilon^2}{\sum_{i=1}^n (b_i-a_i)^2}\right),$$

and the same bound holds for $\mathbb{P}\left(S_n - \mathbb{E}[S_n] \le -\varepsilon\right)$. Consequently,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(|S_n - \mathbb{E}[S_n]| \ge \varepsilon\right) \le 2\exp\left(-\frac{2\varepsilon^2}{\sum_{i=1}^n (b_i-a_i)^2}\right).$$

In particular, if all the X_i's take their values in $[a,b]$, then for the empirical mean $\bar{X}_n = S_n/n$,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(|\bar{X}_n - \mathbb{E}[\bar{X}_n]| \ge \varepsilon\right) \le 2\exp\left(-\frac{2n\varepsilon^2}{(b-a)^2}\right).$$

Proof. Let $s > 0$ and $c^2 = \sum_{i=1}^n (b_i-a_i)^2$. By Chernoff's bound (Theorem 1.12) applied to $S_n - \mathbb{E}[S_n]$,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(S_n - \mathbb{E}[S_n] \ge \varepsilon\right) \le e^{-s\varepsilon}\,\mathbb{E}\left[e^{s(S_n - \mathbb{E}[S_n])}\right] = e^{-s\varepsilon}\,\mathbb{E}\left[\prod_{i=1}^n e^{s(X_i - \mathbb{E}[X_i])}\right]$$

↓ independence, Theorem 1.1 (iv)

$$= e^{-s\varepsilon}\prod_{i=1}^n \mathbb{E}\left[e^{s(X_i - \mathbb{E}[X_i])}\right]$$

↓ Hoeffding's lemma

$$\le \exp\left(-s\varepsilon + \frac{s^2c^2}{8}\right).$$

The exponent is a quadratic function of s, minimal for $s = 4\varepsilon/c^2$, where it equals $-2\varepsilon^2/c^2$: this gives the first bound. The lower tail is obtained by applying this result to the variables $-X_i \in [-b_i, -a_i]$, and the two-sided bound by a union bound on the two events. For the empirical mean, $\{|\bar{X}_n - \mathbb{E}[\bar{X}_n]| \geq \varepsilon\} = \{|S_n - \mathbb{E}[S_n]| \geq n\varepsilon\}$ and $c^2 = n(b-a)^2$. □

Figure 5 compares the inequalities seen so far with the exact tail of a binomial distribution. The polynomial bounds of Markov and Chebyshev are useless for small probabilities, while the exponential bounds of Hoeffding and Chernoff decrease at the right speed, Chernoff's kl bound being the closest to the truth.

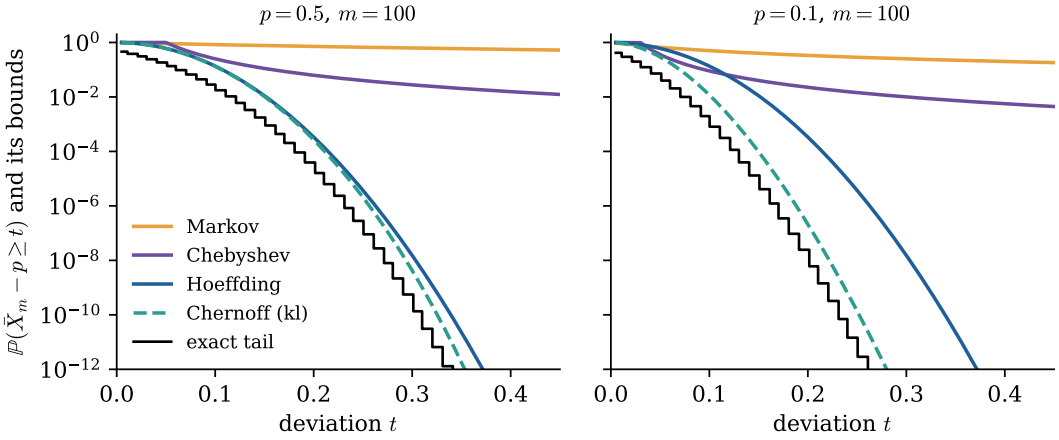


Figure 5: Upper tail $\mathbb{P}(\bar{X}_m - p \geq t)$ of the mean of $m = 100$ Bernoulli variables (black, exact binomial tail) and its upper bounds (log scale): Markov $(p/(p+t))$, Chebyshev $(p(1-p)/(mt^2))$, Hoeffding (e^{-2mt^2}) and Chernoff $(e^{-m\ \mathrm{kl}(p+t\|p)})$. For $p = 0.5$ (left), Hoeffding's and Chernoff's bounds almost coincide; for $p = 0.1$ (right), the variance $p(1-p)$ is small, and the bounds that adapt to it (Chernoff, and Chebyshev for small t) are much better than Hoeffding's.

From a tail bound to a confidence statement

A concentration inequality is usually stated as "the probability of a deviation larger than ε is at most $g(\varepsilon)$". In learning theory, we prefer the inverse form "with probability at least $1-\delta$, the deviation is at most $\varepsilon(\delta)$". To go from one to the other, we solve $g(\varepsilon) = \delta$ in ε.

Corollary 1.15: Hoeffding's inequality, inverse form; sample size

Let $X_1, \ldots, X_m$ be independent random variables with values in $[a, b]$ and the same mean μ, and let $\delta \in (0, 1)$. With probability at least $1 - \delta$,

$$|\bar{X}_m - \mu| < (b-a)\sqrt{\frac{\ln(2/\delta)}{2m}},$$

and (one-sided version), with probability at least $1-\delta$, $\mu < \bar{X}_m + (b-a)\sqrt{\frac{\ln(1/\delta)}{2m}}$. Consequently, to estimate μ with precision ε and confidence $1-\delta$, it suffices to

have

$$m \geq \frac{(b-a)^2 \ln(2/\delta)}{2\varepsilon^2}.$$

Proof. Set $2e^{-2m\varepsilon^2/(b-a)^2} = \delta$, i.e. $\varepsilon = (b-a)\sqrt{\ln(2/\delta)/(2m)}$, in Theorem 1.14: the probability of the event $\{|\bar{X}_m - \mu| \geq \varepsilon\}$ is at most δ, so its complement has probability at least $1-\delta$. The one-sided statement is obtained in the same way from the bound on the lower tail $\mathbb{P}(\bar{X}_m - \mu \leq -\varepsilon)$, without the factor 2. The sample size is the smallest m for which $(b-a)\sqrt{\ln(2/\delta)/(2m)} \leq \varepsilon$. □

Example 1.7 (Running question, second answer). For the test error of a fixed classifier ($a=0$, $b=1$), Hoeffding's inequality guarantees $|\widehat{p} - p| < 0.05$ with confidence 95% as soon as $m \geq \frac{\ln 40}{2\times 0.05^2} \approx 737.8$, i.e. $m = 738$, instead of 2000 with Chebyshev; with confidence 99.9%, we need $m = 1521$ instead of 100 000. With $m = 1000$ test examples and an observed error $\widehat{p} = 0.12$, we can claim that $p \in [0.077, 0.163]$ with confidence 95%, since $\sqrt{\ln 40/2000} \approx 0.043$.

The comparison is summarized in Fig. 6. All the bounds decrease as $1/\sqrt{m}$, but the price of confidence is very different: Chebyshev's sample size grows as $1/\delta$, Hoeffding's only as $\ln(1/\delta)$. This logarithmic dependence is what makes the union bound affordable: replacing δ by δ/K only adds $\ln K$ to the numerator.

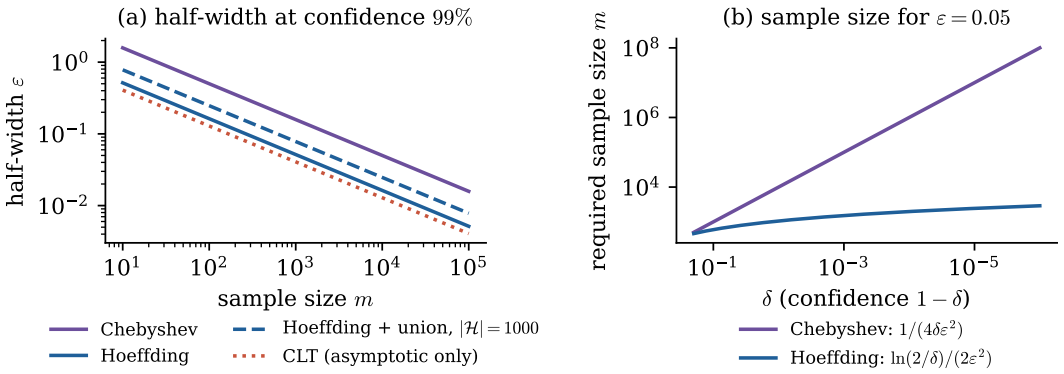


Figure 6: (a) Half-width ε of a confidence interval at level 99% for the mean of variables with values in $[0,1]$, as a function of m (log-log scale): all decrease as $1/\sqrt{m}$, and the union bound over 1000 hypotheses (Section 1.4) costs less than Chebyshev's inequality for a single one. The CLT curve is shown for comparison, with the worst-case variance $\frac{1}{4}$; it is only an approximation. (b) Sample size needed for a precision $\varepsilon = 0.05$, as a function of δ: $1/\delta$ for Chebyshev versus $\ln(2/\delta)$ for Hoeffding.

Pitfall In "with probability at least $1-\delta$, $p \in [\widehat{p} - \varepsilon, \widehat{p} + \varepsilon]$", the randomness is in the *sample*, hence in $\widehat{p}$, not in p, which is a fixed unknown number. The statement means: if we repeated the whole experiment many times, the interval would contain p in at least $100(1-\delta)\%$ of the repetitions. Once the sample has been observed, the interval $[0.077, 0.163]$ either contains p or not; we simply do not know which, and our procedure fails at most 5% of the time.

Bernstein's inequality: adapting to the variance

Hoeffding's inequality only uses the range $[a, b]$ of the variables. It is therefore tight for the worst case, Bernoulli variables with $p = \frac{1}{2}$, whose variance is $\frac{1}{4}$, but pessimistic when the variance is much smaller than $(b-a)^2/4$, which is the case of the test error of a good classifier: a Bernoulli variable with mean 0.01 has variance 0.0099. Bernstein's inequality takes the variance into account.

Proposition 1.16: Bernstein's inequality

Let $X_1, \dots, X_m$ be independent random variables with the same mean μ, such that $|X_i - \mu| \leq c$ almost surely, and let $\sigma^2 = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m} \mathrm{Var}(X_i)$. Then, for every $\varepsilon > 0$,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\bar{X}_m - \mu \geq \varepsilon\right) \leq \exp\left(-\frac{m\varepsilon^2}{2\sigma^2 + 2c\varepsilon/3}\right),$$

and the same bound holds for $\mathbb{P}(\bar{X}_m - \mu \leq -\varepsilon)$. Equivalently, for every $\delta \in (0, 1)$, with probability at least $1 - \delta$,

$$\bar{X}_m - \mu < \sqrt{\frac{2\sigma^2 \ln(1/\delta)}{m}} + \frac{2c\ln(1/\delta)}{3m}.$$

The proof follows Chernoff's method, with a bound on the MGF that involves the variance instead of the range (see Boucheron et al., 2013, Chapter 2). The inverse form is obtained by solving a quadratic equation in ε and using $\sqrt{u+v} \leq \sqrt{u} + \sqrt{v}$. Let us read it.

- For small deviations ($\varepsilon \ll \sigma^2/c$), the exponent is about $m\varepsilon^2/(2\sigma^2)$: the bound behaves like the Gaussian approximation of the central limit theorem, with the *true* variance. Since $\sigma^2 \leq c^2$, and for a Bernoulli variable $\sigma^2 = p(1-p) \leq \frac{1}{4}$, this is never much worse than Hoeffding, and much better when σ^2 is small.
- For a small variance, the second term dominates, and the deviation is of order $\ln(1/\delta)/m$ instead of $\sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)/m}$: this is a *fast rate*. For a classifier with error rate $p = 0.01$, $m = 1000$ and $\delta = 0.05$, Bernstein's one-sided deviation is 0.0097, four times smaller than Hoeffding's 0.0387 (exercise 1.12).
- The price is that σ^2 is unknown in general. In practice, it is either bounded (for the 0-1 loss, $\sigma^2 = p(1-p) \leq p$, which leads to bounds that are implicit in p) or replaced by the empirical variance (*empirical Bernstein* inequalities Maurer and Pontil (2009)). The kl bound of example 1.6 adapts to the variance automatically, and this is one reason why it is preferred in Part IV.

McDiarmid's inequality: beyond sums

Hoeffding's inequality concerns sums of independent variables. McDiarmid's inequality extends it to any function of independent variables that does not depend too much on each of them; it is used, for instance, to derive generalization bounds based on the Rademacher complexity or on algorithmic stability.

Proposition 1.17: McDiarmid's (Bounded Differences) Inequality

Let $X_1, \dots, X_n$ be independent random variables taking values in a set $\mathcal{X}$, and let $f : \mathcal{X}^n \to \mathbb{R}$ be a function satisfying the bounded differences property: there exist constants $c_1, \dots, c_n \geq 0$ such that, for all i and all $x_1, \dots, x_n, x_i' \in \mathcal{X}$,

$$|f(x_1, \dots, x_{i-1}, x_i, x_{i+1}, \dots, x_n) - f(x_1, \dots, x_{i-1}, x_i', x_{i+1}, \dots, x_n)| \leq c_i.$$

Then, for all $\varepsilon > 0$,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(f(X_1, \dots, X_n) - \mathbb{E}\left[f(X_1, \dots, X_n)\right] \geq \varepsilon\right) \leq \exp\left(-\frac{2\varepsilon^2}{\sum_{i=1}^n c_i^2}\right),$$

and the same bound holds for the lower tail, so that the two-sided deviation is bounded by twice this quantity.

Hoeffding's inequality is the special case $f(x_1, \dots, x_n) = \sum_{i=1}^n x_i$ with $x_i \in [a_i, b_i]$, for which $c_i = b_i - a_i$. The proof of McDiarmid's inequality applies the Chernoff method and Hoeffding's lemma to the martingale differences $V_i = \mathbb{E}[f \mid X_1, \dots, X_i] - \mathbb{E}[f \mid X_1, \dots, X_{i-1}]$, each of which lies, conditionally on $X_1, \dots, X_{i-1}$, in an interval of length at most c_i; since $f - \mathbb{E}[f] = \sum_i V_i$, the argument is the same as for a sum (see McDiarmid, 1989; Boucheron et al., 2013).

The strength of McDiarmid's inequality is that f can be very complicated, as long as no single example has too much influence on it. Here is the application that matters in learning theory. Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a class of predictors and ℓ a loss with values in $[0, 1]$, and consider the worst deviation between the true and the empirical risks over the class,

$$\Phi(S) = \sup_{h \in \mathcal{H}} \left(\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)\right).$$

If we replace the example $(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)$ of S by another one, the empirical risk of each h changes by at most $1/m$ (a single term of the average changes, and it lies in $[0, 1]$), hence so does the supremum. McDiarmid's inequality with $c_i = 1/m$ then shows that, with probability at least $1 - \delta$,

$$\forall h \in \mathcal{H}, \qquad \mathcal{R}(h) \leq \mathcal{R}_S(h) + \Phi(S) \leq \mathcal{R}_S(h) + \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S \sim \mathcal{D}^m}[\Phi(S)] + \sqrt{\frac{\ln(1/\delta)}{2m}}.$$

A random quantity, the worst deviation over $\mathcal{H}$, has been replaced by its expectation, up to a Hoeffding-like term. What remains is to bound this expectation: this is exactly what the Rademacher complexity does (Definition 10.1 and Theorem 10.2 in Section 6 and the following ones), and it is how the bounds based on algorithmic stability are proved.

Preview: uniform bounds and PAC-Bayes

Let us conclude by showing how the tools of this section combine into the generalization bounds of the rest of the course.

A finite class of predictors. Let $\mathcal{H} = \{h_1, \dots, h_K\}$ and a loss with values in $[0,1]$. For each fixed h_k, Hoeffding's inequality gives $\mathbb{P}(|\mathcal{R}(h_k) - \mathcal{R}_S(h_k)| \geq \varepsilon) \leq 2e^{-2m\varepsilon^2}$. By the union bound,

$$\mathop{\mathbb{P}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left(\exists h \in \mathcal{H} :\ |\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)| \geq \varepsilon\right) \leq \sum_{k=1}^{K} \mathbb{P}\left(|\mathcal{R}(h_k) - \mathcal{R}_S(h_k)| \geq \varepsilon\right) \leq 2Ke^{-2m\varepsilon^2}.$$

Setting the right-hand side to δ: with probability at least $1-\delta$,

$$\forall h \in \mathcal{H}, \qquad |\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)| < \sqrt{\frac{\ln K + \ln(2/\delta)}{2m}}. \tag{1.4}$$

Since the bound holds simultaneously for all $h \in \mathcal{H}$, it holds in particular for the predictor h_S chosen by the learning algorithm, whatever the way it uses S. The price of uniformity is the term $\ln K = \ln|\mathcal{H}|$, which measures the complexity of the class; Fig. 7 shows that it is real, not an artefact of the proof. This is the starting point of Section 6, which then replaces $\ln|\mathcal{H}|$ by the VC-dimension or the Rademacher complexity for infinite classes.

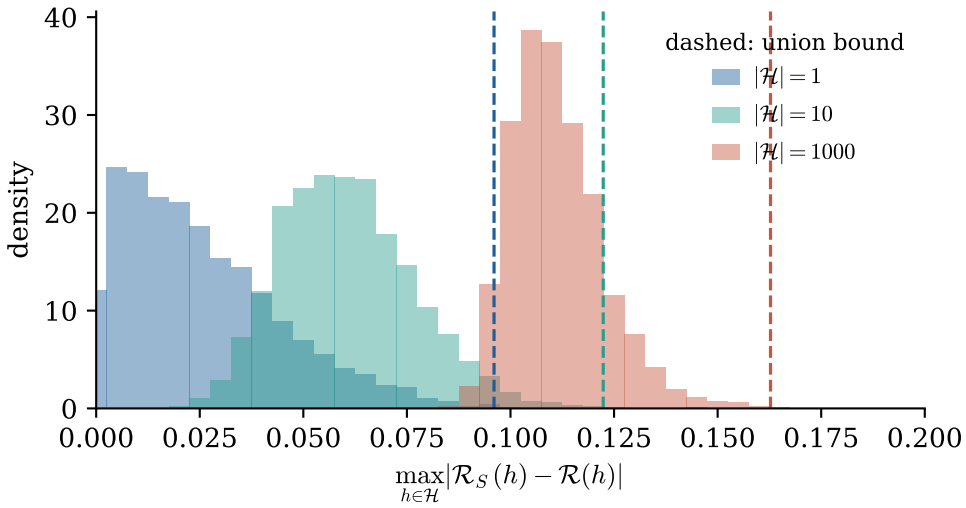


Figure 7: The maximal deviation $\max_{h\in\mathcal{H}} |\mathcal{R}_S(h) - \mathcal{R}(h)|$ over $K = |\mathcal{H}|$ classifiers with true risk 0.3 whose errors are independent, for $m = 200$ (4000 simulated samples). The more classifiers, the larger the worst deviation: picking the classifier with the smallest empirical risk among many is optimistic. The dashed lines show the uniform bound (1.4) with $\delta = 0.05$, which grows only like $\sqrt{\ln K}$.

The kl version. Replacing Hoeffding's inequality by Chernoff's kl bound of example 1.6 gives, for the 0-1 loss and with probability at least $1-\delta$, $\mathrm{kl}\left(\mathcal{R}_S(h) \| \mathcal{R}(h)\right) \leq \frac{\ln K + \ln(1/\delta)}{m}$ for every $h \in \mathcal{H}$ such that $\mathcal{R}_S(h) \leq \mathcal{R}(h)$. This bound adapts to the variance, like Bernstein's inequality: when the empirical risk is close to 0, it gives a deviation of order $\frac{\ln K + \ln(1/\delta)}{m}$ instead of its square root. It is the *Occam bound* of Section 13.

Change of measure. PAC-Bayesian theory (Part IV) goes one step further: instead of a single predictor, it certifies a *distribution* Q over $\mathcal{H}$ (for instance, the weights of the

voters of a majority vote). Its key tool is a direct consequence of Jensen's inequality. For two distributions P, Q on a finite set $\mathcal{H}$, with $P(h) > 0$ for all h, the *Kullback–Leibler divergence* is $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = \sum_h Q(h) \ln \frac{Q(h)}{P(h)} \geq 0$, and for every function $\phi : \mathcal{H} \to \mathbb{R}$,

$$\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}[\phi(h)] \leq \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim P}\left[e^{\phi(h)}\right]. \tag{1.5}$$

Indeed, summing over the h such that $Q(h) > 0$ and using Jensen's inequality for the concave function ln,

$$\begin{aligned}\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}[\phi(h)] - \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) &= \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}\left[\ln\left(e^{\phi(h)}\frac{P(h)}{Q(h)}\right)\right] \leq \ln \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}\left[e^{\phi(h)}\frac{P(h)}{Q(h)}\right] \\ &= \ln \sum_{h:Q(h)>0} P(h)\, e^{\phi(h)} \leq \ln \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim P}\left[e^{\phi(h)}\right].\end{aligned}$$

A PAC-Bayesian bound is then obtained in three steps that use the whole toolbox of this section: (1) bound the exponential moment $\mathbb{E}_S[e^{\phi_S(h)}]$ of a deviation $\phi_S(h)$ of a fixed h (Hoeffding's lemma, or Chernoff's kl bound); (2) average it over the prior P, exchange the expectations, and apply Markov's inequality to the nonnegative variable $\mathbb{E}_{h\sim P}[e^{\phi_S(h)}]$; (3) transfer the result to any posterior Q with (1.5). This is done in detail in Sections 13 and 14.

To remember from Section 1

- The data are modelled as an i.i.d. sample $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$; every quantity computed from S is a random variable.
- The true risk $\mathcal{R}(h) = \mathbb{E}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}[\ell(h(\mathbf{x}), y)]$ is an expectation; for a fixed h, the empirical risk is an unbiased average whose standard deviation decreases as $1/\sqrt{m}$. The Bayes predictors are conditional expectations (regression) and most probable classes (classification).
- The expectation is linear; Jensen's inequality orders $f(\mathbb{E}[X])$ and $\mathbb{E}[f(X)]$ for a convex or concave f; the tower property computes expectations by conditioning.
- The law of large numbers and the central limit theorem are asymptotic; learning needs non-asymptotic concentration inequalities.
- Markov ⇒ Chebyshev (variance, $1/\delta$) and Chernoff (exponential moments) ⇒ Hoeffding (bounded variables, $\ln(1/\delta)$), Bernstein (small variance, fast rates) and the kl bound. McDiarmid extends Hoeffding to functions with bounded differences.
- For variables in $[0,1]$: with probability at least $1-\delta$, $|\bar{X}_m - \mu| < \sqrt{\ln(2/\delta)/(2m)}$; with the union bound over K hypotheses, $\ln(2/\delta)$ becomes $\ln(2K/\delta)$.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q1.9. Why is Markov's inequality applied to $e^{\lambda X}$ (Chernoff's method) much stronger than when it is applied to X itself?

Q1.10. With $m = 500$ test examples, what is the half-width of the two-sided Hoeffding interval for the error rate of a fixed classifier at confidence 95%?

Q1.11. How does the sample size given by Hoeffding's inequality change if we want twice the precision ($\varepsilon/2$)? If we want $\delta/10$ instead of δ?

Q1.12. True or false? Hoeffding's inequality requires the variables $X_1, \ldots, X_m$ to be identically distributed.

Q1.13. Why does one need a union bound (or another uniform argument) to bound the true risk of the hypothesis h_S returned by empirical risk minimization?

Q1.14. In the uniform bound over a finite class, what happens to the half-width when the number of hypotheses goes from 10^3 to 10^6, for $m = 10\,000$ and $\delta = 0.05$?

Q1.15. When is Bernstein's inequality much better than Hoeffding's inequality? Give an example from classification.

Q1.16. What are the bounded differences constants c_i of the function $f(x_1, \ldots, x_m) = \max_i x_i$ for $x_i \in [0, 1]$, and what does McDiarmid's inequality give?

Exercises

Exercise 1.1. **(Comprehension)** True or false? Justify briefly. (a) $\mathbb{E}[X+Y] = \mathbb{E}[X] + \mathbb{E}[Y]$ only holds when X and Y are independent. (b) $\mathrm{Var}(X+Y) = \mathrm{Var}(X) + \mathrm{Var}(Y)$ for all random variables X, Y with finite variances. (c) If $X \geq 0$ and $\mathbb{E}[X] = 0$, then $X = 0$ almost surely. (d) The union bound $\mathbb{P}(A \cup B) \leq \mathbb{P}(A) + \mathbb{P}(B)$ requires A and B to be disjoint. (e) If X has a density f_X, then $\mathbb{P}(X = 1) = f_X(1)$.

Exercise 1.2. **(Computation)** (a) Compute the expectation and the variance of $X \sim \mathcal{B}(p)$ and of $Y \sim \mathrm{Bin}(m, p)$. (b) Compute $\mathbb{E}[U]$, $\mathbb{E}[U^2]$ and $\mathrm{Var}(U)$ for $U \sim \mathcal{U}([a, b])$, and check that $\mathrm{Var}(U) \leq (b-a)^2/4$. (c) A fixed classifier with error rate p is evaluated with the 0-1 loss on an i.i.d. test set of size m. Give the expectation and the standard deviation of its test error $\widehat{p}$. How large must m be for this standard deviation to be at most 0.01 whatever p?

Exercise 1.3. **(Computation)** (a) Let X be the index of the first test example on which a classifier with error rate $p \in (0, 1]$ errs, the examples being independent: $\mathbb{P}(X = k) = (1-p)^{k-1}p$ for $k \geq 1$ (geometric distribution). Compute $\mathbb{P}(X \geq k)$, then $\mathbb{E}[X]$ with the tail formula of Theorem 1.1. (b) Let T follow the exponential distribution with parameter $\lambda > 0$, with density $\lambda e^{-\lambda t}$ on $[0, +\infty)$. Compute $\mathbb{P}(T > t)$, then $\mathbb{E}[T]$ with the tail formula. Using $T^2 \geq 0$ and $\mathbb{P}(T^2 > s) = \mathbb{P}(T > \sqrt{s})$, compute $\mathbb{E}[T^2]$ and $\mathrm{Var}(T)$.

Exercise 1.4. **(Proof)** (a) Prove that $\mathrm{Var}\left(\sum_{i=1}^m X_i\right) = \sum_i \mathrm{Var}(X_i) + 2\sum_{i<j} \mathrm{Cov}(X_i, X_j)$. (b) Deduce that, if $X_1, \ldots, X_m$ are pairwise uncorrelated with the same variance σ^2, $\mathrm{Var}(\bar{X}_m) = \sigma^2/m$. (c) Let X be uniform on $\{-1, 0, 1\}$ and $Y = X^2$. Show that $\mathrm{Cov}(X, Y) = 0$ but that X and Y are not independent. (d) Now let $X_1, \ldots, X_m$ all be equal to the same variable X with variance σ^2 (the extreme case of duplicated examples). What is $\mathrm{Var}(\bar{X}_m)$? Comment.

Exercise 1.5. **(Proof)** Use Jensen's inequality (Theorem 1.3) to prove the following statements. (a) $\mathbb{E}|X| \leq \sqrt{\mathbb{E}[X^2]}$ for every X with $\mathbb{E}[X^2] < +\infty$. (b) $\mathbb{E}[\sqrt{Z}] \leq \sqrt{\mathbb{E}[Z]}$ for every nonnegative Z with finite expectation. (c) (Arithmetic–geometric mean inequality) For positive numbers $x_1, \ldots, x_n$, $\left(\prod_{i=1}^n x_i\right)^{1/n} \leq \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^n x_i$. Hint: consider a variable uniform on $\{x_1, \ldots, x_n\}$. (d) $\mathbb{E}[1/X] \geq 1/\mathbb{E}[X]$ for every positive X (with finite expectations). Check it for X uniform on $\{1, 3\}$.

Exercise 1.6. **(Application)** A variable $X \in \{0, 1, 2\}$ describes a patient and $Y \in \{-1, +1\}$ is the diagnosis. We know that $\mathbb{P}(X = 0) = 0.5$, $\mathbb{P}(X = 1) = 0.3$, $\mathbb{P}(X = 2) = 0.2$, and that $\eta(x) = \mathbb{P}(Y = +1 \mid X = x)$ equals 0.1, 0.6 and 0.9 for $x = 0, 1, 2$. (a) Compute $\mathbb{P}(Y = +1)$ with the law of total probability, and $\mathbb{P}(X = 2 \mid Y = +1)$ with Bayes' formula. (b) Give the Bayes classifier $h^\star$ and its risk $\mathcal{R}^\star$ (Theorem 1.5). (c) Compute the risk of the constant classifier $h \equiv -1$, which predicts the majority class. (d) Compute $\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X = x]$ for each x, and check the tower property $\mathbb{E}\left[\mathbb{E}[Y \mid X]\right] = \mathbb{E}[Y]$.

Exercise 1.7. **(Proof)** Let (X, Y) be a pair of random variables with $\mathbb{E}[Y^2] < +\infty$ and $f^\star(x) = \mathbb{E}[Y \mid X = x]$. (a) Prove the decomposition of Theorem 1.5 (i), detailing each use of the properties of the conditional expectation. (b) Assume that $X \sim \mathcal{U}([0, 1])$ and $Y = 2X + \varepsilon$, where $\varepsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$ is independent of X. Compute $f^\star$, the Bayes risk for the squared loss, and the quadratic risk of the predictor $g(x) = x$.

Exercise 1.8. **(Computation)** (a) Let $\mu > 0$ and $t \geq \mu$. Give a nonnegative variable X with $\mathbb{E}[X] = \mu$ for which Markov's inequality $\mathbb{P}(X \geq t) \leq \mu/t$ is an equality. (b) Let $0 < \sigma \leq \varepsilon$. Show that the variable X equal to $-\varepsilon$ and $+\varepsilon$ with probability $\frac{\sigma^2}{2\varepsilon^2}$ each, and to 0 otherwise, makes Chebyshev's inequality an equality. (c) Let $X \sim \mathrm{Bin}(100, 0.5)$. Bound $\mathbb{P}(X \geq 60)$ with Markov's, Chebyshev's and Hoeffding's inequalities, and compare with the exact value $\mathbb{P}(X \geq 60) \approx 0.0284$.

Exercise 1.9. **(Proof)** (a) Let $X \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$. Show that $\mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda X}] = e^{\lambda\mu + \lambda^2\sigma^2/2}$ and deduce from Chernoff's bound that $\mathbb{P}(X - \mu \geq t) \leq e^{-t^2/(2\sigma^2)}$ for $t \geq 0$. (b) Let $X_1, \ldots, X_m$ be i.i.d. $\mathcal{B}(p)$

and $p < q < 1$. Detail the computation of example 1.6: show that $\sup_{\lambda \geq 0}[\lambda q - \ln(1-p+pe^{\lambda})] = \mathrm{kl}(q\|p)$. (c) Using Pinsker's inequality $\mathrm{kl}(q\|p) \geq 2(q-p)^2$ (admitted), show that the kl bound is always at least as good as Hoeffding's. Compute both for $m = 100$, $p = 0.1$, $q = 0.2$ and compare with the exact value $\mathbb{P}(\bar{X}_{100} \geq 0.2) \approx 0.0020$.

Exercise 1.10. **(Application)** A company has trained a spam filter h on its own data; you are asked to certify its error rate p on new e-mails. You are given an i.i.d. test set of m labelled e-mails, never seen during training, and the 0-1 loss. (a) Why is the test error $\widehat{p}$ an unbiased estimator of p? What would change if the test e-mails had been used to tune the filter? (b) How many test e-mails are needed to guarantee $|\widehat{p} - p| < 0.02$ with probability at least 0.99, using Chebyshev's inequality (with $\mathrm{Var} \leq \frac{1}{4}$)? Using Hoeffding's inequality? (c) With $m = 2000$, the filter makes 240 errors. Give a two-sided confidence interval for p at level 95% with Hoeffding's inequality. (d) In fact, 20 filters were evaluated on the same test set, and the best one, h, was retained. Is the interval of (c) still valid? Propose a valid one. (e) Compare with the CLT interval $\widehat{p} \pm 1.96\sqrt{\widehat{p}(1-\widehat{p})/m}$, and discuss.

Exercise 1.11. **(Proof)** Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a class of predictors, ℓ a loss with values in $[0,1]$, $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$, and $\Phi(S) = \sup_{h \in \mathcal{H}} \big(\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)\big)$. (a) Show that, for two functions u, v on $\mathcal{H}$ bounded above, $\big|\sup_h u(h) - \sup_h v(h)\big| \leq \sup_h |u(h) - v(h)|$. (b) Deduce that Φ satisfies the bounded differences property with $c_i = 1/m$. (c) Deduce from McDiarmid's inequality that, with probability at least $1-\delta$, for all $h \in \mathcal{H}$, $\mathcal{R}(h) \leq \mathcal{R}_S(h) + \mathbb{E}[\Phi(S)] + \sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)/(2m)}$. (d) What does (c) give when $\mathcal{H} = \{h\}$ contains a single predictor?

Exercise 1.12. **(Computation)** The losses of a fixed classifier are i.i.d. $\mathcal{B}(p)$, so that $|X_i - p| \leq 1$ ($c = 1$) and $\sigma^2 = p(1-p)$. Let $m = 1000$ and $\delta = 0.05$, and consider the one-sided deviations $\varepsilon_H = \sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)/(2m)}$ (Hoeffding) and $\varepsilon_B = \sqrt{2\sigma^2 \ln(1/\delta)/m} + \frac{2\ln(1/\delta)}{3m}$ (Bernstein, Theorem 1.16). (a) Compute ε_H, and ε_B for $p = 0.01$ and for $p = 0.5$. (b) For which values of σ^2, then of $p \leq \frac{1}{2}$, is Bernstein's deviation smaller than Hoeffding's? (c) Explain why ε_B cannot be computed in practice, and how this problem can be circumvented.

Exercise 1.13. **(Python)** Simulate $N = 100\,000$ samples of $m = 50$ i.i.d. $\mathcal{B}(0.3)$ variables with `numpy`. For $t \in \{0.05, 0.1, 0.15, 0.2\}$, estimate $\mathbb{P}(\bar{X}_m - p \geq t)$, compute the exact value with `scipy.stats.binom`, and compare with the bounds of Markov ($p/(p+t)$), Chebyshev ($p(1-p)/(mt^2)$) and Hoeffding (e^{-2mt^2}). Comment.

Exercise 1.14. **(Python)** Let $p = 0.01$ be the error rate of a classifier evaluated on $m = 100$ test examples. Compute exactly (by summing the binomial probabilities, without simulation) the *coverage*, i.e. the probability that the interval contains p, of (a) the CLT interval $\widehat{p} \pm 1.96\sqrt{\widehat{p}(1-\widehat{p})/m}$ and (b) the Hoeffding interval $\widehat{p} \pm \sqrt{\ln(2/\delta)/(2m)}$ with $\delta = 0.05$. (c) Redo (a) for $p = 0.3$. Comment.

Exercise 1.15. **(Proof)** Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a finite class of K classifiers, the 0-1 loss and $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$. (a) Prove that, with probability at least $1-\delta$, $|\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)| < \sqrt{\frac{\ln(2K/\delta)}{2m}}$ simultaneously for all $h \in \mathcal{H}$. (b) Let $h_S \in \arg\min_{h \in \mathcal{H}} \mathcal{R}_S(h)$ and $h^\dagger \in \arg\min_{h \in \mathcal{H}} \mathcal{R}(h)$. Deduce that, with probability at least $1-\delta$, $\mathcal{R}(h_S) < \mathcal{R}(h^\dagger) + 2\sqrt{\frac{\ln(2K/\delta)}{2m}}$. (c) How many examples are needed to guarantee a uniform deviation of at most $\varepsilon = 0.05$ with $\delta = 0.05$ when $K = 1000$? When $K = 10^6$? (d) Why can the argument not be used directly for the class of all linear classifiers of $\mathbb{R}^d$?

2 Linear Algebra and Convexity

This first section briefly introduces the mathematical tools required for the rest of the course[1]. Throughout this section, we work in a real vector space E of finite dimension d, which can be identified with $\mathbb{R}^d$.

About this section

Guiding question. *Which geometric and analytic tools do we need to write a learning problem as an optimization problem, and to know when it is "easy"?*

In this section you will learn to:

- *measure the size of vectors and matrices with norms, and interpret the inner product geometrically (angles, projections);*
- *compute gradients and Hessian matrices of functions of several variables;*
- *recognize convex sets and convex functions, and prove convexity from the definition or with the derivatives;*
- *read the eigenvalues of a symmetric matrix on the level sets of the associated quadratic form.*

In a nutshell

Almost every learning algorithm of this course minimizes a function of a vector of parameters (the weights of a linear model, of a neural network, *etc.*). Linear algebra gives us the language to describe these parameters and the geometry of the space they live in, while convexity tells us when this minimization is well-behaved: for a convex function, every local minimum is a global one.

2.1 Norms

Given two vectors $\mathbf{x}$ and $\mathbf{y}$ of $\mathbb{R}^d$, we define their inner product as the sum of the products of their components, *i.e.*

$$\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \rangle = \mathbf{x}^T \mathbf{y} = \sum_{j=1}^{d} x_j y_j.$$

When we compute the inner product of $\mathbf{x}$ with itself, we obtain the squared norm of $\mathbf{x}$:

$$\|\mathbf{x}\|^2 = \langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x} \rangle.$$

Definition 2.1: Norm

Let E be a real vector space of dimension d. A map $\|\cdot\| : E \to \mathbb{R}$ is said to be a norm if, for all $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in E$ and for all $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$, the following properties hold:

[1] You can also read the Linear Algebra course that I wrote for second-year Bachelor students, which is available on my website.

- $\|\mathbf{u}\| \geq 0$ (nonnegativity),
- $\|\mathbf{u}\| = 0 \iff \mathbf{u} = \mathbf{0}$ (definiteness),
- $\|\lambda\mathbf{u}\| = |\lambda| \|\mathbf{u}\|$ (absolute homogeneity),
- $\|\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{v}\| \leq \|\mathbf{u}\| + \|\mathbf{v}\|$ (triangle inequality).

A norm can be used to measure the distance between two vectors $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}$ of the same vector space:

$$d(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}) = \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\| .$$

The following norms are the most commonly used:

- the Manhattan norm, also known as the L_1-norm:

$$\|\mathbf{x}\|_1 = \sum_{j=1}^{d} |x_j|;$$

- the Euclidean norm, also known as the L_2-norm:

$$\|\mathbf{x}\|_2 = \sqrt{\sum_{j=1}^{d} x_j^2};$$

- the L_∞-norm (or max norm):

$$\|\mathbf{x}\|_\infty = \max_{j \in [\![1,d]\!]} |x_j|;$$

- more generally, for any real number $p \geq 1$, the L_p-norm:

$$\|\mathbf{x}\|_p = \left(\sum_{j=1}^{d} |x_j|^p \right)^{1/p} .$$

It is also possible to define more complex norms when we work with objects other than vectors, such as matrices or functions.

Example 2.1. Let us show that the Euclidean norm is indeed a norm. We have to check each property of the definition. Let $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$.

- It is obvious that $\|\mathbf{x}\|_2 = \sqrt{\sum_{j=1}^{d} |x_j|^2}$ is nonnegative.
- Each $|x_j|^2$ is a nonnegative number, and a sum of nonnegative numbers is equal to zero if and only if all of them are equal to zero. Hence $\|\mathbf{x}\|_2 = 0 \Rightarrow \mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$, and the converse is obvious.

- We then focus on absolute homogeneity:

$$\begin{aligned}\|\lambda\mathbf{x}\|_2 &= \sqrt{\sum_{j=1}^{d}(\lambda x_j)^2} \\ &= \sqrt{\sum_{j=1}^{d}|\lambda|^2 x_j^2} \\ &\quad \downarrow \ \lambda \text{ does not depend on the index } j \\ &= |\lambda|\sqrt{\sum_{j=1}^{d} x_j^2}.\end{aligned}$$

- To prove the triangle inequality, we use the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality, which holds for any inner product and the norm it induces (here, the Euclidean inner product and the L_2-norm):

$$|\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle| \leq \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \|\mathbf{y}\|_2 .$$

Thus,

$$\begin{aligned}\|\mathbf{x}+\mathbf{y}\|_2^2 &= \|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 + 2\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle + \|\mathbf{y}\|_2^2 \\ &\quad \downarrow \ \text{using the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality} \\ &\leq \|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 + 2\|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \|\mathbf{y}\|_2 + \|\mathbf{y}\|_2^2 \\ &= (\|\mathbf{x}\|_2 + \|\mathbf{y}\|_2)^2 .\end{aligned}$$

Taking the square root, which is an increasing function, gives the result.

Geometric meaning of the inner product The Cauchy–Schwarz inequality states that, for nonzero vectors, the ratio $\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle/(\|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \|\mathbf{y}\|_2)$ lies in $[-1, 1]$. It is therefore the cosine of an angle $\theta \in [0, \pi]$, the angle between $\mathbf{x}$ and $\mathbf{y}$:

$$\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle = \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \|\mathbf{y}\|_2 \cos\theta.$$

In particular, $\mathbf{x}$ and $\mathbf{y}$ are orthogonal when $\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle = 0$. The inner product also gives the orthogonal projection of $\mathbf{x}$ onto the line spanned by a nonzero vector $\mathbf{y}$:

$$\mathbf{p} = \frac{\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle}{\|\mathbf{y}\|_2^2}\mathbf{y}, \qquad \text{with} \quad \langle \mathbf{x}-\mathbf{p}, \mathbf{y}\rangle = 0,$$

see Figure 8. When $\|\mathbf{y}\|_2 = 1$, the length of the projection is simply $|\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle|$: *the inner product with a unit vector measures how far* $\mathbf{x}$ *goes in the direction* $\mathbf{y}$.

> **Remark** In Machine Learning, the quantity $\cos\theta = \langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}\rangle/(\|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \|\mathbf{y}\|_2)$ is known as the *cosine similarity*; it is widely used to compare documents or embeddings.

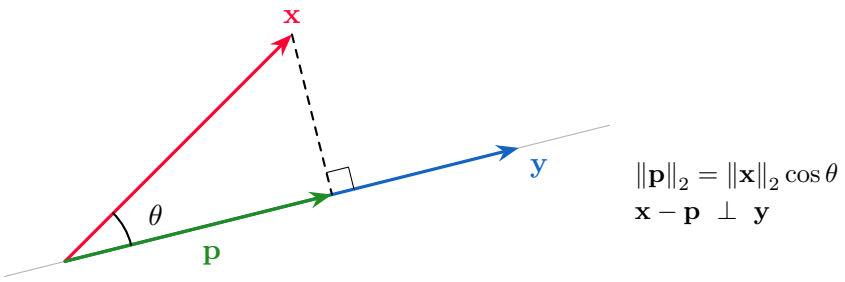


Figure 8: Geometric view of the inner product: $\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \rangle = \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \|\mathbf{y}\|_2 \cos\theta$, and $\mathbf{p} = \frac{\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \rangle}{\|\mathbf{y}\|_2^2} \mathbf{y}$ is the orthogonal projection of $\mathbf{x}$ onto the line spanned by $\mathbf{y}$ (here θ is acute, so $\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \rangle > 0$).

Similarly, a linear model predicts with $\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b$: the sign of the prediction tells on which side of the hyperplane $\{\mathbf{x} \mid \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b = 0\}$ the point $\mathbf{x}$ lies, and, when $\|\mathbf{w}\|_2 = 1$, its absolute value is the distance from $\mathbf{x}$ to this hyperplane.

We can also represent the unit balls associated with the norms defined above, see Figure 9. For every $p \geq 1$, the unit ball is a convex set, which reflects the fact that every norm is a convex function (for $p < 1$, the quantity $\|\cdot\|_p$ is no longer a norm and its unit ball is not convex). Figure 10 shows how the unit ball deforms continuously from the diamond ($p = 1$) to the square ($p = \infty$), and what goes wrong when $p < 1$: the triangle inequality fails and the ball has "inward" corners.

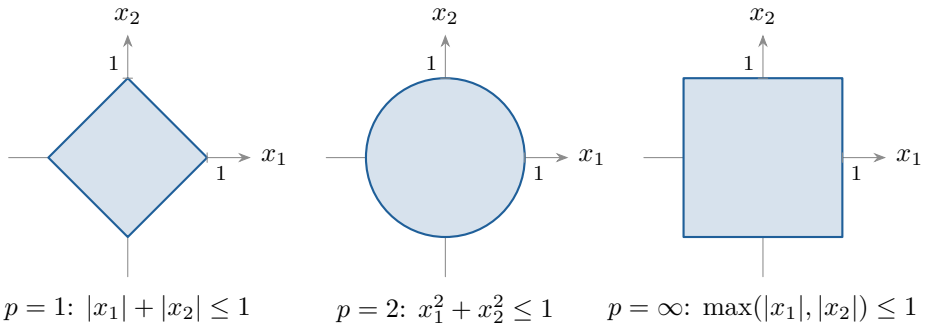


Figure 9: Unit balls $\{\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^2 \mid \|\mathbf{x}\|_p \leq 1\}$ of the L_1-norm (a "diamond"), of the L_2-norm (a disk) and of the L_∞-norm (a square). All three are convex, and they are nested: diamond $\subset$ disk $\subset$ square.

In a nutshell

All norms on $\mathbb{R}^d$ are equivalent (for instance $\|\mathbf{x}\|_\infty \leq \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \leq \|\mathbf{x}\|_1 \leq \sqrt{d}\, \|\mathbf{x}\|_2$), so they define the same notion of convergence; but they do not have the same shape. This shape matters in Machine Learning: when the norm of the parameters is used as a penalty (regularization), the corners of the L_1 ball on the axes favour solutions with many zero coordinates (sparse models, the Lasso), whereas the round L_2 ball only shrinks the coordinates (ridge regression).

Let us now focus on norms on matrices, and more specifically on the Frobenius norm.

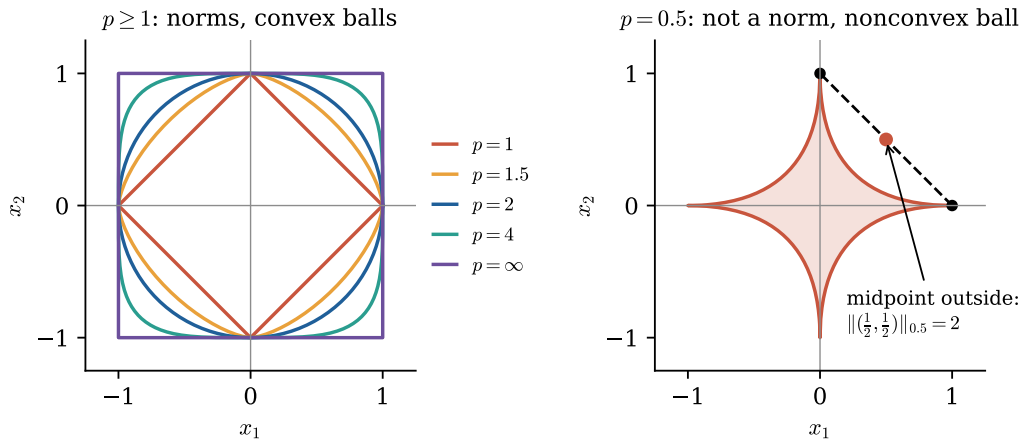


Figure 10: Left: unit spheres $\{\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^2 \mid \|\mathbf{x}\|_p = 1\}$ for several $p \geq 1$; the balls are nested, $\|\mathbf{x}\|_\infty \leq \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \leq \|\mathbf{x}\|_1$, and all of them are convex. Right: for $p = 0.5$, the points $(1, 0)$ and $(0, 1)$ belong to the "ball" but their midpoint does not, so the set is not convex and $\|\cdot\|_{0.5}$ is not a norm.

Definition 2.2: Frobenius norm on Matrices

Given two matrices $\mathbf{X}, \mathbf{Y} \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times d}$, their inner product is defined by

$$\langle \mathbf{X}, \mathbf{Y} \rangle = \mathrm{Tr}\left(\mathbf{X}^T \mathbf{Y}\right) = \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sum_{j=1}^{d} X_{ij} Y_{ij}.$$

The norm induced by this inner product is the Frobenius norm:

$$\|\mathbf{X}\|_F = \sqrt{\mathrm{Tr}\left(\mathbf{X}^T \mathbf{X}\right)} = \left(\sum_{i=1}^{m} \sum_{j=1}^{d} X_{ij}^2 \right)^{1/2}.$$

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q2.1. Is the function $\mathbf{x} \mapsto \|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2$ a norm?

Q2.2. What is the orthogonal projection of $\mathbf{x} = (2, 3)^T$ onto the line spanned by $\mathbf{y} = (1, 0)^T$? And onto the line spanned by $(1, 1)^T$?

Q2.3. True or false? For every $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, $\|\mathbf{x}\|_1 \leq \|\mathbf{x}\|_2$.

Q2.4. Compute $\|\mathbf{I}_d\|_F$ and, for $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^m$ and $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, the Frobenius norm of the rank-one matrix $\mathbf{x}\mathbf{y}^T$.

2.2 Derivatives

The notion of derivative, or more generally of gradient, is fundamental in optimization. It is at the heart of gradient descent algorithms, and it will also allow us to characterize

convex functions. As we will see, this characterization can be made by studying the first-order derivative or, often more simply, the second-order derivative.

A few reminders Let us start with a reminder on the derivative of a function of one variable.

Definition 2.3: Derivative

Let $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ be a function and $x_0 \in \mathbb{R}$. We say that f is differentiable at x_0 if the limit

$$f'(x_0) = \lim_{h \to 0} \frac{f(x_0 + h) - f(x_0)}{h}$$

exists and is finite.
Equivalently, f is differentiable at x_0 if, for h close to 0, we have

$$f(x_0 + h) = f(x_0) + hf'(x_0) + h\,\varepsilon(h),$$

where $\varepsilon(h)$ is a function that tends to 0 when h tends to 0.

The last formula is called the first-order approximation of the function f, and it can be generalized to any order. This is what we call the Taylor expansion of a function.

Proposition 2.1: Taylor's Theorem

Let $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ be a function that is k times differentiable, with $k \geq 1$, at a point x_0. Then there exists a function $\varepsilon_k : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ such that

$$f(x_0 + h) = f(x_0) + hf'(x_0) + f''(x_0)\frac{h^2}{2} + \ldots + f^{(k)}(x_0)\frac{h^k}{k!} + h^k\varepsilon_k(h),$$

where $\lim_{h \to 0} \varepsilon_k(h) = 0$.

First- and second-order derivatives of a function of several variables In Machine Learning, as the reader may have seen with linear models, the number of parameters to learn is almost always greater than 1. We are therefore most often led to study real-valued functions of several variables, *i.e.* functions which take a vector as input and return a real value.

Definition 2.4: First-order Derivative

Let $f : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}$ be a continuous function and $\mathbf{x}_0 \in \mathbb{R}^d$. Then f is differentiable at $\mathbf{x}_0$ if there exists a (row) vector $Jf(\mathbf{x}_0) \in \mathbb{R}^{1 \times d}$ such that

$$\lim_{\mathbf{x} \to \mathbf{x}_0} \frac{|f(\mathbf{x}) - f(\mathbf{x}_0) - Jf(\mathbf{x}_0)(\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}_0)|}{\|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}_0\|} = 0.$$

For all i, the components of $Jf(\mathbf{x}_0)$, called the Jacobian of f at $\mathbf{x}_0$, are given by the partial derivatives

$$J_i f(\mathbf{x}_0) = \left.\frac{\partial f(\mathbf{x})}{\partial x_i}\right|_{\mathbf{x}=\mathbf{x}_0}.$$

The column vector $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}_0) = Jf(\mathbf{x}_0)^T$ is called the gradient of f at $\mathbf{x}_0$.

The gradient makes it possible to approximate the function in the neighborhood of the point where it is computed, *i.e.* in a neighborhood $V(\mathbf{x}_0)$ of $\mathbf{x}_0$. For all $\mathbf{x} \in V(\mathbf{x}_0)$, we have

$$f(\mathbf{x}) \simeq f(\mathbf{x}_0) + \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{x}_0), \mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}_0 \rangle.$$

It is this approximation that will provide a first characterization of convex functions. In the following, we often identify the Jacobian with the gradient, and we write $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}_0)(\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}_0)$ or $\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{x}_0), \mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}_0 \rangle$ indifferently.

In a nutshell

Moving from $\mathbf{x}_0$ by a small step $h\mathbf{d}$ in a unit direction $\mathbf{d}$ changes the value of f by approximately $h\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{x}_0), \mathbf{d} \rangle$. By the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality, this quantity is maximal when $\mathbf{d} = \nabla f(\mathbf{x}_0) / \|\nabla f(\mathbf{x}_0)\|_2$ and minimal for the opposite direction: *the gradient points in the direction of steepest ascent*, and $-\nabla f(\mathbf{x}_0)$ in the direction of steepest descent. This simple observation is the starting point of the gradient descent algorithm of Section 3. In the same way, the gradient is orthogonal to the level set $\{\mathbf{x} \mid f(\mathbf{x}) = f(\mathbf{x}_0)\}$, since f does not change to first order along this set.

Example 2.2. Let us consider the function $f : \mathbb{R}^3 \to \mathbb{R}$ defined by

$$f(x_1, x_2, x_3) = 3x_1^2 + 2x_1x_2x_3 + 6x_3 + 5x_2x_3 + 9x_1x_3.$$

We want to compute the Jacobian (or gradient) of this function. To do so, we need to compute

$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_1}, \quad \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_2} \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_3}.$$

The Jacobian of f at (x_1, x_2, x_3) is given by

$$Jf(x_1, x_2, x_3) = \begin{pmatrix} 6x_1 + 2x_2x_3 + 9x_3 & 2x_1x_3 + 5x_3 & 2x_1x_2 + 6 + 5x_2 + 9x_1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Example 2.3. We consider the log-sum-exp function, defined for all $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and a fixed vector $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ by

$$f(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{b}) = \ln \sum_{j=1}^{d} \exp\left(x_j + b_j\right).$$

When $\mathbf{b} = \mathbf{0}$, this function is known to be a good (and smooth!) approximation of the function $\mathbf{x} \mapsto \max_j x_j$.

The gradient $\nabla_{\mathbf{x}} f(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{b})$ of this function (written here as a row vector) is given by

$$\nabla_{\mathbf{x}} f(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{b}) = \left(\frac{\exp(x_1 + b_1)}{\sum_{j=1}^d \exp(x_j + b_j)} \quad \cdots \quad \frac{\exp(x_d + b_d)}{\sum_{j=1}^d \exp(x_j + b_j)} \right).$$

Its components are positive and sum to 1: this is the *softmax* function, which we will meet again with neural networks.

Definition 2.5: Second-order Derivative

Let $f : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}$ be a real-valued function. Provided that this function is twice differentiable at $\mathbf{x}_0$, its second-order derivative at $\mathbf{x}_0$, also called the Hessian of f at $\mathbf{x}_0$, is the matrix $\mathbf{H} = \nabla^2_{\mathbf{x}} f(\mathbf{x}_0) \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$ whose entries are given by

$$H_{ij} = \left. \frac{\partial^2 f(\mathbf{x})}{\partial x_i \partial x_j} \right|_{\mathbf{x}=\mathbf{x}_0}.$$

This matrix is useful to prove whether a function f is convex, and also to build efficient algorithms.

Example 2.4. Let us consider the function $f : \mathbb{R}^2 \to \mathbb{R}$ defined by

$$f(x_1, x_2) = 4x_1^2 + 6x_2^2 + 3x_1 x_2 + 2\left(\cos(x_1) + \sin(x_2)\right),$$

for which we aim to compute the Hessian matrix. We first have to compute the Jacobian of this function:

$$Jf(\mathbf{x}) = \left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_1} \quad \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_2} \right) = \begin{pmatrix} 8x_1 + 3x_2 - 2\sin(x_1) & 12x_2 + 3x_1 + 2\cos(x_2) \end{pmatrix}.$$

The Hessian matrix is then given by

$$\mathbf{H}_f(\mathbf{x}) = \begin{pmatrix} \dfrac{\partial^2 f}{\partial x_1^2} & \dfrac{\partial^2 f}{\partial x_1 \partial x_2} \\ \dfrac{\partial^2 f}{\partial x_2 \partial x_1} & \dfrac{\partial^2 f}{\partial x_2^2} \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 8 - 2\cos(x_1) & 3 \\ 3 & 12 - 2\sin(x_2) \end{pmatrix}.$$

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q2.5. Compute the gradient and the Hessian of $f(\mathbf{x}) = \|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2$ on $\mathbb{R}^d$.

Q2.6. Let $f(x_1, x_2) = x_1^2 x_2$. Use the first-order approximation at $(1, 2)$ to estimate $f(1.01, 2)$, and compare with the exact value.

Q2.7. From the point $(1, 1)$, in which unit direction does $f(x_1, x_2) = x_1^2 + 3x_2^2$ decrease the fastest? Is it the direction pointing to the minimizer $(0, 0)$?

2.3 Convex sets

The notion of convex set is important when we want to build optimization algorithms and guarantee that the successive iterates of these algorithms remain in a given set. Moreover, it will also allow us to characterize convex functions.

Let us start with the definition of a convex set.

Definition 2.6: Convex Set

A set C is said to be convex if, for all $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in C$ and for all $t \in [0, 1]$, we have

$$t\mathbf{u} + (1 - t)\mathbf{v} \in C.$$

In other words, C is convex if every point of the segment joining $\mathbf{u}$ and $\mathbf{v}$ belongs to the set.

Figure 11 provides some examples of convex and nonconvex sets. The first and third shapes represent nonconvex sets: for each of them, we can find two points of the set such that the segment joining them leaves the set. For instance, for the ring, if we take two diametrically opposed points, the segment joining them goes through the hole in the center, which does not belong to the set. The second and fourth shapes represent convex sets: whichever two points we pick, the segment joining them stays inside.

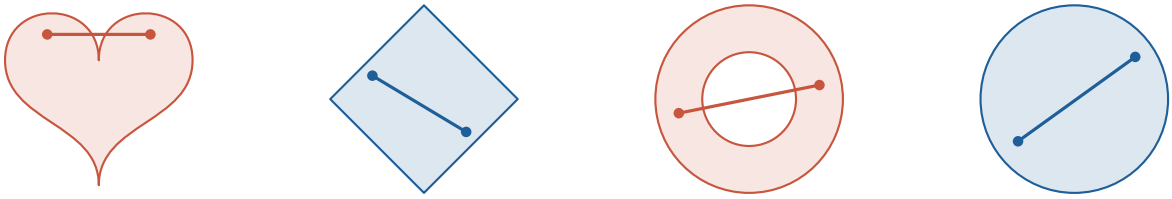


Figure 11: Two nonconvex sets (red) and two convex sets (blue). For the nonconvex sets, the segment joining the two marked points leaves the set (it crosses the notch of the heart, and the hole of the ring); for the convex sets, every such segment stays inside.

Example 2.5. Here are some fundamental examples of convex sets:

- the unit ball $\mathcal{B} = \{\mathbf{u} \in \mathbb{R}^d \mid \|\mathbf{u}\| \leq 1\}$ of any norm;
- every interval of $\mathbb{R}$;
- every hyperplane $\{\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d \mid \mathbf{a}^T\mathbf{x} = b\}$ and every half-space $\{\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d \mid \mathbf{a}^T\mathbf{x} \leq b\}$;
- if C_1 and C_2 are two convex sets, then their intersection $C = C_1 \cap C_2$ is also convex.

Let us study the unit ball, which we have claimed above to be convex, and prove it for the L_2-norm. Consider $\lambda \in [0,1]$ and two vectors $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}$ of the unit ball, and let us set $\mathbf{z} = \lambda\mathbf{u} + (1-\lambda)\mathbf{v}$. Then

$$\begin{aligned}
\|\mathbf{z}\|_2 &= \|\lambda\mathbf{u} + (1-\lambda)\mathbf{v}\|_2 \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ apply the triangle inequality} \\
&\leq \|\lambda\mathbf{u}\|_2 + \|(1-\lambda)\mathbf{v}\|_2 \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ absolute homogeneity of the norm, with } \lambda \geq 0 \text{ and } 1-\lambda \geq 0 \\
&= \lambda \|\mathbf{u}\|_2 + (1-\lambda) \|\mathbf{v}\|_2 \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ both } \mathbf{u} \text{ and } \mathbf{v} \text{ belong to the unit ball} \\
&\leq \lambda + (1-\lambda) = 1.
\end{aligned}$$

Hence $\mathbf{z}$ belongs to the unit ball.

Proposition 2.2: Convex combination

Let $\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2, \ldots, \mathbf{u}_m$ be m points of a convex set C. Then, for all nonnegative numbers $\lambda_1, \lambda_2, \ldots, \lambda_m$ such that $\sum_{i=1}^m \lambda_i = 1$,

$$\mathbf{v} = \sum_{i=1}^m \lambda_i \mathbf{u}_i \in C.$$

In other words, every convex combination of points of a convex set belongs to this convex set.

Given a finite set of points $\mathbf{x}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{x}_m$, the convex combinations of these points form a convex set. This set, called the convex hull $\mathcal{H}$ of the points, is the smallest convex set that contains all of them:

$$\mathcal{H} = \left\{ \mathbf{x} = \sum_{i=1}^m \lambda_i \mathbf{x}_i \;\middle|\; \lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_m \geq 0, \; \sum_{i=1}^m \lambda_i = 1 \right\},$$

see Figure 12.

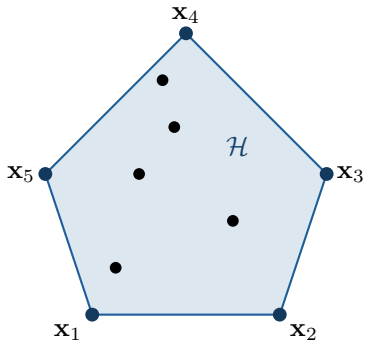


Figure 12: Convex hull $\mathcal{H}$ of ten points of the plane: it is the convex polygon whose vertices $\mathbf{x}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{x}_5$ are five of the points; the five other points lie inside $\mathcal{H}$ and do not change it.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q2.8. Is the union of two convex sets convex? And their intersection?

Q2.9. Is the set $\{\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^2 \mid x_1 x_2 \geq 1\}$ convex?

Q2.10. What is the convex hull of the five points $(0,0), (1,0), (0,1), (1,1)$ and $(\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2})$? Is the way of writing $(\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2})$ as a convex combination of the four others unique?

2.4 Convex functions

The study of convex functions is essential in Machine Learning. Indeed, we will see that most of the problems we will try to solve involve convex functions. Moreover, it is through the study of this type of problem that we will be able to provide theoretical guarantees on the performance of our algorithms.

Fundamental definitions Let us start with the definition of a convex function.

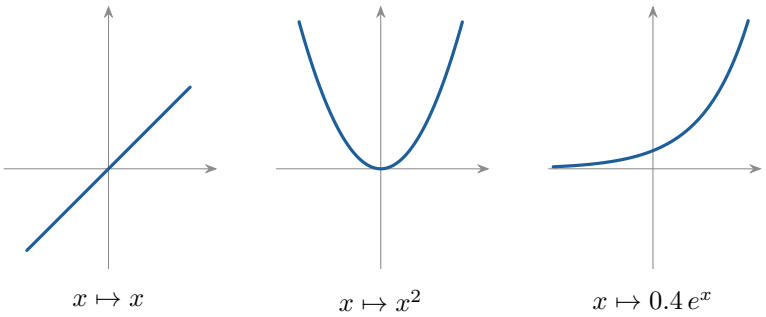
Definition 2.7: Convex functions

Let $\mathcal{U}$ be a nonempty convex subset of a real vector space of dimension d (*i.e.* $\mathcal{U} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$). A function $f : \mathcal{U} \to \mathbb{R}$ is said to be convex if, for all $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in \mathcal{U}$ and for all $t \in [0,1]$, we have

$$f(t\mathbf{u} + (1-t)\mathbf{v}) \leq tf(\mathbf{u}) + (1-t)f(\mathbf{v}).$$

Example 2.6. The following functions are convex:

- any linear (or affine) function,
- $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}, \quad f(x) = x^2$,
- $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}, \quad f(x) = 0.4 \times \exp(x)$.



$x \mapsto x$ $\quad$ $x \mapsto x^2$ $\quad$ $x \mapsto 0.4\, e^x$

Proposition 2.3: Convexity and Restriction

A function $f : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}$ is convex if and only if its restriction to any line is convex, *i.e.* if and only if the function $g : t \mapsto f(\mathbf{x} + t\mathbf{v})$ is convex for all $\mathbf{x}$ and $\mathbf{v}$ (on the set of $t \in \mathbb{R}$ such that $\mathbf{x} + t\mathbf{v}$ belongs to the domain of f). Similarly, f is concave if and only if all such functions g are concave.

Proof. It only requires writing down the definition of a convex function. Assume that f is convex and let t_1, t_2 be two real numbers and $\lambda \in [0, 1]$. Then

$$g(\lambda t_1 + (1-\lambda)t_2) = f\big(\lambda(\mathbf{x} + t_1\mathbf{v}) + (1-\lambda)(\mathbf{x} + t_2\mathbf{v})\big) \leq \lambda g(t_1) + (1-\lambda)g(t_2),$$

so g is convex. Conversely, let $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}$ be two points of the domain of f and $t \in [0, 1]$, and consider the restriction $g(t) = f(\mathbf{v} + t(\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{v}))$ of f to the line going through $\mathbf{v}$ and $\mathbf{u}$. If g is convex, then

$$f(t\mathbf{u} + (1-t)\mathbf{v}) = g(t) = g(t \cdot 1 + (1-t) \cdot 0) \leq tg(1) + (1-t)g(0) = tf(\mathbf{u}) + (1-t)f(\mathbf{v}),$$

which proves that f is convex. The concave case follows by applying this result to $-f$. □

Figure 13 provides an illustration of the definition of convex functions, and Figure 14 contrasts it with a nonconvex function.

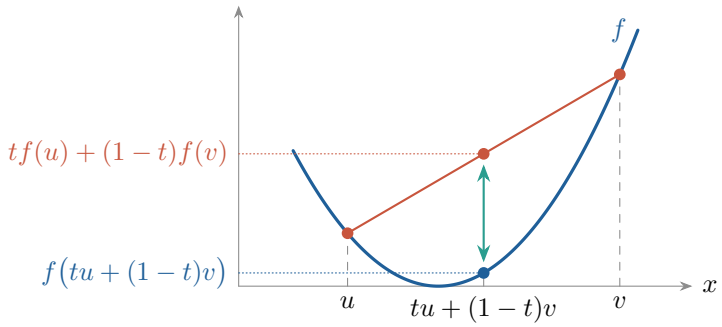


Figure 13: Illustration of the definition of a convex function f (here $f(x) = x^2$, $u = -1$, $v = 2$, $t = 1/2$): the chord (red) joining $(u, f(u))$ and $(v, f(v))$ lies above the graph, *i.e.* $f(tu + (1-t)v) \leq tf(u) + (1-t)f(v)$ for every $t \in [0, 1]$; the teal arrow shows the nonnegative gap between the two sides.

Remark (Jensen's inequality) By induction on the number of points, the definition of convexity extends to any convex combination: if f is convex, then for all $\mathbf{u}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{u}_m \in \mathcal{U}$ and all nonnegative $\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_m$ summing to 1,

$$f\left(\sum_{i=1}^{m} \lambda_i \mathbf{u}_i\right) \leq \sum_{i=1}^{m} \lambda_i f(\mathbf{u}_i).$$

Reading the weights λ_i as the probabilities of a random variable U taking the values $\mathbf{u}_i$, this is $f(\mathbb{E}[U]) \leq \mathbb{E}[f(U)]$, the probabilistic form of Jensen's inequality, which will be used repeatedly in the statistical parts of the course (*e.g.* in Part IV).

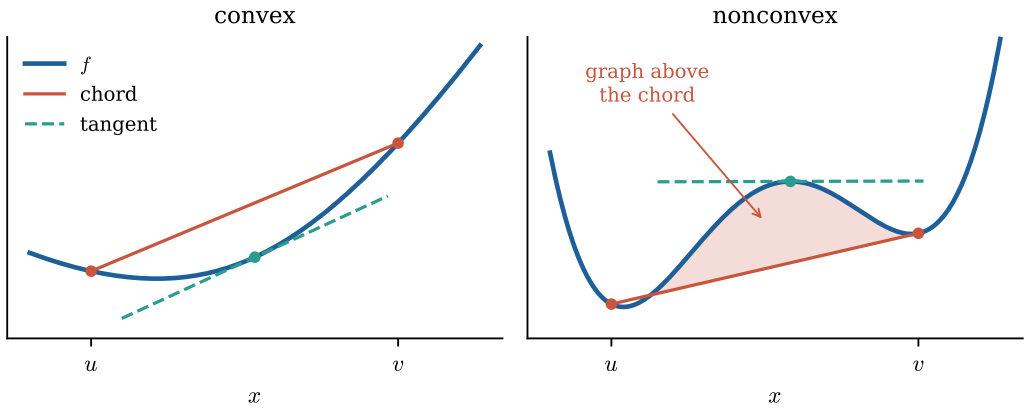


Figure 14: Left: for a convex function, every chord lies above the graph and every tangent lies below it. Right: for a nonconvex function (a "double well"), the graph goes above the chord joining u and v (shaded area), and the tangent at the local maximum goes above the graph. Note that the nonconvex function has two local minima, only one of which is global.

Historical note Convex functions were introduced and studied systematically by the Danish mathematician Johan Jensen, who proved the inequality that bears his name for finite convex combinations (Jensen, 1906). Jensen worked as an engineer for the Copenhagen telephone company and did mathematics in his spare time. A modern reference on convexity and optimization, freely available online, is the book of Boyd and Vandenberghe (2004).

The next definition makes it possible to link convex functions with convex sets.

Definition 2.8: Epigraph

Let $\mathcal{U}$ be a nonempty subset of a real vector space of dimension d (*i.e.* $\mathcal{U} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$) and let $f : \mathcal{U} \to \mathbb{R}$ be a function. The epigraph of f, denoted by E_f, is the set of points lying above the graph of f, *i.e.*

$$E_f = \{(\mathbf{x}, y) \in \mathcal{U} \times \mathbb{R} \mid f(\mathbf{x}) \leq y\}.$$

Proposition 2.4: Convexity via Epigraph

Let $\mathcal{U}$ be a nonempty convex subset of a real vector space of dimension d (*i.e.* $\mathcal{U} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$). A function f is convex on $\mathcal{U}$ if and only if its epigraph E_f is a convex set.

Proof. It is again a direct application of the definitions. Assume that f is convex, and let $(\mathbf{x}_1, y_1)$ and $(\mathbf{x}_2, y_2)$ be two points of E_f and $t \in [0, 1]$. Then

$$f(t\mathbf{x}_1 + (1-t)\mathbf{x}_2) \leq tf(\mathbf{x}_1) + (1-t)f(\mathbf{x}_2) \leq ty_1 + (1-t)y_2,$$

i.e. $t(\mathbf{x}_1, y_1) + (1-t)(\mathbf{x}_2, y_2) \in E_f$: the epigraph is convex. Conversely, assume that E_f is convex and let $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in \mathcal{U}$ and $t \in [0, 1]$. Since $(\mathbf{u}, f(\mathbf{u}))$ and $(\mathbf{v}, f(\mathbf{v}))$ belong to

E_f, so does the point $(t\mathbf{u} + (1-t)\mathbf{v},\, tf(\mathbf{u}) + (1-t)f(\mathbf{v}))$, which exactly means that $f(t\mathbf{u} + (1-t)\mathbf{v}) \leq tf(\mathbf{u}) + (1-t)f(\mathbf{v})$. □

This proposition is illustrated in Figure 15.

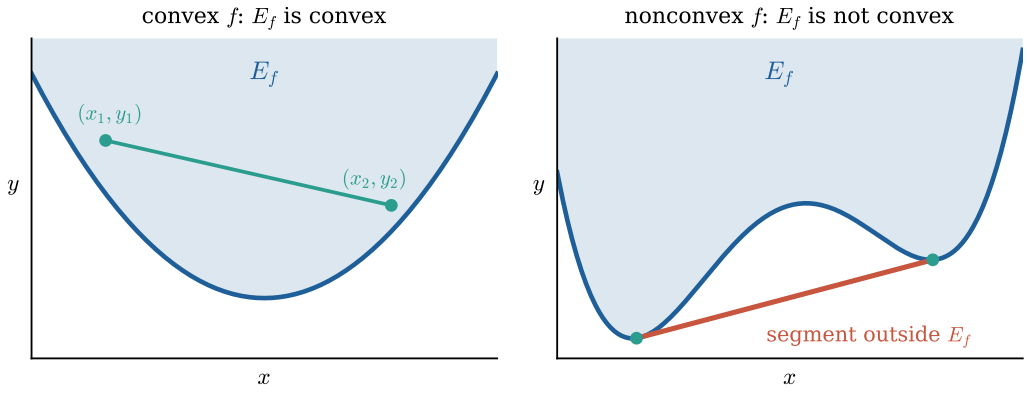


Figure 15: Left: the epigraph E_f (shaded) of a convex function is a convex set: the segment joining two of its points stays inside. Right: for a nonconvex function, the segment joining two points of the graph goes below the graph, *i.e.* it leaves the epigraph, which is therefore not convex.

Definition 2.9: Concave functions

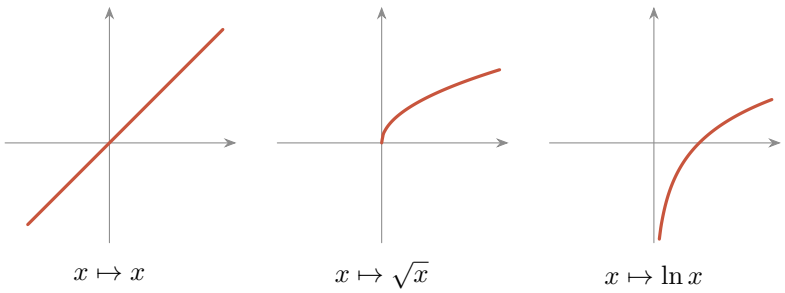
Let $\mathcal{U}$ be a nonempty convex subset of a real vector space of dimension d (*i.e.* $\mathcal{U} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$). A function $f : \mathcal{U} \to \mathbb{R}$ is said to be concave if, for all $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in \mathcal{U}$ and for all $t \in [0, 1]$, we have

$$f(t\mathbf{u} + (1-t)\mathbf{v}) \geq tf(\mathbf{u}) + (1-t)f(\mathbf{v}).$$

With this definition, we directly see that f is concave if and only if $-f$ is convex. Furthermore, it is also possible to characterize concave functions through the convexity of their hypograph, *i.e.* the region below the graph of the function.

Example 2.7. The following functions are concave:

- any linear (or affine) function,
- $f : \mathbb{R}_+ \to \mathbb{R}, \quad f(x) = \sqrt{x}$,
- $f : \mathbb{R}_+^* \to \mathbb{R}, \quad f(x) = \ln(x)$.



The following proposition provides some properties of convex functions.

Proposition 2.5: Properties of Convex Functions

Let f and g be two convex functions defined on a convex subset $\mathcal{U}$ of $\mathbb{R}^d$. Then:

- any linear combination of f and g with nonnegative coefficients, $\alpha f + \beta g$ with $\alpha, \beta \geq 0$, is convex (in particular, any convex combination of f and g);
- if $\varphi : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ is convex and **nondecreasing**, then $\varphi \circ g$ is convex;
- the function h defined by $h(\mathbf{x}) = \max(f(\mathbf{x}), g(\mathbf{x}))$ is convex.

Proof. The proof of this proposition only relies on the definition of convexity; it is left to the reader as an exercise (see Exercises 2.8 and 2.9). □

Pitfall The assumption that φ is **nondecreasing** cannot be dropped. The function $\varphi(t) = e^{-t}$ is convex and $g(x) = x^2$ is convex, but $\varphi \circ g(x) = e^{-x^2}$ is the Gaussian bell, which is not convex (its second derivative $(4x^2 - 2)e^{-x^2}$ is negative for $|x| < 1/\sqrt{2}$). Similarly, the product of two convex functions or the minimum of two convex functions are not convex in general: think of $x \mapsto x \cdot x^2 = x^3$ or of $x \mapsto \min((x-1)^2, (x+1)^2)$.

Remark Another very useful rule: *the composition of a convex function with an affine map is convex.* If $f : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}$ is convex, $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times d}$ and $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, then $\mathbf{x} \mapsto f(\mathbf{A}\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{b})$ is convex on $\mathbb{R}^d$ (see Exercise 2.10). This is why the losses used in Machine Learning (squared loss, hinge loss, logistic loss, *etc.*) are convex *with respect to the parameters* of a linear model: the prediction $\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b$ is affine in $(\mathbf{w}, b)$.

Characterization of convexity using derivatives In the following, we study how the convexity of a function f can be characterized using its first- and second-order derivatives.

Proposition 2.6: First-order derivative and convexity

Let f be a continuously differentiable function on an open convex set $\mathcal{U} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$. Then f is convex if and only if, for all $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in \mathcal{U}$, we have

$$f(\mathbf{v}) \geq f(\mathbf{u}) + \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{u} \rangle.$$

Equivalently, f is convex if and only if, for all $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in \mathcal{U}$, we have

$$\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{v}) - \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{u} \rangle \geq 0.$$

Proof. Convexity ⇒ first inequality. Let $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in \mathcal{U}$ and $t \in]0,1]$. By convexity, $f(\mathbf{u} + t(\mathbf{v}-\mathbf{u})) \leq f(\mathbf{u}) + t(f(\mathbf{v}) - f(\mathbf{u}))$, hence

$$\frac{f(\mathbf{u} + t(\mathbf{v}-\mathbf{u})) - f(\mathbf{u})}{t} \leq f(\mathbf{v}) - f(\mathbf{u}).$$

Letting $t \to 0$, the left-hand side tends to $\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v}-\mathbf{u} \rangle$, which gives the first inequality.

First inequality ⇒ convexity. Let $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in \mathcal{U}$, $t \in [0,1]$ and $\mathbf{w} = t\mathbf{u} + (1-t)\mathbf{v}$. Applying the inequality at the point $\mathbf{w}$ gives $f(\mathbf{u}) \geq f(\mathbf{w}) + \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{w}), \mathbf{u} - \mathbf{w} \rangle$ and $f(\mathbf{v}) \geq f(\mathbf{w}) + \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{w}), \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{w} \rangle$. Multiplying the first inequality by t, the second one by $1-t$ and summing them, we get

$$tf(\mathbf{u}) + (1-t)f(\mathbf{v}) \geq f(\mathbf{w}) + \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{w}), t\mathbf{u} + (1-t)\mathbf{v} - \mathbf{w} \rangle = f(\mathbf{w}).$$

First inequality ⇒ second inequality. Write the first inequality for the pair $(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v})$ and for the pair $(\mathbf{v}, \mathbf{u})$, and sum them.

Second inequality ⇒ first inequality. Let $\varphi(t) = f(\mathbf{u} + t(\mathbf{v}-\mathbf{u}))$ for $t \in [0,1]$. Then $\varphi'(t) = \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u} + t(\mathbf{v}-\mathbf{u})), \mathbf{v}-\mathbf{u} \rangle$, and applying the second inequality to the points $\mathbf{u} + t(\mathbf{v}-\mathbf{u})$ and $\mathbf{u}$ (and dividing by $t > 0$) gives $\varphi'(t) \geq \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v}-\mathbf{u} \rangle$. Hence

$$f(\mathbf{v}) - f(\mathbf{u}) = \varphi(1) - \varphi(0) = \int_0^1 \varphi'(t)\, dt \;\geq\; \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v}-\mathbf{u} \rangle.$$

□

Proposition 2.6 is illustrated in Figure 16: the tangents of a convex function always lie below its graph. Note that, for a concave function, the tangents lie above the graph.

In a nutshell

The first-order condition is remarkable: a *local* information, the value and the gradient of f at a single point $\mathbf{u}$, gives a *global* lower bound on f over the whole set $\mathcal{U}$. In particular, if $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}^\star) = \mathbf{0}$, then $f(\mathbf{v}) \geq f(\mathbf{u}^\star)$ for every $\mathbf{v} \in \mathcal{U}$: *for a differentiable convex function, every critical point is a global minimum.* This is the main reason why convex problems are considered "easy" in optimization, and why we try to formulate learning problems as convex problems whenever possible.

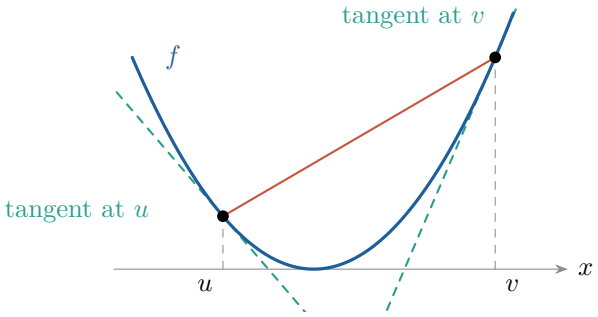


Figure 16: The convex function $f(x) = x^2$ with its tangents (dashed) at the points u and v, and the chord joining them (red). The tangents of a convex function always lie below its graph, while its chords lie above it.

Proposition 2.7: Second-order derivative and convexity

Let f be a twice continuously differentiable function on an open convex subset $\mathcal{U}$ of $\mathbb{R}^d$, and denote by $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u})$ its Hessian matrix at $\mathbf{u}$. Then f is convex if and only if its Hessian is positive semidefinite (PSD) at every point, which we write $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}) \succeq 0$ for all $\mathbf{u} \in \mathcal{U}$, *i.e.*

$$\forall \mathbf{u} \in \mathcal{U},\ \forall \mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^d, \quad \mathbf{z}^T \nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u})\, \mathbf{z} \geq 0.$$

Remember that a symmetric matrix $\mathbf{H}$ is PSD if and only if all its eigenvalues are nonnegative (this is a consequence of the spectral theorem recalled below). It is sometimes easier to check this property than to apply the definition of convexity to a complicated function.

Pitfall Positive semidefiniteness is **not** a property of the entries of the matrix. The matrix $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ has only positive entries, but its eigenvalues are 3 and -1: with $\mathbf{z} = (1, -1)^T$, we get $\mathbf{z}^T \mathbf{H} \mathbf{z} = -2 < 0$. Conversely, a PSD matrix may have negative off-diagonal entries. Also note that a positive *definite* Hessian ($\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}) \succ 0$ everywhere) implies that f is *strictly* convex, but the converse is false: $x \mapsto x^4$ is strictly convex while its second derivative vanishes at 0.

A PSD Hessian means that, along every direction $\mathbf{z}$, the directional derivative $t \mapsto \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}+t\mathbf{z}), \mathbf{z} \rangle$ is a nondecreasing function of t. This is consistent with Proposition 2.6: a differentiable function is convex if and only if its gradient is "nondecreasing" (monotone) along every direction.

Example 2.8. Consider the diagonal matrix $\mathbf{M}$ defined by

$$\mathbf{M} = \begin{pmatrix} \lambda_1 & 0 & \dots & 0 \\ 0 & \lambda_2 & \dots & 0 \\ \vdots & & \ddots & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & \dots & \lambda_d \end{pmatrix},$$

where $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_d$ are nonnegative. Its eigenvalues are $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_d$, so it is PSD. Such matrices arise when the variables are "separated", for instance as the Hessian of a function f of the form

$$f(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_{j=1}^{d} \frac{\lambda_j}{2} x_j^2,$$

which is therefore convex.

Symmetric matrices and quadratic forms The diagonal case of the previous example is, in fact, the general case, up to a rotation of the axes. This is the content of the spectral theorem, one of the most useful results of linear algebra (Strang, 2016; Horn and Johnson, 2012).

Proposition 2.8: Spectral theorem

Let $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times d}$ be a symmetric matrix ($\mathbf{A}^T = \mathbf{A}$). Then all the eigenvalues $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_d$ of $\mathbf{A}$ are real, and there exists an orthonormal basis $(\mathbf{u}_1, \dots, \mathbf{u}_d)$ of $\mathbb{R}^d$ made of eigenvectors of $\mathbf{A}$ ($\mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_j = \lambda_j \mathbf{u}_j$). In matrix form, with $\mathbf{U} = \begin{pmatrix} \mathbf{u}_1 & \cdots & \mathbf{u}_d \end{pmatrix}$ (so that $\mathbf{U}^T\mathbf{U} = \mathbf{I}$) and $\mathbf{\Lambda} = \operatorname{diag}(\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_d)$,

$$\mathbf{A} = \mathbf{U}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{U}^T = \sum_{j=1}^{d} \lambda_j \mathbf{u}_j \mathbf{u}_j^T.$$

Writing $\mathbf{z}$ in the eigenbasis, $\mathbf{z} = \sum_j c_j \mathbf{u}_j$ with $c_j = \langle \mathbf{z}, \mathbf{u}_j \rangle$, the quadratic form associated with $\mathbf{A}$ becomes a weighted sum of squares:

$$\mathbf{z}^T \mathbf{A} \mathbf{z} = \sum_{j=1}^{d} \lambda_j c_j^2.$$

This immediately shows that $\mathbf{A}$ is PSD ($\mathbf{z}^T\mathbf{A}\mathbf{z} \geq 0$ for all $\mathbf{z}$) if and only if all the λ_j are nonnegative, and positive definite if and only if they are all positive. It also gives a geometric picture, shown in Figure 17: the eigenvectors are the axes of the level sets of $\mathbf{z} \mapsto \mathbf{z}^T\mathbf{A}\mathbf{z}$, and the eigenvalues control how fast the function grows along each axis. When f is twice differentiable, Taylor's formula $f(\mathbf{u}+\mathbf{z}) \approx f(\mathbf{u}) + \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{z} \rangle + \frac{1}{2}\mathbf{z}^T \nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}) \mathbf{z}$ shows that, locally, f looks like such a quadratic form: this is why the eigenvalues of the Hessian decide whether f is convex.

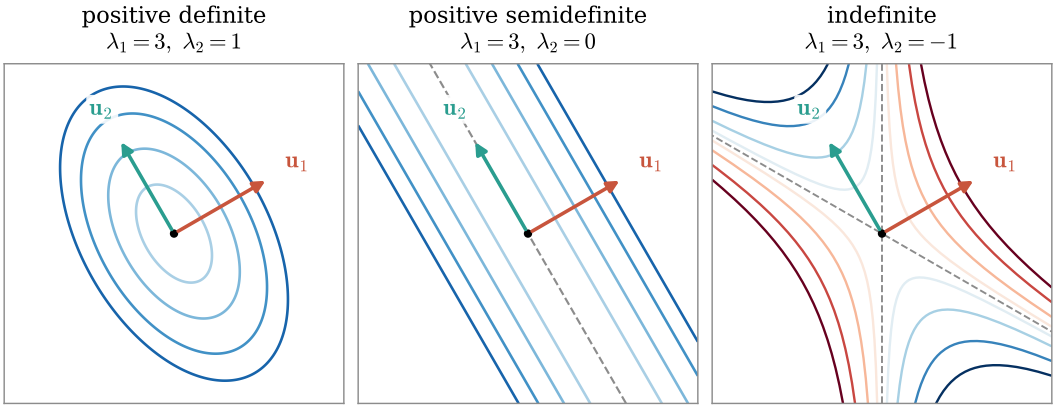


Figure 17: Level sets of the quadratic form $q(\mathbf{z}) = \mathbf{z}^T\mathbf{A}\mathbf{z}$ for $\mathbf{A} = \mathbf{U}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{U}^T$ with the same eigenvectors $\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_2$ (arrows) and three choices of eigenvalues. Left: both eigenvalues are positive, the level sets are ellipses whose axes are the eigenvectors, longer along the direction of the smaller eigenvalue; q is strictly convex with a unique minimizer. Middle: one eigenvalue is zero, q is constant along $\mathbf{u}_2$ (a "valley" of minimizers); q is convex but not strictly. Right: the eigenvalues have opposite signs, q increases along $\mathbf{u}_1$ and decreases along $\mathbf{u}_2$ (red: positive values, blue: negative values); 0 is a saddle point and q is not convex.

Example 2.9. Let $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times d}$ be symmetric, $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, and $f(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{1}{2}\mathbf{x}^T\mathbf{A}\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{b}^T\mathbf{x}$. Then $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{A}\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{b}$ and $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{A}$ for every $\mathbf{x}$, so f is convex if and only if $\mathbf{A}$ is PSD. A fundamental instance is the least-squares objective $f(\mathbf{w}) = \|\mathbf{X}\mathbf{w} - \mathbf{y}\|_2^2$ of linear

regression, whose Hessian $2\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}$ is always PSD, since $\mathbf{z}^T\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}\mathbf{z} = \|\mathbf{X}\mathbf{z}\|_2^2 \geq 0$: the least-squares problem is always convex.

Remark When the smallest eigenvalue of the Hessian is bounded away from zero, *i.e.* $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}) \succeq \alpha \mathbf{I}$ for some $\alpha > 0$ and all $\mathbf{u}$, the function grows at least like a quadratic in every direction, as in the left panel of Figure 17. Such functions are called *strongly convex* (Definition 3.4 in the next section); they have a unique minimizer, and gradient methods converge faster on them. Adding a ridge penalty $\frac{\alpha}{2}\|\mathbf{w}\|_2^2$ to a convex objective makes it α-strongly convex, since it adds $\alpha\mathbf{I}$ to the Hessian.

To remember from Section 2

- A norm measures the size of a vector; the L_1, L_2 and L_∞ norms have different unit balls, all convex. The inner product $\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \rangle = \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \|\mathbf{y}\|_2 \cos\theta$ measures angles and gives orthogonal projections.
- The gradient $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}_0)$ gives the best linear approximation of f around $\mathbf{x}_0$ and points in the direction of steepest ascent; the Hessian $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{x}_0)$ gives the second-order (quadratic) approximation.
- A set is convex if it contains every segment joining two of its points; a function is convex if its chords lie above its graph, *i.e.* if its epigraph is convex.
- For differentiable functions: f is convex $\iff$ its tangents lie below its graph $\iff$ its gradient is monotone $\iff$ (if twice differentiable) its Hessian is PSD everywhere. Consequently, every critical point of a differentiable convex function is a global minimum.
- A symmetric matrix is diagonal in an orthonormal basis of eigenvectors; it is PSD if and only if its eigenvalues are nonnegative, and its eigenvectors and eigenvalues give the axes and the curvatures of the level sets of its quadratic form.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q2.11. Is $f(x) = |x|$ convex? Can Proposition 2.6 be used to prove it?

Q2.12. A differentiable convex function satisfies $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}^\star) = \mathbf{0}$. What can you say about $\mathbf{u}^\star$? Is it necessarily the unique minimizer?

Q2.13. Is the matrix $\begin{pmatrix} 2 & -1 \\ -1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$ positive definite?

Q2.14. Show that $f(x) = e^x - x$ is strictly convex on $\mathbb{R}$ and find its minimizer.

Q2.15. What happens if the Hessian of a twice differentiable function f has a negative eigenvalue at some point $\mathbf{u}$?

Q2.16. True or false? A convex function $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ that is bounded from above is constant.

Exercises

Exercise 2.1. **(Comprehension)** True or false? Justify each answer with a short proof or a counterexample. (a) Every norm on $\mathbb{R}^d$ is a convex function. (b) A strictly convex function $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ always has a unique minimizer. (c) The sum of a convex function and a concave function is convex. (d) The function $x \mapsto x^3$ is convex on $\mathbb{R}_+$. (e) A function $f : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}$ which is both convex and concave is affine. (f) The empty set and $\mathbb{R}^d$ are convex.

Exercise 2.2. **(Computation)** Let $\mathbf{x} = (1, 2, 2)^T$ and $\mathbf{y} = (2, 0, 1)^T$. (a) Compute $\|\mathbf{x}\|_1, \|\mathbf{x}\|_2, \|\mathbf{x}\|_\infty$ and $\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \rangle$. (b) Compute the cosine of the angle θ between $\mathbf{x}$ and $\mathbf{y}$, and θ in degrees. (c) Compute the orthogonal projection $\mathbf{p}$ of $\mathbf{x}$ onto the line spanned by $\mathbf{y}$, and check that $\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{p}$ is orthogonal to $\mathbf{y}$. (d) Deduce the distance from $\mathbf{x}$ to this line.

Exercise 2.3. **(Proof)** Show that the L_1-norm is a norm on $\mathbb{R}^d$. Then show that, for all $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d$,

$$\|\mathbf{x}\|_\infty \leq \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \leq \|\mathbf{x}\|_1 \leq \sqrt{d}\, \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \qquad \text{and} \qquad \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \leq \sqrt{d}\, \|\mathbf{x}\|_\infty ,$$

and give, for each inequality, a nonzero vector for which it is an equality. *Hint:* for the third inequality, apply the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality to the vectors $(|x_1|, \ldots, |x_d|)$ and $(1, \ldots, 1)$.

Exercise 2.4. **(Computation)** Compute the gradient and the Hessian of the following functions on $\mathbb{R}^d$, where $\mathbf{a} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, $\mathbf{M} \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$ (not necessarily symmetric), $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times d}$ and $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^n$: (a) $f(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{a}^T \mathbf{x}$; (b) $f(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{x}^T \mathbf{M} \mathbf{x}$; (c) $f(\mathbf{x}) = \|\mathbf{A}\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{b}\|_2^2$; (d) $f(\mathbf{x}) = \|\mathbf{x}\|_2$, for $\mathbf{x} \neq \mathbf{0}$. Which of these functions are convex? For (d), is f differentiable at $\mathbf{0}$?

Exercise 2.5. **(Computation)** Let $\mathbf{A} = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$. Compute its eigenvalues and an orthonormal basis of eigenvectors, write $\mathbf{A} = \mathbf{U} \mathbf{\Lambda} \mathbf{U}^T$, and sketch the level set $\{\mathbf{z} \mid \mathbf{z}^T \mathbf{A} \mathbf{z} = 1\}$. Along which direction is this ellipse the longest? What are the smallest and largest values of $\mathbf{z}^T \mathbf{A} \mathbf{z}$ on the unit circle $\|\mathbf{z}\|_2 = 1$?

Exercise 2.6. **(Computation)** Using Proposition 2.7, determine for which values of $a \in \mathbb{R}$ the function $f(x_1, x_2) = x_1^2 + a\, x_1 x_2 + x_2^2$ is convex, and for which values it is strictly convex. For $a = 3$, exhibit a direction along which f decreases.

Exercise 2.7. **(Proof)** (a) Prove Proposition 2.2 by induction on m. (b) Show that the convex hull $\mathcal{H}$ of $\mathbf{x}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{x}_m$ is convex. (c) Deduce that $\mathcal{H}$ is the smallest convex set containing $\mathbf{x}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{x}_m$, *i.e.* that it is included in every convex set that contains these points.

Exercise 2.8. **(Proof)** Prove the first two points of Proposition 2.5: (a) if f, g are convex and $\alpha, \beta \geq 0$, then $\alpha f + \beta g$ is convex; (b) if g is convex and $\varphi : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ is convex and nondecreasing, then $\varphi \circ g$ is convex. Point out where each assumption is used. (c) Deduce that $\mathbf{x} \mapsto \exp\left(\|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2\right)$ and $\mathbf{w} \mapsto \|\mathbf{w}\|_2^2 + \lambda \|\mathbf{w}\|_1$ (with $\lambda \geq 0$) are convex.

Exercise 2.9. **(Proof)** Prove the third point of Proposition 2.5: the maximum of two convex functions is convex. Generalize to the maximum of a finite family. Deduce that the hinge loss $z \mapsto \max(0, 1 - z)$ is convex, and that, for a fixed example $(\mathbf{x}, y) \in \mathbb{R}^d \times \{-1, +1\}$, the function $\mathbf{w} \mapsto \max(0, 1 - y\, \mathbf{w}^T \mathbf{x})$ is convex.

Exercise 2.10. **(Proof)** Let $f : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}$ be convex, $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times d}$ and $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^n$. Show that $g : \mathbf{x} \mapsto f(\mathbf{A}\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{b})$ is convex. Deduce that, for a fixed example $(\mathbf{x}, y) \in \mathbb{R}^d \times \{-1, +1\}$, the logistic loss $\mathbf{w} \mapsto \ln\left(1 + \exp(-y\, \mathbf{w}^T \mathbf{x})\right)$ is convex, and so is the empirical risk $\mathbf{w} \mapsto \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^m \ln\left(1 + \exp(-y_i\, \mathbf{w}^T \mathbf{x}_i)\right)$. *Hint:* first show that $\ell : t \mapsto \ln(1 + e^{-t})$ is convex by computing its second derivative.

Exercise 2.11. **(Proof)** (a) Show that, if $f : \mathcal{U} \to \mathbb{R}$ is convex, then for every $c \in \mathbb{R}$ the sublevel set $S_c = \{\mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{U} \mid f(\mathbf{x}) \leq c\}$ is convex. (b) Show that the converse is false with $f(x) = \sqrt{|x|}$ on $\mathbb{R}$. (c) Application: show that the set $\{\mathbf{w} \in \mathbb{R}^d \mid \|\mathbf{X}\mathbf{w} - \mathbf{y}\|_2 \leq \varepsilon\}$ is convex, for any $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times d}$, $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^m$ and $\varepsilon \geq 0$.

Exercise 2.12. **(Computation)** Let $f(\mathbf{x}) = \ln \sum_{j=1}^{d} e^{x_j}$ be the log-sum-exp function on $\mathbb{R}^d$, and let $p_j(\mathbf{x}) = e^{x_j} / \sum_k e^{x_k}$. (a) Show that $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{p}(\mathbf{x}) = (p_1(\mathbf{x}), \dots, p_d(\mathbf{x}))^T$ (the softmax of $\mathbf{x}$). (b) Show that $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{x}) = \operatorname{diag}(\mathbf{p}) - \mathbf{p}\mathbf{p}^T$. (c) Show that, for all $\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, $\mathbf{z}^T \nabla^2 f(\mathbf{x}) \mathbf{z} = \sum_j p_j z_j^2 - \big(\sum_j p_j z_j\big)^2$, and interpret this quantity as the variance of a random variable. Deduce that f is convex. (d) Show that $\max_j x_j \le f(\mathbf{x}) \le \max_j x_j + \ln d$. Compute f for $\mathbf{x} = (1, 2, 3)^T$ and compare with these bounds. (e) Is f strictly convex? *Hint:* compute $f(\mathbf{x} + t\mathbf{1})$.

Exercise 2.13. **(Application)** Let $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times d}$, $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^m$, $\lambda \ge 0$, and consider the ridge regression objective

$$F_\lambda(\mathbf{w}) = \|\mathbf{X}\mathbf{w} - \mathbf{y}\|_2^2 + \lambda \|\mathbf{w}\|_2^2 .$$

(a) Compute $\nabla F_\lambda(\mathbf{w})$ and $\nabla^2 F_\lambda(\mathbf{w})$. (b) Show that F_λ is convex, and that its Hessian satisfies $\nabla^2 F_\lambda \succeq 2\lambda \mathbf{I}$. What does this imply when $\lambda > 0$? (c) Show that, when $\lambda > 0$, F_λ has a unique minimizer $\mathbf{w}_\lambda = (\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X} + \lambda \mathbf{I})^{-1} \mathbf{X}^T \mathbf{y}$. (d) Numerical application with $\mathbf{X} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$ and $\mathbf{y} = (1, 2, 2)^T$: compute $\mathbf{w}_0$ and $\mathbf{w}_1$, their Euclidean norms and the residual sums of squares $\|\mathbf{X}\mathbf{w} - \mathbf{y}\|_2^2$. Comment.

Exercise 2.14. **(Python)** Generate a toy binary classification dataset with numpy: $m = 200$ points $\mathbf{x}_i \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, \mathbf{I}_3)$ and labels $y_i = \operatorname{sign}(\mathbf{w}_\star^T \mathbf{x}_i + 0.5\, \xi_i) \in \{-1, +1\}$ with $\mathbf{w}_\star = (1, -2, 0.5)^T$ and $\xi_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 1)$. Let $R(\mathbf{w}) = \frac{1}{m} \sum_i \ln\big(1 + e^{-y_i \mathbf{w}^T \mathbf{x}_i}\big)$ be the logistic empirical risk. (a) Write the gradient and the Hessian of R (use Exercise 2.10) and implement them. (b) Check the gradient at a random point with centred finite differences $\big(R(\mathbf{w} + \varepsilon \mathbf{e}_j) - R(\mathbf{w} - \varepsilon \mathbf{e}_j)\big)/(2\varepsilon)$. (c) Check numerically that the Hessian is PSD at this point, and that the convexity inequality $R(t\mathbf{u} + (1-t)\mathbf{v}) \le tR(\mathbf{u}) + (1-t)R(\mathbf{v})$ holds for 1000 random triples $(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}, t)$.

3 Unconstrained and Smooth Convex Optimization

This section gives a general presentation of convex optimization; it then focuses on unconstrained convex optimization and presents some fundamental algorithms.

About this section

Guiding question. *How does a computer find the parameters that minimize a training loss when no closed-form formula is available?*

In this section you will learn to:

- *characterize the critical points of a differentiable function with its gradient (Euler's equation) and classify them with its Hessian;*
- *write and run gradient descent, and understand the role of the step size, of line searches (exact step, Armijo's rule) and of the conditioning of the problem;*
- *use Newton's method and quasi-Newton methods (BFGS), and know when they are worth their cost;*
- *recognize the convergence speeds of these algorithms on a log-scale plot.*

3.1 Motivation

Given a convex function $f : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}$, we want to solve the problem

$$\mathbf{x}^\star = \arg\min_{\mathbf{x}\in\mathbb{R}^d} \quad f(\mathbf{x}).$$

The aim of this section is to introduce algorithms that build a sequence $(\mathbf{x}_n)_{n\in\mathbb{N}}$ converging to $\mathbf{x}^\star$, the point at which f reaches its minimum, as in Figure 18.

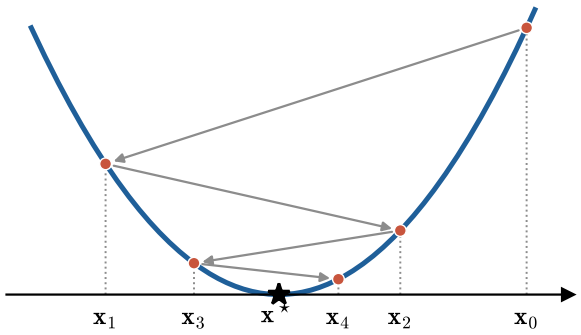


Figure 18: A descent algorithm builds a sequence of points $\mathbf{x}_0, \mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \ldots$ along which the value of f decreases, and which converges to the minimizer $\mathbf{x}^\star$ of f.

We will see how to build such a sequence but, before doing so, we will see how to characterize the optimum of a function f (in our case, its minimum), *i.e.* what the optimality conditions are.

3.2 Optimality Conditions

Let us first define the minimum of a function f.

Definition 3.1: Minimum

Let $f : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}$ be a continuous function. We say that $\mathbf{u} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ is a local minimum of f if there exists a neighborhood $V \subset \mathbb{R}^d$ of $\mathbf{u}$ such that

$$f(\mathbf{u}) \leq f(\mathbf{v}), \quad \forall \mathbf{v} \in V.$$

We say that $\mathbf{u}$ is a global minimum of f if

$$f(\mathbf{u}) \leq f(\mathbf{v}), \quad \forall \mathbf{v} \in \mathbb{R}^d.$$

In other words, a minimum of the function f is simply a point $\mathbf{x}$ where f reaches its lowest value (locally or globally), as illustrated in Figure 19.

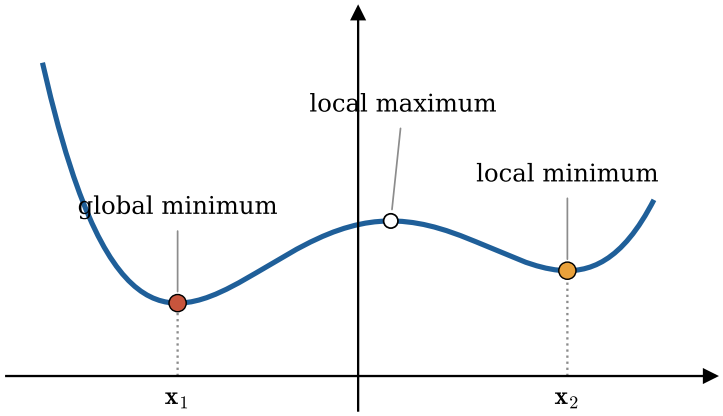


Figure 19: Local and global minima of a function of one variable. The point $\mathbf{x}_1$ is the global minimum of the function, while $\mathbf{x}_2$ is only a local minimum; between them lies a local maximum.

Although such minima are easy to find graphically for a function of one variable, we need other criteria to detect them in general.

The following proposition gives a first characterization of relative (or local) minima.

Proposition 3.1: Euler's Inequality

Let $f : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}$ be a continuous function and $\mathcal{U}$ a nonempty convex set. Furthermore, let $\mathbf{u} \in \mathcal{U}$ be a relative minimum of f on $\mathcal{U}$. If f is differentiable at $\mathbf{u}$, then

$$\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{u} \rangle \geq 0, \quad \forall \mathbf{v} \in \mathcal{U}.$$

This first result will be very useful for constrained problems (see Section 4), but it is rarely used as such for unconstrained ones. If we go back to Figure 19, we see that the minima (and maxima) are located at the points where the derivative of the function is equal to 0. This optimality condition is known as Euler's equation.

Proposition 3.2: Euler's Equation

Let $f : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}$ be a continuous function which is differentiable at $\mathbf{u} \in \mathbb{R}^d$. If $\mathbf{u}$ is a local minimum of f, then

$$\nabla f(\mathbf{u}) = \mathbf{0}.$$

Proof. Let V be a neighborhood of $\mathbf{u}$ as in the definition of a local minimum. For all $\mathbf{v} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, $\mathbf{u} + t\mathbf{v} \in V$ as soon as $t > 0$ is small enough, and a first-order expansion gives

$$\begin{aligned} & f(\mathbf{u}) && \leq f(\mathbf{u} + t\mathbf{v}) = f(\mathbf{u}) + t\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v} \rangle + t \|\mathbf{v}\| \, \varepsilon(t\mathbf{v}), \\ \iff & 0 && \leq t\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v} \rangle + t \|\mathbf{v}\| \, \varepsilon(t\mathbf{v}), \end{aligned}$$

where $\varepsilon(t\mathbf{v}) \to 0$ when $t \to 0$. Dividing by $t > 0$ and letting $t \to 0$, we obtain

$$0 \leq \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v} \rangle.$$

Replacing $\mathbf{v}$ by $-\mathbf{v}$, we also have

$$0 \leq -\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v} \rangle.$$

Hence $\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v} \rangle = 0$ for all $\mathbf{v} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, and thus $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}) = \mathbf{0}$ (take $\mathbf{v} = \nabla f(\mathbf{u})$). □

Although this proof relies on the definition of a (local or global) minimum, the same result holds for a maximum. The solutions of Euler's equation are called *critical points* (or *stationary points*).

Note that this proposition only provides a necessary condition for a point to be a local optimum; this condition is by no means sufficient, as the example below shows.

Example 3.1. Let us consider the functions f and g respectively defined by $f(x) = \frac{1}{2}(x-2)^2 - 2$ and $g(x) = \frac{1}{2}x^3 - 1$, and represented in Figure 20.

The points marked on both graphs ($x = 2$ and $x = 0$) are solutions of Euler's equation, $f'(x) = 0$ and $g'(x) = 0$ respectively. However, while this point is a minimum of f, this is no longer the case for g: its critical point is neither a minimum nor a maximum.

This example shows that it is important to characterize the different solutions of Euler's equation, *i.e.* to determine when they correspond to optima, and what kind of optima they are.

The solutions of *Euler's equation* contain all the points where a differentiable function f reaches a local extremum (a local or global minimum or maximum). Given a solution $\mathbf{u}$ of $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}) = \mathbf{0}$, and assuming that f is twice continuously differentiable, we can say that:

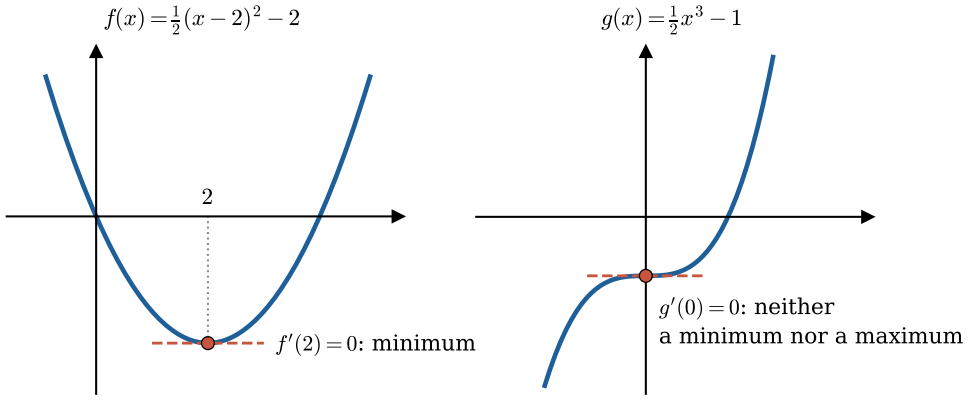


Figure 20: Euler's equation is only a necessary condition. Both functions have a horizontal tangent (dashed) at the marked point, but this critical point is a minimum of f (left) and neither a minimum nor a maximum of g (right).

- $\mathbf{u}$ is a local minimum if $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}) = \mathbf{H}_f(\mathbf{u}) \succ 0$, *i.e.* if the Hessian matrix evaluated at $\mathbf{u}$ is positive definite (all its eigenvalues are positive). This point is a global minimum if the function is convex everywhere; in fact, for a convex function, every critical point is a global minimum;
- $\mathbf{u}$ is a local maximum if $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}) = \mathbf{H}_f(\mathbf{u}) \prec 0$, *i.e.* if the Hessian matrix evaluated at $\mathbf{u}$ is negative definite (all its eigenvalues are negative). This point is a global maximum if the function is concave everywhere;
- if $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u})$ has both positive and negative eigenvalues, $\mathbf{u}$ is neither a minimum nor a maximum (it is a *saddle point*);
- if $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u})$ is only semidefinite (some eigenvalues are zero), we cannot conclude without further study; think of $g(x) = \frac{1}{2}x^3 - 1$ above, for which $g''(0) = 0$.

These three typical situations are represented in Figure 21. They come from the second-order Taylor expansion around a critical point $\mathbf{u}$: since $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}) = \mathbf{0}$,

$$f(\mathbf{u}+\mathbf{h}) = f(\mathbf{u}) + \frac{1}{2}\mathbf{h}^T \nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u})\, \mathbf{h} + o(\|\mathbf{h}\|^2),$$

so that, locally, f behaves like the quadratic form defined by its Hessian: it increases in the directions of the eigenvectors associated with positive eigenvalues and decreases in those associated with negative eigenvalues.

> **Pitfall** In Machine Learning, a vanishing gradient does not mean that we have found a minimum. For nonconvex objectives, such as the training loss of a neural network, saddle points are much more frequent than local maxima in high dimension, and an algorithm based on the gradient alone may slow down considerably in their neighborhood. Convexity is precisely the property that rules out this difficulty: every critical point of a differentiable convex function is a global minimum.

Example 3.2. Let us consider the function $f : \mathbb{R}^2 \to \mathbb{R}$ defined by

$$f(\mathbf{x}) = x_1^2 + 4x_2^2 - 2x_1x_2.$$

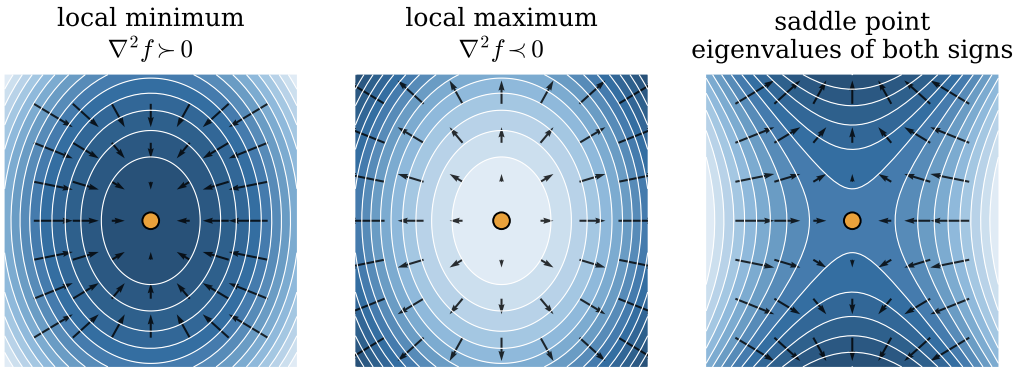


Figure 21: Level sets of f (shaded) and descent directions $-\nabla f$ (arrows) around the three types of nondegenerate critical points (orange dot), where $\nabla f = \mathbf{0}$. Gradient descent is attracted by a minimum, repelled by a maximum, and, around a saddle point, it is attracted along one direction and repelled along the other.

We aim to find the extrema of this function.

We first compute the gradient ∇f of this function and find the values of $\mathbf{x}$ for which this gradient is equal to $\mathbf{0}$. The gradient is given by

$$\nabla f(\mathbf{x}) = \begin{pmatrix} 2x_1 - 2x_2 & 8x_2 - 2x_1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Setting this gradient equal to $\mathbf{0}$ leads to $x_1 = x_2$ using the first component, and then to $x_1 = x_2 = 0$ using the second one. So the point $\mathbf{x}^\star = (0, 0)$ is the only solution of Euler's equation.

We can now compute the Hessian matrix to determine what kind of extremum it is. The Hessian is given by

$$\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{x}) = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & -2 \\ -2 & 8 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The eigenvalues of this matrix, $5 \pm \sqrt{13}$, are both positive: the Hessian is positive definite at every point, so the function f is convex and the point $\mathbf{x}^\star$ is its global minimum.

Example 3.3. Let us study the function $f : [-2, 2]^2 \to \mathbb{R}$ defined by

$$f(\mathbf{x}) = 4 + \left(x_1^2 - 2\cos(2\pi x_1)\right) + \left(x_2^2 - 2\cos(2\pi x_2)\right).$$

This function is particularly interesting because it has many local extrema but a single global minimum, as can be seen in Figure 22. It is therefore often used to test the efficiency of optimization algorithms.

We can see that this function is neither convex nor concave, which could also be verified by studying its Hessian. The gradient of this function is easy to compute:

$$\nabla f(\mathbf{x}) = \begin{pmatrix} 2x_1 + 4\pi\sin(2\pi x_1) & 2x_2 + 4\pi\sin(2\pi x_2) \end{pmatrix}.$$

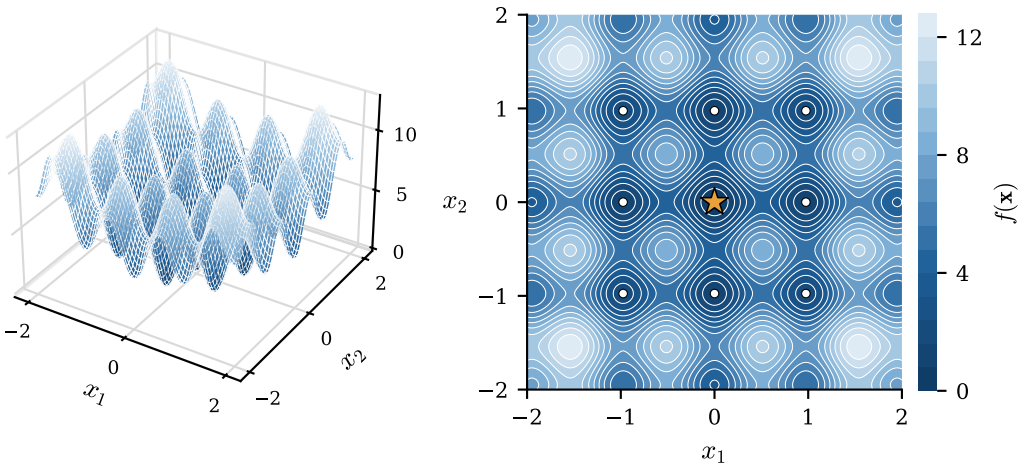


Figure 22: The function $f(\mathbf{x}) = 4 + \big(x_1^2 - 2\cos(2\pi x_1)\big) + \big(x_2^2 - 2\cos(2\pi x_2)\big)$ on $[-2, 2]^2$. Left: its graph. Right: its level sets, some of its local minima (white dots) and its global minimum $\mathbf{0}$ (star). A gradient method started far from the origin is likely to stop at one of the local minima.

The solutions of Euler's equation are obtained by solving the following system:

$$\begin{aligned} x_1 &= -2\pi \sin(2\pi x_1), \\ x_2 &= -2\pi \sin(2\pi x_2). \end{aligned}$$

The two equations are independent but remain hard to solve; an obvious solution, however, is given by the point $\mathbf{x}^\star = (0, 0)$. We can also check that this point is the global minimum of our function: since $x_j^2 \geq 0$ and $-2\cos(2\pi x_j) \geq -2$, we have $f(\mathbf{x}) \geq 0 = f(\mathbf{0})$, with equality only at $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q3.1. Is a point where the gradient vanishes always a local minimum? Give a counterexample in dimension 2.

Q3.2. Classify the critical point $\mathbf{0}$ of $f(\mathbf{x}) = x_1^2 - 4x_1x_2 + x_2^2$.

Q3.3. The functions x^4, $-x^4$ and x^3 all satisfy $f'(0) = f''(0) = 0$. What does this tell you about the second-order test?

Q3.4. True or false: if a differentiable function has a unique critical point, this point is its global minimum.

Q3.5. Why is every critical point of a differentiable convex function a global minimum?

3.3 Minimization Problems

Given a vector space E of dimension d and a function $f : E \to \mathbb{R}$, an optimization problem consists in solving

$$\min_{\mathbf{x}\in E} f(\mathbf{x}).$$

The function f is sometimes called the cost function. It can represent, for instance, the cost for a company of storing a series of products (represented by the parameter $\mathbf{x}$), or the risk taken when making decisions.

Most of the time, we want to minimize this function f under some constraints; this will be studied in Section 4.

Let us first have a look at some basic optimization problems.

Linear Regression We are given a response vector $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^m$ and a feature matrix $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{m\times d}$ whose rows are the feature vectors $\mathbf{x}_1, \dots, \mathbf{x}_m \in \mathbb{R}^d$, where $d < m$. We would like to find a vector $\boldsymbol{\theta} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ that explains the values of $\mathbf{y}$ from $\mathbf{X}$ through the following model:

$$\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta} + \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}, \quad \text{where} \quad \boldsymbol{\varepsilon} \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, \sigma^2\mathbf{I}),$$

and where $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}$ represents the errors of the model.

To find the best vector $\boldsymbol{\theta}$, we have to minimize these errors, *i.e.* to solve

$$\min_{\boldsymbol{\theta}\in\mathbb{R}^d} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \varepsilon_i^2 = \min_{\boldsymbol{\theta}\in\mathbb{R}^d} \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2.$$

We can easily check that this problem is convex. Indeed, the gradient of the objective function $F(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2$ is

$$\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} F(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = -2\mathbf{X}^T(\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}),$$

and its second-order derivative is given by

$$\nabla^2_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} F(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = 2\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X},$$

which is a symmetric positive semidefinite matrix of size d. Let us quickly show it: let λ be an eigenvalue of $\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}$ and $\mathbf{u}_\lambda$ an associated eigenvector. By definition of an eigenvalue and an eigenvector, we have

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}\mathbf{u}_\lambda &= \lambda\mathbf{u}_\lambda \\
&\downarrow \text{ premultiplying by } \mathbf{u}_\lambda^T \\
\mathbf{u}_\lambda^T\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}\mathbf{u}_\lambda &= \lambda\mathbf{u}_\lambda^T\mathbf{u}_\lambda \\
&\downarrow \text{ left: property of the transpose; right: definition of the norm} \\
(\mathbf{X}\mathbf{u}_\lambda)^T\mathbf{X}\mathbf{u}_\lambda &= \lambda\|\mathbf{u}_\lambda\|_2^2 \\
&\downarrow \text{ left: definition of the norm} \\
\|\mathbf{X}\mathbf{u}_\lambda\|_2^2 &= \lambda\|\mathbf{u}_\lambda\|_2^2 .
\end{aligned}$$

Since an eigenvector is necessarily nonzero, we have

$$\lambda = \frac{\|\mathbf{X}\mathbf{u}_\lambda\|_2^2}{\|\mathbf{u}_\lambda\|_2^2} \geq 0.$$

Finally, when $\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}$ is invertible, the unique solution of Euler's equation $\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} F(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \mathbf{0}$ is given by

$$\boldsymbol{\theta}^\star = (\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X})^{-1}\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{y}.$$

In this case, an analytical solution of the minimization problem exists. Unfortunately, this is not always the case.

Logistic Regression Let us now consider the logistic regression problem, which is quite similar to the previous one. We want to find a model that predicts the class $y \in \{0, 1\}$ of our data (see Section 8.4 for further details).

To predict the class of an individual $\mathbf{x}$, we use a model of the form

$$g(\mathbf{x}, \boldsymbol{\theta}) = \log\left(\frac{\mathbb{P}(y = 1 \mid \mathbf{x})}{1 - \mathbb{P}(y = 1 \mid \mathbf{x})}\right) = \theta_0 + \theta_1 x_1 + \ldots + \theta_d x_d.$$

The parameters of the model are estimated by minimizing the negative log-likelihood of our data:

$$\ell(\mathbf{X}, \boldsymbol{\theta}) = -\sum_{i=1}^{m} \Big(y_i \log(p_i) + (1 - y_i)\log(1 - p_i)\Big),$$

where

$$p_i = \frac{1}{1 + \exp\left(-\theta_0 - \sum_{j=1}^{d} \theta_j X_{ij}\right)}$$

is the probability, predicted by the model, that the i-th individual belongs to class 1.

Unfortunately, there is no analytical solution to this problem, so we need a way to approximate the solution step by step. This is the purpose of gradient descent algorithms.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q3.6. When does the least squares problem $\min_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2$ have a unique solution?

Q3.7. True or false: logistic regression has a closed-form solution, like linear regression.

3.4 Gradient Descent Algorithms

Let f be a function and $\mathcal{U}$ a nonempty set, and assume that the following problem has a solution:

$$\mathbf{u}^\star = \arg\min_{\mathbf{v}\in\mathcal{U}} f(\mathbf{v}).$$

The idea is to build a sequence $(\mathbf{u}_k)_{k\in\mathbb{N}}$ which converges towards $\mathbf{u}^\star$ using the following scheme:

- take an initial value $\mathbf{u}_0$: this is where the optimization procedure starts;
- $\mathbf{u}_k \to \mathbf{u}_{k+1}$: choose a direction $\mathbf{d}_k$ and minimize the function f along this direction;
- solve $\rho_k = \arg\min_{\rho>0} f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho\mathbf{d}_k)$: how far should we go in the selected direction?
- $\mathbf{u}_{k+1} = \mathbf{u}_k - \rho_k\mathbf{d}_k$: update the current position.

This process is repeated until we reach the optimal solution $\mathbf{u}^\star$.

Two questions then arise: (i) how should we choose the descent direction, and (ii) how far should we move in the chosen direction?

Indeed, as shown in Figure 23, several paths seem to lead to the desired solution, but is one of them preferable to the others? How can we use our knowledge of the function to be optimized to build such a path, rather than being guided by chance?

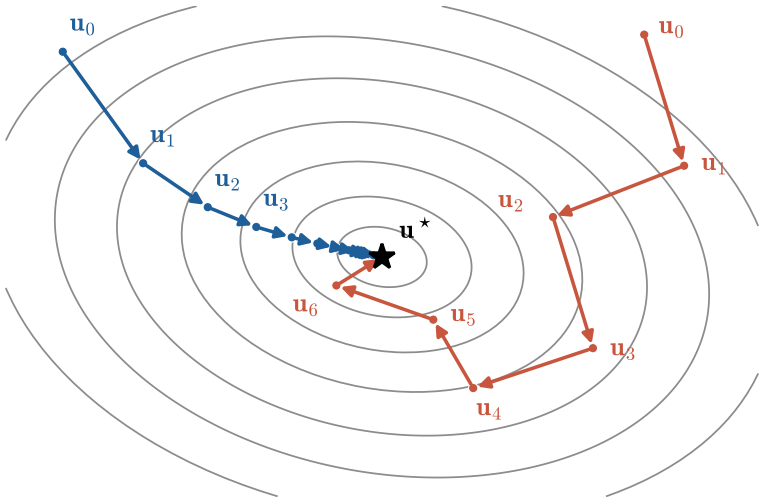


Figure 23: Two ways to reach the optimal solution $\mathbf{u}^\star$ of the function f we aim to minimize; the ellipses represent the level sets of f. The red path uses arbitrary directions; the blue path follows, at each iteration, the direction of steepest descent $-\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$, which is orthogonal to the level set going through $\mathbf{u}_k$ (gradient descent with constant step).

To answer the first question, we focus on the following quantity at a given iteration k:

$$f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho\mathbf{d}_k).$$

More precisely, we focus on the first-order approximation of this quantity. Remember that we have the following expansion when ρ is close to 0:

$$f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho \mathbf{d}_k) = f(\mathbf{u}_k) - \rho \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k), \mathbf{d}_k \rangle + \rho \varepsilon(\rho),$$

where ε is a function that tends to 0 when ρ tends to 0. To decrease $f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho \mathbf{d}_k)$ as much as possible, we have to choose, among the directions $\mathbf{d}_k$ of a given norm, the one that maximizes the inner product $\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k), \mathbf{d}_k \rangle$. By the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality, this direction is given by $\mathbf{d}_k = \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$ (up to a positive factor): the opposite of the gradient is the direction of steepest descent.

In a nutshell

Imagine a hiker lost in the fog on a mountain, who wants to reach the bottom of the valley. She cannot see the landscape, but she can feel the slope under her feet: she takes a step in the direction where the ground goes down most steeply, then looks again. The gradient is the local slope, and gradient descent only uses this local information; the step size says how long each stride is.

So the previous algorithm becomes:

- choose $\mathbf{u}_0$ to initialize the algorithm;
- set $\mathbf{u}_{k+1} = \mathbf{u}_k - \rho_k \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$ with $\rho_k > 0$.

However, we also need a stopping criterion. To find one, keep in mind that the critical points $\mathbf{u}^\star$ satisfy $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}^\star) = \mathbf{0}$. Thus, when the norm of the gradient of f is close to 0, we can assume that we have reached an (or the) optimal solution. In practice, we choose a small enough constant $\eta > 0$ and apply the previous algorithm until

$$\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\| \leq \eta.$$

It remains to choose the value of ρ_k at each step of the gradient descent algorithm. The simplest choice is a constant step, *i.e.* $\rho_k = \rho > 0$ for all k.

This gives our first descent algorithm.

Definition 3.2: Gradient Descent with Constant Step

Let f be a differentiable function defined on a vector space E of dimension d, and let ρ, η be two positive real numbers. Gradient Descent with Constant Step is defined as follows:

- choose $\mathbf{u}_0$ to initialize the algorithm, and set $k = 0$;
- while $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\| > \eta$:
  1. compute $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$,
  2. set $\mathbf{u}_{k+1} = \mathbf{u}_k - \rho \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$,
  3. set $k \leftarrow k + 1$;
- return $\mathbf{u}_k$.

However, a constant step is not always the best choice in practice. Indeed, a bad choice of this constant can lead to a very slow convergence of the algorithm, or even to its divergence, as illustrated in Figure 24. For instance, if f is α-strongly convex (see Definition 3.4 below) and if its gradient is L-Lipschitz, gradient descent with constant step converges as soon as $0 < \rho < 2\alpha/L^2$.

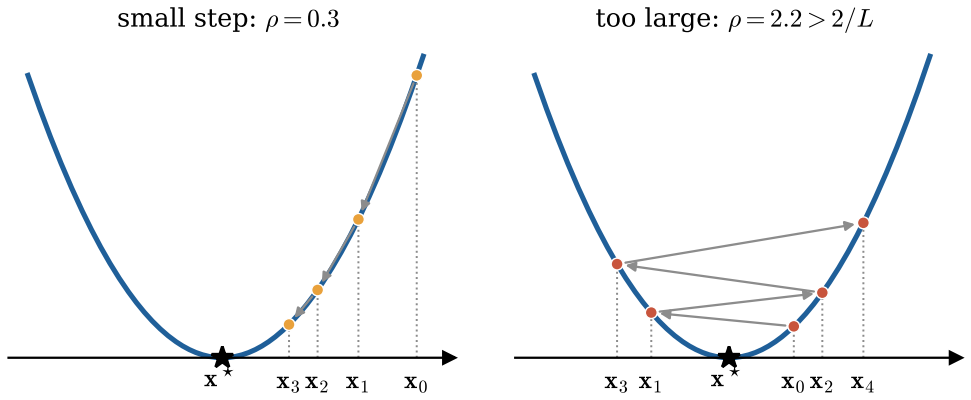


Figure 24: Importance of the choice of the learning rate ρ for gradient descent on $f(x) = \frac{1}{2}x^2$, for which $L = 1$ and $x_{k+1} = (1-\rho)x_k$. A small value slows down the convergence of the algorithm (left), while a too large value, $\rho > 2/L$, makes the algorithm diverge (right).

The same phenomenon in dimension 2 is shown in Figure 25, on the quadratic function $f(\mathbf{u}) = \frac{1}{2}(u_1^2 + 10u_2^2)$. The curvature is ten times larger along u_2 than along u_1: the step must be small enough for the steep direction, which makes the progress slow along the flat one.

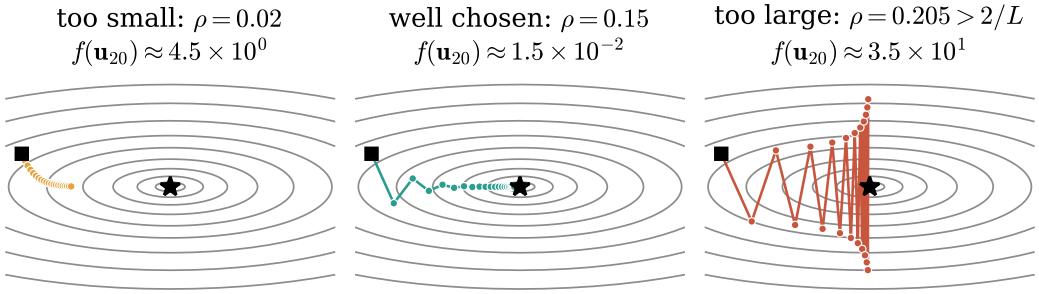


Figure 25: Twenty iterations of gradient descent with constant step on $f(\mathbf{u}) = \frac{1}{2}(u_1^2 + 10u_2^2)$, for which $\alpha = 1$ and $L = 10$, from the same starting point (black square). Left: the step is too small and the iterates crawl towards $\mathbf{u}^\star$. Middle: a good step. Right: $\rho > 2/L$, the iterates oscillate with increasing amplitude along the steep direction and the algorithm diverges.

Remark on the choice of a constant step A function whose gradient is L-Lipschitz, $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}) - \nabla f(\mathbf{v})\| \leq L\,\|\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{v}\|$, is said to be L-smooth; for a twice differentiable function, this means that the eigenvalues of the Hessian are bounded by L in absolute value. The constant L is the largest curvature of f, and it gives the natural scale of the step: the classical choice is $\rho = 1/L$. The condition $\rho < 2\alpha/L^2$ given above is sufficient but pessimistic. For a convex and L-smooth

function, gradient descent converges for every $\rho \in]0, 2/L[$ (Nesterov, 2018, Section 2.1.5); with $\rho = 1/L$,

$$f(\mathbf{u}_k) - f(\mathbf{u}^\star) \leq \frac{L \|\mathbf{u}_0 - \mathbf{u}^\star\|^2}{2k},$$

and, if f is moreover α-strongly convex, $\|\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{u}^\star\|^2 \leq (1 - \alpha/L)^k \|\mathbf{u}_0 - \mathbf{u}^\star\|^2$: the error decreases geometrically, a behavior called *linear convergence* because it appears as a straight line on a log-scale plot. On a quadratic function, the threshold $2/L$ is sharp, as illustrated in Figure 25.

We may rather choose a nonconstant step ρ_k that decreases with k, *e.g.* $\rho_k = \frac{1}{k}$. The most natural choice, however, is the value ρ_k which minimizes the function along the given direction.

This leads to another gradient descent algorithm, with a so-called *optimal step*.

Definition 3.3: Gradient Descent with Optimal Step

Let f be a differentiable function defined on a vector space E of dimension d, and let η be a positive real number. Gradient Descent with Optimal Step is defined as follows:

- choose $\mathbf{u}_0$ to initialize the algorithm, and set $k = 0$;
- while $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\| > \eta$:
  1. compute $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$,
  2. compute $\rho_k = \arg\min_{\rho > 0} f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k))$,
  3. set $\mathbf{u}_{k+1} = \mathbf{u}_k - \rho_k \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$,
  4. set $k \leftarrow k + 1$;
- return $\mathbf{u}_k$.

One can show that this algorithm converges for *strongly convex functions*. We have already discussed convexity but not strong convexity, so let us define it.

Definition 3.4: Strong Convexity

Let f be a convex and continuously differentiable function on $\mathbb{R}^d$. We say that f is strongly convex (or α-elliptic) if there exists $\alpha > 0$ such that

$$\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{v}) - \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{u} \rangle \geq \alpha \|\mathbf{v} - \mathbf{u}\|^2, \quad \forall \mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in \mathbb{R}^d.$$

Equivalently, when f is twice differentiable, f is *α-strongly convex* if and only if

$$\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{x}) \succeq \alpha \mathbf{I} \quad \text{for all } \mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d,$$

i.e. for all $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, $\mathbf{z}^T \nabla^2 f(\mathbf{x})\, \mathbf{z} \geq \alpha \|\mathbf{z}\|^2$.

Proposition 3.3: Optimal Step: Convergence

If f is α-strongly convex and if its gradient is Lipschitz continuous on every bounded set (for instance, if f is twice continuously differentiable), then Gradient Descent with Optimal Step converges to the unique minimizer $\mathbf{u}^\star$ of f, whatever the initial point $\mathbf{u}_0$.

Let us now have a look at the gradient at each step. What can we say about $\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1}), \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k) \rangle$ when $\rho_k = \arg\min_{\rho > 0} f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k))$?

If ρ_k minimizes $\rho \mapsto f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k))$, then

$$\begin{aligned} & \frac{\partial}{\partial \rho} f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k))|_{\rho = \rho_k} = 0 \\ \iff & - \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho_k \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)), \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k) \rangle = 0 \\ \iff & \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1}), \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k) \rangle = 0. \end{aligned}$$

We can see that two successive descent directions are orthogonal. This observation is very useful to determine the optimal step for an important class of problems in Machine Learning, namely quadratic problems, as illustrated in the following example.

Example 3.4. Let $\mathbf{A}$ be a symmetric positive definite matrix and $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^d$. Let us consider the quadratic form f defined for all $\mathbf{u} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ by

$$f(\mathbf{u}) = \frac{1}{2} \langle \mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{u} \rangle - \langle \mathbf{b}, \mathbf{u} \rangle.$$

We aim to determine the optimal step at each iteration of gradient descent applied to this function. We first compute the gradient: for all $k \in \mathbb{N}$, we have $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k) = \mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b}$. Furthermore,

$$\begin{aligned} \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1}) &= \mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_{k+1} - \mathbf{b} \\ &= \mathbf{A}\big(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho_k(\mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b})\big) - \mathbf{b} \\ &= \mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b} - \rho_k \mathbf{A}(\mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b}). \end{aligned}$$

Now, we use the fact that $\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1}), \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k) \rangle = 0$ for this algorithm:

$$\begin{aligned} & \langle \mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b}, \mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b} - \rho_k \mathbf{A}(\mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b}) \rangle && = 0 \\ \implies & \langle \mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b}, \mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b} \rangle && = \rho_k \langle \mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b}, \mathbf{A}(\mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b}) \rangle \\ \implies & \rho_k && = \frac{\langle \mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b}, \mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b} \rangle}{\langle \mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b}, \mathbf{A}(\mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b}) \rangle}. \end{aligned}$$

Finally, for quadratic problems of this form, the optimal learning rate at step k is equal to

$$\rho_k = \frac{\|\mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b}\|^2}{\|\mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{b}\|^2_{\mathbf{A}}},$$

where $\|\mathbf{u}\|^2_{\mathbf{A}} = \mathbf{u}^T\mathbf{A}\mathbf{u}$ (the denominator is positive as long as $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k) \neq \mathbf{0}$, since $\mathbf{A}$ is positive definite).

Because successive directions are orthogonal, gradient descent with optimal step follows a characteristic *zig-zag* path, shown in Figure 26. Its speed depends on the shape of the level sets: on the quadratic function of the previous example, one can show that

$$f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1}) - f(\mathbf{u}^\star) \leq \left(\frac{\kappa - 1}{\kappa + 1}\right)^2 (f(\mathbf{u}_k) - f(\mathbf{u}^\star)), \qquad \text{where} \quad \kappa = \frac{\lambda_{\max}(\mathbf{A})}{\lambda_{\min}(\mathbf{A})}$$

is the condition number of $\mathbf{A}$ (Nocedal and Wright, 2006, Section 3.3). When $\kappa = 1$ (circular level sets), the gradient points towards $\mathbf{u}^\star$ and one step is enough; when κ is large (very elongated level sets), the factor is close to 1 and the convergence is slow.

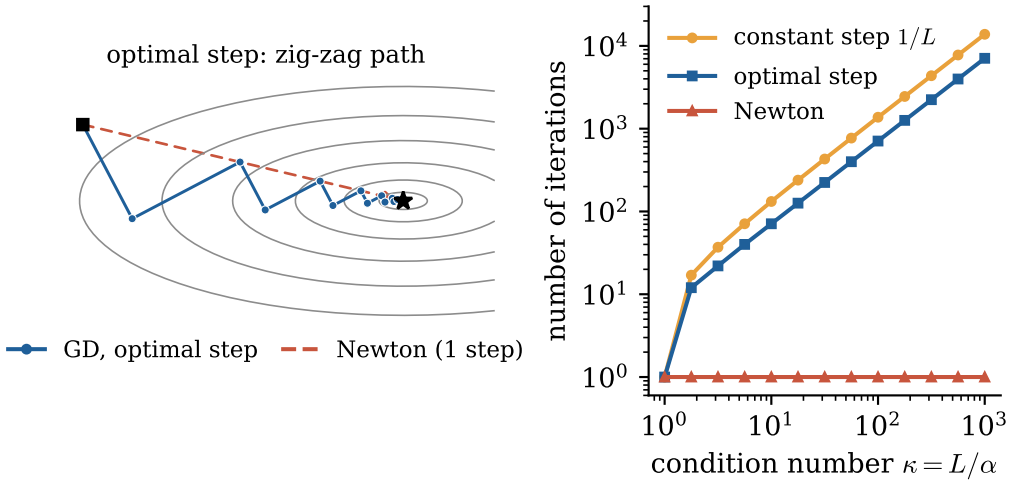


Figure 26: Left: gradient descent with optimal step on $f(\mathbf{u}) = \frac{1}{2}(u_1^2 + 8u_2^2)$; two successive directions are orthogonal, which produces a zig-zag path, whereas Newton's method (dashed) reaches the minimizer of a quadratic function in a single step. Right: number of iterations needed to reach $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\| \leq 10^{-6}$ on $f(\mathbf{u}) = \frac{1}{2}(u_1^2 + \kappa u_2^2)$, as a function of the condition number κ: it grows linearly with κ for gradient descent, and does not depend on κ for Newton's method.

In a nutshell

The condition number $\kappa = L/\alpha$ (ratio of the largest to the smallest curvature) measures how elongated the valley of f is. Gradient descent needs a number of iterations roughly proportional to κ to reach a given accuracy. Many practical tricks in Machine Learning, such as standardizing the features or adding a ridge penalty $\lambda \|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|^2$ (which increases α by 2λ), can be seen as ways to reduce κ.

Other algorithms, or other ways to choose the learning rate at each step, can be studied, such as:

- **line search:** Armijo's criterion, Wolfe's criteria;
- **algorithms:** the conjugate gradient method.

Backtracking line search (Armijo's rule) Except for quadratic functions, the optimal step is itself the solution of an optimization problem, and computing it exactly at each iteration is too costly. In practice, we are satisfied with a step that decreases f *sufficiently*. Let $\varphi(\rho) = f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k))$; note that $\varphi'(0) = -\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\|^2 < 0$. Given $c \in]0,1[$ (typically $c = 10^{-4}$), the step ρ satisfies Armijo's condition (Armijo, 1966) if

$$f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)) \leq f(\mathbf{u}_k) - c\,\rho\, \|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\|^2,$$

i.e. if the graph of φ lies below the line of slope $c\,\varphi'(0)$ going through $(0, \varphi(0))$, see Figure 27. *Backtracking* starts from a large step $\rho = \rho_0$ and divides it by 2 (or multiplies it by some $\beta \in]0,1[$) until Armijo's condition holds. Since $c < 1$, this condition always holds for ρ small enough, so backtracking stops after a finite number of trials; it requires only evaluations of f, and it frees us from the knowledge of L.

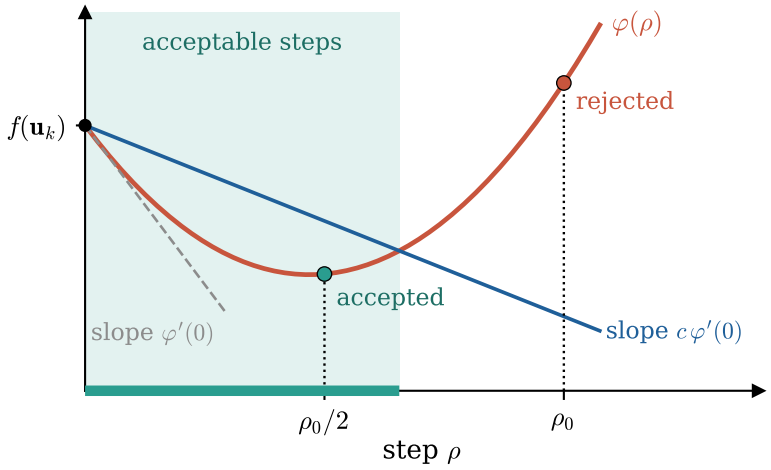


Figure 27: Armijo's rule. A step ρ is accepted (shaded region) when $\varphi(\rho)$ lies below the blue line, whose slope is a fraction c of the initial slope $\varphi'(0)$ (dashed), which guarantees a sufficient decrease of f. Backtracking tries ρ_0, which is too large, then $\rho_0/2$, which is accepted. (Here $\varphi(\rho) = f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k))$ is a parabola and $c = 0.3$ for readability; much smaller values of c are used in practice.)

We conclude this part with a last algorithm called *Newton's method*.

Newton's method is also a descent algorithm. It uses the second-order derivative to refine the descent direction as follows:

$$\mathbf{u}_{k+1} \leftarrow \mathbf{u}_k - \left(\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}_k)\right)^{-1} \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k).$$

- It requires fewer iterations to converge to the solution than the other gradient descent methods.
- It is harder to implement and requires inverting the Hessian of the function we want to optimize (in $\mathcal{O}(d^3)$ operations).
- The Hessian is not always invertible at a given point.

Newton's method is obtained by minimizing, at each iteration, the second-order approximation of f around $\mathbf{u}_k$:

$$f(\mathbf{u}_k + \mathbf{h}) \approx f(\mathbf{u}_k) + \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)^T \mathbf{h} + \frac{1}{2} \mathbf{h}^T \nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}_k)\, \mathbf{h},$$

whose gradient with respect to $\mathbf{h}$ vanishes at $\mathbf{h} = -\left(\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}_k)\right)^{-1} \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$. For a quadratic function, this approximation is exact, and Newton's method finds the minimizer in a single iteration, whatever the condition number (Figure 26). For a general function, its convergence is *quadratic* near a minimizer at which the Hessian is positive definite: roughly speaking, the number of correct digits doubles at each iteration (Nocedal and Wright, 2006, Section 3.3). In practice, the system $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}_k)\,\mathbf{h} = -\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$ is solved (*e.g.* by a Cholesky factorization) rather than computing the inverse of the Hessian.

> **Pitfall** Newton's method is only *locally* convergent. Far from the solution, the pure iteration (with step 1) can diverge, even for a convex function: for $f(x) = \sqrt{1+x^2}$, we have $f'(x)/f''(x) = x(1+x^2)$, so that $x_{k+1} = -x_k^3$, which diverges as soon as $|x_0| > 1$. Moreover, when $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}_k)$ is not positive definite (nonconvex function), the Newton direction may not even be a descent direction, and the method can be attracted by a maximum or a saddle point. This is why Newton's method is used in practice with a line search (*damped Newton*), and why its first iterations are sometimes replaced by gradient steps.

The main drawback of Newton's method is the computation of the inverse of the Hessian matrix $\mathbf{H}_k^{-1}$, where $\mathbf{H}_k = \nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}_k)$. To avoid it, quasi-Newton methods use the following iterations:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{u}_{k+1} &= \mathbf{u}_k - \rho_k \mathbf{M}_k \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k), \\ \mathbf{M}_{k+1} &= \mathbf{M}_k + \mathbf{C}_k. \end{aligned}$$

The idea is to approximate $\mathbf{H}_k^{-1}$ by a matrix $\mathbf{M}_k$, to which a correction matrix $\mathbf{C}_k$ is added at each step.

Remember that

$$\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k) = \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1} + (\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{u}_{k+1})) \approx \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1}) + \nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1})(\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{u}_{k+1});$$

we then have the following approximation:

$$\left(\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1})\right)^{-1} \left(\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1}) - \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\right) \approx \mathbf{u}_{k+1} - \mathbf{u}_k.$$

If we set $\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k = \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1}) - \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$ and $\boldsymbol{\delta}_k = \mathbf{u}_{k+1} - \mathbf{u}_k$, and if we require the new matrix $\mathbf{M}_{k+1}$, which plays the role of $\left(\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1})\right)^{-1}$, to satisfy this relation exactly, we get the quasi-Newton condition:

$$\boxed{\mathbf{M}_{k+1}\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k = \boldsymbol{\delta}_k}.$$

It remains to see how to define such a correction matrix $\mathbf{C}_k$. We present two solutions, based on rank-1 and rank-2 matrices respectively, together with the corresponding algorithms. Note that, in practice, the rank-2 correction is used, in the optimization algorithm known as BFGS.

Rank-1 Correction The correction matrix $\mathbf{C}_k$ is assumed to be of rank 1 (and symmetric). So we can write $\mathbf{C}_k$ as $\mathbf{v}_k\mathbf{v}_k^T$, where $\mathbf{v}_k \in \mathbb{R}^d$.

The update rule of the matrix $\mathbf{M}_k$ can be written as

$$\mathbf{M}_{k+1} = \mathbf{M}_k + \mathbf{v}_k\mathbf{v}_k^T,$$

and the quasi-Newton condition gives

$$\begin{aligned}
(\mathbf{M}_k + \mathbf{v}_k\mathbf{v}_k^T)\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k &= \boldsymbol{\delta}_k, \\
\mathbf{M}_k\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k + \mathbf{v}_k\mathbf{v}_k^T\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k &= \boldsymbol{\delta}_k, \\
\mathbf{v}_k(\mathbf{v}_k^T\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k) &= \boldsymbol{\delta}_k - \mathbf{M}_k\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k, \\
\mathbf{v}_k &= \frac{\boldsymbol{\delta}_k - \mathbf{M}_k\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k}{\mathbf{v}_k^T\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k}.
\end{aligned}$$

Moreover, taking the inner product of the third line with $\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k$ gives $(\mathbf{v}_k^T\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k)^2 = \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T\boldsymbol{\delta}_k - \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T\mathbf{M}_k\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k = (\boldsymbol{\delta}_k - \mathbf{M}_k\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k)^T\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k$, hence

$$\mathbf{v}_k\mathbf{v}_k^T = \frac{(\boldsymbol{\delta}_k - \mathbf{M}_k\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k)(\boldsymbol{\delta}_k - \mathbf{M}_k\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k)^T}{(\boldsymbol{\delta}_k - \mathbf{M}_k\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k)^T\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k}.$$

This rank-one correction leads to the *Broyden algorithm* (also known as the symmetric rank-one, or SR1, method).

Definition 3.5: Broyden Algorithm

Let f be a differentiable function defined on a vector space E of dimension d, and let η be a positive real number. The Broyden algorithm is defined as follows:

- choose $\mathbf{u}_0$ to initialize the algorithm, and set $\mathbf{M}_0 = \mathbf{I}$ and $k = 0$;
- while $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\| > \eta$:
  1. set $\rho_k = \arg\min_{\rho\in\mathbb{R}} f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho\mathbf{M}_k\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k))$,
  2. set $\mathbf{u}_{k+1} = \mathbf{u}_k - \rho_k\mathbf{M}_k\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$,
  3. set $\mathbf{M}_{k+1} = \mathbf{M}_k + \frac{(\boldsymbol{\delta}_k - \mathbf{M}_k\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k)(\boldsymbol{\delta}_k - \mathbf{M}_k\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k)^T}{(\boldsymbol{\delta}_k - \mathbf{M}_k\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k)^T\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k}$,
  4. set $k \leftarrow k + 1$;
- return $\mathbf{u}_k$.

Rank-2 Correction The idea is quite similar but, instead of a rank-one matrix, the correction is written as the sum of two rank-one matrices, which leads to a rank-2 correction. It is easier to first derive the update of the approximation $\mathbf{B}_k$ of the Hessian $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}_k)$ itself (so that $\mathbf{M}_k = \mathbf{B}_k^{-1}$), which must satisfy the equivalent quasi-Newton condition $\mathbf{B}_{k+1}\boldsymbol{\delta}_k = \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k$. We look for a correction of the form

$$\mathbf{B}_{k+1} = \mathbf{B}_k + \alpha \mathbf{v}_k \mathbf{v}_k^T + \beta \mathbf{w}_k \mathbf{w}_k^T.$$

In order to determine suitable values of α and β, we set $\mathbf{v}_k = \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k$ and $\mathbf{w}_k = \mathbf{B}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k$ and use the quasi-Newton condition:

$$\mathbf{B}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k + \alpha \left(\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T \boldsymbol{\delta}_k\right) \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k + \beta \left(\boldsymbol{\delta}_k^T \mathbf{B}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k\right) \mathbf{B}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k = \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k.$$

This condition holds if

$$\alpha = \frac{1}{\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T \boldsymbol{\delta}_k} \quad \text{and} \quad \beta = -\frac{1}{\boldsymbol{\delta}_k^T \mathbf{B}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k},$$

and the update rule becomes

$$\mathbf{B}_{k+1} = \mathbf{B}_k + \frac{\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T}{\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T \boldsymbol{\delta}_k} - \frac{\mathbf{B}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k^T \mathbf{B}_k^T}{\boldsymbol{\delta}_k^T \mathbf{B}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k}.$$

Inverting this relation with the Sherman–Morrison–Woodbury formula gives the corresponding update of $\mathbf{M}_k = \mathbf{B}_k^{-1}$, which directly approximates the inverse of the Hessian and still satisfies $\mathbf{M}_{k+1} \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k = \boldsymbol{\delta}_k$:

$$\mathbf{M}_{k+1} = \left(\mathbf{I} - \frac{\boldsymbol{\delta}_k \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T}{\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T \boldsymbol{\delta}_k}\right) \mathbf{M}_k \left(\mathbf{I} - \frac{\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k^T}{\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T \boldsymbol{\delta}_k}\right) + \frac{\boldsymbol{\delta}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k^T}{\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T \boldsymbol{\delta}_k}.$$

The use of this update rule is known as the *Broyden–Fletcher–Goldfarb–Shanno* (BFGS) algorithm.

Definition 3.6: BFGS Algorithm

Let f be a differentiable function defined on a vector space E of dimension d, and let η be a positive real number. The BFGS algorithm is defined as follows:

- choose $\mathbf{u}_0$ to initialize the algorithm, and set $\mathbf{M}_0 = \mathbf{I}$ and $k = 0$;
- while $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\| > \eta$:
  1. set $\rho_k = \arg\min_{\rho \in \mathbb{R}} f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho \mathbf{M}_k \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k))$,
  2. set $\mathbf{u}_{k+1} = \mathbf{u}_k - \rho_k \mathbf{M}_k \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$,
  3. set $\mathbf{M}_{k+1} = \left(\mathbf{I} - \frac{\boldsymbol{\delta}_k \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T}{\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T \boldsymbol{\delta}_k}\right) \mathbf{M}_k \left(\mathbf{I} - \frac{\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k^T}{\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T \boldsymbol{\delta}_k}\right) + \frac{\boldsymbol{\delta}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k^T}{\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T \boldsymbol{\delta}_k}$,
  4. set $k \leftarrow k + 1$;
- return $\mathbf{u}_k$.

In practice, the exact minimization along the direction is replaced by a line search such as Armijo's rule (usually combined with a curvature condition, the Wolfe conditions, which guarantees $\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T \boldsymbol{\delta}_k > 0$ and thus that $\mathbf{M}_{k+1}$ remains positive definite). BFGS combines the advantages of the two previous families: each iteration only costs $\mathcal{O}(d^2)$

operations and requires only gradients, as for gradient descent, while its convergence is *superlinear* near the solution, almost as fast as Newton's method. For large d, storing the $d \times d$ matrix $\mathbf{M}_k$ itself becomes too expensive, and the limited-memory variant *L-BFGS*, which only keeps the last few pairs $(\boldsymbol{\delta}_k, \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k)$, is used instead (Nocedal and Wright, 2006, Chapter 7); it is, for instance, the default solver of logistic regression in scikit-learn.

Figure 28 compares the algorithms of this section on a logistic regression problem. On a log-scale plot, the error of gradient descent decreases along a straight line (linear convergence), that of BFGS along a curve that bends down (superlinear convergence), and that of Newton's method falls vertically after a few iterations (quadratic convergence).

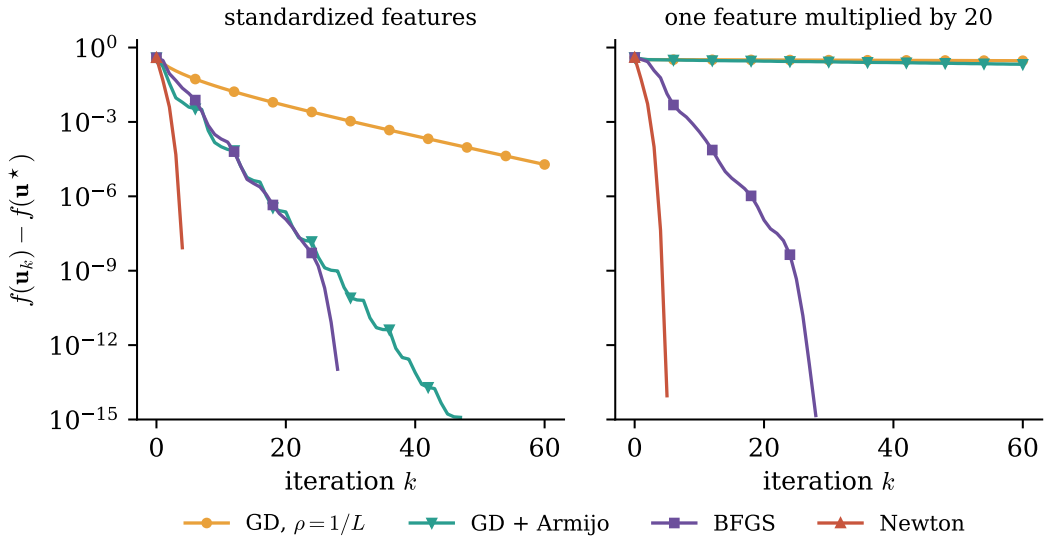


Figure 28: Convergence of gradient descent (with constant step $1/L$, or with Armijo's backtracking), BFGS and Newton's method (both with Armijo's backtracking) on an ℓ_2-regularized logistic regression ($m = 300$, $d = 5$), starting from $\mathbf{u}_0 = \mathbf{0}$; log scale on the vertical axis. Left: standardized features. Right: the same data with one feature multiplied by 20; the condition number increases, gradient descent becomes very slow, while Newton's method and BFGS are almost insensitive to this change of scale.

Pitfall The behavior of gradient descent depends on the units in which the features are measured (right panel of Figure 28), and so does the stopping criterion $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\| \leq \eta$: multiplying f by 100 multiplies its gradient by 100 without changing its minimizer. Always standardize the features before running a first-order method, and choose the tolerance η relative to the initial gradient, *e.g.* $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\| \leq \eta \, \|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_0)\|$.

Remark large-scale learning In Machine Learning, the objective is usually an empirical risk $f(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \ell_i(\boldsymbol{\theta})$, where ℓ_i is the loss on the i-th example. When m is very large, even one evaluation of the full gradient is expensive, and Newton-type methods are out of reach when the number of parameters d is large. The workhorse is then *stochastic gradient descent*, which replaces ∇f

by the gradient $\nabla \ell_i$ of a single example (or of a small batch) drawn at random (Robbins and Monro, 1951); it is presented with its variants (momentum, Adam) in Section 9.6. The survey of Bottou et al. (2018) explains why such "inexact" methods are well suited to learning.

Historical note Gradient descent goes back to Cauchy (1847), who proposed it to solve systems of equations arising in astronomy. Newton's method was introduced by Newton and Raphson in the seventeenth century to find the roots of polynomials; applied to the equation $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}) = \mathbf{0}$, it becomes the optimization method presented here. The BFGS update was discovered independently, in 1970, by Broyden, Fletcher, Goldfarb and Shanno, which explains its name. The textbooks of Nocedal and Wright (2006) and Nesterov (2018) are excellent references for this section.

To remember from Section 3

- At a local minimum of a differentiable function, the gradient vanishes (Euler's equation); a critical point is a local minimum if the Hessian is positive definite there, and every critical point of a convex function is a global minimum.
- Gradient descent $\mathbf{u}_{k+1} = \mathbf{u}_k - \rho_k \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)$ moves in the direction of steepest descent. With a constant step, it requires $\rho < 2/L$ (the classical choice is $\rho = 1/L$); otherwise the step is chosen by an exact or an approximate (Armijo) line search.
- Its speed is governed by the condition number $\kappa = L/\alpha$: the convergence is linear for strongly convex functions, and slow when the level sets are elongated.
- Newton's method uses the Hessian, is insensitive to the conditioning and converges quadratically near the solution, but each iteration costs $\mathcal{O}(d^3)$ and it must be damped far from the solution. Quasi-Newton methods (BFGS, L-BFGS) build an approximation of the inverse Hessian from gradients only.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q3.8. Why is $-\nabla f(\mathbf{u})$ called the direction of steepest descent?

Q3.9. What happens with a constant step $\rho = 0.3$ on $f(\mathbf{u}) = \frac{1}{2}(u_1^2 + 10u_2^2)$?

Q3.10. What is the best constant step for $f(\mathbf{u}) = \frac{1}{2}(u_1^2 + 10u_2^2)$, and the corresponding contraction factor?

Q3.11. Why are two successive directions of gradient descent with optimal step orthogonal?

Q3.12. Why must the constant c of Armijo's condition be smaller than 1?

Q3.13. How many iterations does Newton's method need on a strictly convex quadratic function? And gradient descent?

Q3.14. True or false: for a strictly convex function, the pure Newton iteration (step 1) converges from any starting point.

Q3.15. We replace f by $100f$. Which of gradient descent with fixed step and Newton's method is affected?

Q3.16. Why is BFGS preferred to Newton's method when d is large?

Exercises

Exercise 3.1. **(Comprehension)** True or false? Justify briefly. (a) If $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}) = \mathbf{0}$ and $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u}) \succeq 0$, then $\mathbf{u}$ is a local minimum of f. (b) If f is convex and differentiable, every critical point of f is a global minimum. (c) A strictly convex function always has a minimizer on $\mathbb{R}^d$. (d) Gradient descent with a constant step ρ decreases f at each iteration, whatever $\rho > 0$. (e) Newton's method gives the same iterates for f and for $100f$, whereas gradient descent with a fixed step does not.

Exercise 3.2. **(Computation)** (a) Find the critical points of $f(x, y) = x^3 - 3x + y^2$ on $\mathbb{R}^2$ and classify them with the Hessian. Does f have a global minimum? (b) Same questions for $g(x, y) = x^4 + y^4 - 4xy$. (c) Explain why the global minimum of g exists, and give its value.

Exercise 3.3. **(Computation)** We fit the model $y = \theta_0 + \theta_1 x$ to the three points $(x, y) \in \{(0, 1), (1, 3), (2, 4)\}$ by least squares, *i.e.* we minimize $F(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2$ with $\boldsymbol{\theta} = (\theta_0, \theta_1)$. (a) Write $\mathbf{X}$ and $\mathbf{y}$, and compute $\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}$ and $\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{y}$. (b) Show that F is strictly convex and compute its minimizer $\boldsymbol{\theta}^\star$ and the minimal value $F(\boldsymbol{\theta}^\star)$. (c) Compute the condition number of $\nabla^2 F$. What is the largest constant step for which gradient descent converges?

Exercise 3.4. **(Proof)** Let $f(\mathbf{u}) = \frac{1}{2}\mathbf{u}^T\mathbf{A}\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{b}^T\mathbf{u}$ with $\mathbf{A}$ symmetric positive definite, of eigenvalues $0 < \lambda_{\min} = \lambda_1 \leq \cdots \leq \lambda_d = \lambda_{\max}$. Show that gradient descent with constant step satisfies $\mathbf{u}_{k+1} - \mathbf{u}^\star = (\mathbf{I} - \rho\mathbf{A})(\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{u}^\star)$. Deduce that it converges for every $\mathbf{u}_0$ if and only if $0 < \rho < 2/\lambda_{\max}$, and that the best constant step is $\rho = 2/(\lambda_{\min} + \lambda_{\max})$, with contraction factor $(\kappa - 1)/(\kappa + 1)$, where $\kappa = \lambda_{\max}/\lambda_{\min}$. (*Hint:* diagonalize $\mathbf{A}$; the eigenvalues of $\mathbf{I} - \rho\mathbf{A}$ are $1 - \rho\lambda_i$.)

Exercise 3.5. **(Computation)** Let $f(\mathbf{u}) = \frac{1}{2}(u_1^2 + 4u_2^2)$ and $\mathbf{u}_0 = (4, 1)$. (a) Perform two iterations of gradient descent with optimal step, using the formula of the notes for ρ_k. Check that the two successive gradients are orthogonal. (b) Compute $f(\mathbf{u}_0)$, $f(\mathbf{u}_1)$, $f(\mathbf{u}_2)$ and compare the ratio $f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1})/f(\mathbf{u}_k)$ with the bound $\left(\frac{\kappa-1}{\kappa+1}\right)^2$. (c) Compare $\mathbf{u}_2$ and $\mathbf{u}_0$. What does the sequence look like?

Exercise 3.6. **(Proof)** Let f be differentiable and L-smooth, *i.e.* $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}) - \nabla f(\mathbf{v})\|_2 \leq L\|\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{v}\|_2$ for all $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}$, and bounded below by $f^\star$. (a) Using $f(\mathbf{v}) - f(\mathbf{u}) = \int_0^1 \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u} + t(\mathbf{v} - \mathbf{u})), \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{u}\rangle \, dt$, prove the *descent lemma*

$$f(\mathbf{v}) \leq f(\mathbf{u}) + \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{u}\rangle + \frac{L}{2}\|\mathbf{v} - \mathbf{u}\|_2^2 .$$

(b) Deduce that gradient descent with constant step ρ satisfies $f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1}) \leq f(\mathbf{u}_k) - \rho\left(1 - \frac{L\rho}{2}\right)\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\|_2^2$. For which steps is the decrease guaranteed? Which step maximizes the guaranteed decrease? (c) With $\rho = 1/L$, show that $\min_{0 \leq k < K} \|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\|_2^2 \leq \frac{2L(f(\mathbf{u}_0) - f^\star)}{K}$. Note that f need not be convex.

Exercise 3.7. **(Proof)** Let f be α-strongly convex (Definition 3.4) with minimizer $\mathbf{u}^\star$. (a) Show that $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u})\|_2 \geq \alpha\|\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{u}^\star\|_2$ for all $\mathbf{u}$. (b) Deduce a guarantee on the distance $\|\mathbf{u}_k - \mathbf{u}^\star\|_2$ when the stopping criterion $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\|_2 \leq \eta$ of gradient descent is met. (c) For $f(\mathbf{u}) = \frac{1}{2}(u_1^2 + 10u_2^2)$ and $\eta = 10^{-3}$, what is this guarantee? Is it tight?

Exercise 3.8. **(Computation)** Apply Newton's method to $f(x) = x - \ln x$ on $]0, +\infty[$. Show that $x_{k+1} = 2x_k - x_k^2$ and that $1 - x_{k+1} = (1 - x_k)^2$. For which initial points does the method converge? Illustrate the quadratic convergence with $x_0 = 0.5$.

Exercise 3.9. **(Proof)** Let f be twice differentiable with positive definite Hessian, $\mathbf{M}$ an invertible $d \times d$ matrix, and $g(\mathbf{v}) = f(\mathbf{M}\mathbf{v})$. (a) Express $\nabla g(\mathbf{v})$ and $\nabla^2 g(\mathbf{v})$ in terms of the derivatives of f. (b) Show that if $\mathbf{u}_0 = \mathbf{M}\mathbf{v}_0$, the Newton iterates for f and g satisfy $\mathbf{u}_k = \mathbf{M}\mathbf{v}_k$ for all k: Newton's method is *affine invariant*. (c) Show that this is false for gradient descent, using

$f(\mathbf{u}) = \frac{1}{2}(u_1^2 + 100u_2^2)$ and $\mathbf{M} = \mathrm{diag}(1, 1/10)$. Compute the condition numbers of f and g and comment.

Exercise 3.10. **(Computation)** Let $f(\mathbf{u}) = \frac{1}{2}(u_1^2+10u_2^2)$ and $\mathbf{u}_0 = (1, 1)$. (a) Run one iteration of gradient descent with Armijo's backtracking, starting from $\rho = 1$, dividing the step by 2 at each trial, with $c = 10^{-4}$. Give the accepted step, $\mathbf{u}_1$ and $f(\mathbf{u}_1)$. (b) Compare with the optimal step. (c) Why is the case $c = 1$ excluded? (*Hint:* $\varphi(\rho) = f(\mathbf{u}_0 - \rho\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_0))$ is strictly convex.)

Exercise 3.11. **(Proof)** Let $\mathbf{M}_k$ be symmetric positive definite, $\boldsymbol{\delta}_k, \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k \in \mathbb{R}^d$ with $s = \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T \boldsymbol{\delta}_k > 0$, and

$$\mathbf{M}_{k+1} = \left(\mathbf{I} - \frac{\boldsymbol{\delta}_k \boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T}{s}\right) \mathbf{M}_k \left(\mathbf{I} - \frac{\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k^T}{s}\right) + \frac{\boldsymbol{\delta}_k \boldsymbol{\delta}_k^T}{s}.$$

(a) Check that $\mathbf{M}_{k+1}$ is symmetric and satisfies the quasi-Newton condition $\mathbf{M}_{k+1}\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k = \boldsymbol{\delta}_k$. (b) Show that $\mathbf{M}_{k+1}$ is positive definite. Why is the condition $\boldsymbol{\gamma}_k^T \boldsymbol{\delta}_k > 0$ important in practice?

Exercise 3.12. **(Application)** We minimize $F_\lambda(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{1}{m} \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2 + \lambda \|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2$, where the eigenvalues of $\boldsymbol{\Sigma} = \mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}/m$ range from $s_{\min} = 0.01$ to $s_{\max} = 10$. (a) Compute the Hessian of F_λ and its condition number $\kappa(\lambda)$. (b) Compute $\kappa(0)$, $\kappa(0.1)$ and $\kappa(1)$. (c) Using the rate $(1 - 1/\kappa)^k$ of gradient descent with step $1/L$, estimate the number of iterations needed to reduce the squared distance to the minimizer by a factor 10^6 in the three cases. (d) What is the price to pay for this acceleration?

Exercise 3.13. **(Python)** Implement gradient descent with constant step $1/L$ and with Armijo's backtracking for the logistic regression problem of this section (averaged over the m examples), on the breast cancer data set of scikit-learn with standardized features. Plot $f(\mathbf{u}_k)$ on a log scale, then multiply one of the features by 100 and observe the effect on both methods. (*Hint:* one can take $L = \lambda_{\max}(\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X})/(4m)$.)

Exercise 3.14. **(Python)** The Rosenbrock function $f(x, y) = (1 - x)^2 + 100(y - x^2)^2$ is a classical test for optimization algorithms: its minimizer $(1, 1)$ lies at the bottom of a long curved valley. (a) Compute ∇f and $\nabla^2 f$, and the condition number of $\nabla^2 f(1, 1)$. (b) Starting from $(-1.2, 1)$, count the iterations needed to reach $\|\nabla f\|_2 \leq 10^{-5}$ with gradient descent with Armijo's backtracking, with Newton's method with Armijo's backtracking, and with `scipy.optimize.minimize(method="BFGS")`. Comment.

4 Constrained and Smooth Convex Optimization

In the previous section, the variable $\mathbf{x}$ could take any value in $\mathbb{R}^d$. In many learning problems, however, the parameters we look for must satisfy some constraints. This section explains how the optimality conditions of Section 3 must be adapted in this case. It introduces the Lagrangian, the dual problem and the Karush–Kuhn–Tucker (KKT) conditions, which are the key tools to understand support vector machines, and it presents a simple algorithm to solve constrained problems, projected gradient descent. Our presentation follows Boyd and Vandenberghe (2004), to which we refer the reader for further details and for the proofs that are omitted here.

About this section

Guiding question. *How do we minimize a loss when the parameters are not free, e.g. when they must have a bounded norm or form a probability distribution?*

In this section you will learn to:

- *write a constrained problem in standard form and recognize a convex problem;*
- *interpret Lagrange multipliers geometrically, and build the Lagrangian and the dual problem;*
- *write and use the KKT conditions to solve a problem in closed form, and interpret complementary slackness (support vectors, active constraints);*
- *compute simple projections (ball, box, simplex) and run projected gradient descent.*

4.1 Motivation: Constraints in Machine Learning

Constraints appear naturally in Machine Learning. Let us give three examples that will be met again later in the course.

- **Support vector machines.** Given a sample $\{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ with labels $y_i \in \{-1, +1\}$, the hard-margin SVM looks for the separating hyperplane $\{\mathbf{x} \mid \mathbf{w}^T\mathbf{x} + b = 0\}$ with the largest margin. It is obtained by solving

$$\min_{\mathbf{w}\in\mathbb{R}^d,\, b\in\mathbb{R}} \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{w}\|_2^2 \quad \text{s.t.} \quad y_i(\mathbf{w}^T\mathbf{x}_i + b) \geq 1, \quad i = 1, \dots, m.$$

  Each example gives an *inequality constraint*: it must lie on the right side of the hyperplane, at a distance at least $1/\|\mathbf{w}\|_2$.

- **Norm constraints and regularization.** To avoid overfitting, we often restrict the size of the parameters, *e.g.* by minimizing an empirical risk $F(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ under the constraint $\|\boldsymbol{\theta}\| \leq r$ (the ridge regression with $\|\cdot\|_2$, the Lasso with $\|\cdot\|_1$). We will see that such a constrained problem is closely related to the penalized problem $\min_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} F(\boldsymbol{\theta}) + \lambda\|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|^2$: the regularization parameter λ plays the role of a *Lagrange multiplier*.

- **Weights of a vote.** In ensemble methods (majority votes, boosting, PAC-Bayes), we learn a weight q_j for each voter h_j, $j = 1, \dots, n$. These weights must define a probability distribution, *i.e.* belong to the simplex

$$\Delta_n = \left\{ \mathbf{q} \in \mathbb{R}^n \;\middle|\; q_j \geq 0,\ \sum_{j=1}^n q_j = 1 \right\}.$$

In all these cases, we cannot simply set the gradient of the objective function equal to zero: its minimizer over $\mathbb{R}^d$ is in general *not* feasible.

4.2 Problem Formulation

Definition 4.1: Constrained Optimization Problem

Let $f, g_1, \dots, g_p, h_1, \dots, h_q : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}$ be given functions. A constrained optimization problem (in standard form) is a problem of the form

$$\begin{array}{ll} \min\limits_{\mathbf{x}\in\mathbb{R}^d} & f(\mathbf{x}) \\ \text{s.t.} & g_i(\mathbf{x}) \leq 0, \quad i = 1, \dots, p, \\ & h_j(\mathbf{x}) = 0, \quad j = 1, \dots, q. \end{array} \tag{4.1}$$

The function f is the objective function, the g_i's define the inequality constraints and the h_j's the equality constraints. The set

$$\mathcal{C} = \left\{ \mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d \mid g_i(\mathbf{x}) \leq 0,\ i = 1, \dots, p, \quad h_j(\mathbf{x}) = 0,\ j = 1, \dots, q \right\}$$

is called the feasible set if its elements are the feasible points. The optimal value of the problem is denoted by $p^\star = \inf_{\mathbf{x}\in\mathcal{C}} f(\mathbf{x})$, and a feasible point $\mathbf{x}^\star$ such that $f(\mathbf{x}^\star) = p^\star$ is a solution (or minimizer) of the problem.
The problem is said to be convex if f and $g_1, \dots, g_p$ are convex functions and $h_1, \dots, h_q$ are affine functions, *i.e.* $h_j(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{a}_j^T\mathbf{x} - b_j$.

Note that any constraint can be written in this form: a constraint $g(\mathbf{x}) \geq 0$ becomes $-g(\mathbf{x}) \leq 0$, and maximizing f amounts to minimizing $-f$. For instance, the SVM constraints read $g_i(\mathbf{w}, b) = 1 - y_i(\mathbf{w}^T\mathbf{x}_i + b) \leq 0$, and the simplex constraints read $-q_j \leq 0$ and $\sum_j q_j - 1 = 0$.

Why do we ask the equality constraints to be affine in a convex problem? Because the set $\{\mathbf{x} \mid h(\mathbf{x}) = 0\}$ is in general not convex when h is only convex (think of the circle $\{\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^2 \mid \|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 - 1 = 0\}$), whereas the following result holds.

Proposition 4.1: Convex Problems

For a convex problem (4.1):

- the feasible set $\mathcal{C}$ is convex;
- every local minimum of f on $\mathcal{C}$ is a global minimum;
- if f is differentiable, a feasible point $\mathbf{x}^\star$ is a solution if and only if

$$\langle \nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star), \mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}^\star \rangle \geq 0, \quad \forall \mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{C}. \tag{4.2}$$

Proof. Each sublevel set $\{\mathbf{x} \mid g_i(\mathbf{x}) \leq 0\}$ of a convex function is convex (if $g_i(\mathbf{u}) \leq 0$ and $g_i(\mathbf{v}) \leq 0$, then $g_i(t\mathbf{u}+(1-t)\mathbf{v}) \leq tg_i(\mathbf{u})+(1-t)g_i(\mathbf{v}) \leq 0$), and each set $\{\mathbf{x} \mid h_j(\mathbf{x}) = 0\}$ is a hyperplane, hence convex. $\mathcal{C}$ is an intersection of convex sets, so it is convex.

Let $\mathbf{x}^\star$ be a local minimum and assume that there is $\mathbf{y} \in \mathcal{C}$ with $f(\mathbf{y}) < f(\mathbf{x}^\star)$. For $t \in]0,1]$, the point $\mathbf{x}_t = \mathbf{x}^\star + t(\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{x}^\star)$ belongs to $\mathcal{C}$ and, by convexity, $f(\mathbf{x}_t) \leq (1-t)f(\mathbf{x}^\star) + tf(\mathbf{y}) < f(\mathbf{x}^\star)$. Since $\mathbf{x}_t$ is arbitrarily close to $\mathbf{x}^\star$ when $t \to 0$, this contradicts the local optimality of $\mathbf{x}^\star$.

Finally, condition (4.2) is necessary by Euler's inequality (Proposition 3.1), and it is sufficient because, by Proposition 2.6, $f(\mathbf{x}) \geq f(\mathbf{x}^\star) + \langle \nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star), \mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}^\star \rangle \geq f(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ for all $\mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{C}$. □

Condition (4.2) has a nice geometric interpretation: at a solution, no feasible direction $\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}^\star$ is a descent direction. When $\mathbf{x}^\star$ lies in the interior of $\mathcal{C}$, all the directions are feasible and we recover Euler's equation $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star) = \mathbf{0}$. When $\mathbf{x}^\star$ lies on the boundary of $\mathcal{C}$, the gradient does not vanish in general, but $-\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ must "point outside" the feasible set.

Geometric intuition Consider first a single equality constraint $h(\mathbf{x}) = 0$, as in the left part of Figure 29. Let us move along the curve $\{h = 0\}$ starting from a point $\mathbf{x}$. If $\nabla f(\mathbf{x})$ has a nonzero component along the curve (*i.e.* along its tangent), then we can decrease f while remaining feasible, so $\mathbf{x}$ is not optimal. At a solution $\mathbf{x}^\star$, the gradient $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ must therefore be orthogonal to the feasible set, *i.e.* parallel to $\nabla h(\mathbf{x}^\star)$, which is itself orthogonal to the curve $\{h = 0\}$:

$$\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star) + \mu \nabla h(\mathbf{x}^\star) = \mathbf{0} \quad \text{for some } \mu \in \mathbb{R}.$$

Equivalently, the level set of f going through $\mathbf{x}^\star$ is tangent to the curve $\{h = 0\}$.

For an inequality constraint $g(\mathbf{x}) \leq 0$ (right part of Figure 29), two situations may occur. Either the solution lies inside the feasible set, where $g(\mathbf{x}^\star) < 0$: the constraint is *inactive* and $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star) = \mathbf{0}$. Or it lies on its boundary, where $g(\mathbf{x}^\star) = 0$: the constraint is *active*, and $-\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ must point outwards, *i.e.* in the same direction as $\nabla g(\mathbf{x}^\star)$:

$$\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star) + \lambda \nabla g(\mathbf{x}^\star) = \mathbf{0} \quad \text{for some } \lambda \geq 0.$$

The sign of the multiplier λ now matters: if $-\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ pointed inwards, we could decrease f by moving inside the feasible set.

4.3 Equality Constraints and Lagrange Multipliers

The geometric intuition above is made rigorous by the following classical theorem, which we state without proof (it relies on the implicit function theorem).

Theorem 4.2: Lagrange Multipliers

Let $f, h_1, \ldots, h_q : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}$ be continuously differentiable functions, and let $\mathbf{x}^\star$ be a local minimum of f on the set $\{\mathbf{x} \mid h_j(\mathbf{x}) = 0,\ j = 1, \ldots, q\}$. Assume that the gradients $\nabla h_1(\mathbf{x}^\star), \ldots, \nabla h_q(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ are linearly independent. Then there exist real numbers $\mu_1^\star, \ldots, \mu_q^\star$, called Lagrange multipliers, such that

$$\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star) + \sum_{j=1}^{q} \mu_j^\star \nabla h_j(\mathbf{x}^\star) = \mathbf{0}.$$

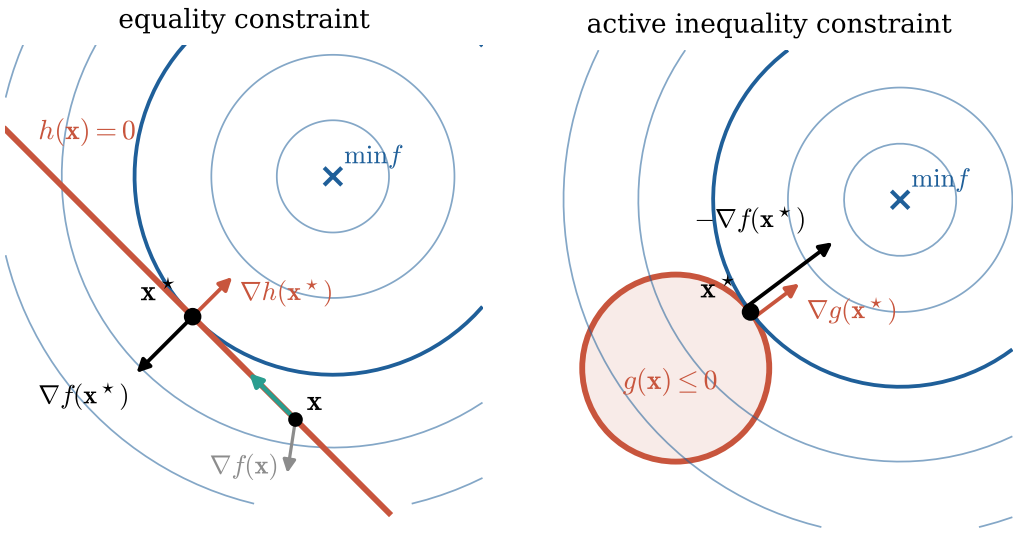


Figure 29: Geometry of constrained optimality. Left: with an equality constraint $h(\mathbf{x}) = 0$ (red line), the solution $\mathbf{x}^\star$ is the point where a level set of f (blue circles) is tangent to the constraint; there, $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ and $\nabla h(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ are parallel. At the non-optimal point $\mathbf{x}$, $\nabla f(\mathbf{x})$ has a component along the line, and moving along the green direction decreases f while remaining feasible. Right: with an active inequality constraint $g(\mathbf{x}) \leq 0$ (red disk), the solution $\mathbf{x}^\star$ lies on the boundary, and $-\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ points outside the feasible set, in the direction of $\nabla g(\mathbf{x}^\star)$. The thick blue circle is the level set of f going through $\mathbf{x}^\star$. [code: `make_figures_ch02.py: fig_ch03_lagrange`]

This condition can be written in a compact way by introducing the Lagrangian

$$\mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) = f(\mathbf{x}) + \sum_{j=1}^{q} \mu_j h_j(\mathbf{x}), \qquad \mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d, \ \boldsymbol{\mu} \in \mathbb{R}^q.$$

The conditions of Theorem 4.2, together with the feasibility of $\mathbf{x}^\star$, simply read

$$\nabla_{\mathbf{x}} \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star) = \mathbf{0} \qquad \text{and} \qquad \nabla_{\boldsymbol{\mu}} \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star) = (h_1(\mathbf{x}^\star), \dots, h_q(\mathbf{x}^\star)) = \mathbf{0}\,:$$

we have replaced a constrained problem with d unknowns by an *unconstrained* system of $d+q$ equations with $d+q$ unknowns. For a convex problem, these conditions are also sufficient (this is a special case of Theorem 4.5 below).

Example 4.1 (Minimum-norm solution of a linear equation). Let $\mathbf{a} \in \mathbb{R}^d \setminus \{\mathbf{0}\}$ and $b \in \mathbb{R}$. We look for the point of the hyperplane $\{\mathbf{x} \mid \mathbf{a}^T\mathbf{x} = b\}$ that is closest to the origin:

$$\min_{\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d} \frac{1}{2} \|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \mathbf{a}^T\mathbf{x} - b = 0.$$

The Lagrangian is $\mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}, \mu) = \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 + \mu(\mathbf{a}^T\mathbf{x} - b)$, and the optimality conditions give

$$\nabla_{\mathbf{x}} \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}, \mu) = \mathbf{x} + \mu\mathbf{a} = \mathbf{0} \iff \mathbf{x} = -\mu\mathbf{a}$$

$$\downarrow \text{ plug into the constraint } \mathbf{a}^T\mathbf{x} = b$$

$$-\mu \|\mathbf{a}\|_2^2 = b \iff \mu^\star = -\frac{b}{\|\mathbf{a}\|_2^2}.$$

Hence $\mathbf{x}^\star = \dfrac{b}{\|\mathbf{a}\|_2^2}\,\mathbf{a}$: the solution is colinear to the normal vector $\mathbf{a}$ of the hyperplane, and the distance from the origin to the hyperplane is $\|\mathbf{x}^\star\|_2 = |b| / \|\mathbf{a}\|_2$. This is exactly the formula used to compute the margin of a linear classifier.

Example 4.2 (Quadratic function under linear constraints). Let $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times d}$ be symmetric positive definite, $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, $\mathbf{C} \in \mathbb{R}^{q\times d}$ of rank q and $\mathbf{d} \in \mathbb{R}^q$. We consider

$$\min_{\mathbf{x}\in\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{1}{2}\mathbf{x}^T\mathbf{A}\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{b}^T\mathbf{x} \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \mathbf{C}\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{d}.$$

With $\mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) = \frac{1}{2}\mathbf{x}^T\mathbf{A}\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{b}^T\mathbf{x} + \boldsymbol{\mu}^T(\mathbf{C}\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{d})$, the optimality conditions form the linear system

$$\begin{pmatrix} \mathbf{A} & \mathbf{C}^T \\ \mathbf{C} & \mathbf{0} \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} \mathbf{x} \\ \boldsymbol{\mu} \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} \mathbf{b} \\ \mathbf{d} \end{pmatrix}.$$

The first block gives $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{A}^{-1}(\mathbf{b} - \mathbf{C}^T\boldsymbol{\mu})$; plugging it into $\mathbf{C}\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{d}$ gives $\mathbf{C}\mathbf{A}^{-1}\mathbf{b} - \mathbf{C}\mathbf{A}^{-1}\mathbf{C}^T\boldsymbol{\mu} = \mathbf{d}$. Since $\mathbf{C}\mathbf{A}^{-1}\mathbf{C}^T$ is invertible (it is positive definite because $\mathbf{C}$ has full rank),

$$\boldsymbol{\mu}^\star = \left(\mathbf{C}\mathbf{A}^{-1}\mathbf{C}^T\right)^{-1}\left(\mathbf{C}\mathbf{A}^{-1}\mathbf{b} - \mathbf{d}\right) \qquad \text{and} \qquad \mathbf{x}^\star = \mathbf{A}^{-1}\left(\mathbf{b} - \mathbf{C}^T\boldsymbol{\mu}^\star\right).$$

Without constraints, we would have found $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{A}^{-1}\mathbf{b}$: the term $-\mathbf{A}^{-1}\mathbf{C}^T\boldsymbol{\mu}^\star$ is the correction due to the constraints.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q4.1. Why must the equality constraints of a convex problem be affine?

Q4.2. Is the problem $\min \|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2$ s.t. $\|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \geq 1$ convex? What are its solutions?

Q4.3. Find the point of the line $x_1 + x_2 = 2$ closest to the origin, and the Lagrange multiplier of $\min \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2$ s.t. $x_1 + x_2 - 2 = 0$.

Q4.4. True or false: at the solution of an equality-constrained problem, $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star) = \mathbf{0}$.

4.4 Lagrangian Duality

We now come back to the general problem (4.1), with inequality constraints, which we call the primal problem. The idea of duality is to incorporate the constraints into the objective function, with a price for violating them.

Definition 4.2: Lagrangian and Dual Function

The Lagrangian associated with problem (4.1) is the function $\mathcal{L} : \mathbb{R}^d \times \mathbb{R}^p \times \mathbb{R}^q \to \mathbb{R}$ defined by

$$\mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}, \boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) = f(\mathbf{x}) + \sum_{i=1}^{p} \lambda_i g_i(\mathbf{x}) + \sum_{j=1}^{q} \mu_j h_j(\mathbf{x}).$$

The variables $\boldsymbol{\lambda} = (\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_p)$ and $\boldsymbol{\mu} = (\mu_1, \ldots, \mu_q)$ are the Lagrange multipliers (or dual variables); the multipliers λ_i of the inequality constraints are required to be nonnegative. The dual function is defined, for $\boldsymbol{\lambda} \in \mathbb{R}^p$ with $\boldsymbol{\lambda} \geq \mathbf{0}$ and $\boldsymbol{\mu} \in \mathbb{R}^q$,

by

$$\mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) = \inf_{\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d} \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}, \boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) \ \in \mathbb{R} \cup \{-\infty\}.$$

For each fixed $\mathbf{x}$, the function $(\boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) \mapsto \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}, \boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu})$ is affine. As a pointwise infimum of affine functions, the dual function $\mathcal{G}$ is always concave, even when the primal problem is not convex (by the same argument as for the maximum of convex functions in Proposition 2.5).

Definition 4.3: Dual Problem

The dual problem of (4.1) is

$$\max_{\boldsymbol{\lambda} \in \mathbb{R}^p, \, \boldsymbol{\mu} \in \mathbb{R}^q} \mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \boldsymbol{\lambda} \geq \mathbf{0}. \tag{4.3}$$

Its optimal value is denoted by $d^\star$. A pair $(\boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu})$ with $\boldsymbol{\lambda} \geq \mathbf{0}$ and $\mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) > -\infty$ is said to be dual feasible.

Since $\mathcal{G}$ is concave and the constraint $\boldsymbol{\lambda} \geq \mathbf{0}$ is convex, the dual problem is always a convex problem (maximizing a concave function amounts to minimizing a convex one). The fundamental property of the dual problem is that it provides lower bounds on the optimal value of the primal problem.

Theorem 4.3: Weak Duality

For every $\boldsymbol{\lambda} \geq \mathbf{0}$ and every $\boldsymbol{\mu} \in \mathbb{R}^q$, we have $\mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) \leq p^\star$. Consequently,

$$d^\star \leq p^\star.$$

Proof. Let $\mathbf{x}$ be a feasible point and $\boldsymbol{\lambda} \geq \mathbf{0}$, $\boldsymbol{\mu} \in \mathbb{R}^q$. Then

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) &= \inf_{\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^d} \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{z}, \boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ the infimum is smaller than any value of the function} \\
&\leq \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}, \boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) = f(\mathbf{x}) + \sum_{i=1}^{p} \lambda_i g_i(\mathbf{x}) + \sum_{j=1}^{q} \mu_j \underbrace{h_j(\mathbf{x})}_{=0} \\
&\quad \downarrow \ \lambda_i \geq 0 \text{ and } g_i(\mathbf{x}) \leq 0, \text{ so each term } \lambda_i g_i(\mathbf{x}) \text{ is nonpositive} \\
&\leq f(\mathbf{x}).
\end{aligned}$$

Taking the infimum over all feasible points $\mathbf{x}$ gives $\mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) \leq p^\star$, and taking the supremum over $(\boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu})$ gives $d^\star \leq p^\star$. □

The difference $p^\star - d^\star \geq 0$ is called the duality gap. Weak duality always holds, but the gap may be positive, in particular for nonconvex problems. When $d^\star = p^\star$, we say that strong duality holds: solving the dual problem, which is often easier, then gives the optimal value of the primal problem. For convex problems, strong duality

holds under mild assumptions called *constraint qualifications*; the most popular one is Slater's condition.

Theorem 4.4: Strong Duality – Slater's Condition

Assume that problem (4.1) is convex and that there exists a strictly feasible point $\tilde{\mathbf{x}}$, *i.e.*

$$g_i(\tilde{\mathbf{x}}) < 0, \quad i = 1, \dots, p, \qquad \text{and} \qquad h_j(\tilde{\mathbf{x}}) = 0, \quad j = 1, \dots, q.$$

Then strong duality holds, $d^\star = p^\star$, and if $p^\star > -\infty$, the dual problem has a solution $(\boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star)$. Moreover, strict feasibility is not required for the inequality constraints g_i that are affine: in particular, if all the constraints are affine, strong duality holds as soon as the problem is feasible.

The proof relies on a separating hyperplane argument; see Boyd and Vandenberghe (2004, Section 5.3.2).

Example 4.3 (Dual of the minimum-norm problem). Let us come back to the problem $\min \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2$ s.t. $\mathbf{a}^T\mathbf{x} = b$. For a fixed μ, the Lagrangian $\mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}, \mu) = \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 + \mu(\mathbf{a}^T\mathbf{x} - b)$ is a convex quadratic function of $\mathbf{x}$, minimized at $\mathbf{x} = -\mu\mathbf{a}$. Hence

$$\mathcal{G}(\mu) = \frac{1}{2}\mu^2\|\mathbf{a}\|_2^2 - \mu^2\|\mathbf{a}\|_2^2 - \mu b = -\frac{1}{2}\mu^2\|\mathbf{a}\|_2^2 - \mu b.$$

This concave function of μ is maximized at $\mu^\star = -b/\|\mathbf{a}\|_2^2$, and $d^\star = \mathcal{G}(\mu^\star) = \dfrac{b^2}{2\|\mathbf{a}\|_2^2}$, which is exactly $p^\star = \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{x}^\star\|_2^2$: strong duality holds, as predicted by Theorem 4.4 (the constraint is affine).

4.5 The Karush–Kuhn–Tucker Conditions

We can now state the optimality conditions of constrained problems, which generalize Euler's equation $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star) = \mathbf{0}$ and Lagrange's theorem. They were obtained by Karush (1939) and, independently, by Kuhn and Tucker (1951).

Theorem 4.5: Karush–Kuhn–Tucker (KKT) Conditions

Assume that $f, g_1, \dots, g_p, h_1, \dots, h_q$ are differentiable. We say that $(\mathbf{x}^\star, \boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star)$ satisfies the KKT conditions if

1. **(stationarity)** $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star) + \sum_{i=1}^{p} \lambda_i^\star \nabla g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star) + \sum_{j=1}^{q} \mu_j^\star \nabla h_j(\mathbf{x}^\star) = \mathbf{0}$, *i.e.* $\nabla_{\mathbf{x}}\mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}^\star, \boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star) = \mathbf{0}$;
2. **(primal feasibility)** $g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star) \leq 0$ for all i and $h_j(\mathbf{x}^\star) = 0$ for all j;
3. **(dual feasibility)** $\lambda_i^\star \geq 0$ for all i;
4. **(complementary slackness)** $\lambda_i^\star g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star) = 0$ for all i.

Then:

- **necessity:** if strong duality holds, $\mathbf{x}^\star$ is a solution of the primal problem (4.1) and $(\boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star)$ is a solution of the dual problem (4.3), then $(\mathbf{x}^\star, \boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star)$ satisfies the KKT conditions;
- **sufficiency:** if the problem is convex and $(\mathbf{x}^\star, \boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star)$ satisfies the KKT conditions, then $\mathbf{x}^\star$ is a solution of the primal problem, $(\boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star)$ is a solution of the dual problem, and $p^\star = d^\star$.

In particular, for a convex problem satisfying Slater's condition, $\mathbf{x}^\star$ is a solution if and only if there exist $(\boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star)$ such that the KKT conditions hold.

Proof. Necessity. Since $\mathbf{x}^\star$ is feasible and $\boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star \geq \mathbf{0}$, primal and dual feasibility hold. Moreover,

$$\begin{aligned} f(\mathbf{x}^\star) = p^\star = d^\star = \mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star) &= \inf_{\mathbf{x}\in\mathbb{R}^d} \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}, \boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star) \\ &\leq \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}^\star, \boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star) = f(\mathbf{x}^\star) + \sum_{i=1}^{p} \lambda_i^\star g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star) + \sum_{j=1}^{q} \mu_j^\star \underbrace{h_j(\mathbf{x}^\star)}_{=0} \\ &\downarrow \text{ each } \lambda_i^\star g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star) \text{ is nonpositive} \\ &\leq f(\mathbf{x}^\star). \end{aligned}$$

Hence all these inequalities are equalities. The first one says that $\mathbf{x}^\star$ minimizes the differentiable function $\mathbf{x} \mapsto \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}, \boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star)$ over $\mathbb{R}^d$, so its gradient vanishes at $\mathbf{x}^\star$ by Euler's equation (Proposition 3.2): this is stationarity. The second one says that $\sum_i \lambda_i^\star g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star) = 0$; since each term of this sum is nonpositive, each term is zero: this is complementary slackness.

Sufficiency. Since the problem is convex and $\boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star \geq \mathbf{0}$, the function $\mathbf{x} \mapsto \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}, \boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star)$ is convex (a nonnegative combination of convex functions plus affine functions). By stationarity and Proposition 2.6, $\mathbf{x}^\star$ is a global minimizer of this function, hence

$$\mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star) = \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{x}^\star, \boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star) = f(\mathbf{x}^\star) + \sum_{i=1}^{p} \underbrace{\lambda_i^\star g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star)}_{=0} + \sum_{j=1}^{q} \mu_j^\star \underbrace{h_j(\mathbf{x}^\star)}_{=0} = f(\mathbf{x}^\star),$$

using complementary slackness and primal feasibility. By weak duality, $\mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star) \leq d^\star \leq p^\star \leq f(\mathbf{x}^\star)$, so all these quantities are equal: $\mathbf{x}^\star$ is primal optimal, $(\boldsymbol{\lambda}^\star, \boldsymbol{\mu}^\star)$ is dual optimal and $p^\star = d^\star$. □

Remark Without a constraint qualification, the KKT conditions may fail to hold at a solution, even for a convex problem. Consider $\min_{x\in\mathbb{R}} x$ s.t. $g(x) = x^2 \leq 0$. The only feasible point, hence the solution, is $x^\star = 0$, but stationarity would require $1 + 2\lambda x^\star = 1 = 0$, which is impossible. Here Slater's condition fails: no point satisfies $x^2 < 0$.

Complementary slackness and its interpretation Complementary slackness says that, for each inequality constraint,

$$\lambda_i^\star > 0 \implies g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star) = 0 \qquad \text{and} \qquad g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star) < 0 \implies \lambda_i^\star = 0.$$

In words: a constraint that is not active at the solution ($g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star) < 0$) does not play any role, and its multiplier is zero; the solution would not change if this constraint were removed. Conversely, a positive multiplier indicates an active constraint, which really "pushes" the solution. This is what we observed in Figure 29: an inactive constraint gives $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star) = \mathbf{0}$, an active one gives $-\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star) = \lambda^\star \nabla g(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ with $\lambda^\star \geq 0$.

The multipliers also have an economic interpretation, as prices or sensitivities: if the i-th constraint is relaxed into $g_i(\mathbf{x}) \leq u_i$ with u_i small, then, under regularity assumptions, the optimal value changes by approximately $-\lambda_i^\star u_i$. A large multiplier thus indicates a constraint which is expensive, *i.e.* which strongly limits the decrease of the objective (Boyd and Vandenberghe, 2004, Section 5.6).

In the SVM, the multipliers are attached to the training examples: complementary slackness implies that only the examples whose constraint is active, the support vectors, have a nonzero multiplier and contribute to the solution (see the preview below).

4.6 Worked Examples

The KKT conditions often allow us to compute the solution in closed form, by examining which constraints are active.

Example 4.4 (Projection onto a Euclidean ball). Let $\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and $r > 0$. We look for the point of the ball $\{\mathbf{x} \mid \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \leq r\}$ closest to $\mathbf{z}$:

$$\min_{\mathbf{x}\in\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{z}\|_2^2 \quad \text{s.t.} \quad g(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{1}{2}\left(\|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 - r^2\right) \leq 0.$$

The problem is convex and Slater's condition holds ($g(\mathbf{0}) < 0$), so the KKT conditions characterize the solution:

$$\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{z} + \lambda\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}, \qquad \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \leq r, \qquad \lambda \geq 0, \qquad \lambda\left(\|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 - r^2\right) = 0.$$

Stationarity gives $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{z}/(1+\lambda)$. Two cases occur.

- If $\|\mathbf{z}\|_2 \leq r$, then $\lambda = 0$ and $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{z}$ satisfy all the conditions: the constraint is inactive and $\mathbf{z}$ is its own projection.
- If $\|\mathbf{z}\|_2 > r$, then $\lambda = 0$ is impossible (it would give $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{z}$, which is not feasible), so the constraint is active: $\|\mathbf{x}\|_2 = r$, *i.e.* $1 + \lambda = \|\mathbf{z}\|_2 / r$, and $\mathbf{x} = r\,\mathbf{z}/\|\mathbf{z}\|_2$.

In both cases, the projection is

$$\Pi_{\mathcal{B}(r)}(\mathbf{z}) = \min\left(1, \frac{r}{\|\mathbf{z}\|_2}\right)\mathbf{z}\,:$$

the point $\mathbf{z}$ is simply rescaled onto the sphere when it lies outside the ball. This operation is known as *gradient clipping* in deep learning.

Example 4.5 (Projection onto the simplex). Let $\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^n$. We look for the probability vector closest to $\mathbf{z}$:

$$\min_{\mathbf{q}\in\mathbb{R}^n} \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{q}-\mathbf{z}\|_2^2 \quad \text{s.t.} \quad -q_j \leq 0,\ j = 1,\dots,n, \qquad \sum_{j=1}^n q_j - 1 = 0.$$

All the constraints are affine, so the KKT conditions are necessary and sufficient. With multipliers $\lambda_j \geq 0$ for the inequalities and μ for the equality, they read

$$q_j - z_j - \lambda_j + \mu = 0, \qquad q_j \geq 0, \qquad \lambda_j \geq 0, \qquad \lambda_j q_j = 0, \qquad \sum_{j=1}^{n} q_j = 1.$$

Let us set $\tau = \mu$ and discuss according to complementary slackness:

- if $q_j > 0$, then $\lambda_j = 0$ and $q_j = z_j - \tau$ (which requires $z_j > \tau$);
- if $q_j = 0$, then $\lambda_j = \tau - z_j \geq 0$, *i.e.* $z_j \leq \tau$.

In both cases, $q_j = \max(z_j - \tau, 0)$, where the threshold τ is determined by the constraint

$$\sum_{j=1}^{n} \max(z_j - \tau, 0) = 1.$$

The left-hand side is a continuous and nonincreasing function of τ, decreasing from $+\infty$ to 0 on the range where it is positive, so this equation has a unique solution, which can be found by sorting the z_j's. For instance, with $\mathbf{z} = (0.8, 0.6, -0.2)$, we try to keep the two largest components: $(0.8 - \tau) + (0.6 - \tau) = 1$ gives $\tau = 0.2$, and indeed $z_3 = -0.2 \leq \tau$. Hence $\mathbf{q}^\star = (0.6, 0.4, 0)$: the projection onto the simplex produces *sparse* weights.

Example 4.6 (A preview of the hard-margin SVM dual). Let us apply Lagrangian duality to the hard-margin SVM problem of the motivation, with the constraints $g_i(\mathbf{w}, b) = 1 - y_i(\mathbf{w}^T \mathbf{x}_i + b) \leq 0$. With multipliers $\alpha_i \geq 0$, the Lagrangian is

$$\mathcal{L}(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\alpha}) = \frac{1}{2} \|\mathbf{w}\|_2^2 + \sum_{i=1}^{m} \alpha_i \left(1 - y_i(\mathbf{w}^T \mathbf{x}_i + b)\right).$$

For a fixed $\boldsymbol{\alpha}$, this function is convex in $(\mathbf{w}, b)$, and it is minimized where its gradient vanishes:

$$\nabla_{\mathbf{w}} \mathcal{L} = \mathbf{w} - \sum_{i=1}^{m} \alpha_i y_i \mathbf{x}_i = \mathbf{0} \qquad \text{and} \qquad \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial b} = -\sum_{i=1}^{m} \alpha_i y_i = 0.$$

If $\sum_i \alpha_i y_i \neq 0$, the Lagrangian is affine and nonconstant in b, so $\mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{\alpha}) = -\infty$. Otherwise, plugging $\mathbf{w} = \sum_i \alpha_i y_i \mathbf{x}_i$ into $\mathcal{L}$ gives the dual problem

$$\max_{\boldsymbol{\alpha} \in \mathbb{R}^m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \alpha_i - \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sum_{k=1}^{m} \alpha_i \alpha_k y_i y_k \, \mathbf{x}_i^T \mathbf{x}_k \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \alpha_i \geq 0, \quad \sum_{i=1}^{m} \alpha_i y_i = 0.$$

Since the constraints are affine, strong duality holds as soon as the data are linearly separable. Three important facts can already be observed:

- the solution $\mathbf{w}^\star = \sum_i \alpha_i^\star y_i \mathbf{x}_i$ is a linear combination of the training examples;
- by complementary slackness, $\alpha_i^\star > 0$ only if $y_i(\mathbf{w}^{\star T} \mathbf{x}_i + b^\star) = 1$, *i.e.* only for the examples lying exactly on the margin: the support vectors;
- the data only appear through the inner products $\mathbf{x}_i^T \mathbf{x}_k$, which opens the way to *kernels*.

These properties are studied in detail in the section devoted to support vector machines in Part II.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q4.5. Why is the dual problem always convex, even when the primal problem is not?

Q4.6. A feasible point gives $f(\mathbf{x}) = 3.2$ and a dual feasible pair gives $\mathcal{G}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu}) = 3.0$. What can you say?

Q4.7. True or false: for a convex problem, the KKT conditions always hold at a solution.

Q4.8. A multiplier satisfies $\lambda_i^\star > 0$. What can you say about the i-th constraint? And if $g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star) < 0$?

Q4.9. What is the projection of $\mathbf{z} = (2, 0.5, 0)$ onto the simplex Δ_3?

4.7 Projected Gradient Descent

The KKT conditions do not always lead to a closed-form solution, and we need algorithms. When the feasible set $\mathcal{C}$ is simple, the most natural idea is to perform a gradient step, which may leave $\mathcal{C}$, and then to come back to $\mathcal{C}$ by projecting onto it.

Definition 4.4: Projection onto a Convex Set

Let $\mathcal{C} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$ be a nonempty, closed and convex set. The projection of a point $\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ onto $\mathcal{C}$ is

$$\Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{z}) = \arg\min_{\mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{C}} \frac{1}{2} \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{z}\|_2^2 .$$

Proposition 4.6: Properties of the Projection

Let $\mathcal{C}$ be a nonempty, closed and convex subset of $\mathbb{R}^d$.

- For all $\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, the projection $\Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{z})$ exists and is unique.
- A point $\mathbf{p} \in \mathcal{C}$ is the projection of $\mathbf{z}$ if and only if

$$\langle \mathbf{z} - \mathbf{p}, \mathbf{x} - \mathbf{p} \rangle \leq 0, \quad \forall \mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{C}.$$

- The projection is non-expansive: $\|\Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{z}) - \Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{z}')\|_2 \leq \|\mathbf{z} - \mathbf{z}'\|_2$ for all $\mathbf{z}, \mathbf{z}'$.

Proof (of the second point). The function $\mathbf{x} \mapsto \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{z}\|_2^2$ is convex, with gradient $\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{z}$. By Proposition 4.1 (or directly by Euler's inequality and Proposition 2.6), $\mathbf{p}$ minimizes it over $\mathcal{C}$ if and only if $\langle \mathbf{p} - \mathbf{z}, \mathbf{x} - \mathbf{p} \rangle \geq 0$ for all $\mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{C}$. Existence follows from the continuity of the function and the fact that we can restrict the search to the compact set $\mathcal{C} \cap \{\mathbf{x} \mid \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{z}\|_2 \leq \|\mathbf{x}_0 - \mathbf{z}\|_2\}$ for any $\mathbf{x}_0 \in \mathcal{C}$, and uniqueness from the strong convexity of the function. □

Geometrically, the angle between $\mathbf{z} - \Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{z})$ and any vector pointing from $\Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{z})$ into $\mathcal{C}$ is obtuse. Combining this characterization with condition (4.2), one checks that,

Algorithm 1: Projected Gradient Descent

Input: a differentiable function f, a closed convex set $\mathcal{C}$ with an easy projection $\Pi_{\mathcal{C}}$, an initial point $\mathbf{x}_0 \in \mathcal{C}$, a step size $\rho > 0$, a number of iterations K (or a tolerance $\eta > 0$)

Output: an approximate solution $\mathbf{x}_K$ of $\min_{\mathbf{x}\in\mathcal{C}} f(\mathbf{x})$

for $k = 0, 1, \dots, K-1$ **do**
  $\mathbf{y}_{k+1} \leftarrow \mathbf{x}_k - \rho \nabla f(\mathbf{x}_k)$; `// gradient step`
  $\mathbf{x}_{k+1} \leftarrow \Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{y}_{k+1})$; `// projection onto the feasible set`
  if $\|\mathbf{x}_{k+1} - \mathbf{x}_k\|_2 \leq \rho\,\eta$ **then**
    stop and return $\mathbf{x}_{k+1}$
return $\mathbf{x}_K$

for any $\rho > 0$, $\mathbf{x}^\star$ is a solution of $\min_{\mathbf{x}\in\mathcal{C}} f(\mathbf{x})$ (with f convex and differentiable) if and only if

$$\mathbf{x}^\star = \Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{x}^\star - \rho \nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star)).$$

The solutions are thus the fixed points of the map $\mathbf{x} \mapsto \Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{x} - \rho\nabla f(\mathbf{x}))$, which suggests the following algorithm.

Note that the stopping criterion is not $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{x}_k)\|_2 \leq \eta$ anymore, since the gradient does not vanish at a solution lying on the boundary of $\mathcal{C}$; we use instead the distance between two successive iterates, which is zero exactly at the fixed points.

The projections computed in the previous examples can directly be plugged into Algorithm 1: onto a ball, the projection is a rescaling; onto a box $[a, b]^d$, it amounts to clipping each coordinate, $x_j \mapsto \min(\max(x_j, a), b)$; onto the simplex, it is the thresholding operation computed above. Figure 30 shows the algorithm at work on a ball and on a box. As long as the iterates remain inside $\mathcal{C}$, the algorithm coincides with gradient descent; once the boundary is reached, each gradient step leaves $\mathcal{C}$ and the projection brings the iterate back, so that the iterates slide along the boundary towards the point where $-\nabla f$ is orthogonal to it, as in Figure 29.

Remark on convergence Projected gradient descent enjoys the same guarantees as gradient descent in the unconstrained case. Assume that f is convex and L-smooth, *i.e.* that its gradient is L-Lipschitz: $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{u}) - \nabla f(\mathbf{v})\|_2 \leq L\,\|\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{v}\|_2$. With the step $\rho = 1/L$, the iterates satisfy

$$f(\mathbf{x}_k) - f(\mathbf{x}^\star) \leq \frac{L\,\|\mathbf{x}_0 - \mathbf{x}^\star\|_2^2}{2k},$$

a convergence rate in $\mathcal{O}(1/k)$. If f is moreover α-strongly convex, the convergence is linear (geometric): $\|\mathbf{x}_k - \mathbf{x}^\star\|_2^2 \leq (1 - \alpha/L)^k\,\|\mathbf{x}_0 - \mathbf{x}^\star\|_2^2$. The projection does not slow down the algorithm, but each iteration is only cheap if the projection is cheap: for complicated feasible sets, computing $\Pi_{\mathcal{C}}$ is itself an optimization problem, and one rather uses duality or other methods (interior point methods, Frank–Wolfe algorithm, ...).

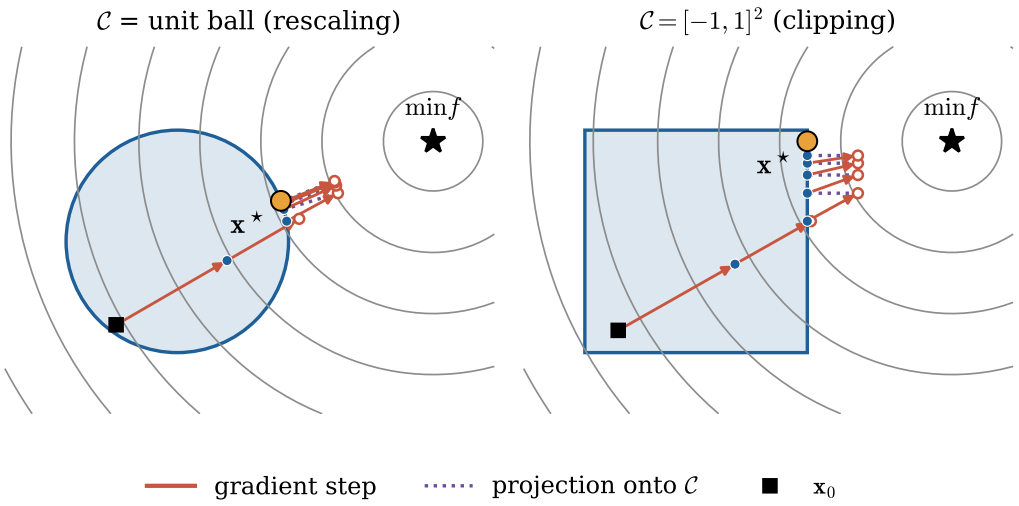


Figure 30: Six iterations of projected gradient descent (step $\rho = 0.35$) for a quadratic function whose unconstrained minimizer (star) is not feasible, starting from the black square. Each gradient step (red arrow) may leave the feasible set $\mathcal{C}$ (blue); the projection (dotted line) brings the point back onto $\mathcal{C}$. Left: unit ball, the projection is a rescaling. Right: box $[-1, 1]^2$, the projection clips each coordinate. In both cases, the constraint is active at the solution $\mathbf{x}^\star$, where the gradient does not vanish. [code: `make_figures_ch02.py: fig_ch03_projgd`]

To remember from Section 4

- A constrained problem is convex when the objective and the inequality constraints are convex and the equality constraints are affine; then every local minimum is global.
- At a solution, $-\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ is a nonnegative combination of the gradients of the active constraints (plus any combination of those of the equality constraints): this is the stationarity condition of the Lagrangian.
- The dual function is always concave and gives lower bounds on the optimal value (weak duality); for convex problems satisfying Slater's condition, the duality gap is zero (strong duality).
- The KKT conditions (stationarity, primal and dual feasibility, complementary slackness) characterize the solutions of convex problems satisfying Slater's condition. Complementary slackness says that inactive constraints have zero multipliers, which explains the support vectors of the SVM.
- When the projection onto $\mathcal{C}$ is cheap (ball, box, simplex), projected gradient descent alternates a gradient step and a projection, with the same convergence guarantees as gradient descent.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q4.10. What is the projection of $\mathbf{z} = (3, 4)$ onto the unit ball? onto the box $[-1, 1]^2$?

Q4.11. Project $\mathbf{z} = (1.5, -0.3)$ onto the box $[0, 1]^2$.

Q4.12. Why can we not use $\|\nabla f(\mathbf{x}_k)\|_2 \leq \eta$ as a stopping criterion in projected gradient descent?

Q4.13. True or false: if the unconstrained minimizer of f belongs to $\mathcal{C}$, projected gradient descent produces the same iterates as gradient descent.

Q4.14. Why does the fixed-point characterization $\mathbf{x}^\star = \Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{x}^\star - \rho \nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star))$ hold for every $\rho > 0$?

Q4.15. What is the cost of one iteration of projected gradient descent on the simplex Δ_n?

Exercises

Exercise 4.1. **(Comprehension)** True or false? Justify briefly. (a) The dual function of a nonconvex problem is concave. (b) For every optimization problem, $d^\star = p^\star$. (c) At a solution of a convex problem satisfying Slater's condition, the multiplier of an inactive constraint is zero. (d) The projection onto any closed set $\mathcal{C} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$ is unique. (e) A convex problem may have several solutions.

Exercise 4.2. **(Computation)** Solve the problem $\min_{\mathbf{x}\in\mathbb{R}^2} \; x_1 + x_2$ s.t. $x_1^2 + x_2^2 \leq 2$ using the KKT conditions. Check that Slater's condition holds, that the constraint is active at the solution, and give the value of the multiplier.

Exercise 4.3. **(Computation)** We consider $\min_{\mathbf{x}\in\mathbb{R}^2} \; x_1^2 + 2x_2^2$ s.t. $x_1 + x_2 = 3$. (a) Write the Lagrangian and solve the problem with Theorem 4.2. Why is the point found a global minimizer? (b) Compute the dual function $\mathcal{G}(\mu)$ and solve the dual problem. (c) Check that strong duality holds, and interpret the sign of $\mu^\star$ using the sensitivity interpretation of the multipliers.

Exercise 4.4. **(Computation)** We consider

$$\min_{\mathbf{x}\in\mathbb{R}^2} \; (x_1 - 2)^2 + (x_2 - 1)^2 \quad \text{s.t.} \quad x_1 + x_2 \leq 2, \quad x_1 \geq 0.$$

(a) Show that the problem is convex, that Slater's condition holds and that the unconstrained minimizer is not feasible. (b) Write the KKT conditions. (c) Examine the four possible sets of active constraints and find the solution, the multipliers and the optimal value.

Exercise 4.5. **(Proof)** Let $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{q\times d}$, $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^q$ and $\mathbf{c} \in \mathbb{R}^d$. Show that the dual of the linear program $\min_{\mathbf{x}} \; \mathbf{c}^T\mathbf{x}$ s.t. $\mathbf{A}\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$, $\mathbf{x} \geq \mathbf{0}$, is (up to a change of sign of the multiplier) the linear program

$$\max_{\boldsymbol{\nu}\in\mathbb{R}^q} \; \mathbf{b}^T\boldsymbol{\nu} \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \mathbf{A}^T\boldsymbol{\nu} \leq \mathbf{c}.$$

(*Hint:* the dual function is $-\infty$ unless the Lagrangian does not depend on $\mathbf{x}$.)

Exercise 4.6. **(Computation)** Compute the projection of $\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ onto the box $[a, b]^d$, with $a < b$, using the KKT conditions, and write the corresponding projected gradient descent to minimize $\|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2$ under the constraint $\boldsymbol{\theta} \in [a, b]^d$.

Exercise 4.7. **(Computation)** (a) Using the method of the notes, compute the projection of $\mathbf{z} = (0.5, 1.2, -0.3, 0.9)$ onto the simplex Δ_4, and the multipliers λ_j of the constraints $q_j \geq 0$. (b) Same question for $\mathbf{z} = (2, 0.5, 0)$. Comment. (c) Write a Python function computing the projection onto Δ_n by sorting.

Exercise 4.8. **(Proof)** Let $\mathcal{C}$ be a nonempty closed convex set. (a) Using the characterization of Proposition 4.6, prove that the projection is non-expansive: $\|\Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{z}) - \Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{z}')\|_2 \leq \|\mathbf{z} - \mathbf{z}'\|_2$. (b) Let f be convex and differentiable, and $\rho > 0$. Prove that $\mathbf{x}^\star \in \mathcal{C}$ minimizes f on $\mathcal{C}$ if and only if $\mathbf{x}^\star = \Pi_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathbf{x}^\star - \rho\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star))$.

Exercise 4.9. **(Proof)** *Softmax as the solution of a constrained problem.* Let $\mathbf{c} \in \mathbb{R}^n$. We consider the problem

$$\min_{\mathbf{q}\in\mathbb{R}^n} \; \sum_{j=1}^n q_j c_j + \sum_{j=1}^n q_j \ln q_j \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \mathbf{q} \in \Delta_n$$

(with the convention $0 \ln 0 = 0$). Admitting that the constraints $q_j \geq 0$ are inactive at the solution, show using a Lagrange multiplier for the constraint $\sum_j q_j = 1$ that

$$q_j^\star = \frac{\exp(-c_j)}{\sum_{k=1}^n \exp(-c_k)},$$

and that the optimal value is $-\ln \sum_{k=1}^n \exp(-c_k)$. Compare with the log-sum-exp function of Section 2. This result is at the heart of the Gibbs posterior in PAC-Bayes theory (Part IV).

Exercise 4.10. **(Proof)** Let F be a convex differentiable function and $r > 0$. Write the KKT conditions of the problem $\min_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} F(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ s.t. $\|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2 \leq r^2$, and show that its solution $\boldsymbol{\theta}^\star$ is also a minimizer of the penalized function $F(\boldsymbol{\theta}) + \lambda^\star \|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2$ for some $\lambda^\star \geq 0$. Explain the link between constrained and regularized learning.

Exercise 4.11. **(Application)** We consider two training points $\mathbf{x}_1 = (1, 1)$ with $y_1 = +1$ and $\mathbf{x}_2 = (-1, -1)$ with $y_2 = -1$. (a) Write the dual problem of the hard-margin SVM (see the preview in the notes) and solve it. (b) Deduce $\mathbf{w}^\star$ and $b^\star$, and check all the KKT conditions. (c) Compute the margin $1/\|\mathbf{w}^\star\|_2$ and compare with the distance between the two points.

Exercise 4.12. **(Python)** *Nonnegative least squares.* Generate $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{50\times 8}$ with i.i.d. standard Gaussian entries, $\boldsymbol{\theta}_{\text{true}} = (2, 0, 0, 1.5, 0, 0, 0.5, 0)$ and $\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}_{\text{true}} + 0.5\,\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}$ with Gaussian noise. Solve $\min_{\boldsymbol{\theta}\geq \mathbf{0}} \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2$ with projected gradient descent, compare with `scipy.optimize.nnls` and with ordinary least squares, and check the KKT conditions numerically.

Part II

Supervised Machine Learning

This part introduces the supervised learning problem and the main algorithms used to solve it. Section 5 describes the data and the different learning tasks; Section 6 presents the framework of statistical learning theory, which explains what it means for a model to *generalize*, through empirical risk minimization and generalization bounds; Section 7 details the learning procedure in practice: how to train a model, tune its hyper-parameters and evaluate it with performance measures adapted to the task. Section 8 then presents the classical supervised algorithms: the k-nearest neighbors, support vector machines, linear and logistic regression, kernel regression and decision trees. Section 9 is devoted to neural networks. For each algorithm we describe the model, the optimization problem it solves, and its strengths and weaknesses in practice.

5 Introduction

In this first section, we present some generalities on what machine learning is, on the importance of data, and on the various problems related to finding a good representation of these data.

About this section

Guiding question. *What does it mean for a machine to "learn", and what do we need to make it learn?*

In this section you will learn to:

- *state Mitchell's definition of learning (task T, performance P, experience E) and recognize these three ingredients in a concrete application;*
- *explain why every type of data (images, tables, texts) must eventually be turned into a vector of features;*
- *describe the main steps of a learning pipeline, from raw data to predictions;*
- *distinguish supervised, unsupervised and reinforcement learning, and, within supervised learning, regression from classification.*

5.1 Generalities

Machine Learning is a subfield of *Artificial Intelligence* at the frontier of computer science and *Applied Mathematics* (statistics and optimization). This discipline also partially overlaps with Data Science, as it relies on collecting data that are analyzed and studied in order to extract the relevant information for the application at hand.

The main question we would like to answer is:

Can machines think?

In other words, are machines able to perform tasks that are usually done by humans (A. Turing), such as:

- driving a car,
- creating a masterpiece,
- recognizing people,
- detecting anomalies in medical images,
- etc.

Tom Mitchell Mitchell (1997) has provided a more formal definition of *Machine Learning*[2]:

> A computer program is said to learn from experience E with respect to some class of tasks T and performance measure P, if its performance at tasks in T, as measured by P, improves with experience E.

[2]The book is available here: https://www.cs.cmu.edu/ tom/mlbook.html. Its first chapters may be of interest to the reader.

The experience E can be thought of as a collection of data, but also as the training process used to train your *algorithm*. Generally speaking, the more (good) data we have and the better we train our model, the better the results will be; we will see, however, that training "too much" on the same data can also be harmful. In any case, everything depends on the performance measure P that is used, and we will come back to this point later. The task T can be, for instance, a classification or a regression task, as studied in the linear models course.

In a nutshell

Let us identify the three ingredients on a spam filter. The task T is to decide whether an incoming email is a spam or not; the performance P is, for instance, the proportion of emails that are correctly sorted; the experience E is a collection of emails that the users have already flagged as spam or as legitimate. The program *learns* if its proportion of correctly sorted emails increases as more flagged emails become available. Note that nobody writes the rules ("if the email contains the word *lottery*, then…") by hand: the rules are *inferred from the data*.

Historical note The question "Can machines think?" is the opening sentence of the famous paper of Alan Turing Turing (1950), in which he proposes the *imitation game* (now called the Turing test) and already suggests that, rather than programming an adult mind, one could build a "child machine" and *educate* it. The expression *machine learning* itself was popularized a few years later by Arthur Samuel Samuel (1959), whose checkers-playing program improved by playing against itself, a very early instance of learning from experience.

To sum up, to solve a given task, and *to help our machine think or solve a problem*, we need a collection of observations, *i.e.* a collection of data.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q5.1. Identify the task T, the performance measure P and the experience E of a program that plays chess.

Q5.2. True or false? "A program whose rules were all written by hand by experts learns, in the sense of Mitchell, as soon as it performs well."

Q5.3. Does more experience E always improve the performance P?

Q5.4. Why does the definition of learning depend on the choice of the performance measure P?

5.2 Data and Machine Learning problems

Another definition of Machine Learning can be stated as follows:

> Machine Learning is a field of Computer Science, and a subfield of Artificial Intelligence, which aims to design and study algorithms that are able to learn from data and to make predictions.

Depending on the application, the data can be of many different natures: images, videos, raw data, categorical data, trees, graphs, time series, etc.

A concrete example is illustrated in Figure 31 with two images. The aim of the algorithm is to distinguish dogs from cats in a collection of images. In this case, the algorithm is trained to solve a classification problem where the output can take two values: *dog* or *cat*.



Figure 31: An example of data that can be used for classification tasks. These two images are extracted from the *Dogs vs Cats* dataset, available on Kaggle.

We also often deal with data that can be represented in a table. This is the case in the following regression task, where we aim to predict the score obtained in a language test (y) from the scores obtained in four other tests, x_1, x_2, x_3 and x_4 (see Table 1).

y	x_1	x_2	x_3	x_4
125	13	18	25	11
158	39	18	59	30
207	52	50	62	53
182	29	43	50	29
196	50	37	65	56

Table 1: Data describing the score obtained in a language test according to the scores obtained in four other tests.

Although these data may look very different in their usual representation, a machine necessarily sees them in the same form. This form is most often the one of the second example, *i.e.* an array of values, in other words a matrix.

This data representation is one of the important pillars of machine learning. Although it may seem simple at first, obtaining a good representation of the data is far from trivial. It is even an important research topic, very often guided by the problem we are trying to solve. Representation learning is particularly important in *Natural Language Processing* (NLP), where one needs to learn a good representation of words or sentences in the form of *vectors*.

Let us go back to our images to see this more precisely. Remember that an image can be seen as a collection of *pixels* (or *voxels* if you are working in a three-dimensional space), each of which is associated with a number. Generally, in a black and white (grayscale) image, the pixel value lies between 0 and 255 (or between 0 and 1 if the

data are *scaled*). A color image, such as the ones presented in Figure 31, is represented by three different matrices[3], where each entry represents the pixel intensity associated with a color channel (R: red, G: green and B: blue):

$$R = \begin{pmatrix} 0.1 & 1 & 0.23 \\ 0.12 & 0.23 & 0.95 \\ 0 & 0.45 & 0.22 \end{pmatrix}, \quad G = \begin{pmatrix} 0.34 & 1 & 0.19 \\ 0.67 & 0.53 & 0.95 \\ 1 & 0.95 & 0.23 \end{pmatrix}, \quad B = \begin{pmatrix} 0.56 & 0.83 & 0.23 \\ 0.74 & 0.81 & 0.34 \\ 0.45 & 0.45 & 0.29 \end{pmatrix}.$$

However, these raw features have some flaws:

- the intensity of the pixels depends on the brightness, but also on the conditions under which the image was captured;
- the shape of the object in the image depends on the viewing angle, and the object may be harder to distinguish from its background;
- finally, the apparent size of the object depends on its distance from the camera.

For all these reasons, it is important to define (or find) descriptors that are independent of such environmental factors; this is the objective of a *Representation Learning* course. These methods are generally based on neural network algorithms, which we will present later in this document.

As we can see, data are at the core of Machine Learning algorithms (they can be compared to the experience E mentioned by Tom Mitchell). We have also seen that they can take different forms: they can be raw, or transformed to make them usable by an algorithm (*e.g.* the translation of a text or a word into a vector of numbers). Finally, the descriptors of these data can also be learned in order to obtain a representation of the data suited to the task at hand.

A question one might then ask when observing a series of numbers is:
Do the observed values of the different descriptors follow a **well-known distribution**?

The observed values do follow some distribution. However, and this is the main problem we have to deal with in Machine Learning, this distribution **is always unknown**. We will see that this fact has consequences on the learning process of an algorithm and on its performance.

Let us first focus on the use of the data and go back to the image classification task with *cats* and *dogs*. Suppose that we have a collection of such images, as illustrated in Figure 32 (keep in mind that each image is actually a point in a d-dimensional space, where d is the length of the vector representing it, *i.e.* the number of descriptors of the image), and that we want to classify these images, *i.e.* to learn an algorithm, or a model, which is able to predict the class of an image and thus to separate the two types of images.

To build such an algorithm, we need to define three things:

- **Input:** the data that will be used for the task, *e.g.* our images of cats and dogs (in vector form);

[3] In practice, images are not left in matrix form: we use models, such as convolutional neural networks, to learn a vector representation of these images; such vectors are then easier to manipulate by subsequent algorithms.



Figure 32: A collection of images that can be used for a classification task. These images are extracted from the *Dogs vs Cats* dataset, available on Kaggle.

- **Output:** the answer to the task under study, *e.g.* the label of the image;
- **Model:** a collection of objects that are used to solve the problem (objective function, type of hypothesis and optimization process).

These ingredients fit together in the *pipeline* summarized in Figure 33, which will serve as a map for the rest of this document: Section 6 formalizes the training phase, Section 7 explains how to evaluate the resulting model, and the following sections present several learning algorithms.

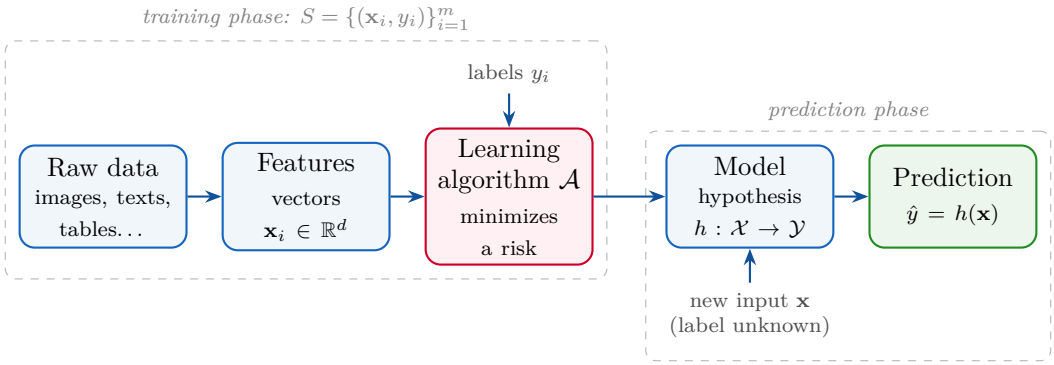


Figure 33: The supervised learning pipeline. Raw data are first turned into feature vectors; a learning algorithm then uses these vectors together with their labels to select a model h, which is finally applied to new inputs whose label is unknown. Choosing the representation (first arrow) is often as important as choosing the algorithm.

In this case, we could learn several types of separators, or classifiers, for the images, such as straight lines or more complex curves in the feature space. The classifier we learn will try to minimize the classification error on the observed data, *i.e.* we will try to minimize the number of images of dogs classified as cats and vice versa. This will

be done based on the descriptors of the images as well as on their labels. Through a learning process that we will detail later, the algorithm will then iteratively learn from its errors in order to improve and reach an optimal solution. Once this model is learned, it is applied to new data (*e.g.* new images) that it has to classify without knowing their labels.

Pitfall Learning makes sense only if the new data "look like" the training data, *i.e.* if they are generated by the same (unknown) distribution. A cat-versus-dog classifier trained on daylight pictures may fail on night pictures, and a fraud detector trained on last year's transactions may become obsolete when fraudsters change their habits. This *distribution shift* is one of the main causes of failure of machine learning systems in practice; the theory presented in the next section relies on the assumption that training and test examples are drawn independently from the same distribution.

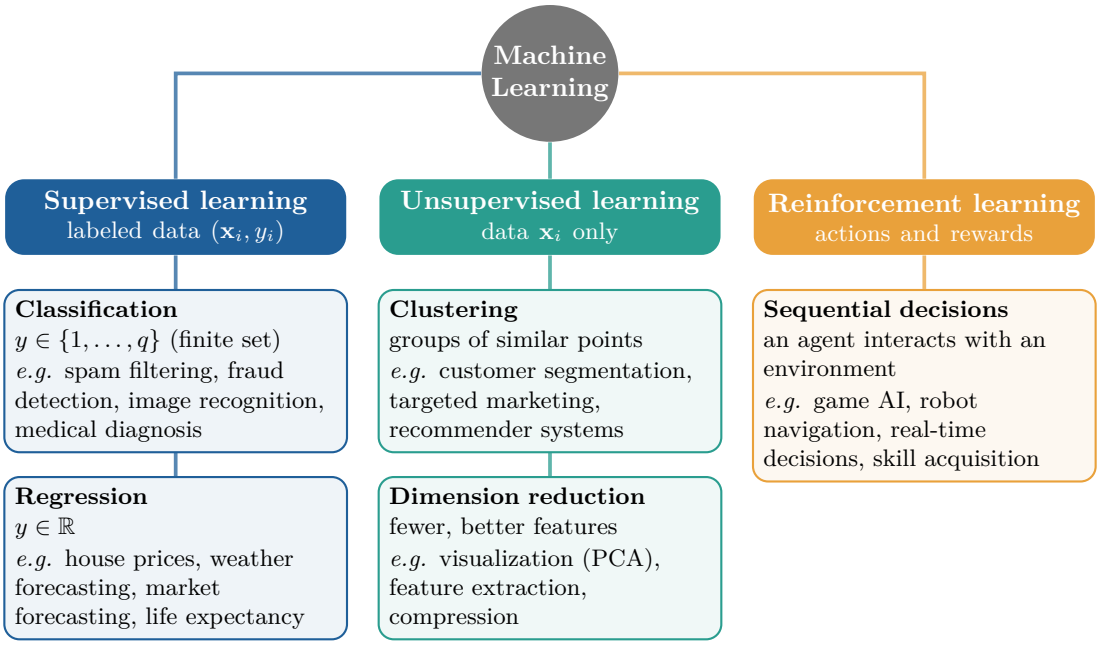


Figure 34: The three main branches of Machine Learning, the main tasks within each of them and some typical applications. Supervised learning, on the left, is the subject of this course. (Adapted from a diagram found here.)

As we have seen, once the data are collected (and often completed and cleaned), they can be used for several machine learning tasks, such as regression, *e.g.* to predict the price of a share, or the price of a house according to its characteristics. They can also be exploited for classification tasks, *e.g.* to discriminate spam from ham (legitimate email) when receiving an email, to identify whether a transaction is fraudulent or genuine, or to detect anomalies in a medical examination such as a blood test. In both cases, the data are labeled by a variable y: it is a real number in regression and a category in classification, as illustrated in Figure 35.

When we have a genuine transaction or a ham email, the example is usually labeled -1 (it is called a negative example), while it is labeled 1 (positive example) when it is an object of interest, such as a spam or a fraudulent transaction. When such label information is used by a Machine Learning algorithm, we talk about *Supervised*

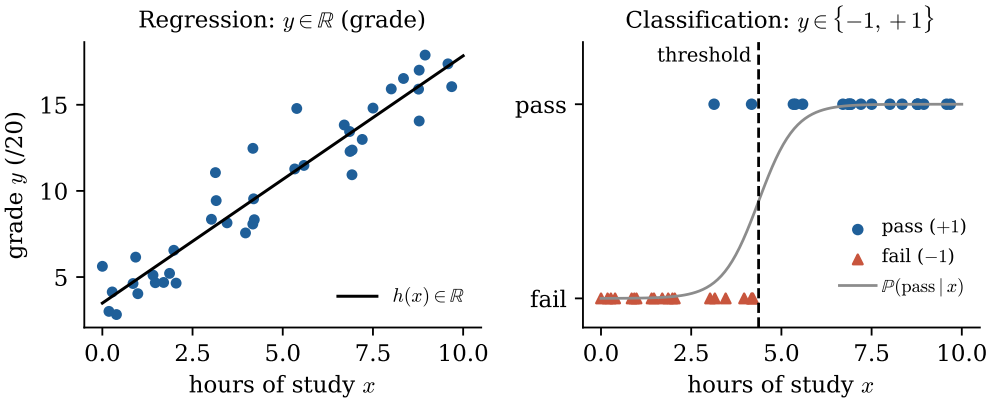


Figure 35: The same input (number of hours of study of a student) used for two different tasks. Left: *regression*, the output y is the grade, a real number, and the model h returns a real number. Right: *classification*, the output is pass/fail; a model (here a logistic regression) estimates the probability of passing, and thresholding it gives a classifier.

Learning; otherwise, we talk about *Unsupervised Learning*[4]. The difference is illustrated in Figure 36: the data points are the same, but the questions we can ask about them are not.

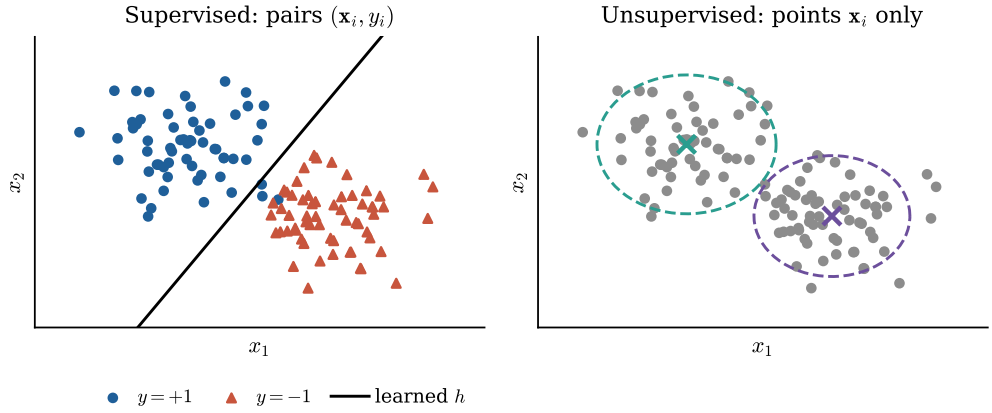


Figure 36: Supervised *versus* unsupervised learning on the same points. Left: each point comes with a label, and we learn a classifier h (here a straight line) that predicts the label of new points. Right: no label is available; an unsupervised method (here k-means with $k = 2$) looks for a structure in the data, *e.g.* groups of similar points, without any notion of "correct answer".

There also exists another branch of Machine Learning called *Reinforcement Learning*[5]. For the sake of completeness, we give a brief description of each branch below; more information can be found in Figure 34.

Supervised Learning This branch includes all classification and regression tasks. It covers applications such as fraud detection, recommendation systems, time series analysis, the study of medical images, EEG and ECG signals, the prediction of the

[4]This branch will be studied in a dedicated course.
[5]We do not study Reinforcement Learning here.

number of people infected by a given disease or virus, or of the stock market value of a given company, etc. The important point here is the access to labeled data.

Some research fields, such as transfer learning (how to exploit the knowledge learned in one domain in order to apply it to a related domain), can also be classified in this branch. Many algorithms belong to this field. Readers who have taken a course on linear models will certainly remember the Gaussian linear model (regression) or logistic regression (classification). Other models are of course commonly used, and we will present them in the next sections.

Unsupervised Learning Unlike in supervised learning, the data used here have no label. The analysis is then based only on the distribution of the data. Applications include anomaly detection, clustering (*e.g.* population segmentation for marketing strategies), and recommendation systems based on customer typology. Another aspect is dimension reduction, via statistical methods such as Principal Component Analysis, and feature construction.

We can also include approaches such as unsupervised domain adaptation, which is the unsupervised counterpart of a subcategory of transfer learning.

Reinforcement Learning This last category differs from the first two in that there is no fixed dataset per se. Here, the system evolves in an environment and must be able to take the right actions according to this environment and to its own state, through a reward/punishment system.

A simple example is the automatic piloting of a drone whose goal is to avoid obstacles in order to reach its destination. The environment can then be considered as the set of objects that are close to the drone. The state of the drone can be its structural state as well as its position relative to the elements around it, and the actions correspond to the movements of the drone (left, right, up, down). When the drone hits or gets too close to an obstacle, we decrease the value of a quantity that reflects the reward obtained by the system.

In this course, we will focus on the first branch, *i.e.* on Supervised Learning. Our objective will be to learn a classifier h, also called a hypothesis, from a collection of labeled data $\{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$, in order to classify new instances, where each $\mathbf{x}_i$ is a vector of descriptors. The next section focuses on the theoretical aspects of Supervised Learning.

> **Remark** In this document, the words *hypothesis*, *model*, *predictor* and *classifier* (or *regressor*) are used almost interchangeably to denote the function h returned by the learning algorithm. Similarly, *features*, *descriptors*, *variables* and *attributes* all denote the coordinates of $\mathbf{x}$, and *examples*, *instances*, *observations* or *data points* denote the pairs $(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)$.

Requirements In order to understand the different notions presented in this document, and in Machine Learning in general, the reader is invited to review the fundamental concepts in *Probability/Statistics*, *Linear Models*, *Linear Algebra* (operations on matrices: determinant, transpose, multiplication, eigenvalues, eigenvectors) and finally *Analysis* (differentiation, integration, study of functions of several variables with real or vector values, sequences of functions and sequences of real vectors). Part I recalls

the main tools of linear algebra and optimization that will be needed. For a gentle and non-technical overview of the practical lessons of machine learning, the reader may also enjoy Domingos (2012).

To remember from Section 5

- A program *learns* when its performance P on a task T improves with experience E, which in practice is a collection of data.
- Whatever their original nature (images, texts, tables), data are represented as vectors of features $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and gathered in a matrix; finding a good representation is a problem in itself.
- The distribution of the data is always **unknown**: we only observe a finite sample, and new data are assumed to come from the same distribution.
- Supervised learning uses labeled data $\{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ to learn a hypothesis h; it is called regression when y is real-valued and classification when y takes finitely many values.
- Unsupervised learning works without labels (clustering, dimension reduction), and reinforcement learning learns actions from rewards.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q5.5. For a system that recommends movies, give a possible task T, performance measure P and experience E.

Q5.6. Is predicting tomorrow's temperature a regression or a classification task? And predicting whether it will rain tomorrow?

Q5.7. A 64×64 color image is turned into a vector by stacking its pixel values. What is the dimension d of this vector?

Q5.8. You are given the customer database of a company, without any additional information, and you are asked to find groups of similar customers. Which branch of machine learning is this?

Q5.9. Why can we not simply compute the error of a model on the true distribution of the data?

Q5.10. True or false? "Since the labels y_i are observed, the distribution of the data is known in supervised learning."

Q5.11. In the pipeline of Figure 33, at which stage are the labels y_i used? Are labels needed to make a prediction for a new input?

Q5.12. Give two reasons why the raw pixel values of a photograph are poor features to recognize a cat.

Q5.13. A spam filter labels spam emails $+1$ and legitimate emails -1. Does "positive" mean "good"?

Q5.14. True or false? "Principal Component Analysis is a supervised method, since it produces new variables."

Q5.15. A fraud detector was trained on last year's transactions and its error rate has doubled this year, although the code has not changed. What is the most likely explanation?

Q5.16. What is the main difference between the data used in reinforcement learning and in supervised learning?

Exercises

Exercise 5.1. **(Comprehension)** For each of the following problems, say whether it is a supervised (regression or classification), unsupervised or reinforcement learning problem, and describe the input $\mathbf{x}$ and, if relevant, the output y: (a) estimating the price of a flat from its surface, location and number of rooms; (b) detecting fraudulent credit card transactions from a history of transactions checked by experts; (c) grouping news articles by topic; (d) teaching a robot to walk; (e) predicting the number of visitors of a museum tomorrow; (f) finding the handwritten digit (0 to 9) written on an envelope.

Exercise 5.2. **(Comprehension)** In Table 1, what are m, d, the matrix $\mathbf{X}$ and the vector $\mathbf{y}$? Is the task a regression or a classification task? Which row of $\mathbf{X}$ corresponds to the third student?

Exercise 5.3. **(Comprehension)** Identify the task T, the performance measure P and the experience E in the following situations, and say whether the program learns in the sense of Mitchell: (a) a program that recognizes handwritten digits, trained on a database of labeled images; (b) a thermostat that switches the heating on when the temperature drops below 19°C; (c) a navigation application that predicts the travel time of a trip from the trips recorded by its users.

Exercise 5.4. **(Computation)** (a) The images of the MNIST dataset are grayscale images of 28×28 pixels. What is the dimension d of the corresponding vectors? (b) The images of Figure 32 are resized to 224×224 color pixels, the usual input size of many convolutional networks. What is d? (c) The training set of the *Dogs vs Cats* competition contains 25 000 images. How much memory is needed to store the matrix $\mathbf{X}$ with one float of 4 bytes per entry? (d) Comment on these orders of magnitude.

Exercise 5.5. **(Computation)** A bank describes its customers by their age (in years), their city (Lyon, Paris or Marseille) and whether they own their home (yes or no). (a) Why can we not simply encode the cities by 1, 2 and 3? (b) Using a *one-hot encoding* of each categorical variable (one binary indicator per category), give the dimension d of the feature vectors and the vector of a 35-year-old customer living in Paris who does not own their home (order: age, Lyon, Paris, Marseille, owner, non-owner). (c) Show that some of these features are redundant, and give the dimension after removing the redundancy.

Exercise 5.6. **(Computation)** We represent texts by the number of occurrences of each word of the vocabulary $\{$*cat*, *dog*, *eats*, *fish*, *the*$\}$ (*bag of words*). Consider the three sentences t_1 = "the cat eats the fish", t_2 = "the dog eats the cat" and t_3 = "the dog eats". (a) Give the vectors $\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \mathbf{x}_3 \in \mathbb{R}^5$. (b) Compute the Euclidean distances $\|\mathbf{x}_1 - \mathbf{x}_2\|_2$, $\|\mathbf{x}_1 - \mathbf{x}_3\|_2$ and $\|\mathbf{x}_2 - \mathbf{x}_3\|_2$. Which two sentences are the closest? (c) Give two sentences with very different meanings that have the same representation. What does this say about this representation?

Exercise 5.7. **(Computation)** Among 1 000 emails, 200 are spam. A first filter declares every email legitimate. A second filter detects 180 of the spams but also sends 30 legitimate emails to the spam folder. (a) Compute the proportion of correctly sorted emails (accuracy) of both filters. (b) What proportion of spams does each filter detect? (c) What do you conclude on the choice of the performance measure P?

Exercise 5.8. **(Application)** In the regression panel of Figure 35, assume that the learned model is $h(x) = 4 + 1.3\,x$, where x is the number of hours of study and $h(x)$ the predicted grade out of 20. (a) Predict the grades of two students who studied 3 and 5 hours. (b) We derive a classifier by predicting "pass" when $h(x) \geq 10$. Write this classifier as $g(x) = \text{sign}(x - t)$ and give t. (c) Give one advantage and one drawback of learning the classifier through the regression model rather than directly from the pass/fail labels.

Exercise 5.9. **(Comprehension)** A cat-versus-dog classifier is trained on 25 000 pictures taken by the owners of the animals and is then deployed in an application for wildlife cameras that take night pictures in infrared. (a) Which assumption of the learning framework is violated? (b)

Give two other real situations where this assumption fails. (c) Propose a simple way to detect the problem before deploying the classifier.

Exercise 5.10. **(Comprehension)** Consider the drone example of the paragraph on reinforcement learning. (a) Describe the state, the actions and the reward. (b) Why would it be difficult to solve this problem by supervised learning?

Exercise 5.11. **(Application, exam style)** A hospital wants to predict, at the admission of a patient, whether he or she will be readmitted within 30 days after leaving the hospital. It has the records of 50 000 past stays: age, sex, department, length of stay, 20 blood test results, number of previous stays, and whether a readmission occurred. About 8% of the stays were followed by a readmission. (a) Identify T, E, the input $\mathbf{x}$, the output y and the type of task. (b) The variable "department" takes 12 values. Using a one-hot encoding (without removing redundancy), give the dimension d and the size of $\mathbf{X}$. (c) A model reaches an accuracy of 92%. Is it a good model? Propose a better performance measure P. (d) The model will be used in another hospital of the region. What could go wrong? (e) A colleague suggests clustering the patients first. Is it a supervised or an unsupervised method? What could it bring to the project?

Exercise 5.12. **(Python)** Using `scikit-learn`, load the datasets `load_iris` and `load_digits` of `sklearn.datasets`. For each of them, print m, d and the number of classes. The digits dataset also contains the original images in the attribute `images`: check that the matrix $\mathbf{X}$ is obtained by flattening these images.

Exercise 5.13. **(Python)** Generate 200 points in two groups with `make_blobs(n_samples=200, centers=2, cluster_std=1.5, random_state=0)`. (a) Fit a logistic regression using the labels and print its accuracy on the training points. (b) Fit k-means with $k = 2$ *without* the labels and compute the proportion of points whose cluster coincides with their label (the numbering of the clusters being arbitrary). (c) Comment, in relation with Figure 36.

6 Statistical Learning Theory

In this section, we first introduce the notion of *risk*, the quantity we aim to minimize in most of the optimization problems arising in supervised learning. We will then see that it is possible to provide theoretical guarantees on the performance of the learned model using statistical tools such as concentration inequalities.

About this section

Guiding question. *A model makes few errors on the data it was trained on: what can we say about its errors on data it has never seen?*

In this section you will learn to:

- *define the true risk and the empirical risk of a hypothesis, and explain why only the latter can be computed;*
- *describe empirical, structural and regularized risk minimization, and relate them to under- and over-fitting;*
- *decompose the error of a learned model into an approximation error and an estimation error;*
- *read a generalization bound: confidence $1-\delta$, accuracy ε, sample size m and complexity of $\mathcal{H}$ (cardinality, VC-dimension) or stability of the algorithm.*

Let us denote by $\mathcal{X}$ the input space of our data, also called the feature space, and by $\mathcal{Y}$ the output space[6]. The input space, *i.e.* the features used to describe the data, can be of different types: it can consist of continuous or discrete descriptors. In this document, we will focus on continuous features, *i.e.* $\mathcal{X} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$.

The output space can also vary from one task to another: it can be discrete, real-valued, or even consist of structured data. The nature of the output gives important information on the nature of the problem and leads the user to choose the appropriate tools.

- When $\mathcal{Y} \subset \mathbb{R}$ or $\mathcal{Y} = [0,1]$, *i.e.* when the output is a real value, the aim is to learn a score or a probability, or to estimate a quantity, as is usually done in *regression tasks*.
- When $\mathcal{Y} = \{-1,+1\}$ or $\{0,1\}$, *i.e.* when the output is binary, we aim to classify the data into two categories, also called *classes*. This type of task is called *binary classification*. Note that the output can take more than two values, *i.e.* $\mathcal{Y} = \{1,\dots,q\}$, where q is the number of classes. In this case, we talk about *multi-class classification*.

To solve these different tasks, we use an algorithm $\mathcal{A}$ which aims at learning a function $h : \mathcal{X} \to \mathcal{Y}$, called a *hypothesis*. From a practical point of view, the joint distribution $\mathcal{D}$ of the data over $\mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{Y}$ is unknown, and we only have access to a collection of *sample points*, *i.e.* a set of observations $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ drawn i.i.d. from $\mathcal{D}$. The goal is then to learn, from the sample S, a function h which is "good enough" on this training sample but which is also able to perform well on a new example $(\mathbf{x}, y)$.

The observed data are usually gathered in a matrix $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times d}$ as follows:

[6] Note that there may be no output space, *i.e.* $\mathcal{Y} = \emptyset$, as in *unsupervised learning*.

$$\mathbf{X} = \begin{array}{c} \\ \mathbf{x}_1 \\ \vdots \\ \mathbf{x}_i \\ \vdots \\ \mathbf{x}_m \end{array} \begin{array}{c} \begin{array}{cccccc} \mathbf{v}_1 & \cdots & \mathbf{v}_k & \cdots & \mathbf{v}_d \end{array} \\ \begin{pmatrix} x_{11} & \cdots & x_{1k} & \cdots & x_{1d} \\ \vdots & & \vdots & & \vdots \\ x_{i1} & \cdots & x_{ik} & \cdots & x_{id} \\ \vdots & & \vdots & & \vdots \\ x_{m1} & \cdots & x_{mk} & \cdots & x_{md} \end{pmatrix} \end{array},$$

where each row represents an observation (m observations) and each column represents a variable, or descriptor (d columns).

In the next subsections, we explain how the function h is learned and what we mean by the performance of an algorithm.

6.1 Empirical Risk Minimization

In order to solve a given task, the algorithm $\mathcal{A}$ needs a criterion to optimize, called a *loss function* and usually denoted by $\ell(h(\cdot), \cdot) : \mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{Y} \to \mathbb{R}_+$. In a regression task, it can be based on the difference between the estimated value $h(\mathbf{x})$ and the true value y, for example $\ell(h(\mathbf{x}), y) = |h(\mathbf{x}) - y|$ or $\ell(h(\mathbf{x}), y) = (h(\mathbf{x}) - y)^2$. In a classification task, the most natural way is to count the number of errors made by the classifier h. The corresponding loss function is then defined by $\ell(h(\mathbf{x}), y) = \mathbb{1}_{\{h(\mathbf{x}) \neq y\}}$ and is called the *0-1 loss*. However, this loss is neither convex nor differentiable (it is piecewise constant), and minimizing the empirical error it induces is known to be NP-hard in general, even over simple classes such as linear classifiers. That is why we usually replace the *0-1* loss by a convex *surrogate* function, such as the hinge loss $\max(0, 1 - yh(\mathbf{x}))$ or the logistic loss $\ln(1 + e^{-yh(\mathbf{x})})$ when $\mathcal{Y} = \{-1, +1\}$ and h returns a real-valued score.

Whatever the hypothesis h, what we would really like to minimize is the expected value of its loss over the distribution $\mathcal{D}$, which leads to the *True Risk*.

Definition 6.1: True Risk

Let $\ell : \mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{Y} \to \mathbb{R}_+$ be a loss function and $\mathcal{D}$ the distribution of the data. The *True Risk* $\mathcal{R}^\ell$ of a hypothesis h is defined by:

$$\mathcal{R}^\ell(h) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}} [\ell(h(\mathbf{x}), y)].$$

However, we cannot compute this quantity in practice because the joint distribution $\mathcal{D}$ of the data is unknown. Instead, we minimize the *Empirical Risk*, *i.e.* the average error over the sample S.

Definition 6.2: Empirical Risk

Let $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ be a collection of m examples drawn i.i.d. from $\mathcal{D}$ and $\ell : \mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{Y} \to \mathbb{R}_+$ a loss function. The *Empirical Risk* of a hypothesis h is defined by:

$$\mathcal{R}_S^\ell(h) = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m} \ell(h(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i).$$

In other words, the empirical risk is the mean value of the loss over all the observed data.

Note that, for a *fixed* hypothesis h, $\mathcal{R}_S^\ell(h)$ is an unbiased estimator of $\mathcal{R}^\ell(h)$, since $\mathbb{E}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}[\mathcal{R}_S^\ell(h)] = \mathcal{R}^\ell(h)$ by linearity of the expectation (see Section 1, where risks are introduced as expectations). We therefore minimize the empirical risk in the hope that the sample S is representative of the unknown distribution.

In a nutshell

The true risk is the average error of h over *all* the examples the distribution $\mathcal{D}$ could generate, weighted by their probability; the empirical risk is the average error over the m examples we happened to observe. It is the same relation as between the mean of a population and the mean of a sample in a survey: the latter is a noisy, but computable, estimate of the former.

At first glance, minimizing the empirical risk might then seem equivalent to minimizing the true (or generalization) risk. This is not the case in general: the learned hypothesis depends on S, and we run the risk of *over-fitting* the data, as illustrated in Figure 37.

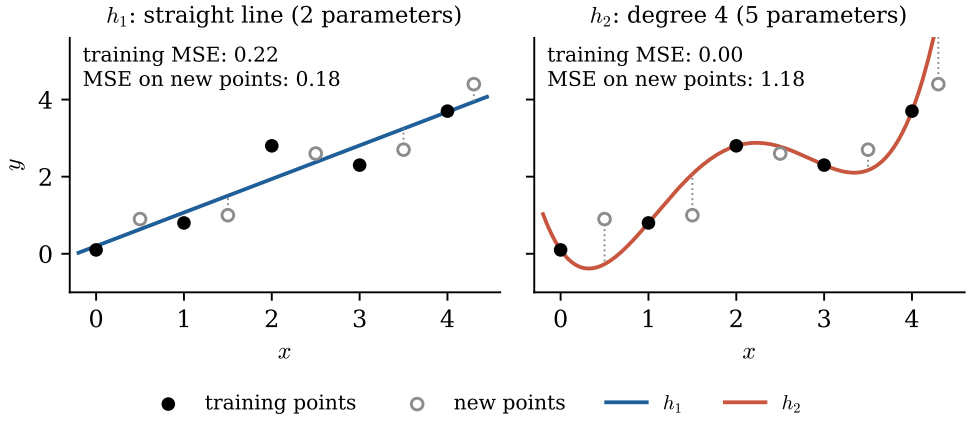


Figure 37: Illustration of the over-fitting phenomenon on a regression task with five training points (black). On the left, the learned hypothesis h_1 (a straight line) does not fit the training data exactly but generalizes well to new points drawn from the same distribution (white); on the right, the hypothesis h_2, the polynomial of degree 4 interpolating the five points, has a zero training error but a much larger error on the new points (dotted segments).

In this figure, we can see that the model learned on the right is more complex (it is a curve of degree 4) than the one on the left, which is a straight line. This remark shows that it is important to impose some constraints on the hypotheses we can learn in order to avoid such a situation.

Pitfall A small training error is **not** a proof that a model is good: the interpolating polynomial h_2 of Figure 37 has a training error equal to zero. The performance of a model must always be assessed on data that were not used to learn it (see Section 7), or certified by a generalization bound such as the ones presented in Section 6.2.

We present below a non-exhaustive list of ways to constrain the learned hypothesis.

Empirical risk minimization. The most straightforward solution is to fix in advance the hypothesis space $\mathcal{H}$, called a *set of hypotheses* or *function class*. Then, given this set of hypotheses $\mathcal{H}$, a sample S and a loss function ℓ, we look for the hypothesis $h_S^\star$ defined as a solution of:

$$h_S^\star = \operatorname*{argmin}_{h \in \mathcal{H}} \mathcal{R}_S^\ell(h).$$

If the set $\mathcal{H}$ is small enough, we can avoid the situation previously described. However, without any side information on the data, it is hard to choose the appropriate set of hypotheses for the task at hand.

Remark (approximation and estimation errors) The choice of $\mathcal{H}$ is a trade-off, which can be made precise as follows. Let $\mathcal{R}^\star$ be the smallest risk achievable by *any* function (the *Bayes risk*), and let $h_\mathcal{H}$ be the best hypothesis of $\mathcal{H}$, *i.e.* the minimizer of the true risk over $\mathcal{H}$ (assumed to exist). Then the excess risk of $h_S^\star$ splits into two terms:

$$\mathcal{R}^\ell(h_S^\star) - \mathcal{R}^\star = \underbrace{\mathcal{R}^\ell(h_S^\star) - \mathcal{R}^\ell(h_\mathcal{H})}_{\text{estimation error}} + \underbrace{\mathcal{R}^\ell(h_\mathcal{H}) - \mathcal{R}^\star}_{\text{approximation error}}.$$

The approximation error only depends on $\mathcal{H}$ and decreases when $\mathcal{H}$ grows; the estimation error comes from the fact that we only see a finite sample, and it typically increases with the size of $\mathcal{H}$ and decreases with m (see Figure 38). This decomposition is studied in more detail in Section 10.

Structural risk minimization. [*See Section 4.1 of Vapnik (1995)*] The idea here is to consider a growing sequence of sets of hypotheses $\{\mathcal{H}_n\}_{n\in\mathbb{N}}$, *i.e.* $\mathcal{H}_1 \subset \mathcal{H}_2 \subset \cdots$, so that the complexity (or the number of hypotheses) grows with n, and to choose the hypothesis $h_S^\star$ solution of the following minimization problem:

$$h_S^\star = \operatorname*{argmin}_{h \in \mathcal{H}_n,\, n\in\mathbb{N}} \mathcal{R}_S^\ell(h) + pen(n, d).$$

Compared to the previous formulation, a *penalty term* is added to the empirical risk. This term measures the complexity (or size) of the set of hypotheses $\mathcal{H}_n$ and is an increasing function of n (note that it may also depend on the dimension d of the data). The aim is then to find a hypothesis with a low empirical risk in a set $\mathcal{H}_n$ that is as small as possible. With such a formulation, we are able to find a good trade-off between empirical risk minimization and the complexity of the learned model, *i.e.* to find a hypothesis that generalizes well. However, choosing a relevant sequence of sets of hypotheses remains hard in practice.

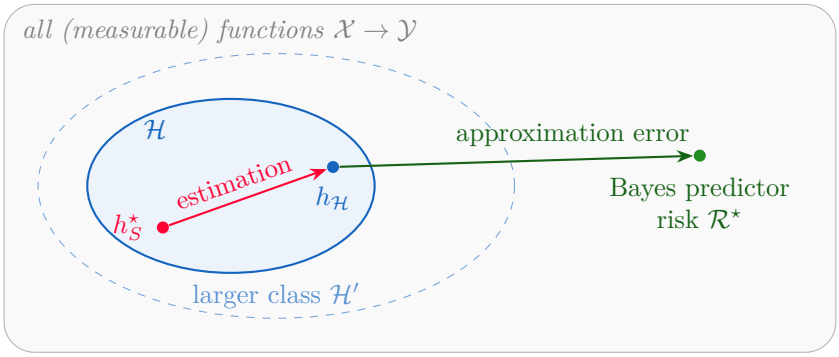


Figure 38: Decomposition of the excess risk of the hypothesis $h_S^\star$ learned on a sample S. The *approximation error* measures how far the best hypothesis $h_\mathcal{H}$ of the class is from the best possible predictor; the *estimation error* measures how far $h_S^\star$ is from $h_\mathcal{H}$ because of the finite sample. Enlarging the class (dashed ellipse) reduces the first error but makes the second one larger: this is the trade-off of Figure 39.

Regularized risk minimization. The preferred solution in practice, because it is easier to implement, is to choose a sufficiently large set of hypotheses $\mathcal{H}$ and to add a constraint on the parameters $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ of the learned model $h = h_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$. The added term, $\lambda \|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|$, is called a *regularization term*, and $\lambda \geq 0$ is the associated *regularization constant*:

$$h_S^\star = \operatorname*{argmin}_{h \in \mathcal{H}} \mathcal{R}_S^\ell(h) + \lambda \|\boldsymbol{\theta}\| .$$

Through the parameter λ, we are able to indirectly control the size, or complexity, of the set of hypotheses, for instance by constraining the norm of the parameters of the model[7].

Example 6.1. Such a formulation was met in the Linear Models course when the lasso regression was presented. In this problem, we aim to find the best linear model, described by a vector $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ (the intercept being included, hence the dimension $d+1$), which fits a set of data $(\mathbf{y}, \mathbf{X})$. We also require the chosen model to be as sparse as possible, *i.e.* to be based on as few features as possible. To do so, we solve the following minimization problem:

$$\min_{\boldsymbol{\theta} \in \mathbb{R}^{d+1}} \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2 + \lambda \|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_1,$$

where $\|\cdot\|_1$ is the lasso regularization term, which induces a sparse solution for a sufficiently large λ.

In this last expression (as in the previous example), the smaller the value of λ, the more importance we give to fitting the data well. Conversely, the greater λ, the more importance we give to the complexity of the learned model: the errors made by the algorithm become insignificant compared to the control of the magnitude of the parameters $\boldsymbol{\theta}$. The risk is then that, when $\lambda \to \infty$, we face an *under-fitting* phenomenon: the model is too simple to capture the structure of the data and generalizes poorly.

[7] In the rest of the document, such a regularization constant will be called a *hyper-parameter* instead of a parameter, to distinguish it from the parameters of the learned hypothesis h.

The aim is thus to learn a model with an appropriate value of λ, *i.e.* to find a good trade-off between the minimization of the empirical risk and the complexity of the hypothesis, as depicted in Figure 39. To *tune* the value of λ, we typically use a *k-fold cross-validation* on the training set: we split the dataset into k folds of (roughly) equal size. This process will be described later; in short, it consists in learning a hypothesis (model) on $k-1$ folds of the training data and testing its performance on the remaining one. The process is repeated k times, so that each fold is used once for testing, and we keep the value of λ that achieves the lowest average error on the held-out folds.

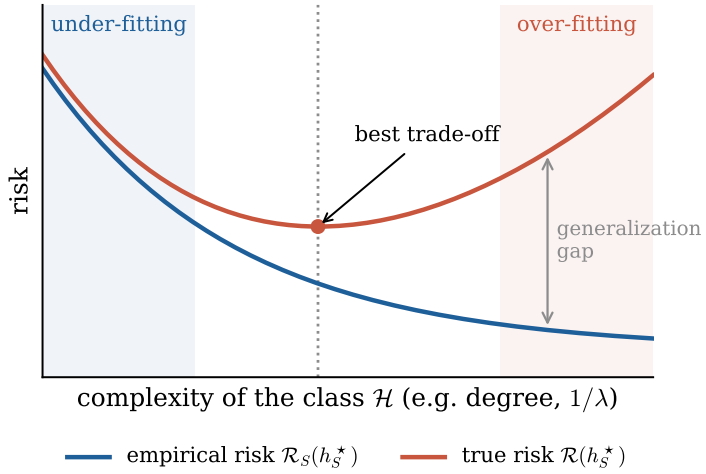


Figure 39: Evolution of the empirical and true risks of the learned hypothesis $h_S^\star$ according to the complexity of the set of hypotheses (schematic curves). The empirical risk always decreases with the complexity, whereas the true risk first decreases (less under-fitting) and then increases (over-fitting); the difference between the two curves is the generalization gap.

Figure 40 shows this trade-off on a real experiment, where the complexity of the model is the degree of a polynomial fitted by least squares: the training error always decreases with the degree, whereas the test error first decreases (the model becomes flexible enough to capture the shape of the target), then increases (the model starts fitting the noise).

Remark (beyond the U-shaped curve) The U-shaped test error of Figures 39 and 40 is the classical picture, which is also known as the *bias-variance trade-off* Geman et al. (1992); Hastie et al. (2009). Very large models, such as modern neural networks, can however behave differently: when the number of parameters greatly exceeds the number of examples, the test error may decrease again after the interpolation threshold, a phenomenon called *double descent* Belkin et al. (2019). Such models generalize well although they can fit random labels perfectly Zhang et al. (2017), which shows that the number of parameters alone is not always a good measure of complexity; the stability and PAC-Bayesian approaches of this document are two ways of going beyond it.

Even if we can empirically assess the performance of a model on a test set, it is also important to provide *generalization guarantees*, *i.e.* to bound the true risk of the learned model using quantities observed at training time.

The next subsection is dedicated to this point and presents generalization bounds

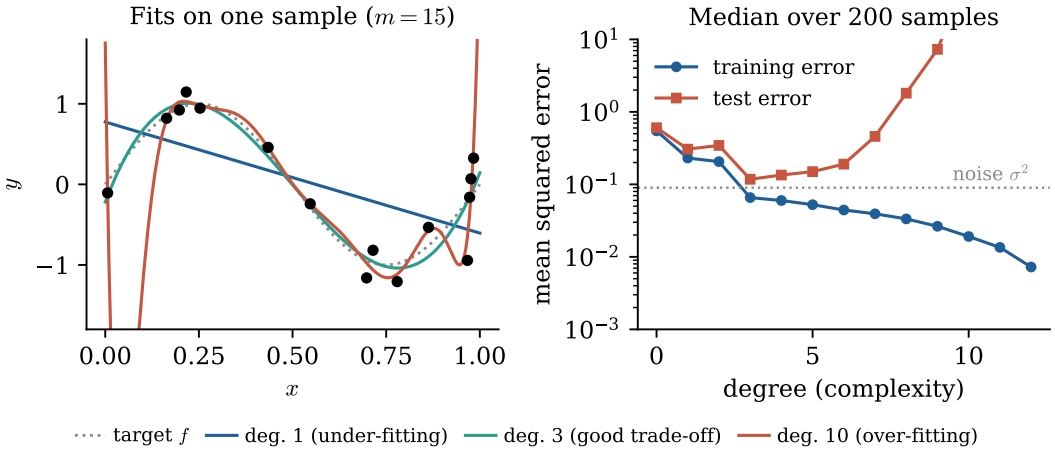


Figure 40: Under- and over-fitting with polynomial regression. The data are $y = \sin(2\pi x) + \epsilon$ with Gaussian noise of standard deviation 0.3 and $m = 15$ training points. Left: least-squares polynomials of degrees 1, 3 and 10 on one sample. Right: training and test mean squared errors as a function of the degree (log scale, median over 200 training samples). The test error is minimal for degrees around 3-5 and explodes when the number of parameters approaches m.

based either on the complexity of the set of hypotheses or on some properties of the learning algorithm.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q6.1. Why do we usually minimize a convex surrogate, such as the hinge loss, instead of the 0-1 loss?

Q6.2. A regressor predicts $h(\mathbf{x}_1) = 1$, $h(\mathbf{x}_2) = 2.5$ and $h(\mathbf{x}_3) = 0.5$ for the labels $y_1 = 1$, $y_2 = 2$ and $y_3 = 1$. Compute its empirical risk for the squared loss and for the absolute loss.

Q6.3. True or false? "Since $\mathcal{R}^\ell_S(h)$ is an unbiased estimator of $\mathcal{R}^\ell(h)$ for every h, the training error of $h^\star_S$ is an unbiased estimator of its true risk."

Q6.4. How do the approximation error and the estimation error evolve when the class $\mathcal{H}$ grows? When the sample size m grows?

Q6.5. In Figure 40, why does the test error explode when the degree approaches $m = 15$?

6.2 Generalization Bounds

A generalization bound controls the gap between the true risk and the empirical risk. It usually has the following general form, often referred to as a *Probably Approximately Correct* (PAC) bound Valiant (1984):

$$\mathbb{P}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left(\left|\mathcal{R}^\ell(h) - \mathcal{R}^\ell_S(h)\right| \geq \varepsilon\right) \leq \delta, \tag{6.1}$$

where $\varepsilon \geq 0$ and $\delta \in [0, 1]$. Here, δ is an upper bound on the probability that the true risk deviates by at least ε from its empirical estimate: the estimate is *approximately*

correct (up to ε) with *high probability* (at least $1-\delta$). An immediate consequence is that, for a fixed sample size, the smaller ε, the greater (*i.e.* the closer to 1) the value of δ: we cannot be both very precise and very confident with a limited amount of data. Of course, the closer to 0 both δ and ε are, the more reliable our estimate is. Such bounds are usually derived using concentration inequalities, such as the Hoeffding Hoeffding (1963) or McDiarmid McDiarmid (1989) inequalities. Bound (6.1) can equivalently be rewritten as a probabilistic *bound of convergence* of the empirical estimate towards its mean Vapnik and Chervonenkis (1982); Valiant (1984):

$$\left|\mathcal{R}^{\ell}(h) - \mathcal{R}^{\ell}_{S}(h)\right| \leq \varepsilon(\delta, m),$$

where $1-\delta$ is the confidence level of the bound and ε is a function of δ that decreases with the number m of training examples. Such a bound holds with probability at least $1-\delta$ over the draw of S, and the aim is to build a function $\varepsilon(\cdot)$ that converges to 0 as fast as possible.

In the following, we will see how such generalization bounds can be built, and that their convergence rate is often of order $\mathcal{O}(\sqrt{\ln(m)/m})$ or even $\mathcal{O}(1/\sqrt{m})$.

For a complete derivation of the presented bounds, the reader can refer to the references cited in the different parts and to the excellent book *Foundations of Machine Learning* Mohri et al. (2012, 2018); the book of Shalev-Shwartz and Ben-David Shalev-Shwartz and Ben-David (2014) is another very accessible introduction.

> **Historical note** The PAC framework was introduced by Leslie Valiant in 1984 Valiant (1984), in the setting of computational learning theory, where one also asks the learning algorithm to run in polynomial time. The uniform convergence results it relies on are older: they were established by Vladimir Vapnik and Alexey Chervonenkis in the late 1960s and published in English in 1971 Vapnik and Chervonenkis (1971); Vapnik later developed them into a complete *statistical learning theory* Vapnik (1995, 1998), which also led to Support Vector Machines.

Uniform Deviation

As stated before, generalization bounds are based on the convergence of empirical quantities to their means Vapnik and Chervonenkis (1971) and rely on the law of large numbers (Theorem 1.6 in Section 1). Intuitively, the larger our training set, the closer the empirical risk of a fixed hypothesis h will be to its expected value, *i.e.*:

$$\lim_{m\to\infty} \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m} \ell(h(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}[\ell(h(\mathbf{x}), y)] \quad \text{almost surely.}$$

The law of large numbers only tells us that the empirical risk converges; Hoeffding's inequality (Proposition 1.14 in Section 1), recalled below, tells us *how fast*, and holds for every finite m. Figure 41 illustrates it for a fixed classifier.

However, the hypothesis $h^{\star}_{S}$ returned by the algorithm is *not* fixed in advance: it is chosen using the very same sample S. To handle this dependence, we look for bounds that are *uniform*, *i.e.* that hold simultaneously for all hypotheses $h \in \mathcal{H}$, hence in particular for $h^{\star}_{S}$. Figure 42 shows why this is necessary: for each sample, the

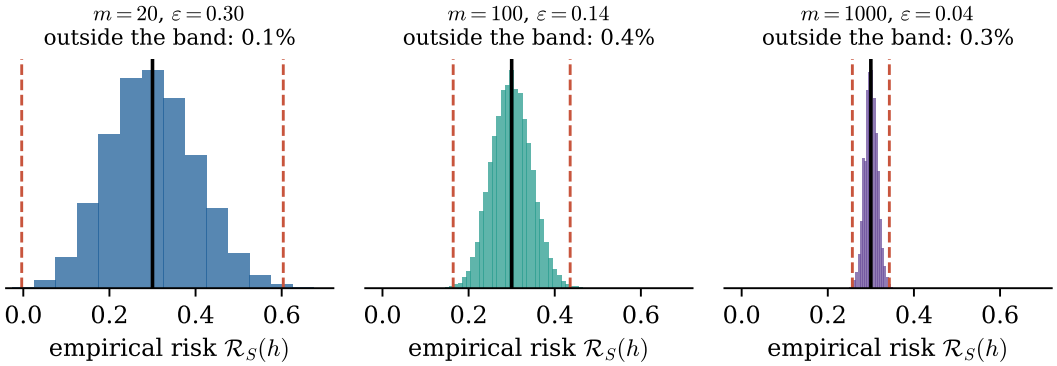


Figure 41: Concentration of the empirical risk of a *fixed* classifier h with true risk $\mathcal{R}^\ell(h) = 0.3$ (black line) and the 0-1 loss: histograms of $\mathcal{R}^\ell_S(h)$ over 20 000 samples S of size m. The dashed lines delimit the band $\mathcal{R}^\ell(h) \pm \varepsilon$ with $\varepsilon = \sqrt{\ln(2/\delta)/(2m)}$ and $\delta = 0.05$ given by Hoeffding's inequality: the empirical risk falls outside this band with frequency at most δ (in fact much less, Hoeffding's inequality being conservative), and the width of the band shrinks as $1/\sqrt{m}$.

minimizer of the empirical risk is typically a hypothesis whose empirical risk happens to be lower than its true risk, so its training error is an optimistic estimate.

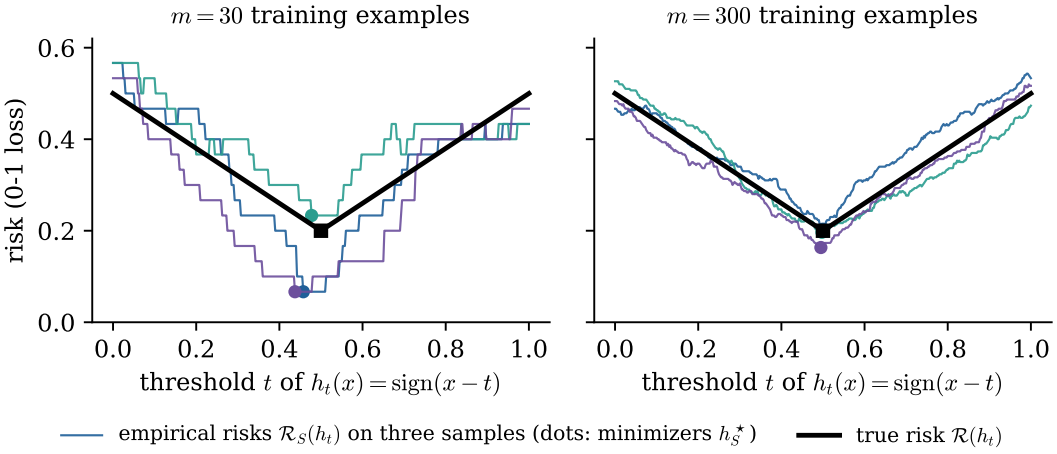


Figure 42: Empirical risk minimization over the threshold classifiers $h_t(x) = \text{sign}(x - t)$, for data with x uniform on $[0, 1]$ and $y = \text{sign}(x - 0.5)$ flipped with probability 0.2. Black: true risk (minimal at $t = 0.5$, square). Colored: empirical risks on three independent samples, with their minimizers $h_S^\star$ (dots). With $m = 30$, the empirical curves are far from the true one and their minimum underestimates the risk of $h_S^\star$; with $m = 300$, the whole curves are uniformly close to the true risk, so minimizing one amounts to almost minimizing the other.

To get such a bound, we need to estimate the probability of the following event:

$$\left\{ \sup_{h \in \mathcal{H}} \left| \mathcal{R}^\ell(h) - \mathcal{R}^\ell_S(h) \right| \geq \varepsilon \right\}.$$

When $\mathcal{H}$ is finite and the loss takes its values in $[0, 1]$, the probability of this event can be bounded using Hoeffding's inequality, which states that for a fixed h, $\mathbb{P}\left(\left| \mathcal{R}^\ell(h) - \mathcal{R}^\ell_S(h) \right| \geq \varepsilon \right) \leq 2e^{-2m\varepsilon^2}$, together with the *union bound* (Proposition 1.8):

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}}\left|\mathcal{R}^{\ell}(h)-\mathcal{R}^{\ell}_{S}(h)\right|\geq\varepsilon\right)=\mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{h\in\mathcal{H}}\left\{\left|\mathcal{R}^{\ell}(h)-\mathcal{R}^{\ell}_{S}(h)\right|\geq\varepsilon\right\}\right)$$

$$\downarrow \text{ union bound: } \mathbb{P}(\cup_j A_j)\leq\sum_j\mathbb{P}(A_j)$$

$$\leq\sum_{h\in\mathcal{H}}\mathbb{P}\left(\left|\mathcal{R}^{\ell}(h)-\mathcal{R}^{\ell}_{S}(h)\right|\geq\varepsilon\right)$$

$$\downarrow \text{ Hoeffding's inequality applied to each fixed } h$$

$$\leq 2\,|\mathcal{H}|\,e^{-2m\varepsilon^2}.$$

Setting the right-hand side equal to δ and solving for ε leads to the following result Bousquet et al. (2004).

Theorem 6.1: Uniform Generalization Bound

Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a finite set of hypotheses, S a training sample of size m drawn i.i.d. from $\mathcal{D}$, ℓ a loss function taking its values in $[0,1]$, and $\delta\in(0,1]$. Then, with probability at least $1-\delta$ over the draw of S, we have, for all $h\in\mathcal{H}$ simultaneously:

$$\mathcal{R}^{\ell}(h)\leq\mathcal{R}^{\ell}_{S}(h)+\sqrt{\frac{\ln|\mathcal{H}|+\ln(2/\delta)}{2m}}.$$

Example 6.2. Consider threshold classifiers $h_t(x)=\operatorname{sign}(x-t)$ on the real line, where the threshold t is chosen among $|\mathcal{H}|=1000$ values of a fixed grid, and the 0-1 loss. With $m=10\,000$ training examples and $\delta=0.05$, we get $\sqrt{(\ln 1000+\ln 40)/20\,000}\approx\sqrt{(6.91+3.69)/20\,000}\approx 0.023$. Hence, with probability at least 95%, the true error rate of *any* of these classifiers, in particular the one minimizing the empirical error, exceeds its training error rate by at most 2.3 percentage points. Note that the size of $\mathcal{H}$ only enters through $\ln|\mathcal{H}|$: multiplying the number of hypotheses by 1000 only adds $\ln 1000\approx 6.9$ in the numerator.

In a nutshell

All the bounds of this section have the same structure:

$$\text{true risk}\ \leq\ \text{empirical risk}\ +\ \sqrt{\frac{\text{complexity}+\ln(1/\delta)}{m}}\quad\text{(up to constants)}.$$

The first term is what we observe and minimize; the second one is the price to pay for having looked at only m examples. It grows with the richness of the class (or the instability of the algorithm) and with the required confidence $1-\delta$, and it shrinks as $1/\sqrt{m}$: to divide it by 2, we need 4 times more data.

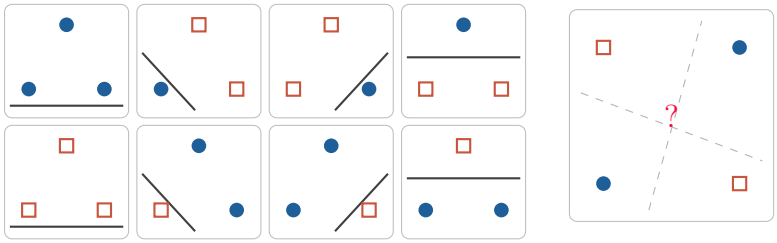
When the set $\mathcal{H}$ is infinite, *e.g.* the set of linear classifiers in $\mathbb{R}^d$, whose parameters belong to $\mathbb{R}^{d+1}$, the term $\ln|\mathcal{H}|$ is infinite and we need another way to measure the size, or complexity, of the set of hypotheses. A first way to measure this complexity is the VC-dimension, denoted by $VC(\mathcal{H})$ and introduced by Vapnik and Chervonenkis in the

1970s Vapnik and Chervonenkis (1971). It counts the largest number of points on which the hypotheses of $\mathcal{H}$ can realize *all* possible labelings.

Definition 6.3: VC-dimension

Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a set of binary classifiers with values in $\{-1, +1\}$. A set of points $\{\mathbf{x}_1, \dots, \mathbf{x}_n\} \subset \mathcal{X}$ is said to be *shattered* by $\mathcal{H}$ if, for every labeling $(y_1, \dots, y_n) \in \{-1, +1\}^n$, there exists $h \in \mathcal{H}$ such that $h(\mathbf{x}_i) = y_i$ for all $i = 1, \dots, n$. The VC-dimension $VC(\mathcal{H})$ is the size of the largest set of points that can be shattered by $\mathcal{H}$ (it is $+\infty$ if arbitrarily large sets can be shattered).

Example 6.3. Linear classifiers in $\mathbb{R}^2$ can shatter any set of 3 non-collinear points, but no set of 4 points (think of the "XOR" configuration, where the two diagonals of a square have opposite labels). Their VC-dimension is therefore 3. More generally, the VC-dimension of linear classifiers in $\mathbb{R}^d$ is $d + 1$, *i.e.* the number of parameters.



3 points: all the $2^3 = 8$ labelings are realized by a line

4 points (XOR): no line works

Figure 43: The VC-dimension of linear classifiers (half-planes) in $\mathbb{R}^2$ is 3. Left: three non-collinear points are *shattered*, *i.e.* each of the 8 possible labelings (blue disks: $+1$, red squares: -1) is realized by some line. Right: the XOR labeling of four points cannot be realized, since any line (dashed attempts) leaves points of both classes on one side; one can check that no set of four points in the plane can be shattered.

For the 0-1 loss, a set of hypotheses with finite VC-dimension enjoys a uniform generalization bound Vapnik and Chervonenkis (1971); Mohri et al. (2012): if $VC(\mathcal{H}) \leq m$, with probability at least $1 - \delta$, for all $h \in \mathcal{H}$,

$$\mathcal{R}^{\ell}(h) \leq \mathcal{R}^{\ell}_S(h) + \sqrt{\frac{2\,VC(\mathcal{H}) \ln\left(e\,m/VC(\mathcal{H})\right)}{m}} + \sqrt{\frac{\ln(1/\delta)}{2m}}.$$

Compared to Theorem 6.1, the quantity $\ln|\mathcal{H}|$ is essentially replaced by $VC(\mathcal{H}) \ln m$, which gives a convergence rate in $\mathcal{O}(\sqrt{\ln(m)/m})$.

Remark Why does $\ln m$ appear? Even if $\mathcal{H}$ is infinite, on a given sample of m points its hypotheses can only produce a finite number of distinct labelings, and only these labelings matter for the empirical risk. Sauer's lemma Sauer (1972) shows that this number is at most $(em/VC(\mathcal{H}))^{VC(\mathcal{H})}$ when $m \geq VC(\mathcal{H})$, *i.e.* it grows polynomially, and not exponentially, with m. Its logarithm, $VC(\mathcal{H}) \ln(em/VC(\mathcal{H}))$, plays the role of $\ln|\mathcal{H}|$ in the union bound.

Another way to measure the complexity of a set of hypotheses is the Rademacher complexity Bartlett and Mendelson (2003); Koltchinskii and Panchenko (2000a), which

is studied in more detail later in this document (see Definition 10.1). Informally, it measures the ability of the set of hypotheses to fit random noise: if the functions of $\mathcal{H}$ can correlate well with random labels $\sigma_i \in \{-1, +1\}$, then $\mathcal{H}$ is rich, and a small empirical risk is less informative about the true risk.

However, these two measures are usually hard to compute, or even to estimate accurately, for most problems (except for simple ones, such as linear models), and the resulting bounds are often loose in practice. Fortunately, there exists another way to establish generalization bounds for convex regularized optimization problems: the *Uniform Stability* framework.

Uniform Stability

This framework is more recent Bousquet and Elisseeff (2002) and is not directly based on a measure of the complexity of the set of hypotheses. It relies instead on the concept of *stability* of the learning algorithm. Roughly speaking, an algorithm is *stable* if its output does not change significantly under a small modification of the training sample. The intuition is the following: if replacing one training example by another one barely changes the learned model, then the model cannot have "memorized" individual examples, and its training error should be a good proxy for its error on new data. More precisely, we focus on *uniform stability*: we look at the largest possible change in the loss, over all possible examples, when a single training example is replaced. A formal definition is given below.

Definition 6.4: Uniform Stability

A learning algorithm $\mathcal{A}$ has a uniform stability in $\frac{\beta}{m}$ with respect to a loss function ℓ, where β is a positive constant, if:

$$\forall S,\ \forall i,\ 1 \leq i \leq m,\ \sup_{\mathbf{z} \in \mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{Y}} |\ell(\boldsymbol{\theta}_S, \mathbf{z}) - \ell(\boldsymbol{\theta}_{S^i}, \mathbf{z})| \leq \frac{\beta}{m},$$

where S is a training sample of size m, $\boldsymbol{\theta}_S$ denotes the model parameters learned from S, and $\boldsymbol{\theta}_{S^i}$ the model parameters learned from the sample S^i obtained by replacing the ith example $\mathbf{z}_i = (\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)$ of S by another example $\mathbf{z}'_i = (\mathbf{x}'_i, y'_i)$ drawn from $\mathcal{D}$, independently of S. Here, $\ell(\boldsymbol{\theta}_S, \mathbf{z})$ denotes the loss suffered at $\mathbf{z} = (\mathbf{x}, y)$ by the model learned from S[a].

[a] Note that the authors also provide a definition of stability in which an example is removed instead of replaced. For the sake of convenience, we use the definition based on replacement throughout this document: indeed, it keeps the same number of training instances from one sample to the other.

The constant β depends on the properties of the loss function, but also on the regularization term of the minimization problem. The uniform stability property has been shown to hold for a wide range of minimization problems Bousquet and Elisseeff (2002). Using McDiarmid's inequality (Proposition 1.17), we get the following generalization bound, whose rate of convergence is in $\mathcal{O}(1/\sqrt{m})$.

Theorem 6.2: Uniform Stability based Bound

Let $\delta \in (0,1)$ and $m > 1$. For any algorithm with uniform stability β/m with respect to a loss function ℓ satisfying $0 \leq \ell \leq K$, with probability at least $1-\delta$ over the random draw of S, we have:

$$\mathcal{R}^{\ell}(\boldsymbol{\theta}_S) \leq \mathcal{R}^{\ell}_S(\boldsymbol{\theta}_S) + \frac{2\beta}{m} + (4\beta + K)\sqrt{\frac{\ln(1/\delta)}{2m}},$$

where $\mathcal{R}^{\ell}(\cdot)$ is the true risk and $\mathcal{R}^{\ell}_S(\cdot)$ its empirical estimate over S.

The previous bound has a global convergence rate in $\mathcal{O}(1/\sqrt{m})$ and depends on two parameters: β, the uniform stability constant of the algorithm $\mathcal{A}$, and K, an upper bound on the loss function ℓ. Note that, unlike Theorem 6.1, it does not need to hold uniformly over $\mathcal{H}$: it only concerns the hypothesis actually returned by the algorithm.

The convexity of the problem is what makes it possible to compute β. The typical result is the following one.

Example 6.4. Consider a linear model $h_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}) = \langle \boldsymbol{\theta}, \mathbf{x} \rangle$ with $\|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \leq \kappa$ for all $\mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{X}$, learned by solving

$$\boldsymbol{\theta}_S = \operatorname*{argmin}_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \ell(h_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i) + \lambda \|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2,$$

where the loss ℓ is convex and σ-Lipschitz with respect to its first argument (*e.g.* the hinge loss, with $\sigma = 1$). Bousquet and Elisseeff Bousquet and Elisseeff (2002) showed that, when one example is removed, the loss changes by at most $\frac{\sigma^2\kappa^2}{2\lambda m}$; replacing an example amounts to one removal followed by one addition, so this algorithm is uniformly stable with

$$\frac{\beta}{m} \leq \frac{\sigma^2\kappa^2}{\lambda m}.$$

Plugging this value into Theorem 6.2 gives a bound in which everything is explicit: the smaller λ, the larger β, and the looser the bound.

This generalization bound is thus quite informative in practice, as both β and K can often be computed explicitly. Moreover, compared to the two previous frameworks, it is consistent with the practice of Machine Learning, since it takes into account the regularization term which is used in most minimization problems. As the previous example shows, the uniform stability constant β is a decreasing function of the hyper-parameter λ associated with the regularization term, whereas the empirical risk usually increases with λ. The impact of the hyper-parameter value is depicted in Figure 44, which shows that it is important to find the right value in order to obtain the best solution.

We will see that it is easy to build such bounds for convex regularized optimization problems, for both classification and regression tasks. It only requires some tools from linear algebra and the definition of a convex function.

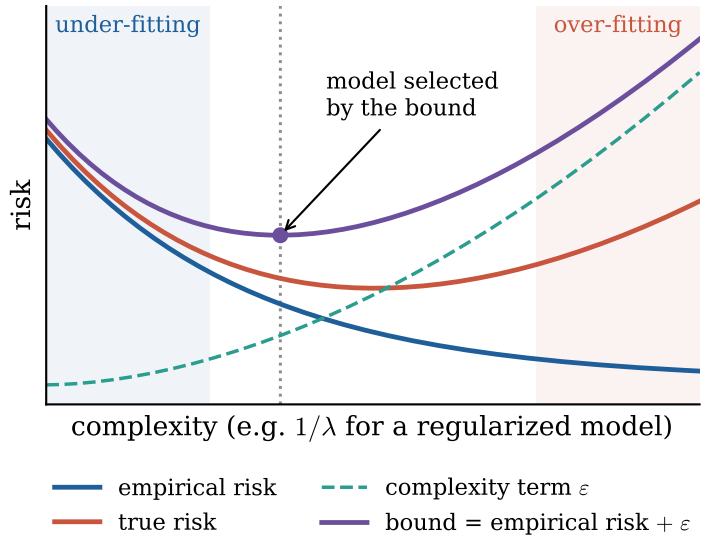


Figure 44: Evolution of the empirical and true risks and of a generalization bound according to the complexity of the model, *e.g.* the inverse $1/\lambda$ of the regularization hyper-parameter (schematic curves). The bound is the sum of the empirical risk and of a complexity term ε that increases with the complexity; it always lies above the true risk, and its minimizer gives a reasonable, if somewhat conservative, choice of the hyper-parameter.

To remember from Section 6

- The **true risk** $\mathcal{R}^\ell(h)$ is the expected loss of h on the unknown distribution $\mathcal{D}$; the **empirical risk** $\mathcal{R}^\ell_S(h)$ is its average on the sample S, an unbiased estimate for a *fixed* h.
- Minimizing the empirical risk over a too rich class leads to **over-fitting**; constraining the class too much leads to **under-fitting**. Structural and regularized risk minimization control the complexity through a penalty, tuned in practice by cross-validation.
- The excess risk of the learned model is the sum of an **approximation error** (due to $\mathcal{H}$) and an **estimation error** (due to the finite sample).
- A **generalization bound** states that, with probability at least $1-\delta$, true risk $\leq$ empirical risk $+\,\varepsilon(\delta, m)$. Since $h^\star_S$ depends on S, the bound must hold uniformly over $\mathcal{H}$ (union bound, VC-dimension, Rademacher complexity) or exploit the **stability** of the algorithm.
- Typical rates are $\mathcal{O}(1/\sqrt{m})$ or $\mathcal{O}(\sqrt{\ln(m)/m})$; for regularized convex problems, the stability constant behaves as $1/\lambda$.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q6.6. Why can the true risk not be computed in practice, and which quantity do we use instead?

Q6.7. Is the training error of $h_S^\star$ an unbiased estimate of its true risk?

Q6.8. In regularized risk minimization, what happens when $\lambda \to 0$? When $\lambda \to \infty$?

Q6.9. For a fixed classifier, $m = 1000$ examples and $\delta = 0.05$, what is the deviation ε given by Hoeffding's inequality?

Q6.10. In Theorem 6.1, by how much must the sample size be multiplied to divide the deviation term by 2? By how much must $|\mathcal{H}|$ be multiplied to double $\ln|\mathcal{H}|$ when $|\mathcal{H}| = 1000$?

Q6.11. True or false? "For a fixed sample size, a larger δ gives a smaller ε."

Q6.12. How does Theorem 6.1 change if the loss takes its values in $[0, K]$ instead of $[0, 1]$?

Q6.13. What is the VC-dimension of linear classifiers in $\mathbb{R}^5$?

Q6.14. True or false? "To prove that $VC(\mathcal{H}) \geq 3$, it suffices to exhibit one set of 3 points shattered by $\mathcal{H}$; to prove that $VC(\mathcal{H}) < 4$, it suffices to exhibit one set of 4 points that is not shattered."

Q6.15. Which quantity does the uniform stability bound depend on, instead of the complexity of $\mathcal{H}$?

Q6.16. Why does the uniform stability bound not need to hold uniformly over $\mathcal{H}$?

Exercises

Exercise 6.1. **(Computation)** Let X be uniform on $\{0,1,2,3\}$ and $Y \in \{-1,+1\}$ with $\eta(x) = \mathbb{P}(Y=+1 \mid X=x)$ equal to 0.9, 0.7, 0.3 and 0.1 for $x=0,1,2,3$. Consider the classifiers $h(x)=+1$ if $x \le 1$ and -1 otherwise, and $h'(x)=+1$ if $x \le 2$ and -1 otherwise, with the 0-1 loss. (a) Compute the true risks $\mathcal{R}(h)$ and $\mathcal{R}(h')$. (b) Compute their empirical risks on the sample $S = \{(0,+1),(0,+1),(1,-1),(2,-1),(2,+1),(3,-1)\}$. Comment. (c) Show that h is the best possible classifier (the Bayes classifier) and give the Bayes risk $\mathcal{R}^\star$. (d) Give the standard deviation of $\mathcal{R}_S(h)$ for a random sample of size $m=6$, and then of size $m=600$.

Exercise 6.2. **(Proof)** Let h be a fixed classifier and ℓ the 0-1 loss. (a) Show that $\mathbb{E}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}[\mathcal{R}_S(h)] = \mathcal{R}(h)$ and $\mathrm{Var}(\mathcal{R}_S(h)) = \mathcal{R}(h)(1-\mathcal{R}(h))/m \le 1/(4m)$. (b) Using the Bienaymé–Chebyshev inequality (Proposition 1.10), show that, with probability at least $1-\delta$, $|\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)| \le 1/(2\sqrt{m\delta})$. (c) Compare numerically with the deviation $\sqrt{\ln(2/\delta)/(2m)}$ given by Hoeffding's inequality for $m=1000$ and $\delta=0.05$, then $\delta=0.001$. Which dependence on δ makes the difference?

Exercise 6.3. **(Computation)** Using Theorem 6.1 with $\delta=0.05$, find the number m of examples needed to guarantee that the true risk of every hypothesis of a class of $|\mathcal{H}| = 10^6$ classifiers exceeds its empirical risk by at most $\varepsilon = 0.05$. How does this number change if $\varepsilon = 0.01$? If $|\mathcal{H}| = 10^{12}$?

Exercise 6.4. **(Proof, exam style)** Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a finite class of classifiers and ℓ the 0-1 loss. (a) Starting from Hoeffding's inequality for a fixed hypothesis and the union bound, prove Theorem 6.1. (b) *Realizable case.* Assume that the learned hypothesis $h_S^\star$ always satisfies $\mathcal{R}_S(h_S^\star)=0$. Let h be a fixed hypothesis with $\mathcal{R}(h) > \varepsilon$. Show that $\mathbb{P}(\mathcal{R}_S(h)=0) \le (1-\varepsilon)^m \le e^{-\varepsilon m}$. (c) Deduce that, with probability at least $1-\delta$, every $h \in \mathcal{H}$ with $\mathcal{R}_S(h)=0$ satisfies $\mathcal{R}(h) \le (\ln|\mathcal{H}| + \ln(1/\delta))/m$. (d) Compare the two bounds for $|\mathcal{H}|=1000$, $m=10\,000$ and $\delta=0.05$. Which rate in m does each of them achieve?

Exercise 6.5. **(Proof)** We use the notation of the remark on approximation and estimation errors, $h_S^\star$ being a minimizer of the empirical risk over $\mathcal{H}$. (a) True or false? Justify. (i) Enlarging $\mathcal{H}$ can never increase the approximation error. (ii) The estimation error is always nonnegative. (iii) If the Bayes predictor belongs to $\mathcal{H}$, the excess risk of $h_S^\star$ is zero. (b) Show that $\mathcal{R}(h_S^\star) - \mathcal{R}(h_{\mathcal{H}}) \le 2\sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}}|\mathcal{R}(h)-\mathcal{R}_S(h)|$. (c) Deduce, for a finite class and a loss with values in $[0,1]$, a bound on the estimation error that holds with probability at least $1-\delta$.

Exercise 6.6. **(Proof)** Consider the threshold classifiers on the real line, $\mathcal{H} = \{x \mapsto \mathrm{sign}(x-t),\ t\in\mathbb{R}\}$ (with the convention $\mathrm{sign}(0)=+1$). Show that $VC(\mathcal{H})=1$. What is the VC-dimension of the class of "intervals" $\{x \mapsto 2\cdot\mathbb{1}_{[a,b]}(x)-1,\ a\le b\}$?

Exercise 6.7. **(Proof)** (a) Show that a finite class satisfies $VC(\mathcal{H}) \le \log_2|\mathcal{H}|$. (b) Let $\mathcal{H}_\pm = \{x \mapsto s\cdot\mathrm{sign}(x-t),\ t\in\mathbb{R},\ s\in\{-1,+1\}\}$ be the two-sided thresholds. Show that $VC(\mathcal{H}_\pm)=2$. (c) For m distinct points on the line, count the number of distinct labelings realized by $\mathcal{H}_\pm$ and compare it, for $m=10$, with 2^m and with the two bounds of Sauer's lemma, $\sum_{i=0}^{d}\binom{m}{i}$ and $(em/d)^d$, where $d=VC(\mathcal{H}_\pm)$.

Exercise 6.8. **(Computation)** We learn a linear classifier in $\mathbb{R}^{10}$ with the 0-1 loss and use the VC bound given after Definition 6.3, with $\delta=0.05$. (a) What is the VC-dimension of the class? (b) Compute the complexity term of the bound for $m=10\,000$. (c) How many examples are needed for this complexity term to be smaller than 0.05? Comment.

Exercise 6.9. **(Application)** A model, learned beforehand, is evaluated on a test set of 500 new examples, independent of the training data, on which it makes 60 errors. (a) Using Hoeffding's inequality, give an interval that contains its true risk with probability at least 95%. (b) A colleague evaluates 20 different models on the same test set and reports the smallest test error. How must the interval be modified to remain valid for the reported model? (c) Why can we apply Hoeffding's inequality to a fixed hypothesis on a test set, but not to $h_S^\star$ on its training

set?

Exercise 6.10. **(Application, exam style)** We compare three nested finite classes $\mathcal{H}_1 \subset \mathcal{H}_2 \subset \mathcal{H}_3$ with $|\mathcal{H}_1| = 10$, $|\mathcal{H}_2| = 10^4$ and $|\mathcal{H}_3| = 10^8$. On a sample of $m = 2\,000$ examples, the empirical risk minimizers have empirical risks 0.20, 0.12 and 0.11 (0-1 loss). (a) Which class would plain empirical risk minimization over $\mathcal{H}_3$ select? Why is this not a reliable criterion? (b) Applying Theorem 6.1 to each class with confidence parameter $\delta/3$, $\delta = 0.05$, compute the three upper bounds on the true risk. (c) Why do we use $\delta/3$ and not δ? Which class does this structural risk minimization select? (d) What would you do in practice to confirm this choice?

Exercise 6.11. **(Computation)** Using the example following Theorem 6.2, write the generalization bound for a linear SVM (hinge loss, $\sigma = 1$) when $\|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \leq 1$ and the loss is bounded by K. (a) How must λ depend on m for the bound to converge to the empirical risk? (b) Show that the solution satisfies $\|\boldsymbol{\theta}_S\|_2 \leq 1/\sqrt{\lambda}$ and deduce a value of K. (c) Evaluate the complexity terms for $m = 10\,000$, $\lambda = 0.1$ and $\delta = 0.05$. Comment.

Exercise 6.12. **(Python)** Reproduce the setting of Figure 42: x uniform on $[0, 1]$, $y = \operatorname{sign}(x - 0.5)$ flipped with probability 0.2, and threshold classifiers h_t with t on a grid of 201 values of $[0, 1]$. For $m \in \{30, 300, 3000\}$, draw 1000 samples, compute on each of them the empirical risk minimizer $h_S^\star$, and report the averages of $\mathcal{R}_S(h_S^\star)$ and $\mathcal{R}(h_S^\star)$, using $\mathcal{R}(h_t) = 0.2 + 0.6\,|t - 0.5|$. Comment.

Exercise 6.13. **(Python)** Generate $m = 30$ points x_i uniform on $[0, 1]$ and $y_i = \sin(2\pi x_i) + \epsilon_i$, with $\epsilon_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 0.3^2)$. For each degree $d \in \{0, \dots, 12\}$, fit a polynomial regression (`PolynomialFeatures` and `LinearRegression` of scikit-learn) and compute its training error, its 5-fold cross-validation error and its error on 5000 new points. Which degree does cross-validation select? Relate the results to Figures 39 and 40.

7 Learning Procedure

Before presenting the different algorithms used in Supervised Learning, it is important to describe the way we learn a model. The aim of this section is to describe the right way to evaluate an algorithm and to tune its hyper-parameters, when the optimization problem involves one or several of them. We also present the classical performance measures used to evaluate a model in regression and in classification.

About this section

In this section you will learn to:

- *split a dataset into training, validation and test sets, and know which decision each of them is allowed to influence;*
- *tune hyper-parameters by (stratified) k-fold cross-validation, and read validation and learning curves to diagnose under- and over-fitting;*
- *recognize the most common forms of data leakage, which make an evaluation over-optimistic;*
- *compute and interpret the measures derived from a confusion matrix (accuracy, recall, precision, F_β, balanced accuracy, ...);*
- *build a ROC curve by moving a decision threshold, and know when a precision-recall curve is more informative.*

7.1 How to train and tune a Model

Imagine that we want to solve a given task in practice, such as a classification task, and that we have a labeled dataset $\{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ for this purpose. Our goal is then to learn from our data a hypothesis h that solves this task as well as possible. We also want our model to generalize well to new data that it has not encountered yet. This last point is important because it is what allows us to deploy algorithms in production to solve tasks automatically.

The first question that arises is:

How can we measure the performance of our model on data that it has not encountered yet, starting from the data we have?

This is the first step of an experimental protocol in Machine Learning. In order to evaluate the performance of the model learned from our dataset, we start by splitting the dataset into two sets: a *training set* and a *test set* (see Figure 45).

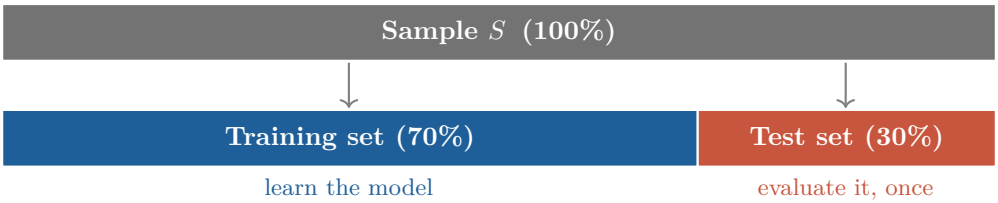


Figure 45: Illustration, with typical proportions, of how to split the sample into a training set and a test set.

Training set This set is used to learn the parameters of the model, *e.g.* the parameters of a linear separator or of a linear regression model. The algorithm has access to the features $\mathbf{x}_i$ **and** to the labels y_i of the data in order to be trained.

Test set This set is used to evaluate the model once it has been learned. The prediction is only based on the descriptors $\mathbf{x}_i$ of the data, and the labels are used a posteriori only, to check whether the predictions made by the model are correct or not, *i.e.* to evaluate the performance of the model on new data, that is, data that have not been seen during training.

Usually, we keep approximately 2/3 (or 70% to 80%) of the examples to train the model and the remaining examples to test it. It is important to keep a large amount of data to train the model, so that it is able to capture all the specificities of the data: indeed, the more data you have, the better they describe the underlying distribution. However, it is also important to keep enough examples in the test set so that the observed results are statistically significant. Note that the split should be random (and, in classification, it is common to preserve the class proportions in both sets, which is called a *stratified* split).

In a nutshell

The test set plays the role of the final exam of a student. The training set contains the exercises studied during the semester. If the exam is made of exercises already solved in class, a good grade only proves that the student has a good memory, not that they have understood the course. Likewise, a model must be evaluated on examples that it has never seen, and the exam must remain sealed until the very end.

But what about hyper-parameter tuning?

The methodology presented above evaluates the model, but it does not solve the problem of hyper-parameter tuning: the test set must **never** be used to choose the hyper-parameters, otherwise the test performance would be an optimistic estimate of the generalization performance. The first thing we can do is to mimic the previous procedure, but on the *training set*! We thus obtain a sort of test set, called the *validation set*, which can be used to evaluate the performance of the model learned with each value of the hyper-parameter. More concretely, imagine that we aim to learn a hypothesis h which depends on a parameter $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ and on a hyper-parameter λ. To tune the value of λ, we first select a range of candidate values for λ, denoted by λ_i, and the process works as follows:

1. Split the dataset into a training set and a test set.
2. Split the training set into a learning set and a validation set.
3. For each value λ_i:
   (a) train your hypothesis (*i.e.* learn the parameter $\boldsymbol{\theta}$) with λ_i on the learning set;
   (b) evaluate the performance of the learned model on the validation set. This gives you a performance p_i.

4. Keep the hyper-parameter value associated with the highest performance p_i; we denote its index by $i_{\max}$.
5. Learn a model on *the whole training set* using the hyper-parameter value $\lambda_{i_{\max}}$.
6. Evaluate this model on the test set.

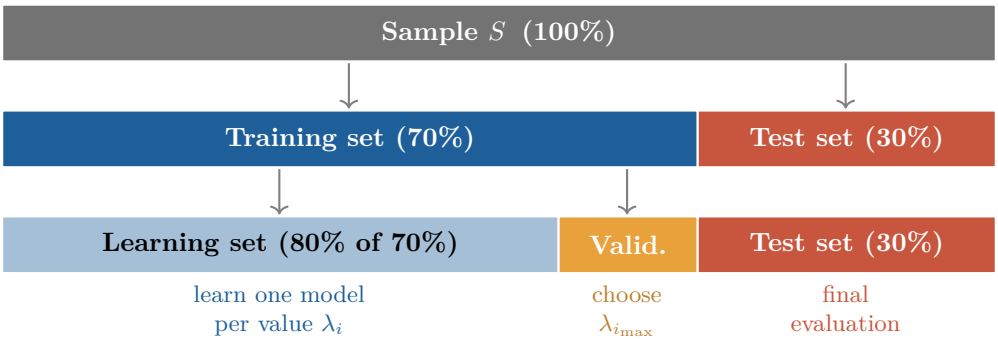


Figure 46: Illustration, with typical proportions, of how to split the sample into training and test sets, and then the training set into learning and validation sets.

The splitting process is illustrated in Figure 46. Note that, once the best hyper-parameter value is found, the model is trained again using a larger amount of data (the whole training set), in the hope of improving its performance. Figure 47 summarizes the role of each set: each of them is allowed to influence one, and only one, kind of decision.

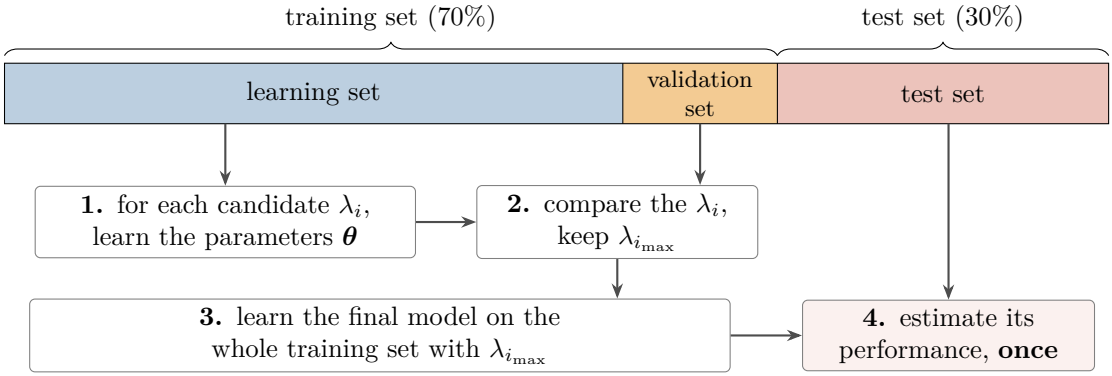


Figure 47: The hold-out protocol: which set is used for which decision. The parameters are learned on the learning set, the hyper-parameters are chosen on the validation set, and the test set is only used at the very end, to estimate the performance of the final model.

Pitfall: peeking at the test set If several models (or several values of a hyper-parameter) are evaluated on the test set and the best one is reported, the test set has in fact been used as a validation set, and the reported score is optimistic: among many noisy scores, the largest one is partly large by chance (this is made precise in Proposition 11.1 of Section 11). The same holds if the test set is used to choose the features, the preprocessing or the decision threshold of a classifier. Once a test score has been looked at, any decision taken on its basis turns the test set into a validation set.

Comparing the training and validation performances is also a way to diagnose the behavior of the model: if the model performs much better on the learning set than on the validation set, it probably suffers from *over-fitting*; if its performance is poor on both sets, it probably suffers from *under-fitting*. This diagnosis is conveniently made with two plots, illustrated in Figure 48.

- The *validation curve* shows the training and validation scores as a function of a hyper-parameter that controls the complexity of the model (here, the maximal depth of a decision tree). The training score keeps increasing with the complexity, while the validation score first increases (the bias decreases) and then decreases (the variance increases): the best value lies at the top of the validation curve.
- The *learning curve* shows the same scores, for a fixed model, as a function of the size of the learning set. The gap between the two curves shrinks as more data become available; if the validation curve is still increasing at the right end of the plot, collecting more data is likely to improve the model.

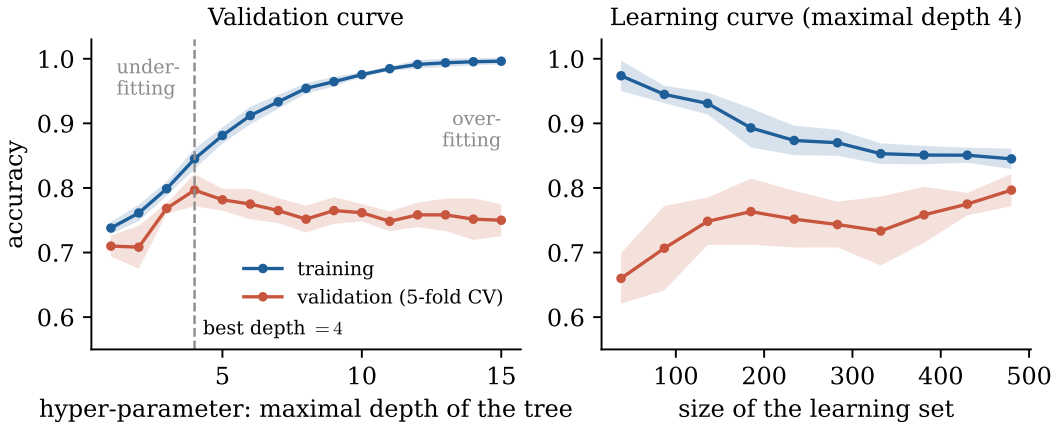


Figure 48: Left: validation curve of a decision tree on a synthetic dataset with 15% of noisy labels; the shaded areas represent ± one standard deviation over the 5 folds. Deep trees fit the training set almost perfectly but generalize worse. Right: learning curve of the selected tree; the gap between training and validation accuracy shrinks when the learning set grows.

However, this tuning technique can be improved. Indeed, it has a flaw: the validation relies on a single, rather small, subset of the data, hence potentially on a small part of their distribution, and the result may depend a lot on this particular split.

In the previous section, we mentioned cross-validation as a way to tune hyper-parameters. **What does it consist of?** Let us illustrate it using Figure 49.

In this case, the training set is no longer split into two groups; instead, it is split into k groups, called folds. The tuning process is then the following:

1. For each value λ_i of the hyper-parameter:
   (a) at the first round, select the first fold as the validation set and the $k-1$ others as the learning set. This gives a first performance measure p_1;
   (b) at the second round, select the second fold as the validation set and the $k-1$ others as the learning set. This gives a second performance measure p_2;
   (c) ...

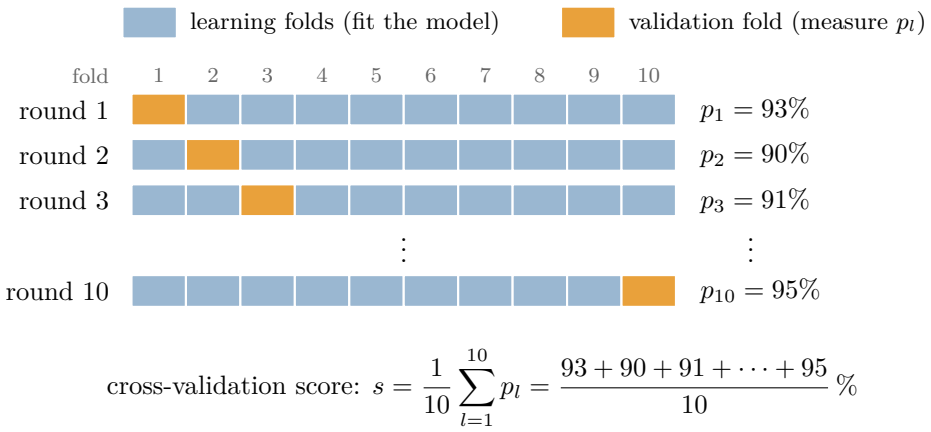


Figure 49: Illustration of the cross-validation process using a 10-fold cross-validation. The training set is divided into 10 folds, or groups. At each round, the model is learned on 9 folds (blue) and validated on the remaining one (orange), which gives a performance p_l, here an accuracy. The validation fold changes at each round, so that every example of the training set is used exactly once for validation. The cross-validation score is the average of the 10 values $p_1, \ldots, p_{10}$.

   (d) at round k, select fold k as the validation set and the $k-1$ others as the learning set. This gives a last performance measure p_k;

   (e) compute $s_i = \frac{1}{k}\sum_{l=1}^{k} p_l$, *i.e.* the average score over the k rounds.

2. Keep the hyper-parameter value associated with the highest score s_i; we denote its index by $i_{\max}$.

3. Learn a model on *the whole training set* using the hyper-parameter value $\lambda_{i_{\max}}$.

4. Evaluate this model on the test set.

With this tuning method, every example of the training set is used once for validation, so that a larger part of the underlying distribution is explored. In practice, it therefore leads to a more reliable choice of the hyper-parameters. However, it requires learning as many models as there are folds (*i.e.* k) times the number of hyper-parameter values to test. Common choices are $k = 5$ or $k = 10$.

> **Remark on the number of folds** The extreme case $k = m$, where each fold contains a single example, is called *leave-one-out* cross-validation. Since each model is learned on $m - 1$ examples, its estimate is almost unbiased, but it is costly and its variance can be large, because the m learned models are almost identical. Conversely, a small k learns models on noticeably fewer examples than the final one, which makes the estimate pessimistic. The values $k = 5$ or $k = 10$ are a good trade-off in practice Kohavi (1995); see Arlot and Celisse (2010) for a survey. In classification, the folds should be *stratified*, *i.e.* each of them should have the class proportions of the whole training set.

Example 7.1. Suppose that we want to choose the regularization constant λ of the lasso among the 5 values $\{10^{-3}, 10^{-2}, 10^{-1}, 1, 10\}$ using a 10-fold cross-validation. We then learn $5 \times 10 = 50$ models, compute 5 average scores $s_1, \ldots, s_5$, keep the best value of λ,

and learn a 51st model on the whole training set, which is finally evaluated once on the test set.

Remark on nested cross-validation When data are too scarce to set a test set aside, the cross-validation can itself be repeated inside another one: an *outer* cross-validation estimates the performance, and, in each of its rounds, an *inner* cross-validation chooses the hyper-parameters on the outer training folds only. This *nested cross-validation* Varma and Simon (2006) is detailed in Section 11.5 (see Figure 104).

Pitfall: data leakage through preprocessing Every step whose parameters are estimated from the data is part of the learning procedure, and must only see the learning data. A classical mistake is to standardize the features (with means and variances computed on the *whole* dataset), to impute the missing values, or to select the most relevant features *before* splitting the data or running the cross-validation: the validation and test examples then influence the model through the preprocessing. With standardization, the effect is often small; with feature selection, it can be dramatic Ambroise and McLachlan (2002), (Hastie et al., 2009, Section 7.10.2). In Figure 50, the labels are pure noise, so no classifier can do better than 50% of accuracy; yet, selecting the 20 features that are the most correlated with the labels on the whole dataset before running the cross-validation leads to an estimated accuracy above 90%. The cure is to fit the preprocessing *inside* each round of the cross-validation, *e.g.* with a pipeline (Section 11.4).

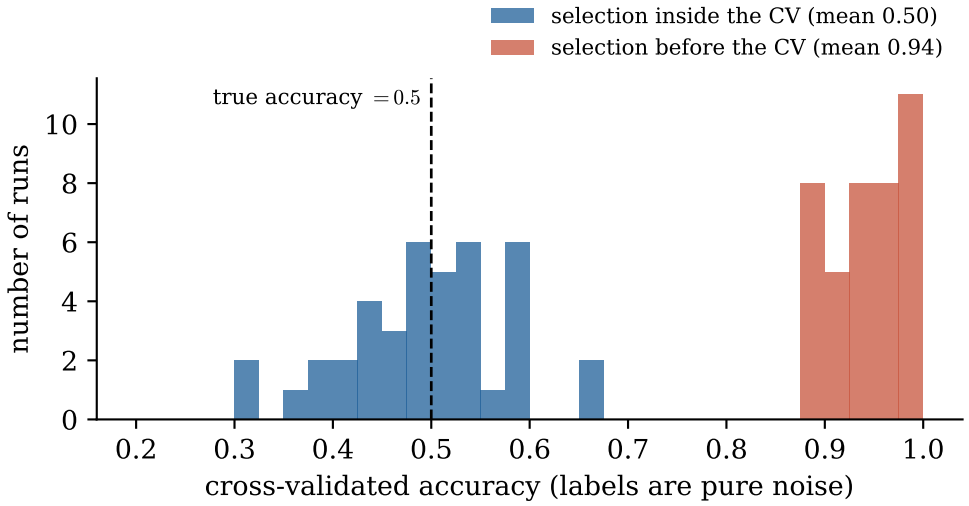


Figure 50: Feature selection must be part of the cross-validation. Each of the 40 runs draws $m = 50$ examples with 2000 Gaussian features and random labels, keeps the 20 features most correlated with the labels and estimates the accuracy of a logistic regression by 5-fold cross-validation. Red: the features are selected once, on the whole dataset (leakage). Blue: they are selected again on the learning folds of each round.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q7.1. Why must the hyper-parameters never be chosen on the test set?

Q7.2. After a 10-fold cross-validation has selected $\lambda_{i_{\max}}$, which model is evaluated on the test set?

Q7.3. A model reaches 99% of accuracy on the learning set and 70% on the validation set. What is your diagnosis, and what could you try?

Q7.4. What is wrong with standardizing the features of the whole dataset and then running a cross-validation?

Q7.5. Two hyper-parameters are tuned on a grid of 4×3 values by 5-fold cross-validation. How many models are learned, including the final one?

Q7.6. True or false? Leave-one-out cross-validation is always the best choice, since each model is learned on $m - 1$ examples.

Q7.7. On a learning curve, the training and validation accuracies are both around 65% and are almost flat for the largest learning sets. Will collecting more data help?

Q7.8. Why is the best average score obtained during a cross-validated grid search not a reliable estimate of the performance of the selected model?

So far, we have mentioned performance measures without ever explaining what they are. In Section 6.1, we already hinted at a potential performance measure when we talked about the number of errors made by a classifier (the error rate, whose complement is called the accuracy). The next subsection is devoted to the presentation of classical performance measures in classification and regression.

7.2 Performance Measures

The choice of the performance measure depends on the nature of the problem, *i.e.* classification or regression, but also on what matters for the application at hand.

As in the previous section, we denote by $\mathbf{x}$ the feature vector and by y the label, or the real value to predict. We also denote by $\hat{y} = h(\mathbf{x})$ the output of a hypothesis h. All the measures below are computed on a set of m examples (typically a validation or a test set).

7.2.1 Regression tasks

In regression tasks, where the output space satisfies $\mathcal{Y} \subset \mathbb{R}$, we have already met several performance measures.

The most widely used one is the *Mean Squared Error* (MSE), which is the mean value, over all examples, of the squared difference between the predicted value $\hat{y}$ and the true value y:

$$MSE_h = \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} (y_i - \hat{y}_i)^2.$$

Up to the constant $1/m$, the MSE is the squared ℓ_2 norm of the vector $\mathbf{y} - \hat{\mathbf{y}}$, *i.e.* $MSE_h = \frac{1}{m} \|\mathbf{y} - \hat{\mathbf{y}}\|_2^2$. Its main advantage is that it is convex and differentiable, and can thus be directly optimized. One also often considers the *Root Mean Squared Error* (RMSE), which has the advantage of being expressed in the same unit as the target y, and is therefore easier to interpret:

$$RMSE_h = \sqrt{\frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} (y_i - \hat{y}_i)^2}.$$

The MSE is certainly the most used performance measure in regression. However, it has an important flaw: it is very sensitive to outliers. When an observation lies far from the regression line, its squared deviation, hence its contribution to the MSE, quickly becomes very large. When the MSE is used as the training criterion, this also introduces an important bias in the model, which is attracted towards the outliers (see Figure 51). That is why we often use another performance measure, the *Mean Absolute Error* (MAE), which is the mean value, over all examples, of the absolute difference between the predicted value $\hat{y}$ and the true value y:

$$MAE_h = \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} |y_i - \hat{y}_i|.$$

Up to the constant $1/m$, the MAE is the ℓ_1 norm of the vector $\mathbf{y} - \hat{\mathbf{y}}$.

Example 7.2. Consider $m = 4$ examples with residuals $y_i - \hat{y}_i$ equal to $1, -1, 1$ and -1. Then $MSE = MAE = 1$. If the last residual is replaced by -9 (an outlier), the MAE becomes $(1 + 1 + 1 + 9)/4 = 3$, whereas the MSE becomes $(1 + 1 + 1 + 81)/4 = 21$: the single outlier accounts for more than 95% of the MSE.

Other measures of the *quality* of a regression model were met in the Linear Models course, such as the AIC and BIC criteria, or the coefficient of determination R^2, defined by

$$R^2 = 1 - \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{m} (y_i - \hat{y}_i)^2}{\sum_{i=1}^{m} (y_i - \bar{y})^2}, \quad \text{where } \bar{y} = \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} y_i,$$

which compares the error of the model to that of the constant predictor $\bar{y}$: the closer R^2 is to 1, the better the model.

7.2.2 Classification tasks

In this section, we present different metrics, or performance measures, that are suited to the binary setting. Some of them can easily be extended to the multi-class setting, as explained at the end of this section.

We consider a binary classification problem with two classes: $y = -1$ and $y = 1$. The class $y = 1$ is called the positive class and the class $y = -1$ the negative one[8]. In many applications (fraud, disease, spam), the positive class is the class of interest and is also the minority class. In this setting, we can compute several performance measures

[8] We will sometimes use the label 0 to denote the negative class, for the sake of simplicity, when presenting some of the algorithms.

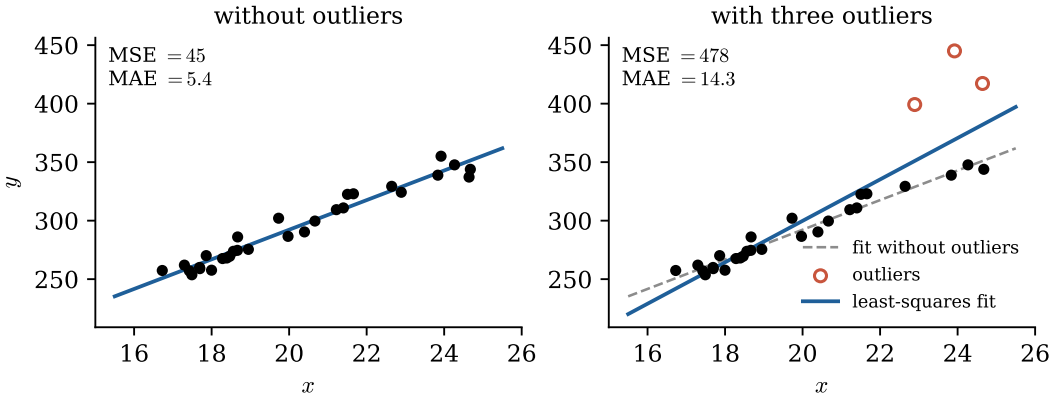


Figure 51: Sensitivity of the MSE to outliers. Left: a least-squares regression line fitted on 30 points without outliers. Right: the same data in which three responses have been shifted upwards (open circles); the least-squares line (solid) is attracted towards them and moves away from the line fitted without outliers (dashed). The MSE of the fitted line is multiplied by more than 10 (from 45 to 478), the MAE only by about 2.6 (from 5.4 to 14.3).

from a *Confusion Matrix*, an example of which is given in Table 2. An example from the positive class that is predicted positive by the learned model is called a *True Positive (TP)*; if it is misclassified, it is called a *False Negative (FN)*. Similarly, an example from the negative class that is well classified is called a *True Negative (TN)*, and a *False Positive (FP)* otherwise. With a slight abuse of notation, TP, FN, FP and TN also denote the *numbers* of such examples, so that $TP + FN + FP + TN = m$.

	Predicted positive ($h(\mathbf{x}) = 1$)	Predicted negative ($h(\mathbf{x}) = 0$)
Actual positive ($y = 1$)	True Positive (TP)	False Negative (FN)
Actual negative ($y = 0$)	False Positive (FP)	True Negative (TN)

Table 2: Confusion matrix for a binary classification task. The label is denoted by y and the prediction by $h(\mathbf{x})$.

Standard Measures The most common performance measure used to evaluate an algorithm is the *Accuracy*, which is the complement of the *Error rate*. Using the notations of Table 2, they are defined as follows.

Definition 7.1: Accuracy - Error rate

Let us consider a set of m examples and a hypothesis h which leads to a given confusion matrix on these examples. The Accuracy of h is then defined by:

$$\text{Accuracy} = \frac{TP + TN}{m},$$

and the Error rate is defined by:

$$\text{Error rate} = 1 - \text{Accuracy} = \frac{FP + FN}{m}.$$

Although this measure is the most used one to evaluate the performance of algorithms, it is not relevant in all settings, *e.g.* when the dataset is *imbalanced*, *i.e.* when one class is much less represented than the other.

Example 7.3. Let us consider a dataset with $m = 100{,}000$ examples. Suppose that the number of positive examples is $m_+ = 1{,}000$ and the number of negative examples is $m_- = 99{,}000$. Then a trivial classifier, which predicts all the examples as negative, achieves an accuracy of 99%. This looks good at first glance, but this solution is not satisfactory because the learned hypothesis does not detect a single example of the positive class.

To overcome the issue raised in the above example, we need another performance measure which takes into account the ability of the model h to capture the minority class.

Definition 7.2: Sensitivity or Recall

Let us consider a set of m examples and a hypothesis h which leads to a given confusion matrix on these examples. The *Sensitivity*, also known as *Recall* or *True Positive Rate*, of a classifier h is defined as:

$$\text{Recall} = \frac{TP}{TP + FN}.$$

By definition, the Recall is the proportion of examples of the class of interest that the model is able to retrieve. The higher this value (*i.e.* the closer to 1), the more examples of the minority class are retrieved (the trivial classifier of the previous example has a Recall equal to 0). Because it measures the ability of a model to detect the examples of the minority class, the Recall is a good candidate for a performance measure in imbalanced scenarios, *e.g.* in medical diagnosis, where missing a patient with a serious disease can be fatal.

In other applications, such as in banking, it is important to be confident in positive predictions: *e.g.* when an individual is denied a more or less fundamental right (such as a loan), the decision had better be the right one, otherwise there could be serious consequences for the company or organization that made the decision. In this case, we want the model to be reliable when it predicts the positive class, *i.e.* we focus on the Precision of the model.

Definition 7.3: Precision

Let us consider a set of m examples and a hypothesis h which leads to a given confusion matrix on these examples. The *Precision*, also called *Positive Predictive Value*, of a hypothesis h is defined as:

$$\text{Precision} = \frac{TP}{TP + FP}.$$

The Precision is the proportion of correct predictions among the examples predicted positive. Note that Recall and Precision are usually in tension: predicting more examples as positive tends to increase the Recall and to decrease the Precision.

In a nutshell

Both measures share the same numerator, TP, but they look at the confusion matrix of Table 2 in two different directions. The Recall reads the first **row**: among the examples that *are* positive, how many did we find? The Precision reads the first **column**: among the examples that we *predicted* positive, how many are really positive? A search engine returning a single, relevant page has a perfect Precision but a poor Recall; one returning the whole web has a perfect Recall but a poor Precision.

Other performance measures Konukoglu and Ganz (2014); Branco et al. (2016) based on the confusion matrix of h are given below:

$$\text{True Negative Rate} = \frac{TN}{TN + FP}, \quad \text{False Negative Rate} = \frac{FN}{FN + TP},$$
$$\text{False Positive Rate} = \frac{FP}{FP + TN}, \quad \text{Negative Predictive Value} = \frac{TN}{TN + FN}.$$

Such measures can be seen as complementary to the Precision and the Recall. Note that the True Negative Rate is also known as *Specificity*, and that False Positive Rate $=$ $1 -$ Specificity and False Negative Rate $= 1 -$ Recall. As shown before, the choice of the metric depends on the user's preferences Torgo and Ribeiro (2007); Torgo and Lopes (2011).

In imbalanced settings, such as fraud detection, it is important to take into account both the Precision and the Recall of the model. This is the goal of the F-measure, introduced in the seventies Rijsbergen (1979).

A Versatile Measure: the F-measure The F-measure is a good performance measure when a user wants to focus on the behavior of a model on a minority class. It is widely used in information retrieval Sanderson (1994) and, of course, in fraud and anomaly detection Gee (2014); Bahnsen et al. (2014); Bolton and Hand (2002). It is defined as a weighted harmonic mean of the Precision and the Recall, and depends on a parameter $\beta > 0$. Denoting by $P = TP + FN$ the number of positive examples, it reads:

$$\begin{aligned} F_\beta &= \frac{(1 + \beta^2)\,\text{Precision} \times \text{Recall}}{\beta^2 \times \text{Precision} + \text{Recall}} \\ &= \frac{(1 + \beta^2)TP}{(1 + \beta^2)TP + \beta^2 FN + FP} = \frac{(1 + \beta^2)(P - FN)}{(1 + \beta^2)P - FN + FP}. \end{aligned}$$

An illustration of the F-measure is given in Figure 52. The F-measure is a flexible measure: by modifying the value of β, the user controls the relative importance of the Precision and the Recall. If $\beta = 1$, the same weight is given to both. If the user wants to give more importance to the Recall, they can choose a value of β greater than one; by choosing $\beta < 1$, they give more importance to the Precision.

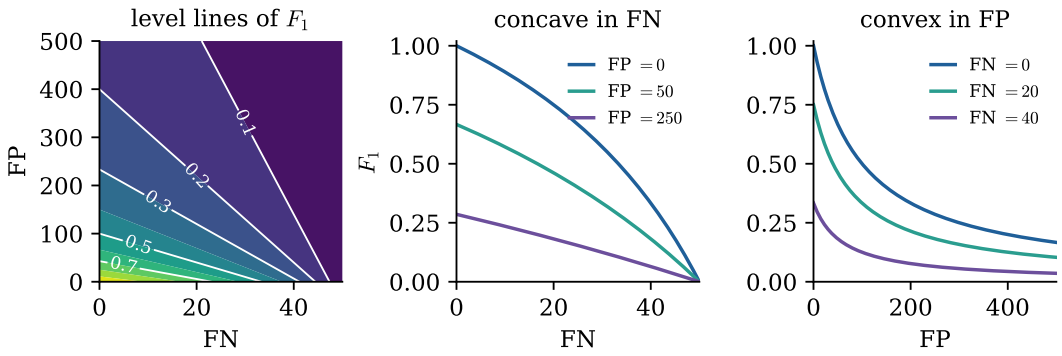


Figure 52: The F-measure F_1 as a function of the numbers of false negatives (FN) and false positives (FP), with 50 positive and 500 negative examples. Left: map of F_1 with some of its level lines, which are straight lines. Middle: sections at a fixed FP, which are concave functions of FN. Right: sections at a fixed FN, which are convex functions of FP. The F-measure is therefore neither convex nor concave in the entries of the confusion matrix.

Example 7.4. Let us consider a sample of 1000 instances in which the minority class represents 1% of the data, so that we have 10 positive examples for 990 negative ones. Let us also consider two hypotheses, h_1 and h_2, with the following confusion matrices:

h_1		Predicted positive	Predicted negative
	Actual positive	TP = 3	FN = 7
	Actual negative	FP = 0	TN = 990

h_2		Predicted positive	Predicted negative
	Actual positive	TP = 9	FN = 1
	Actual negative	FP = 6	TN = 984

Both classifiers have the same error rate, $7/1000 = 0.7\%$, which is less than 1%. The first classifier, h_1, has a Precision equal to 1 and a Recall equal to 0.3, while for the second classifier, h_2, these two values are respectively equal to $9/15 = 0.6$ and 0.9. These two classifiers lead to very different F-measures (with $\beta = 1$): $2 \times 0.3/1.3 \approx 0.46$ for the first hypothesis and $2 \times 0.54/1.5 = 0.72$ for the second one. Despite the perfect Precision reached by the first classifier, its F-measure remains lower than the one achieved by h_2.

Despite its usefulness in imbalanced scenarios, the F-measure remains, compared to the Accuracy, hard to optimize. It presents two main drawbacks: (i) it is non-linear in the entries of the confusion matrix and (ii) it is neither convex nor concave in these entries, as depicted in Figure 52: for a fixed FP, it is a concave function of FN, while for a fixed FN, it is a convex function of FP. Because of (i), the F-measure cannot be written as an average of losses over the examples, which makes it hard to derive generalization guarantees for it. Moreover, like the accuracy, it is computed from counts of errors and is thus piecewise constant with respect to the parameters of the model, so standard

gradient descent algorithms cannot be used to optimize it directly. Because of (ii), the optimization problems obtained when the F-measure is expressed as a function of the parameters of the model are non-convex, and an optimization algorithm can get stuck in local optima that may be far from the optimal solution. However, the literature offers many studies and algorithms dealing with this task Zhao et al. (2013); Busa-Fekete et al. (2015).

7.2.3 Other Performance Measures

The *Class Weighted Accuracy*, denoted by CWA and proposed by Cohen et al. (2006), is similar in spirit to the F-measure. However, it no longer involves the Precision but the Specificity instead, which, like the Precision, penalizes false positives. It is expressed as a convex combination of the Sensitivity (*i.e.* the Recall) and the Specificity: for any $\alpha \in [0, 1]$,

$$CWA = \alpha \times \text{Sensitivity} + (1 - \alpha) \times \text{Specificity}.$$

As for the parameter β of the F-measure, the user chooses the value of the parameter α. With $\alpha = 1/2$, it is called the *balanced accuracy*; the trivial classifier of the example above then gets a score of only 0.5.

Another evaluation metric used in imbalanced scenarios is the G-mean. As for the Class Weighted Accuracy, its expression depends on both Sensitivity and Specificity: it is the square root of the product (*i.e.* the geometric mean) of these two quantities:

$$\text{G-mean} = \sqrt{\text{Specificity} \times \text{Sensitivity}}.$$

This measure is used in imbalanced scenarios because it takes into account the performance on both classes, while giving the same importance to each class.

A last popular evaluation metric used in imbalanced scenarios is the AUC ROC Metz (1978); Cortes and Mohri (2004), the "Area Under the Receiver Operating Characteristic curve". This metric is used when the learned model returns a score, such as a confidence in its prediction, and an example is predicted positive when its score exceeds a threshold. Each value of the threshold gives a pair (False Positive Rate, Recall); the ROC curve is obtained by plotting the Recall (True Positive Rate) against the False Positive Rate for all possible thresholds, *i.e.* for all the scores obtained by the model on the examples (see Figure 54). The AUC is the area under this curve: it equals 1 for a perfect ranking and 0.5 for a random one, and it can be interpreted as the probability that a randomly drawn positive example gets a higher score than a randomly drawn negative example. The closer to 1 the AUC, the better the model.

More precisely, let $f(\mathbf{x})$ denote the score of the model, and let $h_t(\mathbf{x}) = 1$ if $f(\mathbf{x}) \geq t$ and -1 otherwise be the classifier obtained with the threshold t. Denoting by m_+ and m_- the numbers of positive and negative examples, the ROC curve is the set of points

$$(\text{FPR}(t),\, \text{TPR}(t)) = \left(\frac{1}{m_-} \sum_{i:\, y_i = -1} \mathbb{1}[f(\mathbf{x}_i) \geq t]\,,\ \frac{1}{m_+} \sum_{i:\, y_i = 1} \mathbb{1}[f(\mathbf{x}_i) \geq t] \right), \quad t \in \mathbb{R}.$$

When t decreases from $+\infty$ to $-\infty$, more and more examples are predicted positive, and the point moves from $(0, 0)$ (everything is predicted negative) to $(1, 1)$ (everything

is predicted positive), as illustrated in Figure 53. Each positive example that passes the threshold moves the curve up by $1/m_+$, and each negative example moves it right by $1/m_-$: the curve is therefore a staircase, and it only depends on the *ranking* of the examples induced by the scores, not on the values of the scores themselves. Counting, for each positive example, the proportion of negative examples with a lower score, one obtains the equivalent expression

$$\text{AUC} = \frac{1}{m_+ m_-} \sum_{i:\, y_i=1} \sum_{j:\, y_j=-1} \mathbb{1}[f(\mathbf{x}_i) > f(\mathbf{x}_j)]$$

(ties being counted for 1/2), which is exactly the probabilistic interpretation given above Fawcett (2006).

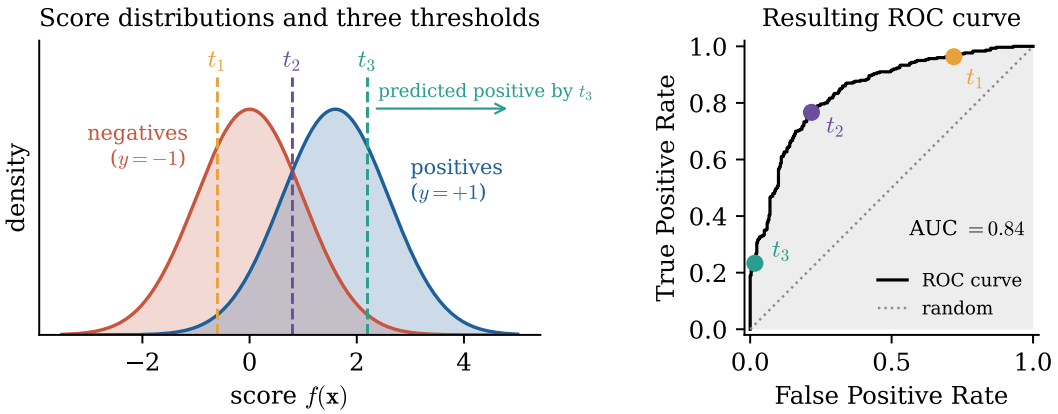


Figure 53: Construction of a ROC curve. Left: distribution of the scores of the negative and positive examples. A threshold t predicts positive every example on its right; the proportion of positive (resp. negative) examples on its right is the True (resp. False) Positive Rate. Right: each threshold gives one point of the ROC curve; a high threshold t_3 gives few false positives but a low recall, a low threshold t_1 the opposite. The more the two distributions overlap, the closer the curve to the diagonal.

> **Historical note** ROC curves come from *signal detection theory*, developed during the Second World War to analyze radar signals: an operator had to decide whether a blip on the screen was an enemy aircraft (a "signal") or noise, and the curve described the trade-off between detections and false alarms, hence the name *Receiver Operating Characteristic*. They were then adopted in psychology and in medical diagnosis Metz (1978), before becoming a standard tool in machine learning Fawcett (2006).

Compared to the previous measures, the ROC curve allows us to visualize the performance of the model for all thresholds at once. Furthermore, it is often used to choose the appropriate threshold for the task at hand. It also makes it possible to plot several models on a single graph and to choose the one best suited to a given purpose. The ideal model is the one that achieves a True Positive Rate equal to 1 while the False Positive Rate remains equal to 0, *i.e.* a model for which all the examples of the minority class have a greater score than the examples of the majority class.

There exist other measures used in imbalanced scenarios, such as the Average Precision, the H-measure or the Precision-Recall curve, to cite a few Frery et al. (2017);

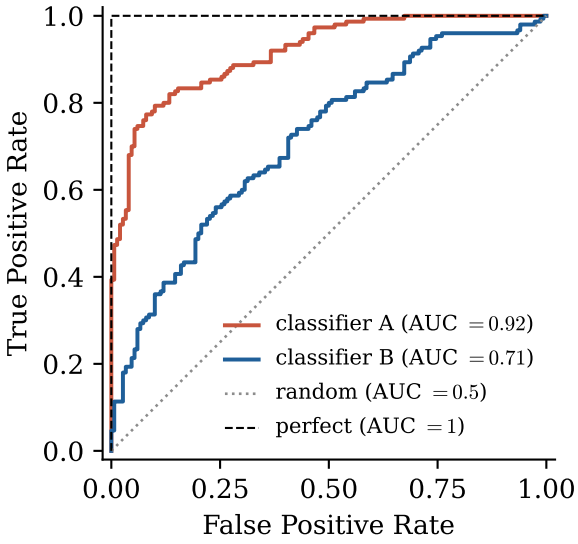


Figure 54: ROC curves and AUC of two classifiers evaluated on the same 300 examples. The curve of classifier A (red) lies above that of classifier B (blue) almost everywhere, hence a larger AUC. The dotted diagonal corresponds to a random ranking, the dashed line to a perfect one.

Ferri et al. (2009); Jeni et al. (2013); Branco et al. (2016); Behl et al. (2014). Although most of them were designed for imbalanced tasks, they can also be used to evaluate performance in standard contexts. The *Precision-Recall curve* is built exactly like the ROC curve, by moving the threshold t, but it plots the Precision against the Recall; the area under this curve is usually estimated by the *Average Precision* (AP).

> **Pitfall: a ROC curve can hide a poor Precision** The True and False Positive Rates are each computed within one class, so the ROC curve and the AUC do not depend on the class proportions. This is a strength when comparing models across datasets, but it can be misleading in a strongly imbalanced setting: a False Positive Rate of 5% looks small, yet with 99 negatives for each positive it means about five false alarms for each positive example of the dataset. The Precision, on the contrary, involves both classes and directly reveals this problem. In Figure 55, the scores of each class have the same distribution in both datasets: the ROC curves are identical, whereas the Precision-Recall curves are very different. When the positive class is rare, the Precision-Recall curve is therefore more informative Davis and Goadrich (2006); Saito and Rehmsmeier (2015). Note also that the curve of a random classifier is the diagonal in ROC space, but a horizontal line at the proportion of positives in Precision-Recall space.

Multi-class setting. The Accuracy and the Error rate extend directly to $q > 2$ classes, as the proportions of well-classified and misclassified examples, and the confusion matrix becomes a $q \times q$ table. The other measures (Recall, Precision, F-measure, ...) are computed for each class c by considering c as the positive class and all the other classes as the negative one (*one-versus-rest*); the q values obtained are then averaged, either with equal weights (*macro-averaging*) or by first summing the TP, FP and FN counts over the classes (*micro-averaging*).

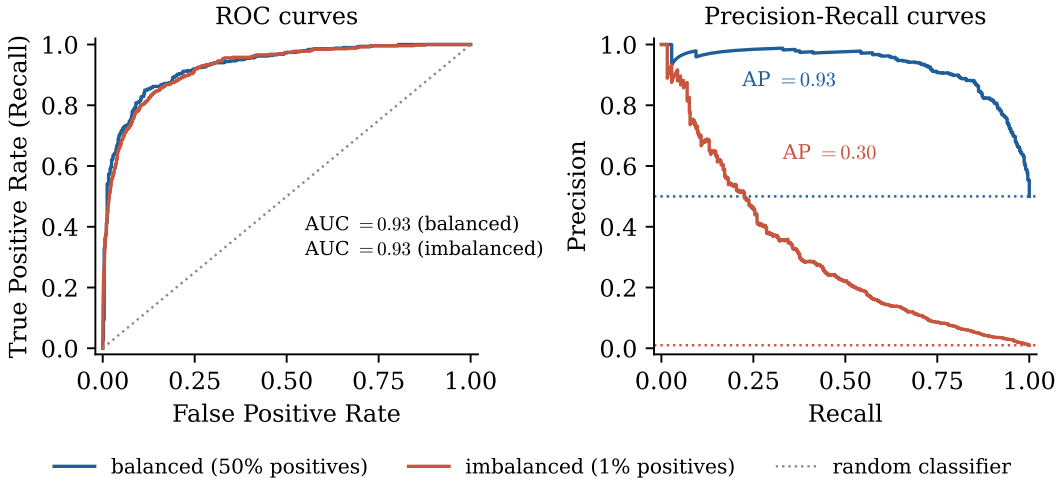


Figure 55: ROC curves (left) and Precision-Recall curves (right) of the same scoring function on a balanced dataset (500 positives, 500 negatives) and on an imbalanced one (500 positives, 49,500 negatives). The AUC is unchanged, but the Average Precision drops from 0.93 to 0.30. The dotted horizontal lines give the Precision of a random classifier, *i.e.* the proportion of positives.

Now that we have explained how to learn, tune and evaluate a model in general, it is time to present some fundamental algorithms of supervised Machine Learning.

To remember from Section 7

- The parameters are learned on the learning set, the hyper-parameters are chosen on a validation set (or by k-fold cross-validation on the training set), and the test set is used **once**, at the end, to estimate the performance of the final model.
- Validation and learning curves compare the training and validation scores to diagnose under-fitting (both are poor) and over-fitting (large gap).
- Any step estimated from the data (scaling, imputation, feature selection, resampling) belongs to the learning procedure and must be fitted on the learning data only; otherwise, there is a data leakage and the evaluation is optimistic.
- In regression, the MSE penalizes large errors much more than the MAE, which is more robust to outliers.
- In classification, the accuracy is misleading on imbalanced data; the Recall (row of the confusion matrix), the Precision (column), the F_β-measure, the balanced accuracy or the G-mean focus on the minority class.
- The ROC curve is obtained by moving the threshold of a scoring function; its area is the probability that a positive example is ranked above a negative one. When positives are rare, the Precision-Recall curve is more informative.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q7.9. On a dataset with 1% of positives, what are the accuracy, the Recall and the balanced accuracy of the classifier that always predicts the negative class?

Q7.10. A model has an AUC of 0.5. What does it mean? Why can a model with an AUC of 0.95 still be useless when positives are very rare?

Q7.11. The residuals of a regression model on four examples are $2, -2, 0, 0$. Compute its MSE, RMSE and MAE.

Q7.12. True or false? The coefficient R^2 of a model computed on a test set always lies in $[0, 1]$.

Q7.13. A classifier gives $TP = 40$, $FN = 10$, $FP = 20$ and $TN = 930$. Compute its accuracy, Recall, Precision and F_1.

Q7.14. True or false? The F_1-measure always lies between the Precision and the Recall.

Q7.15. What does F_β become when $\beta \to 0$ and when $\beta \to +\infty$?

Q7.16. What happens to the ROC curve and to the AUC if all the scores $f(\mathbf{x}_i)$ are replaced by $\exp(f(\mathbf{x}_i))$? By $-f(\mathbf{x}_i)$?

Exercises

Exercise 7.1. **(Comprehension)** A dataset has been split into a learning set, a validation set and a test set. For each of the following quantities, say on which set(s) it must be computed or chosen, and why: (a) the weights of a logistic regression; (b) the number of neighbors k of a k-NN classifier; (c) the means and standard deviations used to standardize the features; (d) the choice between a random forest and an SVM; (e) the decision threshold applied to the scores of a classifier; (f) the accuracy reported in the final report.

Exercise 7.2. **(Computation)** The two hyper-parameters of a model are chosen in a grid of 3×4 values by 5-fold cross-validation, and the whole procedure is evaluated by a 5-fold nested cross-validation (Section 11.5). How many models are learned in total, including the final one?

Exercise 7.3. **(Proof)** Let $y_1, \dots, y_m$ be real numbers and consider the constant predictors $\hat{y}_i = c$ for all i. (a) Show that the constant c minimizing the MSE is the mean $\bar{y}$, and that the minimal MSE is the empirical variance of the y_i. (b) Show that any median of the y_i minimizes the MAE. *Hint:* study the slope of $c \mapsto \sum_i |y_i - c|$. (c) Compute the two optimal constants and the MSE and MAE of each of them for the values $1, 2, 3, 4, 100$. Comment.

Exercise 7.4. **(Computation)** (a) Show that $R^2 = 1 - MSE_h / \hat{\sigma}_y^2$, where $\hat{\sigma}_y^2 = \frac{1}{m}\sum_i (y_i - \bar{y})^2$. What is the R^2 of the constant predictor $\bar{y}$? (b) On a test set of $m = 5$ examples, the targets are $y = (3, 5, 7, 9, 11)$ and a model predicts $\hat{y} = (4, 5, 6, 10, 10)$. Compute its MSE, RMSE, MAE and R^2. (c) A second model predicts $\hat{y} = (11, 9, 7, 5, 3)$. Compute its R^2 and comment.

Exercise 7.5. **(Computation)** Compute the Specificity, the balanced accuracy and the G-mean of the hypotheses h_1 and h_2 of the example of the F-measure. Do these measures rank the two hypotheses as the F-measure does?

Exercise 7.6. **(Proof)** Let P and R denote the Precision and the Recall of a classifier, with $P, R > 0$, and $\beta > 0$. (a) Starting from $\frac{1}{F_\beta} = \frac{1}{1+\beta^2}\left(\frac{1}{P} + \frac{\beta^2}{R}\right)$ (a weighted harmonic mean), derive the two expressions of F_β given in the notes. (b) Show that $\min(P, R) \leq F_\beta \leq \max(P, R)$. (c) Show that $F_1 \leq (P + R)/2$, with equality if and only if $P = R$. (d) A classifier has $P = 0.9$ and $R = 0.3$. Compute $F_{0.5}$, F_1 and F_2, and explain the order of these values.

Exercise 7.7. **(Proof)** We consider a set with P positive examples and see F_β as a function of $(FN, FP) \in [0, P] \times [0, +\infty)$:

$$F_\beta(FN, FP) = \frac{(1+\beta^2)(P - FN)}{(1+\beta^2)P - FN + FP}.$$

(a) Show that, for any $c \in (0, 1)$, the level set $\{F_\beta = c\}$ is a segment of straight line, and that all these lines go through the point $(FN, FP) = (P, -\beta^2 P)$. Check this on Figure 52. (b) Show that, for a fixed FN, F_β is a convex function of FP. (c) Show that, for a fixed FP, F_β is a concave function of FN. *Hint:* write $F_\beta = (1 + \beta^2) - \dfrac{(1+\beta^2)(\beta^2 P + FP)}{(1+\beta^2)P - FN + FP}$. (d) Conclude that F_β is neither convex nor concave on its domain.

Exercise 7.8. **(Proof)** Let $\pi = m_+/m$ be the proportion of positive examples of a set, TPR the Recall and TNR the Specificity of a classifier on this set. (a) Show that Accuracy $= \pi\, TPR + (1 - \pi)\, TNR$. Which Class Weighted Accuracy is the accuracy? (b) Deduce that the accuracy of a classifier is close to its Specificity when π is small, and explain why the accuracy is not suited to imbalanced data. (c) Show that the balanced accuracy of a classifier that predicts the positive class with probability q, independently of $\mathbf{x}$, is $1/2$ for every $q \in [0, 1]$. What is its accuracy?

Exercise 7.9. **(Computation)** A classifier is evaluated on 120 examples of 3 classes. Its confu-

sion matrix (rows: true classes, columns: predicted classes) is

	pred. 1	pred. 2	pred. 3
class 1	50	5	5
class 2	10	20	10
class 3	0	5	15

(a) Compute the accuracy. (b) For each class, compute the Recall, the Precision and the F_1-measure in the one-versus-rest setting. (c) Compute the macro-averaged F_1 and the micro-averaged F_1. Show that, in a multi-class problem where each example receives exactly one label, the micro-averaged F_1 is always equal to the accuracy.

Exercise 7.10. **(Computation)** A model gives the scores 0.9, 0.7 and 0.4 to three positive examples, and the scores 0.8, 0.3 and 0.2 to three negative examples. Draw its ROC curve and compute its AUC in two ways: as an area, and by counting the pairs (positive, negative) that are correctly ranked.

Exercise 7.11. **(Proof)** We assume that the $m = m_+ + m_-$ scores $f(\mathbf{x}_i)$ are pairwise distinct. (a) Show that the vertical step of the ROC curve due to a positive example $\mathbf{x}_i$ occurs at the abscissa $\frac{1}{m_-}\text{card}\{j : y_j = -1,\ f(\mathbf{x}_j) > f(\mathbf{x}_i)\}$. (b) Deduce that the area under the ROC curve equals $\dfrac{1}{m_+ m_-} \displaystyle\sum_{i:\, y_i=1} \sum_{j:\, y_j=-1} \mathbb{1}[f(\mathbf{x}_i) > f(\mathbf{x}_j)]$. (c) Deduce that, if the scores are replaced by $-f(\mathbf{x}_i)$, the AUC becomes $1 - \text{AUC}$.

Exercise 7.12. **(Application)** A classifier gives the following scores to 10 validation examples, sorted by decreasing score (label 1 for the positive class):

score	0.95	0.85	0.80	0.70	0.60	0.55	0.40	0.30	0.20	0.10
label	1	1	0	1	0	1	0	0	1	0

(a) For the thresholds $t \in \{0.9, 0.75, 0.65, 0.5, 0.35, 0.15\}$ (an example is predicted positive when its score is $\geq t$), compute the Precision, the Recall and the F_1-measure. (b) Which threshold maximizes F_1? Which one would you choose if a false negative is much more costly than a false positive? (c) Compute the AUC of the classifier. (d) Why must the threshold chosen in (b) not be chosen on the test set?

Exercise 7.13. **(Python)** Implement a 5-fold cross-validation "by hand" (with `numpy` only for the splits) to choose the number of neighbors $k \in \{1, 3, 5, 7, 9, 15, 25, 51\}$ of a k-NN classifier, preceded by a standardization, on the `breast_cancer` dataset of `scikit-learn`. Check that you obtain the same scores as `cross_val_score` with the same folds. Where must the standardization be fitted?

Exercise 7.14. **(Python)** Reproduce the experiment of Figure 50 for one run: draw $m = 50$ examples with 2000 independent Gaussian features and random balanced labels, and estimate the accuracy of a logistic regression learned on the 20 features that are the most correlated with the labels (`SelectKBest(f_classif, k=20)`), (a) when the selection is made once on the whole dataset before the 5-fold cross-validation, (b) when it is made inside the cross-validation. Explain the difference.

8 Supervised Algorithms

About this section

Guiding question. *Given a labeled sample, which classical algorithms can we use, what do they optimize, and how do their hyperparameters control their behavior?*

In this section you will learn to:

- *explain why convex surrogate losses replace the 0-1 loss, and recognize the hinge, logistic and exponential losses;*
- *use the k-NN rule, and anticipate the effect of k, of the scaling of the features and of the dimension;*
- *derive the hard and soft margin SVM problems and their dual, and use the kernel trick to obtain nonlinear classifiers;*
- *fit linear, logistic and multinomial logistic regression models, with L_1 or L_2 regularization;*
- *build a kernel regression estimator and a decision tree, and relate their hyperparameters (bandwidth, depth) to the bias-variance trade-off.*

8.1 Surrogate losses

In Section 6, generalization bounds based on uniform deviations were presented for a loss function ℓ taking its values in $[0, 1]$, typically the 0-1 loss in the context of classification. However, as we have already pointed out, this loss is hard to optimize from an algorithmic point of view because it is neither convex nor differentiable. We therefore rather use convex (and sometimes differentiable) relaxations of it, called *surrogate losses*, to learn our hypothesis $h(\cdot, \cdot)$, whose two arguments are respectively the parameters $\mathbf{w}$ of the model and an input $\mathbf{x}$. When the parameters are clear from the context, we simply write $h(\mathbf{x})$. The 0-1 loss and some of its surrogates are represented in Figure 56; they are all written as functions of the quantity $yh(\mathbf{x})$, which is positive when the prediction is correct and negative otherwise.

Among these surrogates, the *hinge loss* is the one used to train a Support Vector Machine Boser et al. (1992); Vapnik and Cortes (1995). It is used for classification tasks and is defined by

$$\begin{aligned}\ell(h(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}), y) &= [1 - yh(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x})]_+ \\ &= \max(0, 1 - yh(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x})).\end{aligned}$$

Another well-known surrogate is the *exponential loss*, which is widely used in the context of boosting Friedman et al. (2000):

$$\ell(h(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}), y) = \exp(-yh(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x})).$$

Compared to the hinge loss, the exponential loss penalizes errors much more heavily (the penalty grows exponentially with the size of the error) and it never equals 0.

Finally, the *logistic loss*, used to train a logistic regression model Mohri et al. (2012), is defined by

$$\ell(h(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}), y) = \frac{1}{\ln(2)} \ln\left(1 + \exp(-yh(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}))\right).$$

The constant $1/\ln(2)$ is only a normalization ensuring that the loss equals 1 when $yh(\mathbf{w},\mathbf{x}) = 0$, as the 0-1 loss does; it is often omitted. Note that this definition holds when $y \in \{-1,1\}$ and $h(\mathbf{w},\mathbf{x}) \in \mathbb{R}$. There is another, equivalent, definition when we focus on the probability of belonging to one class or the other, *i.e.* when $y \in \{0,1\}$ and the score $h(\mathbf{w},\mathbf{x}) \in \mathbb{R}$ is turned into a probability $\sigma(h(\mathbf{w},\mathbf{x})) \in [0,1]$ with the logistic function $\sigma(t) = 1/(1+\exp(-t))$. This variant Cox (1958), also called the *cross-entropy* loss, is defined by

$$\ell(h(\mathbf{w},\mathbf{x}),y) = -y \ln\left(\frac{1}{1+\exp(-h(\mathbf{w},\mathbf{x}))}\right) - (1-y)\ln\left(1 - \frac{1}{1+\exp(-h(\mathbf{w},\mathbf{x}))}\right).$$

One can check that, up to the constant $1/\ln(2)$, both definitions coincide when the label $y \in \{0,1\}$ is mapped to $2y-1 \in \{-1,1\}$: for $y=1$ the loss is $\ln(1+\exp(-h(\mathbf{w},\mathbf{x})))$, and for $y=0$ it is $\ln(1+\exp(h(\mathbf{w},\mathbf{x})))$.

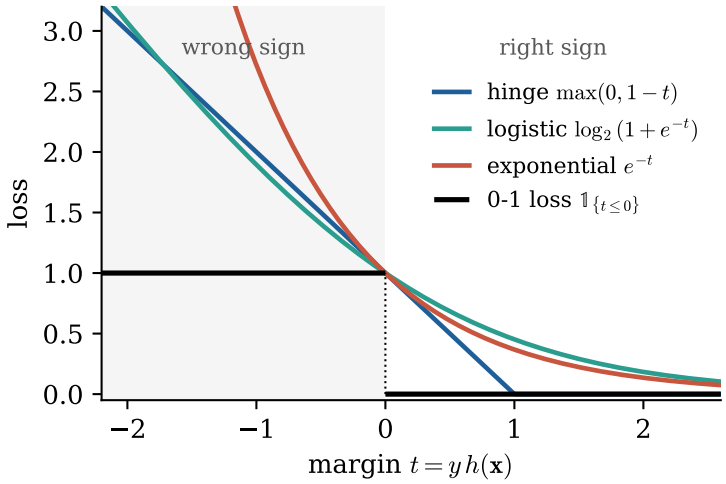


Figure 56: Examples of loss functions used for classification tasks, as functions of the margin $t = yh(\mathbf{x})$: the 0-1 loss, the hinge loss (used by the SVM algorithm), the normalized logistic loss (used for logistic regression) and the exponential loss (used in the context of boosting). All the surrogates upper bound the 0-1 loss and are convex.

We now present the main algorithms used in supervised learning.

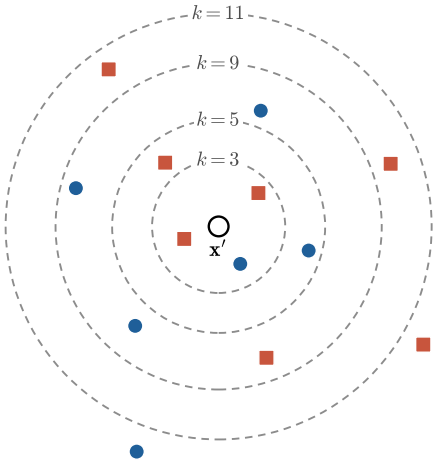
8.2 k-Nearest Neighbors

A description of the algorithm The k-Nearest Neighbors algorithm (k-NN) Cover and Hart (1967) is a nonparametric method: it does not make any assumption on the underlying distribution of the data. To predict the label of a new instance $\mathbf{x}'$, it computes the "distances" between this new query $\mathbf{x}'$ and all the samples $\mathbf{x}_i \in S$. Then, for a chosen value of k, it looks for the k nearest neighbors of $\mathbf{x}'$ and predicts the label of $\mathbf{x}'$ by a majority vote, *i.e.*

$$\hat{y}(\mathbf{x}') = \arg\max_{y \in \mathcal{Y}} \frac{k_y}{k},$$

where k_y denotes the number of neighbors of $\mathbf{x}'$, among the k nearest ones, whose label is y. In other words, the predicted label $\hat{y}(\mathbf{x}')$ is the most represented class in the k-neighborhood of the new query $\mathbf{x}'$.

Example 8.1. An example of the use of the k-NN algorithm is depicted in Figure 57. It shows how much the prediction for a new instance depends on the choice of k. In this example, the new point is close to points of both classes, which is why its prediction varies with k: it is predicted "red" (class -1) when k is equal to 3 or 5, "blue" (class $+1$) when $k = 9$, and "red" again when $k = 11$.



k	votes	prediction
3	1 / 2	-1
5	2 / 3	-1
9	5 / 4	$+1$
11	5 / 6	-1

(blue / red)

Figure 57: Illustration of the k-NN algorithm with the Euclidean distance. Left: a query $\mathbf{x}'$ (white disc) and the training points of the two classes; the dashed circles contain its k nearest neighbors. Right: number of votes for each class and predicted label. The prediction depends on the value of k.

For small values of k, for instance $k = 1$, the algorithm assigns to the new example $\mathbf{x}'$ the label of its closest example in the training set: similar examples are assumed to share the same label. This rule is the simplest one, and it has been shown Cover and Hart (1967) that, when m tends to infinity, its error rate is at most twice the Bayes error, *i.e.* the smallest error that can be achieved given the distribution of the data. Conversely, when we increase the value of k, the decision becomes smoother. When k is very large (typically when $k = m$), the label given to any new example is simply the majority class of the dataset. This raises an important question: *which value of k should we choose?* In practice, we usually rely on a cross-validation procedure to select the best value of k.

In a nutshell

The k-NN rule is a "tell me who your neighbors are" principle, and k is its complexity knob, as shown in Figure 58. With $k = 1$, the decision regions follow every training point, including the noisy ones: the training error is 0 but the boundary is very irregular (low bias, high variance, overfitting). With a very large k, each prediction averages over a large part of the sample: the boundary becomes almost straight and misses the curved structure of the classes (high bias, low variance, underfitting). An intermediate value achieves the best test error. Note that, contrary to most models, the complexity *decreases* when the hyperparameter k increases.

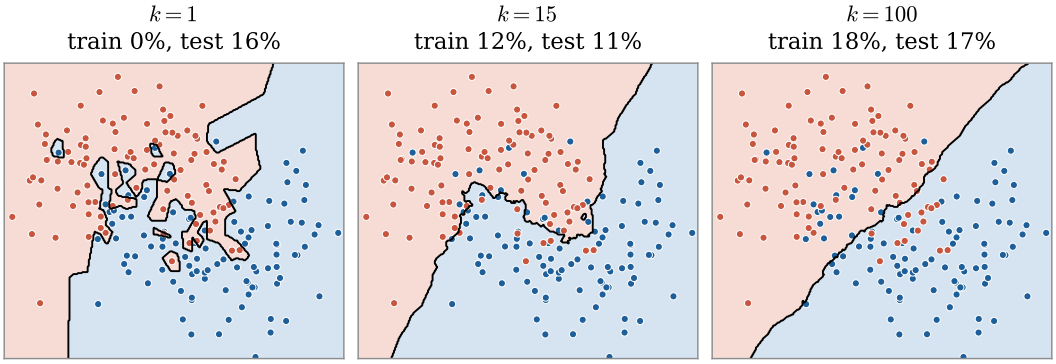


Figure 58: Decision regions of the k-NN rule on a noisy two-moons dataset ($m = 200$) for $k = 1$, 15 and 100. The training error increases with k, while the test error (estimated on 5000 new points) is the smallest for the intermediate value.

Some problems The dimension d of the data and the choice of the distance are also important for this algorithm. Indeed, when dealing with high-dimensional data, some features (or attributes), possibly non-informative ones, can have a huge impact on the computation of the distance. This leads to a classification based on irrelevant features and to poor performance. Furthermore, some features can weigh more in the distance computation simply because they take larger values than the other ones. Most of the time, the distance we use is the Euclidean one, *i.e.* for $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}' \in \mathbb{R}^d$:

$$d_2^2(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}'\|_2^2 = \sum_{j=1}^{d} (x_j - x'_j)^2.$$

Example 8.2. Let us consider the following dataset, described by three features:

y	x_1	x_2	x_3
1	0.3	0.89	232
-1	-0.1	0.23	652
-1	0.2	0.7	122
1	0.3	-0.8	232

If we compute the Euclidean distance between the first and the second examples, we get

$$\begin{aligned} d_2^2(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2) &= \|\mathbf{x}_1 - \mathbf{x}_2\|_2^2 \\ &= \sum_{j=1}^{d} (x_{1j} - x_{2j})^2 \\ &= (0.3 + 0.1)^2 + (0.89 - 0.23)^2 + (232 - 652)^2 \\ &\simeq (232 - 652)^2. \end{aligned}$$

The first two features have almost no impact on the computed distance, which only depends on the third one.

To overcome this issue, we can change the distance we use. We can, for instance,

use the Manhattan distance (associated with the L_1-norm)[9], *i.e.* for $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}' \in \mathbb{R}^d$:

$$d_1(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}'\|_1 = \sum_{j=1}^{d} |x_j - x'_j|.$$

We can also give a weight w_j to each feature, according to the influence we want it to have. For instance, if a feature is known to be noisy, we can give it a weight close to 0, whereas if it is known to be informative, we can give it a weight close to 1; the weighted Euclidean distance is then $\sqrt{\sum_{j=1}^{d} w_j (x_j - x'_j)^2}$. The choice of the weights can be guided by domain knowledge.

Finally, another method consists in rescaling the data, so that all the features take their values in the same range or have the same mean and variance. The most common transformations are the following:

- **Standardization (also called normalization or z-score):** for each feature vector $\mathbf{v}_j$, we compute
$$\mathbf{v}_j \leftarrow \frac{\mathbf{v}_j - \mu_j}{\sigma_j},$$
where μ_j and σ_j are respectively the mean and the standard deviation of the feature vector $\mathbf{v}_j$.
- **Rescaling to the hypercube $[-1, 1]^d$:** for each feature vector $\mathbf{v}_j$, we compute
$$\mathbf{v}_j \leftarrow 2 \times \frac{\mathbf{v}_j - \min \mathbf{v}_j}{\max \mathbf{v}_j - \min \mathbf{v}_j} - 1.$$
- **Rescaling to the hypercube $[0, 1]^d$ (also called min-max normalization):** for each feature vector $\mathbf{v}_j$, we compute
$$\mathbf{v}_j \leftarrow \frac{\mathbf{v}_j - \min \mathbf{v}_j}{\max \mathbf{v}_j - \min \mathbf{v}_j}.$$

The first transformation centers and scales the data, so that each feature has zero mean and unit variance, *i.e.* for all $j \in [\![1, d]\!]$, the empirical mean of $\mathbf{v}_j$ is 0 and its empirical variance is 1 (note that it does not make the data normally distributed: it only fixes the first two moments). The second and third transformations are very similar: they simply shift and rescale the values of each feature so that they lie in the interval $[-1, 1]$ or $[0, 1]$, respectively.

With the first transformation, all the features have the same variance and thus the same weight in the distance (implicitly, they are all considered as carrying the same quantity of information). This is not the case when we only rescale the features to a hypercube.

[9] Note that all these distances are particular cases of the distance induced by the L_p-norm, defined for all $p \geq 1$ and all $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}' \in \mathbb{R}^d$ by

$$d_p(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}'\|_p = \sqrt[p]{\sum_{j=1}^{d} |x_j - x'_j|^p}.$$

Algorithm 2: k-Nearest Neighbors

Input: training set $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$; an example $\mathbf{x}'$ to classify; the number k of nearest neighbors

Output: the predicted label $\hat{y}(\mathbf{x}')$

for $i = 1, \ldots, m$ **do**
    compute the distance $d(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}')$;
sort the distances in increasing order;
keep the k nearest neighbors of $\mathbf{x}'$ in S;
count the number of occurrences of each class among these k neighbors;
set $\hat{y}(\mathbf{x}')$ to the most frequent class;

Example 8.3. Let us consider the data of Example 8.2 and apply the first transformation (standardization, on the left, using the unbiased estimate of the standard deviation) and the third one (min-max normalization, on the right) to this dataset.

y	x_1	x_2	x_3
1	0.66	0.84	-0.33
-1	-1.45	-0.03	1.46
-1	0.13	0.59	-0.80
1	0.66	-1.40	-0.33

y	x_1	x_2	x_3
1	1	1	0.21
-1	0	0.61	1
-1	0.75	0.89	0
1	1	0	0.21

After either transformation, the three features contribute to the distance on a comparable scale.

Pitfall: forgetting to scale, or scaling with the test set This last suggestion applies to all the algorithms based on a distance or on an inner product (k-NN, SVM, kernel methods, regularized regressions, neural networks): rescaling the data with one of the above methods can be done before using any other learning algorithm. In practice, data normalization or scaling is almost always performed, so keep it in mind when you run experiments. It generally improves the performance of the algorithms when no expert is available to tell us how important the features are. On a practical level, it also makes it easier to compare algorithms with one another.
Be careful, however: the quantities μ_j, σ_j, $\min \mathbf{v}_j$ and $\max \mathbf{v}_j$ must be computed on the *training set only*, and then applied unchanged to the validation and test examples (and, within a cross-validation, recomputed on each training fold). Computing them on the whole dataset lets information about the test set leak into the model and gives over-optimistic performance estimates (see Section 7). Decision trees, on the other hand, are insensitive to such monotone rescalings of the features, since their splits only depend on the order of the values.

Algorithm and complexity The k-NN procedure is described in Algorithm 2. As the reader may notice, to predict the class of a new instance $\mathbf{x}'$, we need to keep the whole training set in memory and to compute the distance between the new example and every training instance.

As a consequence, the prediction of a single example costs $\mathcal{O}(md)$ operations to compute the distances, plus $\mathcal{O}(m \log m)$ operations to sort them (or only $\mathcal{O}(mk)$ if we

Algorithm 3: Condensed Nearest Neighbor

Input: training set $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$
Output: a smaller sample $S' \subset S$

$S' \leftarrow \emptyset$;
select an example of S at random, remove it from S and add it to S';
repeat
  foreach *example* $(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i) \in S$ **do**
    if $\mathbf{x}_i$ *is misclassified by the* 1*-NN rule based on* S' **then**
      add $(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)$ to S' and remove it from S;
    else
      keep $(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)$ in S;
until *no example has been added to* S' *during a full pass over* S;

simply extract the k smallest distances). Furthermore, the memory required by the algorithm is in $\mathcal{O}(md)$, since the whole training set must be stored. This short analysis shows that this algorithm is not well suited to large datasets.

Pitfall: the curse of dimensionality The k-NN rule relies on the idea that a query has close neighbors in the training set. This idea breaks down when the dimension d grows, a phenomenon called the *curse of dimensionality* Bellman (1961). Consider data uniformly distributed in the unit hypercube $[0, 1]^d$, and a small hypercube around a query containing a fraction r of the data. Its edge length is $r^{1/d}$: to capture only 1% of the data, we need an edge of length $0.01^{1/2} = 0.1$ in dimension 2, but $0.01^{1/10} \simeq 0.63$ in dimension 10 and $0.01^{1/100} \simeq 0.95$ in dimension 100 Hastie et al. (2009). The "neighborhood" then covers almost the whole range of every feature and is no longer local. Moreover, in high dimension, the distances from a query to its nearest and to its farthest neighbors tend to become similar Beyer et al. (1999), so that the notion of nearest neighbor loses its meaning. Feature selection, dimensionality reduction or metric learning are then needed before applying k-NN.

Refinements of the algorithm As we have seen, one drawback of this algorithm is that it needs to store the entire dataset and to compute the distances to all the training samples to predict the label of a new one. However, we can reduce the computation time and the memory footprint with approaches based on the triangle inequality Elkan (2003), on structured partitions of the space such as k-d trees Bentley (1975), or by selecting the most relevant instances of the training set, as in the *Condensed Nearest Neighbor* algorithm Hart (1968) presented in Algorithm 3. This algorithm selects a subset S' of the training set S such that the 1-NN rule based on S' classifies the examples almost as accurately as the 1-NN rule based on the whole dataset S.

Other refinements of the k-NN algorithm exist; the most common one is the weighted k-Nearest Neighbors algorithm Dudani (1976). The idea is simple and consists in assigning a weight to each neighbor in the vote. A standard choice is the inverse of the distance to the query Liu and Chawla (2011): in this way, we give less importance to the examples that are far from the tested one.

Example 8.4. Let us consider an example $\mathbf{x}'$ that we aim to classify with the 3-NN rule, its three nearest neighbors being $(\mathbf{x}_1, y_1)$, $(\mathbf{x}_2, y_2)$ and $(\mathbf{x}_3, y_3)$. Their labels and their distances to $\mathbf{x}'$ are given below:

Example	$\mathbf{x}_1$	$\mathbf{x}_2$	$\mathbf{x}_3$
Label	1	1	0
Distance	3	4	1

If we follow the classical decision rule of this algorithm, we predict that $\mathbf{x}'$ belongs to class 1, since two of its three nearest neighbors belong to this class. This corresponds to the case where every neighbor has the same weight in the decision.

Let us now give each neighbor a weight equal to the inverse of its distance to $\mathbf{x}'$. In this case, the sum of the weights associated with the label 0 is equal to 1, whereas it is only $\frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{4} = \frac{7}{12} < 1$ for the label 1. Once the weights of the voters are taken into account[10], the new example $\mathbf{x}'$ is therefore given the label 0.

Such a decision rule can be relevant when some regions of the space are sparse and some points are isolated. Another possibility is to learn a new representation of the data, by projecting them into a (better) latent space He and Wang (2008); Weinberger and Saul (2009), as done by Metric Learning algorithms.

An interesting reference von Luxburg and Bousquet (2004) draws a link between the nearest neighbor algorithm (the 1-NN) and the next algorithm we study, the Support Vector Machine (SVM).

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q8.1. What is the training error of the 1-NN rule, and what does it tell us about its test error?

Q8.2. In binary classification, why is an odd value of k usually preferred? What happens with $k = 4$ when the vote is 2 against 2?

Q8.3. Data are uniform in $[0, 1]^5$. What is the edge length of a small hypercube around a query that contains 10% of the data? Comment.

8.3 Support Vector Machine

The Support Vector Machine (SVM) is probably one of the best known and most widely used algorithms for binary classification in Machine Learning Vapnik and Cortes (1995). Its derivation relies on the tools of constrained optimization (Lagrangian, dual problem and Karush-Kuhn-Tucker conditions) presented in Section 4.5.

> **Historical note** The idea of a maximal margin linear separator (the "generalized portrait") goes back to the work of Vapnik and Chervonenkis in the 1960s. It became the modern SVM in two steps: Boser et al. (1992) combined it with the kernel trick to obtain nonlinear classifiers, and Vapnik and Cortes (1995) introduced

[10] This notion of (weighted) majority vote is very common in Machine Learning, especially in *PAC-Bayesian learning*. We will see that majority votes are involved in many algorithms, such as boosting, presented in Section 10.

the soft margin, with slack variables, to handle non-separable data. Together with its theoretical grounding in statistical learning theory, this made kernel SVMs one of the reference methods of the late 1990s and 2000s; see Scholkopf and Smola (2001) for a comprehensive treatment.

Linear SVM The SVM algorithm outputs a hypothesis h which returns the label of an example $\mathbf{x}$. This hypothesis is defined by an (affine) hyperplane which splits the space into two half-spaces, associated with the two labels $\{-1, +1\}$, as follows:

$$h(\mathbf{x}) = \text{sign}\left(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b\right) = \begin{cases} -1 & \text{if} \quad \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b < 0, \\ +1 & \text{if} \quad \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b > 0. \end{cases} \tag{8.1}$$

When the two classes can be perfectly separated, there are many hyperplanes, *i.e.* many values of $(\mathbf{w}, b)$, which separate the data well. The idea developed by Boser et al. (1992) is to choose the one with the largest margin. But why? Let us have a look at Figure 59 to understand it.

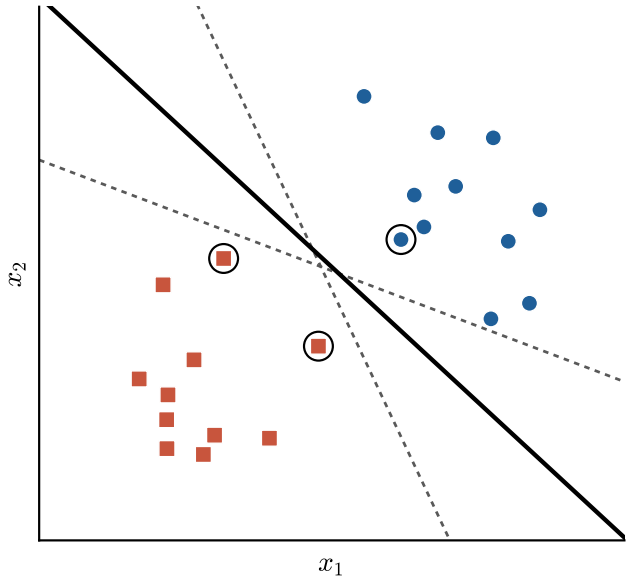


Figure 59: Different linear separators for a classification task. The separator shown as a solid line is the solution of the SVM algorithm, which maximizes the margin (the circled points are the closest ones to it). The two other separators, shown as dashed lines, achieve the same (zero) error on the training data, but pass very close to some training points.

To understand why, we simply need to remember our main goal in Machine Learning: finding a classifier which generalizes as well as possible to new data. If we focus on the two dotted lines, we see that they are really close to the examples of one of the classes. At test time, this increases the risk that a new example, drawn from the same distribution, falls on the wrong side of the separator. Thus, to avoid this problem and to select the separator which is likely to generalize best to new data, we choose the one with the largest margin.

In Figure 60, the margin γ is defined as the distance between the two hyperplanes of equations $\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b = \pm\rho$. Note that, by rescaling $(\mathbf{w}, b)$, we can always rewrite

these equations as $\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b = \pm 1$, which we assume from now on. Let us denote $f(\mathbf{x}) = \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b$ the score whose sign gives the prediction, and let us consider two points $\mathbf{x}_+$ and $\mathbf{x}_-$ lying respectively on the hyperplanes $f(\mathbf{x}) = +1$ and $f(\mathbf{x}) = -1$ (see Figure 60). Each of these vectors can be decomposed as $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{x}^{\mathbf{w}} + \mathbf{x}^{\mathbf{w}^\perp}$, where $\mathbf{x}^{\mathbf{w}}$ is collinear with $\mathbf{w}$ and $\mathbf{x}^{\mathbf{w}^\perp}$ is orthogonal to $\mathbf{w}$. This leads to the following relations:

$$\begin{aligned} f(\mathbf{x}_+) - f(\mathbf{x}_-) &= 2, \\ \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_+ \rangle + b - (\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_- \rangle + b) &= 2, \\ \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_+^{\mathbf{w}} \rangle + \underbrace{\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_+^{\mathbf{w}^\perp} \rangle}_{=0} + b - (\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_-^{\mathbf{w}} \rangle + \underbrace{\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_-^{\mathbf{w}^\perp} \rangle}_{=0} + b) &= 2, \\ \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_+^{\mathbf{w}} \rangle - \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_-^{\mathbf{w}} \rangle &= 2. \end{aligned} \tag{8.2}$$

Furthermore, the margin γ, *i.e.* the distance between the two hyperplanes, is the length of the projection of the vector $\mathbf{x}_+ - \mathbf{x}_-$ onto the unit vector $\frac{\mathbf{w}}{\|\mathbf{w}\|_2}$, *i.e.*

$$\gamma = \frac{\langle \mathbf{x}_+ - \mathbf{x}_-, \mathbf{w} \rangle}{\|\mathbf{w}\|_2}.$$

Thus, we have:

$$\begin{aligned} \gamma &= \frac{\langle \mathbf{x}_+ - \mathbf{x}_-, \mathbf{w} \rangle}{\|\mathbf{w}\|_2} \\ &= \frac{1}{\|\mathbf{w}\|_2} \underbrace{\langle \mathbf{x}_+ - \mathbf{x}_-, \mathbf{w} \rangle}_{} \\ &\quad \downarrow \text{ expanding and keeping only the collinear parts} \\ &= \frac{1}{\|\mathbf{w}\|_2} \underbrace{\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_+^{\mathbf{w}} \rangle - \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_-^{\mathbf{w}} \rangle}_{} \\ &\quad \downarrow \text{ using Equation (8.2)} \\ \gamma &= \frac{2}{\|\mathbf{w}\|_2}. \end{aligned}$$

Maximizing the margin γ is thus equivalent to minimizing $\frac{\|\mathbf{w}\|_2}{2}$, or equivalently $\frac{\|\mathbf{w}\|_2^2}{2}$, which is easier to handle since it is differentiable. The minimization problem associated with the *hard margin SVM* is the following.

Definition 8.1: Hard Margin SVM problem

Let $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ be a sample of size m. The best linear separator in the sense of the SVM algorithm is the solution of the following optimization problem:

$$\begin{aligned} \min_{(\mathbf{w},b) \in \mathbb{R}^{d+1}} \quad & \frac{1}{2} \|\mathbf{w}\|_2^2 \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b) \geq 1, \quad \text{for all } i = 1, \dots, m, \end{aligned}$$

where the inequality constraints are a compact way of writing that every training example is correctly classified by the rule (8.1), and lies outside the margin.

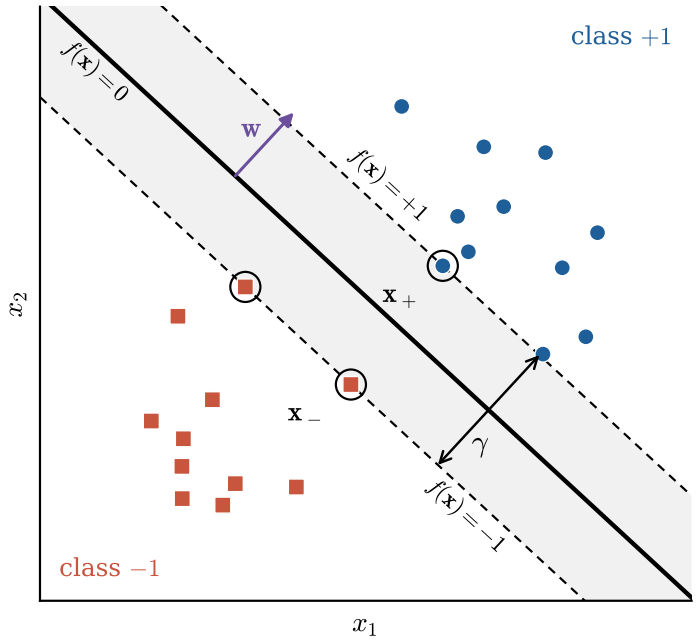


Figure 60: Illustration of the (hard margin) SVM algorithm when the problem is linearly separable, with $f(\mathbf{x}) = \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b$. The circled points are the support vectors; $\mathbf{x}_+$ and $\mathbf{x}_-$ lie on the hyperplanes $f(\mathbf{x}) = +1$ and $f(\mathbf{x}) = -1$ (dashed lines), and the distance between these two hyperplanes is the margin $\gamma = 2/\|\mathbf{w}\|_2$. The vector $\mathbf{w}$ is orthogonal to the separator.

For the moment, we do not focus on how to solve such an optimization problem (which is a convex constrained optimization problem, more precisely a quadratic program). We will see that, in practice, solvers are available to solve these problems without having to deal with all the mathematical aspects and difficulties.

The problem studied so far corresponds to an ideal situation, where the data are linearly separable. However, in most real cases, the two classes are not linearly separable (see Figure 61), and some points violate the constraint $y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b) \geq 1$. This means that such a point is either on the wrong side of the hyperplane, or on the right side of it but inside the margin.

We therefore need a relaxation of the optimization problem which takes this kind of errors into account. These errors are measured by a vector of *slack variables* $\boldsymbol{\xi} = (\xi_1, \ldots, \xi_m)$, which is included in the optimization problem. This leads to a new optimization problem, called the *soft margin SVM*, whose aim is to find the right balance between margin maximization and training errors.

Definition 8.2: Soft Margin SVM problem

Let $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ be a sample of size m and let us denote by $\boldsymbol{\xi} = (\xi_1, \ldots, \xi_m)$ the vector of slack variables. The best linear separator in the sense of the SVM

algorithm is the solution of the following optimization problem:

$$\begin{aligned} \min_{\boldsymbol{\xi}\in\mathbb{R}^m,\ (\mathbf{w},b)\in\mathbb{R}^{d+1}} \quad & \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{w}\|_2^2 + \frac{C}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \xi_i \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i\rangle + b) \geq 1 - \xi_i, \quad \text{for all } i = 1,\dots,m, \\ & \xi_i \geq 0, \qquad\qquad\qquad\quad \text{for all } i = 1,\dots,m. \end{aligned} \tag{8.3}$$

Compared to Definition 8.1, a term $\frac{C}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \xi_i$ has been added, which represents the cost of violating the constraints. In the first constraint, we allow some violations by subtracting the slack variable ξ_i, which is constrained to be nonnegative: ξ_i measures how much the example $\mathbf{x}_i$ violates the margin constraint. The balance between the two terms of the objective is controlled by a hyperparameter $C > 0$ that has to be tuned during the learning process: the larger C, the more the violations are penalized.

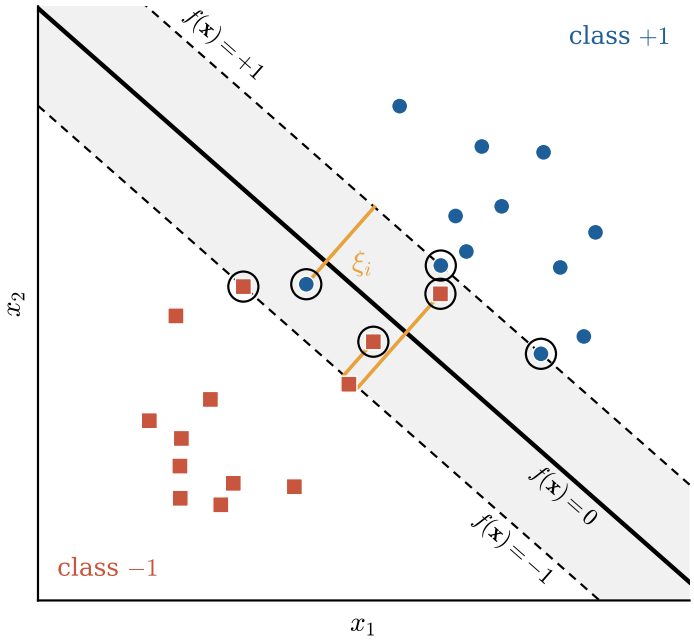


Figure 61: Illustration of the soft margin SVM algorithm when the problem is not linearly separable, with $f(\mathbf{x}) = \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}\rangle + b$. The circled points are the support vectors. The dashed lines are the hyperplanes $f(\mathbf{x}) = \pm 1$; the orange segments show the examples that violate the margin constraint, whose slack variable ξ_i is proportional to the length of the segment ($\xi_i > 1$ for a misclassified example).

Proposition 8.1: Equivalent Formulation of the Soft Margin SVM

Let $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ be a sample of size m. Eliminating the slack variables $\boldsymbol{\xi}$ with the help of the constraints, the optimization problem (8.3) can be rewritten as

$$\min_{(\mathbf{w},b)\in\mathbb{R}^{d+1}} \ \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{w}\|_2^2 + \frac{C}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m [1 - y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i\rangle + b)]_+ ,$$

where $[x]_+ = \max(0, x)$, *i.e.* the second term is the average hinge loss on S.

Proof. Let us fix $(\mathbf{w}, b)$ and minimize the objective with respect to $\boldsymbol{\xi}$ only. The objective is increasing in each ξ_i, and the two constraints on ξ_i can be summarized as $\xi_i \geq 0$ and $\xi_i \geq 1 - y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b)$. Hence, the optimal value of each slack variable is the smallest value satisfying both constraints: it is equal to zero if $y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b) \geq 1$, and to the gap $1 - y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b)$ otherwise, *i.e.*

$$\forall\, i = 1, \ldots, m, \quad \xi_i = \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } 1 - y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b) \leq 0, \\ 1 - y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b) & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

This can be summarized as

$$\forall\, i = 1, \ldots, m, \quad \xi_i = \left[1 - y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b)\right]_+ .$$

Plugging these values into the objective gives the announced problem. □

However, this problem is not so easy to optimize: even though it is convex, it is not smooth (the hinge loss is not differentiable at 1). Furthermore, when the dimension of the data is high, standard (second-order) methods applied to the primal problem have a complexity in $\mathcal{O}(d^3)$ in general Chapelle (2007). We therefore usually solve the so-called *dual formulation* of the problem (see Section 4.5 for the notions of Lagrangian and dual problem): its number of variables is the number m of examples instead of the dimension d, its constraints are very simple, and, as we will see, it only involves the data through inner products.

Proposition 8.2: Dual Problem of the SVM

Let $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ be a sample of size m. The dual formulation of the soft margin SVM described in Definition 8.2 is

$$\begin{aligned} \max_{\boldsymbol{\alpha} \in \mathbb{R}^m} \quad & -\frac{1}{2} \sum_{i=1}^m \sum_{j=1}^m \alpha_i \alpha_j y_i y_j \langle \mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j \rangle + \sum_{i=1}^m \alpha_i \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & 0 \leq \alpha_i \leq \frac{C}{m}, \qquad \text{for all } i = 1, \ldots, m, \\ & \sum_{i=1}^m y_i \alpha_i = 0. \end{aligned} \tag{8.4}$$

The vector $\boldsymbol{\alpha}$ is the vector of Lagrange multipliers, also called dual variables.

Proof. We are dealing with a constrained optimization problem. To derive its dual formulation, we use the Lagrangian of this problem:

$$\mathcal{L}(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\xi}, \boldsymbol{\alpha}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) = \frac{1}{2} \|\mathbf{w}\|_2^2 + \frac{C}{m} \sum_{i=1}^m \xi_i + \sum_{i=1}^m \alpha_i \left(1 - \xi_i - y_i \left(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b\right)\right) - \sum_{i=1}^m \beta_i \xi_i,$$

where $\boldsymbol{\alpha} \geq 0$ and $\boldsymbol{\beta} \geq 0$ are the vectors of dual variables associated respectively with the first and the second constraints. The dual function is obtained by minimizing $\mathcal{L}$ with respect to the primal variables $(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\xi})$. Since $\mathcal{L}$ is convex and differentiable in these variables, its minimum, when it is finite, is reached at the points where its gradient vanishes:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \mathbf{w}}(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\xi}, \boldsymbol{\alpha}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) = 0, \quad \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial b}(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\xi}, \boldsymbol{\alpha}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) = 0, \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \boldsymbol{\xi}}(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\xi}, \boldsymbol{\alpha}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) = 0.$$

These conditions allow us to express the primal variable $\mathbf{w}$ as a function of the dual ones ($\boldsymbol{\alpha}$ and $\boldsymbol{\beta}$), and they give constraints on the dual variables. Remember that these stationarity conditions are part of the Karush-Kuhn-Tucker (KKT) conditions (Section 4.5). We respectively have:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \mathbf{w}}(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\xi}, \boldsymbol{\alpha}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) = 0 \iff \mathbf{w} - \sum_{i=1}^{m} y_i \alpha_i \mathbf{x}_i = 0 \iff \mathbf{w} = \sum_{i=1}^{m} y_i \alpha_i \mathbf{x}_i, \tag{8.5}$$

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial b}(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\xi}, \boldsymbol{\alpha}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) = 0 \iff \sum_{i=1}^{m} \alpha_i y_i = 0, \tag{8.6}$$

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \xi_i}(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\xi}, \boldsymbol{\alpha}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) = 0 \iff \frac{C}{m} - \alpha_i - \beta_i = 0 \iff \beta_i = \frac{C}{m} - \alpha_i. \tag{8.7}$$

(If (8.6) or (8.7) is not satisfied, $\mathcal{L}$ is affine and non-constant in b or in ξ_i, and its infimum is $-\infty$.) We now plug these results into the expression of the Lagrangian:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathcal{L}(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\xi}, \boldsymbol{\alpha}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) &= \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{w}\|_2^2 + \frac{C}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m}\xi_i + \sum_{i=1}^{m}\alpha_i\left(1 - \xi_i - y_i\left(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i\rangle + b\right)\right) - \sum_{i=1}^{m}\beta_i\xi_i \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ using Equation (8.5) and rearranging the terms} \\
&= \frac{1}{2}\sum_{i=1}^{m}\sum_{j=1}^{m} y_i y_j \alpha_i \alpha_j \langle \mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j\rangle + \sum_{i=1}^{m}\xi_i\left(\frac{C}{m} - \alpha_i - \beta_i\right) + \sum_{i=1}^{m}\alpha_i \\
&\quad - \sum_{i=1}^{m}\alpha_i y_i \langle \sum_{j=1}^{m} y_j \alpha_j \mathbf{x}_j, \mathbf{x}_i\rangle - b\sum_{i=1}^{m}\alpha_i y_i \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ using Equations (8.6) and (8.7)} \\
&= \frac{1}{2}\sum_{i=1}^{m}\sum_{j=1}^{m} y_i y_j \alpha_i \alpha_j \langle \mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j\rangle + \sum_{i=1}^{m}\xi_i \times 0 + \sum_{i=1}^{m}\alpha_i \\
&\quad - \sum_{i=1}^{m}\sum_{j=1}^{m} y_i y_j \alpha_i \alpha_j \langle \mathbf{x}_j, \mathbf{x}_i\rangle - b \times 0 \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ computing the difference} \\
&= -\frac{1}{2}\sum_{i=1}^{m}\sum_{j=1}^{m} y_i y_j \alpha_i \alpha_j \langle \mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j\rangle + \sum_{i=1}^{m}\alpha_i.
\end{aligned}$$

The dual problem consists in maximizing this dual function with respect to the dual variables. Finally, the constraints of the dual problem come from Equation (8.6), and from Equation (8.7) combined with the nonnegativity of the multipliers: $\alpha_i \geq 0$ and $\beta_i = \frac{C}{m} - \alpha_i \geq 0$, *i.e.* $0 \leq \alpha_i \leq \frac{C}{m}$. □

Note that the dual problem is a concave maximization problem with respect to the dual variables (a convex quadratic program). Indeed, the constraints are linear, hence define a convex set. As for the objective function, it can be rewritten using a quadratic form:

$$\max_{\boldsymbol{\alpha}} \; -\frac{1}{2}\boldsymbol{\alpha}^T \mathbf{G}\boldsymbol{\alpha} + \sum_{i=1}^{m} \alpha_i,$$

where $\mathbf{G}$ is the matrix defined by $G_{ij} = y_i y_j \langle \mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j \rangle$. This matrix is the Gram matrix of the vectors $y_1\mathbf{x}_1, \ldots, y_m\mathbf{x}_m$, and it is therefore positive semi-definite: $\boldsymbol{\alpha}^T\mathbf{G}\boldsymbol{\alpha} = \|\sum_{i=1}^m \alpha_i y_i \mathbf{x}_i\|_2^2 \geq 0$. Moreover, since the primal problem is convex with affine constraints and is feasible, strong duality holds (see Section 4.5): the optimal values of the primal and dual problems coincide. Note however that $\mathbf{G}$ is in general not positive definite (it has rank at most d), so the dual objective is not *strictly* concave and the optimal $\boldsymbol{\alpha}$ need not be unique; the optimal vector $\mathbf{w}$, on the other hand, is unique since the primal objective is strictly convex in $\mathbf{w}$.

Remarks. The dual problem looks for a solution in a different space: we work in the space of the examples (one variable α_i per example) rather than in the space of the parameters. Furthermore, once the dual problem is solved, Equation (8.5) gives the primal solution $\mathbf{w}$. The value of the offset b does not appear in the stationarity conditions, but it can be recovered from the complementary slackness conditions, as we will see below.

Although the dual formulation leads to a problem that is easier to solve when the number of examples is small, it does not solve the problem of data that are not linearly separable. To tackle this issue, we use what is commonly called the *kernel trick*.

In a nutshell

Consider the one-dimensional data of Figure 62: the positive examples lie on both sides of the negative ones, so no threshold on x, *i.e.* no linear classifier in $\mathbb{R}$, can separate them. If we map each example to $\Phi(x) = (x, x^2) \in \mathbb{R}^2$, the two classes become separable by the horizontal line $x^2 = c$, *i.e.* by the linear classifier of $\mathbb{R}^2$ with $\mathbf{w} = (0, 1)$ and $b = -c$. Back in the input space, this linear classifier is the *nonlinear* rule "predict $+1$ if $|x| > \sqrt{c}$". The SVM only needs the inner products $\langle \Phi(x), \Phi(x') \rangle = xx' + x^2x'^2$, which can be computed directly from x and x': this function is a kernel, and the map Φ never has to be computed explicitly.

Kernel SVM Instead of using the standard inner product between two examples, we define a function $K(\cdot, \cdot)$ which takes two vectors as input and returns a real number. Such a function K is called a (positive semi-definite) kernel when it is (i) symmetric and (ii) positive semi-definite, in the sense that every matrix $\mathbf{K}$ built from it on a finite sample is positive semi-definite:

(i) for all $(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') \in \mathbb{R}^d \times \mathbb{R}^d$, we have $K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = K(\mathbf{x}', \mathbf{x})$;

(ii) for all $m \geq 1$, all $\mathbf{x}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{x}_m \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and all $\mathbf{c} \in \mathbb{R}^m$, we have $\mathbf{c}^T\mathbf{K}\mathbf{c} = \sum_{i=1}^m \sum_{j=1}^m c_i c_j K(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j) \geq 0$, where $\mathbf{K}$ is the matrix of general term $K_{ij} = K(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j)$.

These properties of the function K (or of the matrices $\mathbf{K}$) play a key role and lead to the following result due to Mercer Mercer (1909).

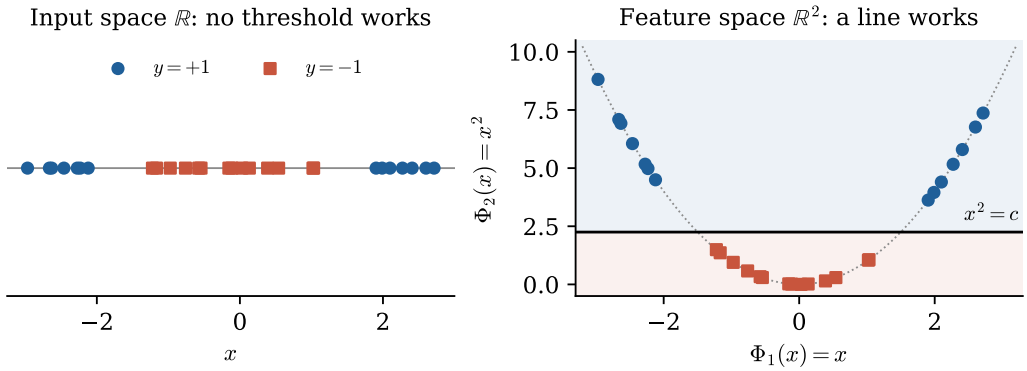


Figure 62: The idea behind the kernel trick. Left: one-dimensional data that are not linearly separable. Right: after the mapping $\Phi(x) = (x, x^2)$, a line separates the two classes; it corresponds to the nonlinear rule $|x| > \sqrt{c}$ in the input space.

Theorem 8.3: Mercer Theorem

Let $\mathcal{X}$ be a compact subset of $\mathbb{R}^d$ and let K be a continuous, symmetric, positive semi-definite function, *i.e.* a kernel. Then, there exist an orthonormal family of functions $(\Phi_j)_{j\geq 1}$ of $L^2(\mathcal{X})$ and a sequence $(\lambda_j)_{j\geq 1}$ of nonnegative real numbers such that

$$K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \sum_{j=1}^{\infty} \lambda_j \Phi_j(\mathbf{x}) \Phi_j(\mathbf{x}') = \langle \Phi(\mathbf{x}), \Phi(\mathbf{x}') \rangle,$$

where $\Phi(\mathbf{x}) = (\sqrt{\lambda_1}\Phi_1(\mathbf{x}), \ldots, \sqrt{\lambda_j}\Phi_j(\mathbf{x}), \ldots)$ is the representation of $\mathbf{x}$ in a new space.

The kernel trick thus says that there is no need to know the transformation Φ explicitly: the knowledge of K is enough, since the dual problem and the predictions only involve inner products between examples. Furthermore, it makes it possible to (implicitly) project the data into a higher-dimensional space, called the feature space (possibly of infinite dimension), in which the classes may become linearly separable.

Introducing the kernel K into the optimization problem (8.4) leads to the following dual formulation:

$$\begin{aligned} \max_{\boldsymbol{\alpha} \in \mathbb{R}^m} \quad & -\frac{1}{2} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sum_{j=1}^{m} \alpha_i \alpha_j y_i y_j K(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j) + \sum_{i=1}^{m} \alpha_i \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & 0 \leq \alpha_i \leq \frac{C}{m}, \qquad \text{for all } i = 1, \ldots, m, \\ & \sum_{i=1}^{m} y_i \alpha_i = 0. \end{aligned} \tag{8.8}$$

There exists a large number of kernel functions (see Genton (2002) for a more complete list), among which the most widely used are:

- **Linear kernel:** $K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}' \rangle$, which is the standard inner product.
- **Polynomial kernel:** $K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = (\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}' \rangle + c)^p$, where $c \geq 0$ is a constant and $p \in \mathbb{N}^*$ is the degree.

- **Gaussian kernel:** $K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \exp\left(-\frac{\|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}'\|_2^2}{2\sigma^2}\right)$, where $\sigma > 0$ is a hyperparameter that needs to be tuned. It controls how fast the similarity between two instances decreases with their distance. The larger σ, the slower this decrease: distant examples are then still considered as similar, and all the examples of the dataset play a more uniform role, which leads to smoother decision boundaries.

Example 8.5. Let us consider two 2-dimensional vectors $\mathbf{x}$ and $\mathbf{z}$ and the polynomial kernel of degree 2. We aim to write this kernel as an inner product, *i.e.* to find a mapping function Φ such that $K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z}) = \Phi(\mathbf{x})^T\Phi(\mathbf{z})$:

$$\begin{aligned}
K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z}) &= (x_1z_1 + x_2z_2 + c)^2 \\
&= c^2 + x_1^2z_1^2 + x_2^2z_2^2 + 2x_1z_1x_2z_2 + 2cx_1z_1 + 2cx_2z_2 \\
&= \left(c, x_1^2, x_2^2, \sqrt{2}x_1x_2, \sqrt{2c}x_1, \sqrt{2c}x_2\right)\left(c, z_1^2, z_2^2, \sqrt{2}z_1z_2, \sqrt{2c}z_1, \sqrt{2c}z_2\right)^T \\
&= \Phi(\mathbf{x})^T\Phi(\mathbf{z}),
\end{aligned}$$

where $\Phi : \mathbf{x} \mapsto \left(c, x_1^2, x_2^2, \sqrt{2}x_1x_2, \sqrt{2c}x_1, \sqrt{2c}x_2\right)$. Using this kernel, we thus implicitly project the data into a 6-dimensional space.

As an exercise, apply the same process to show that, for a 3-dimensional dataset and a polynomial kernel of degree 2 with $c = 0$, the data are projected into a space of dimension 6.

Let us now show why the Gaussian kernel projects the data into a space of infinite dimension. Let us consider two instances $\mathbf{x}$ and $\mathbf{z}$ in $\mathbb{R}^d$ and recall that

$$\|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{z}\|_2^2 = \|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 + \|\mathbf{z}\|_2^2 - 2\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z}\rangle.$$

Thus, we can write[11]

$$\begin{aligned}
K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z}) &= \exp\left(-\frac{\|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{z}\|_2^2}{2\sigma^2}\right) \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ using the previous equation and the properties of the exponential} \\
&= \exp\left(-\frac{\|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2}{2\sigma^2}\right)\exp\left(-\frac{\|\mathbf{z}\|_2^2}{2\sigma^2}\right)\exp\left(\frac{\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z}\rangle}{\sigma^2}\right) \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ using the power series expansion of the exponential function} \\
&= c(\mathbf{x})c(\mathbf{z})\sum_{k=0}^{\infty}\frac{\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z}\rangle^k}{k!\,\sigma^{2k}} \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ writing } \langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z}\rangle^k = \langle \mathbf{x}^{\otimes k}, \mathbf{z}^{\otimes k}\rangle, \text{ where } \mathbf{x}^{\otimes k} \in \mathbb{R}^{d^k} \text{ gathers all the products } x_{j_1}\cdots x_{j_k} \\
&= \sum_{k=0}^{\infty}\left\langle \frac{c(\mathbf{x})}{\sqrt{k!}\,\sigma^k}\mathbf{x}^{\otimes k}, \frac{c(\mathbf{z})}{\sqrt{k!}\,\sigma^k}\mathbf{z}^{\otimes k}\right\rangle.
\end{aligned}$$

Hence $K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z}) = \langle \Phi(\mathbf{x}), \Phi(\mathbf{z})\rangle$, where $\Phi(\mathbf{x})$ is the infinite sequence obtained by concatenating the vectors $\frac{c(\mathbf{x})}{\sqrt{k!}\,\sigma^k}\mathbf{x}^{\otimes k}$ for $k = 0, 1, 2, \ldots$: the feature space associated with the Gaussian kernel contains all the monomials of all degrees, and is thus of infinite dimension.

[11] See the development here for further details.

Figure 63 illustrates the use of a linear and of a Gaussian kernel. Do you think that a polynomial kernel of degree 2 would be enough, in this case, to separate the two classes?

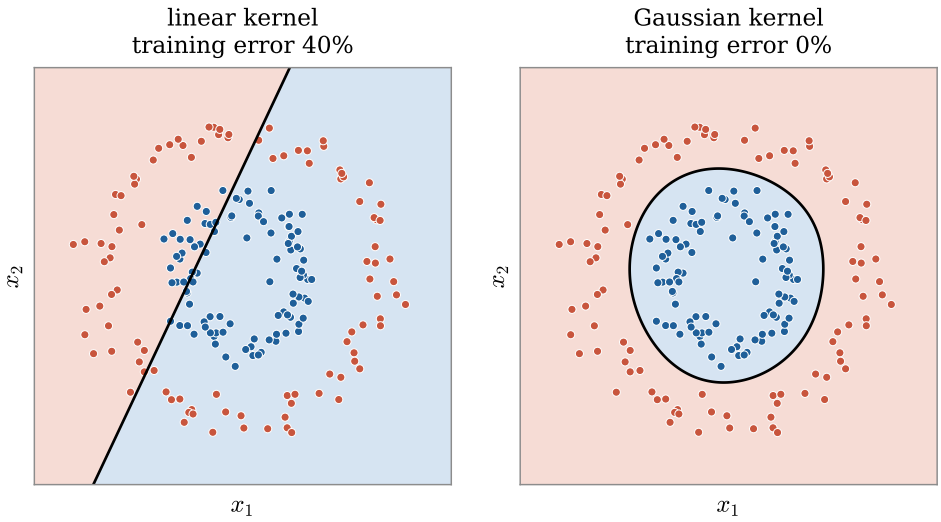


Figure 63: Illustration of the kernel SVM algorithm when the problem is not linearly separable (linear kernel on the left, Gaussian kernel on the right). Blue points represent the positive class and red points the negative class. The colored areas represent the decision regions of the learned hypothesis.

Tuning the Gaussian kernel SVM A Gaussian kernel SVM has two hyperparameters, which must be tuned jointly (typically by a grid search with cross-validation, on a logarithmic grid). In software such as `scikit-learn`, the Gaussian kernel is parameterized as $K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \exp(-\gamma \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}'\|_2^2)$, *i.e.* $\gamma = 1/(2\sigma^2)$, and the cost parameter multiplies the *sum* of the slack variables, so that it corresponds to our C/m. Figure 64 shows their effect:

- a large γ (small σ) makes the similarity very local: each example only influences its immediate neighborhood, and the boundary can wrap around individual points (overfitting); a small γ gives a smooth, almost linear, boundary;
- a small C favors a large margin at the price of many margin violations, so that many examples are support vectors; a large C forces the classifier to fit the training data more closely.

Prediction phase With the linear SVM (hard or soft margin), to predict the label of a new instance $\mathbf{x}'$, we compute

$$h(\mathbf{x}') = \text{sign}\left(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}' \rangle + b\right).$$

With the kernelized version, using Equation (8.5) in the feature space, the hypothesis (or classifier) takes the following form:

$$h(\mathbf{x}') = \text{sign}\left(\sum_{i=1}^{m} \alpha_i y_i K(\mathbf{x}', \mathbf{x}_i) + b\right).$$

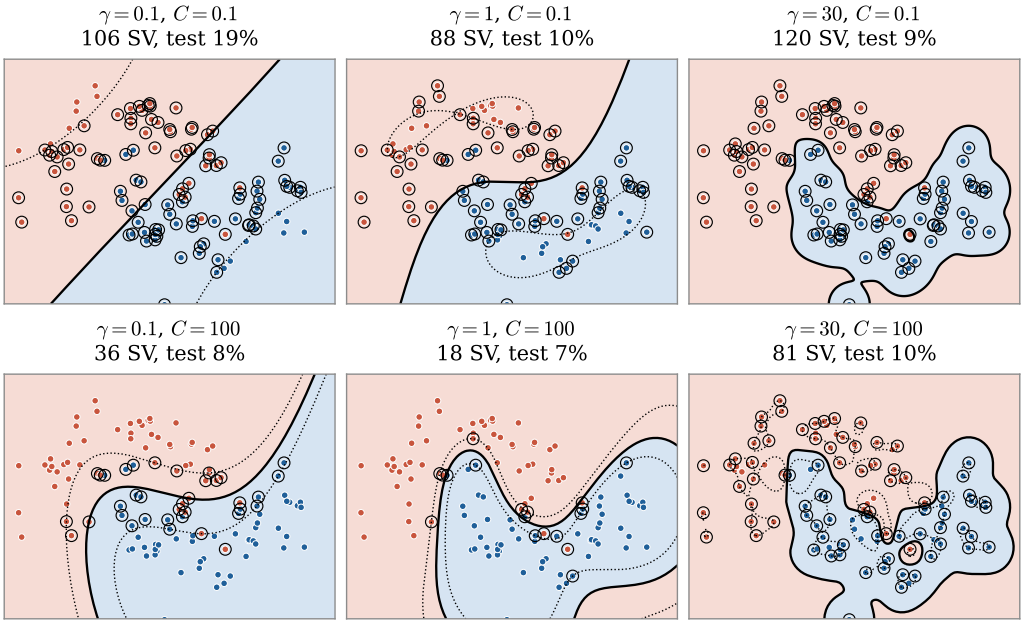


Figure 64: Gaussian kernel SVM (`scikit-learn` parameterization) on a two-moons dataset ($m = 120$), for three bandwidths γ (columns) and two costs C (rows). Solid line: decision boundary $f(\mathbf{x}) = 0$; dotted lines: $f(\mathbf{x}) = \pm 1$; circled points: support vectors. The titles give the number of support vectors and the test error.

Note that, in this case, we need to compute the similarity between the new example and the training examples. However, both hypotheses are linear: they simply work in different spaces (the input space for the former, the feature space for the latter).

A more detailed analysis of the dual formulation We now take advantage of the dual formulation presented above to study its link with the primal solution, and to explain why this model is called a *Support Vector Machine*.

For the first point, we write the full set of KKT conditions (please refer to Section 4.5, and more precisely to Section 4.5, for further details on how to obtain them) for the soft margin SVM problem (see Definition 8.2), using the previous notation:

- Stationarity conditions:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \mathbf{w}}(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\xi}, \boldsymbol{\alpha}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) = 0 \iff \mathbf{w} = \sum_{i=1}^{m} y_i \alpha_i \mathbf{x}_i, \tag{8.9}$$

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial b}(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\xi}, \boldsymbol{\alpha}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) = 0 \iff \sum_{i=1}^{m} \alpha_i y_i = 0, \tag{8.10}$$

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \xi_i}(\mathbf{w}, b, \boldsymbol{\xi}, \boldsymbol{\alpha}, \boldsymbol{\beta}) = 0 \iff \alpha_i + \beta_i = \frac{C}{m}, \quad \forall i = 1, \dots, m. \tag{8.11}$$

- Primal feasibility:

$$1 - \xi_i - y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b) \leq 0, \quad \forall i = 1, \dots, m, \tag{8.12}$$

$$\xi_i \geq 0, \quad \forall i = 1, \dots, m. \tag{8.13}$$

- Dual feasibility:

$$\alpha_i \geq 0, \quad \forall i = 1, \ldots, m, \tag{8.14}$$
$$\beta_i \geq 0, \quad \forall i = 1, \ldots, m. \tag{8.15}$$

- Complementary slackness:

$$\alpha_i \left(1 - \xi_i - y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b)\right) = 0, \quad \forall i = 1, \ldots, m, \tag{8.16}$$
$$\beta_i \xi_i = 0, \quad \forall i = 1, \ldots, m. \tag{8.17}$$

Equation (8.9) immediately gives an expression of $\mathbf{w}$ in terms of the dual variables. It remains to find an expression of the offset b to fully recover the primal solution. The stationarity conditions do not provide it, but, as we will see, the complementary slackness conditions do.

Let us now focus on the *support vectors*, *i.e.* the training examples $\mathbf{x}_i$ for which $\alpha_i > 0$. We will see that they are points which lie on the margin, inside it, or on the wrong side of the hyperplane (the circled points in Figures 60 and 61), and that they are the only points needed to define our separator. We will also describe the role of all the other points.

To do so, we focus on the complementary slackness conditions (8.16) and (8.17), which hold for every instance $i = 1, \ldots, m$. Since $0 \leq \alpha_i \leq \dfrac{C}{m}$ for all $i = 1, \ldots, m$, there are three possible cases for α_i:

i) if $\alpha_i = 0$, then Equation (8.11) implies $\beta_i = \dfrac{C}{m} > 0$, and thus $\xi_i = 0$ by Equation (8.17). Using the primal feasibility condition (8.12), we then get $y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b) \geq 1$. So the point $\mathbf{x}_i$ is **correctly classified and lies outside the margin** (or on its boundary).

ii) if $\alpha_i = \dfrac{C}{m}$, then Equation (8.11) implies $\beta_i = 0$, so Equation (8.17) only tells us that $\xi_i \geq 0$. Equation (8.16) then gives $y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b) = 1 - \xi_i \leq 1$. So the point $\mathbf{x}_i$ lies **on the margin** (if $\xi_i = 0$), **inside the margin** (if $0 < \xi_i \leq 1$), or is **misclassified** (if $\xi_i > 1$).

iii) finally, if $0 < \alpha_i < \dfrac{C}{m}$, then Equation (8.11) implies $0 < \beta_i < \dfrac{C}{m}$, and thus $\xi_i = 0$ by Equation (8.17). Equation (8.16) then gives $y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b) = 1$. So the point $\mathbf{x}_i$ lies **exactly on the margin**.

The last case gives us the value of the offset: for any index i such that $0 < \alpha_i < \frac{C}{m}$, since $y_i \in \{-1, 1\}$, we have

$$b = y_i - \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle = y_i - \sum_{j=1}^{m} \alpha_j y_j \langle \mathbf{x}_j, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle,$$

where the inner product is replaced by $K(\mathbf{x}_j, \mathbf{x}_i)$ in the kernel case. In practice, to obtain a numerically more stable value, we average this quantity over all the support vectors lying exactly on the margin.

If we combine this analysis with the fact that $\mathbf{w} = \sum_{i=1}^{m} \alpha_i y_i \mathbf{x}_i$, we note that the points lying strictly outside the margin ($\alpha_i = 0$) do not contribute to the definition

of the hyperplane at all! Only the support vectors matter, hence the name of the algorithm. This is important from a computational point of view: we do not need to use all the training points in the prediction phase, *i.e.* there is no need to compute the similarities between a new example and all the training examples, but only with the support vectors.

It is also possible to speed up the learning phase of the (kernel) SVM, for instance by using a low-rank approximation of the kernel matrix; we do not go into these details here.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q8.4. In the soft margin SVM, which training examples have $\alpha_i = 0$, and what is their influence on the classifier?

Q8.5. A linear SVM returns $\mathbf{w} = (3, 4)$. What is the width of its margin γ?

Q8.6. True or false: increasing the hyperparameter C of the soft margin SVM can only widen the margin. Justify.

Q8.7. What happens to a Gaussian kernel SVM when σ becomes very small (*i.e.* γ very large)?

The next algorithm we study can be used for both regression and classification tasks, depending on the nature of the output.

8.4 Linear Regression and Logistic Regression

The support vector machine was a first example of a linear model. In this section, we present the well-known linear regression model and its counterpart for classification tasks, logistic regression.

Linear Regression Linear regression is mainly used when we aim to predict a real value, *e.g.* the price of a house or the score obtained at a given exam, as illustrated in Figure 65.

As for the linear SVM, the learned model is affine: in its simplest form (a single input variable), it is a straight line, and a hyperplane in general. Given $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m \subset \mathbb{R}^d \times \mathbb{R}$, we aim to find the hyperplane which best approximates the scatter plot, *i.e.* to learn a hypothesis h of the form

$$h(\boldsymbol{\theta}, \mathbf{x}) = \theta_0 + \theta_1 x_1 + \theta_2 x_2 + \ldots + \theta_d x_d.$$

To learn the parameters $\boldsymbol{\theta} = (\theta_0, \ldots, \theta_d)$ of the model, we minimize a loss, as for the SVM. For regression tasks, as stated in Section 7.2, we usually minimize the Mean Squared Error (MSE).

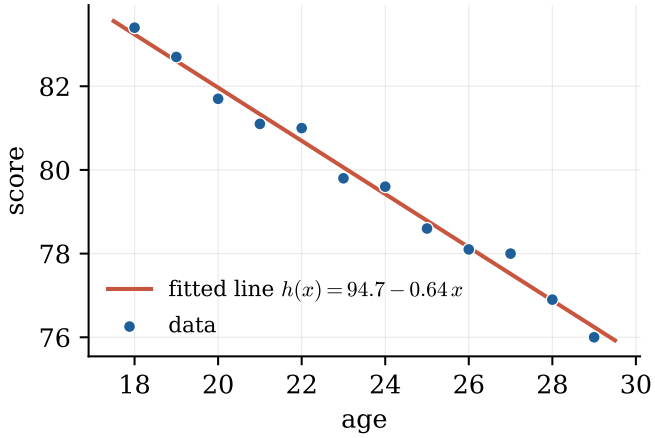


Figure 65: Example of a linear regression, where the aim is to predict the score of a person according to his or her age. The solution obtained by linear regression is represented in red.

Proposition 8.4: Linear Regression

We consider the following probabilistic model for our data:

$$Y = \theta_0 + \theta_1 X_1 + \ldots + \theta_d X_d + \varepsilon,$$

where Y is the variable to predict, $X = (X_1, \ldots, X_d)$ is the vector of variables used for the prediction, and ε is a centered random noise representing the error of the model. We consider a hypothesis h of the form

$$h(\boldsymbol{\theta}, \mathbf{x}) = \theta_0 + \theta_1 x_1 + \theta_2 x_2 + \ldots + \theta_d x_d.$$

Given a set S of m examples, let $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times (d+1)}$ be the design matrix whose i-th row is $(1, \mathbf{x}_i^T)$, and let $\mathbf{y} = (y_1, y_2, \ldots, y_m)^T$. If $\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}$ is invertible, then the solution of the Mean Squared Error problem

$$\min_{\boldsymbol{\theta} \in \mathbb{R}^{d+1}} \|\mathbf{y} - h(\boldsymbol{\theta}, \mathbf{X})\|_2^2 = \min_{\boldsymbol{\theta} \in \mathbb{R}^{d+1}} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \left(y_i - h(\boldsymbol{\theta}, \mathbf{x}_i)\right)^2,$$

where $h(\boldsymbol{\theta}, \mathbf{X}) = \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}$ is the vector of predictions, is given by

$$\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} = (\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X})^{-1}\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{y}.$$

Proof. The objective function $F(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2$ is convex, since its Hessian matrix $2\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}$ is positive semi-definite. Its minimizers are thus the points where its gradient vanishes:

$$\nabla F(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = -2\mathbf{X}^T(\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta}) = 0 \iff \mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}\boldsymbol{\theta} = \mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{y},$$

and these *normal equations* have the unique solution $\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ when $\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}$ is invertible. This is exactly the proof studied in the course on linear models. □

This first model is quite simple, and an analytical solution is available: no iterative

optimization procedure is needed to learn the model[12].

Let us now place ourselves in a slightly different context and consider the following example.

Example 8.6. We are trying to build a regression model able to determine whether or not an individual has an infection, according to his or her lymphocyte count. The variable to predict can take two values: 1 if the person has an infection and 0 otherwise.

At first sight, nothing prevents us from learning a linear model, by least squares, to fit this new point cloud, as illustrated in panel (a) of Figure 66. We then simply have to choose a threshold on the values taken by the hypothesis h, above which an individual is considered as sick: *e.g.* we consider that an example $\mathbf{x}$ belongs to the positive class when $h(\mathbf{x})$ is greater than 0.5 (*i.e.* the prediction is negative on the left of the vertical dotted line and positive on its right). In this example, it works well.

Let us now consider another dataset, in which the number of lymphocytes can be extremely high, meaning that the infection is serious. This new dataset is represented in panel (b) of Figure 66. This time, we see that if we use the same threshold, we miss some positive instances, *i.e.* some infected people: the few very large values have "pulled" the line and shifted the threshold to the right (from 3 to about 4.4), so that the patient with a count of 4 is now predicted healthy.

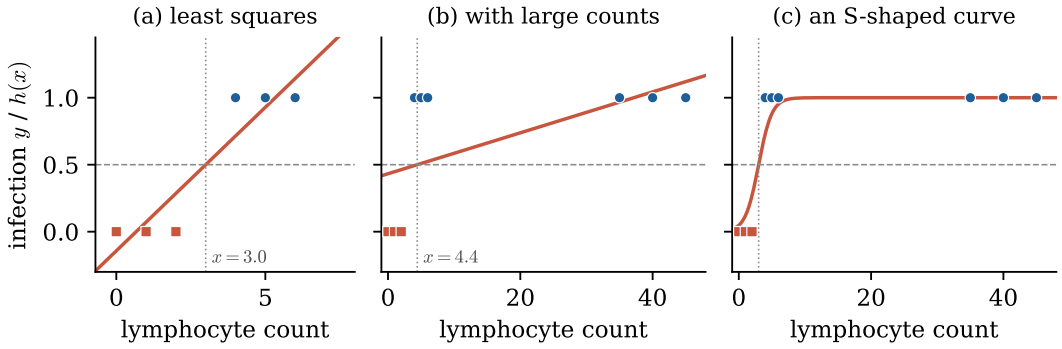


Figure 66: Predicting an infection ($y = 1$, blue) from the lymphocyte count. (a) A least squares line and the threshold $h(x) = 0.5$ separate the two classes. (b) Adding a few patients with very large counts pulls the line and moves the threshold to the right: a sick patient is now misclassified. (c) An S-shaped curve with values in $[0, 1]$ is not affected by these extreme values.

This example shows that the linear model is not well suited to this problem: we need a different shape, *i.e.* a curve which is better adapted to the structure of our data, such as the S-shaped curve of panel (c) of Figure 66. Such a model takes its values in $[0, 1]$, and we can thus interpret it as an estimate of the probability of having an infection. To transform the values predicted by a linear model into probabilities, we use the logistic function, *i.e.* we compute

$$\frac{1}{1 + \exp\left(-h(\mathbf{x})\right)}.$$

We then talk about *(linear) logistic regression*.

[12]For more information on linear regression, and especially on its statistical aspects, the reader can consult the course on Linear Models given by Stéphane Chrétien, available here.

Logistic Regression The logistic regression model, also called the *logit model*, was introduced in the middle of the 20th century Cox (1958), but the use of *logit* functions dates back to the 19th century Cramer (2003).

This model is close to the SVM in the sense that it also learns a linear separator between two classes. However, it differs from the SVM in that it estimates the probability that an example belongs to a given class, for instance the positive class: $\eta(\mathbf{x}) = Pr(Y = 1 \mid X = \mathbf{x})$. More precisely, logistic regression models the logarithm of the *odds*, *i.e.* of the ratio between the probabilities of the two classes, with a linear model:

$$\ln\left(\frac{Pr(y=1 \mid \mathbf{x})}{Pr(y=0 \mid \mathbf{x})}\right) = h(\mathbf{w}, b, \mathbf{x}) = b + \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle.$$

Thus, once the parameters of the model are learned, we can compute the probability of belonging to class 1:

$$Pr(y=1 \mid \mathbf{x}) = \frac{\exp(h(\mathbf{w}, b, \mathbf{x}))}{1 + \exp(h(\mathbf{w}, b, \mathbf{x}))} = \frac{1}{1 + \exp(-h(\mathbf{w}, b, \mathbf{x}))}.$$

This function of h is called the *logistic function* (or sigmoid function), and it takes its values in $[0, 1]$. An example $\mathbf{x}$ is (usually) assigned to class 1 if $Pr(y = 1 \mid \mathbf{x}) > 0.5$, *i.e.* if $h(\mathbf{w}, b, \mathbf{x}) > 0$. Depending on the task and on the objective, we can choose to modify this threshold, as we will see later.

To estimate the parameters of the model, we maximize the likelihood $\mathfrak{L}(\mathbf{w}, b, S)$ of the data, where S is a set of m examples with labels $y_i \in \{0, 1\}$, assumed to be independent:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathfrak{L}(\mathbf{w}, b, S) &= \prod_{i=1}^{m} Pr(Y = y_i \mid X = \mathbf{x}_i) \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ separating the examples such that } y_i = 1 \text{ and those such that } y_i = 0 \\
&= \prod_{i:\, y_i = 1} Pr(Y = 1 \mid X = \mathbf{x}_i) \times \prod_{i:\, y_i = 0} Pr(Y = 0 \mid X = \mathbf{x}_i) \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ using the fact that, given } \mathbf{x}_i, \text{ the label follows a Bernoulli distribution} \\
&= \prod_{i=1}^{m} \left(\frac{1}{1 + \exp(-h(\mathbf{w}, b, \mathbf{x}_i))}\right)^{y_i} \times \left(\frac{1}{1 + \exp(h(\mathbf{w}, b, \mathbf{x}_i))}\right)^{1 - y_i}.
\end{aligned}$$

We usually prefer to minimize the negative log-likelihood of the data, which turns the product into a sum:

$$\begin{aligned}
\ell(\mathbf{w}, b, S) &= -\ln\left(\mathfrak{L}(\mathbf{w}, b, S)\right) \\
&= -\sum_{i=1}^{m} \left[y_i \ln\left(\frac{1}{1 + \exp\left(-(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b)\right)}\right) \right. \\
&\qquad \left. + (1 - y_i) \ln\left(1 - \frac{1}{1 + \exp\left(-(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b)\right)}\right) \right].
\end{aligned}$$

In this way, we recover the logistic loss (in its version with labels in $\{0, 1\}$) introduced at the beginning of this section. In the following, for the sake of simplicity, we set $g(\mathbf{w}, b, \mathbf{x}) = \dfrac{1}{1 + \exp\left(-(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b)\right)}$. The optimization problem then becomes

$$\min_{(\mathbf{w}, b) \in \mathbb{R}^{d+1}} \; -\frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \left[y_i \ln\left(g(\mathbf{w}, b, \mathbf{x}_i)\right) + (1 - y_i) \ln\left(1 - g(\mathbf{w}, b, \mathbf{x}_i)\right) \right].$$

We divide the loss by m in order to be consistent with the notion of empirical risk defined previously; this does not change the minimizer.

SVMs and logistic regression models are similar from a geometric point of view (they both learn a hyperplane) and both minimize a (regularized) empirical risk with a convex surrogate of the 0-1 loss. A closer look at their loss functions (Figure 56) nevertheless reveals some differences, which can lead to different solutions:

- the hinge loss is equal to zero as soon as $yh(\mathbf{x}) \geq 1$, so the SVM solution only depends on the support vectors, whereas the logistic loss never vanishes, so every training example (even a well-classified one far from the separator) has an influence on the logistic regression solution;
- both losses grow *linearly* for badly misclassified points, so they have a comparable sensitivity to outliers; this is not the case of the exponential loss used in boosting, which penalizes errors exponentially and is thus much more sensitive to outliers and label noise;
- logistic regression directly provides an estimate of the probability $Pr(y = 1 \mid \mathbf{x})$, whereas the SVM only provides a score whose sign gives the class.

Compared to linear regression for real-valued outputs, there is no analytical solution here. However, the problem is convex, so we can use a gradient-based algorithm to find a solution.

> **Pitfall: separable data in logistic regression** Convexity does not guarantee that a minimizer exists. If the training data are linearly separable by $(\mathbf{w}, b)$, *i.e.* $(2y_i - 1)(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b) > 0$ for all i, then replacing $(\mathbf{w}, b)$ by $(t\mathbf{w}, tb)$ and letting $t \to +\infty$ makes every predicted probability tend to the true label, and the negative log-likelihood tends to 0 without ever reaching it: the maximum likelihood estimate does not exist Albert and Anderson (1984). In practice, the norm of the parameters keeps growing along the iterations, the estimated probabilities become (over-confident) 0's and 1's, and the software may report convergence warnings. Adding a regularization term $\lambda \|\mathbf{w}\|_2^2$, as described below, prevents the weights from diverging: the regularized objective is strictly convex in $\mathbf{w}$ and tends to $+\infty$ when $\|\mathbf{w}\|_2 \to \infty$, so that its minimizer exists.

Learning procedure To simplify the notation and avoid handling the offset b separately, we append a constant coordinate equal to 1 to each input and include b in the vector of parameters, *i.e.* we write $\mathbf{x} \leftarrow (1, \mathbf{x}) \in \mathbb{R}^{d+1}$ and $\mathbf{w} \leftarrow (b, \mathbf{w}) \in \mathbb{R}^{d+1}$, so that $\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b$ becomes $\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle$ and $g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}) = 1/(1 + \exp(-\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle))$. We consider the negative log-likelihood $\ell(\mathbf{w}, S)$ without the factor $\frac{1}{m}$. Using the fact that the logistic function $\sigma(t) = 1/(1 + \exp(-t))$ satisfies $\sigma'(t) = \sigma(t)(1 - \sigma(t))$, we have $\nabla_{\mathbf{w}} \ln g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}) = (1 - g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}))\mathbf{x}$ and $\nabla_{\mathbf{w}} \ln(1 - g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x})) = -g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x})\mathbf{x}$. We can thus compute the gradient of ℓ with respect to $\mathbf{w}$:

$$\nabla \ell(\mathbf{w}, S) = \begin{bmatrix} \frac{\partial \ell}{\partial w_1}(\mathbf{w}, S) \\ \frac{\partial \ell}{\partial w_2}(\mathbf{w}, S) \\ \vdots \\ \frac{\partial \ell}{\partial w_{d+1}}(\mathbf{w}, S) \end{bmatrix}$$

$$
\begin{aligned}
&\downarrow \text{ using the derivatives of } \ln g \text{ and } \ln(1-g) \\
&= -\sum_{i=1}^{m} [y_i(1 - g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i))\mathbf{x}_i - (1 - y_i)g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i)\mathbf{x}_i] \\
&\downarrow \text{ simplifying} \\
&= -\sum_{i=1}^{m} \left(y_i - \frac{1}{1 + \exp(-\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle)} \right) \mathbf{x}_i.
\end{aligned}
$$

Each example thus contributes proportionally to its "residual" $y_i - g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i)$, *i.e.* to the difference between its label and its predicted probability.

We can then apply the gradient descent algorithm, using the above expression of the gradient of the negative log-likelihood (which plays the role of our loss function in this case):

$$
\mathbf{w}^{(k+1)} = \mathbf{w}^{(k)} - \eta \, \nabla \ell(\mathbf{w}^{(k)}, S), \quad k = 0, 1, 2, \ldots,
$$

where $\eta > 0$ is the learning rate.

In practice, we often use the **Newton-Raphson** method to minimize the loss function, *i.e.* we replace the learning rate η by the inverse of the Hessian matrix of ℓ in the update. This Hessian matrix is given by

$$
\nabla^2 \ell(\mathbf{w}, S) = \begin{bmatrix}
\dfrac{\partial^2 \ell}{\partial w_1^2}(\mathbf{w}, S) & \cdots & \dfrac{\partial^2 \ell}{\partial w_1 \partial w_{d+1}}(\mathbf{w}, S) \\
\dfrac{\partial^2 \ell}{\partial w_2 \partial w_1}(\mathbf{w}, S) & \cdots & \dfrac{\partial^2 \ell}{\partial w_2 \partial w_{d+1}}(\mathbf{w}, S) \\
\vdots & & \vdots \\
\dfrac{\partial^2 \ell}{\partial w_{d+1} \partial w_1}(\mathbf{w}, S) & \cdots & \dfrac{\partial^2 \ell}{\partial w_{d+1}^2}(\mathbf{w}, S)
\end{bmatrix},
$$

and a direct computation, using again $\sigma' = \sigma(1 - \sigma)$, gives

$$
\nabla^2 \ell(\mathbf{w}, S) = \sum_{i=1}^{m} g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i) \left(1 - g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i)\right) \mathbf{x}_i \mathbf{x}_i^T.
$$

We can express the Hessian matrix in a more compact form:

$$
\nabla^2 \ell(\mathbf{w}, S) = \mathbf{X}^T \mathbf{G} \mathbf{X},
$$

where $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times (d+1)}$ is the design matrix (*i.e.* the matrix whose rows are the examples $\mathbf{x}_i^T$) and $\mathbf{G} \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times m}$ is the diagonal matrix defined by

$$
\mathbf{G} = \begin{bmatrix}
g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_1) \left(1 - g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_1)\right) & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\
0 & g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_2) \left(1 - g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_2)\right) & \ddots & \vdots \\
\vdots & \ddots & \ddots & 0 \\
0 & \cdots & 0 & g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_m) \left(1 - g(\mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_m)\right)
\end{bmatrix}.
$$

Note that, with the first expression, the Hessian matrix is a nonnegative linear combination of the rank-one positive semi-definite matrices $\mathbf{x}_i \mathbf{x}_i^T$, and is thus itself positive semi-definite: this proves that ℓ is convex. The Newton-Raphson algorithm then reads

$$
\mathbf{w}^{(k+1)} = \mathbf{w}^{(k)} - \left(\nabla^2 \ell(\mathbf{w}^{(k)}, S) \right)^{-1} \nabla \ell(\mathbf{w}^{(k)}, S),
$$

which converges much faster (quadratically, near the solution) than the standard gradient descent algorithm with a constant step size, at the price of solving a linear system of size $d+1$ at each iteration. In the context of logistic regression, this algorithm is also known as *Iteratively Reweighted Least Squares* (IRLS).

Let us now say a few words about regularization, which is commonly used in both regression and SVM models[13].

Regularization In order to avoid overfitting, a regularization term of the form $\lambda \|\mathbf{w}\|$ (or $\lambda \|\mathbf{w}\|^2$), where $\lambda > 0$ is a hyperparameter, is usually added to the objective, in regression as well as in classification tasks. The optimization problem of logistic regression can then be rewritten as

$$\min_{(\mathbf{w},b)\in\mathbb{R}^{d+1}} \; -\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m}\left[y_i \ln\left(g(\mathbf{w},b,\mathbf{x}_i)\right) + (1-y_i)\ln\left(1-g(\mathbf{w},b,\mathbf{x}_i)\right)\right] + \lambda\|\mathbf{w}\|^2 .$$

For linear regression, it can be written as

$$\min_{\boldsymbol{\theta}\in\mathbb{R}^{d+1}} \|\mathbf{y}-h(\boldsymbol{\theta},\mathbf{X})\|_2^2 + \lambda\|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|^2 = \min_{\boldsymbol{\theta}\in\mathbb{R}^{d+1}} \sum_{i=1}^{m}\left(y_i - h(\boldsymbol{\theta},\mathbf{x}_i)\right)^2 + \lambda\|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|^2 .$$

Note that the offset (b or θ_0) is usually not penalized.

In the two expressions above, the norm is not specified, but two norms are very often encountered: the L_1 norm $\|\cdot\|_1$ and the (squared) L_2 norm $\|\cdot\|_2^2$. The choice has an important impact on the model, and especially on the parameters it learns (see Hastie et al. (2009) for a detailed discussion):

- The L_1 norm is notably used to induce sparsity in the learned hypothesis, *i.e.* when we want the learned hypothesis to depend on as few parameters as possible. When we use this regularization term in linear regression, we talk about *Lasso regression*. This type of regularization is particularly useful for high-dimensional models, with many variables, as is the case in genetics: it highlights the most important variables for the prediction task. However, it has an important drawback: it is not differentiable at the points where some coordinates are equal to 0, and there is no closed-form solution in general, so specific optimization algorithms (*e.g.* subgradient or proximal methods) are required.
- The squared L_2 norm is used to prevent some parameters from taking too large values compared to the other parameters of the model. In this case, we talk about *Ridge regression*. The objective remains differentiable and, for linear regression, a closed-form solution is still available: $\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} = (\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X} + \lambda\mathbf{I})^{-1}\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{y}$, where the matrix to invert is always invertible when $\lambda > 0$ (for simplicity, this formula also penalizes the offset θ_0).

Ridge regression was introduced by Hoerl and Kennard (1970) to stabilize least squares when the features are strongly correlated, and the Lasso by Tibshirani (1996).

[13] If you look at the soft margin SVM problem, the data-fitting term is the mean value of the slack variables (*i.e.* the average hinge loss), and the L_2 regularization term is related to the inverse of the margin of the model.

In a nutshell: why does the L_1 norm produce sparse solutions?

By Lagrangian duality (Section 4.5), minimizing the empirical risk plus $\lambda \|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|$ amounts to minimizing the empirical risk over a ball $\{\boldsymbol{\theta} : \|\boldsymbol{\theta}\| \leq t\}$, for some radius t depending on λ. The solution is the first point where the level sets of the risk (ellipses, for least squares) touch this ball, as shown in Figure 67. The L_2 ball is round, so the contact point generally has all its coordinates nonzero: Ridge *shrinks* all the coefficients. The L_1 ball is a diamond (a cross-polytope in dimension d) whose corners lie on the axes, and the ellipses very often touch it first at a corner, where some coordinates are exactly zero: the Lasso *selects* variables.

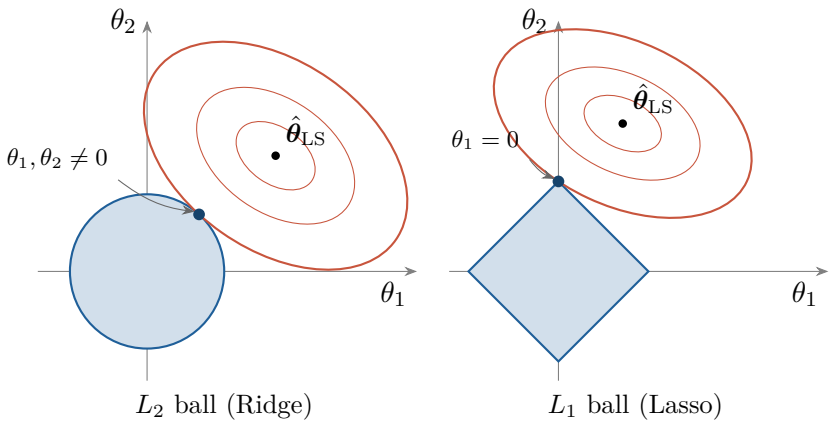


Figure 67: Geometry of Ridge (left) and Lasso (right) regularization in dimension 2. The red ellipses are level sets of the least squares objective, centered at the unregularized solution $\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}_{\text{LS}}$; the regularized solution (dark dot) is the point of the ball reached by the smallest level set. The corners of the L_1 ball lie on the axes, which produces exact zeros.

Before moving on to another algorithm, we extend *binary logistic regression* to multi-class classification.

8.5 Multinomial Logistic Regression

The previous classification algorithm was presented in the context of binary classification, and we may wonder how to adapt this procedure to multi-class classification tasks, *i.e.* how to define a *multinomial logistic regression* Engel (1988). To this aim, let us assume that the set of labels is now $\{1, 2, \ldots, q\}$, where $q > 2$. As before, we include the offset in the vector of parameters, $\mathbf{w} = (w_0, w_1, \ldots, w_d)$, and we write $\mathbf{x} = (1, x_1, \ldots, x_d)$.

In the binary case, we have built a linear model to estimate the logarithm of the ratio between the probability of belonging to class 1 and the probability of belonging to class 0 (also called a *logit*). We now have to do something similar with more than two classes: we select one class as a reference class, say class q, and we build the following models:

$$\ln\left(\frac{Pr(y=1 \mid \mathbf{x})}{Pr(y=q \mid \mathbf{x})}\right) = \langle \mathbf{w}^{(1)}, \mathbf{x} \rangle,$$

$$\ln\left(\frac{Pr(y=2 \mid \mathbf{x})}{Pr(y=q \mid \mathbf{x})}\right) = \langle \mathbf{w}^{(2)}, \mathbf{x}\rangle,$$
$$\vdots$$
$$\ln\left(\frac{Pr(y=q-1 \mid \mathbf{x})}{Pr(y=q \mid \mathbf{x})}\right) = \langle \mathbf{w}^{(q-1)}, \mathbf{x}\rangle.$$

From this set of equations, we can recover the value of $Pr(y=k \mid \mathbf{x})$ for all $k=1,\dots,q$. Indeed, if we take the exponential of each equation, sum all of them, and use the fact that $\sum_{k=1}^{q-1} Pr(y=k \mid \mathbf{x}) = 1 - Pr(y=q \mid \mathbf{x})$, we get

$$\frac{1-Pr(y=q \mid \mathbf{x})}{Pr(y=q \mid \mathbf{x})} = \sum_{k=1}^{q-1} \exp\left(\langle \mathbf{w}^{(k)}, \mathbf{x}\rangle\right),$$

and thus

$$Pr(y=q \mid \mathbf{x}) = \frac{1}{1+\sum_{k=1}^{q-1}\exp\left(\langle \mathbf{w}^{(k)}, \mathbf{x}\rangle\right)}.$$

Using this equality, we immediately obtain, for all $k \in [\![1, q-1]\!]$,

$$Pr(y=k \mid \mathbf{x}) = \frac{\exp\left(\langle \mathbf{w}^{(k)}, \mathbf{x}\rangle\right)}{1+\sum_{l=1}^{q-1}\exp\left(\langle \mathbf{w}^{(l)}, \mathbf{x}\rangle\right)}.$$

Let us make a few remarks about this model:

- the probabilities defined above sum to 1;
- the number of parameters to learn is equal to the number of parameters of a single binary logistic regression times the number of classes minus one, *i.e.* $(q-1)\times(d+1)$;
- the way the model is built depends on the choice of the reference class: if we change it, the parameters have no reason to remain the same (although the modeled probabilities can be the same).

A simple way to learn this model is to fit $q-1$ binary logistic regressions, the k-th one opposing class k to the reference class q (on the examples of these two classes only), which gives a simple approximation of the joint estimate; the parameters can also be estimated jointly, by maximizing the multinomial likelihood described below. At the prediction step, we compute all the probabilities $Pr(y=k \mid \mathbf{x})$, $k=1,\dots,q$, and a new example $\mathbf{x}$ is assigned to the class with the highest probability, *i.e.*

$$\hat{y} = \arg\max_{k \in [\![1,q]\!]} Pr(y=k \mid \mathbf{x}).$$

The above procedure has the advantage of reusing the tools presented in the binary setting. However, it requires learning $q-1$ models which depend on a reference class. To address this last issue, and make our model independent of the reference class q, we can consider a parameter vector $\mathbf{w}^{(k)}$ for every class and define the probabilities by

$$Pr(y=k \mid \mathbf{x}) = \frac{\exp\left(\langle \mathbf{w}^{(k)}, \mathbf{x}\rangle\right)}{\sum_{l=1}^{q}\exp\left(\langle \mathbf{w}^{(l)}, \mathbf{x}\rangle\right)}, \quad \forall k = 1,\dots,q.$$

This function is known as the **softmax** function (it can be seen as a generalization of the logistic function), and the probabilities still sum to one. Note that adding the same vector to all the $\mathbf{w}^{(k)}$ does not change these probabilities: the parameters are thus only defined up to such a shift. Setting $\mathbf{w}^{(q)} = \mathbf{0}$ gives back the model with reference class q, while adding a regularization term is another common way to remove this indeterminacy. For $q = 2$, the softmax reduces to the logistic function applied to $\langle \mathbf{w}^{(1)} - \mathbf{w}^{(2)}, \mathbf{x} \rangle$.

It remains to explain the word *multinomial* in the name of the model. In the binary case, we have assumed that the label is drawn according to a Bernoulli distribution (*i.e.* a binomial distribution with $n = 1$). With q classes, the label of an example $\mathbf{x}$ now follows a categorical distribution (*i.e.* a multinomial distribution with $n = 1$) whose parameters are the q probabilities $Pr(y = k \mid \mathbf{x})$, $k = 1, \dots, q$. Denoting by $\mathbf{W} = (\mathbf{w}^{(1)}, \dots, \mathbf{w}^{(q)})$ the matrix of all the parameters, the likelihood $\mathfrak{L}$ of our data is therefore based on the *multinomial distribution* and defined by

$$\begin{aligned}\mathfrak{L}(\mathbf{W}, S) &= \prod_{i=1}^{m} \prod_{k=1}^{q} Pr(y = k \mid \mathbf{x}_i)^{\mathbb{1}_{\{y_i = k\}}} \\ &= \prod_{i=1}^{m} \prod_{k=1}^{q} \left(\frac{\exp\left(\langle \mathbf{w}^{(k)}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle\right)}{\sum_{l=1}^{q} \exp\left(\langle \mathbf{w}^{(l)}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle\right)} \right)^{\mathbb{1}_{\{y_i = k\}}}.\end{aligned}$$

The negative log-likelihood ℓ, also called the *cross-entropy loss*, can then be written as

$$\ell(\mathbf{W}, S) = -\sum_{i=1}^{m} \sum_{k=1}^{q} \mathbb{1}_{\{y_i = k\}} \ln \left(\frac{\exp\left(\langle \mathbf{w}^{(k)}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle\right)}{\sum_{l=1}^{q} \exp\left(\langle \mathbf{w}^{(l)}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle\right)} \right). \tag{8.18}$$

The estimation of the parameters works exactly as in the binary case: there is no analytical solution to the minimization of (8.18), and we usually use a gradient descent or a Newton-Raphson algorithm. It is thus necessary to compute the gradient (and the Hessian matrix) of ℓ with respect to all the parameters. Denoting by $p_k(\mathbf{x}_i)$ the softmax probability of class k for the example $\mathbf{x}_i$, the gradient with respect to $\mathbf{w}^{(k)}$ takes a form very similar to the binary case:

$$\nabla_{\mathbf{w}^{(k)}} \ell(\mathbf{W}, S) = -\sum_{i=1}^{m} \Big(\mathbb{1}_{\{y_i = k\}} - p_k(\mathbf{x}_i) \Big) \mathbf{x}_i, \quad \forall k = 1, \dots, q.$$

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q8.8. Why does the Lasso produce exact zeros in the coefficients, whereas Ridge regression does not?

Q8.9. A logistic regression model gives the score $h(\mathbf{w}, b, \mathbf{x}) = \ln 3$ for an example $\mathbf{x}$. What is the estimated probability that $y = 1$? What are the odds?

Q8.10. How many parameters does a multinomial logistic regression with a reference class have for images of 28×28 pixels and $q = 10$ classes? And the softmax version with one vector per class?

In the next section, we focus on a nonparametric counterpart of regression, called *kernel regression*.

8.6 Kernel Regression

The linear and logistic regression models presented in the previous sections are both **parametric models**, *i.e.* we need to learn (or estimate) a fixed number of parameters, which determine the shape of the model, in order to make predictions.

There also exist **nonparametric models**, which do not rely on a fixed set of parameters. The prediction for a new instance is then directly based on the training instances and, more precisely, on those which are the most similar to it. The k-NN algorithm is an example of such a model.

Let us consider the problem of estimating the value of y given the value of $\mathbf{x}$; for the illustration, $\mathbf{x}$ is a real number. The data, together with the linear regression model learned from them, are represented in Figure 68.

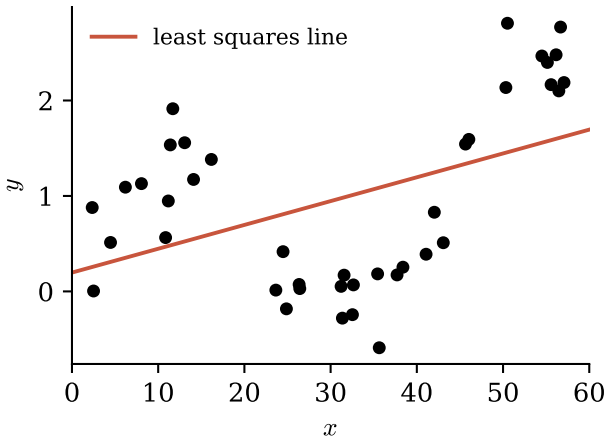


Figure 68: Representation of the data and of the linear model learned to fit them. This model is not appropriate, and it seems that we should use a nonlinear one.

Using a linear model to estimate the values of y does not seem appropriate here. How would a nonparametric model perform in this case?

Let us introduce a first simple model. To estimate the value $y(\mathbf{x})$ associated with $\mathbf{x}$, we simply compute the mean of the values $y_i = y(\mathbf{x}_i)$ of the neighbors of $\mathbf{x}$, *i.e.* of the training examples lying at a distance at most λ from $\mathbf{x}$. The estimator h is thus given by

$$h(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{m} K_\lambda(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}_i) y_i}{\sum_{i=1}^{m} K_\lambda(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}_i)},$$

where, in this case, $K_\lambda(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}_i) = 1$ if the distance $\|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}_i\|$ between $\mathbf{x}$ and $\mathbf{x}_i$ is lower than or equal to λ, and 0 otherwise. This estimator is a local average, but it has two drawbacks: it is discontinuous (a training point suddenly enters or leaves the neighborhood when $\mathbf{x}$ moves), and it is not defined when no training point lies within distance λ of $\mathbf{x}$. A natural idea is to replace this "all-or-nothing" weight by a weight which decreases smoothly with the distance. This leads to the following definition, due independently to Nadaraya (1964) and Watson (1964).

Definition 8.3: Kernel regression (Nadaraya-Watson estimator)

Let $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m \subset \mathbb{R}^d \times \mathbb{R}$ be a sample of size m, let $\lambda > 0$ be a bandwidth, and let $K_\lambda(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = D\left(\frac{\|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}'\|}{\lambda}\right)$, where $D : \mathbb{R}_+ \to \mathbb{R}_+$ is a nonincreasing function. The kernel regression estimator is defined, for all $\mathbf{x}$ such that the denominator is positive, by

$$h(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^m K_\lambda(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}_i)\, y_i}{\sum_{i=1}^m K_\lambda(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}_i)} = \sum_{i=1}^m \omega_i(\mathbf{x})\, y_i, \quad \text{with} \quad \omega_i(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{K_\lambda(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}_i)}{\sum_{j=1}^m K_\lambda(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}_j)}.$$

The prediction is thus a weighted average of the training outputs, whose weights $\omega_i(\mathbf{x})$ are nonnegative, sum to one, and are larger for the training points close to $\mathbf{x}$. Equivalently, $h(\mathbf{x})$ is the constant c which minimizes the locally weighted squared error $\sum_{i=1}^m K_\lambda(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}_i)(y_i - c)^2$: kernel regression fits a constant model locally, around each query point (see Hastie et al. (2009) for extensions such as local linear regression). Common choices for D are the "box" function $D(t) = \mathbb{1}_{\{t \leq 1\}}$, which gives back the first estimator, and the Gaussian function $D(t) = \exp(-t^2/2)$, which gives $K_\lambda(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}_i) = \exp\left(-\frac{\|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}_i\|^2}{2\lambda^2}\right)$ (multiplicative constants do not matter since they cancel out in the ratio).

The bandwidth λ plays the same role as k in the k-NN algorithm and controls the bias-variance trade-off:

- when λ is small, only the very close points are taken into account: the estimator follows the data closely and is very wiggly (low bias, high variance, risk of overfitting);
- when λ is large, all the points receive almost the same weight: the estimator becomes almost constant, close to the mean of the y_i's (high bias, low variance, risk of underfitting).

As usual, λ is selected by cross-validation. Note that, like the k-NN algorithm, kernel regression requires storing the whole training set and computing m distances for each prediction.

Example 8.7. Let us consider the four training points $(1, 1)$, $(2, 3)$, $(3, 2)$ and $(4, 6)$, and let us predict the output at $x = 2.5$.

- With the box kernel and $\lambda = 1$, only the points $x_2 = 2$ and $x_3 = 3$ are within distance 1 of x, so $h(2.5) = \frac{3+2}{2} = 2.5$.
- With the box kernel and $\lambda = 2$, all four points are taken into account, and $h(2.5) = \frac{1+3+2+6}{4} = 3$, the global mean.
- With the Gaussian kernel and $\lambda = 1$, the weights are $\exp(-1.5^2/2) \simeq 0.32$ for x_1 and x_4, and $\exp(-0.5^2/2) \simeq 0.88$ for x_2 and x_3, so

$$h(2.5) \simeq \frac{0.32 \times 1 + 0.88 \times 3 + 0.88 \times 2 + 0.32 \times 6}{2 \times 0.32 + 2 \times 0.88} \simeq 2.77.$$

All the points contribute to the Gaussian estimate, but the closest ones contribute more.

Figure 69 shows the estimators obtained with these two kernels on the data of Figure 68: both follow the nonlinear trend of the data, and the Gaussian kernel gives a much smoother curve than the box kernel. Its right panel illustrates the role of the bandwidth: a very small λ gives an irregular estimator that follows the noise, while a very large λ gives an almost constant one.

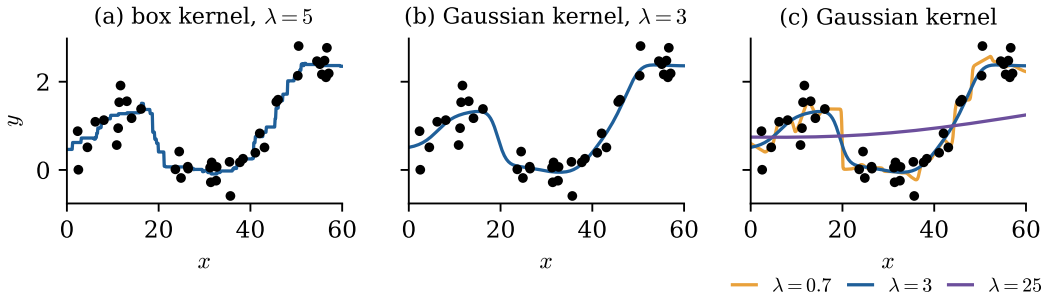


Figure 69: Kernel regression (Nadaraya-Watson) estimators on the data of Figure 68: (a) box kernel $K_\lambda(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}_i) = \mathbb{1}_{\{\|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}_i\| \leq \lambda\}}$ with $\lambda = 5$; (b) Gaussian kernel $K_\lambda(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}_i) = \exp\left(-\|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}_i\|^2/(2\lambda^2)\right)$ with $\lambda = 3$; (c) Gaussian kernel with a too small ($\lambda = 0.7$, overfitting), a reasonable ($\lambda = 3$) and a too large ($\lambda = 25$, underfitting) bandwidth.

The next algorithm we present can be used for both regression and classification tasks. It can return the probability of belonging to a given class, like logistic regression, or directly assign a label, like the SVM or the k-NN algorithm.

8.7 Decision Trees (classification and regression)

Two classical families of decision tree algorithms coexist: the Classification and Regression Trees (CART) algorithm introduced by Breiman et al. (1984), which is the version most widely used today, and the ID3 algorithm (and its successors) introduced by Quinlan (1986).

A decision tree consists of a series of rules which are successively applied to the dataset in order to split the data into two or more groups. Here, we only focus on binary decision trees, *i.e.* trees in which each decision rule splits the dataset into exactly two subsets.

The nature of the tree depends on the output space $\mathcal{Y}$:

- when $\mathcal{Y} \subset \mathbb{R}$, we talk about a regression tree;
- when $\mathcal{Y}$ is a finite set of classes, *e.g.* $\mathcal{Y} = \{-1, 1\}$, we talk about a classification tree.

An example of classification tree is provided in Figure 70 on a toy dataset, in which we aim to separate two classes (male and female) using two descriptors (age and height) and a set of rules. The initial dataset is composed of 4 females and 3 males. The first decision rule, *Age*$\leq$ 25, divides the initial dataset into two groups: one composed of two females, and the other one of 3 males and 2 females. The group on the left is *pure*, since it only contains females, so we no longer need to split it. We then apply a second decision rule, *Height*$\leq$ 170, which separates the remaining males and females. To predict the label of a new example, we simply follow the rules from the root to a

leaf, and predict the majority class of that leaf (the proportion of each class in the leaf can also be used as an estimate of the class probabilities).

Toy dataset

Age	Height	Sex
20	175	F
32	180	M
40	175	M
28	172	M
22	165	F
40	169	F
70	170	F

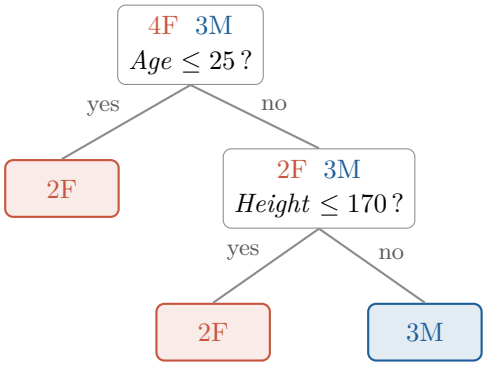


Figure 70: An example of classification tree learned on the toy dataset on the left (F: female, M: male). Each internal node shows its class counts and its decision rule; the three leaves are pure.

Such an algorithm is able to separate complex (not linearly separable) datasets by using a large number of decision rules. To choose the decision rules, we define a criterion to optimize.

For this purpose, we need two tools: a *metric* which evaluates the quality (or impurity) of a node, and a measure of the improvement obtained after a split, called the *gain* Safavian and Landgrebe (1991); Rokach and Maimon (2005).

The metric depends on the type of tree we are dealing with. A list of such metrics is provided by Rokach and Maimon (2005), among which:

- the *variance*, used for regression trees:

$$\frac{1}{m_N}\sum_{i=1}^{m_N}(y_i-\bar{y})^2,$$

  where m_N denotes the number of examples in the node N and $\bar{y}$ the average value of the y_i's in this node;

- the *entropy*, a notion also used in physics to quantify the disorder of a system, defined by $Ent_N = -\sum_{j=1}^{L} p_j \log_2(p_j)$ (with the convention $0\log_2 0 = 0$), where p_j is the proportion of examples of class j in the node N and L is the number of classes;

- the *Gini impurity*, used for classification trees. It measures the impurity of a node from the proportions of the different classes present in the node. For instance, in binary classification[14], the Gini impurity G_N of a node N is defined by

$$G_N = \sum_{j\in\{-1,1\}} p_j(1-p_j) = 2p_1(1-p_1), \tag{8.19}$$

  where p_j denotes the proportion of examples of class j in the node.

[14] The definition can be extended to L classes: the Gini impurity is then defined by $G_N = \sum_{j=1}^{L} p_j(1-p_j) = 1-\sum_{j=1}^{L} p_j^2$, where p_j is the proportion of examples of class j in the node N.

In the binary setting, the Gini impurity is a real number which belongs to $[0, 0.5]$. A value of 0 means that the node is pure, *i.e.* it only contains examples from one class. A value of 0.5 means that the node contains the same number of examples from both classes. Similarly, the binary entropy belongs to $[0, 1]$, with the same interpretation of its extreme values.

Let us now illustrate this notion. In the previous example (Figure 70), the Gini impurity of the root is $G_{\text{root}} = 2 \times \frac{4}{7}\left(1 - \frac{4}{7}\right) = \frac{24}{49} \simeq 0.49$, while it is equal to 0 and $\frac{12}{25}$ respectively in the two nodes obtained after the first split. We have already said that the node on the left is *pure*, because it only contains examples from one class; its Gini impurity therefore cannot be improved.

The next step consists in choosing the optimal rule to split a node into two child nodes. This rule is chosen so as to decrease the impurity as much as possible. For this purpose, we define the *Gini gain* Γ of a split of a node N (here the root) into two nodes N_L and N_R as follows:

$$\Gamma = G_{\text{root}} - \left(\frac{|N_L|}{|N_L| + |N_R|} G_{N_L} + \frac{|N_R|}{|N_L| + |N_R|} G_{N_R}\right),$$

where $|N_L|$ and $|N_R|$ denote the numbers of examples in the left and right nodes, and G_{N_L} and G_{N_R} their Gini impurities. In our example, the first split has a gain $\Gamma = \frac{24}{49} - \frac{5}{7} \times \frac{12}{25} = \frac{36}{245} \simeq 0.15$ (with the entropy instead of the Gini impurity, the gain would be $0.985 - \frac{5}{7} \times 0.971 \simeq 0.29$).

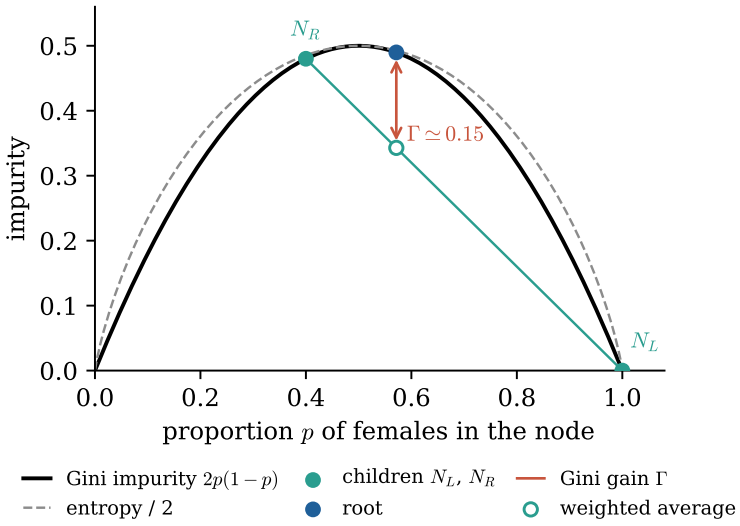


Figure 71: Illustration of the Gini gain using the first split of the example presented in Figure 70, as a function of the proportion p of females in a node. The root ($p = 4/7$) is split into N_L ($p = 1$) and N_R ($p = 2/5$); the weighted average of the impurities of the children lies on the green chord, and the red arrow represents the Gini gain Γ. The (halved) entropy has a very similar shape.

Figure 71 illustrates the use of the Gini impurity as a metric to build our decision tree on this example. The red arrow represents the Gini gain Γ. This figure also shows that the Gini impurity is a concave function of the proportion p_1. Since the proportion of a class in the parent node is the weighted average of its proportions in the two child nodes, this concavity ensures, by Jensen's inequality Jensen (1906) (Proposition 1.3 in

Section 1), that the gain is always nonnegative: a split never increases the (weighted) impurity. Note, however, that a split does not necessarily decrease the classification error of the tree, which is precisely why a concave impurity measure is used instead of the error rate. At each step, we choose the feature and the corresponding threshold which maximize the gain Γ. The decision rule is then applied, and the nodes are recursively split until pure leaves are obtained.

In practice, it is always possible to obtain such perfect leaves (unless two identical inputs have different labels). However, such trees tend to overfit and to generalize poorly. To overcome this issue, we usually restrict the growth of the tree (pre-pruning) using hyperparameters such as:

- the maximal *size/depth* of the tree;
- the size of a node: the minimum number of examples required in a node to split it;
- the size of a leaf: the minimum number of examples in each of the two leaves after a split;
- a threshold on the gain: the minimum value of the gain required to make a new split.

Another strategy (post-pruning) consists in growing a full tree and then removing the branches which do not improve the performance enough, as done in the cost-complexity pruning of CART Breiman et al. (1984).

Geometrically, each decision rule of the form $x_j \leq s$ cuts a region of the input space into two by a hyperplane orthogonal to the j-th axis: a tree thus partitions the space into axis-aligned rectangles $R_1, \ldots, R_L$, one per leaf, and predicts a constant (a class or a value) in each of them, as shown in Figure 72.

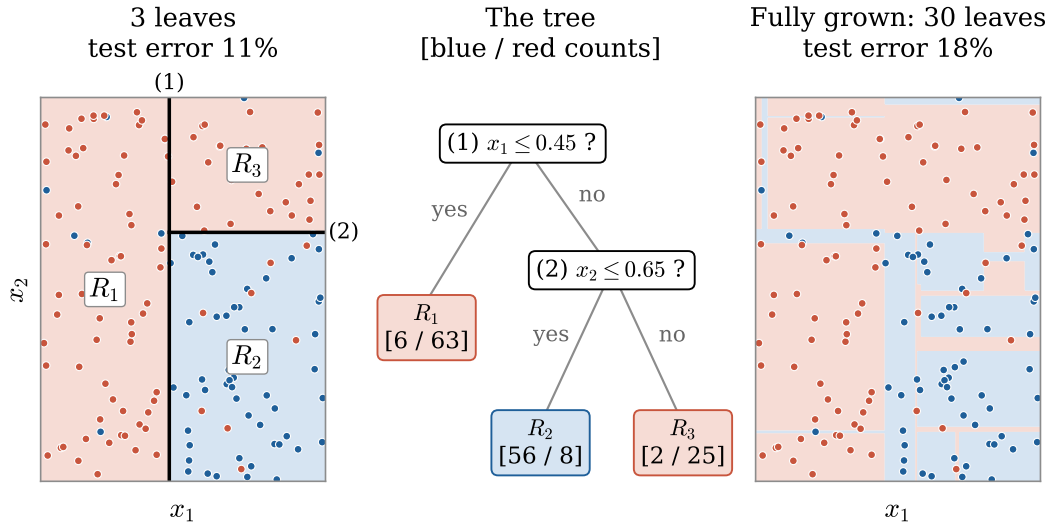


Figure 72: Left and middle: a small classification tree (three leaves) learned on 160 points of $[0, 1]^2$, 10% of whose labels have been flipped, and the corresponding partition of the input space into axis-aligned rectangles; (1) and (2) mark the two splits. Right: the fully grown tree has pure leaves, isolates the noisy points in small rectangles and has a larger test error.

Pitfall: deep trees overfit and are unstable A fully grown tree reaches a zero training error (when no two identical inputs have different labels), but, as in the right panel of Figure 72, it does so by creating tiny leaves around noisy examples: its test error is much larger than its training error. Deep trees also have a high variance in another sense: a small change in the training set can change the first split, and hence the whole tree. Therefore, never select the depth of a tree on the training error; tune the pruning hyperparameters by cross-validation. This instability is also what ensemble methods such as bagging and random forests exploit by averaging many trees (Section 10).

The gain defined above can be used with any impurity measure: entropy, Gini impurity, variance, or any other measure you may want to define.

Before moving on to another topic, let us consider another example with the same dataset, where we now aim to predict the age of a person from his or her height, using a regression tree. We first compute the variance at the root of the tree; in our case, it is equal to $Var_{\text{root}} \simeq 245.71$. We now have to find the binary split for which the gain, defined by

$$\Gamma = Var_{\text{root}} - \left(\frac{|N_L|}{|N_L| + |N_R|} Var_{N_L} + \frac{|N_R|}{|N_L| + |N_R|} Var_{N_R} \right),$$

is the highest. For this purpose, we test the possible thresholds on the variable *height* and compute the associated values of Γ. The results of these computations are provided in Table 3 and show that, among the three tested splits, the best one is obtained with a threshold equal to 170. In a regression tree, the prediction associated with a leaf is the average output of the training examples it contains.

Threshold	$\lvert N_L \rvert$	$\lvert N_R \rvert$	Var_{N_L}	Var_{N_R}	Γ
169	2	5	81	297.6	10
170	3	4	392	52	**48**
172	4	3	342	67.56	21.33

Table 3: Values of the gain Γ, in terms of variance, for three different thresholds. An instance whose height is lower than or equal to the threshold is put in the left node, and in the right one otherwise.

Later in this document, we will see how decision trees can be combined to build stronger algorithms.

Summary Table 4 summarizes the main features of the algorithms presented in this section. There is no universally best algorithm: the choice depends on the size and dimension of the data, on the need for probabilities or for an interpretable model, and on the computational budget, and it should be validated experimentally (*e.g.* by cross-validation).

We conclude the presentation of the standard algorithms with Neural Networks, in the next section.

Algorithm	Task	Parametric	Output	Main hyperparameters
k-NN	classif./regression	no	label	k, distance
SVM	classification	yes*	label (score)	C, kernel
Linear regression	regression	yes	real value	regularization λ
Logistic regression	classification	yes	probability	regularization λ
Kernel regression	regression	no	real value	bandwidth λ, kernel
Decision tree	classif./regression	no	label/prob./value	depth, leaf size

* with a nonlinear kernel, the number of dual parameters grows with m.

Table 4: Summary of the supervised algorithms presented in this section.

To remember from Section 8

- The 0-1 loss is replaced by convex surrogates (hinge, logistic, exponential), written as functions of the margin $yh(\mathbf{x})$.
- k-NN is a nonparametric, memory-based rule; k controls the bias-variance trade-off, and the method requires scaled features and suffers from the curse of dimensionality.
- The SVM maximizes the margin $2/\|\mathbf{w}\|_2$; its soft margin version minimizes a regularized hinge loss. The dual only involves inner products, which the kernel trick replaces by a kernel K; the solution only depends on the support vectors ($\alpha_i > 0$).
- Linear regression has a closed-form solution; logistic regression models the log-odds linearly, is fitted by maximum likelihood (gradient descent or Newton/IRLS), and extends to q classes with the softmax. L_2 regularization shrinks the coefficients, L_1 regularization sets some of them to zero.
- Kernel regression is a locally weighted average whose bandwidth λ plays the role of k.
- Decision trees recursively split the space into axis-aligned rectangles by maximizing an impurity gain (Gini, entropy, variance); they are interpretable but overfit when grown fully, hence pruning.
- In all cases, the hyperparameters (k, C, γ or σ, λ, depth) are selected by cross-validation.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q8.11. Why do we minimize a surrogate loss rather than the 0-1 loss itself?

Q8.12. Which algorithm of this section is insensitive to a rescaling of the features, and why?

Q8.13. What does the Nadaraya-Watson estimator with a Gaussian kernel become when $\lambda \to +\infty$? And when $\lambda \to 0$?

Q8.14. What is the Gini impurity of a node containing the same number of examples of 3 classes? Is it the maximal value for 3 classes?

Q8.15. A node contains 80 examples of class 1 and 20 of class -1. It is split into a pure node (50 examples of class 1) and a node with 30 examples of class 1 and 20 of class -1. What

is the decrease of the misclassification error? Why do trees use the Gini impurity or the entropy instead?

Q8.16. Which algorithms of this section must keep (part of) the training set in memory to make predictions?

Exercises

Exercise 8.1. **(Proof)** Let $y \in \{-1, 1\}$ and $t = h(\mathbf{x}) \in \mathbb{R}$. (a) Show that $\mathbb{1}_{\{yt \leq 0\}} \leq \max(0, 1 - yt)$, $\mathbb{1}_{\{yt \leq 0\}} \leq \exp(-yt)$ and $\mathbb{1}_{\{yt \leq 0\}} \leq \log_2(1 + \exp(-yt))$. (b) Deduce that the empirical risks associated with the hinge, exponential and (normalized) logistic losses upper bound the empirical 0-1 risk. (c) The squared loss $(1 - yt)^2$ also upper bounds the 0-1 loss. Why is it nevertheless a questionable surrogate for classification? *Hint:* distinguish the cases $yt \leq 0$ and $yt > 0$.

Exercise 8.2. **(Comprehension)** For each hyperparameter below, say whether *increasing* it makes the learned model more complex (more prone to overfitting) or simpler (more prone to underfitting): (a) the number k of neighbors of k-NN; (b) the parameter C of the soft margin SVM; (c) the parameter $\gamma = 1/(2\sigma^2)$ of the Gaussian kernel; (d) the regularization parameter λ of Ridge or Lasso regression; (e) the bandwidth λ of kernel regression; (f) the maximal depth of a decision tree; (g) the minimal number of examples in a leaf of a decision tree. Then, (h) a model has a training error of 1% and a validation error of 25%: in which direction would you move each hyperparameter?

Exercise 8.3. **(Computation)** Consider the training set below, with two features on very different scales, and the query $\mathbf{x}' = (0.12, 218)$.

	P_1	P_2	P_3	P_4	P_5
x_1	0.10	0.20	0.90	0.85	0.15
x_2	200	260	215	225	330
y	$+1$	$+1$	-1	-1	$+1$

(a) Compute the Euclidean distances between $\mathbf{x}'$ and the five training points, and give the predictions of the 1-NN and 3-NN rules. (b) Rescale both features to $[0, 1]$ (min-max normalization) using the minimum and maximum computed *on the training set*, apply the same transformation to $\mathbf{x}'$, and answer the same questions. (c) Comment.

Exercise 8.4. **(Computation)** We consider the sample S made of $\mathbf{x}_1 = (2, 0)$ and $\mathbf{x}_2 = (0, 2)$, with label $+1$, and $\mathbf{x}_3 = (0, 0)$, with label -1.

(a) Draw the sample and explain why it is linearly separable.

(b) Write the hard margin SVM problem (Definition 8.1) for this sample.

(c) The problem is invariant when the two coordinates are swapped, and its solution $\mathbf{w}$ is unique; deduce that $\mathbf{w} = (a, a)$ for some $a \in \mathbb{R}$. Show that the constraints reduce to $b \leq -1$ and $2a + b \geq 1$, and solve the problem.

(d) Compute the margin γ. Which points are support vectors?

(e) Using the KKT conditions (8.9) and (8.10), compute the dual variables $\alpha_1, \alpha_2, \alpha_3$. Check that the optimal values of the primal and dual problems coincide.

(f) Predict the labels of $(1, 0.2)$ and $(0.3, 0.3)$.

(g) For which values of C does the soft margin SVM (Definition 8.2) return the same solution?

Exercise 8.5. **(Proof)** (a) Let K_1 and K_2 be two kernels on $\mathbb{R}^d$ and $a, b \geq 0$. Show that $aK_1 + bK_2$ is a kernel. (b) Let $\Phi : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}^D$ be any map. Show that $K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \langle \Phi(\mathbf{x}), \Phi(\mathbf{x}') \rangle$ is a kernel. Using the feature map of Figure 62, deduce that $K(x, x') = xx' + x^2x'^2$ is a kernel on $\mathbb{R}$. (c) Is $K(x, x') = -xx'$ a kernel on $\mathbb{R}$? *Hint:* check the symmetry and compute $\mathbf{c}^T(a\mathbf{K}_1 + b\mathbf{K}_2)\mathbf{c}$.

Exercise 8.6. **(Computation)** (a) For $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^3$, find a feature map Φ such that $(\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z} \rangle)^2 = \langle \Phi(\mathbf{x}), \Phi(\mathbf{z}) \rangle$, and give its dimension. (b) Admitting that the number of monomials of degree at most p in d variables is $\binom{d+p}{p}$, give the dimension of the feature space of the polynomial kernel $(\langle \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z} \rangle + c)^p$ with $c > 0$, and check it on the example of the notes ($d = 2$, $p = 2$). (c) Compare, for $d = 100$ and $p = 3$, the cost of computing $\Phi(\mathbf{x})$ explicitly and that of computing $K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z})$.

Exercise 8.7. **(Proof)** Let $K(\mathbf{x},\mathbf{z}) = \exp(-\|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{z}\|_2^2/(2\sigma^2))$ be the Gaussian kernel and Φ an associated feature map, *i.e.* $K(\mathbf{x},\mathbf{z}) = \langle\Phi(\mathbf{x}),\Phi(\mathbf{z})\rangle$. (a) Show that $\|\Phi(\mathbf{x})\| = 1$ for all $\mathbf{x}$, and that $\|\Phi(\mathbf{x})-\Phi(\mathbf{z})\|^2 = 2-2K(\mathbf{x},\mathbf{z})$. Interpret. (b) Let $\mathbf{x}_1,\dots,\mathbf{x}_m$ be distinct points. What is the limit of the kernel matrix $\mathbf{K}$ when $\sigma \to 0$? (c) In this limit, and with $b=0$, show that the decision function $f(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_i \alpha_i y_i K(\mathbf{x},\mathbf{x}_i)$ with $\alpha_i = 1$ classifies every training example correctly, whatever the labels. What does f predict for a new point $\mathbf{x} \notin \{\mathbf{x}_1,\dots,\mathbf{x}_m\}$? Conclude.

Exercise 8.8. **(Computation)** We observe the points (x_i,y_i): $(0,1)$, $(1,3)$, $(2,2)$ and $(3,5)$, and we fit $h(\boldsymbol{\theta},x) = \theta_0+\theta_1 x$. (a) Write the design matrix $\mathbf{X}$, compute $\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}$ and $\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{y}$, and solve the normal equations. (b) Compute the residuals, check that they sum to zero, and compute the training mean squared error. Predict the output at $x=4$. (c) We now add the penalty $\lambda\theta_1^2$ (the offset is not penalized). Show that $\hat\theta_0 = \bar y - \hat\theta_1\bar x$ and $\hat\theta_1 = \frac{\sum_i (x_i-\bar x)(y_i-\bar y)}{\sum_i (x_i-\bar x)^2+\lambda}$, and compute the solution for $\lambda = 1$.

Exercise 8.9. **(Proof)** Let $\mathbf{X}\in\mathbb{R}^{m\times(d+1)}$, $\mathbf{y}\in\mathbb{R}^m$ and $\lambda>0$. (a) Show that $\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}+\lambda\mathbf{I}$ is positive definite, hence invertible, even when $\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}$ is not (for instance when $d+1>m$). (b) Derive the closed form $\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} = (\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}+\lambda\mathbf{I})^{-1}\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{y}$ of Ridge regression and justify that it is the unique minimizer. (c) What are the limits of $\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ when $\lambda\to+\infty$ and, if $\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}$ is invertible, when $\lambda\to 0$? *Hint:* for all $\mathbf{u}\neq 0$, $\mathbf{u}^T(\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}+\lambda\mathbf{I})\mathbf{u} = \|\mathbf{X}\mathbf{u}\|_2^2 + \lambda\|\mathbf{u}\|_2^2$.

Exercise 8.10. **(Computation)** We fit a logistic regression without offset, $Pr(y=1 \mid x) = \sigma(wx)$ with $\sigma(t) = 1/(1+e^{-t})$, on the four examples (x_i,y_i): $(-2,0)$, $(-1,0)$, $(1,1)$, $(2,0)$.

(a) Write the negative log-likelihood $\ell(w)$.

(b) Show that $\ell'(w) = -\sum_i (y_i-\sigma(wx_i))x_i$ and $\ell''(w) = \sum_i \sigma(wx_i)(1-\sigma(wx_i))x_i^2$. Is ℓ convex?

(c) Starting from $w^{(0)}=0$, perform one Newton-Raphson step.

(d) The Newton iterations converge to $\hat w \simeq 0.420$. Interpret $e^{\hat w}$, and compute the estimated probability that $y=1$ when $x=1$.

(e) The label of the last example is now changed to $y_4 = 1$. Show that $\ell(w)$ is decreasing and tends to 0 when $w\to+\infty$. What can we say about the maximum likelihood estimator? How can this be fixed?

Exercise 8.11. **(Proof)** For q classes and scores $z_k = \langle\mathbf{w}^{(k)},\mathbf{x}\rangle$, let $p_k = e^{z_k}/\sum_{l=1}^q e^{z_l}$. (a) Show that the probabilities $(p_k)_k$ do not change when the same vector $\mathbf{v}$ is added to all the $\mathbf{w}^{(k)}$. (b) Show that, for $q=2$, $p_1 = \sigma(\langle\mathbf{w}^{(1)}-\mathbf{w}^{(2)},\mathbf{x}\rangle)$, where σ is the logistic function. (c) For one example with label y, the cross-entropy loss is $-\ln p_y$. Show that $\frac{\partial(-\ln p_y)}{\partial z_k} = p_k - \mathbb{1}_{\{y=k\}}$, and deduce the expression of $\nabla_{\mathbf{w}^{(k)}}\ell(\mathbf{W},S)$ given in the notes.

Exercise 8.12. **(Computation)** A node contains 60 examples of class 1 and 40 examples of class -1. Two splits are considered: split A sends $(40,0)$ examples (class 1, class -1) to the left and $(20,40)$ to the right; split B sends $(50,20)$ to the left and $(10,20)$ to the right.

(a) Compute the Gini impurity and the entropy of the node.

(b) Compute the Gini gain and the entropy gain of both splits. Which split is chosen?

(c) Compute the decrease of the misclassification rate for both splits.

(d) Using the concavity of $p\mapsto 2p(1-p)$, show that the Gini gain of any split is nonnegative.

Exercise 8.13. **(Application)** For each of the following problems, propose one algorithm of this section, justify your choice and name the hyperparameters to tune. (a) A bank wants the probability of default of its 10^6 clients, described by 30 numerical features, and must be able to explain the influence of each feature to the regulator. (b) 500 images of 100×100 gray pixels must be classified into two classes; the boundary is known to be nonlinear. (c) Physicians want a small set of readable rules to triage patients, from features measured in very different units

(age, temperature, blood counts). (d) For a kernel SVM in situation (a), how much memory would the full kernel matrix require (in double precision, 8 bytes per entry)?

Exercise 8.14. **(Python)** Using `scikit-learn`, load the breast cancer dataset with the function `load_breast_cancer`, keep 30% of the data as a test set, and select the number of neighbors $k \in \{1, 3, \ldots, 29\}$ of a k-NN classifier by 5-fold cross-validation on the training set, (a) without scaling and (b) with a `StandardScaler` placed in a `Pipeline`. Compare the selected k, the cross-validation accuracy and the test accuracy. Why must the scaler be inside the pipeline?

Exercise 8.15. **(Python)** Load the diabetes dataset (`load_diabetes`, $m = 442$, $d = 10$). For $\alpha \in \{0.01, 0.1, 1, 10\}$, fit a `Lasso(alpha)` and a `Ridge(alpha)` model, and count the nonzero coefficients. Which features are kept by the Lasso for $\alpha = 1$? Relate your observations to Figure 67. (In `scikit-learn`, the Lasso minimizes $\frac{1}{2m} \|\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{X}\mathbf{w}\|_2^2 + \alpha \|\mathbf{w}\|_1$.)

9 Neural Networks

Neural networks are the last family of models presented in this part. They can be used for classification and for regression, but also, as we will see at the end of the section, in unsupervised learning (dimensionality reduction, generative models). They are at the heart of what is now called *deep learning*, which has driven most of the recent progress in computer vision, speech recognition and natural language processing. A neural network is nothing more than a parametric function obtained by *composing* simple operations (affine maps and non-linear functions), whose parameters are learned by minimizing an empirical risk with a gradient-based method. The main ideas of this section are thus already familiar: a model, a loss and an optimization algorithm, see Sections 6 and 3. The reference textbook on the topic is the book of Goodfellow et al. (2016).

About this section

We start from the perceptron, the ancestor of all neural networks, and understand why it has to be stacked into several layers (Section 9.1). We then study the ingredients of a multilayer perceptron: activation functions (Section 9.2), its expressive power (Section 9.3) and the losses used to train it (Section 9.4). The core of the section is the backpropagation algorithm (Section 9.5) and the optimization and regularization techniques that make the training of deep networks possible (Sections 9.6 and 9.7). We finally present the main architectures: convolutional networks (Section 9.8), recurrent networks (Section 9.9) and a few others (Section 9.10), before giving some practical advice (Section 9.11).

9.1 From the perceptron to the multilayer perceptron

Foundations. Neural networks are (very freely) inspired by nature, and more precisely by neuroscience and models of synapses. The first traces of neural networks can be found in works from the middle of the 20th century: McCulloch and Pitts (1943) proposed the first mathematical model of a neuron, a unit that "fires" when the weighted sum of its inputs exceeds a threshold. A few years later, Rosenblatt (1958) proposed a way to *learn* the weights of such a unit from examples: this is the *perceptron*, represented in Fig. 73.

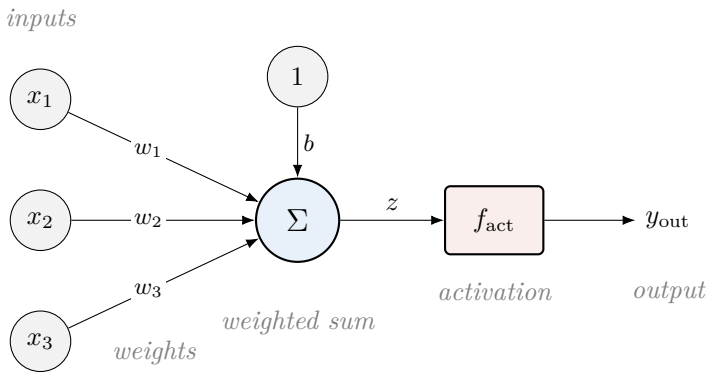


Figure 73: A perceptron with an input space of dimension 3. Each feature x_j is multiplied by a weight w_j and a bias b is added: $z = \sum_{j=1}^{3} w_j x_j + b$. This weighted sum then goes through an activation function f_{act} to give the output $y_{\text{out}} = f_{\text{act}}(z)$.

The perceptron. A perceptron takes a vector $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ as input and depends on a parameter $(\mathbf{w}, b) \in \mathbb{R}^d \times \mathbb{R}$, where $\mathbf{w}$ is the vector of *weights* and b the *bias*. Historically, its output $h(\mathbf{x})$ is the sign of the inner product between $\mathbf{x}$ and $\mathbf{w}$, to which the bias b is added, *i.e.*

$$h(\mathbf{x}) = \text{sign}\left(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b\right) = \text{sign}\left(\sum_{j=1}^{d} w_j x_j + b\right).$$

This first model was thus designed for binary classification. It computes an affine function of the input (linear if $b = 0$), to which an *activation function* is applied to return the predicted class. With labels in $\{0, 1\}$, the prediction reads

$$h(\mathbf{x}) = \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b < 0, \\ 1 & \text{otherwise,} \end{cases}$$

and the activation function is the *Heaviside* (or step) function $H(z) = \mathbb{1}_{z \geq 0}$, represented in Fig. 77 (left). Note that this decision rule is exactly the one of the linear SVM seen in Section 8: the perceptron is a linear classifier, and only the way its parameters are learned differs. In the rest of this paragraph, we use labels in $\{-1, +1\}$ and $h(\mathbf{x}) = \text{sign}(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b)$, which makes the formulas shorter.

The perceptron learning rule. The first algorithm used to learn the parameters $\mathbf{w}$ and b is inspired by the rule of the neuropsychologist Hebb ("neurons that fire together wire together"). Its principle is simple: the examples are visited one after the other, and the parameters are only modified when the current example is misclassified, *i.e.* when $y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b) \leq 0$. In this case, we update

$$\mathbf{w} \leftarrow \mathbf{w} + \alpha\, y_i \mathbf{x}_i \quad \text{and} \quad b \leftarrow b + \alpha\, y_i,$$

where $\alpha > 0$ is the *learning rate*. Such an update moves the hyperplane in the right direction for the example $(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)$, since the new score satisfies

$$y_i\left(\langle \mathbf{w} + \alpha y_i \mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b + \alpha y_i\right) = y_i\left(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b\right) + \alpha\left(\|\mathbf{x}_i\|^2 + 1\right) > y_i\left(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b\right).$$

The procedure is repeated until no example is misclassified, or stops after a given number of passes over the data (called *epochs*). The procedure is summarized in Algorithm 4. A classical result states that it stops after a finite number of updates when the data are linearly separable.

Theorem 9.1: Convergence of the perceptron (Novikoff, 1962)

Let $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ be a training set with $\|\mathbf{x}_i\| \leq R$ for all i. Assume that the data are linearly separable with a margin $\gamma > 0$, *i.e.* there exists $\mathbf{w}^*$ with $\|\mathbf{w}^*\| = 1$ such that $y_i \langle \mathbf{w}^*, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle \geq \gamma$ for all i (no bias here, see the remark below). Then the perceptron (without bias, starting from $\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{0}$, with any $\alpha > 0$) makes at most R^2/γ^2 updates.

Proof. Let $\mathbf{w}_k$ be the weight vector after k updates, and let $(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)$ be the example that triggers the $(k+1)$-th update, so that $y_i \langle \mathbf{w}_k, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle \leq 0$. On the one hand, the projection on $\mathbf{w}^*$ increases at each update:

$$\langle \mathbf{w}_{k+1}, \mathbf{w}^* \rangle = \langle \mathbf{w}_k, \mathbf{w}^* \rangle + \alpha y_i \langle \mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{w}^* \rangle \geq \langle \mathbf{w}_k, \mathbf{w}^* \rangle + \alpha\gamma, \quad \text{hence} \quad \langle \mathbf{w}_k, \mathbf{w}^* \rangle \geq k\alpha\gamma.$$

Algorithm 4: Perceptron learning rule (Rosenblatt, 1958)

Input: training set $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ with $y_i \in \{-1, +1\}$, learning rate $\alpha > 0$, maximal number of epochs T

Output: parameters $(\mathbf{w}, b)$ of the linear classifier $h(\mathbf{x}) = \text{sign}(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b)$

$\mathbf{w} \leftarrow \mathbf{0}$, $b \leftarrow 0$;
for $t = 1, \dots, T$ **do**
  for $i = 1, \dots, m$ **do**
    if $y_i \left(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b \right) \leq 0$ **then**
      $\mathbf{w} \leftarrow \mathbf{w} + \alpha\, y_i \mathbf{x}_i$ and $b \leftarrow b + \alpha\, y_i$;
  if *no update has been made during the epoch* **then stop**;

On the other hand, the norm does not increase too fast:

$$\|\mathbf{w}_{k+1}\|^2 = \|\mathbf{w}_k\|^2 + 2\alpha \underbrace{y_i \langle \mathbf{w}_k, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle}_{\leq 0} + \alpha^2 \|\mathbf{x}_i\|^2 \leq \|\mathbf{w}_k\|^2 + \alpha^2 R^2, \quad \text{hence} \quad \|\mathbf{w}_k\|^2 \leq k\alpha^2 R^2.$$

Combining both inequalities with the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality gives $k\alpha\gamma \leq \langle \mathbf{w}_k, \mathbf{w}^* \rangle \leq \|\mathbf{w}_k\| \leq \sqrt{k}\, \alpha R$, *i.e.* $k \leq R^2/\gamma^2$. □

Remark The bias can be handled by adding a constant feature equal to 1 to each input: $\tilde{\mathbf{x}} = (\mathbf{x}, 1)$ and $\tilde{\mathbf{w}} = (\mathbf{w}, b)$. Note also that the number of updates does not depend on the dimension d nor on the number of examples m, but only on the geometry of the problem through the ratio R/γ. The margin γ is the same notion as the one maximized by the SVM. However, the perceptron returns *one* separating hyperplane, not the one with maximal margin, and it never stops (it cycles) when the data are not linearly separable.

The Widrow-Hoff rule. Another rule to learn the parameters of a perceptron, called the *Widrow-Hoff rule* (or *delta rule*), works in a similar manner but takes into account the error made on the current example:

$$\mathbf{w} \leftarrow \mathbf{w} + \alpha \left(y_i - h(\mathbf{x}_i) \right) \mathbf{x}_i \quad \text{and} \quad b \leftarrow b + \alpha \left(y_i - h(\mathbf{x}_i) \right).$$

This rule can be used with the sign function, but it is usually combined with the hyperbolic tangent tanh, which can be seen as a smooth version of the sign function (see Fig. 77), or with the sigmoid function, a smooth version of the Heaviside function. Smooth activation functions have a major advantage: the derivative of the Heaviside function is equal to 0 almost everywhere, so that it does not provide any information to a gradient descent algorithm, whereas smooth functions do. When h is the identity, the Widrow-Hoff rule is exactly a stochastic gradient step on the squared loss $\frac{1}{2}(y_i - \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle - b)^2$, a point of view that we will generalize to any network in Section 9.5.

The limits of the perceptron: the XOR problem. The previous algorithms work well when the problem is linearly separable. This situation is rarely met in practice, and we need more flexible models to achieve good performance on non-linear problems.

For instance, the perceptron can perfectly classify the **OR** and **AND** datasets, since a linear model is enough to separate the two classes, but it cannot solve the **XOR** (exclusive or) problem. These three problems are illustrated in Fig. 74: no line can separate the two classes of the third dataset. This simple observation, formalized by Minsky and Papert (1969), contributed to a significant decline of research on neural networks in the 1970s. To solve the problem, we need a more complex model, one that *learns another representation of the data* in which the problem becomes linearly separable.

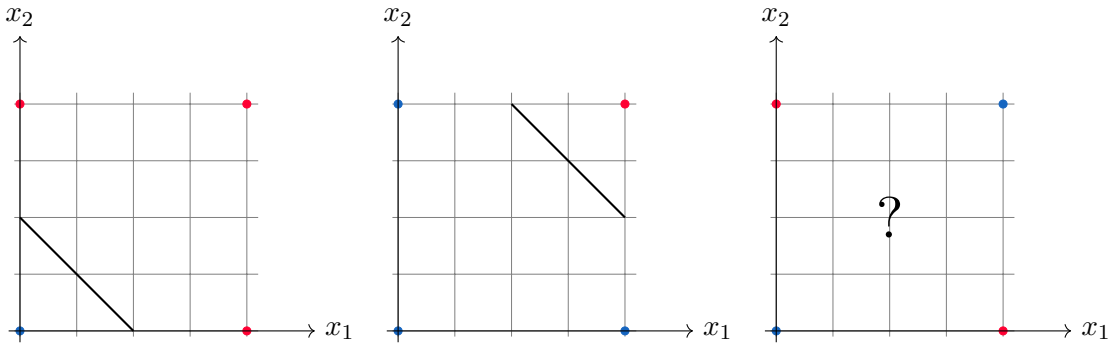
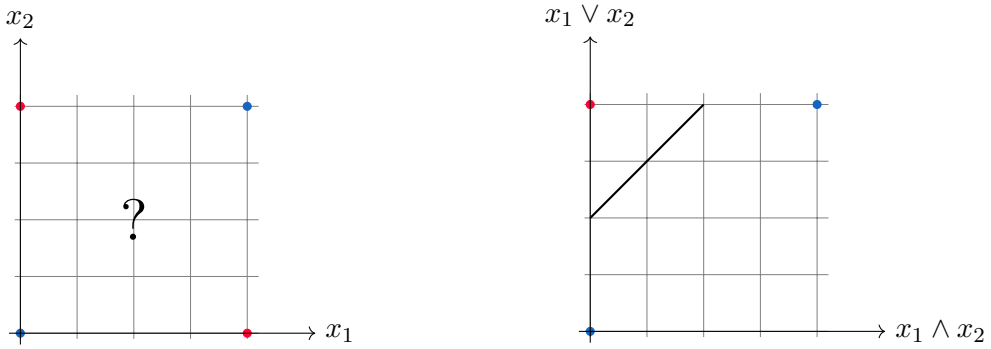


Figure 74: The **OR**, **AND** and **XOR** classification datasets (from left to right) in a two-dimensional space. A coordinate x_j equal to 0 means that the corresponding entry is *FALSE*; it is equal to 1 if the entry is *TRUE*. The color of a point gives its label, determined by the logical operator: TRUE or FALSE. A line separates the classes of the first two datasets, but no line can separate those of the **XOR** dataset.

To this end, we are again inspired by the architecture of the brain, where many neurons are connected to each other: this is what we call a *neural network*. Before describing the general architecture, let us go back to our example and see how the **XOR** problem can be solved. Consider the following transformation of the axes:

$$x_1 \leftarrow x_1 \wedge x_2 \quad \text{and} \quad x_2 \leftarrow x_1 \vee x_2,$$

which gives the following new representation of the data (the **XOR** dataset on the left, its new representation on the right):



With this transformation, the two red points are mapped to the same point of the new space, because exactly one of their two entries is *TRUE*. The blue points stay where they are, since their two entries are equal. In this new representation, the problem is linearly separable, and such a representation can be learned by a neural network, more precisely by a *multilayer perceptron*.

Function	Weights	Bias	Output
$x_1 \wedge x_2$ (AND)	$w_1 = w_2 = 1$	$b = -1.5$	$H(x_1 + x_2 - 1.5)$
$x_1 \vee x_2$ (OR)	$w_1 = w_2 = 1$	$b = -0.5$	$H(x_1 + x_2 - 0.5)$
$\overline{x}$ (NOT)	$w = -1$	$b = 0.5$	$H(-x + 0.5)$

Table 5: The elementary logical functions are perceptrons with the Heaviside activation $H(z) = \mathbb{1}_{z \geq 0}$ and inputs in $\{0, 1\}$.

To find a suitable architecture, let us first rewrite the **XOR** function. This function is *TRUE* if and only if exactly one of its inputs is *TRUE*. In other words,

$$\mathrm{XOR}(x_1, x_2) = (x_1 \vee x_2) \wedge (\overline{x_1 \wedge x_2}) \,.$$

It is now enough to translate this expression with several perceptrons using the Heaviside activation H: the elementary logical functions are all perceptrons, as shown in Table 5. Composing them gives the network of Fig. 75, whose hidden layer computes the new representation $(x_1 \vee x_2, x_1 \wedge x_2)$ and whose output unit computes "$x_1 \vee x_2$ and not $x_1 \wedge x_2$".

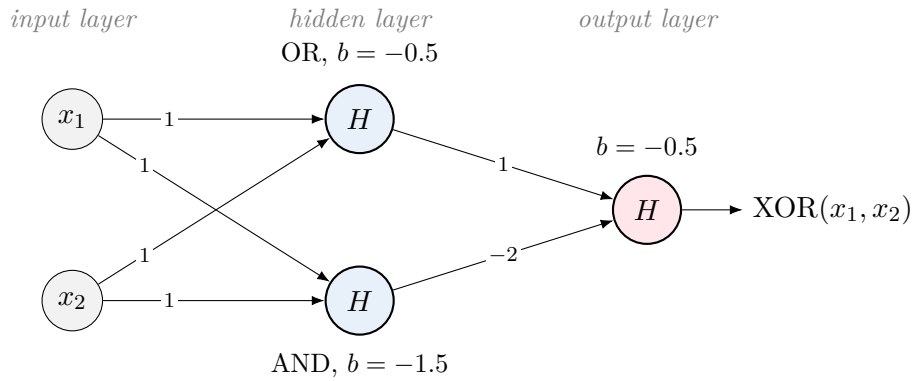


Figure 75: A multilayer perceptron with Heaviside activations solving the **XOR** problem. The hidden units compute $x_1 \vee x_2$ and $x_1 \wedge x_2$; the output unit computes $H\left((x_1 \vee x_2) - 2(x_1 \wedge x_2) - 0.5\right)$, which is equal to 1 if and only if exactly one input is equal to 1.

The multilayer perceptron. A multilayer perceptron (MLP) is represented in Fig. 76. The first layer is called the *input layer*. Its size is equal to the dimension of the input space, and we add another unit whose value is always equal to 1 and which represents the bias term. The intermediate layers are called *hidden layers*: their number and their sizes are chosen by the user according to the problem at hand. To each hidden layer, we can also associate a bias that is used to compute the values of the next layer. The last layer is called the *output layer*, and its size depends on the output space. For regression or binary classification, the output is of dimension 1. For multi-class classification, the output layer has as many units as there are classes in the dataset.

The network of Fig. 76 is said to be *fully connected*: every unit of a layer is connected to every unit of the next layer. It is possible to remove some of the connections,

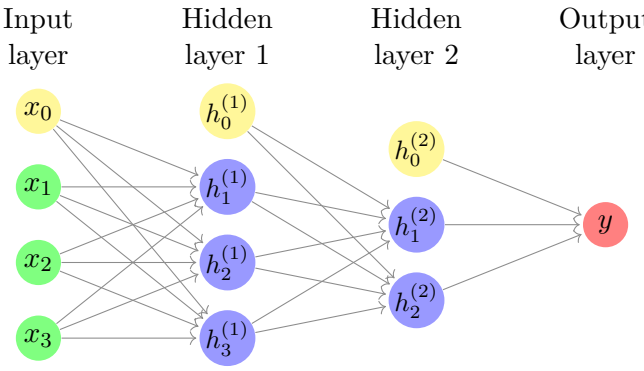


Figure 76: A multilayer perceptron. In this example, the input space is of dimension 3 and there are two hidden layers, of size 3 and 2 respectively. The output space is of dimension 1. The units labeled 1 represent the biases.

by setting the corresponding weights to 0, and we could also imagine connections between two non-consecutive layers (this is the idea of residual networks, see Section 9.8). Let us formalize the model.

Definition 9.1: Multilayer perceptron

Let $L \geq 1$ be the number of layers (the input layer is not counted) and $d_0 = d, d_1, \ldots, d_L$ their sizes. A *multilayer perceptron* is a function $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}^{d_L}$ defined by $\mathbf{h}^{(0)} = \mathbf{x}$ and, for $\ell = 1, \ldots, L$,

$$\mathbf{a}^{(\ell)} = \mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}\mathbf{h}^{(\ell-1)} + \mathbf{b}^{(\ell)} \quad \text{and} \quad \mathbf{h}^{(\ell)} = \sigma_\ell\left(\mathbf{a}^{(\ell)}\right),$$

and $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{h}^{(L)}$, where

- $\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_\ell \times d_{\ell-1}}$ is the weight matrix and $\mathbf{b}^{(\ell)} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_\ell}$ the bias vector of layer ℓ;
- $\sigma_\ell : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ is the activation function of layer ℓ, applied componentwise (σ_L can be the identity or the softmax function, see Section 9.4);
- $\mathbf{a}^{(\ell)}$ is called the *pre-activation* and $\mathbf{h}^{(\ell)}$ the *activation* (or hidden representation) of layer ℓ.

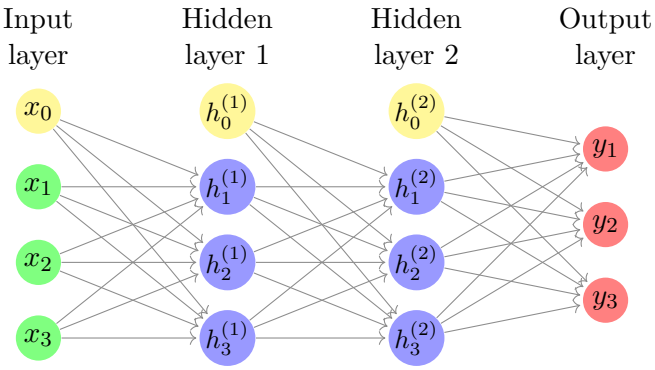
The parameter of the network is $\boldsymbol{\theta} = \left(\mathbf{W}^{(1)}, \mathbf{b}^{(1)}, \ldots, \mathbf{W}^{(L)}, \mathbf{b}^{(L)}\right)$. A network is called *deep* when it has several hidden layers.

In other words, a multilayer perceptron is the composition $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} = \sigma_L \circ A_L \circ \sigma_{L-1} \circ A_{L-1} \circ \cdots \circ \sigma_1 \circ A_1$, where $A_\ell : \mathbf{h} \mapsto \mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}\mathbf{h} + \mathbf{b}^{(\ell)}$ is an affine map. Each hidden layer computes a new representation of the data, and the last layer is a linear (or logistic) model applied to the last representation $\mathbf{h}^{(L-1)}$: the network *learns the representation* in which the final problem becomes simple, as we did by hand for the **XOR** problem.

Number of parameters. Since each unit of layer ℓ is connected to all the units of layer $\ell - 1$ plus a bias unit, the number of parameters of a fully connected network is

$$\sum_{\ell=1}^{L} d_\ell \times (d_{\ell-1} + 1)\,.$$

In the example of Fig. 76, we have $d_0 = 3$, $d_1 = 3$, $d_2 = 2$ and $d_3 = 1$. There are $(3 + 1) \times 3 = 12$ parameters between the input layer and the first hidden layer, $(3+1)\times 2 = 8$ parameters between the two hidden layers, and $(2+1)\times 1 = 3$ parameters between the second hidden layer and the output layer, *i.e.* a total of 23 parameters. The network below has $(3 + 1) \times 3 \times 3 = 36$ parameters:



It has three outputs and can be used for *multi-class classification* with three classes; we explain how in Section 9.4. Modern networks have millions, or even billions, of parameters, often many more than the number of training examples.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q9.1. True or false? When the data are linearly separable, the perceptron learning rule returns the separating hyperplane with the largest margin.

Q9.2. The inputs satisfy $\|\mathbf{x}_i\| \leq 2$ and are separable with margin $\gamma = 0.1$ (no bias). How many updates can the perceptron make at most?

Q9.3. Why can a single perceptron not compute the **XOR** function, and what does the hidden layer of Fig. 75 do?

Q9.4. How many parameters does a fully connected network with layer sizes 10-20-20-3 have (biases included)?

9.2 Activation functions

Why do we need non-linear activations? Without activation functions (or with linear ones), a multilayer perceptron is useless, whatever its depth.

Name	$\sigma(z)$	$\sigma'(z)$	Range
Heaviside	$\mathbb{1}_{z\geq 0}$	0 (for $z \neq 0$)	$\{0, 1\}$
Sigmoid (logistic)	$\dfrac{1}{1+e^{-z}}$	$\sigma(z)\,(1-\sigma(z))$	$(0, 1)$
Hyperbolic tangent	$\tanh(z) = \dfrac{e^z - e^{-z}}{e^z + e^{-z}}$	$1 - \tanh^2(z)$	$(-1, 1)$
ReLU	$\max(0, z)$	$\mathbb{1}_{z>0}$ (for $z \neq 0$)	$[0, +\infty)$
Leaky ReLU	$\max(\beta z, z)$, $0 < \beta < 1$	1 if $z > 0$, β if $z < 0$	$\mathbb{R}$
ELU	z if $z > 0$, $e^z - 1$ otherwise	1 if $z > 0$, e^z otherwise	$(-1, +\infty)$

Table 6: Common activation functions and their derivatives.

Proposition 9.2: Composition of affine maps

If all the activation functions $\sigma_1, \ldots, \sigma_L$ are the identity, then the multilayer perceptron of Definition 9.1 is an affine function of its input: there exist $\mathbf{W} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_L \times d}$ and $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_L}$ such that $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{W}\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{b}$ for all $\mathbf{x}$.

Proof. By induction on L: the result is clear for $L = 1$, and if $\mathbf{h}^{(L-1)} = \mathbf{W}'\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{b}'$, then $\mathbf{h}^{(L)} = \mathbf{W}^{(L)}(\mathbf{W}'\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{b}') + \mathbf{b}^{(L)} = (\mathbf{W}^{(L)}\mathbf{W}')\mathbf{x} + (\mathbf{W}^{(L)}\mathbf{b}' + \mathbf{b}^{(L)})$. □

A deep linear network thus has exactly the same expressive power as a linear model: it cannot solve the **XOR** problem. The non-linearity of the activations is what makes the depth useful. Since the networks are trained with gradient-based methods, we also want activation functions that are differentiable (at least almost everywhere) with non-zero derivatives. The most common activation functions are given in Table 6 and represented in Fig. 77.

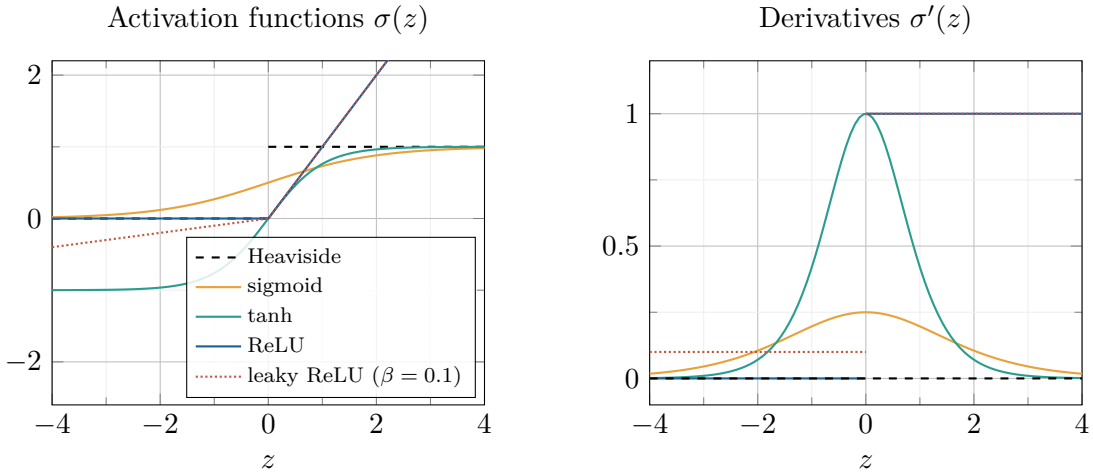


Figure 77: Graphs of the activation functions of Table 6 (left) and of their derivatives (right). The derivative of the sigmoid is at most 1/4 and those of the sigmoid and of tanh vanish when $|z|$ is large (saturation), whereas the derivative of the ReLU is equal to 1 on the whole positive half-line.

Sigmoid and hyperbolic tangent. The sigmoid $\sigma(z) = 1/(1+e^{-z})$ was the standard activation function until the 2000s. Its values lie in $(0, 1)$, so that it can be interpreted as a probability, which is why it is still used on the output layer for binary classification (Section 9.4). The hyperbolic tangent is a rescaled sigmoid, $\tanh(z) = 2\sigma(2z) - 1$, whose outputs are centered around 0, which usually makes the optimization easier. Both functions *saturate*: their derivatives tend to 0 when $|z| \to +\infty$, and the derivative of the sigmoid is bounded by $1/4$. We will see in Section 9.5 that this causes the gradients to vanish in deep networks.

ReLU and its variants. The *Rectified Linear Unit* $\mathrm{ReLU}(z) = \max(0, z)$ is now the default choice for hidden layers. It is very cheap to compute, it does not saturate for positive inputs (its derivative is equal to 1), and it produces sparse representations (many units are exactly equal to 0). It is not differentiable at 0, but this is not a problem in practice: we simply use 0 (or 1) as the derivative at this point. Its main drawback is that a unit whose pre-activation is negative for all the training examples has a zero gradient and no longer learns (a "dead" unit). The *leaky ReLU* and the *ELU* avoid this issue by allowing a small non-zero slope for negative inputs. Smooth variants such as GELU or SiLU ($z \mapsto z\,\sigma(z)$) are popular in recent architectures.

The softmax function. The last activation function is not applied componentwise: it transforms a vector of scores into a probability distribution, and it is used on the output layer for multi-class classification.

Definition 9.2: Softmax function

The softmax function $\mathrm{softmax} : \mathbb{R}^q \to \Delta_q = \{\mathbf{p} \in [0,1]^q, \sum_k p_k = 1\}$ is defined by

$$\mathrm{softmax}(\mathbf{z})_k = \frac{e^{z_k}}{\sum_{l=1}^{q} e^{z_l}}, \quad k = 1, \dots, q.$$

Its Jacobian matrix is $\dfrac{\partial\,\mathrm{softmax}(\mathbf{z})_k}{\partial z_l} = p_k\,(\mathbb{1}_{k=l} - p_l)$, where $\mathbf{p} = \mathrm{softmax}(\mathbf{z})$, *i.e.* $J = \mathrm{diag}(\mathbf{p}) - \mathbf{p}\mathbf{p}^\top$.

The name comes from the fact that $\mathrm{softmax}(\mathbf{z})$ is a smooth approximation of the indicator vector of $\arg\max_k z_k$. It is invariant to the addition of a constant to all the scores, $\mathrm{softmax}(\mathbf{z} + c\mathbf{1}) = \mathrm{softmax}(\mathbf{z})$, a property that is used in practice to avoid numerical overflows: we compute $\mathrm{softmax}(\mathbf{z} - \max_k z_k \mathbf{1})$. For $q = 2$, the softmax reduces to the sigmoid: $\mathrm{softmax}(\mathbf{z})_1 = \sigma(z_1 - z_2)$. We recover the multinomial logistic regression model of Section 8.

9.3 Expressive power: the universal approximation theorem

We have seen that a network with one hidden layer can represent the **XOR** function. In fact, a network with one hidden layer can approximate *any* continuous function, provided that the hidden layer is large enough.

Theorem 9.3: Universal approximation (Cybenko, 1989; Hornik, 1991; Leshno et al., 1993)

Let $\sigma : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ be a continuous function which is not a polynomial (*e.g.* the sigmoid, tanh or ReLU), let $K \subset \mathbb{R}^d$ be a compact set and let $f^* : K \to \mathbb{R}$ be a continuous function. Then, for every $\varepsilon > 0$, there exist an integer N and parameters $\mathbf{w}_j \in \mathbb{R}^d$, $b_j, v_j \in \mathbb{R}$ $(j = 1, \dots, N)$ such that the network with one hidden layer of N units

$$f(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_{j=1}^{N} v_j \, \sigma\left(\langle \mathbf{w}_j, \mathbf{x} \rangle + b_j\right) \quad \text{satisfies} \quad \sup_{\mathbf{x} \in K} |f(\mathbf{x}) - f^*(\mathbf{x})| \leq \varepsilon.$$

The proof relies on functional analysis (Hahn-Banach and Riesz representation theorems) and is beyond the scope of these notes, but the intuition is easy to grasp in dimension one. With a sigmoid, the difference $\sigma(k(x-a)) - \sigma(k(x-b))$ of two hidden units is a "bump" that is close to the indicator function of $[a, b]$ when k is large. A continuous function on $[0, 1]$ can be approximated by a piecewise constant function, *i.e.* by a weighted sum of such bumps, and thus by a network with one hidden layer, see Fig. 78.

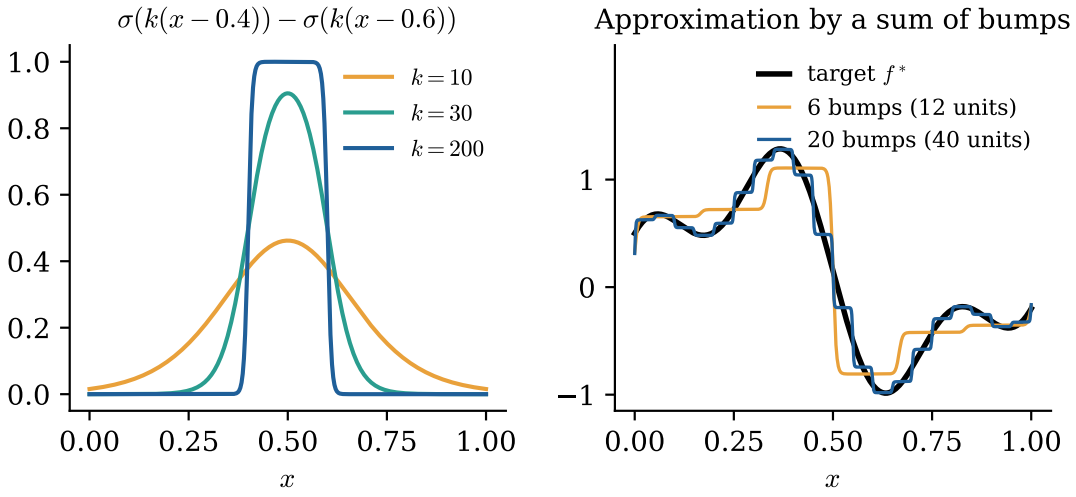


Figure 78: Intuition behind the universal approximation theorem. Left: the difference of two steep sigmoids is close to the indicator function of an interval. Right: a weighted sum of such bumps, *i.e.* a network with one hidden layer, approximates a continuous function; the approximation improves as the number of hidden units grows.

This result must be read with care.

- It is an *existence* result: it says nothing about how to find the parameters, and gradient descent on a non-convex objective is not guaranteed to find them.
- The required number of hidden units N can be huge: in the construction above, it grows like $(1/\varepsilon)^d$, exponentially with the dimension.
- It says nothing about generalization: a model able to approximate any function is also able to fit the noise of the training set (see Section 6 on the estima-

tion/approximation trade-off).

In practice, *deep* networks are preferred to wide and shallow ones: some functions can be represented by a deep network with a number of units that is exponentially smaller than the number required by a shallow network, and depth favors the learning of hierarchical representations (edges, then textures, then parts of objects, then objects for images). Figure 79 illustrates the effect of the size of the hidden layer on a two-dimensional problem.

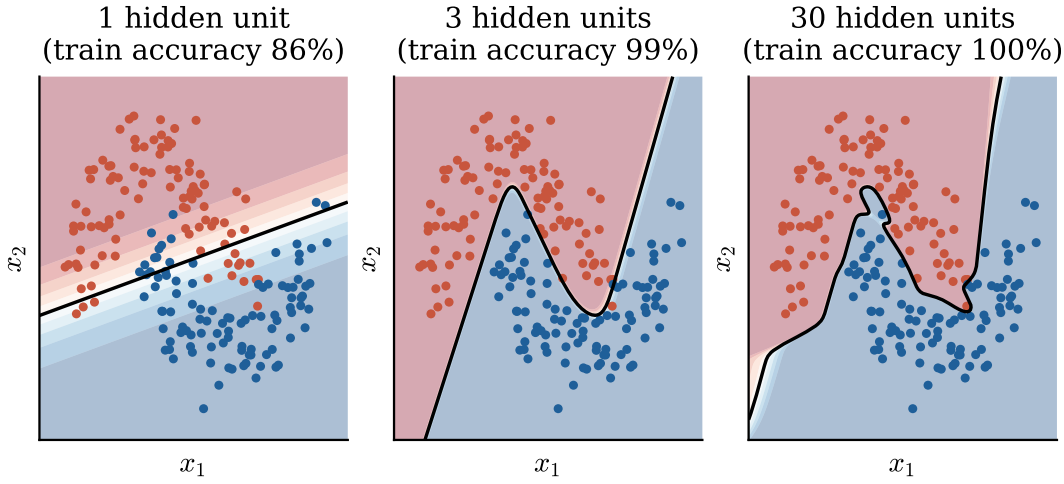


Figure 79: Decision boundaries of networks with one hidden layer (tanh activation, sigmoid output) trained on the same "two moons" dataset. With one hidden unit, the model is essentially a logistic regression; three units are enough to separate the two moons; with 30 units, the boundary starts to fit the noise of the training set.

9.4 Loss functions

Given a training set $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$, the parameters of a network are learned by minimizing the (possibly regularized) empirical risk

$$\hat{L}_S(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \ell\left(f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i\right),$$

as in Section 6. The choice of the loss ℓ goes together with the choice of the activation of the output layer. In each case below, we give the *derivative of the loss with respect to the pre-activation of the output layer* $\mathbf{a}^{(L)}$, which is the starting point of the backpropagation algorithm. We will see that it always takes the simple form "prediction minus target".

Regression. For regression ($\mathcal{Y} = \mathbb{R}^q$), the output layer is linear ($\sigma_L = \mathrm{id}$, so that $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{a}^{(L)}$) and we use the squared loss

$$\ell(f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}), \mathbf{y}) = \frac{1}{2} \left\| f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbf{y} \right\|_2^2, \qquad \text{hence} \qquad \frac{\partial \ell}{\partial \mathbf{a}^{(L)}} = f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbf{y}.$$

As for linear regression, minimizing this loss amounts to maximizing the likelihood of the model $\mathbf{y} = f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}) + \varepsilon$ with a Gaussian noise $\varepsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, s^2\mathbf{I})$. The absolute loss or the Huber loss can be used when the data contain outliers.

Binary classification. For $\mathcal{Y} = \{0, 1\}$, the output layer has one unit with a sigmoid activation, and $p = f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}) = \sigma(a^{(L)})$ is interpreted as an estimate of $\mathbb{P}(y = 1 \mid \mathbf{x})$. The negative log-likelihood of the Bernoulli model is the *binary cross-entropy*

$$\ell(p, y) = -y \ln p - (1 - y) \ln(1 - p), \qquad \text{hence} \qquad \frac{\partial \ell}{\partial a^{(L)}} = p - y,$$

where we used $\sigma' = \sigma(1 - \sigma)$. Written as a function of the score $a^{(L)}$ and with labels $\tilde{y} = 2y - 1 \in \{-1, +1\}$, this is exactly the logistic loss $\ln(1 + e^{-\tilde{y} a^{(L)}})$ of Section 8. In particular, *a network without hidden layer, with a sigmoid output and the cross-entropy loss, is a logistic regression*: an MLP is a logistic regression applied to a learned representation $\mathbf{h}^{(L-1)}$ of the data.

Multi-class classification. For $\mathcal{Y} = \{1, \dots, q\}$, the output layer has q units and a softmax activation, and $p_k = \text{softmax}(\mathbf{a}^{(L)})_k$ estimates $\mathbb{P}(y = k \mid \mathbf{x})$. We encode the label y by its *one-hot* vector $\mathbf{e}_y \in \{0, 1\}^q$ (the y-th vector of the canonical basis) and use the *cross-entropy* loss, *i.e.* the negative log-likelihood of the categorical model:

$$\ell(\mathbf{p}, y) = -\ln p_y = -\sum_{k=1}^{q} (\mathbf{e}_y)_k \ln p_k.$$

This is the multinomial logistic regression model of Section 8, applied to the last hidden representation.

Proposition 9.4: Gradient of the softmax cross-entropy

Let $\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^q$, $\mathbf{p} = \text{softmax}(\mathbf{z})$ and $y \in \{1, \dots, q\}$. Then

$$\ell = -\ln p_y = -z_y + \ln \sum_{l=1}^{q} e^{z_l} \qquad \text{and} \qquad \nabla_{\mathbf{z}} \ell = \mathbf{p} - \mathbf{e}_y.$$

Proof. By definition of the softmax,

$$\begin{aligned} \ell &= -\ln \frac{e^{z_y}}{\sum_l e^{z_l}} \\ &\downarrow \text{ property of the logarithm} \\ &= -z_y + \ln \sum_{l=1}^{q} e^{z_l}. \end{aligned}$$

Differentiating with respect to z_k,

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial \ell}{\partial z_k} &= -\mathbb{1}_{k=y} + \frac{e^{z_k}}{\sum_l e^{z_l}} \\ &\downarrow \text{ definition of the softmax} \\ &= p_k - (\mathbf{e}_y)_k. \end{aligned}$$

□

The function $\mathbf{z} \mapsto \ln \sum_l e^{z_l}$ (called *log-sum-exp*) is convex, so that the cross-entropy is a convex function of the scores. However, the scores $\mathbf{a}^{(L)}$ are themselves non-linear functions of the parameters, and the empirical risk of a network with at least

one hidden layer is *not convex* in $\boldsymbol{\theta}$. The optimization algorithms of Section 3 are thus only guaranteed to find stationary points, and the result of the training depends on the initialization. Surprisingly, in large networks, the local minima found by gradient methods are usually good enough.

> **Pitfall** Never compute the cross-entropy by first computing $\mathbf{p} = \text{softmax}(\mathbf{z})$ and then $\ln p_y$: if p_y is rounded to 0, the loss is infinite. Use the expression $-z_y + \ln \sum_l e^{z_l}$ with the "max trick" of the previous section. This is what deep learning libraries do when the loss is fed with the scores (the *logits*) rather than with the probabilities.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q9.5. What does a network with 10 hidden layers and identity activations compute?

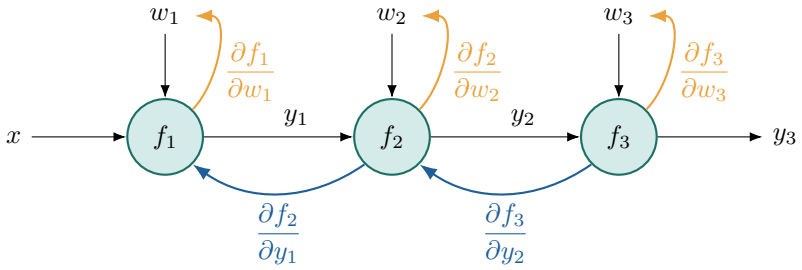
Q9.6. Compute $\text{softmax}(1, 2, 3)$ and $\text{softmax}(101, 102, 103)$.

Q9.7. True or false? Since a network with one hidden layer is a universal approximator, deep networks are useless.

Q9.8. A 3-class network outputs $\mathbf{p} = (0.7, 0.2, 0.1)$ on an example of class $y = 2$. What are the loss and its gradient with respect to the scores $\mathbf{z}$?

9.5 Training: forward pass and backpropagation

A first example with the chain rule. To minimize $\hat{L}_S(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ with a gradient method, we need its gradient with respect to *all* the parameters of the network. Let us start with a very simple network made of three layers with a single unit each, and a one-dimensional input[15]:



Here w_i and f_i respectively denote the parameter and the function computed by the i-th layer, and $y_i = f_i(y_{i-1}, w_i)$ its output, with $y_0 = x$. The training alternates two steps. The *forward* step feeds the network with data, one example at a time (stochastic) or a small subset of the data (a mini-batch), and computes the successive outputs y_1, y_2, y_3 and the value of the loss. The *backward* step computes the gradient of the loss with respect to each parameter and updates the parameters. The main difficulty is to propagate the error through the whole network: the parameter of the last layer is

[15] This example is taken from the PhD thesis of Damien Fourure.

directly linked to the output, but this is not the case for the parameters of the first layers, whose influence on the output goes through all the following layers. The derivatives are obtained with the chain rule: *if g is differentiable at x and f is differentiable at $g(x)$, then*

$$(f \circ g)'(x) = f'(g(x)) \times g'(x).$$

For the sake of simplicity, we compute the derivatives of the output y_3 with respect to w_1, w_2 and w_3; the derivatives of the loss $\ell(y_3, y)$ are obtained by multiplying them by $\partial \ell / \partial y_3$.

- Derivative with respect to w_3:

$$\frac{\partial y_3}{\partial w_3} = \frac{\partial f_3}{\partial w_3}(y_2, w_3).$$

- Derivative with respect to w_2 (which influences y_3 through y_2 only):

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\partial y_3}{\partial w_2} &= \frac{\partial f_3}{\partial y_2}(y_2, w_3) \times \frac{\partial y_2}{\partial w_2} \\ &\downarrow \text{ since } y_2 = f_2(y_1, w_2) \\ &= \frac{\partial f_3}{\partial y_2}(y_2, w_3) \times \frac{\partial f_2}{\partial w_2}(y_1, w_2).\end{aligned}$$

- Derivative with respect to w_1 (which influences y_3 through y_1, then y_2):

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\partial y_3}{\partial w_1} &= \frac{\partial f_3}{\partial y_2}(y_2, w_3) \times \frac{\partial y_2}{\partial w_1} \\ &\downarrow \text{ chain rule again, } y_2 = f_2(y_1, w_2) \\ &= \frac{\partial f_3}{\partial y_2}(y_2, w_3) \times \frac{\partial f_2}{\partial y_1}(y_1, w_2) \times \frac{\partial y_1}{\partial w_1} \\ &\downarrow \text{ since } y_1 = f_1(x, w_1) \\ &= \underline{\frac{\partial f_3}{\partial y_2}(y_2, w_3) \times \frac{\partial f_2}{\partial y_1}(y_1, w_2)} \times \frac{\partial f_1}{\partial w_1}(x, w_1).\end{aligned}$$

Two observations are essential. First, the derivatives involve the intermediate values y_1, y_2: they must be computed and stored during the forward step. Second, the term underlined in blue, $\partial y_3 / \partial y_1$, also appears (partially) in the computation of $\partial y_3 / \partial w_2$: if we compute the derivatives *from the output to the input*, each product can reuse the previous one. Updating the weights by computing the derivatives backward, layer by layer, with the chain rule is called **backpropagation** (Rumelhart et al., 1986).

Backpropagation for a multilayer perceptron. Let us now derive the algorithm for the general multilayer perceptron of Definition 9.1, in matrix form. We consider a single example $(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y})$ and denote by $J = \ell\left(f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}), \mathbf{y}\right)$ its loss (we use the letter J since ℓ is used here as a layer index); the gradient of the empirical risk is the average of the gradients over the examples. The key quantity is the gradient of the loss with respect to the pre-activations of layer ℓ (the "error" of the layer):

$$\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)} = \frac{\partial J}{\partial \mathbf{a}^{(\ell)}} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_\ell}.$$

We denote by $\odot$ the componentwise (Hadamard) product of two vectors.

Proposition 9.5: Backpropagation equations

For a multilayer perceptron with componentwise activations on the hidden layers,

1. output layer: $\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(L)} = \nabla_{\mathbf{a}^{(L)}} J$, *e.g.* $\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(L)} = f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbf{y}$ for the three pairs (output activation, loss) of Section 9.4;
2. for $\ell = L-1, \dots, 1$: $\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)} = \sigma'_\ell\left(\mathbf{a}^{(\ell)}\right) \odot \left(\mathbf{W}^{(\ell+1)\top} \boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell+1)}\right)$;
3. for $\ell = 1, \dots, L$: $\dfrac{\partial J}{\partial \mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}} = \boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)}\, \mathbf{h}^{(\ell-1)\top} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_\ell \times d_{\ell-1}}$ and $\dfrac{\partial J}{\partial \mathbf{b}^{(\ell)}} = \boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)}$.

Proof. Point 1 was established in Section 9.4. For point 2, J depends on $a_j^{(\ell)}$ only through $h_j^{(\ell)} = \sigma_\ell(a_j^{(\ell)})$, which in turn influences all the pre-activations of the next layer, $a_k^{(\ell+1)} = \sum_{j'} W_{kj'}^{(\ell+1)} h_{j'}^{(\ell)} + b_k^{(\ell+1)}$. Hence

$$\begin{aligned}
\delta_j^{(\ell)} = \frac{\partial J}{\partial a_j^{(\ell)}} &= \sum_{k=1}^{d_{\ell+1}} \frac{\partial J}{\partial a_k^{(\ell+1)}} \frac{\partial a_k^{(\ell+1)}}{\partial h_j^{(\ell)}} \frac{\partial h_j^{(\ell)}}{\partial a_j^{(\ell)}} \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ multivariate chain rule} \\
&= \sum_{k=1}^{d_{\ell+1}} \delta_k^{(\ell+1)}\, W_{kj}^{(\ell+1)}\, \sigma'_\ell\left(a_j^{(\ell)}\right) \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ definition of } \boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell+1)} \text{ and of } \mathbf{a}^{(\ell+1)} \\
&= \sigma'_\ell\left(a_j^{(\ell)}\right) \left(\mathbf{W}^{(\ell+1)\top} \boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell+1)}\right)_j .
\end{aligned}$$

For point 3, the weight $W_{jk}^{(\ell)}$ only influences $a_j^{(\ell)} = \sum_{k'} W_{jk'}^{(\ell)} h_{k'}^{(\ell-1)} + b_j^{(\ell)}$, so that

$$\frac{\partial J}{\partial W_{jk}^{(\ell)}} = \frac{\partial J}{\partial a_j^{(\ell)}} \frac{\partial a_j^{(\ell)}}{\partial W_{jk}^{(\ell)}} = \delta_j^{(\ell)}\, h_k^{(\ell-1)} \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial J}{\partial b_j^{(\ell)}} = \delta_j^{(\ell)}. \qquad \square$$

The error is thus propagated *backward* through the transposed weight matrices, which gives its name to the algorithm. The gradient with respect to a weight is the product of the error at its "output end" and of the activation at its "input end". The complete training procedure with mini-batch gradient descent is given in Algorithm 5. For a mini-batch B of examples, the vectors $\mathbf{h}^{(\ell)}$ and $\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)}$ become matrices of size $d_\ell \times |B|$ (one column per example), and all the operations are matrix products, which run very efficiently on GPUs.

Example 9.1 (One step of backpropagation by hand). Consider a network with $d = 2$ inputs, one hidden layer of 2 ReLU units and a linear output unit, trained with the squared loss $\ell = \frac{1}{2}(f - y)^2$ on the single example $\mathbf{x} = (1, 2)^\top$, $y = 2$. The parameters are

$$\mathbf{W}^{(1)} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ 0.5 & 0.5 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{b}^{(1)} = \begin{pmatrix} 0.5 \\ -1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{W}^{(2)} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}, \quad b^{(2)} = 0.$$

Forward pass. $\mathbf{a}^{(1)} = \mathbf{W}^{(1)}\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{b}^{(1)} = (1 - 2 + 0.5,\ 0.5 + 1 - 1)^\top = (-0.5,\ 0.5)^\top$, so $\mathbf{h}^{(1)} = \mathrm{ReLU}(\mathbf{a}^{(1)}) = (0,\ 0.5)^\top$. Then $f = a^{(2)} = 1 \times 0 + 2 \times 0.5 + 0 = 1$ and $\ell = \frac{1}{2}(1 - 2)^2 = 0.5$.

Algorithm 5: Training of a multilayer perceptron with backpropagation and mini-batch gradient descent

Input: training set $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{y}_i)\}_{i=1}^{m}$, architecture $(d_\ell, \sigma_\ell)_{\ell=1}^{L}$, learning rate η, batch size B, number of epochs T

Output: parameters $\boldsymbol{\theta} = (\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}, \mathbf{b}^{(\ell)})_{\ell=1}^{L}$

Initialize the weights randomly (Section 9.6) and the biases to $\mathbf{0}$;
for $t = 1, \dots, T$ **do**
  Shuffle S and split it into mini-batches of size B;
  for *each mini-batch* $\mathcal{B}$ **do**
    for *each* $(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}) \in \mathcal{B}$ **do**
      `// forward pass: compute and store the activations`
      $\mathbf{h}^{(0)} \leftarrow \mathbf{x}$;
      for $\ell = 1, \dots, L$ **do**
        $\mathbf{a}^{(\ell)} \leftarrow \mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}\mathbf{h}^{(\ell-1)} + \mathbf{b}^{(\ell)}$ and $\mathbf{h}^{(\ell)} \leftarrow \sigma_\ell(\mathbf{a}^{(\ell)})$;
      `// backward pass: propagate the errors`
      $\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(L)} \leftarrow \nabla_{\mathbf{a}^{(L)}} \ell(\mathbf{h}^{(L)}, \mathbf{y})$;
      for $\ell = L, \dots, 1$ **do**
        $\mathbf{g}_{\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}}(\mathbf{x}) \leftarrow \boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)}\mathbf{h}^{(\ell-1)\top}$ and $\mathbf{g}_{\mathbf{b}^{(\ell)}}(\mathbf{x}) \leftarrow \boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)}$;
        if $\ell > 1$ **then** $\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell-1)} \leftarrow \sigma'_{\ell-1}(\mathbf{a}^{(\ell-1)}) \odot \left(\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)\top}\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)}\right)$;
    `// update of the parameters`
    for $\ell = 1, \dots, L$ **do**
      $\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)} \leftarrow \mathbf{W}^{(\ell)} - \frac{\eta}{|\mathcal{B}|} \sum_{\mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{B}} \mathbf{g}_{\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}}(\mathbf{x})$ and $\mathbf{b}^{(\ell)} \leftarrow \mathbf{b}^{(\ell)} - \frac{\eta}{|\mathcal{B}|} \sum_{\mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{B}} \mathbf{g}_{\mathbf{b}^{(\ell)}}(\mathbf{x})$;

Backward pass. For the output layer, $\delta^{(2)} = f - y = -1$, hence

$$\frac{\partial \ell}{\partial \mathbf{W}^{(2)}} = \delta^{(2)}\mathbf{h}^{(1)\top} = (0,\ -0.5) \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial \ell}{\partial b^{(2)}} = -1.$$

For the hidden layer, $\mathbf{W}^{(2)\top}\delta^{(2)} = (-1,\ -2)^\top$ and $\mathrm{ReLU}'(\mathbf{a}^{(1)}) = (0,\ 1)^\top$, hence $\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(1)} = (0,\ -2)^\top$ and

$$\frac{\partial \ell}{\partial \mathbf{W}^{(1)}} = \boldsymbol{\delta}^{(1)}\mathbf{x}^\top = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ -2 & -4 \end{pmatrix} \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial \ell}{\partial \mathbf{b}^{(1)}} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ -2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Update with $\eta = 0.05$: $\mathbf{W}^{(1)} \leftarrow \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ 0.6 & 0.7 \end{pmatrix}$, $\mathbf{b}^{(1)} \leftarrow (0.5,\ -0.9)^\top$, $\mathbf{W}^{(2)} \leftarrow (1,\ 2.025)$ and $b^{(2)} \leftarrow 0.05$.

New forward pass. $\mathbf{a}^{(1)} = (-0.5,\ 1.1)^\top$, $\mathbf{h}^{(1)} = (0,\ 1.1)^\top$ and $f = 2.025 \times 1.1 + 0.05 = 2.2775$: the loss decreased from 0.5 to $\frac{1}{2}(0.2775)^2 \approx 0.039$. Note that the first hidden unit is inactive ($a_1^{(1)} < 0$): its incoming weights receive a zero gradient and are not modified. If this happens for all the examples, the unit is "dead".

Computational cost. The forward pass of a fully connected network costs about $\sum_\ell d_\ell d_{\ell-1}$ multiplications per example, *i.e.* of the order of the number of parameters P.

The backward pass requires two matrix products per layer (one for $\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell-1)}$, one for the gradient of $\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}$), so its cost is about twice the cost of the forward pass. Computing the full gradient thus costs $O(P)$ operations per example, *the same order as evaluating the network*. Compare with a finite-difference approximation $\frac{\partial \ell}{\partial \theta_j} \approx \frac{\ell(\boldsymbol{\theta}+\epsilon \mathbf{e}_j)-\ell(\boldsymbol{\theta})}{\epsilon}$, which requires one forward pass per parameter, *i.e.* $O(P^2)$ operations: backpropagation is what makes the training of large networks possible. The price to pay is memory, since all the activations of the forward pass must be stored until the backward pass. Backpropagation is a particular case of *reverse-mode automatic differentiation*: modern libraries (PyTorch, TensorFlow, JAX) build the computational graph of any function made of elementary operations and compute its gradient automatically, so that we never have to derive the backpropagation equations by hand in practice. Finite differences remain useful to *check* a hand-written gradient (*gradient checking*).

Vanishing and exploding gradients. Unrolling the recursion of Proposition 9.5 shows that the error at layer ℓ is a product of $L-\ell$ terms:

$$\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)} = D^{(\ell)} \mathbf{W}^{(\ell+1)\top} D^{(\ell+1)} \mathbf{W}^{(\ell+2)\top} \cdots D^{(L-1)} \mathbf{W}^{(L)\top} \boldsymbol{\delta}^{(L)},$$

with $D^{(k)} = \operatorname{diag}\left(\sigma_k'(\mathbf{a}^{(k)})\right)$, so that

$$\left\|\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)}\right\| \leq \prod_{k=\ell+1}^{L} \left(\left\|\mathbf{W}^{(k)}\right\| \max_z |\sigma_{k-1}'(z)|\right) \left\|\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(L)}\right\|.$$

If the factors are smaller than 1, the gradient of the first layers decreases exponentially fast with the depth: this is the *vanishing gradient* problem, and the first layers barely learn. With the sigmoid, $|\sigma'| \leq 1/4$, and this is precisely what happens unless the weights are large. Conversely, if the factors are larger than 1, the gradients can grow exponentially (*exploding gradients*) and the training diverges. This phenomenon, identified by Bengio et al. (1994) for recurrent networks, long prevented the training of deep networks. The remedies, presented in the next subsections, are: non-saturating activations (ReLU), a careful initialization, normalization layers, residual connections and, for exploding gradients, *gradient clipping* (rescaling the gradient when its norm exceeds a threshold).

9.6 Optimization

Stochastic and mini-batch gradient descent. The empirical risk is an average over m examples, and m can be of the order of millions. Computing the full gradient $\nabla \hat{L}_S(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ at each iteration, as in the gradient descent of Section 3, is too costly. *Stochastic gradient descent* (SGD) replaces it by the gradient on one example i_t drawn uniformly at random:

$$\boldsymbol{\theta}_{t+1} = \boldsymbol{\theta}_t - \eta_t \, \nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \ell\left(f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}_t}(\mathbf{x}_{i_t}), y_{i_t}\right).$$

This direction is an *unbiased* estimate of the full gradient, $\mathbb{E}_{i_t}\left[\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \ell(f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}_t}(\mathbf{x}_{i_t}), y_{i_t})\right] = \nabla \hat{L}_S(\boldsymbol{\theta}_t)$, but it is noisy. In practice, we use *mini-batch* gradient descent: the gradient is averaged over a small batch $\mathcal{B}_t$ of B examples (typically $B \in \{32, \ldots, 512\}$), which divides the variance of the estimate by B and exploits the parallelism of GPUs (Algorithm 5). One pass over the whole training set is called an *epoch*. For convex problems, SGD converges if the step sizes satisfy $\sum_t \eta_t = +\infty$ and $\sum_t \eta_t^2 < +\infty$ (*e.g.* $\eta_t \propto 1/t$). For neural networks, the noise of SGD is also believed to help escape saddle points and poor local minima.

Momentum. When the objective is ill-conditioned (a narrow valley), gradient descent oscillates across the valley and progresses slowly along it. The *momentum* method (Polyak, 1964) (or "heavy ball") accumulates the past gradients in a velocity $\mathbf{v}$:

$$\mathbf{v}_{t+1} = \beta\,\mathbf{v}_t + \mathbf{g}_t, \qquad \boldsymbol{\theta}_{t+1} = \boldsymbol{\theta}_t - \eta\,\mathbf{v}_{t+1},$$

where $\mathbf{g}_t$ is the (stochastic) gradient at $\boldsymbol{\theta}_t$ and $\beta \in [0, 1)$ (typically 0.9). The oscillating components of the gradient cancel out in the average, while the consistent ones add up. The *Nesterov* variant evaluates the gradient at the "look-ahead" point $\boldsymbol{\theta}_t - \eta\beta\mathbf{v}_t$.

Adaptive methods: RMSProp and Adam. Different parameters may require different step sizes. *RMSProp* divides the step of each coordinate by a running average of the squared gradients:

$$\mathbf{s}_{t+1} = \rho\,\mathbf{s}_t + (1-\rho)\,\mathbf{g}_t \odot \mathbf{g}_t, \qquad \boldsymbol{\theta}_{t+1} = \boldsymbol{\theta}_t - \frac{\eta}{\sqrt{\mathbf{s}_{t+1}} + \epsilon} \odot \mathbf{g}_t,$$

where the square root and the division are componentwise, $\rho \approx 0.9$ and $\epsilon \approx 10^{-8}$ avoids divisions by zero. *Adam* (Kingma and Ba, 2015) combines momentum and RMSProp, with a bias correction for the first iterations (the averages are initialized at $\mathbf{0}$):

$$\mathbf{m}_t = \beta_1 \mathbf{m}_{t-1} + (1-\beta_1)\mathbf{g}_t, \qquad \hat{\mathbf{m}}_t = \frac{\mathbf{m}_t}{1-\beta_1^t},$$

$$\mathbf{s}_t = \beta_2 \mathbf{s}_{t-1} + (1-\beta_2)\mathbf{g}_t \odot \mathbf{g}_t, \qquad \hat{\mathbf{s}}_t = \frac{\mathbf{s}_t}{1-\beta_2^t},$$

$$\boldsymbol{\theta}_t = \boldsymbol{\theta}_{t-1} - \eta\,\frac{\hat{\mathbf{m}}_t}{\sqrt{\hat{\mathbf{s}}_t} + \epsilon},$$

with the default values $\beta_1 = 0.9$, $\beta_2 = 0.999$, $\eta = 10^{-3}$. Adam is the default optimizer of many practitioners because it is robust to the choice of η, although well-tuned SGD with momentum sometimes generalizes better. The behavior of these methods is illustrated in Fig. 80.

Learning-rate schedules. The learning rate η is the most important hyperparameter. Too large, the training diverges; too small, it is very slow. In practice, the learning rate is decreased during the training: step decay (divide η by 10 every few epochs), exponential decay $\eta_t = \eta_0\gamma^t$, inverse decay $\eta_t = \eta_0/(1+\kappa t)$, or cosine annealing $\eta_t = \frac{\eta_0}{2}\,(1 + \cos(\pi t/T))$. Large models are often trained with a short *warm-up* phase, during which η increases linearly from 0 to η_0.

Weight initialization. The initialization matters for a non-convex problem. The weights cannot be initialized to $\mathbf{0}$ (or to any common value): all the units of a layer would then compute the same function and receive the same gradient, and they would remain identical forever. The weights are thus initialized randomly to *break the symmetry*, and their scale is chosen so that the variance of the activations (and of the gradients) is preserved from one layer to the next. Consider a unit $a_j = \sum_{k=1}^{n_{\text{in}}} W_{jk} h_k$ where the W_{jk} are independent, centered, with variance v, and independent of the inputs h_k, which have variance $\text{Var}(h)$ and zero mean. Then

$$\text{Var}(a_j) = \sum_{k=1}^{n_{\text{in}}} \text{Var}(W_{jk}h_k) = n_{\text{in}}\, v\ \text{Var}(h).$$

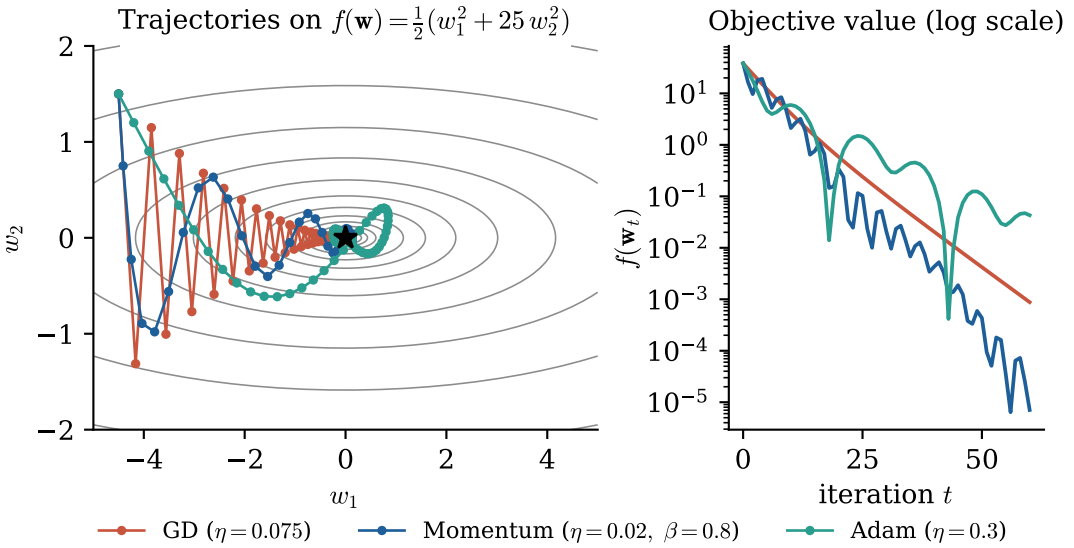


Figure 80: Gradient descent, momentum and Adam on an ill-conditioned quadratic function (deterministic gradients, 60 iterations from the same starting point). Gradient descent oscillates along the steep direction and progresses slowly along the flat one; momentum damps the oscillations; Adam normalizes the step of each coordinate and quickly reaches a neighborhood of the minimum, but with a constant learning rate it keeps oscillating around it.

Keeping $\mathrm{Var}(a_j) = \mathrm{Var}(h)$ requires $v = 1/n_{\text{in}}$ (for an activation close to the identity around 0, such as tanh), while the same reasoning on the backward pass requires $v = 1/n_{\text{out}}$. This leads to the following classical choices.

- *Xavier/Glorot initialization* (Glorot and Bengio, 2010), for tanh or sigmoid: $v = \dfrac{2}{n_{\text{in}} + n_{\text{out}}}$, *e.g.* $W_{jk} \sim \mathcal{U}\left[-\sqrt{\frac{6}{n_{\text{in}}+n_{\text{out}}}}, \sqrt{\frac{6}{n_{\text{in}}+n_{\text{out}}}}\right]$.
- *He initialization* (He et al., 2015), for ReLU: $v = \dfrac{2}{n_{\text{in}}}$, *e.g.* $W_{jk} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 2/n_{\text{in}})$; the factor 2 compensates for the fact that the ReLU sets half of its inputs to 0.

The biases are usually initialized to 0.

9.7 Regularization

Neural networks have many parameters and can easily overfit the training set (see Fig. 79). Besides collecting more data, several regularization techniques are available.

Weight decay. As for ridge regression, we add the penalty $\frac{\lambda}{2}\sum_\ell \left\|\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}\right\|_{\mathcal{F}}^2$ to the empirical risk (the biases are usually not penalized). The gradient step becomes

$$\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)} \leftarrow \mathbf{W}^{(\ell)} - \eta\left(\nabla_{\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}}\hat{L}_S + \lambda\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}\right) = (1-\eta\lambda)\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)} - \eta\nabla_{\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}}\hat{L}_S,$$

i.e. the weights are shrunk by a factor $(1-\eta\lambda)$ at each step, hence the name *weight decay*.

Early stopping. During the training, the training loss decreases while the validation loss first decreases, then increases when the network starts to overfit (Fig. 81). *Early stopping* monitors the validation loss after each epoch and returns the parameters with the lowest validation loss; the training is stopped when this loss has not improved for a given number of epochs (the *patience*). It is simple, cheap and very effective: the number of epochs acts as a regularization hyperparameter, and for a quadratic loss, early stopping can be shown to be closely related to ℓ_2 regularization.

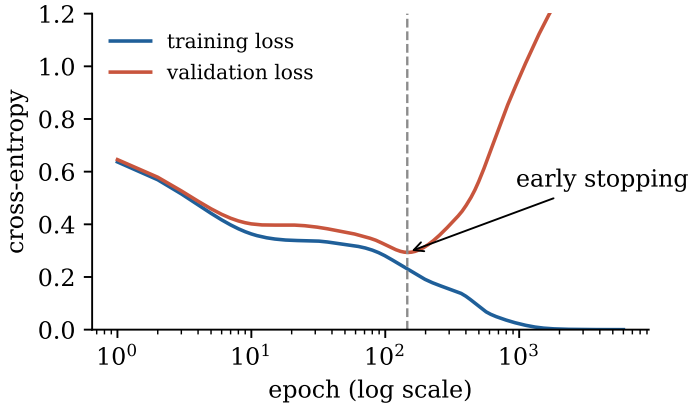


Figure 81: Training and validation losses of an over-parameterized network (60 hidden units, 60 noisy training examples). The validation loss reaches its minimum after about 150 epochs, then increases while the training loss keeps decreasing: the network overfits.

Dropout. *Dropout* (Srivastava et al., 2014) randomly "switches off" units during the training. At each forward pass and for each hidden unit independently, the activation is multiplied by a Bernoulli variable $r_j \sim \mathcal{B}(1-p)$, where p is the dropout rate (typically $p \in [0.1, 0.5]$). In the "inverted dropout" implementation, the kept activations are divided by $1-p$, so that $\mathbb{E}[r_j h_j/(1-p)] = h_j$, and nothing has to be changed at test time, when all the units are kept. Dropout prevents the units from co-adapting, since a unit cannot rely on the presence of the others, and it can be interpreted as training an ensemble of exponentially many sub-networks sharing their weights (see the ensemble methods of Section 10). For a linear model trained with the squared loss, dropout on the inputs is, in expectation, equivalent to an ℓ_2 penalty (Exercise 9.12); more generally, it acts as an adaptive, data-dependent regularization (Wager et al., 2013).

Data augmentation. The best regularization is more data. When the task is invariant to some transformations, we can create new training examples by applying them to the existing ones: for images, random crops, horizontal flips, small rotations, changes of color or contrast; for sounds, time shifts or added noise. This encodes prior knowledge about the problem, and it is essential to train large vision models.

Batch normalization. *Batch normalization* (Ioffe and Szegedy, 2015) normalizes the pre-activations of a layer over the current mini-batch $\mathcal{B}$. For each unit j,

$$\hat{a}_j = \frac{a_j - \mu_{\mathcal{B},j}}{\sqrt{s^2_{\mathcal{B},j} + \epsilon}}, \qquad \tilde{a}_j = \gamma_j \hat{a}_j + \beta_j,$$

where $\mu_{\mathcal{B},j}$ and $s^2_{\mathcal{B},j}$ are the empirical mean and variance of a_j over the mini-batch, and γ_j, β_j are learned parameters (which allow the network to recover the original activation if needed). At test time, the batch statistics are replaced by running averages computed during the training. Batch normalization stabilizes and accelerates the training, allows larger learning rates, makes the network less sensitive to the initialization and has a slight regularizing effect. Its variant *layer normalization*, which normalizes over the units of a layer rather than over the examples, is used in recurrent networks and transformers.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q9.9. A network has $P = 10^6$ parameters. Compare the cost of one gradient computed by backpropagation with that of a finite-difference approximation.

Q9.10. Why can the weights of a network not all be initialized to 0?

Q9.11. With inverted dropout and a dropout rate $p = 0.2$, by which factor are the kept activations multiplied during training? What is done at test time?

Q9.12. What is the standard deviation of the He initialization for a ReLU layer with $n_{\text{in}} = 512$ inputs?

9.8 Convolutional neural networks

Motivation. Fully connected networks are not suited to images. A color image of size 224×224 has $224 \times 224 \times 3 \approx 150\,000$ entries: a single fully connected layer of 1 000 units would already have 150 million parameters. Moreover, such a layer ignores the structure of the image: the pixels are treated as an unordered set of features, and an object must be learned again at each position in the image. *Convolutional neural networks* (CNNs) (LeCun et al., 1998) exploit two properties of images:

- *locality*: the relevant patterns (edges, corners, textures) are local, so that each unit only needs to look at a small neighborhood of pixels (its *receptive field*);
- *translation invariance*: a pattern has the same meaning wherever it appears, so that the same weights can be used at every position (*weight sharing*).

The convolution operation. Let $\mathbf{I} \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n}$ be an input image (one channel) and $\mathbf{K} \in \mathbb{R}^{k \times k}$ a *filter* (or kernel), with k small (typically 3 or 5). The (discrete) convolution[16] produces the *feature map*

$$(\mathbf{I} * \mathbf{K})_{i,j} = \sum_{u=1}^{k} \sum_{v=1}^{k} I_{i+u-1,\, j+v-1}\, K_{u,v} + b,$$

i.e. the filter slides over the image, and at each position we compute the inner product between the filter and the patch of the image it covers, see Fig. 82. A convolution layer is thus a linear layer with a very particular weight matrix: sparse (locality) and with

[16] Strictly speaking, this operation is a cross-correlation: the mathematical convolution flips the kernel. Since the kernel is learned, the distinction does not matter.

many shared entries (weight sharing). It is followed by a non-linear activation, usually a ReLU. A filter acts as a pattern detector: the feature map takes large values where the image looks like the filter. In classical image processing, filters are designed by hand (*e.g.* the Sobel filter of Fig. 83 detects vertical edges); in a CNN, they are learned by backpropagation.

$$\begin{array}{|cccc|} \hline 1 & 2 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 3 & 1 \\ 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ \hline \end{array} \quad * \quad \begin{array}{|ccc|} \hline 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 1 & 0 & -1 \\ \hline \end{array} \quad = \quad \begin{array}{|cc|} \hline 0 & 2 \\ -1 & -1 \\ \hline \end{array}$$

input $\mathbf{I}$ (4×4) | filter $\mathbf{K}$ (3×3) | feature map (2×2)

Figure 82: A convolution without padding and with stride 1. The highlighted output is the inner product between the filter and the highlighted 3×3 patch: $(1+0+2) \times 1 + (2+1+1) \times 0 + (0+3+0) \times (-1) = 0$. This filter responds to vertical transitions from bright (left) to dark (right).

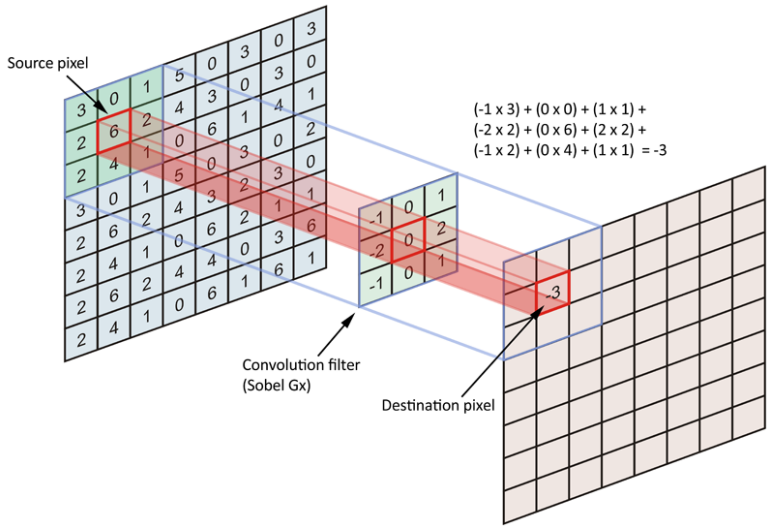


Figure 83: A convolution with the 3×3 Sobel filter G_x, a classical hand-designed filter that detects vertical edges. Each pixel of the output (destination pixel) is the inner product of the filter with the neighborhood of the corresponding input pixel (source pixel).

Channels, padding and stride. A color image has $C = 3$ channels (red, green, blue), and the output of a convolution layer has as many channels as filters. A filter of a layer with C_{in} input channels is thus a tensor of size $k \times k \times C_{\text{in}}$, and a layer with C_{out} filters has $(k^2 C_{\text{in}} + 1)\, C_{\text{out}}$ parameters, *independently of the size of the image*. Two other hyperparameters control the size of the output:

- the *padding* p: we add p rows and columns of zeros around the input, *e.g.* to preserve the spatial size (with $p = (k-1)/2$ for an odd k) and to treat the border pixels like the others;
- the *stride* s: the filter moves by s pixels at a time, which reduces the size of the

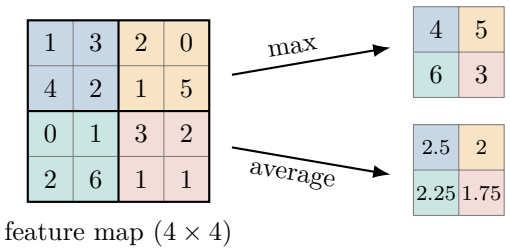
output.

For an input of size $n \times n$, the output of a convolution with a $k \times k$ filter, padding p and stride s is of size $n' \times n'$ with

$$n' = \left\lfloor \frac{n + 2p - k}{s} \right\rfloor + 1.$$

For instance, in Fig. 82, $n' = (4 + 0 - 3)/1 + 1 = 2$.

Pooling. A *pooling* layer reduces the spatial size of the feature maps by summarizing each window (typically 2×2 with stride 2) by its maximum (*max pooling*) or its average (*average pooling*), independently on each channel, see Fig. 84. It has no parameters. Pooling reduces the computational cost of the next layers, increases the receptive field of the units, and makes the representation robust to small translations of the input.



feature map (4×4)

Figure 84: Max pooling (top) and average pooling (bottom) with a 2×2 window and stride 2: each colored block of the feature map is summarized by a single value.

A typical architecture. A classical CNN for image classification alternates blocks of the form [convolution $\to$ ReLU] $\times\, n \to$ pooling. Along the network, the spatial size of the feature maps decreases while the number of channels increases: the first layers detect simple patterns (edges, colors), and the deeper layers combine them into increasingly abstract patterns (textures, parts of objects, objects). The last feature maps are then flattened into a vector and fed to a few fully connected layers ending with a softmax. The first successful CNN, LeNet-5 (LeCun et al., 1998), recognized handwritten digits with two convolution layers; the victory of AlexNet at the ImageNet competition in 2012 marked the beginning of the deep learning era. Since then, the architectures have become deeper and deeper (VGG, Inception, ...), which was made possible by the *residual connections* of ResNet (He et al., 2016): a block computes $\mathbf{h} \mapsto \mathbf{h} + F(\mathbf{h})$ instead of $F(\mathbf{h})$, so that the gradient can flow directly through the identity path, which greatly alleviates the vanishing gradient problem and allows the training of networks with more than 100 layers. Figure 85 summarizes this evolution (Khan et al., 2020). CNNs are also used for other tasks than classification, such as object detection or semantic segmentation, where a class must be predicted for each pixel of the image (Fig. 86).

9.9 Recurrent neural networks

Sequential data. Many data are sequences of variable length: texts (sequences of words), speech, time series, DNA sequences, user logs. A *recurrent neural network*

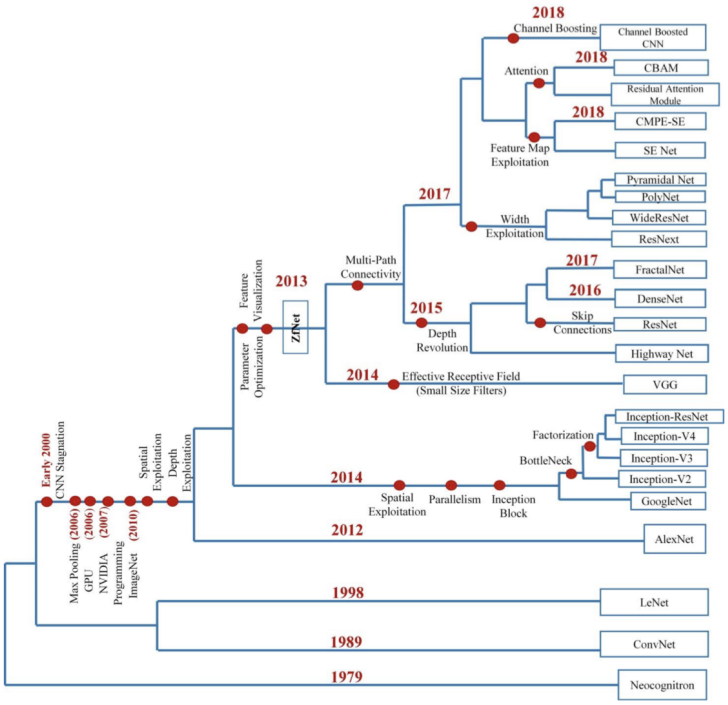


Figure 85: A taxonomy of the main CNN architectures, from the Neocognitron (1979) and LeNet (1998) to the architectures of 2018; figure from Khan et al. (2020).



Figure 86: Semantic segmentation of a street scene: a convolutional network predicts the class of each pixel (car, pedestrian, road, sidewalk, vegetation, sign, ...). Result obtained with the GridNet architecture (Fourure et al., 2017).

(RNN) processes a sequence $\mathbf{x}_1, \dots, \mathbf{x}_T$ one element at a time, and maintains a *hidden state* $\mathbf{h}_t$ that summarizes the past:

$$\mathbf{h}_t = \tanh\left(\mathbf{W}\mathbf{h}_{t-1} + \mathbf{U}\mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{b}\right), \qquad \hat{\mathbf{y}}_t = \mathbf{V}\mathbf{h}_t + \mathbf{c},$$

with $\mathbf{h}_0 = \mathbf{0}$. The same parameters $(\mathbf{W}, \mathbf{U}, \mathbf{b}, \mathbf{V}, \mathbf{c})$ are used at every time step (weight sharing through time), so that the model can process sequences of any length. Depending on the task, we use all the outputs $\hat{\mathbf{y}}_1, \dots, \hat{\mathbf{y}}_T$ (*e.g.* tagging each word of a sentence) or only the last one (*e.g.* classifying the sentiment of a review). Figure 87 shows that an RNN *unrolled* through time is a deep feedforward network with shared weights. Its gradient is thus computed by backpropagation on the unrolled network, an algorithm called *backpropagation through time* (BPTT).

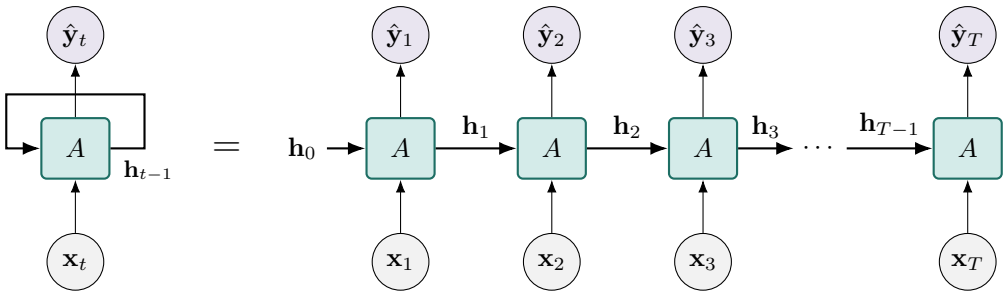


Figure 87: A recurrent neural network (left) and its unrolled version (right): the block A receives the current input $\mathbf{x}_t$ and the previous hidden state $\mathbf{h}_{t-1}$, computes the new hidden state $\mathbf{h}_t = \tanh(\mathbf{W}\mathbf{h}_{t-1} + \mathbf{U}\mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{b})$ and the output $\hat{\mathbf{y}}_t = \mathbf{V}\mathbf{h}_t + \mathbf{c}$. The same parameters are used in every copy of A.

Long-term dependencies. The gradient of the loss at time T with respect to the hidden state at time t involves the product of $T-t$ Jacobian matrices $\mathrm{diag}(\tanh'(\cdot))\mathbf{W}$, with the *same* matrix $\mathbf{W}$. As explained in Section 9.5, this product vanishes or explodes exponentially fast with $T-t$, depending on the spectral norm of $\mathbf{W}$ (Bengio et al., 1994). In practice, a simple RNN is unable to learn dependencies that span more than a few dozen time steps. Gated architectures solve this issue.

LSTM. The *Long Short-Term Memory* network (Hochreiter and Schmidhuber, 1997) adds a *cell state* $\mathbf{c}_t$, a memory updated in an additive way and controlled by three *gates* with values in $(0, 1)$, see Fig. 88:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathbf{f}_t &= \sigma\left(\mathbf{W}_f\mathbf{h}_{t-1} + \mathbf{U}_f\mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{b}_f\right) && \text{(forget gate)}\\
\mathbf{i}_t &= \sigma\left(\mathbf{W}_i\mathbf{h}_{t-1} + \mathbf{U}_i\mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{b}_i\right) && \text{(input gate)}\\
\mathbf{o}_t &= \sigma\left(\mathbf{W}_o\mathbf{h}_{t-1} + \mathbf{U}_o\mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{b}_o\right) && \text{(output gate)}\\
\tilde{\mathbf{c}}_t &= \tanh\left(\mathbf{W}_c\mathbf{h}_{t-1} + \mathbf{U}_c\mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{b}_c\right) && \text{(candidate memory)}\\
\mathbf{c}_t &= \mathbf{f}_t \odot \mathbf{c}_{t-1} + \mathbf{i}_t \odot \tilde{\mathbf{c}}_t, \qquad \mathbf{h}_t = \mathbf{o}_t \odot \tanh(\mathbf{c}_t).
\end{aligned}$$

The forget gate decides what to erase from the memory, the input gate what to write in it, and the output gate what to read from it. When $\mathbf{f}_t \approx \mathbf{1}$ and $\mathbf{i}_t \approx \mathbf{0}$, the memory is copied unchanged and the gradient flows through time without vanishing, as in a residual connection.

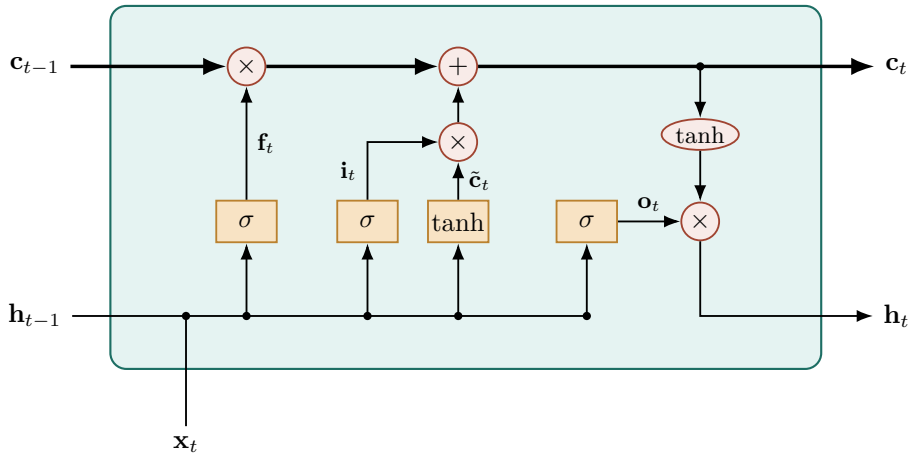


Figure 88: An LSTM cell. The thick upper line carries the cell state $\mathbf{c}_t$, which is only modified by a multiplication (forget gate $\mathbf{f}_t$) and an addition (input gate $\mathbf{i}_t$ times the candidate $\tilde{\mathbf{c}}_t$); the output gate $\mathbf{o}_t$ controls what is read from the memory to produce $\mathbf{h}_t$. The yellow boxes are layers with their own parameters, the red circles are componentwise operations.

GRU. The *Gated Recurrent Unit* (Cho et al., 2014) is a simplified version of the LSTM, with two gates and no separate cell state, see Fig. 89:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathbf{z}_t &= \sigma\left(\mathbf{W}_z\mathbf{h}_{t-1} + \mathbf{U}_z\mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{b}_z\right) && \text{(update gate)}\\
\mathbf{r}_t &= \sigma\left(\mathbf{W}_r\mathbf{h}_{t-1} + \mathbf{U}_r\mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{b}_r\right) && \text{(reset gate)}\\
\hat{\mathbf{h}}_t &= \tanh\left(\mathbf{W}_h(\mathbf{r}_t \odot \mathbf{h}_{t-1}) + \mathbf{U}_h\mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{b}_h\right) && \text{(candidate state)}\\
\mathbf{h}_t &= (\mathbf{1} - \mathbf{z}_t) \odot \mathbf{h}_{t-1} + \mathbf{z}_t \odot \hat{\mathbf{h}}_t.
\end{aligned}$$

It has fewer parameters than an LSTM and often performs similarly.

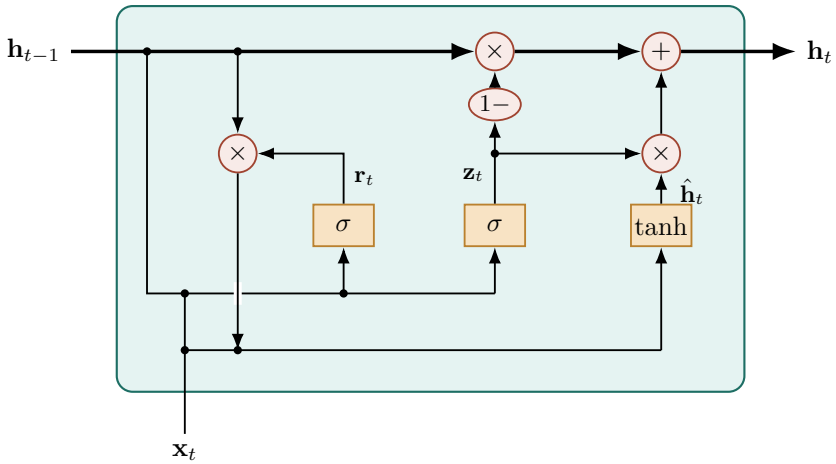


Figure 89: A GRU cell: the update gate $\mathbf{z}_t$ interpolates between the previous state $\mathbf{h}_{t-1}$ (upper line) and the candidate state $\hat{\mathbf{h}}_t$; the reset gate $\mathbf{r}_t$ controls how much of the past is used to compute the candidate. The yellow boxes are layers with their own parameters, the red circles are componentwise operations.

9.10 Other architectures

The building blocks presented so far can be assembled in many ways. We briefly present a few important architectures; see Goodfellow et al. (2016) for more details.

Autoencoders. An *autoencoder* is trained to reproduce its input: an *encoder* $g_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}$ maps $\mathbf{x}$ to a code $\mathbf{z} = g_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}(\mathbf{x})$ of small dimension, and a *decoder* $f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ reconstructs $\hat{\mathbf{x}} = f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{z})$ from it, see Fig. 90. The two networks are trained jointly by minimizing the reconstruction error $\sum_i \|\mathbf{x}_i - f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(g_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}(\mathbf{x}_i))\|^2$, which does not require any label: this is unsupervised learning. The bottleneck forces the network to keep only the most important information: an autoencoder performs a non-linear dimensionality reduction (Hinton and Salakhutdinov, 2006), and a linear autoencoder with the squared loss recovers the subspace of principal component analysis. Autoencoders are also used for denoising (the network reconstructs $\mathbf{x}$ from a corrupted version) and for anomaly detection (anomalies are poorly reconstructed).

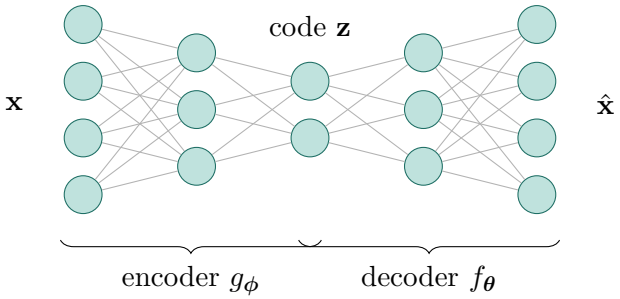


Figure 90: An autoencoder: the encoder compresses the input $\mathbf{x}$ into a low-dimensional code $\mathbf{z}$, and the decoder reconstructs $\hat{\mathbf{x}} \approx \mathbf{x}$ from the code.

Siamese networks. A *siamese network* (Bromley et al., 1994; Chopra et al., 2005) applies the *same* network (same weights) to two inputs $\mathbf{x}$ and $\mathbf{x}'$ and compares their embeddings $\mathbf{z} = g_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}(\mathbf{x})$ and $\mathbf{z}' = g_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}(\mathbf{x}')$, *e.g.* with the Euclidean distance. It is trained so that the embeddings of similar pairs are close and those of dissimilar pairs are far apart, for instance with the *contrastive loss* $y\,\|\mathbf{z} - \mathbf{z}'\|^2 + (1-y)\,[\mu - \|\mathbf{z} - \mathbf{z}'\|]_+^2$, where $y = 1$ for a similar pair and $\mu > 0$ is a margin. The network thus learns a metric, which is useful for verification tasks (is this the same person, the same signature?) and when many classes have few examples (face recognition), see Fig. 91.

Generative adversarial networks. A *generative adversarial network* (GAN) (Goodfellow et al., 2014) learns to generate new data similar to the training data. A *generator* G transforms a random noise $\mathbf{z} \sim p_{\mathbf{z}}$ into a fake example $G(\mathbf{z})$, and a *discriminator* D outputs the probability that its input is a real example, see Fig. 92. The two networks play a two-player game:

$$\min_G \max_D \; \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}} [\ln D(\mathbf{x})] + \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{z}\sim p_{\mathbf{z}}} [\ln (1 - D(G(\mathbf{z})))] \,.$$

The discriminator is trained to distinguish the real examples from the fake ones (a binary cross-entropy), and the generator to fool the discriminator. At the equilibrium, the distribution of $G(\mathbf{z})$ equals the data distribution.

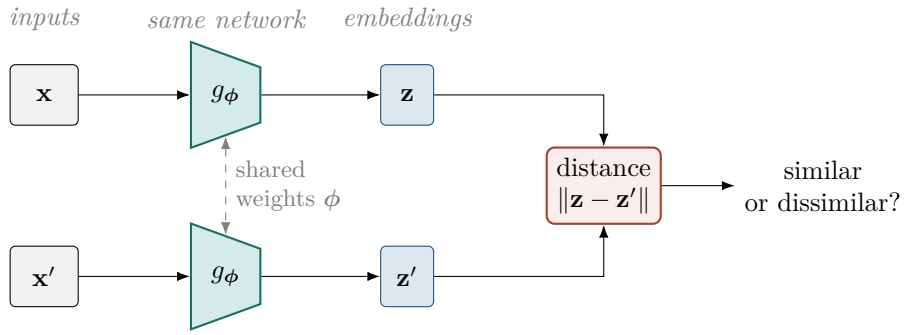


Figure 91: A siamese network: the same network $g_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}$ (for images, a CNN) maps each input to an embedding, and the network is trained so that the embeddings of similar inputs are close and those of dissimilar inputs are far apart.

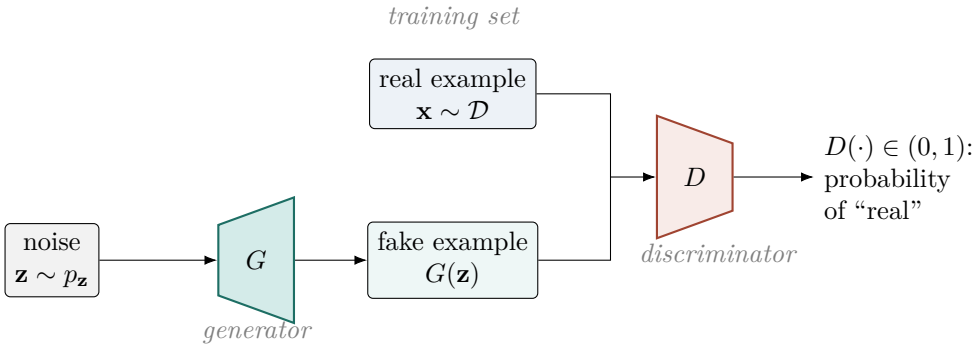


Figure 92: A generative adversarial network: the generator G turns a random noise $\mathbf{z}$ into a fake example $G(\mathbf{z})$, and the discriminator D tries to distinguish the fake examples from the real examples of the training set. D is trained to classify correctly, G to fool D.

Attention and transformers. Recurrent networks process sequences sequentially, which is slow and makes long-range dependencies hard to learn. The *attention* mechanism lets each element of a sequence directly look at all the others. Given queries $\mathbf{Q}$, keys $\mathbf{K}$ and values $\mathbf{V}$ (matrices whose rows are linear projections of the elements of the sequence), it computes

$$\text{Attention}(\mathbf{Q}, \mathbf{K}, \mathbf{V}) = \text{softmax}\left(\frac{\mathbf{Q}\mathbf{K}^\top}{\sqrt{d_k}}\right)\mathbf{V},$$

where the softmax is applied row by row: the output for each element is a weighted average of the values, with weights given by the similarity between its query and the keys. The *transformer* (Vaswani et al., 2017) stacks attention layers, fully connected layers, residual connections and layer normalization, without any recurrence. Its computations are highly parallel, and it has become the standard architecture for natural language processing (large language models are transformers trained to predict the next word), and increasingly for images, sounds and other modalities.

9.11 Practical advice

Training a neural network involves many choices. Here are a few guidelines that work well in most cases.

- **Preprocess the data.** Standardize the input features (zero mean, unit variance); for images, rescale the pixel values. Networks are very sensitive to the scale of the inputs.
- **Start simple.** Begin with a small architecture and a standard configuration (ReLU, He initialization, Adam with $\eta = 10^{-3}$, mini-batches of size 32 to 256), and use a known architecture (or a pre-trained model) for images and texts.
- **Check that the network can overfit.** Before tuning the regularization, make sure that the network reaches a near-zero training loss on a small subset of the data; otherwise, there is a bug or the model is too small.
- **Monitor the training.** Plot the training and validation losses after each epoch. If the training loss does not decrease, decrease the learning rate; if it explodes or becomes `NaN`, decrease the learning rate or clip the gradients; if the validation loss increases, regularize (early stopping, weight decay, dropout, data augmentation).
- **Tune the learning rate first.** It is the most important hyperparameter; try values on a logarithmic grid $(10^{-4}, \dots, 10^{-1})$ and use a schedule.
- **Use transfer learning.** When few labeled data are available, start from a network pre-trained on a large dataset (*e.g.* ImageNet for images) and fine-tune it on the task at hand.
- **Evaluate properly.** The test set must only be used once, at the end; the hyperparameters (architecture, learning rate, regularization) are selected on a validation set, as for any other model (Section 7).
- **Be reproducible.** Fix the random seeds and keep in mind that the result depends on the initialization: report the mean and standard deviation over several runs.

To remember from Section 9

- A **perceptron** is a linear classifier; its learning rule converges on linearly separable data (Novikoff), but it cannot solve the **XOR** problem.
- A **multilayer perceptron** composes affine maps and non-linear **activation functions** (ReLU in the hidden layers); without non-linearity, it is a linear model. Each layer learns a new representation of the data.
- With one large enough hidden layer, a network can approximate any continuous function (**universal approximation**), but this says nothing about learning and generalization.
- The output activation and the loss go together: linear + squared loss (regression), sigmoid + binary cross-entropy (binary classification, generalizes logistic regression), softmax + cross-entropy (multi-class). In all cases $\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(L)} = f_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbf{y}$.
- **Backpropagation** computes all the gradients in one backward pass through the network, at a cost of the same order as the forward pass: $\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)} = \sigma'_\ell(\mathbf{a}^{(\ell)}) \odot (\mathbf{W}^{(\ell+1)\top} \boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell+1)})$ and $\partial J / \partial \mathbf{W}^{(\ell)} = \boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)} \mathbf{h}^{(\ell-1)\top}$.
- Deep networks suffer from **vanishing/exploding gradients**, alleviated by ReLU, Xavier/He initialization, batch normalization and residual connections.

- Training uses **mini-batch SGD** with momentum or **Adam** and a learning-rate schedule; regularization uses weight decay, **early stopping**, dropout and data augmentation.
- **CNNs** (local filters, weight sharing, pooling) are suited to images, **RNNs** (LSTM, GRU) to sequences, and **transformers** (attention) are now the standard for texts.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q9.13. How many parameters does a convolution layer with 64 filters of size 3×3 applied to 32 input channels have? Does it depend on the size of the images?

Q9.14. A 32×32 image goes through a 5×5 convolution without padding and with stride 1, then through a 2×2 max pooling with stride 2. What is the spatial size of the output?

Q9.15. Why does the LSTM suffer less from vanishing gradients than a simple RNN?

Q9.16. In a GAN, what does the optimal discriminator output when the generator perfectly reproduces the data distribution?

Exercises

Exercise 9.1. **(Proof)** *Logical functions.* We work with inputs in $\{0,1\}^2$ and the Heaviside activation $H(z) = \mathbb{1}_{z \geq 0}$. (a) Check that the perceptrons of Table 5 compute the AND, OR and NOT functions. (b) Check, by computing its output on the four points of $\{0,1\}^2$, that the network of Figure 75 computes the XOR function. (c) Prove that no perceptron $H(w_1 x_1 + w_2 x_2 + b)$ can compute the XOR function. *Hint: write the four inequalities that the parameters must satisfy and add two of them.* (d) Propose a network with one hidden layer of two ReLU units and a linear output unit that computes XOR exactly on $\{0,1\}^2$.

Exercise 9.2. **(Computation)** *The perceptron rule by hand.* Consider the training set of $\mathbb{R}^2$ made of $\mathbf{x}_1 = (2,1)$ and $\mathbf{x}_2 = (0,2)$, with label $+1$, and $\mathbf{x}_3 = (-1,0)$ and $\mathbf{x}_4 = (1,-2)$, with label -1. (a) Run Algorithm 4 with $\alpha = 1$, starting from $\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{0}$, $b = 0$, visiting the examples in the order $1,2,3,4$. Give all the updates and the final classifier. (b) Check that the final classifier separates the training set and draw the four points and the line. (c) Run the algorithm again, visiting the examples in the order $4,3,2,1$. Comment.

Exercise 9.3. **(Python)** *Novikoff's bound in practice.* Draw a unit vector $\mathbf{w}^* \in \mathbb{R}^5$ at random and $m = 500$ points uniformly in $[-1,1]^5$ among those satisfying $|\langle \mathbf{w}^*, \mathbf{x} \rangle| \geq \gamma$, labeled by $y = \operatorname{sign}(\langle \mathbf{w}^*, \mathbf{x} \rangle)$. (a) Implement the perceptron without bias (Algorithm 4 with $b = 0$) and count the number of updates until convergence. (b) Compare it with the bound R^2/γ^2 of Theorem 9.1 for $\gamma \in \{0.2, 0.1, 0.05, 0.01\}$. Comment.

Exercise 9.4. **(Proof)** *Activation functions.* Let σ denote the sigmoid function. (a) Show that $\sigma'(z) = \sigma(z)(1-\sigma(z))$ and that $0 < \sigma'(z) \leq 1/4$. (b) Show that $\tanh(z) = 2\sigma(2z) - 1$ and deduce that a network with one hidden layer of tanh units and a linear output can be rewritten as a network with sigmoid hidden units (with different parameters). (c) Show that $\operatorname{softmax}(\mathbf{z} + c\mathbf{1}) = \operatorname{softmax}(\mathbf{z})$ for all $c \in \mathbb{R}$, and that for $q = 2$, $\operatorname{softmax}(\mathbf{z})_1 = \sigma(z_1 - z_2)$. (d) Compute the Jacobian of the softmax function (Definition 9.2) and use it to recover Proposition 9.4 with the chain rule.

Exercise 9.5. **(Computation)** *Why the cross-entropy rather than the squared loss for classification?* A network ends with a single sigmoid unit, $p = \sigma(a)$, where a is the pre-activation of the output, and $y \in \{0,1\}$. (a) Compute $\partial \ell / \partial a$ for the squared loss $\ell = \frac{1}{2}(p-y)^2$ and for the binary cross-entropy $\ell = -y \ln p - (1-y)\ln(1-p)$. (b) Evaluate both derivatives for $y = 1$ and $a = -5$ (the network is confidently wrong). Compare. (c) Show that the cross-entropy is a convex function of a, and conclude.

Exercise 9.6. **(Computation)** *Backpropagation by hand.* Consider the network with one input x, one hidden unit with a sigmoid activation and a sigmoid output: $h = \sigma(w_1 x + b_1)$, $p = \sigma(w_2 h + b_2)$, trained with the binary cross-entropy. (a) Write the forward pass and the backpropagation equations, and give the four partial derivatives of the loss. (b) Compute them numerically for $x = 1$, $y = 1$, $w_1 = w_2 = 1$ and $b_1 = b_2 = 0$, then perform one gradient step with $\eta = 1$ and check that the loss decreases. (c) Check your result with a centered finite-difference approximation (a few lines of Python).

Exercise 9.7. **(Computation)** *Counting parameters.* In this exercise, every layer has biases. (a) How many parameters does a fully connected network with layer sizes 784–256–128–10 have (MNIST digits)? (b) A CNN takes $32 \times 32 \times 3$ images as input. Its first layer has 16 filters of size 5×5, with padding 2 and stride 1, followed by a 2×2 max pooling with stride 2; its second layer has 32 filters of size 3×3, without padding and with stride 1. Give the size of each output and the number of parameters of each layer. (c) Compare with a fully connected layer producing an output of the same size as the first convolution.

Exercise 9.8. **(Computation)** *Convolution and pooling by hand.* Consider the image and the

filter

$$\mathbf{I} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 2 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 3 & 1 & 1 \\ 2 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 2 \\ 1 & 0 & 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 2 & 1 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \mathbf{K} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 1 & 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \quad (b = 0).$$

(a) Compute the feature map $\mathbf{I} * \mathbf{K}$ (no padding, stride 1) with the formula of Section 9.8. (b) Apply a ReLU, then a 2×2 max pooling with stride 1. (c) What is the size of the output with padding 1 and stride 2? Compute it. (d) The first layer of ResNet applies 64 filters of size 7×7 with padding 3 and stride 2 to $224 \times 224 \times 3$ images. Give the size of its output and its number of parameters.

Exercise 9.9. **(Proof)** *Initialization.* This exercise justifies the initialization schemes of Section 9.6. (a) Consider a network with one hidden layer. Show that if all the weights are initialized to the same value, the hidden units remain identical during the whole training by gradient descent. (b) Let $a = \sum_{k=1}^{n} W_k h_k$ where the W_k are i.i.d., centered with variance v, and independent of the $h_k = \max(0, a'_k)$, where the a'_k are i.i.d., symmetric around 0, with variance s^2. Show that $\mathbb{E}[h_k^2] = s^2/2$ and $\mathrm{Var}(a) = n\, v\, s^2/2$. Deduce the He initialization.

Exercise 9.10. **(Computation)** *Vanishing and exploding gradients.* Consider a "chain" network with L layers of one unit each: $a_\ell = w_\ell h_{\ell-1} + b_\ell$ and $h_\ell = \sigma(a_\ell)$, with $h_0 = x$. (a) Show that $\delta_1 = \partial J/\partial a_1 = \delta_L \prod_{\ell=1}^{L-1} \sigma'(a_\ell)\, w_{\ell+1}$, and deduce a bound on $|\delta_1|/|\delta_L|$ when σ is the sigmoid and $|w_\ell| \le w_{\max}$. (b) With the sigmoid and $w_\ell = 1$, how small can the ratio $|\delta_1|/|\delta_L|$ be for $L = 10$? From which depth is it guaranteed to be smaller than 10^{-6}? (c) Same question with tanh, assuming that all the pre-activations are equal to 0, and with ReLU, assuming that all the units are active. (d) With the sigmoid, $w_\ell = 5$ and all the pre-activations equal to 0, compute the ratio for $L = 21$. Comment.

Exercise 9.11. **(Computation)** *Momentum and Adam.* Let $\mathbf{g}$ be a gradient that does not depend on t (a long, gently sloping valley). (a) Show that the velocity of the momentum method (Section 9.6), starting from $\mathbf{v}_0 = \mathbf{0}$, satisfies $\mathbf{v}_t = \frac{1-\beta^t}{1-\beta}\mathbf{g}$. What is the effective learning rate after many iterations for $\beta = 0.9$? (b) Compute the first step $\boldsymbol{\theta}_1 - \boldsymbol{\theta}_0$ of Adam, coordinate by coordinate (neglect ϵ). Does it depend on the scale of the gradient? (c) Same question without the bias correction ($\hat{\mathbf{m}}_t$, $\hat{\mathbf{s}}_t$ replaced by $\mathbf{m}_t$, $\mathbf{s}_t$), with $\beta_1 = 0.9$ and $\beta_2 = 0.999$. What is the role of the bias correction? (d) Show that the iterates of Adam (with $\epsilon = 0$) are unchanged when the loss is multiplied by a constant $c > 0$. Is it the case for gradient descent?

Exercise 9.12. **(Proof)** *Dropout as a regularization.* Consider a linear model $f(\mathbf{x}) = \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle$ trained with the squared loss, to which inverted dropout is applied on the inputs: $\tilde{f}(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_{j=1}^{d} w_j \frac{r_j}{1-p} x_j$, where the $r_j \sim \mathcal{B}(1-p)$ are independent. (a) Compute $\mathbb{E}[\tilde{f}(\mathbf{x})]$ and $\mathrm{Var}(\tilde{f}(\mathbf{x}))$. (b) Deduce that $\mathbb{E}\left[(y - \tilde{f}(\mathbf{x}))^2\right] = (y - \langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x} \rangle)^2 + \frac{p}{1-p} \sum_{j=1}^{d} w_j^2 x_j^2$. (c) Interpret this result when it is averaged over a training set whose features are standardized ($\frac{1}{m}\sum_i x_{ij}^2 = 1$ for all j). What happens when $p \to 0$ and when $p \to 1$?

Exercise 9.13. **(Computation)** *Recurrent networks.* Inputs $\mathbf{x}_t \in \mathbb{R}^d$, hidden states of dimension n, outputs of dimension q. (a) Give the number of parameters of the simple RNN of Section 9.9. Does it depend on the length T of the sequences? (b) Give the number of parameters of an LSTM cell and of a GRU cell (without the output layer). Compute them, and that of the simple RNN cell $(\mathbf{W}, \mathbf{U}, \mathbf{b})$, for $d = 100$ and $n = 128$. (c) Consider the scalar linear RNN $h_t = w\, h_{t-1} + u\, x_t$. Compute $\partial h_T / \partial h_t$ and evaluate it for $T - t = 50$ and $w \in \{0.9, 1.1\}$. What happens with $h_t = \tanh(w\, h_{t-1} + u\, x_t)$? (d) For an LSTM, compute $\partial \mathbf{c}_T / \partial \mathbf{c}_t$ when the gates are frozen (*i.e.* treated as constants) and explain why it is better behaved.

Exercise 9.14. **(Python)** *Practical session.* Implement a multilayer perceptron with one hidden layer of tanh units and a sigmoid output in `numpy` (forward pass, backpropagation, mini-batch gradient descent with weight decay) and train it on the "two moons"

dataset (`sklearn.datasets.make_moons` with 400 points and `noise=0.25`, half of them for validation). (a) Study the influence of the number of hidden units on the training and validation accuracies. (b) Study the influence of the learning rate and of the weight decay. (c) Compare with `sklearn.neural_network.MLPClassifier`. The script `code/figures_course/make_figures_nn.py` can be used as a starting point.

Part III

Advanced Supervised Machine Learning and Implementation

The algorithms of Part II learn a single model. This part shows how to go further. Section 10 comes back to statistical learning theory through the decomposition of the error into approximation, estimation and optimization terms, and uses it to explain why *combining* models works: bagging and random forests reduce the variance of unstable learners, boosting and gradient boosting reduce the bias of weak ones, and stacking learns how to combine heterogeneous models. The section ends with an introduction to metric learning, which learns the representation of the data rather than the model. Section 11 gathers practical advice to conduct a machine learning study from the raw data to the final model. The theory of ensemble methods is developed further in Part IV.

10 Advanced Supervised Algorithms

About this section

In this section you will learn to:

- *decompose the error of a predictor into bias, variance and noise, and relate it to the approximation and estimation errors and to the Rademacher complexity;*
- *explain why averaging several models reduces the variance, and implement bagging and random forests (with the out-of-bag error);*
- *run AdaBoost, prove that its training error decreases exponentially fast, and interpret it as a coordinate descent on the exponential loss;*
- *derive gradient boosting as a gradient descent in function space, and understand the second-order criterion of XGBoost;*
- *learn a Mahalanobis distance from labeled data (MMC, ITML, LMNN) to improve distance-based methods.*

10.1 Back to Statistical Learning Theory

In Section 6, we focused on the generalization error and discussed the over-fitting and under-fitting of algorithms by looking at their errors. We have seen that, in practice, we look for the parameters that minimize the error of our algorithm, but we never paid attention to the value of this error itself. More precisely, what is the smallest value our algorithm can possibly reach? If this value is reached, does it mean that the algorithm is perfect? Is it really the best model we could have learned, or even the right class of models?

10.1.1 Error Decomposition

In this part, we will see that the error can be decomposed into several terms, which brings some answers to these questions. This decomposition of the error is also at the origin of more complex models (such as combinations of models), which are designed to reduce some of its components.

The examples of the regression setting presented previously have shown that a simple model, such as a linear one, is sometimes not flexible enough to achieve good performance, *i.e.* it presents a large *bias*. Conversely, a complex model, such as a high-degree polynomial, has a low bias but may not generalize well: it has a high *variance*.

Let us show where these two terms come from by assuming that our data are generated by the following model:

$$y = f(\mathbf{x}) + \varepsilon,$$

where ε is a random noise with zero mean, independent of $\mathbf{x}$, which represents the errors of measurement (or everything that $\mathbf{x}$ cannot explain). Using a sample $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ generated by this model, we learn a hypothesis h, which is an estimator of f. Because h is learned from the sample S, it is a random quantity. We are now interested in the generalization capacities of h, measured with the mean squared error $\mathbb{E}[(y - h(\mathbf{x}))^2]$ on a new example. More precisely, we study the different components of

this error at a fixed point $\mathbf{x}$, the expectation being taken over the draw of the training sample S and over the noise of the new observation y.

Proposition 10.1: Error Decomposition

We consider the data generation model

$$y = f(\mathbf{x}) + \varepsilon,$$

where $\mathbb{E}[\varepsilon] = 0$. Using a sample $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ generated by this model, we learn a hypothesis h, which is an estimator of f. Then, for any $\mathbf{x}$, the generalization error of h measured with the mean squared error can be written as:

$$\mathbb{E}[(y - h(\mathbf{x}))^2] = (\mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{x})] - f(\mathbf{x}))^2 + \mathbb{E}\left[(\mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{x})] - h(\mathbf{x}))^2\right] + \mathbb{E}[(y - f(\mathbf{x}))^2].$$

Proof. We will use the *König-Huygens* formula, which states that for any random variable X with a finite second moment:

$$\mathbb{E}\left[(X - \mathbb{E}[X])^2\right] = \mathbb{E}[X^2] - \mathbb{E}[X]^2.$$

We also use the fact that the noise of the new observation y is independent of the training sample S, hence of $h(\mathbf{x})$, and that $\mathbb{E}[y] = f(\mathbf{x})$. We now expand the left-hand side of our equation:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathbb{E}[(y - h(\mathbf{x}))^2] &= \mathbb{E}[y^2 - 2yh(\mathbf{x}) + h(\mathbf{x})^2], \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ linearity of the expectation} \\
&= \underbrace{\mathbb{E}[y^2]} - \mathbb{E}[2yh(\mathbf{x})] + \underbrace{\mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{x})^2]}, \\
&\quad \downarrow \textit{ König-Huygens} \text{ formula and independence of } y \text{ and } h(\mathbf{x}) \\
&= \mathbb{E}[y]^2 + \mathbb{E}\left[(y - \mathbb{E}[y])^2\right] - 2\,\mathbb{E}[y]\,\mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{x})] \\
&\quad + \mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{x})]^2 + \mathbb{E}\left[(h(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{x})])^2\right], \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ using the data generation model, } \mathbb{E}[y] = f(\mathbf{x}) \\
&= f(\mathbf{x})^2 + \mathbb{E}\left[(y - f(\mathbf{x}))^2\right] - 2f(\mathbf{x})\,\mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{x})] \\
&\quad + \mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{x})]^2 + \mathbb{E}\left[(h(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{x})])^2\right], \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ factorizing the remaining terms} \\
&= (\mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{x})] - f(\mathbf{x}))^2 + \mathbb{E}\left[(\mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{x})] - h(\mathbf{x}))^2\right] + \mathbb{E}[(y - f(\mathbf{x}))^2].
\end{aligned}$$

□

In this proposition, the terms on the right-hand side respectively represent:

- the squared bias of h: the difference between its mean value over the samples S and the target value $f(\mathbf{x})$;

- the variance of h: how much h varies around its mean value when the sample S changes. It represents the sensitivity of the model to the training data;
- the Bayes error, which is equal to the variance of the noise ε. It does not depend on the estimator, but only on the distribution of the data: no model can do better.

Example 10.1. Let us consider the two class-conditional densities d_{+1} and d_{-1} represented in Figure 93, with equal class priors. The Bayes classifier predicts, at each point x, the class whose density is the largest. The Bayes error is then related to the area of the region lying under both curves (it is equal to half of this area, here $\mathcal{R}^\star \simeq 0.224$), *i.e.* the region where no classifier is able to tell whether a point comes from one distribution or from the other.

As an exercise (see Exercise 10.1), you can compute the Bayes error of a two-class problem with equal priors whose class-conditional densities are:

$$d_1(x) = \begin{cases} \frac{3}{2}x^2 + x & \text{when } 0 \leq x \leq 1, \\ 0 & \text{otherwise,} \end{cases} \quad \text{and} \quad d_2(x) = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{when } \frac{3}{4} \leq x \leq \frac{7}{4}, \\ 0 & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

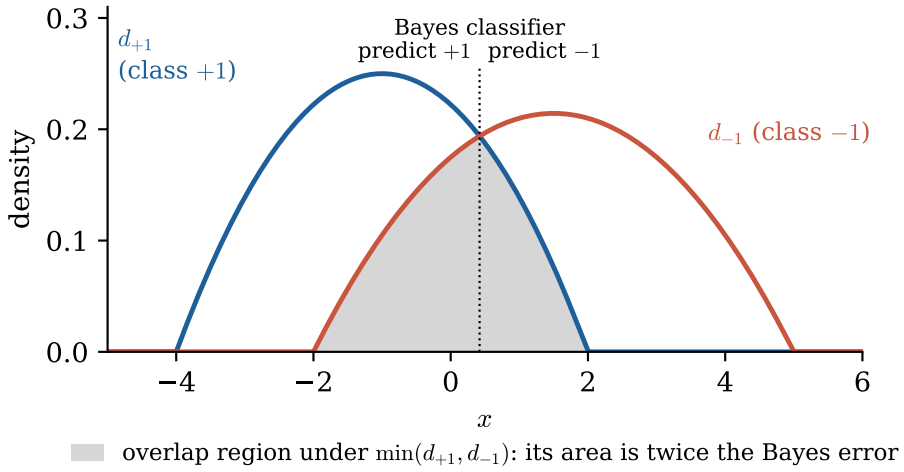


Figure 93: Two class-conditional densities with equal priors, $d_{+1}(x) = (2-x)(x+4)/36$ on $[-4, 2]$ and $d_{-1}(x) = 6(5-x)(x+2)/343$ on $[-2, 5]$. The Bayes classifier predicts the class with the largest density (dotted line). Even this optimal classifier errs on the points of the shaded region, which lies under both curves: the Bayes error is half of its area, $\mathcal{R}^\star \simeq 0.224$.

In view of the previous proposition, the quantity we actually aim to minimize is the **excess risk**, that is:

$$\mathbb{E}[(y - h(\mathbf{x}))^2] - \mathbb{E}[(y - f(\mathbf{x}))^2].$$

Although this study has been conducted in the special case of regression with the squared loss, a similar decomposition holds in the general case.

We now suppose, more generally, that the observations are sampled from a joint distribution $\mathcal{D}$ over $\mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{Y}$, associated with a probability measure μ. We also consider a loss function ℓ,

$$\ell : \mathcal{Y} \times \mathcal{Y} \to \mathbb{R},$$

which quantifies the cost incurred by a hypothesis h when it predicts $h(\mathbf{x})$ while the true value is y. The function, or hypothesis, h we are looking for is the one that minimizes the expected error over $\mathcal{D}$, *i.e.* the risk

$$\mathcal{R}(h) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}} [\ell(y, h(\mathbf{x}))] = \int_{\mathcal{X}\times\mathcal{Y}} \ell(y, h(\mathbf{x}))\, d\mu(\mathbf{x}, y).$$

Keep in mind that, in practice, the hypothesis h is learned from a finite sample. We now assume that we minimize the risk over a function (or hypothesis) space $\mathcal{H}$. If we denote by $\mathcal{R}^\star$ the Bayes risk, *i.e.* the smallest risk achievable by any measurable function, we can decompose the **Bayes regret** as:

$$\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}^\star = \left(\mathcal{R}(h) - \inf_{g\in\mathcal{H}} \mathcal{R}(g)\right) + \inf_{g\in\mathcal{H}} \mathcal{R}(g) - \mathcal{R}^\star.$$

The first term is the excess risk of h with respect to the best function of the hypothesis space $\mathcal{H}$, also called the **estimation error**. The second term is the **approximation error**, *i.e.* the smallest excess risk we can achieve with a function of $\mathcal{H}$. This is a bias term: it does not depend on the data, but only on the hypothesis space $\mathcal{H}$.

We now draw the link with the generalization bounds presented in Section 6 and go a little further by bounding the **excess risk**. Let us denote by h the hypothesis obtained by minimizing the empirical risk over $\mathcal{H}$ using a sample S:

$$h \in \arg\min_{g\in\mathcal{H}} \mathcal{R}_S(g).$$

We also denote by $h_\mathcal{H}$ the minimizer of the risk $\mathcal{R}$ over the hypothesis space $\mathcal{H}$ (we assume that it exists), *i.e.*

$$h_\mathcal{H} \in \arg\min_{g\in\mathcal{H}} \mathcal{R}(g).$$

The **excess risk** $\mathcal{R}(h) - \inf_{g\in\mathcal{H}} \mathcal{R}(g)$ can be rewritten as the sum of three terms:

$$\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}(h_\mathcal{H}) = (\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)) + (\mathcal{R}_S(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h_\mathcal{H})) + (\mathcal{R}_S(h_\mathcal{H}) - \mathcal{R}(h_\mathcal{H})),$$

where $(\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h))$ is the difference between the true risk and the empirical risk of the hypothesis h. This is precisely the quantity we are interested in when we study the generalization of algorithms. The second term $(\mathcal{R}_S(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h_\mathcal{H}))$ is non-positive by construction, since h minimizes the empirical risk. The third term $(\mathcal{R}_S(h_\mathcal{H}) - \mathcal{R}(h_\mathcal{H}))$ is easier to control, as it involves a fixed (deterministic) function to which the law of large numbers applies.

However, the first term cannot be handled in the same way, because h depends on the sample S. It can nevertheless be bounded as follows:

$$\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h) \leq \sup_{g \in \mathcal{H}} \left| \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}} [\ell(g(\mathbf{x}), y)] - \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i) \right|.$$

Since this quantity also bounds the third term, and since the second term is non-positive, we immediately obtain:

$$\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}(h_{\mathcal{H}}) \leq 2\sup_{g \in \mathcal{H}} \left| \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}} [\ell(g(\mathbf{x}), y)] - \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i) \right|.$$

This last bound can be seen as a variance term, which increases with the size of $\mathcal{H}$. If $\mathcal{H}$ is large, we can achieve a low empirical risk; however, the true risk is then more likely to be much higher than the empirical one.

A question naturally arises:

How can we define the size of the hypothesis space $\mathcal{H}$?

When $\mathcal{H}$ contains a finite number of hypotheses, the answer is clear: its size is simply the number of hypotheses in the set. But when it is infinite, there exist several measures of the size of $\mathcal{H}$, such as the *Rademacher complexity*.

The Rademacher complexity Bartlett and Mendelson (2003) has been introduced to measure the complexity of a set of hypotheses Koltchinskii and Panchenko (2000a). Informally, it measures how well the set of hypotheses is able to fit random noise in the dataset.

Definition 10.1: (Empirical) Rademacher complexity

Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a family of functions and $S = \{\mathbf{x}_i\}_{i=1}^m$ a fixed sample of size m. The empirical Rademacher complexity of $\mathcal{H}$ with respect to S is defined as:

$$\mathfrak{R}_S(\mathcal{H}) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\boldsymbol{\sigma}} \left[\sup_{h \in \mathcal{H}} \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sigma_i h(\mathbf{x}_i) \right],$$

where $\boldsymbol{\sigma} = (\sigma_1, \ldots, \sigma_m)$ is a vector of independent Rademacher random variables, *i.e.* random variables taking the values -1 and $+1$ with probability $1/2$ each. The Rademacher complexity is the expectation of the above quantity with respect to the distribution $\mathcal{D}$ of the data:

$$\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H}) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m} [\mathfrak{R}_S(\mathcal{H})].$$

This measure increases with the size of $\mathcal{H}$ and, for most classes of interest, decreases with the sample size m.

In a nutshell

Draw random labels $\sigma_i \in \{-1, +1\}$ by tossing a coin for each point of S, and look for the hypothesis of $\mathcal{H}$ that agrees best with these meaningless labels. The quantity $\frac{1}{m}\sum_i \sigma_i h(\mathbf{x}_i)$ is the correlation between h and the noise: $\mathfrak{R}_S(\mathcal{H})$ is the best correlation that $\mathcal{H}$ can reach, on average over the coin tosses. A class that contains a single function has a Rademacher complexity equal to 0, whereas a

class able to fit *any* labeling of the m points (it *shatters* S) reaches the maximal value 1 for functions with values in $\{-1,+1\}$. A class which can fit pure noise can also fit the noise present in the data: this is exactly the over-fitting phenomenon.

In the rest of this section, with a slight abuse of notation, we write $\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H})$ for the Rademacher complexity of the class of losses $\{(\mathbf{x},y)\mapsto \ell(g(\mathbf{x}),y) : g\in\mathcal{H}\}$ associated with $\mathcal{H}$ (and, in the next few lines, with an absolute value inside the supremum). Using this measure, we will show that

$$\begin{aligned}\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\mathcal{R}(h)-\mathcal{R}(h_{\mathcal{H}})\right] &\leq 2\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\sup_{g\in\mathcal{H}}\left|\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\left[\ell(g(\mathbf{x}),y)\right]-\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i),y_i)\right|\right],\\ &\leq 4\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H}).\end{aligned}$$

Therefore,

$$\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\mathcal{R}(h)\right]-\mathcal{R}^\star \leq \inf_{g\in\mathcal{H}}\mathcal{R}(g)-\mathcal{R}^\star+4\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H}).$$

This result illustrates, in a more general way, the bias-variance trade-off in risk minimization: enlarging $\mathcal{H}$ decreases the approximation error but increases the complexity term. It also makes explicit the link between complexity and sample size.

It remains to explain where the following inequality comes from:

$$\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\sup_{g\in\mathcal{H}}\left|\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\left[\ell(g(\mathbf{x}),y)\right]-\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i),y_i)\right|\right]\leq 2\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H}).$$

We prove it using the *symmetrization technique*, which introduces a *ghost sample* $S'=\{(\mathbf{x}'_i,y'_i)\}_{i=1}^m$, drawn from $\mathcal{D}^m$ independently of S. Concretely,

$$\begin{aligned}&\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\sup_{g\in\mathcal{H}}\left|\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\left[\ell(g(\mathbf{x}),y)\right]-\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i),y_i)\right|\right],\\ =&\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\sup_{g\in\mathcal{H}}\left|\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S'\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \ell(g(\mathbf{x}'_i),y'_i)\right]-\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i),y_i)\right|\right],\\ &\downarrow \text{ the second term does not depend on } S'\\ =&\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\sup_{g\in\mathcal{H}}\left|\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S'\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \ell(g(\mathbf{x}'_i),y'_i)-\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i),y_i)\right]\right|\right],\\ &\downarrow \text{ linearity of the empirical mean}\\ =&\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\sup_{g\in\mathcal{H}}\left|\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S'\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \left(\ell(g(\mathbf{x}'_i),y'_i)-\ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i),y_i)\right)\right]\right|\right],\\ \leq&\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S,S'\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\sup_{g\in\mathcal{H}}\left|\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \left(\ell(g(\mathbf{x}'_i),y'_i)-\ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i),y_i)\right)\right|\right],\end{aligned}$$

where the last inequality uses Jensen's inequality ($|\mathbb{E}[X]|\leq\mathbb{E}[|X|]$) and the fact that the supremum of expectations is smaller than the expectation of the supremum.

We now introduce our Rademacher variables $\sigma_i,\ i = 1, \dots, m$, and notice that, for any fixed $\boldsymbol{\sigma} \in \{-1, +1\}^m$,

$$\begin{aligned}
&\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S,S' \sim \mathcal{D}^m} \left[\sup_{g \in \mathcal{H}} \left| \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \left(\ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i'), y_i') - \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i) \right) \right| \right] \\
&= \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S,S' \sim \mathcal{D}^m} \left[\sup_{g \in \mathcal{H}} \left| \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sigma_i \left(\ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i'), y_i') - \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i) \right) \right| \right].
\end{aligned}$$

This is due to the fact that the data are *i.i.d.*: multiplying the i-th term by $\sigma_i = -1$ amounts to swapping $(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)$ and $(\mathbf{x}_i', y_i')$, which does not change the distribution of the pair (S, S'). Since this equality holds for any choice of $\boldsymbol{\sigma}$, it also holds when we take the expectation over a vector $\boldsymbol{\sigma}$ of Rademacher variables. Finally, using the triangle inequality,

$$\begin{aligned}
&\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S,S' \sim \mathcal{D}^m, \boldsymbol{\sigma}} \left[\sup_{g \in \mathcal{H}} \left| \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sigma_i \left(\ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i'), y_i') - \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i) \right) \right| \right], \\
&\leq \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S \sim \mathcal{D}^m, \boldsymbol{\sigma}} \left[\sup_{g \in \mathcal{H}} \left| \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sigma_i \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i) \right| \right] + \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S' \sim \mathcal{D}^m, \boldsymbol{\sigma}} \left[\sup_{g \in \mathcal{H}} \left| \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sigma_i \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i'), y_i') \right| \right], \\
&= 2 \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S \sim \mathcal{D}^m, \boldsymbol{\sigma}} \left[\sup_{g \in \mathcal{H}} \left| \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sigma_i \ell(g(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i) \right| \right], \\
&= 2\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H}).
\end{aligned}$$

There exist other measures of the capacity of a hypothesis space $\mathcal{H}$, such as the *VC-dimension* Vapnik and Chervonenkis (1971), which is easier to compute when we deal with linear classifiers. We will not study this measure here; instead, we come back to generalization bounds and derive a first bound based on the Rademacher complexity.

10.1.2 Back to Generalization Bounds

Using Definition 10.1, we can now state a first generalization bound, given in Theorem 10.2.

Theorem 10.2: Rademacher Generalization Bound

Let $\mathcal{H}$ be our class of hypotheses and ℓ a loss function such that $(\mathbf{x}, y) \mapsto \ell(h(\mathbf{x}), y)$ takes its values in $[0, 1]$ for every $h \in \mathcal{H}$. Then, for any $\delta \in (0, 1)$, with probability at least $1 - \delta$ over the draw of an *i.i.d.* sample S of size m, each of the following bounds holds for all $h \in \mathcal{H}$:

$$\mathcal{R}(h) \leq \mathcal{R}_S(h) + 2\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H}) + \sqrt{\frac{\log(1/\delta)}{2m}}, \quad \text{and}$$

$$\mathcal{R}(h) \leq \mathcal{R}_S(h) + 2\mathfrak{R}_S(\mathcal{H}) + 3\sqrt{\frac{\log(2/\delta)}{2m}},$$

where the Rademacher complexities are those of the class of losses associated with $\mathcal{H}$.

Proof. Let us consider a sample $S = \{\mathbf{z}_i\}_{i=1}^m$, with $\mathbf{z}_i = (\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)$, drawn from $\mathcal{D}^m$, and let us write $\ell(h, \mathbf{z}) = \ell(h(\mathbf{x}), y)$ for short. For any $h \in \mathcal{H}$, we denote by $\mathcal{R}_S(h) = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \ell(h, \mathbf{z}_i)$ the empirical risk of the hypothesis h.

The proof consists in applying McDiarmid's inequality to the function Φ defined for any sample S by

$$\Phi(S) = \sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}} \left(\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)\right).$$

Let us consider two samples S and S' differing by exactly one point, say $\mathbf{z}_m = (\mathbf{x}_m, y_m) \in S$ and $\mathbf{z}'_m = (\mathbf{x}'_m, y'_m) \in S'$. Since the difference of suprema does not exceed the supremum of the difference, we have

$$\Phi(S) - \Phi(S') \leq \sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}} \left(\mathcal{R}_{S'}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)\right) = \sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}} \frac{\ell(h, \mathbf{z}'_m) - \ell(h, \mathbf{z}_m)}{m} \leq \frac{1}{m}.$$

Similarly, we obtain $\Phi(S') - \Phi(S) \leq \frac{1}{m}$, so that $|\Phi(S') - \Phi(S)| \leq \frac{1}{m}$. Then, by McDiarmid's inequality, for any $\delta \in (0, 1)$, with probability at least $1 - \delta$, the following holds:

$$\Phi(S) \leq \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}[\Phi(S)] + \sqrt{\frac{\log(1/\delta)}{2m}}.$$

Our next step consists in bounding the expectation on the right-hand side of the previous inequality:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}[\Phi(S)] &= \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}} \left(\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)\right)\right], \\
&= \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}} \left(\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S'\sim\mathcal{D}^m}[\mathcal{R}_{S'}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)]\right)\right], \\
&\leq \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S,S'\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}} \left(\mathcal{R}_{S'}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)\right)\right], \\
&= \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S,S'\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}} \left(\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \left(\ell(h, \mathbf{z}'_i) - \ell(h, \mathbf{z}_i)\right)\right)\right], \\
&= \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S,S'\sim\mathcal{D}^m,\boldsymbol{\sigma}}\left[\sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}} \left(\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \sigma_i\left(\ell(h, \mathbf{z}'_i) - \ell(h, \mathbf{z}_i)\right)\right)\right], \\
&\leq \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S'\sim\mathcal{D}^m,\boldsymbol{\sigma}}\left[\sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}} \left(\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \sigma_i\ell(h, \mathbf{z}'_i)\right)\right] \\
&\quad + \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m,\boldsymbol{\sigma}}\left[\sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}} \left(\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m (-\sigma_i)\ell(h, \mathbf{z}_i)\right)\right],
\end{aligned}$$

$$
\begin{aligned}
&\downarrow\ \boldsymbol{\sigma} \text{ and } -\boldsymbol{\sigma} \text{ have the same distribution} \\
&= 2 \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m,\boldsymbol{\sigma}} \left[\sup_{h\in\mathcal{H}} \left(\frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sigma_i \ell(h, \mathbf{z}_i) \right) \right], \\
&= 2\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H}).
\end{aligned}
$$

This proves the first bound. The reader has probably noticed that this step of the proof is exactly the same as the one used when studying the excess risk.

For the second bound, we note that changing one point of S changes $\mathfrak{R}_S(\mathcal{H})$ by at most $1/m$. Using McDiarmid's inequality again, we get, with probability at least $1 - \delta/2$,

$$
\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H}) \leq \mathfrak{R}_S(\mathcal{H}) + \sqrt{\frac{\log(2/\delta)}{2m}}.
$$

Applying the first bound with $\delta/2$ instead of δ and combining the two inequalities with a union bound, we obtain that, with probability at least $1 - \delta$:

$$
\Phi(S) \leq 2\mathfrak{R}_S(\mathcal{H}) + 3\sqrt{\frac{\log(2/\delta)}{2m}}.
$$

□

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q10.1. Data follow the model $y = f(\mathbf{x}) + \varepsilon$ with $\mathrm{Var}(\varepsilon) = 0.25$. At a point $\mathbf{x}$, a learned predictor satisfies $\mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{x})] = f(\mathbf{x}) + 0.3$ and $\mathrm{Var}(h(\mathbf{x})) = 0.16$. What is its expected squared error at $\mathbf{x}$, and which part of it could a better algorithm remove?

Q10.2. In the decomposition of the excess risk $\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}(h_{\mathcal{H}})$, why can the term $\mathcal{R}_S(h_{\mathcal{H}}) - \mathcal{R}(h_{\mathcal{H}})$ be controlled by the law of large numbers (or by Hoeffding's inequality), whereas the term $\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)$ cannot?

Q10.3. Assume that $\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H}) \leq C/\sqrt{m}$ for some constant C. By how much is the gap $\mathcal{R}(h) - \mathcal{R}_S(h)$ guaranteed by the first bound of Theorem 10.2 reduced when the sample size is multiplied by 4?

10.2 Ensemble Methods

In what we have seen so far, we only used one model to answer a given problem, *e.g.* a linear regression to predict the price of a house given its characteristics, or a logistic regression to predict whether someone is infected or not.

But why use only one model? Would it not be more interesting to use several models to build a more powerful one?

The answer is indeed yes: it is often more interesting to do so, and combinations of models are currently among the best-performing methods on many tasks.

But how can we create such a combination of models?

A naive rule Let us imagine that we want to create T models using a sample $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ of size m. We can train a hypothesis h_t, for t from 1 to T, using the same training sample S for each t.

Then, we can combine the different hypotheses into a single one, denoted by H_T, by averaging them to take our final decision:

- for a regression task, the predicted value is the mean of the predictions made by the hypotheses h_t, *i.e.*

$$H_T(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^{T} h_t(\mathbf{x}).$$

- for a (binary) classification task, we can apply the same rule. However, instead of taking the mean value as the output of the combined classifier, we take the sign of this mean value, *i.e.*

$$H_T(\mathbf{x}) = \text{sign}\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^{T} h_t(\mathbf{x})\right).$$

  When the hypotheses h_t return a value in $\{-1, 1\}$, the hypothesis H_T can then be seen as a majority vote with equal weights. On the other hand, if the hypotheses h_t return real values, we can interpret H_T as a weighted majority vote, where the weight of each vote is given by the confidence $|h_t(\mathbf{x})|$ of the hypothesis.

Although this rule is simple, it is not very useful in practice. Indeed, if the learning problems we solve are convex, the hypotheses h_t are very likely to be (almost) identical when we use the same training set each time.

Varying the hyper-parameters One could then be tempted to diversify the hypotheses by imposing different hyper-parameter values, *e.g.* one could choose T different hyper-parameter values in order to obtain T different models.

Again, this solution is not satisfactory. It may even lead to hypotheses with a low predictive power. Moreover, such a process would conflict with the cross-validation procedure presented earlier, which is precisely used to optimize the values of these hyper-parameters.

We will see that, even if our algorithm does not depend on hyper-parameters, it is possible to improve it using a single training set S. The two main methods to do so are known as **Bagging** and **Boosting**. They act differently on the performance of algorithms, or more precisely on the different components of their error. We will also present a third, more general, method, which consists in learning how to combine several algorithms. But before presenting these approaches, let us motivate the use of several models.

A theoretical analysis We now explain why it is interesting to combine several models. To do so, let us consider data $(\mathbf{x}, y)$ drawn from a distribution $\mathcal{D}$, where $\mathbf{x}$ is the feature vector and y is the response variable, *i.e.* the value to predict.

In a regression setting, we learn a hypothesis h which aims to predict the value y from $\mathbf{x}$. For the sake of simplicity, we suppose that there exists a *true function* r such that $r(\mathbf{x}) = y$ for all $(\mathbf{x}, y) \sim \mathcal{D}$. We also consider a training set S of size m and recall that we aim to learn a set of hypotheses $h_t,\ t = 1, \ldots, T$. Thus, for any instance $\mathbf{x}$ and any hypothesis h_t,

$$h_t(\mathbf{x}) = r(\mathbf{x}) + \varepsilon_t(\mathbf{x}),$$

where $\varepsilon_t(\mathbf{x})$ is the error between the value predicted by h_t and the true value of the function at $\mathbf{x}$.

Keep in mind that, in a regression setting, the error we consider is the MSE, *i.e.* the mean squared error. Thus, the generalization error of a single hypothesis h_t is defined by:

$$\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}\left[(h_t(\mathbf{x}) - r(\mathbf{x}))^2\right] = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}\left[\varepsilon_t(\mathbf{x})^2\right],$$

where $\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}$ denotes the marginal distribution of $\mathbf{x}$. The generalization error of our averaged hypothesis $H_T = \frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^{T} h_t$ is

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}\left[(H_T(\mathbf{x}) - r(\mathbf{x}))^2\right] &= \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}\left[\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^{T} h_t(\mathbf{x}) - r(\mathbf{x})\right)^2\right], \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ applying the definition of } \varepsilon_t \\
&= \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}\left[\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^{T} \varepsilon_t(\mathbf{x})\right)^2\right].
\end{aligned}$$

Let us now suppose that the errors ε_t are centered (with a mean value equal to 0) and uncorrelated. We can rewrite the previous expression as:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}\left[(H_T(\mathbf{x}) - r(\mathbf{x}))^2\right] &= \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}\left[\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^{T} \varepsilon_t(\mathbf{x})\right)^2\right], \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ we expand the square} \\
&= \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}\left[\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t_1=1}^{T} \varepsilon_{t_1}(\mathbf{x})\right)\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t_2=1}^{T} \varepsilon_{t_2}(\mathbf{x})\right)\right], \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ we use the fact that } \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}[\varepsilon_{t_1}(\mathbf{x})\varepsilon_{t_2}(\mathbf{x})] = 0 \text{ for all } t_1 \neq t_2 \\
&= \frac{1}{T^2}\sum_{t=1}^{T} \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}\left[\varepsilon_t(\mathbf{x})^2\right], \\
&= \frac{1}{T}\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^{T} \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}\left[\varepsilon_t(\mathbf{x})^2\right]\right).
\end{aligned}$$

This last equation shows that the generalization error of the combination of hypotheses is equal to the average error of the T hypotheses divided by T.

Note that, in practice, the assumption of uncorrelated errors is essentially wrong, because the hypotheses h_t are learned using similar samples S_t. However, we can still show that the error of the averaged hypothesis is never larger than the average error of the hypotheses h_t. Indeed, the function $u \mapsto u^2$ is convex, so Jensen's inequality gives, for every $\mathbf{x}$,

$$\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^{T}\varepsilon_t(\mathbf{x})\right)^2 \leq \frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^{T}\varepsilon_t(\mathbf{x})^2.$$

Taking the expectation over $\mathbf{x}$, we immediately obtain:

$$\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}\left[(H_T(\mathbf{x}) - r(\mathbf{x}))^2\right] \leq \frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^{T}\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{\mathbf{x}\sim\mathcal{D}_\mathcal{X}}\left[\varepsilon_t(\mathbf{x})^2\right].$$

Let us now go on with a first ensemble approach: the *bagging* procedure.

10.2.1 Bagging and Random Forests

Bagging Bagging Breiman (1996a) is a way to combine models that perform well on the training set, *i.e.* models with a low bias. We have previously seen that we can bound the expected *Bayes regret* by the sum of two terms:

$$\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}[\mathcal{R}(h)] - \mathcal{R}^\star \leq \inf_{g\in\mathcal{H}}\mathcal{R}(g) - \mathcal{R}^\star + 4\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H}).$$

Here, we are more precisely interested in the variance term of the error decomposition. This term tells us how sensitive the algorithm is to variations of the training set: if its value is low, our algorithm is only slightly affected by a change of the training set.

Let us illustrate this with a small example, depicted in Figure 94, for a regression task (the situation is similar for classification tasks). We learn a polynomial regression model of degree 15 on different datasets drawn from the same distribution, each training set being of size 30. In total, we learn 10 different models, which are represented on the left-hand graph. We note that the variance of the models is very large, *i.e.* for the same value on the x-axis, the models return very different values on the y-axis: the models are very sensitive to the training data.

On the other hand, if we average the predictions of the 10 models, we obtain the right-hand graph. We notice that the combined model varies much less around the true regression function. We have therefore succeeded in reducing the variance by combining several models.

With bagging, we wish to exploit the fact that the variance of a combination of models is smaller than the variance of the individual models. Moreover, the combined model retains a strong predictive power, *i.e.* it remains accurate.

In this example, the models are learned on different datasets. But, in practice, we only have one training set S. We therefore have to find a way to create several training sets S_t from this set S. This can be done using the *bootstrap* Efron (1979), a resampling method based on random draws. How does it work in practice?

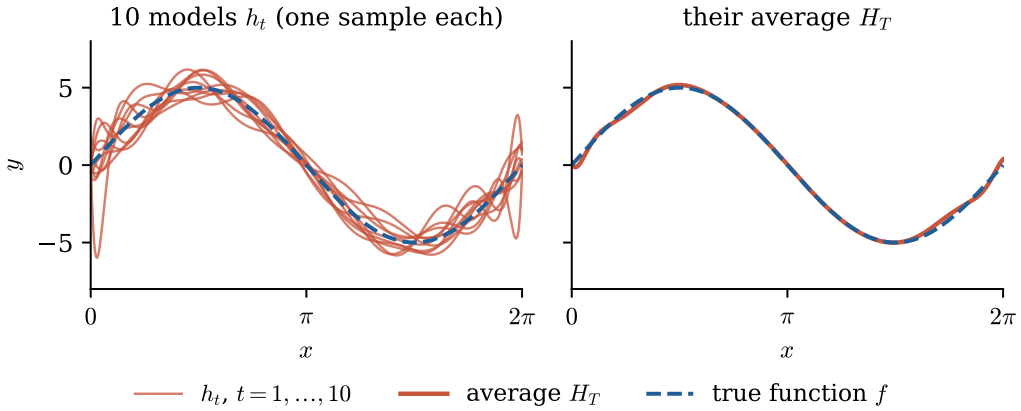


Figure 94: Illustration of the variance reduction obtained by combining models (polynomials of degree 15, regression function $f(x) = 5\sin(x)$, Gaussian noise of variance 1). Left: the 10 models h_t learned on 10 different datasets of size 30 drawn from the same distribution (red), together with the regression function (dashed blue); right: the model H_T obtained by averaging the 10 previous models.

Let us consider a training set S of size m. To create a bootstrap sample S_t of the same size m, we simply draw m examples from S uniformly at random and with replacement, *i.e.* each example of S has the same probability $1/m$ of being drawn at each draw.

With this procedure, the same example may occur several times in the same training set. Thus, in order to minimize its error, the algorithm has to pay more attention to such an example and gives it more importance. This sampling method therefore creates diversity among the learned models. Indeed, since the sets S_t are different, the hypotheses h_t focus on different regions of the data space. Conversely, some examples are never drawn: they are said to be *out-of-bag* for the hypothesis h_t, and we will see below that they can be used to estimate its error for free (see Figure 95).

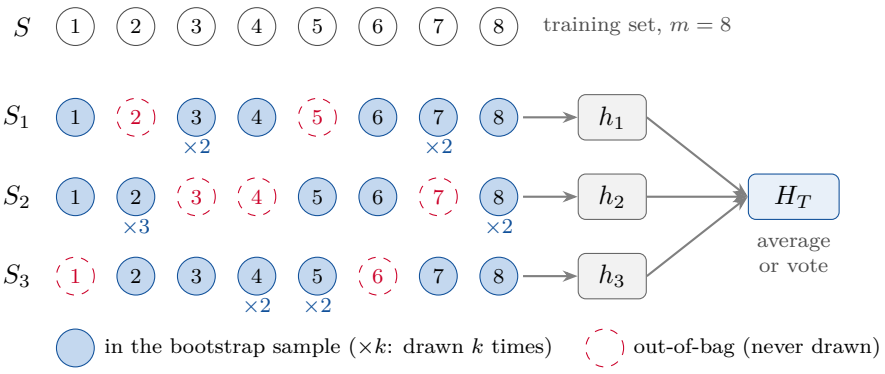


Figure 95: Bagging with $T = 3$ bootstrap samples of size $m = 8$. Each S_t is obtained by 8 draws with replacement from S: some examples are drawn several times, others are never drawn (dashed red circles) and are *out-of-bag* for h_t. For instance, example 2 is out-of-bag for h_1 only, so that its OOB prediction is made by h_1 alone, while the hypotheses h_2 and h_3, which have seen it, are not used.

The bagging procedure is summarized in Algorithm 6. As the reader may guess, *bagging* stands for *bootstrap aggregating*: we generate several samples and hypotheses,

Algorithm 6: Bagging

Inputs : Training set $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$, number of models T
Output: Hypothesis H_T

```
for t = 1 to T do
    create a bootstrap sample S_t of size m from S;
    learn a hypothesis h_t using S_t;
set H_T = (1/T) Σ_{t=1}^T h_t (or its sign, or a majority vote, for classification);
```

and then aggregate their predictions.

Before presenting one of the most famous models based on this process, *the random forest algorithm*, let us see from a theoretical point of view why it is interesting to combine these models.

Theoretical analysis of bagging We can conduct an analysis similar to the one presented in the previous section. Let us denote by $H_T = \frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t$ our bagging hypothesis, used to estimate (for instance) the output y of a regression function, *i.e.* $H_T(\mathbf{x}) \simeq y$. Then, the average error made by the set of hypotheses is equal to:

$$\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\left[\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T(h_t(\mathbf{x})-y)^2\right] = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\left[y^2 - 2y\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t(\mathbf{x}) + \frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t(\mathbf{x})^2\right].$$

Using Jensen's inequality again, we have $\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t(\mathbf{x})\right)^2 \leq \frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t(\mathbf{x})^2$, so that

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\left[\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T(h_t(\mathbf{x})-y)^2\right] &\geq \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\left[y^2 - 2y\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t(\mathbf{x}) + \left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t(\mathbf{x})\right)^2\right], \\
&= \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\left[\left(y - \frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t(\mathbf{x})\right)^2\right], \\
&= \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(\mathbf{x},y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\left[(y - H_T(\mathbf{x}))^2\right].
\end{aligned}$$

This last inequality shows that the error of the bagging hypothesis is always lower than or equal to the average error of the individual hypotheses.

We can go a little further by studying the potential gain of the bagging hypothesis. This gain is given by the expectation of the difference between the two sides of the inequality

$$\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t(\mathbf{x})\right)^2 \leq \frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t(\mathbf{x})^2,$$

Algorithm 7: Random Forests

Inputs : Training set $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$, number of trees T, a sample size m' and a number of features p'

Output: Hypothesis H_T

for $t = 1$ *to* T **do**
  create a bootstrap sample S_t of size $m' \leq m$ from S;
  build a decision tree h_t on S_t where, at each node, only a random subset of p' features is considered to split the node;
set $H_T = \frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t$ (majority vote of the trees for classification);

that is,

$$\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t(\mathbf{x})^2 - \left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T h_t(\mathbf{x})\right)^2 = \frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^T \left(h_t(\mathbf{x}) - H_T(\mathbf{x})\right)^2,$$

which is the variance (or *ambiguity* Krogh and Vedelsby (1995)) of the predictions of our set of hypotheses h_t at the point $\mathbf{x}$. If this variance is large, then the gain is large. This shows that, to obtain a good bagging hypothesis, it is more interesting to use base hypotheses with a high variance but a low bias, which is exactly the case of **decision trees**. This is why it is interesting to combine them using this procedure, which leads us to the **random forest** algorithm.[17]

Random forests When we introduced decision trees, we said that the size of a tree, *i.e.* its depth, depends on the data: the tree grows until we obtain pure leaves.

If we go back to our error decomposition, (deep) decision trees are thus hypotheses with a low bias (their training error decreases with the depth) but with a high variance: they are very sensitive to the data, and their structure can vary greatly from one training set to another.

In fact, we are in exactly the same situation as in the regression example presented in Figure 94. We therefore combine tree models using bagging, in order to reduce the variance of the trees while preserving their predictive capacities. This combination of trees by bagging gives rise to the random forest algorithm, introduced by Breiman at the beginning of the 21st century Breiman (2001).

The idea is to build several trees on different training sets S_t drawn randomly with replacement from S, *i.e.* using the bootstrap procedure, and to combine the predictions of the different trees. However, the random forest algorithm (presented in Algorithm 7) is in fact more sophisticated than that: it is based on the principle of double sampling, *i.e.* sampling both the examples and the features.

This double sampling creates diversity both at the level of the examples and at the level of the features. Compared to the standard bagging algorithm, note that the bootstrap sample has a size $m' \leq m$ and that the number p' of features considered at each node of a tree is smaller than the dimension d of the data (a common default choice is $p' \simeq \sqrt{d}$ for classification). Note that it is not mandatory to have $m' < m$: it only

[17] Note that a similar study can be conducted in the case of classification, but it is not presented here.

makes the learning procedure faster. From an algorithmic point of view, both kinds of sampling speed up the learning of the trees: there are fewer examples, and the splitting procedure is applied to fewer features.

In a nutshell: why sample the features?

Our analysis of the averaged hypothesis assumed uncorrelated errors, which is far too optimistic for trees grown on bootstrap samples of the same dataset: if a feature is very informative, all the trees split on it first and look alike. If the T hypotheses have the same variance σ^2 at $\mathbf{x}$ and a pairwise correlation $\rho \geq 0$, a direct computation gives (Hastie et al., 2009, Chapter 15)

$$\mathrm{Var}\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^{T} h_t(\mathbf{x})\right) = \rho\,\sigma^2 + \frac{1-\rho}{T}\,\sigma^2.$$

Adding trees only kills the second term: the first one, $\rho\sigma^2$, remains whatever the size of the forest. Drawing a random subset of p' features at each node decorrelates the trees (it decreases ρ), at the price of slightly worse individual trees (a small increase of the bias and of σ^2): this is the whole idea of random forests compared with plain bagging.

The presented algorithm is the simplest version. It is not rare to give different weights to the trees according to their performance: remember, this is our weighted majority vote.

Decision trees and random forests are used in many applications, such as finance, security or the social sciences in general. These algorithms have the advantage of being easy to build. Moreover, the decision of a single tree is easy to understand (explainable AI): you just have to follow the path of the example in the tree. A forest of hundreds of trees is less transparent, but tools such as the feature importance presented below help to interpret it.

Out-of-bag (OOB) error for validation The bootstrap procedure implies that we do not use all the data to learn each hypothesis. More precisely, given a sample S of size m, if every example of S is drawn with the same probability $1/m$, then the probability of never selecting a given example in m draws is equal to $(1-1/m)^m$. When the sample size m is large enough, this quantity tends towards $e^{-1} \simeq 0.37$.

It means that the bagging procedure does not use approximately 37% of the (distinct) examples when learning a base hypothesis: only approximately 63% of them are used. We can wonder how these remaining data can be exploited in the bagging procedure. These examples are called **out-of-bag** (OOB) data. Each example $\mathbf{x}_i$ is out-of-bag for roughly a third of the base hypotheses; we can therefore predict its label using only these hypotheses and compare this prediction with y_i. Averaging these errors over the training set gives the **OOB error**, an almost free estimate of the generalization error, which can be used to tune the hyper-parameters of the model without a separate validation set.

Bagging is thus mainly interesting to

- obtain an ensemble with a lower variance than its base hypotheses;

- train a model with better generalization capacities at a moderate cost, since the base models can be learned in parallel and the OOB error provides a validation for free.

Figure 96 illustrates these properties on a simulated classification problem: a single deep tree over-fits, bagging and random forests quickly improve on it as trees are added, and their test error then reaches a plateau. In particular, adding trees does not lead to over-fitting: increasing T only reduces the Monte Carlo variability of the ensemble, so that T is not a hyper-parameter that needs careful tuning (it is enough to take it large enough).

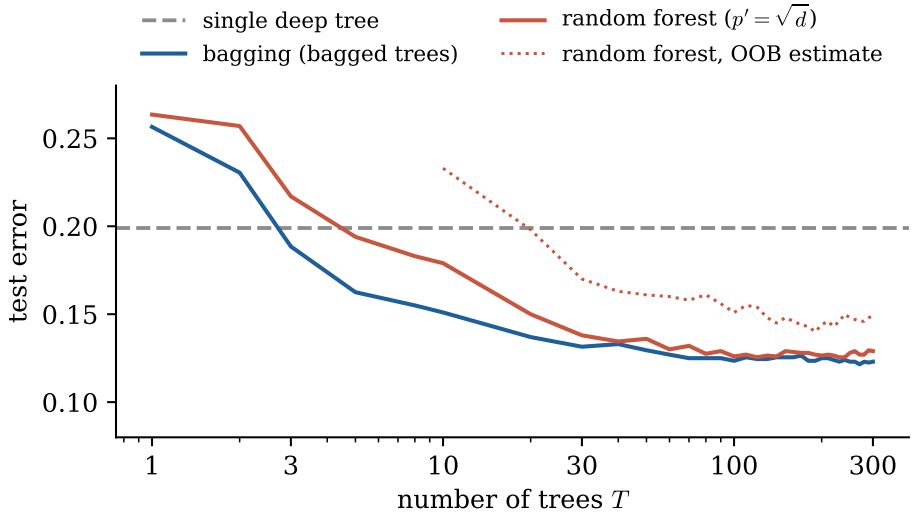


Figure 96: Test error of a single fully grown tree, of bagged trees and of a random forest as a function of the number of trees T (logarithmic scale), on a simulated problem with $d = 20$ features and 1000 training examples. The dotted line is the OOB estimate of the error of the forest: it is computed for free from the training set and follows the test error, slightly pessimistically, since each OOB prediction only uses about a third of the trees.

Pitfall: bagging is not a universal booster Bagging only reduces the variance. Bagging a *stable* learner with a high bias, such as a linear regression or a k-NN classifier with a large k, hardly changes its predictions: all the bootstrap models are almost identical, and the bias is unchanged. Bagging pays off for unstable, low-bias learners such as deep trees or flexible neural networks Breiman (1996a). Note also that the OOB error is only a fair estimate of the generalization error when the examples are *i.i.d.*: with repeated measurements of the same individual, or with time series, an example and its "copies" may fall on both sides of the bootstrap split, exactly as for the cross-validation procedure (Section 11).

As for simple decision trees, random forests can be used for both regression and classification: the main difference lies in the way the trees are built, *i.e.* in the impurity measure (or loss function) used.

Measuring the importance of variables As for the decision trees presented in Section 8.7, we can measure the importance of each feature X^j in the set of trees. This

way of measuring feature importance was introduced together with the random forest algorithm Breiman (2001).

Remember that, to assess the quality of a split of a node N according to a feature X^j in a decision tree, we measure the decrease of entropy $\Delta Ent_N(X^j)$ between before and after the split (we present it for binary decision trees for the sake of simplicity):

$$\Delta Ent_N(X^j) = Ent(\mathbf{p}_N) - Ent(\mathbf{p}_N, X^j),$$

where $Ent(\mathbf{p}_N) = -\sum_{k=1}^{C} p_{N,k} \log_2(p_{N,k})$ and

$$Ent(\mathbf{p}_N, X^j) = -\frac{|N_L|}{|N|} \sum_{k=1}^{C} p_{N_L,k} \log_2(p_{N_L,k}) - \frac{|N_R|}{|N|} \sum_{k=1}^{C} p_{N_R,k} \log_2(p_{N_R,k}).$$

In these expressions, N_L and N_R denote the two children (left and right) obtained after the split of the node N, $|N|$ denotes the number of training examples reaching the node N, and $p_{N,k}$ is the proportion of examples of class k in the node N.

To measure the importance Imp^j of the variable X^j, we sum the decreases $\Delta Ent_N(X^j)$ over the nodes N that are split using X^j, each decrease being weighted by the proportion of training examples reaching the node, and we average over the trees:

$$Imp^j = \frac{1}{T} \sum_{t=1}^{T} \sum_{N \in \mathcal{N}_t} \frac{|N|}{m_t} \Delta Ent_N(X^j) \, \mathbb{1}_{\{X^j \text{ is used to split } N\}},$$

where $\mathcal{N}_t$ denotes the set of internal nodes of the t-th tree, m_t the size of the training sample of the t-th tree, and T the total number of trees. The entropy can of course be replaced by any other impurity measure, such as the Gini index: this measure is known as the *mean decrease in impurity*. Note that it is computed on the training data and tends to favor features with many possible split values; the *permutation importance*, also introduced in Breiman (2001) and discussed in Section 11, is a useful complement.

We will see in the next section that there is another way to combine trees (or other classifiers or regressors) of limited capacity, called *weak hypotheses*: the *boosting* procedure.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q10.4. A model has a very small training error and a large test error. Which term of the error decomposition is large, and which ensemble method would you try first?

Q10.5. What fraction of the distinct examples of S appears, on average, in a bootstrap sample of size m, when m is large?

Q10.6. Why does a random forest draw a random subset of the features at each node, rather than just using bootstrap samples?

Q10.7. True or false? "A random forest with 1000 trees over-fits more than the same forest with 100 trees."

10.2.2 Boosting

This section is largely inspired by Chapter 7 of the book *Foundations of Machine Learning* Mohri et al. (2012).

Setting Let us first introduce the definitions of *strong* and *weak* learnability. They are given in the context of classification, where boosting is mainly used, so that we can use the terms classifier and hypothesis interchangeably.

Definition 10.2: Strong Learnability Mohri et al. (2012)

A concept class $\mathcal{C}$ is said to be (strongly) PAC-learnable if there exist an algorithm $\mathcal{A}$ and a polynomial function *poly* such that for any $\varepsilon > 0$ and $\delta > 0$, for all distributions $\mathcal{D}$ over $\mathcal{X}$ and for any target concept $c \in \mathcal{C}$, the following holds for any sample size $m \geq poly(1/\varepsilon, 1/\delta, d, size(c))$:

$$\underset{S \sim \mathcal{D}^m}{\mathbb{P}} \left[\mathcal{R}(h_S) \leq \varepsilon\right] \geq 1 - \delta,$$

where h_S is the hypothesis returned by $\mathcal{A}$ when trained on S. If $\mathcal{A}$ further runs in $poly(1/\varepsilon, 1/\delta, d, size(c))$, then $\mathcal{C}$ is said to be efficiently PAC-learnable.

In this definition, a concept c is a function from $\mathcal{X}$ to $\mathcal{Y}$ that we want to learn. For example, a concept may be the indicator function of the set of points lying inside a given triangle. A concept class, denoted by $\mathcal{C}$, is a set of concepts we may wish to learn, for example the set of (indicator functions of) all triangles in the plane.

According to the previous definition, a concept class $\mathcal{C}$ is PAC-learnable if the hypothesis returned by the algorithm after observing a number of points polynomial in $1/\varepsilon$ and $1/\delta$ is approximately correct (its error is at most ε) with high probability (at least $1 - \delta$).

Definition 10.3: Weak Learnability Mohri et al. (2012)

A concept class $\mathcal{C}$ is said to be weakly PAC-learnable if there exist an algorithm $\mathcal{A}$, a constant $\gamma > 0$ and a polynomial function *poly* such that for any $\delta > 0$, for all distributions $\mathcal{D}$ over $\mathcal{X}$ and for any target concept $c \in \mathcal{C}$, the following holds for any sample size $m \geq poly(1/\delta, d, size(c))$:

$$\underset{S \sim \mathcal{D}^m}{\mathbb{P}} \left[\mathcal{R}(h_S) \leq \frac{1}{2} - \gamma\right] \geq 1 - \delta,$$

where h_S is the hypothesis returned by $\mathcal{A}$ when trained on S. When such an algorithm exists, it is called a weak learning algorithm, a weak learner or a base classifier.

The idea is quite similar to that of strong learners. The difference between the two definitions lies in the required error of the hypothesis h_S. In the first one, we require the classifier to achieve an error of at most ε, for any $\varepsilon > 0$, given a sufficiently large

sample. In the second one, we just want the classifier to be slightly better (by a margin $\gamma > 0$) than random guessing.

We have already met strong classifiers, such as deep decision trees or over-parameterized neural networks. Weak classifiers are also naturally present in the literature, *e.g.* small decision trees with a depth of one or two (decision stumps), or linear classifiers such as a linear SVM when the problem is not linearly separable.

Whereas bagging combines strong classifiers (with a low bias and a high variance), boosting combines weak ones. It tries to combine them in order to build a strong classifier, but in a way that is different from the bagging procedure. Instead of building bootstrap samples, boosting modifies the distribution of the data in order to build a sequence of classifiers $(h_t)_{t\in\mathbb{N}}$, where h_{t+1} tries to correct the errors made by the previous classifiers.

> **Historical note** Boosting was born from a purely theoretical question raised by Kearns and Valiant at the end of the 1980s Kearns and Valiant (1994): are weak and strong learnability equivalent? In other words, can a learner that is only slightly better than random guessing always be "boosted" into an arbitrarily accurate one? Schapire answered positively in 1990 with a first, rather impractical, recursive construction Schapire (1990). A few years later, Freund and Schapire proposed AdaBoost Freund and Schapire (1997), simple and adaptive (it does not need to know the edge γ in advance), which turned out to be remarkably efficient in practice. The statistical interpretation of boosting as the minimization of a loss by a greedy, stage-wise procedure Friedman et al. (2000); Friedman (2001) then opened the way to gradient boosting (Section 10.3). A complete account is given in the book Schapire and Freund (2012).

AdaBoost A well-known boosting algorithm is *AdaBoost* Freund and Schapire (1999), which iteratively focuses on the examples that are difficult to classify. The algorithm is presented in Algorithm 8, and an illustration is provided in Figure 97. Here, the labels are in $\{-1, +1\}$ and the base classifiers h_t take their values in $\{-1, +1\}$.

Let us say a few words about this algorithm before analyzing it.

At round t, the i-th training example has the weight $w_i^{(t)}$. For $t = 1$, all the training examples have the same weight, equal to $1/m$. A hypothesis h_t is learned, and we compute its weighted classification error ε_t:

$$\varepsilon_t = \sum_{i=1}^{m} w_i^{(t)} \mathbb{1}_{\{h_t(\mathbf{x}_i) y_i < 0\}}.$$

Using this value, we compute the *weight* α_t of the learned classifier:

$$\alpha_t = \frac{1}{2} \ln\left(\frac{1-\varepsilon_t}{\varepsilon_t}\right).$$

Keep in mind that the idea is to learn a hypothesis H_T which is the sign of a linear combination of the weak learners h_t. The better the weak learner (the smaller ε_t), the larger its weight; note that $\alpha_t > 0$ as soon as $\varepsilon_t < 1/2$.

Algorithm 8: AdaBoost

Inputs : Training set $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ with $y_i \in \{-1, +1\}$, number of rounds T
Output: Hypothesis H_T

for $i = 1$ *to* m **do**
  set the weight of the i-th example to $w_i^{(1)} = 1/m$;
for $t = 1$ *to* T **do**
  learn a base classifier h_t using S weighted by $\mathbf{w}^{(t)}$;
  compute the weighted error $\varepsilon_t = \sum_{i=1}^m w_i^{(t)} \mathbb{1}_{\{h_t(\mathbf{x}_i) y_i < 0\}}$ of h_t ; `// we assume` $\varepsilon_t < 1/2$
  set $\alpha_t = \frac{1}{2} \ln\left(\frac{1-\varepsilon_t}{\varepsilon_t}\right)$;
  set $Z_t = \sum_{i=1}^m w_i^{(t)} \exp(-\alpha_t y_i h_t(\mathbf{x}_i)) = 2\sqrt{\varepsilon_t(1-\varepsilon_t)}$;
  for $i = 1$ *to* m **do**
    set $w_i^{(t+1)} = w_i^{(t)} \frac{\exp(-\alpha_t y_i h_t(\mathbf{x}_i))}{Z_t}$;
set $f_T = \sum_{t=1}^T \alpha_t h_t$ and $H_T = \operatorname{sign}(f_T)$;

The rest of the procedure consists in finding a good reweighting of the training examples such that, during the next round, the new classifier h_{t+1} is able to correct the mistakes made by the classifier h_t. This is done using the following update rule:

$$w_i^{(t+1)} = w_i^{(t)} \frac{\exp(-\alpha_t y_i h_t(\mathbf{x}_i))}{Z_t},$$

where Z_t is a normalization factor which ensures that the weights sum to 1. We will show (see the proof below) that $Z_t = 2\sqrt{\varepsilon_t(1-\varepsilon_t)}$. Since $\alpha_t > 0$, the weights of the misclassified examples ($y_i h_t(\mathbf{x}_i) = -1$) are multiplied by e^{α_t}/Z_t, whereas those of the correctly classified examples are multiplied by $e^{-\alpha_t}/Z_t$. This reweighting thus gives more weight to the examples misclassified by h_t and, conversely, decreases the weight of the examples that are correctly classified.

Proposition 10.3: Empirical error bound of AdaBoost

The empirical error of the classifier returned by AdaBoost satisfies:

$$\mathcal{R}_S(H_T) \leq \exp\left[-2\sum_{t=1}^T \left(\frac{1}{2} - \varepsilon_t\right)^2\right].$$

Furthermore, if there exists $\gamma > 0$ such that, for all $t \in [\![1, T]\!]$, $\gamma \leq \frac{1}{2} - \varepsilon_t$, then:

$$\mathcal{R}_S(H_T) \leq \exp(-2\gamma^2 T).$$

Proof. First, we recall that the exponential function is an upper bound of the 0-1 loss, *i.e.* for any real-valued function f,

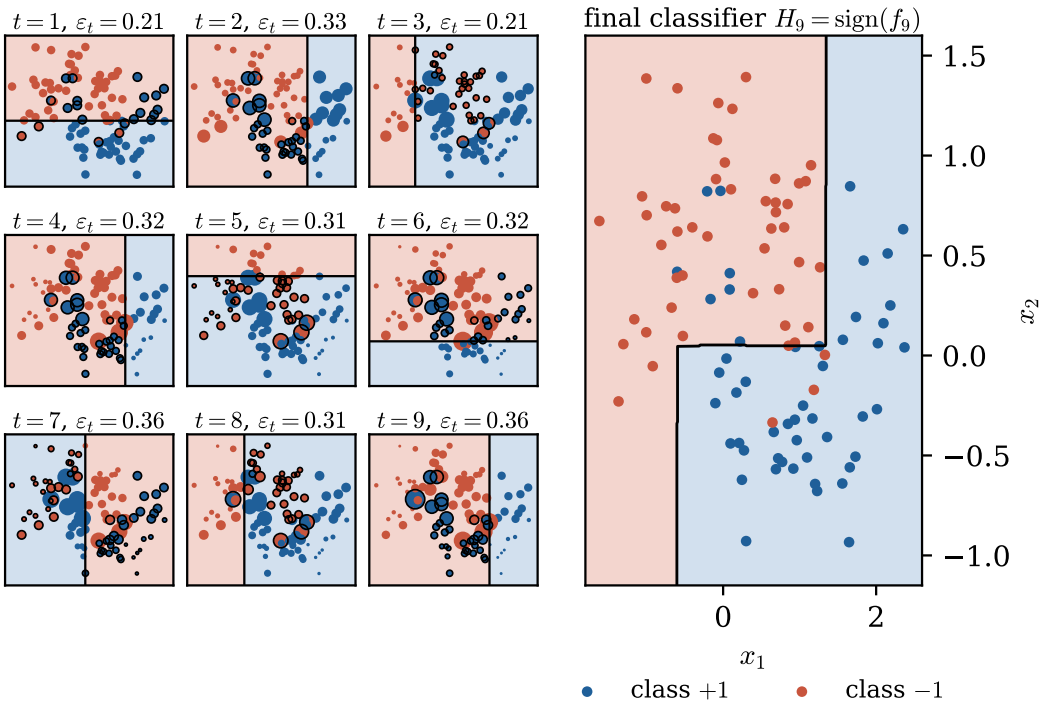


Figure 97: The first nine rounds of AdaBoost with decision stumps on a binary classification task ($m = 100$ points, class $+1$ in blue, class -1 in red). Left: the stump h_t learned at round t (the background color is its prediction) and its weighted error ε_t; the area of each point is proportional to its weight $w_i^{(t)}$, and the points misclassified by h_t are circled in black: their weights increase at the next round. Right: the decision boundary of the final classifier $H_9 = \mathrm{sign}\left(\sum_{t=1}^{9} \alpha_t h_t\right)$, which is no longer a stump (training error 0.10).

$$\forall (\mathbf{x}, y), \quad \mathbb{1}_{\{yf(\mathbf{x}) \leq 0\}} \leq \exp(-yf(\mathbf{x})).$$

We can then upper bound the empirical risk $\mathcal{R}_S(H_T)$, where $H_T = \mathrm{sign}(f_T)$ with $f_T = \sum_{t=1}^{T} \alpha_t h_t$:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{R}_S(H_T) &\leq \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \mathbb{1}_{\{y_i f_T(\mathbf{x}_i) \leq 0\}}, \\ &\leq \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \exp(-y_i f_T(\mathbf{x}_i)). \end{aligned}$$

We can now express this last sum using the normalization factors Z_t and the weights $w_i^{(T+1)}$. Indeed, we have:

$$w_i^{(t+1)} = w_i^{(t)} \frac{\exp(-\alpha_t y_i h_t(\mathbf{x}_i))}{Z_t},$$

$$\downarrow \text{ by induction, using } w_i^{(1)} = 1/m$$

$$= \frac{1}{m} \times \frac{\exp\left(-y_i \sum_{s=1}^{t} \alpha_s h_s(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)}{\prod_{s=1}^{t} Z_s}.$$

Thus, the empirical risk can be upper bounded as follows:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathcal{R}_S(H_T) &\leq \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \exp(-y_i f_T(\mathbf{x}_i)), \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ using the definition of } f_T \text{ and the previous relation with } t = T \\
&= \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \left(m \prod_{t=1}^{T} Z_t \right) w_i^{(T+1)}, \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ the weights } w_i^{(T+1)} \text{ sum to 1} \\
&= \prod_{t=1}^{T} Z_t.
\end{aligned}$$

We now focus on the normalization factor and show how it can be written as a function of the weighted classification error ε_t for all $t \in [\![1, T]\!]$:

$$\begin{aligned}
Z_t &= \sum_{i=1}^{m} w_i^{(t)} \exp(-\alpha_t y_i h_t(\mathbf{x}_i)), \\
&= \sum_{i:y_i h_t(\mathbf{x}_i)=1} w_i^{(t)} \exp(-\alpha_t) + \sum_{i:y_i h_t(\mathbf{x}_i)=-1} w_i^{(t)} \exp(\alpha_t), \\
&= (1 - \varepsilon_t) \exp(-\alpha_t) + \varepsilon_t \exp(\alpha_t), \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ using the value of } \alpha_t \\
&= (1 - \varepsilon_t) \sqrt{\frac{\varepsilon_t}{1 - \varepsilon_t}} + \varepsilon_t \sqrt{\frac{1 - \varepsilon_t}{\varepsilon_t}}, \\
&= 2\sqrt{\varepsilon_t (1 - \varepsilon_t)}.
\end{aligned}$$

As the empirical risk $\mathcal{R}_S(H_T)$ is upper bounded by the product of the normalization factors, we directly obtain:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathcal{R}_S(H_T) &\leq \prod_{t=1}^{T} Z_t, \\
&= \prod_{t=1}^{T} 2\sqrt{\varepsilon_t (1 - \varepsilon_t)}, \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ using } 4\varepsilon_t(1 - \varepsilon_t) = 1 - 4\left(\frac{1}{2} - \varepsilon_t\right)^2 \\
&= \prod_{t=1}^{T} \sqrt{1 - 4\left(\frac{1}{2} - \varepsilon_t\right)^2}, \\
&\quad \downarrow \text{ for all } x \in \mathbb{R},\ 1 - x \leq \exp(-x)
\end{aligned}$$

$$\leq \prod_{t=1}^{T} \exp\left[-2\left(\frac{1}{2}-\varepsilon_t\right)^2\right],$$

$$\downarrow \text{ property of the exponential}$$

$$= \exp\left[-2\sum_{t=1}^{T}\left(\frac{1}{2}-\varepsilon_t\right)^2\right].$$

This ends the first part of the proof. Furthermore, if for all t, $\gamma \leq \frac{1}{2} - \varepsilon_t$, then:

$$\mathcal{R}_S(H_T) \leq \exp\left[-2\sum_{t=1}^{T}\left(\frac{1}{2}-\varepsilon_t\right)^2\right],$$

$$\downarrow \text{ using the assumption}$$

$$\leq \exp\left[-2\sum_{t=1}^{T}\gamma^2\right],$$

$$= \exp\left[-2T\gamma^2\right].$$

□

In other words, as soon as each weak learner is slightly better than random guessing, the training error of AdaBoost decreases exponentially fast with the number of rounds. Since the training error of H_T is a multiple of $1/m$, it even becomes exactly 0 as soon as the bound is smaller than $1/m$, *i.e.* after at most $\lfloor \ln(m)/(2\gamma^2) \rfloor + 1$ rounds. This behavior is illustrated in Figure 98.

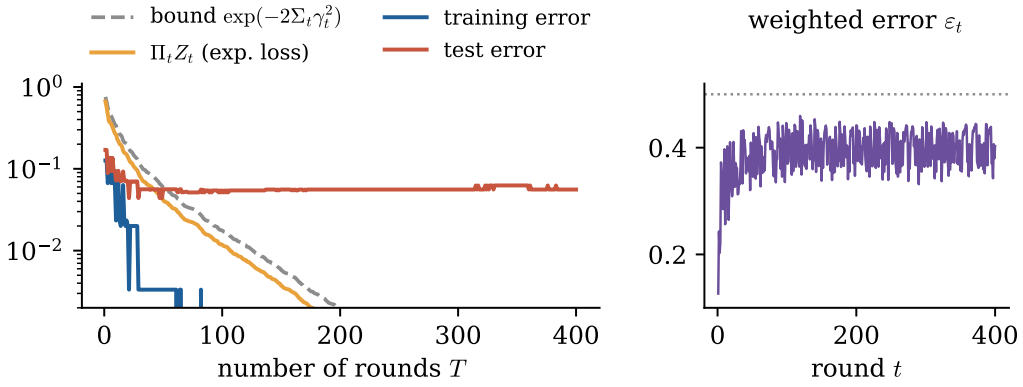


Figure 98: AdaBoost with decision stumps on the two-moons dataset ($m = 300$ training examples). Left (logarithmic scale): the training error is always below the empirical exponential loss $\prod_t Z_t = \frac{1}{m}\sum_i e^{-y_i f_T(\mathbf{x}_i)}$, itself below the bound of Proposition 10.3 with $\gamma_t = \frac{1}{2} - \varepsilon_t$; the training error reaches 0 in less than 100 rounds (and then disappears from the plot), whereas the test error stabilizes. Right: the weighted errors ε_t of the stumps increase, because the examples that are still misclassified are the hardest ones, but they remain below 1/2.

Remark Proposition 10.3 only deals with the *training* error. Surprisingly, the test error of AdaBoost often keeps decreasing, or at least does not increase, long after the training error has reached 0 (in the left panel of Figure 98, the test

error does not increase during the 300 rounds that follow): the complexity of f_T seems to grow with T, but the generalization does not degrade. The explanation proposed by Schapire *et al.* Schapire et al. (1998) is that AdaBoost keeps increasing the *margins* $y_i f_T(\mathbf{x}_i)/\sum_t \alpha_t$ of the training examples, which leads to generalization bounds independent of T.

Pitfall: AdaBoost and label noise The weight of a misclassified example is multiplied by $e^{\alpha_t} > 1$ at each round. A mislabeled example, which the weak learners consistently "misclassify", thus sees its weight grow exponentially, and AdaBoost ends up spending most of its effort on outliers. This is a direct consequence of the exponential loss, which penalizes large negative margins much more than the logistic loss does. On noisy data, prefer gradient boosting with the logistic loss, early stopping, or a small learning rate (Section 10.3).

We did not explain earlier where the expression of α_t comes from, but the answer lies in the previous proof. Indeed, α_t is chosen to minimize the upper bound $\prod_t Z_t$ of the empirical error. Thus, it is chosen to minimize the function:

$$\varphi : \alpha \mapsto (1-\varepsilon_t)\exp(-\alpha) + \varepsilon_t \exp(\alpha).$$

This function is (strictly) convex as a positive combination of two (strictly) convex functions. So it reaches its minimum at a single value α_t, which satisfies the first-order optimality condition (Euler's equation):

$$\begin{aligned}
\varphi'(\alpha_t) &= 0, \\
-(1-\varepsilon_t)\exp(-\alpha_t) + \varepsilon_t \exp(\alpha_t) &= 0, \\
(1-\varepsilon_t)\exp(-\alpha_t) &= \varepsilon_t \exp(\alpha_t), \\
\frac{1-\varepsilon_t}{\varepsilon_t} &= \exp(2\alpha_t), \\
\alpha_t &= \frac{1}{2}\ln\left(\frac{1-\varepsilon_t}{\varepsilon_t}\right).
\end{aligned}$$

Note also that the analysis extends to base hypotheses h_t taking real values in the range $[-1,+1]$: in this case, ε_t is replaced by $\frac{1}{2}\left(1 - \sum_{i=1}^m w_i^{(t)} y_i h_t(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)$, and the expression of Z_t becomes an upper bound obtained by convexity of the exponential.

Link with gradient descent We can draw a link between AdaBoost and a gradient descent algorithm called *coordinate descent*: we just have to change our point of view on the algorithm.

Let us consider a (finite) family of base classifiers $h_1, h_2, \ldots, h_N$ and a function $f_{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}$ which depends on a vector $\boldsymbol{\alpha} \in \mathbb{R}^N$ and is defined by

$$f_{\boldsymbol{\alpha}} = \sum_{l=1}^{N} \alpha_l h_l.$$

Let us also consider a set of m labeled examples $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$. We aim to solve the following optimization problem:

$$\min_{\boldsymbol{\alpha}\in\mathbb{R}^N} F(\boldsymbol{\alpha}) = \min_{\boldsymbol{\alpha}\in\mathbb{R}^N} \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \exp(-y_i f_{\boldsymbol{\alpha}}(\mathbf{x}_i)) = \min_{\boldsymbol{\alpha}\in\mathbb{R}^N} \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m \exp\left(-y_i \sum_{l=1}^N \alpha_l h_l(\mathbf{x}_i)\right).$$

We see that the objective function F is exactly the upper bound of the empirical risk of $\text{sign}(f_{\boldsymbol{\alpha}})$ used in the proof above. F is also a convex function of $\boldsymbol{\alpha}$, as a sum of convex functions.

The idea of coordinate descent is to update only one coordinate of the vector we are looking for at each iteration of the descent. More precisely, starting from a vector $\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)}$ at a given iteration k of the descent,

$$\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)} = \left(\alpha_1^{(k-1)}, \alpha_2^{(k-1)}, \ldots, \alpha_l^{(k-1)}, \ldots, \alpha_N^{(k-1)}\right),$$

we change only one coordinate of this vector, say the l-th one, to get the new vector $\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k)}$, so that

$$\forall j \neq l, \quad \alpha_j^{(k)} = \alpha_j^{(k-1)} \quad \text{and} \quad \alpha_l^{(k)} = \alpha_l^{(k-1)} + \rho, \quad \textit{i.e.} \quad \boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k)} = \boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)} + \rho\, \mathbf{e}_l,$$

where ρ is a step size and $\mathbf{e}_l$ is the l-th vector of the canonical basis, *i.e.* the direction (or coordinate) that is updated.

Let us consider the function g_k defined at iteration k by $g_k = \sum_{l=1}^N \alpha_l^{(k)} h_l$. Then, the coordinate descent update coincides with the update $g_k = g_{k-1} + \rho h_l$. Thus, since both algorithms start with $g_0 = 0$, to show that AdaBoost coincides with coordinate descent applied to F, it suffices to show that, at every iteration k, coordinate descent selects the same base classifier and the same step ρ as AdaBoost, assuming that the weak learner of AdaBoost returns the classifier of the family with the smallest weighted error.

We assume by induction that this holds up to iteration $k-1$, which implies the equality $g_{k-1} = f_{k-1}$ (the function f built by AdaBoost after $k-1$ rounds), and we show that it also holds at iteration k.

At each iteration k, we select the steepest descent direction, that is, the direction $\mathbf{e}_l$ along which the directional derivative of the objective function F is the most negative, and we select the best step along that direction, that is, we choose ρ to minimize $F(\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)} + \rho \mathbf{e}_l)$.

We first need to introduce quantities similar to those of the boosting algorithm. We denote by $\tilde{w}_i^{(k)}$ the weight of the i-th example at iteration k:

$$\tilde{w}_i^{(k)} = \frac{\exp\left(-y_i \sum_{l=1}^N \alpha_l^{(k-1)} h_l(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)}{\tilde{Z}_k} = \frac{\exp\left(-y_i g_{k-1}(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)}{\tilde{Z}_k},$$

where $\tilde{Z}_k = \sum_{i=1}^m \exp\left(-y_i g_{k-1}(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)$ is a normalization factor, such that the weights sum to 1. Since $g_{k-1} = f_{k-1}$, the relation obtained in the proof of Proposition 10.3 shows that $\mathbf{w}^{(k)} = \tilde{\mathbf{w}}^{(k)}$.

We also define the weighted error of a base classifier h_l with respect to the distribution $\tilde{\mathbf{w}}^{(k)}$ as:

$$\tilde{\varepsilon}_l^{(k)} = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{i\sim\tilde{\mathbf{w}}^{(k)}}\left[\mathbb{1}_{\{y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i)<0\}}\right] = \sum_{i=1}^{m} \tilde{w}_i^{(k)} \mathbb{1}_{\{y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i)<0\}}.$$

The directional derivative of F at $\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)}$ along $\mathbf{e}_l$ is denoted by $F'(\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)}, \mathbf{e}_l)$ and defined by

$$F'(\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)}, \mathbf{e}_l) = \lim_{\rho\to 0} \frac{F(\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)} + \rho\mathbf{e}_l) - F(\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)})}{\rho}.$$

Since $F(\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)} + \rho\mathbf{e}_l) = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m} \exp\left(-y_i \sum_{j=1}^{N} \alpha_j^{(k-1)} h_j(\mathbf{x}_i) - \rho y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)$, the directional derivative can be expressed as:

$$\begin{aligned}
F'(\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)}, \mathbf{e}_l) =& -\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m} y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i) \exp\left(-y_i \sum_{j=1}^{N} \alpha_j^{(k-1)} h_j(\mathbf{x}_i)\right), \\
&\downarrow \text{ we use the relation between } \tilde{Z}_k \text{ and the weights } \tilde{w}_i^{(k)} \\
=& -\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m} y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i) \tilde{w}_i^{(k)} \tilde{Z}_k, \\
&\downarrow \text{ we split the sum according to the sign of } y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i) \\
=& -\frac{\tilde{Z}_k}{m}\left[\sum_{i:y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i)=1} \tilde{w}_i^{(k)} - \sum_{i:y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i)=-1} \tilde{w}_i^{(k)}\right], \\
&\downarrow \text{ using the definition of the error} \\
=& -\frac{\tilde{Z}_k}{m}\left[1 - \tilde{\varepsilon}_l^{(k)} - \tilde{\varepsilon}_l^{(k)}\right], \\
=& (2\tilde{\varepsilon}_l^{(k)} - 1)\frac{\tilde{Z}_k}{m}.
\end{aligned}$$

The steepest descent direction is therefore the one that minimizes $\tilde{\varepsilon}_l^{(k)}$. So the base classifier h_l selected at iteration k is the one with the smallest weighted error on the sample S with respect to the distribution $\tilde{\mathbf{w}}^{(k)} = \mathbf{w}^{(k)}$. This is exactly the choice made by AdaBoost at the k-th round.

It remains to see how the step size is computed along the chosen direction $\mathbf{e}_l$. The step size ρ is the solution of the following convex optimization problem:

$$\min_{\rho\in\mathbb{R}} F(\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)} + \rho\mathbf{e}_l).$$

To minimize this quantity, it is enough to look for the value of ρ at which its derivative vanishes:

$$\frac{d}{d\rho} F(\boldsymbol{\alpha}^{(k-1)} + \rho\mathbf{e}_l) = 0,$$

$$
\begin{aligned}
-\frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m} y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i) \exp\left(-y_i \sum_{j=1}^{N} \alpha_j^{(k-1)} h_j(\mathbf{x}_i) - \rho y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i)\right) &= 0, \\
\sum_{i=1}^{m} y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i) \tilde{w}_i^{(k)} \tilde{Z}_k \exp\left(-\rho y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i)\right) &= 0, \\
\sum_{i=1}^{m} y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i) \tilde{w}_i^{(k)} \exp\left(-\rho y_i h_l(\mathbf{x}_i)\right) &= 0, \\
(1-\tilde{\varepsilon}_l^{(k)}) \exp(-\rho) - \tilde{\varepsilon}_l^{(k)} \exp(\rho) &= 0, \\
\rho &= \frac{1}{2} \ln\left(\frac{1-\tilde{\varepsilon}_l^{(k)}}{\tilde{\varepsilon}_l^{(k)}}\right).
\end{aligned}
$$

This proves that the step size chosen by coordinate descent coincides with the weight α_k assigned by AdaBoost to the classifier chosen at the k-th round. Thus, coordinate descent applied to the exponential objective F coincides exactly with AdaBoost, and F can be viewed as the objective function that AdaBoost seeks to minimize.

10.2.3 Stacking

Stacked generalization, or *stacking* Wolpert (1992); Džeroski and Ženko (2004), is another ensemble method, which works rather differently from bagging and boosting. Although the idea is still to combine models in order to improve performance, stacking learns a meta-model on top of several sub-models.

The aim of this ensemble method is to learn how different models, with different predictive capabilities, can be optimally combined. It differs from the two previous procedures in two ways: (i) the models can all be different (for instance, we can combine an SVM with a decision tree) and they are learned using the same dataset; (ii) the weights of the models are not learned iteratively. All the models are learned independently, and a meta-model is then used to learn the optimal way to combine the base learners.

Its architecture involves at least two different learners, and the procedure consists of two steps:

1. learn a set of base learners on the training data;
2. use the predictions made by each base learner as new features for the meta-model, which then learns a good combination of these predictions.

As the reader may have noticed, while each sub-model h_t works with the initial features $\mathbf{x}$, the meta-model works with the predictions of the sub-models, *i.e.* the features of the meta-model are $(h_1(\mathbf{x}), h_2(\mathbf{x}), \ldots, h_T(\mathbf{x}))$. Note that we do not specify the output of h_t: it can be a real value, a binary output, a probability, *etc.*

At first glance, it seems rather simple to learn this ensemble model: all we have to do is train our sub-models on the training data and then reuse these data to learn our meta-model. However, this method is not the best in terms of generalization performance. Indeed, by using the same data to learn our sub-models and our meta-model, we increase the risk of over-fitting: the meta-model would learn to trust the sub-models that best memorize the training data. As a result, the data we give to the meta-model

should not be the data used to learn the sub-models, but rather data used to validate them, *i.e.* a held-out validation set, resulting in a *training-validation* procedure.

We can go a little further and learn what is called a **Super Learner** Van der Laan et al. (2007), which can be seen as a generalization of stacking relying on a k-fold cross-validation procedure, as depicted in Figure 99.[18]

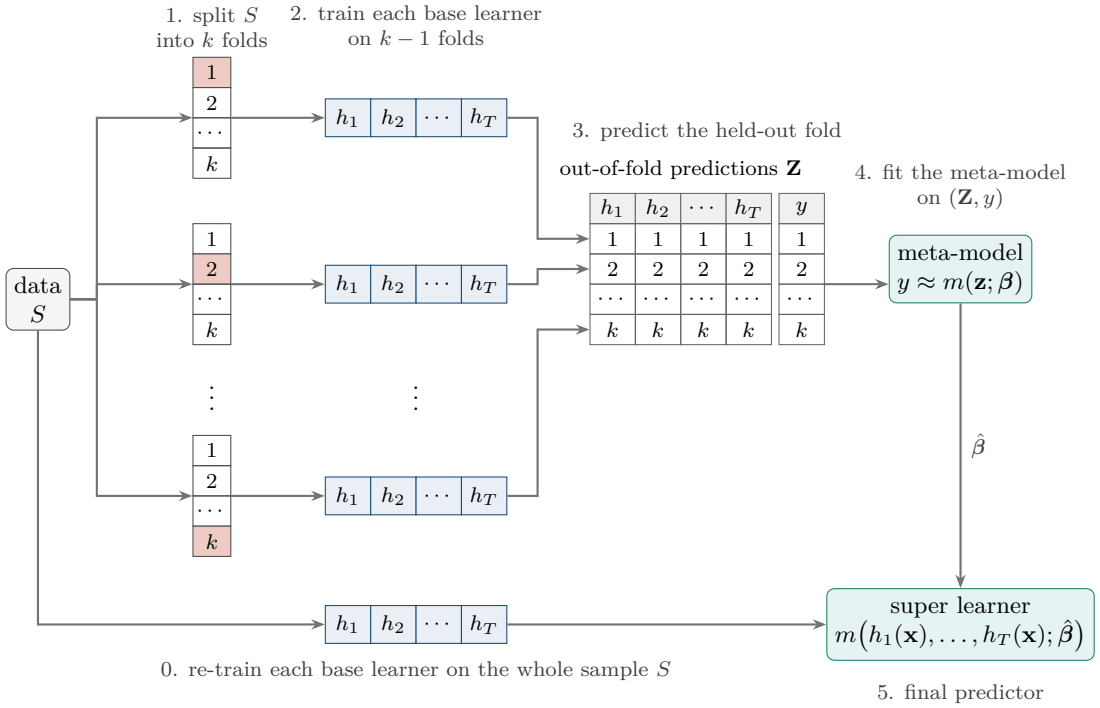


Figure 99: The Super Learner: stacking with a k-fold cross-validation procedure. Each base learner $h_1, \ldots, h_T$ is trained k times, each time on $k-1$ folds, and predicts the held-out fold (shaded). These out-of-fold predictions form a new design matrix $\mathbf{Z}$, on which the meta-model $m(\mathbf{z}; \boldsymbol{\beta})$ is fitted. The final predictor combines, with the learned parameters $\hat{\boldsymbol{\beta}}$, the base learners re-trained on the whole sample.

The procedure can be described as follows:

1. Split the training data into k folds (as in a k-fold cross-validation procedure).
2. Train each base learner on $k-1$ folds and compute its predictions on the remaining fold.
3. Repeat the previous step, changing the *validation* fold each time, until every fold has been used as the *validation* fold. Every training example then has a prediction from each base learner, made by a model that has not seen it: these *out-of-fold* predictions form the new representation of the data.
4. Use this new representation of the data to learn the parameters of the meta-model (the base learners are then usually re-trained on the whole training set).
5. Evaluate the performance of the whole model on the test data.

A legitimate question concerns the classic cross-validation procedure. How can we use our data not only to learn our model, but also to ensure that we have the best base

[18] This figure is adapted from slide 17 of the Super Learner course of the van der Laan lab.

learners, and therefore a good ensemble model? How can we tune the hyper-parameters of our base learners? Is this really necessary?

We leave these questions open, so that the reader can draw on the previous explanations to discuss possible answers (see also Section 11). We end our presentation of ensemble methods with the one that is certainly the best known and most widely used in industrial practice: *gradient boosting*.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q10.8. In AdaBoost, what happens to the weight α_t when $\varepsilon_t = 1/2$? And to the weights of the examples misclassified by h_t when $\varepsilon_t < 1/2$?

Q10.9. The weak learner of AdaBoost returns a classifier h_t with a weighted error $\varepsilon_t = 0.8$. Is it useless? What does AdaBoost do with it?

Q10.10. Why should the meta-model of a stacking procedure not be trained on the predictions of the base learners on their own training data?

10.3 Gradient Boosting

The AdaBoost algorithm (see Section 10.2.2) is based on the exponential loss. However, this loss is not suited to all settings, and it is sometimes better to use other losses, depending on the model we want to learn or on the application. This motivation leads us to a more general boosting algorithm, *gradient boosting* Friedman (2001).

Generalities Unlike the AdaBoost algorithm Freund and Schapire (1999), as usually presented, gradient boosting performs an optimization in the *function* space rather than in the *parameter* space. At each iteration, a weak learner h_t is learned using the *residuals* (or errors) of the linear combination of the previous models. The linear combination H_t at iteration t is defined as follows:

$$H_t = H_{t-1} + \alpha_t h_t, \tag{10.1}$$

where H_{t-1} is the linear combination of the first $t-1$ models and α_t is the weight given to the t-th weak learner. The weak learners are trained on the *pseudo-residuals* r_i of the current model. These pseudo-residuals are given by the negative gradient $-g_t$ of the loss function ℓ with respect to the current prediction $H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i)$:

$$r_i = -g_t(\mathbf{x}_i) = -\left[\frac{\partial \ell(y_i, H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i))}{\partial H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i)}\right].$$

Once the pseudo-residuals r_i are computed, the following optimization problem is solved:

$$(h_t, \alpha_t) = \arg\min_{\alpha, h} \sum_{i=1}^{m} (r_i - \alpha h(\mathbf{x}_i))^2.$$

Finally, the update rule (10.1) is applied. In practice, the weight α_t is often refined by a line search on the loss ℓ itself, as in Algorithm 9, and multiplied by a small *learning rate* (or *shrinkage*) $\nu \in (0, 1]$ to reduce over-fitting.

In a nutshell

Think of a golfer who does not reach the hole in one shot: each new stroke starts from where the ball stopped, and aims at the remaining distance. With the squared loss $\frac{1}{2}(y-H)^2$, the pseudo-residuals are exactly the residuals $y_i - H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i)$: each new weak learner is trained to predict *what the current model still gets wrong*, and is added to it. Figure 100 shows the first three rounds on a one-dimensional regression problem, with decision stumps as weak learners. For other losses, the pseudo-residuals are "generalized residuals": they indicate in which direction, and how strongly, the prediction at each training point should move to decrease the loss.

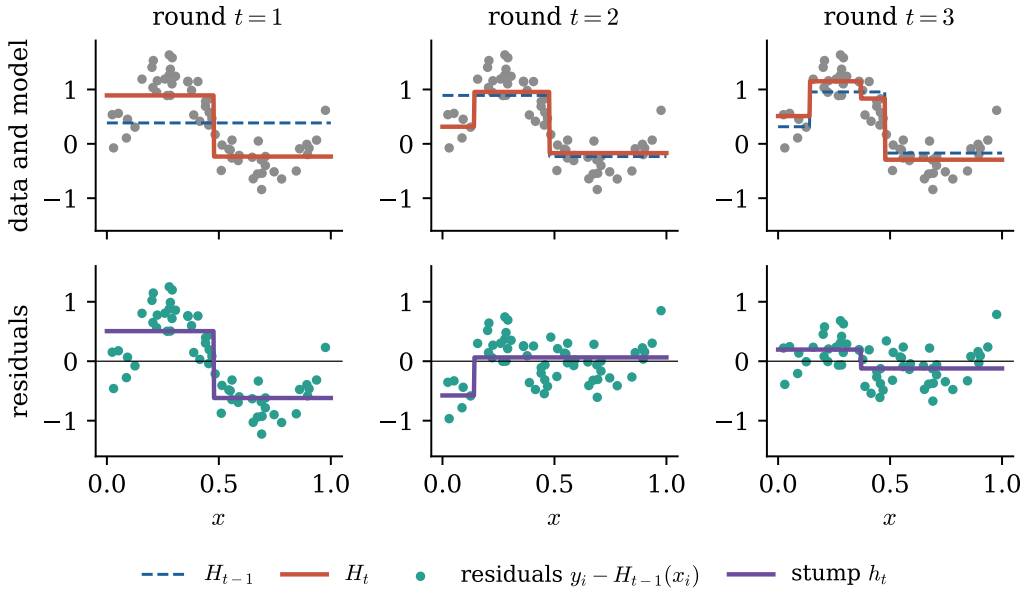


Figure 100: Gradient boosting with the squared loss and decision stumps on a 1D regression problem (H_0 is the mean of the y_i, $\nu = 1$). Top: the model before (H_{t-1}, dashed) and after (H_t, solid) round t. Bottom: the residuals of H_{t-1} and the stump h_t fitted to them by least squares. For the squared loss, the line search gives $\alpha_t = 1$, so that $H_t = H_{t-1} + h_t$; the residuals shrink from one round to the next and the model gets progressively closer to the data.

This algorithm was first developed for classification and regression trees, and most of the work and libraries, such as **XGBoost** Chen and Guestrin (2016), use decision trees as weak learners. To be weak learners, these trees are mainly decision stumps or trees with a small depth. Unlike AdaBoost, gradient boosting makes it possible to use custom losses. The procedure is summarized in Algorithm 9, where the weak learners $h_{\mathbf{a}}$ are parameterized by a vector $\mathbf{a}$.

Example 10.2. Let us compute the pseudo-residuals for two different losses ℓ: the *squared loss* for a regression task, and the *logistic loss* for a classification task.

- Using the squared loss $\ell(y, H) = (y - H)^2$, the pseudo-residuals are defined by:

Algorithm 9: Gradient Boosting Friedman (2001)

Inputs : Training set $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$, number of models T, a loss ℓ
Output: a model $H_T = H_0 + \sum_{t=1}^T \alpha_t h_{\mathbf{a}_t}$

Initial hypothesis: $H_0(\mathbf{x}) = \arg\min_{\rho \in \mathbb{R}} \sum_{i=1}^m \ell(y_i, \rho)$ for all $\mathbf{x}$;
for $t = 1$ *to* T **do**
  compute the pseudo-residuals: $\tilde{y}_i = -\dfrac{\partial \ell(y_i, H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i))}{\partial H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i)}$, $\forall i = 1, \ldots, m$;
  fit the pseudo-residuals to learn the new hypothesis:
  $\mathbf{a}_t = \arg\min_{\mathbf{a}} \sum_{i=1}^m (\tilde{y}_i - h_{\mathbf{a}}(\mathbf{x}_i))^2$;
  learn the weight of the hypothesis $h_{\mathbf{a}_t}$:
  $\alpha_t = \arg\min_{\alpha \in \mathbb{R}^+} \sum_{i=1}^m \ell(y_i, H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i) + \alpha h_{\mathbf{a}_t}(\mathbf{x}_i))$;
  update: $H_t = H_{t-1} + \alpha_t h_{\mathbf{a}_t}$;

$$\begin{aligned}
\tilde{y} &= -\frac{\partial \ell(y, H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}))}{\partial H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x})}, \\
&= -\frac{\partial (y - H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}))^2}{\partial H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x})}, \\
&= 2(y - H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x})).
\end{aligned}$$

The pseudo-residual is just twice the difference between the true value and the predicted value, *i.e.* (up to the factor 2) the usual residual (remember that this loss is mainly used in the regression setting).

- Using the logistic loss $\ell(y, H) = \ln(1 + \exp(-2yH))$ for classification with labels $y \in \{-1, +1\}$ (this is the convention used in Friedman (2001)), the pseudo-residuals are defined by:

$$\begin{aligned}
\tilde{y} &= -\frac{\partial \ell(y, H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}))}{\partial H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x})}, \\
&= -\frac{\partial \ln(1 + \exp(-2yH_{t-1}(\mathbf{x})))}{\partial H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x})}, \\
&= \frac{2y \exp(-2yH_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}))}{1 + \exp(-2yH_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}))}, \\
&= \frac{2y}{1 + \exp(2yH_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}))}.
\end{aligned}$$

Note that the pseudo-residual vanishes when $yH_{t-1}(\mathbf{x})$ is large, *i.e.* when the example is already correctly classified with a large margin.

This is not the most commonly used version of this loss. Since $H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x})$ is a real value, we rather pass this output through the logistic function in order to obtain the probability of belonging to the positive class, and use labels $y \in \{0, 1\}$. In such a case, the pseudo-residuals are given by:

Algorithm 10: Gradient boosting seen as a steepest gradient descent in function space Friedman (2001)

Inputs : Training set $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$, number of models T, a loss ℓ
Output: a model $H_T = H_0 + \sum_{t=1}^T \alpha_t h_{\mathbf{a}_t}$

Initialization: $H_0(\mathbf{x}) = \arg\min_{\rho \in \mathbb{R}} \sum_{i=1}^m \ell(y_i, \rho)$ for all $\mathbf{x}$;
for $t = 1$ *to* T **do**
  Compute the negative gradient: $\tilde{y}_i = -\dfrac{\partial \ell(y_i, H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i))}{\partial H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i)}$, $\forall i = 1, \ldots, m$;
  Learn a model that approximates this direction: $\mathbf{a}_t = \arg\min_{\mathbf{a}} \sum_{i=1}^m (\tilde{y}_i - h_{\mathbf{a}}(\mathbf{x}_i))^2$;
  Find the optimal step for $h_{\mathbf{a}_t}$: $\alpha_t = \arg\min_{\alpha \in \mathbb{R}^+} \sum_{i=1}^m \ell(y_i, H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i) + \alpha h_{\mathbf{a}_t}(\mathbf{x}_i))$;
  Update: $H_t = H_{t-1} + \alpha_t h_{\mathbf{a}_t}$;

$$
\begin{aligned}
\tilde{y} = & -\frac{\partial \ell(y, H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}))}{\partial H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x})}, \\
= & -\frac{\partial \left[-y \ln\left(\sigma(H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}))\right) - (1-y)\ln\left(1-\sigma(H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}))\right)\right]}{\partial H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x})}, \\
& \quad \downarrow \text{ same computation as for the logistic regression, using } \sigma' = \sigma(1-\sigma) \\
= & \, y - \sigma(H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x})),
\end{aligned}
$$

where σ denotes the logistic function $\sigma(x) = (1 + e^{-x})^{-1}$. The pseudo-residual is then the difference between the label and the predicted probability.

We can also draw a parallel between the gradient boosting algorithm and a gradient descent algorithm. This is quite natural, since the algorithm involves the gradient of the loss. Here, the parallel can be drawn with the steepest gradient descent with an optimal step size (computed by a line search), as shown in Algorithm 10: gradient boosting is a gradient descent in the space of functions, in which the gradient, only known at the training points, is approximated by a weak learner.

Note that gradient boosting, in its original presentation, uses the mean squared error in the step that fits the pseudo-residuals. However, we can choose any loss function we want to optimize, such as the exponential loss for classification tasks. Furthermore, the reader has to be careful: the loss ℓ we aim to optimize is the one used both to compute the pseudo-residuals and to find the weights of the base learners, whereas the squared loss is only used to fit the pseudo-residuals.

Regularization of gradient boosting Unlike bagging, boosting *can* over-fit when the number of weak learners T grows: each round decreases the training loss, and nothing prevents the model from eventually fitting the noise. The two main levers to control this are the number of rounds T, chosen by early stopping on a validation set, and the learning rate ν, which replaces the update by $H_t = H_{t-1} + \nu\, \alpha_t h_t$. Figure 101 shows their interplay: a smaller ν requires more rounds, but leads to a better minimum of the test error.

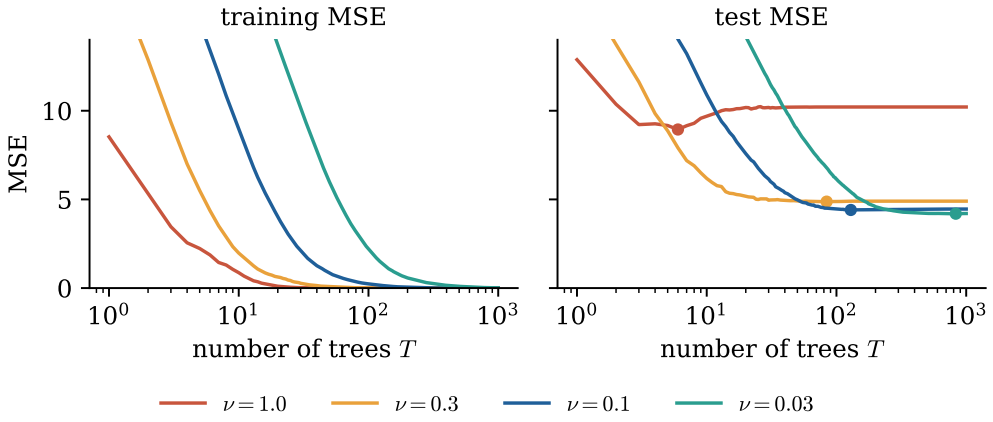


Figure 101: Effect of the learning rate ν in gradient boosting (squared loss, trees of depth 3, `make_friedman1` regression problem with 200 training examples). Left: the training error always goes to 0, all the faster as ν is large. Right: the test error reaches a minimum (dots) and then slightly increases or stagnates; with $\nu = 1$ the model quickly over-fits, whereas smaller values of ν reach a lower test error, at the price of more trees.

Remark : gradient boosting in practice Small steps generalize better: a value $\nu \in [0.01, 0.1]$ combined with early stopping is a robust default Friedman (2001), and ν and T should be tuned *together*. Friedman also showed that fitting each weak learner on a random subsample of the data (typically half of it), as in bagging, both speeds up the algorithm and improves its accuracy: this is *stochastic gradient boosting* Friedman (2002). Modern libraries such as XGBoost Chen and Guestrin (2016), presented below, LightGBM Ke et al. (2017) and CatBoost Prokhorenkova et al. (2018) add many algorithmic improvements (histograms of the features, sparsity handling, efficient treatment of categorical features, *etc.*). On tabular data, these tree ensembles remain, to this day, very hard to beat, even by deep neural networks Grinsztajn et al. (2022).

Presentation of XGBoost We finish this presentation of boosting by going back to decision trees and presenting XGBoost Chen and Guestrin (2016), a powerful and very fast tree-based boosting algorithm. We first explain how the weights of the leaves are computed, and then we explain the splitting criterion that is used. The main strength of this algorithm is that it can be used to optimize a risk based on any loss function, provided that this loss function is twice differentiable.

From now on, we consider a twice differentiable loss function ℓ and the following optimization problem:

$$\min_{f_1,\dots,f_T} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \ell(y_i, \hat{y}_i) + \Omega(f_1, \dots, f_T), \tag{10.2}$$

where $\hat{y}_i = \sum_{t=1}^{T} f_t(\mathbf{x}_i)$, T is the number of models and the f_t are the base learners (trees). The term $\Omega(f_1, \dots, f_T) = \sum_{t=1}^{T} \left(\beta \mathcal{L}_t + \frac{\lambda}{2} \sum_{j=1}^{\mathcal{L}_t} (f_t^{(j)})^2 \right)$ is composed

of two regularization terms, used to control the number of leaves $\mathcal{L}_t$ of each tree and the weight $f_t^{(j)}$ of each leaf j of the t-th tree.

Recall that the models are learned in an additive manner, so let us denote by $\hat{y}_i^{(t-1)}$ the value predicted by the first $t-1$ trees, *i.e.* $\hat{y}_i^{(t-1)} = \sum_{s=1}^{t-1} f_s(\mathbf{x}_i) = H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i)$.

Let us now have a look at the tree f_t learned at iteration t of our algorithm. For this purpose, we rewrite the objective (10.2) and aim to minimize, with respect to f_t, the quantity R_t defined as:

$$R_t = \sum_{i=1}^{m} \ell(y_i, \hat{y}_i^{(t-1)} + f_t(\mathbf{x}_i)) + \beta\mathcal{L}_t + \frac{\lambda}{2}\sum_{j=1}^{\mathcal{L}_t}(f_t^{(j)})^2. \tag{10.3}$$

In practice, the authors of Chen and Guestrin (2016) only consider a second-order approximation of the function they aim to optimize. This second-order approximation is taken with respect to the value predicted at the previous iteration, *i.e.* $\hat{y}_i^{(t-1)}$. Recall that, for any function u which is twice differentiable on an open set, we have, for any x and any small ε:

$$u(x+\varepsilon) \simeq u(x) + u'(x)\varepsilon + \frac{1}{2}u''(x)\varepsilon^2.$$

We respectively denote by $g(\mathbf{x}_i)$ and $h(\mathbf{x}_i)$ the first- and second-order derivatives of the function $\ell(y_i, \cdot)$ taken at $\hat{y}_i^{(t-1)}$. We can then approximate (10.3) as follows:

$$R_t \simeq \sum_{i=1}^{m}\left[\ell(y_i, \hat{y}_i^{(t-1)}) + f_t(\mathbf{x}_i)g(\mathbf{x}_i) + \frac{1}{2}f_t^2(\mathbf{x}_i)h(\mathbf{x}_i)\right] + \beta\mathcal{L}_t + \frac{\lambda}{2}\sum_{j=1}^{\mathcal{L}_t}(f_t^{(j)})^2. \tag{10.4}$$

Remember that we aim to learn the function f_t, *i.e.* the values $(f_t^{(j)})_{j=1,\dots,\mathcal{L}_t}$ of its leaves once the structure of the tree is fixed. Let us consider a leaf j and denote by I_j the set of indices i such that $\mathbf{x}_i$ falls into the leaf j, so that $f_t(\mathbf{x}_i) = f_t^{(j)}$ for all $i \in I_j$. Since the first term of (10.4) does not depend on f_t, the value $f_t^{(j)}$ shall minimize the following quantity V_j for a given index j:

$$V_j \;=\; \left(\sum_{i\in I_j} g(\mathbf{x}_i)\right) f_t^{(j)} + \frac{1}{2}\left(\lambda + \sum_{i\in I_j} h(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)(f_t^{(j)})^2. \tag{10.5}$$

This function is convex when $\lambda + \sum_{i\in I_j} h(\mathbf{x}_i) > 0$ (since $\lambda \geq 0$, this is the case as soon as the loss function ℓ is convex, so that $h(\mathbf{x}_i) \geq 0$, and $\lambda > 0$), and its minimum is then given by the solution of *Euler's equation*, *i.e.* the value $f_t^{(j)}$ at which the derivative vanishes. This solution is given by:

$$f_t^{(j)} = -\frac{\sum_{i\in I_j} g(\mathbf{x}_i)}{\sum_{i\in I_j} h(\mathbf{x}_i) + \lambda}. \tag{10.6}$$

Example 10.3. Let us come back to our previous example, where we considered the *squared loss* and the *logistic loss*, and let us compute the weights of the leaves for these two losses.

For the squared loss $\ell(y, \hat{y}^{(t-1)}) = \frac{1}{2}(y - \hat{y}^{(t-1)})^2$, the gradient g with respect to the prediction is

$$g = \frac{\partial \ell}{\partial \hat{y}^{(t-1)}}(y, \hat{y}^{(t-1)}) = \hat{y}^{(t-1)} - y,$$

and the second-order derivative h with respect to the prediction is

$$h = \frac{\partial^2 \ell}{\partial (\hat{y}^{(t-1)})^2}(y, \hat{y}^{(t-1)}) = 1.$$

So the optimal value of a leaf $f_t^{(j)}$ is:

$$f_t^{(j)} = -\frac{\sum_{i \in I_j} g(\mathbf{x}_i)}{\sum_{i \in I_j} h(\mathbf{x}_i) + \lambda} = \frac{\sum_{i \in I_j} (y_i - \hat{y}_i^{(t-1)})}{\lambda + |I_j|}.$$

Thus, when learning the first tree, with $\hat{y}_i^{(0)} = 0$ for all i and $\lambda = 0$, we find that the optimal score of a leaf is equal to the average of the target values of the instances in the leaf. For subsequent iterations, the optimal score of each leaf becomes the average of the residuals (shrunk towards 0 when $\lambda > 0$).

For the logistic loss $\ell(y, \hat{y}^{(t-1)}) = -\Big(y \ln(p(\hat{y}^{(t-1)})) + (1-y)\ln(1 - p(\hat{y}^{(t-1)}))\Big)$, where $y \in \{0, 1\}$ and p is the logistic function, the gradient g with respect to the prediction is

$$g = \frac{\partial \ell}{\partial \hat{y}^{(t-1)}}(y, \hat{y}^{(t-1)}) = p(\hat{y}^{(t-1)}) - y,$$

and the second-order derivative h with respect to the prediction is

$$h = \frac{\partial^2 \ell}{\partial (\hat{y}^{(t-1)})^2}(y, \hat{y}^{(t-1)}) = p(\hat{y}^{(t-1)})(1 - p(\hat{y}^{(t-1)})).$$

So the optimal value of a leaf $f_t^{(j)}$ is:

$$f_t^{(j)} = -\frac{\sum_{i \in I_j} g(\mathbf{x}_i)}{\sum_{i \in I_j} h(\mathbf{x}_i) + \lambda} = \frac{\sum_{i \in I_j} \Big(y_i - p(\hat{y}_i^{(t-1)})\Big)}{\lambda + \sum_{i \in I_j} p(\hat{y}_i^{(t-1)}) \Big(1 - p(\hat{y}_i^{(t-1)})\Big)}.$$

Splitting criterion Let us now focus on the splitting criterion. Once the optimal weight (10.6) of each leaf is found, we can compute the optimal value $V_j^\star$ of the objective by plugging it into (10.5). We get:

$$\begin{aligned} V_j^\star &= \underbrace{-\left(\sum_{i\in I_j} g(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)\frac{\sum_{i\in I_j} g(\mathbf{x}_i)}{\sum_{i\in I_j} h(\mathbf{x}_i)+\lambda}} + \underbrace{\frac{1}{2}\left(\lambda+\sum_{i\in I_j} h(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)\left(-\frac{\sum_{i\in I_j} g(\mathbf{x}_i)}{\sum_{i\in I_j} h(\mathbf{x}_i)+\lambda}\right)^2}, \\ &= -\frac{\left(\sum_{i\in I_j} g(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)^2}{\sum_{i\in I_j} h(\mathbf{x}_i)+\lambda} + \frac{1}{2}\frac{\left(\sum_{i\in I_j} g(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)^2}{\sum_{i\in I_j} h(\mathbf{x}_i)+\lambda}, \\ &= -\frac{1}{2}\frac{\left(\sum_{i\in I_j} g(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)^2}{\sum_{i\in I_j} h(\mathbf{x}_i)+\lambda}. \end{aligned}$$

This formula is used to measure the quality of a leaf (the lower, the better). It can be seen as a generalization of impurity measures, such as the Gini impurity, to any loss function. Using this measure, the authors define their splitting criterion, *i.e.* the gain associated with the split of a leaf into a left and a right child, as follows:

$$\text{Gain} = \frac{1}{2}\left[\frac{\left(\sum_{i\in I_L} g(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)^2}{\sum_{i\in I_L} h(\mathbf{x}_i)+\lambda} + \frac{\left(\sum_{i\in I_R} g(\mathbf{x}_i)\right)^2}{\sum_{i\in I_R} h(\mathbf{x}_i)+\lambda} - \frac{(\sum_{i\in I} g(\mathbf{x}_i))^2}{\sum_{i\in I} h(\mathbf{x}_i)+\lambda}\right] - \beta,$$

where $I = I_L \cup I_R$ is the set of examples of the leaf before the split, and the parameter β penalizes the creation of an additional leaf. The split with the largest gain is selected, and a leaf is not split if no split has a positive gain.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q10.11. What are the pseudo-residuals of gradient boosting for the loss $\frac{1}{2}(y-H)^2$? Does increasing the number of trees always improve a gradient boosting model?

Q10.12. With the logistic loss and labels $y \in \{0,1\}$, the pseudo-residual is $y - \sigma(H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}))$. Compute it for a positive example ($y=1$) predicted with probability 0.9, then with probability 0.1. Which one will the next weak learner focus on?

Q10.13. In XGBoost with the squared loss $\frac{1}{2}(y-\hat{y})^2$, a leaf contains three examples whose residuals $y_i - \hat{y}_i^{(t-1)}$ are 1, 2 and 3. Compute the value of the leaf for $\lambda = 0$ and for $\lambda = 1$.

10.4 Metric Learning

All the algorithms presented so far rely, explicitly or implicitly, on a way to compare examples. The k-nearest neighbors algorithm (Section 8) predicts the label of a new point from the labels of its closest training examples, the k-means algorithm groups

points that are close to each other, and kernel methods such as SVMs rely on a similarity function between examples. In all these cases, the performance of the algorithm crucially depends on the *representation* of the data and on the *distance* used to compare them. Most of the time, this distance is the Euclidean one, chosen by default, even though nothing guarantees that it is adapted to the task at hand.

Learning a good representation of the data is one of the key ingredients of modern machine learning: this is precisely what the hidden layers of neural networks do (Section 9). *Metric learning* addresses this question from a different angle: instead of learning a model on a fixed representation, it learns, from the data, the distance (or the similarity) used to compare the examples, in such a way that examples that should be considered as similar (*e.g.* examples of the same class) are close, while examples that should be considered as dissimilar are far apart. This section is largely inspired by the survey of Bellet, Habrard and Sebban Bellet et al. (2013), see also their book Bellet et al. (2015); we restrict ourselves to the most classical family of learned metrics, the Mahalanobis distances, and we will not go further than the LMNN algorithm.

10.4.1 Why Learn a Metric?

Let us recall what a distance is.

Definition 10.4: Distance and pseudo-distance

A *distance* (or *metric*) on a set $\mathcal{X}$ is a function $d : \mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{X} \to \mathbb{R}^+$ such that, for all $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}', \mathbf{x}'' \in \mathcal{X}$:

1. $d(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = 0 \iff \mathbf{x} = \mathbf{x}'$ (separation)
2. $d(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = d(\mathbf{x}', \mathbf{x})$ (symmetry)
3. $d(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}'') \leq d(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') + d(\mathbf{x}', \mathbf{x}'')$ (triangle inequality)

A function satisfying these properties, except that the separation property is weakened into $d(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}) = 0$ (two distinct points may be at distance 0), is called a *pseudo-distance*.

The Euclidean distance $d_2(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}'\|_2$ gives the same importance to all the features and ignores their correlations. This causes at least three kinds of problems, which we have already met when we studied the k-NN algorithm:

- **scale**: a feature taking large values (*e.g.* an income in euros) dominates a feature taking small values (*e.g.* a height in meters), whatever their relevance for the task;
- **relevance**: non-informative, noisy features contribute to the distance as much as the informative ones, so that the nearest neighbors of a point may be determined by noise;
- **correlations**: two strongly correlated features count twice the same information.

Standardizing the features (Section 11) solves the first problem, but not the other two, since it does not use the labels. The idea of metric learning is to use the supervision to reshape the space, as illustrated in Figure 103 below: after learning, the neighbors of each point should mostly belong to its class, which directly improves the k-NN classifier.

10.4.2 Mahalanobis Distances

The most studied family of learned metrics is the family of (generalized) Mahalanobis distances. In what follows, $\mathbb{S}_+^d$ denotes the cone of symmetric positive semi-definite (PSD) matrices of size $d \times d$, and we write $\mathbf{M} \succeq 0$ for $\mathbf{M} \in \mathbb{S}_+^d$.

Definition 10.5: Mahalanobis distance

Let $\mathbf{M} \in \mathbb{S}_+^d$. The Mahalanobis distance associated with $\mathbf{M}$ is defined, for all $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}' \in \mathbb{R}^d$, by

$$d_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}')^\top \mathbf{M} (\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}')}.$$

A few remarks are in order:

- when $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{I}$, we recover the Euclidean distance;
- when $\mathbf{M}$ is diagonal, $d_{\mathbf{M}}^2(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \sum_{j=1}^d M_{jj}(x_j - x'_j)^2$ simply re-weights the features; standardizing the data amounts to choosing $M_{jj} = 1/s_j^2$, where s_j is the standard deviation of the j-th feature;
- when $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{\Sigma}^{-1}$ is the inverse of the covariance matrix of the data, we obtain the distance originally introduced by P. C. Mahalanobis, which takes the correlations between the features into account;
- a general matrix $\mathbf{M}$ both re-weights the features and takes their correlations into account.

The PSD assumption is essential: it ensures that $(\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}')^\top \mathbf{M} (\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}') \geq 0$, so that the square root is well defined, and it makes $d_{\mathbf{M}}$ a pseudo-distance. When $\mathbf{M}$ is positive definite, $d_{\mathbf{M}}$ is a distance; when $\mathbf{M}$ is only PSD, two distinct points $\mathbf{x}$ and $\mathbf{x}'$ such that $\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}'$ belongs to the kernel of $\mathbf{M}$ are at distance 0, which can be useful to discard irrelevant directions of the space. The following proposition gives a very convenient interpretation of Mahalanobis distances.

Proposition 10.4: Mahalanobis distances are Euclidean distances after a linear map

Let $\mathbf{M}$ be a symmetric matrix of size $d \times d$. Then $\mathbf{M} \succeq 0$ if and only if there exists a matrix $\mathbf{L} \in \mathbb{R}^{r \times d}$, with $r \geq \operatorname{rank}(\mathbf{M})$, such that $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{L}^\top \mathbf{L}$. In this case, for all $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}' \in \mathbb{R}^d$,

$$d_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \|\mathbf{L}\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{L}\mathbf{x}'\|_2.$$

Proof. If $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{L}^\top \mathbf{L}$, then $\mathbf{M}$ is symmetric and, for any $\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, $\mathbf{z}^\top \mathbf{M} \mathbf{z} = \mathbf{z}^\top \mathbf{L}^\top \mathbf{L} \mathbf{z} = \|\mathbf{L}\mathbf{z}\|_2^2 \geq 0$, so $\mathbf{M} \succeq 0$. Conversely, if $\mathbf{M} \succeq 0$, the spectral theorem gives $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{U}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{U}^\top$, where $\mathbf{U}$ is orthogonal and $\mathbf{\Lambda} = \operatorname{diag}(\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_d)$ with $\lambda_k \geq 0$. Setting $\mathbf{L} = \mathbf{\Lambda}^{1/2}\mathbf{U}^\top$ gives $\mathbf{L}^\top \mathbf{L} = \mathbf{U}\mathbf{\Lambda}^{1/2}\mathbf{\Lambda}^{1/2}\mathbf{U}^\top = \mathbf{M}$; removing the rows of $\mathbf{L}$ associated with zero eigenvalues gives a matrix with $r = \operatorname{rank}(\mathbf{M})$ rows. Finally, with $\mathbf{z} = \mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}'$, we have $d_{\mathbf{M}}^2(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \mathbf{z}^\top \mathbf{L}^\top \mathbf{L} \mathbf{z} = \|\mathbf{L}\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{L}\mathbf{x}'\|_2^2$. □

In other words, **learning a Mahalanobis distance is equivalent to learning a linear transformation $\mathbf{x} \mapsto \mathbf{L}\mathbf{x}$** of the data and using the Euclidean distance in the

new space. If $\mathbf{M}$ has a low rank $r < d$, this transformation also performs a (supervised) *dimensionality reduction*. Geometrically, the unit ball $\{\mathbf{x} : d_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{0}) \leq 1\}$ is an ellipsoid whose axes are given by the eigenvectors $\mathbf{u}_k$ of $\mathbf{M}$, with semi-axis lengths $1/\sqrt{\lambda_k}$ (see Figure 102).

Example 10.4. Let us consider $\mathbf{M} = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$, whose eigenvalues are $\lambda_1 = 3$, associated with $\mathbf{u}_1 = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(1,1)^\top$, and $\lambda_2 = 1$, associated with $\mathbf{u}_2 = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(1,-1)^\top$. Hence $\mathbf{M} \succeq 0$ (it is even positive definite).

- For $\mathbf{x} = (1,0)^\top$ and $\mathbf{x}' = (0,1)^\top$, $\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}' = (1,-1)^\top$ and $d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = 2-1-1+2 = 2$: the distance is equal to the Euclidean one, $\sqrt{2}$, because $\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}'$ is along $\mathbf{u}_2$.
- For $\mathbf{x} = (1,1)^\top$ and $\mathbf{x}' = (0,0)^\top$, $d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = 2 + 1 + 1 + 2 = 6$, so $d_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \sqrt{6} = \sqrt{3} \times \sqrt{2}$: distances along $\mathbf{u}_1$ are stretched by a factor $\sqrt{\lambda_1} = \sqrt{3}$.

A possible choice of linear map is $\mathbf{L} = \mathbf{\Lambda}^{1/2}\mathbf{U}^\top = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} \begin{pmatrix} \sqrt{3} & \sqrt{3} \\ 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}$, and one can check that $\mathbf{L}^\top \mathbf{L} = \mathbf{M}$.

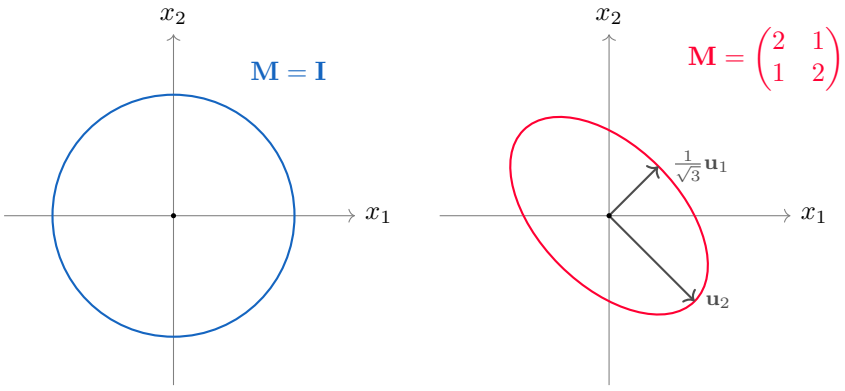


Figure 102: Unit balls $\{\mathbf{x} : d_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{0}) \leq 1\}$ of the Euclidean distance (left) and of the Mahalanobis distance of the example above (right). The ellipse is oriented along the eigenvectors of $\mathbf{M}$, with semi-axes $1/\sqrt{\lambda_k}$: the directions associated with large eigenvalues are the ones along which distances are stretched.

Why does it help k-NN and k-means? Since $d_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \|\mathbf{L}\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{L}\mathbf{x}'\|_2$, running the k-NN algorithm with $d_{\mathbf{M}}$ is the same as running the usual (Euclidean) k-NN algorithm on the transformed data $\mathbf{L}\mathbf{x}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{L}\mathbf{x}_m$. If $\mathbf{L}$ stretches the directions that discriminate the classes and shrinks the irrelevant ones, the neighborhood of a point contains more examples of its own class, and the majority vote is more often correct. Similarly, the k-means algorithm with $d_{\mathbf{M}}$ builds Voronoi cells that are no longer balls but ellipsoids, and can thus recover elongated or correlated clusters: it was precisely to improve clustering with side information that one of the first metric learning algorithms was proposed Xing et al. (2002).

10.4.3 Learning a Metric from Side Information

To learn $\mathbf{M}$, we need some supervision telling us which examples should be close and which ones should be far apart. This supervision generally takes one of the following forms Bellet et al. (2013):

- **must-link** (or similarity) constraints: a set $\mathcal{S}$ of pairs $(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j)$ such that $\mathbf{x}_i$ and $\mathbf{x}_j$ should be similar;
- **cannot-link** (or dissimilarity) constraints: a set $\mathcal{D}$ of pairs $(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j)$ such that $\mathbf{x}_i$ and $\mathbf{x}_j$ should be dissimilar;
- **relative** (or triplet) constraints: a set $\mathcal{R}$ of triplets $(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j, \mathbf{x}_k)$ such that $\mathbf{x}_i$ should be more similar to $\mathbf{x}_j$ than to $\mathbf{x}_k$.

We follow here the notation of Bellet et al. (2013): in this section only, $\mathcal{D}$ and $\mathcal{R}$ denote sets of constraints, and not the data distribution and the risk.

In supervised classification, these constraints are directly derived from the labels: two examples of the same class form a must-link pair, two examples of different classes form a cannot-link pair, and a triplet $(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j, \mathbf{x}_k)$ with $y_i = y_j \neq y_k$ forms a relative constraint. Such constraints are also available in weakly supervised settings where labels are unknown, *e.g.* when a user tells us that two images are "alike". Metric learning then consists in solving a problem of the form

$$\min_{\mathbf{M} \in \mathbb{S}_+^d} \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{M}, \mathcal{S}, \mathcal{D}, \mathcal{R}) + \lambda\, \Omega(\mathbf{M}),$$

where the loss $\mathcal{L}$ penalizes the violated constraints and Ω is a regularizer (*e.g.* $\|\mathbf{M}\|_{\mathcal{F}}^2$, or the trace of $\mathbf{M}$ to favor low-rank solutions). A key observation is that the squared distance is **linear** in $\mathbf{M}$:

$$d_{\mathbf{M}}^2(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j) = (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)^\top \mathbf{M} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j) = \mathrm{Tr}\left(\mathbf{M}\mathbf{C}_{ij}\right), \quad \text{with} \quad \mathbf{C}_{ij} = (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)^\top.$$

Hence, constraints on squared distances are linear constraints on $\mathbf{M}$ and, together with the convex constraint $\mathbf{M} \succeq 0$, they often lead to convex optimization problems. Let us briefly present two classical algorithms.

MMC Xing et al. (2002) The first Mahalanobis metric learning method, sometimes called MMC, brings the similar pairs together while keeping the dissimilar pairs apart:

$$\min_{\mathbf{M} \in \mathbb{S}_+^d} \sum_{(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j) \in \mathcal{S}} d_{\mathbf{M}}^2(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j) \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \sum_{(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j) \in \mathcal{D}} d_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j) \geq 1.$$

The constraint prevents the trivial solution $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{0}$ (using $d_{\mathbf{M}}$ rather than $d_{\mathbf{M}}^2$ in the constraint avoids solutions of rank one). The problem is convex, and it is solved by a projected gradient method which requires an eigenvalue decomposition at each iteration, which becomes costly in high dimension. Note that MMC tries to bring *all* the similar pairs together, which is a strong requirement when a class is made of several separated groups.

ITML Davis et al. (2007) Information-Theoretic Metric Learning regularizes the learned matrix towards a prior matrix $\mathbf{M}_0$ (*e.g.* the identity):

$$\min_{\mathbf{M}\in\mathbb{S}_+^d} D_{ld}(\mathbf{M},\mathbf{M}_0) \quad \text{s.t.} \quad d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}_i,\mathbf{x}_j) \leq u \quad \forall(\mathbf{x}_i,\mathbf{x}_j)\in\mathcal{S},$$
$$d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}_i,\mathbf{x}_j) \geq l \quad \forall(\mathbf{x}_i,\mathbf{x}_j)\in\mathcal{D},$$

where u and l are two thresholds and $D_{ld}(\mathbf{M},\mathbf{M}_0) = \mathrm{Tr}\left(\mathbf{M}\mathbf{M}_0^{-1}\right) - \log\det(\mathbf{M}\mathbf{M}_0^{-1}) - d$ is the LogDet divergence, which is closely related to the Kullback-Leibler divergence between two Gaussian distributions of covariance matrices $\mathbf{M}^{-1}$ and $\mathbf{M}_0^{-1}$. This divergence is finite only for positive definite matrices, so that the iterates automatically remain in the PSD cone and no projection is needed. The problem is solved with Bregman projections, and slack variables are added when the constraints cannot all be satisfied.

10.4.4 Large Margin Nearest Neighbors (LMNN)

The Large Margin Nearest Neighbors algorithm (LMNN) of Weinberger and Saul Weinberger and Saul (2009) is one of the most widely used metric learning algorithms. It is specifically designed to improve the k-NN classifier, and its key idea is that, to classify $\mathbf{x}_i$ correctly, we do not need all the examples of its class to be close to $\mathbf{x}_i$ (as in MMC): it is enough that its k nearest neighbors belong to its class. The constraints are thus *local*.

Target neighbors and impostors Before learning, we associate with each training example $\mathbf{x}_i$ a set of k **target neighbors**: the k nearest examples (for the Euclidean distance, or using prior knowledge) that share the label of $\mathbf{x}_i$. We write $j \rightsquigarrow i$ when $\mathbf{x}_j$ is a target neighbor of $\mathbf{x}_i$. These target neighbors are fixed once and for all. We would like the target neighbors of $\mathbf{x}_i$ to be its nearest neighbors in the learned metric. The examples that prevent this are the **impostors**: an impostor of $\mathbf{x}_i$ is an example $\mathbf{x}_l$ with a different label, $y_l \neq y_i$, which lies inside the perimeter defined by the target neighbors of $\mathbf{x}_i$ enlarged by a margin, *i.e.* such that

$$d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}_i,\mathbf{x}_l) \leq d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}_i,\mathbf{x}_j) + 1 \quad \text{for some target neighbor } j \rightsquigarrow i.$$

The objective function LMNN combines two terms, illustrated in Figure 103. Denoting $y_{il} = 1$ if $y_i = y_l$ and $y_{il} = 0$ otherwise:

- a **pull** term, which brings the target neighbors closer:

$$\varepsilon_{\text{pull}}(\mathbf{M}) = \sum_{i=1}^{m}\sum_{j\rightsquigarrow i} d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}_i,\mathbf{x}_j);$$

- a **push** term, which pushes the impostors out of the perimeter, with a margin of 1, using the hinge loss $[u]_+ = \max(0,u)$:

$$\varepsilon_{\text{push}}(\mathbf{M}) = \sum_{i=1}^{m}\sum_{j\rightsquigarrow i}\sum_{l=1}^{m}(1-y_{il})\left[1 + d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}_i,\mathbf{x}_j) - d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}_i,\mathbf{x}_l)\right]_+.$$

The learned matrix is then the solution of

$$\min_{\mathbf{M} \in \mathbb{S}_+^d} (1-\mu)\, \varepsilon_{\text{pull}}(\mathbf{M}) + \mu\, \varepsilon_{\text{push}}(\mathbf{M}),$$

where $\mu \in [0,1]$ balances the two terms ($\mu = 1/2$ usually works well). The unit margin fixes the scale of $\mathbf{M}$: without it, multiplying $\mathbf{M}$ by a small constant would make all the distances, and thus the pull term, arbitrarily small. The similarity with the soft-margin SVM (Section 8) is striking, and justifies the name of the algorithm: a hinge loss enforces a margin, and a second term plays the role of a regularizer.

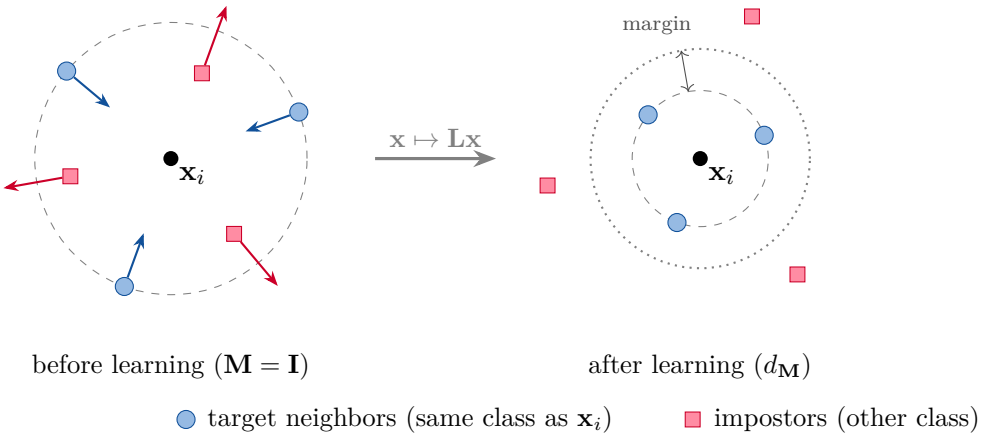


Figure 103: Principle of LMNN. Left: with the Euclidean distance, several examples of another class (impostors, red squares) are closer to $\mathbf{x}_i$ than its target neighbors (blue circles), so that the k-NN classifier makes an error. The pull term brings the target neighbors closer (blue arrows) and the push term moves the impostors away (red arrows). Right: in the learned metric, the target neighbors lie inside the perimeter of $\mathbf{x}_i$ (dashed circle) and the impostors lie beyond this perimeter plus a margin (dotted circle).

A semi-definite program Introducing a slack variable $\xi_{ijl} \geq 0$ for each triplet, as for the soft-margin SVM, and using $d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j) = \operatorname{Tr}(\mathbf{M}\mathbf{C}_{ij})$, the LMNN problem can be rewritten as

$$\begin{aligned} \min_{\mathbf{M}, \boldsymbol{\xi}} \quad & (1-\mu) \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sum_{j \rightsquigarrow i} \operatorname{Tr}(\mathbf{M}\mathbf{C}_{ij}) + \mu \sum_{i=1}^{m} \sum_{j \rightsquigarrow i} \sum_{l=1}^{m} (1 - y_{il})\, \xi_{ijl} \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & \operatorname{Tr}(\mathbf{M}\mathbf{C}_{il}) - \operatorname{Tr}(\mathbf{M}\mathbf{C}_{ij}) \geq 1 - \xi_{ijl}, \quad \xi_{ijl} \geq 0, \quad \forall\, i,\ j \rightsquigarrow i,\ l : y_{il} = 0, \\ & \mathbf{M} \succeq 0. \end{aligned}$$

The objective and the constraints are linear in $(\mathbf{M}, \boldsymbol{\xi})$, and the variable $\mathbf{M}$ is constrained to belong to the cone of PSD matrices: this is a **semi-definite program** (SDP), a convex optimization problem. Consequently, LMNN does not suffer from local minima. However, generic SDP solvers do not scale well: the number of triplets is of the order of $k\, m^2$ and each iteration of an interior point method is expensive. Weinberger and Saul therefore proposed a dedicated first-order solver, which exploits the fact that only a small number of triplets are active (*i.e.* involve an actual impostor) at a given time.

Projected (sub)gradient descent Let us denote by $\varepsilon(\mathbf{M}) = (1-\mu)\varepsilon_{\text{pull}}(\mathbf{M}) + \mu\varepsilon_{\text{push}}(\mathbf{M})$ the objective function. It is convex but not differentiable, because of the

hinge loss. A subgradient of ε at $\mathbf{M}$ is given by

$$\mathbf{G}(\mathbf{M}) = (1-\mu)\sum_{i=1}^{m}\sum_{j\rightsquigarrow i}\mathbf{C}_{ij} + \mu\sum_{(i,j,l)\in\mathcal{A}(\mathbf{M})}(\mathbf{C}_{ij}-\mathbf{C}_{il}),$$

where $\mathcal{A}(\mathbf{M})$ is the set of *active* triplets, *i.e.* the triplets (i,j,l) with $j \rightsquigarrow i$, $y_{il}=0$ and $1+d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}_i,\mathbf{x}_j)-d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}_i,\mathbf{x}_l)>0$. A gradient step $\mathbf{M}-\eta\mathbf{G}(\mathbf{M})$ may leave the cone $\mathbb{S}^d_+$; we then project it back onto the cone, which is easy thanks to the following result.

Proposition 10.5: Projection onto the PSD cone

Let $\mathbf{A}$ be a symmetric matrix with eigendecomposition $\mathbf{A}=\mathbf{U}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{U}^\top$, where $\mathbf{\Lambda}=\operatorname{diag}(\lambda_1,\dots,\lambda_d)$. Then the projection of $\mathbf{A}$ onto $\mathbb{S}^d_+$ for the Frobenius norm is

$$\Pi_{\mathbb{S}^d_+}(\mathbf{A}) = \operatorname*{arg\,min}_{\mathbf{M}\in\mathbb{S}^d_+}\|\mathbf{M}-\mathbf{A}\|_{\mathcal{F}} = \mathbf{U}\max(\mathbf{\Lambda},0)\,\mathbf{U}^\top,$$

where $\max(\mathbf{\Lambda},0)=\operatorname{diag}(\max(\lambda_1,0),\dots,\max(\lambda_d,0))$, *i.e.* the negative eigenvalues are set to 0.

Proof. The Frobenius norm is invariant under orthogonal transformations, so $\|\mathbf{M}-\mathbf{A}\|_{\mathcal{F}}=\|\mathbf{B}-\mathbf{\Lambda}\|_{\mathcal{F}}$ with $\mathbf{B}=\mathbf{U}^\top\mathbf{M}\mathbf{U}$, and $\mathbf{B}\succeq 0$ if and only if $\mathbf{M}\succeq 0$. For any $\mathbf{B}\succeq 0$, the diagonal entries satisfy $B_{kk}=\mathbf{e}_k^\top\mathbf{B}\mathbf{e}_k\geq 0$, hence

$$\|\mathbf{B}-\mathbf{\Lambda}\|^2_{\mathcal{F}} = \sum_{k=1}^{d}(B_{kk}-\lambda_k)^2 + \sum_{k\neq k'}B^2_{kk'} \geq \sum_{k=1}^{d}(B_{kk}-\lambda_k)^2 \geq \sum_{k=1}^{d}\min(\lambda_k,0)^2.$$

This lower bound is attained by $\mathbf{B}=\max(\mathbf{\Lambda},0)$, which is PSD, *i.e.* by $\mathbf{M}=\mathbf{U}\max(\mathbf{\Lambda},0)\mathbf{U}^\top$. □

The resulting procedure is summarized in Algorithm 11. Each iteration requires an eigenvalue decomposition, whose cost is $O(d^3)$: this is affordable for moderate dimensions, and a preliminary dimensionality reduction (*e.g.* with a principal component analysis) is often applied beforehand. An alternative, used in many implementations, is to optimize directly over the linear map $\mathbf{L}$ of Proposition 10.4: the PSD constraint then disappears, but the problem is no longer convex in $\mathbf{L}$.

Once $\mathbf{M}$ is learned, a new example is classified with the k-NN rule using $d_{\mathbf{M}}$ or, equivalently, with the Euclidean k-NN rule applied to the transformed data $\mathbf{L}\mathbf{x}$. On many benchmarks, LMNN significantly improves the accuracy of the k-NN classifier compared with the Euclidean distance Weinberger and Saul (2009).

Going further We stop our presentation of metric learning here. Let us simply mention that many other approaches exist, *e.g.* metric learning with generalization guarantees, local metric learning, which learns several metrics in different regions of the space Zantedeschi et al. (2016), or nonlinear metric learning, where the linear map $\mathbf{L}$ is replaced by a neural network trained on pairs or triplets of examples (siamese networks Bromley et al. (1994); Chopra et al. (2005)). We refer the interested reader to the survey Bellet et al. (2013) and to the book Bellet et al. (2015) for a comprehensive overview.

Algorithm 11: LMNN by projected subgradient descent

Inputs : Training set $S = \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$, number of target neighbors k, trade-off $\mu \in [0,1]$, step size $\eta > 0$, number of iterations T

Output: A matrix $\mathbf{M} \in \mathbb{S}_+^d$

for $i = 1$ *to* m **do**
  find the k target neighbors $j \rightsquigarrow i$ of $\mathbf{x}_i$: its k nearest (Euclidean) neighbors with label y_i;
set $\mathbf{M}_0 = \mathbf{I}$;
for $t = 0$ *to* $T-1$ **do**
  compute the set $\mathcal{A}(\mathbf{M}_t)$ of active triplets (target neighbors violated by an impostor);
  compute the subgradient $\mathbf{G}(\mathbf{M}_t) = (1-\mu)\sum_i \sum_{j \rightsquigarrow i} \mathbf{C}_{ij} + \mu \sum_{(i,j,l)\in\mathcal{A}(\mathbf{M}_t)} (\mathbf{C}_{ij} - \mathbf{C}_{il})$;
  gradient step: $\mathbf{A} = \mathbf{M}_t - \eta\, \mathbf{G}(\mathbf{M}_t)$;
  projection: compute $\mathbf{A} = \mathbf{U}\mathbf{\Lambda}\mathbf{U}^\top$ and set $\mathbf{M}_{t+1} = \mathbf{U} \max(\mathbf{\Lambda}, 0)\mathbf{U}^\top$;
return $\mathbf{M}_T$

To remember from Section 10

- The expected squared error decomposes into bias^2 + variance + noise; more generally, the excess risk is the sum of an approximation error and of an estimation error, the latter being controlled by the Rademacher complexity of $\mathcal{H}$ (Theorem 10.2).
- Averaging T models never increases the squared error, and divides the variance by T when the errors are uncorrelated; correlation between the models limits the gain.
- The three ensemble strategies of this section are compared in the table below.
- AdaBoost is a coordinate descent on the exponential loss; its training error is at most $\exp(-2\gamma^2 T)$ when every weak learner has an edge γ.
- Gradient boosting is a gradient descent in function space: each weak learner fits the negative gradient (pseudo-residuals) of any differentiable loss; XGBoost uses a second-order expansion to compute the leaf values and the splitting gain. Use a small learning rate and early stopping.
- Stacking learns how to combine models; its meta-model must be trained on out-of-fold predictions.
- A Mahalanobis distance $d_{\mathbf{M}}$ is a Euclidean distance after the linear map $\mathbf{L}$, with $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{L}^\top\mathbf{L}$; LMNN learns it with local pull/push constraints to improve the k-NN classifier.

	bagging, random forests	**boosting**	**stacking**
base learners	strong (deep trees)	weak (stumps, small trees)	any, heterogeneous
training	parallel, bootstrap	sequential, reweighting	base models, then meta-model
mainly reduces	the variance	the bias (and the variance)	both
large T	no over-fitting	over-fitting: early stopping	–

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q10.14. Let $\mathbf{M} = \mathrm{diag}(1, 0)$. Is $d_{\mathbf{M}}$ a distance on $\mathbb{R}^2$? Give a matrix $\mathbf{L}$ such that $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{L}^\top \mathbf{L}$.

Q10.15. True or false? "Standardizing the features is enough to make the Euclidean k-NN classifier insensitive to irrelevant features."

Q10.16. LMNN can be solved either over the matrix $\mathbf{M} \succeq 0$ or directly over the linear map $\mathbf{L}$, with $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{L}^\top \mathbf{L}$. What is gained and what is lost in the second case?

Exercises

Exercise 10.1. **(Computation)** We consider a two-class problem with equal priors $\mathbb{P}(Y=1) = \mathbb{P}(Y=2) = 1/2$, and denote by d_1 and d_2 the class-conditional densities of $X \in \mathbb{R}$.

(a) Show that, for any classifier h, $\mathcal{R}(h) = \frac{1}{2}\int_{\{h=2\}} d_1(x)\,dx + \frac{1}{2}\int_{\{h=1\}} d_2(x)\,dx$, and deduce that the Bayes error is $\mathcal{R}^\star = \frac{1}{2}\int_{\mathbb{R}} \min(d_1(x), d_2(x))\,dx$, *i.e.* half of the area of the region lying under both curves.

(b) We now take $d_1(x) = \frac{3}{2}x^2 + x$ for $0 \le x \le 1$ (and 0 otherwise) and $d_2(x) = 1$ for $\frac{3}{4} \le x \le \frac{7}{4}$ (and 0 otherwise). Check that d_1 and d_2 are densities and give the Bayes classifier.

(c) Compute the Bayes error.

(d) What happens to the Bayes error if the priors are no longer equal, say $\mathbb{P}(Y=1) = 0.9$?

Exercise 10.2. **(Computation)** Let $Y_1, \dots, Y_m$ be *i.i.d.* real random variables with mean μ and variance σ^2, and let Y be a new, independent, observation with the same distribution. To predict Y, we use the *shrunk* empirical mean $h_c = c\,\bar{Y}$, where $\bar{Y} = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m Y_i$ and $c \in [0,1]$.

(a) Using Proposition 10.1 (there are no features here: $f = \mu$), compute the squared bias, the variance and the noise term of $\mathbb{E}[(Y - h_c)^2]$.

(b) Find the value $c^\star$ that minimizes this error. Is the unbiased estimator ($c = 1$) optimal?

(c) Numerical application: $\mu = 1$, $\sigma^2 = 4$, $m = 4$. Compare the errors of h_1 and $h_{c^\star}$.

(d) Why can we not use $c^\star$ directly in practice?

Exercise 10.3. **(Computation)** Let $S = \{\mathbf{x}_1, \dots, \mathbf{x}_m\}$ be a sample of m distinct points. Compute the empirical Rademacher complexity $\mathfrak{R}_S(\mathcal{H})$ (Definition 10.1) of the following classes of functions with values in $\{-1, +1\}$:

(a) a class $\mathcal{H} = \{h_0\}$ reduced to a single function;

(b) the class $\mathcal{H}_\pm = \{\mathbf{x} \mapsto +1,\ \mathbf{x} \mapsto -1\}$ of the two constant classifiers, for $m = 1$, $m = 2$ and $m = 4$; then show that $\mathfrak{R}_S(\mathcal{H}_\pm) \le 1/\sqrt{m}$ for every m;

(c) the class of all the functions from $\mathcal{X}$ to $\{-1, +1\}$;

(d) What do these results tell us about the bound of Theorem 10.2?

Exercise 10.4. **(Computation)** Let S be a training set of size m and S_t a bootstrap sample of S (Algorithm 6).

(a) Compute the probability $(1-1/m)^m$ that a given example is out-of-bag for S_t, for $m = 10$, $m = 100$ and $m = 1000$, and compare it with e^{-1}.

(b) With $T = 100$ trees and m large, how many trees, on average, can be used to compute the OOB prediction of an example?

(c) Show that the expected number of *distinct* examples in S_t is $m\,(1 - (1 - 1/m)^m)$. Compute it for $m = 8$ and compare with the three bootstrap samples of Figure 95.

(d) What is the probability that an example is in-bag for *all* the T trees, so that it has no OOB prediction? Give its value for $T = 10$ and m large.

Exercise 10.5. **(Proof)** Let $Z_1, \dots, Z_T$ be random variables with the same variance σ^2 and the same pairwise correlation ρ.

(a) Show that $\mathrm{Var}\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_t Z_t\right) = \rho\sigma^2 + \frac{1-\rho}{T}\sigma^2$.

(b) Deduce that the variance of an average of positively correlated models cannot be smaller than $\rho\sigma^2$, however large T is.

(c) Show that necessarily $\rho \ge -1/(T-1)$.

(d) Numerical application: $\sigma^2 = 1$, $\rho = 0.3$. Compute the variance of the average for $T = 10$ and $T = \infty$. If the random sampling of the features decreases the correlation to $\rho = 0.1$ but increases the variance of each tree to $\sigma^2 = 1.2$, is it worth it?

Exercise 10.6. **(Python)** Generate a classification problem with `make_classification`, using the arguments `n_samples=3000`, `n_features=20`, `n_informative=6`, `n_redundant=4`, `flip_y=0.05` and `random_state=0`; keep the first 1000 examples for training and the other ones for testing. Compare the test errors of a single fully grown decision tree, of bagged trees and of a random forest (both with 200 trees), and compare the OOB errors of the two ensembles with their test errors.

Exercise 10.7. **(Computation)** We run AdaBoost (Algorithm 8) by hand on the $m = 6$ points $x_i = i \in \{1, \dots, 6\}$ of the real line, with labels

$$(y_1, \dots, y_6) = (+1, +1, -1, -1, -1, +1).$$

The weak learner returns the decision stump $h_{\theta,s}(x) = s\ \mathrm{sign}(x - \theta)$, with $\theta \in \{0.5, 1.5, \dots, 6.5\}$ and $s \in \{-1, +1\}$ (for $\theta = 0.5$ or 6.5 the stump is constant), that has the smallest weighted error.

(a) Explain why no stump has a zero training error. Find the stump h_1 selected at the first round, and compute ε_1, α_1 and the new weights $\mathbf{w}^{(2)}$.

(b) Same questions for the second round: h_2, ε_2, α_2, $\mathbf{w}^{(3)}$.

(c) Same questions for the third round (h_3, ε_3, α_3).

(d) Compute $f_3 = \alpha_1 h_1 + \alpha_2 h_2 + \alpha_3 h_3$ at each training point, and the training error of $H_3 = \mathrm{sign}(f_3)$. Compare with $\prod_{t=1}^{3} Z_t$ and with the bound of Proposition 10.3.

Exercise 10.8. **(Computation)** Assume that all the weak learners of AdaBoost have a weighted error $\varepsilon_t = 0.3$.

(a) Using the bound $\prod_t Z_t$, then the bound $\exp(-2\gamma^2 T)$, find the number of rounds that guarantees a training error smaller than 1%.

(b) For $m = 500$ examples, after how many rounds is the training error guaranteed to be 0?

Exercise 10.9. **(Proof)** In this exercise, the base hypotheses h_t of AdaBoost take real values in $[-1, +1]$, and we denote by $r_t = \sum_{i=1}^{m} w_i^{(t)} y_i h_t(\mathbf{x}_i) \in [-1, 1]$ the weighted *edge* of h_t.

(a) Show that, for all $u \in [-1, 1]$ and $\alpha \in \mathbb{R}$, $e^{-\alpha u} \leq \frac{1+u}{2} e^{-\alpha} + \frac{1-u}{2} e^{\alpha}$.

(b) Deduce that $Z_t(\alpha) = \sum_i w_i^{(t)} e^{-\alpha y_i h_t(\mathbf{x}_i)} \leq \frac{1+r_t}{2} e^{-\alpha} + \frac{1-r_t}{2} e^{\alpha}$, and find the value α_t minimizing this upper bound. Show that, with this choice, $Z_t \leq \sqrt{1 - r_t^2}$.

(c) Conclude that $\mathcal{R}_S(H_T) \leq \exp\left(-\frac{1}{2}\sum_{t=1}^{T} r_t^2\right)$, and check that we recover Proposition 10.3 when h_t takes its values in $\{-1, +1\}$.

Exercise 10.10. **(Python)** Implement AdaBoost with decision stumps on the dataset `make_moons` (with `n_samples=300`, `noise=0.2` and `random_state=0`), for $T = 100$ rounds; the weak learner is a `DecisionTreeClassifier` with `max_depth=1`, trained with the argument `sample_weight`. At each round, check numerically that (i) the training error of H_t is smaller than $\prod_{s \leq t} Z_s$, and (ii) the weighted error of h_t with respect to the *new* weights $\mathbf{w}^{(t+1)}$ is exactly $1/2$. Explain (ii).

Exercise 10.11. **(Computation)** We apply gradient boosting (Algorithm 9) with the loss $\ell(y, H) = \frac{1}{2}(y - H)^2$ and decision stumps (regression trees of depth 1, whose leaf values are the means of the targets in the leaves) to the dataset

$$x = (1, 2, 3, 4), \qquad y = (1, 3, 2, 6).$$

(a) Compute H_0 and the pseudo-residuals of the first round.

(b) Find the stump h_1 fitted to the pseudo-residuals by least squares (the candidate thresholds are 1.5, 2.5 and 3.5).

(c) Show that, for the squared loss, the line search of Algorithm 9 gives $\alpha_1 = 1$ (more generally, $\alpha_t = 1$ for any regression tree whose leaf values are the means of the residuals).

(d) Compute H_1 and its training mean squared error with a learning rate $\nu = 1$, then with $\nu = 0.5$ (*i.e.* $H_1 = H_0 + \nu\alpha_1 h_1$).

Exercise 10.12. **(Proof)** We use gradient boosting with the absolute loss $\ell(y, H) = |y - H|$.

(a) Show that the initial hypothesis H_0 of Algorithm 9 is a median of the y_i.

(b) Show that the pseudo-residuals are $\tilde{y}_i = \operatorname{sign}(y_i - H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i))$ (where ℓ is differentiable).

(c) Why is this loss more robust to outliers than the squared loss? Illustrate with the targets $y = (1, 2, 3, 4, 100)$.

Exercise 10.13. **(Computation)** We build the *first* tree of XGBoost for a binary classification problem with the logistic loss (labels $y \in \{0, 1\}$), starting from $\hat{y}_i^{(0)} = 0$, with $\lambda = 1$. Six examples, sorted by the value of a feature, have the labels

$$y = (1, 1, 1, 0, 0, 1).$$

(a) Compute the gradients $g(\mathbf{x}_i)$ and second-order derivatives $h(\mathbf{x}_i)$.

(b) Compute the optimal value (10.6) of a leaf containing the six examples, and the corresponding predicted probability.

(c) Compute the gain of the five possible splits (with $\beta = 0$), and the values of the two leaves of the best split.

(d) Is the best split performed if $\beta = 0.6$?

Exercise 10.14. **(Computation)** Let $\mathbf{A} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$.

(a) Is $(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') \mapsto \sqrt{(\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}')^\top \mathbf{A} (\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}')}$ a valid (pseudo-)distance? Compute $(\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}')^\top \mathbf{A} (\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}')$ for $\mathbf{x} = (1, 0)^\top$ and $\mathbf{x}' = (0, 1)^\top$.

(b) Compute the projection $\mathbf{M} = \Pi_{\mathbb{S}_+^2}(\mathbf{A})$ (Proposition 10.5) and $\|\mathbf{M} - \mathbf{A}\|_{\mathcal{F}}$.

(c) Give a linear map $\mathbf{L}$ such that $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{L}^\top \mathbf{L}$ (Proposition 10.4). Compute $d_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}')$ for the two points of (a). Is $d_{\mathbf{M}}$ a distance or only a pseudo-distance?

Exercise 10.15. **(Application)** We consider the LMNN objective restricted to the triplets of a single point. In $\mathbb{R}^2$, $\mathbf{x}_i = (0, 0)$ has the label $+1$ and a single target neighbor $\mathbf{x}_j = (1, 0)$ (so $k = 1$), and three points of the class -1: $\mathbf{x}_a = (0, 1)$, $\mathbf{x}_b = (0, 2)$ and $\mathbf{x}_c = (2, 0)$. We take $\mu = 1/2$.

(a) With $\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{I}$, which points are impostors of $\mathbf{x}_i$? Compute $\varepsilon_{\text{pull}}$, $\varepsilon_{\text{push}}$ and the objective.

(b) We restrict ourselves to diagonal matrices $\mathbf{M} = \operatorname{diag}(a, b)$ with $a, b \geq 0$. Write the objective $E(a, b)$.

(c) Minimize E and give all the minimizers. Interpret the learned metric.

(d) What does the non-uniqueness of the solution suggest?

11 Applications and Learning in Practice

The previous sections presented many algorithms together with their theoretical properties. In practice, however, choosing the "best" algorithm is rarely the most difficult part of a machine learning project: most of the time is spent understanding the problem, collecting and cleaning the data, designing a sound evaluation protocol and interpreting the results. A powerful model evaluated with a flawed protocol is worse than useless, since it gives a false sense of confidence.

This section is a practical guide to conduct a supervised learning study, from the formulation of the problem to the report of the results. It gathers advice that is scattered throughout the literature and that is usually learned the hard way. We illustrate some of the steps with short pieces of `Python` code using the `scikit-learn` library Pedregosa et al. (2011), but the principles do not depend on the software. As a running illustration, the reader may think of a fraud detection problem: predicting whether a banking transaction is fraudulent from its characteristics Dal Pozzolo et al. (2015); Metzler et al. (2018b).

About this section

In this section you will learn to:

- *frame a prediction problem and choose a performance measure before looking at the results;*
- *explore and preprocess the data (missing values, categorical features, scaling) without leaking information from the test set;*
- *split the data according to their structure (stratified, grouped or temporal) and evaluate a whole tuning procedure by nested cross-validation;*
- *handle imbalanced data with adapted measures, resampling, costs and decision thresholds;*
- *interpret a model, report its performance with its uncertainty and compare models with appropriate statistical tests.*

11.1 Framing the Problem and Choosing a Metric

Before any computation, the problem must be translated into a well-defined learning task. This requires answering a few questions with the people who will use the model.

- **What exactly do we predict, and for which unit?** A transaction, a customer, a day? Is it a classification task (fraudulent or not) or a regression task (amount of the loss)? Is the label reliable, and when is it known (a fraud may only be detected weeks later)?
- **Which information is available at prediction time?** A feature that is only known *after* the event we want to predict must not be used, even if it is present in the historical database (see Section 11.4).
- **What is the cost of the errors?** Missing a fraud (a false negative) and blocking a legitimate transaction (a false positive) do not have the same cost. These costs determine the performance measure and, as we will see, the decision threshold of the model.

- **What is a useful level of performance?** Comparing the model with the current solution (*e.g.* a set of expert rules) or with a trivial model tells us whether machine learning brings any value.

The choice of the **performance measure** follows from these answers, and it must be made *before* looking at the results, to avoid choosing the measure that makes our favorite model look good. The classical measures have been presented in Section 7.2: the accuracy is only meaningful when the classes are balanced and the errors have similar costs; otherwise, the precision, the recall, the F-measure, the area under the ROC or precision-recall curves, or an explicit cost are more appropriate. In regression, the choice between the mean squared error and the mean absolute error depends on how much large errors should be penalized.

11.2 Collecting and Exploring the Data

Machine learning assumes that the training data are representative of the data the model will face in production, *i.e.* that both are drawn from the same distribution $\mathcal{D}$. This assumption must be questioned from the start: was the sample collected in a biased way (*e.g.* only the transactions that were manually checked have a label)? Did the distribution change over time (new fraud patterns, a new version of a sensor)?

An **exploratory data analysis** then aims at understanding the data before modeling them. It typically includes:

- the size of the dataset and the type of each feature (numerical, categorical, ordinal, date, text), together with a description of what each feature means;
- the distribution of the target: proportion of each class, or histogram of the target value (a strong imbalance calls for the methods of Section 11.6);
- univariate summaries (mean, median, quantiles, number of distinct values) and plots of each feature, which reveal errors of encoding, impossible values or strong asymmetries;
- the proportion and the structure of the missing values, and the presence of duplicated examples;
- the relations between the features (correlation matrix, scatter plots) and between each feature and the target;
- the temporal or grouped structure of the data (several examples per customer, per patient, per day), which will matter when splitting the data.

Suspicious findings, such as a feature that predicts the target almost perfectly, must be investigated: they are more often the sign of a problem (*e.g.* a leakage) than of a miracle.

11.3 Preprocessing and Feature Engineering

Most algorithms expect a numerical matrix without missing values. Preprocessing transforms the raw data into such a matrix, and feature engineering tries to build a representation in which the task is easier to learn.

Missing values Removing the examples (or the features) with missing values is the simplest solution, but it wastes data and may bias the sample when the values are not missing at random (*e.g.* people with a high income may be less likely to report it). The most common alternative is *imputation*: replacing a missing value by the mean or the median of the feature (for numerical features), by its most frequent value (for categorical features), or by a value predicted from the other features (*e.g.* with a k-NN or a regression model). Since the fact that a value is missing can itself be informative, it is often useful to add a binary *missingness indicator* feature. Note that some algorithms, such as several implementations of gradient boosting, handle missing values natively.

Categorical features A categorical feature with q modalities is usually encoded with a *one-hot encoding*: it is replaced by q binary features, exactly one of which is equal to 1. Encoding the modalities by integers $1, \dots, q$ is only appropriate for ordinal features (*e.g.* a level of education), since it introduces an order and distances between the modalities. When q is very large (*e.g.* a zip code or a merchant identifier), one can group the rare modalities, or use a *target encoding*, which replaces each modality by the mean of the target over the examples having this modality; the latter must be computed on the training data only (and, ideally, out-of-fold), otherwise it leaks the label into the features.

Scaling Algorithms based on distances (k-NN, k-means, kernel methods), on gradient descent (neural networks) or on a penalty on the weights (ridge, lasso, SVM) are sensitive to the scale of the features. Decision trees and their ensembles are not, since their splits only depend on the order of the values.

Definition 11.1: Standardization

Let $\{\mathbf{x}_i\}_{i=1}^m$ be a training sample in $\mathbb{R}^d$. The standardization of a feature j transforms any value x_j (of a training or a new example) into

$$\tilde{x}_j = \frac{x_j - \hat{\mu}_j}{\hat{s}_j}, \quad \text{where} \quad \hat{\mu}_j = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m x_{ij} \quad \text{and} \quad \hat{s}_j^2 = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^m (x_{ij} - \hat{\mu}_j)^2$$

are estimated on the **training** sample only.

The standardized features have zero mean and unit variance on the training set. Another common choice is the *min-max* scaling, which maps each feature to $[0, 1]$ using its minimum and maximum on the training set. In the vocabulary of Section 10.4, standardizing the data before a k-NN is the same as using a Mahalanobis distance with a diagonal matrix $\mathbf{M}$ of entries $1/\hat{s}_j^2$; metric learning goes further by learning $\mathbf{M}$ from the labels.

Outliers Outliers can be detected with simple univariate rules (*e.g.* a value more than 1.5 interquartile ranges below the first quartile or above the third quartile) or with dedicated algorithms Breunig et al. (2000). They should not be removed blindly: an outlier may be an error of measurement, but it may also be the most interesting example of the dataset (a fraud is, by nature, an unusual transaction). Robust alternatives

consist in transforming the feature (*e.g.* with a logarithm), clipping extreme values, or using robust estimators (median and interquartile range instead of mean and standard deviation).

Feature engineering Knowledge of the domain is often the most effective way to improve a model. Typical transformations include applying a logarithm to a skewed positive feature (amounts, counts), extracting information from dates (hour, day of the week, time since the last event), computing ratios or interactions between features, and aggregating the history of an entity (*e.g.* the number of transactions of the card in the last hour, which is known to be very informative for fraud detection). Conversely, *feature selection* removes irrelevant or redundant features, which reduces the variance of the model and its cost. As always, every transformation whose parameters are estimated from the data must be estimated on the training set only.

11.4 Splitting the Data and Avoiding Leakage

The protocol of Section 7 splits the data into a training set, used to learn and tune the model (possibly with a cross-validation, see Figure 49), and a test set, used once at the end to estimate the generalization performance. This protocol is only valid if the test set mimics new, unseen data. The way the data are split must therefore respect their structure:

- in classification, the split is usually *stratified*, so that each set has the same class proportions (this is essential with imbalanced data);
- when several examples come from the same entity (a customer, a patient), all of them must belong to the same set (*group* split), otherwise the model is evaluated on entities it has already seen;
- when the data are ordered in time and the model will predict the future, the training set must precede the test set (*temporal* split); a random split would let the model use the future to predict the past.

Definition 11.2: Data leakage

There is a *data leakage* when information that would not be available at prediction time, in particular information about the test examples or about the target, is used to train or to select a model Kaufman et al. (2012).

A leakage leads to an optimistic estimate of the performance, which collapses once the model is deployed. Classical sources of leakage are:

- features that are consequences of the target (*e.g.* a "refund issued" flag to predict a fraud, or a treatment to predict a diagnosis);
- preprocessing parameters (means, variances, imputation values, selected features, target encodings) estimated on the whole dataset before splitting it;
- duplicated (or near-duplicated) examples present in both the training and the test sets, or a random split of grouped or temporal data;

- using the test set, even indirectly, to choose the model, the features or the hyper-parameters.

The simplest way to avoid the second kind of leakage is to gather all the steps of preprocessing and learning into a single object, a *pipeline*, which is fitted on the training data only and then applied, unchanged, to the test data. When a pipeline is evaluated by cross-validation, the preprocessing is re-fitted on the learning folds at each round, so that the validation fold never influences it.

```
from sklearn.pipeline import Pipeline
from sklearn.compose import ColumnTransformer
from sklearn.impute import SimpleImputer
from sklearn.preprocessing import StandardScaler, OneHotEncoder
from sklearn.linear_model import LogisticRegression
from sklearn.model_selection import train_test_split

num = Pipeline([("impute", SimpleImputer(strategy="median")),
                ("scale", StandardScaler())])
cat = Pipeline([("impute", SimpleImputer(strategy="most_frequent")),
                ("onehot", OneHotEncoder(handle_unknown="ignore"))])
prep = ColumnTransformer([("num", num, num_cols),
                          ("cat", cat, cat_cols)])
model = Pipeline([("prep", prep),
                  ("clf", LogisticRegression(max_iter=1000))])

X_train, X_test, y_train, y_test = train_test_split(
    X, y, test_size=0.3, stratify=y, random_state=0)
# imputation and scaling are fitted on X_train only
model.fit(X_train, y_train)
print(model.score(X_test, y_test))
```

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q11.1. A categorical feature has 5 modalities. How many binary features does its one-hot encoding create, and why is the encoding $1, \ldots, 5$ usually a bad idea?

Q11.2. True or false? The features must be standardized before learning a random forest.

Q11.3. A merchant identifier appears in a single training transaction, which is fraudulent. What is its target encoding computed on the training set, and why is it a problem?

Q11.4. Why can it be useful to add a binary feature indicating that a value was missing, in addition to imputing it?

11.5 Choosing, Tuning and Comparing Models

Start with baselines Any study should start with *baselines*: a trivial model (predicting the majority class, or the mean of the target in regression) and a simple, well-understood model (a regularized linear or logistic regression, a small decision tree).

They provide a reference: a complex model is only worth its cost if it clearly outperforms them. They also help detect bugs, *e.g.* a model that does not beat the trivial one on the training set. Then, more flexible models can be tried; for tabular data, ensembles of trees such as random forests and gradient boosting (Sections 10.2.1 and 10.3) are often very strong candidates.

Diagnosing a model Comparing the training and validation errors tells us in which regime we are (Section 10): a high training error indicates a large bias (under-fitting), and calls for a more flexible model or better features; a low training error with a much higher validation error indicates a large variance (over-fitting), and calls for more data, more regularization or an ensemble method. Plotting these errors as a function of the size of the training set (*learning curves*) tells us whether collecting more data would help.

Hyper-parameter search The hyper-parameters are chosen by cross-validation, as explained in Section 7. The candidate values can be explored in two main ways.

- **Grid search** evaluates all the combinations of a finite set of values for each hyper-parameter. Its cost grows exponentially with the number of hyper-parameters.
- **Random search** evaluates a fixed number of combinations drawn at random from given distributions (*e.g.* a log-uniform distribution for a regularization constant). For the same budget, it is often more efficient than a grid search Bergstra and Bengio (2012): when only a few hyper-parameters really matter, a grid of n^2 points only tests n distinct values of each of them, whereas n^2 random points test n^2 distinct values of each of them.

More sophisticated strategies, such as Bayesian optimization, build a model of the validation score as a function of the hyper-parameters to choose the next candidates, and are useful when each evaluation is expensive.

Nested cross-validation A subtle but important point is that the best cross-validation score obtained during the search is *not* an unbiased estimate of the performance of the selected model: by selecting the maximum of many noisy scores, we select, in part, the noise Cawley and Talbot (2010); Varma and Simon (2006).

Proposition 11.1: Optimism of the selected score

Let $\hat{s}_1, \dots, \hat{s}_K$ be unbiased estimates of the true performances $s_1, \dots, s_K$ of K candidate models, *i.e.* $\mathbb{E}[\hat{s}_k] = s_k$ for all k. Then

$$\mathbb{E}\left[\max_k \hat{s}_k\right] \geq \max_k s_k.$$

Proof. For all k, we have $\max_{k'} \hat{s}_{k'} \geq \hat{s}_k$, hence $\mathbb{E}[\max_{k'} \hat{s}_{k'}] \geq \mathbb{E}[\hat{s}_k] = s_k$. Taking the maximum over k of the right-hand side gives the result. □

The inequality is usually strict, and the bias increases with the number of candidates and with the variance of the estimates (small datasets). This is why the final

performance must be measured on data that played no role in the selection: either a separate test set, or, when data are scarce, a **nested cross-validation**. In a nested cross-validation, an *outer* cross-validation estimates the performance, and, within each outer training set, an *inner* cross-validation selects the hyper-parameters (Figure 104). The outer validation folds are thus never used for the selection.

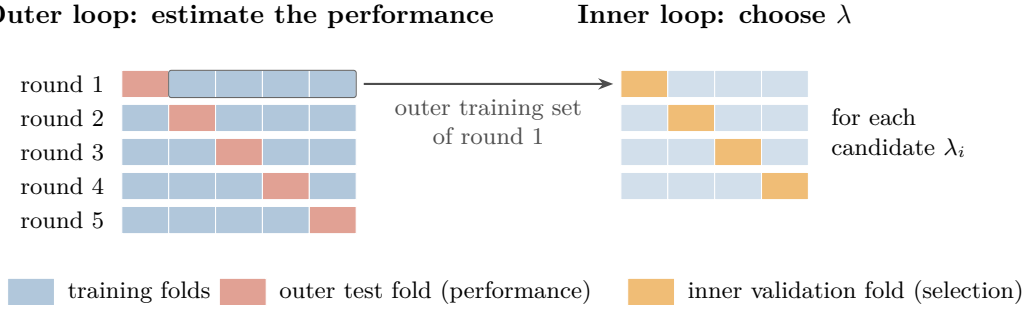


Figure 104: Nested 5×4-fold cross-validation. In each outer round, the four blue folds form the outer training set: an inner 4-fold cross-validation run on them chooses the hyper-parameter λ, a model is refitted on them with this value, and it is scored on the red outer test fold. The red folds never take part in the selection, so the average of the five outer scores estimates the performance of the whole procedure (search included).

Note that nested cross-validation evaluates the *whole procedure* (search included); the final model is then obtained by running the search on all the data.

```
from sklearn.model_selection import (GridSearchCV, StratifiedKFold,
                                     cross_val_score)
inner = StratifiedKFold(n_splits=5, shuffle=True, random_state=1)
outer = StratifiedKFold(n_splits=5, shuffle=True, random_state=2)
search = GridSearchCV(model, {"clf__C": [0.01, 0.1, 1, 10, 100]},
                      cv=inner, scoring="f1")
scores = cross_val_score(search, X_train, y_train, cv=outer,
                         scoring="f1")
print(scores.mean(), scores.std())
```

The same reasoning applies to ensembles: the base learners of a stacking model (Section 10.2.3) can be tuned in an inner loop, while the meta-model is learned on out-of-fold predictions.

11.6 Learning from Imbalanced Data

In many applications, such as fraud detection, medical diagnosis or anomaly detection, the class of interest (the *positive* or *minority* class) is much rarer than the other one: the *imbalance ratio* between the majority and the minority classes can reach 100 or 1000. In this case, a classifier that always predicts the majority class has an excellent accuracy but is useless, and most learning algorithms, which minimize a surrogate of the error rate, tend to neglect the minority class Lopez et al. (2013). Learning from imbalanced data has been an active research topic for more than twenty years, to which the author of these notes has contributed Metzler et al. (2018a,b); Viola et al. (2019); Bascol et al. (2019). The approaches can be grouped into three families.

Adapted performance measures The first step is to use a measure that focuses on the minority class (Section 7.2): the recall, the precision, the F-measure, the area under the precision-recall curve, or the balanced accuracy (the mean of the recalls of the two classes). The area under the ROC curve Metz (1978); Cortes and Mohri (2004) is insensitive to the imbalance, which can make it over-optimistic when the positive class is very rare.

Data-level methods: resampling These methods modify the training set to balance the classes, and can be used with any algorithm Batista et al. (2003). *Random undersampling* removes examples of the majority class; it is fast but discards information. *Random oversampling* duplicates examples of the minority class; it keeps all the information but tends to over-fit the duplicated points. The SMOTE algorithm Chawla et al. (2002) (Synthetic Minority Over-sampling TEchnique) generates instead *new* synthetic minority examples: for a minority example $\mathbf{x}_i$, it draws one of its k nearest minority neighbors $\mathbf{x}_{nn}$ and creates

$$\mathbf{x}_{\text{new}} = \mathbf{x}_i + u\,(\mathbf{x}_{nn} - \mathbf{x}_i), \quad \text{with} \quad u \sim \mathcal{U}([0,1]),$$

i.e. a random point on the segment joining $\mathbf{x}_i$ and $\mathbf{x}_{nn}$ (Figure 105). Many variants exist, focusing on the examples close to the decision boundary (Borderline-SMOTE Han et al. (2005)) or on the hardest examples (ADASYN He et al. (2008)), or combining oversampling with the removal of ambiguous pairs of examples (Tomek links Tomek (1976)); see Fernández et al. (2018) for a review. These methods are implemented in the `imbalanced-learn` library Lemaître et al. (2017). Resampling can also be combined with ensemble methods, as in SMOTEBoost Chawla et al. (2003); see Galar et al. (2012) for a review.

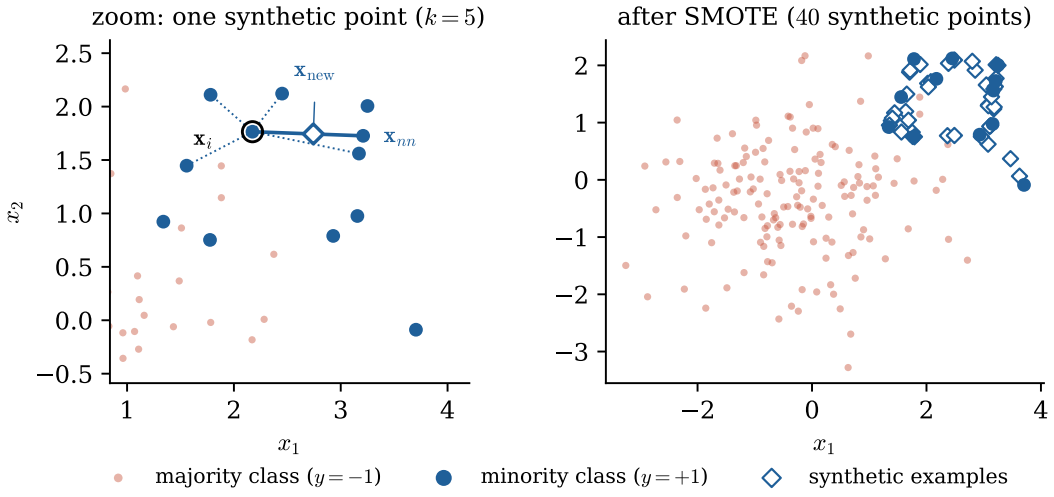


Figure 105: The SMOTE algorithm. Left: a synthetic example $\mathbf{x}_{\text{new}}$ is drawn at random on the segment joining a minority example $\mathbf{x}_i$ (circled) and one of its $k = 5$ nearest minority neighbors (dotted segments), here $\mathbf{x}_{nn}$. Right: 40 synthetic examples generated in this way; they fill the region spanned by the minority class, but never leave it.

> **Pitfall** Resampling must only be applied to the **training** data (and, within a cross-validation, only to the learning folds). Oversampling before splitting puts

copies, or interpolations, of the same minority examples in both the training and the validation sets: this is a leakage, which leads to very optimistic estimates. The validation and test sets must keep the true class proportions.

```
from imblearn.pipeline import Pipeline as ImbPipeline
from imblearn.over_sampling import SMOTE
from sklearn.ensemble import RandomForestClassifier
model = ImbPipeline([("prep", prep),
                     ("smote", SMOTE(k_neighbors=5)),
                     ("clf", RandomForestClassifier())])
# the sampler is only applied when fitting (learning folds)
scores = cross_val_score(model, X_train, y_train, cv=outer,
                         scoring="f1")
```

Algorithm-level methods: costs and thresholds Instead of modifying the data, we can modify the learning algorithm so that errors on the minority class cost more. This is the principle of *cost-sensitive learning* Elkan (2001); López et al. (2012). The following result, which follows directly from the definition of the Bayes classifier, shows that costs essentially move the decision threshold.

Proposition 11.2: Optimal decision with asymmetric costs Elkan (2001)

Let $\eta(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbb{P}(Y = 1 \mid \mathbf{x})$, and let $c_{FN} > 0$ (resp. $c_{FP} > 0$) be the cost of predicting 0 for a positive example (resp. 1 for a negative example), correct predictions having no cost. Then the classifier minimizing the expected cost predicts 1 if and only if

$$\eta(\mathbf{x}) \geq \frac{c_{FP}}{c_{FP} + c_{FN}}.$$

Proof. At a given $\mathbf{x}$, predicting 1 has an expected cost $(1 - \eta(\mathbf{x}))\, c_{FP}$, while predicting 0 has an expected cost $\eta(\mathbf{x})\, c_{FN}$. Predicting 1 is optimal if and only if $(1 - \eta(\mathbf{x}))\, c_{FP} \leq \eta(\mathbf{x})\, c_{FN}$, *i.e.* $\eta(\mathbf{x})\,(c_{FP} + c_{FN}) \geq c_{FP}$. □

With equal costs, we recover the usual threshold 1/2. With $c_{FN} = 9\, c_{FP}$, a transaction should be flagged as soon as its probability of being fraudulent exceeds 0.1 (Figure 106).

In practice, costs can be taken into account in three ways: by weighting the examples of each class in the loss function (the `class_weight` option of many `scikit-learn` models), by learning a model that estimates $\eta(\mathbf{x})$ and then moving the threshold, or by designing cost-sensitive versions of the algorithms, *e.g.* of decision trees Ling et al. (2006); Metzler et al. (2018b) or boosting Fan et al. (1999). Moving the threshold requires reasonably calibrated probabilities; note that resampling distorts the predicted probabilities, since it changes the class proportions seen during training.

When the target measure is not a cost but, *e.g.*, the F-measure, the optimal classifier is still a threshold on $\eta(\mathbf{x})$, but the optimal threshold depends on the distribution Koyejo et al. (2014); Narasimhan et al. (2015). The threshold (or, equivalently, the costs) is then tuned on validation data, and the F-measure can be optimized through

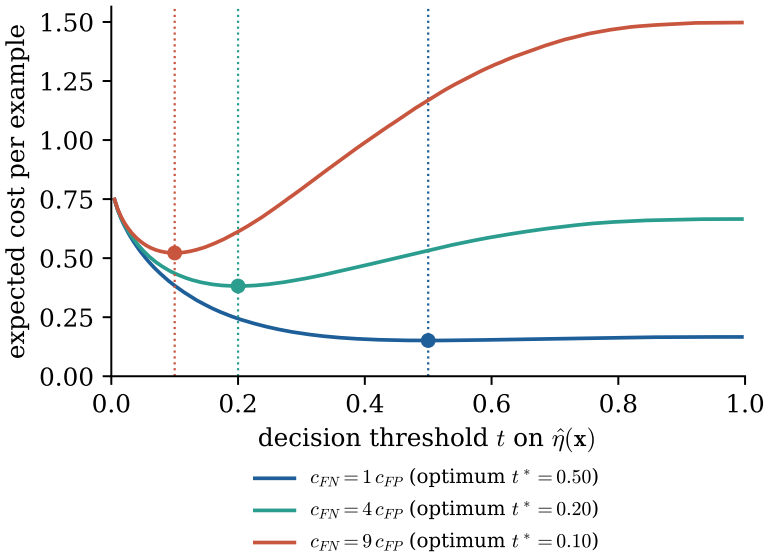


Figure 106: Expected cost per example of the classifier "predict 1 if $\eta(\mathbf{x}) \geq t$" as a function of the threshold t, for $c_{FP} = 1$ and three values of c_{FN} (the probabilities $\eta(\mathbf{x})$ follow a Beta$(0.6, 3)$ distribution, *i.e.* about 17% of positives). The minimum is reached at $t^* = c_{FP}/(c_{FP} + c_{FN})$, as stated by Proposition 11.2: the more costly the false negatives, the lower the threshold.

a sequence of cost-sensitive problems Parambath et al. (2014); Bascol et al. (2019). In all cases, the threshold is a hyper-parameter and must be tuned without using the test set.

11.7 Interpreting a Model

A model with a good performance is not always sufficient: users, regulators or domain experts want to understand *why* it makes a given decision, and interpretation tools are also very effective to detect leakages or spurious correlations. We distinguish *global* explanations, which describe the behavior of the model as a whole (which features matter?), from *local* explanations, which explain a single prediction (why was this transaction flagged?).

Interpretable models Some models are interpretable by design: the coefficients of a linear or logistic regression (provided the features are standardized, so that the coefficients are comparable), or a small decision tree, whose decision can be read as a set of rules. For ensembles, the impurity-based importance of the features of a random forest (Section 10.2.1) gives a first global view, but it is computed on the training data and it favors features with many possible split values.

Permutation importance A model-agnostic alternative, introduced with random forests Breiman (2001), consists in measuring how much the performance of the model degrades when the information carried by a feature is destroyed.

Definition 11.3: Permutation importance

Let h be a trained model, s a performance measure and V a validation (or test) set. For a feature j and a random permutation π of the examples of V, let $V^{(j,\pi)}$ be the set V in which the values of the j-th feature have been permuted according to π (the other features and the labels being unchanged). The permutation importance of the feature j is

$$I_j = s(h, V) - \frac{1}{R}\sum_{r=1}^{R} s\left(h, V^{(j,\pi_r)}\right),$$

where $\pi_1, \ldots, \pi_R$ are R independent random permutations.

Permuting a feature breaks its relation with the target while keeping its marginal distribution. A large drop of performance means that the model relies heavily on the feature. The measure is computed on held-out data and applies to any model (`sklearn.inspection.permutation_importance`). Its main limitation concerns correlated features: when two features carry the same information, permuting one of them barely changes the performance, and both may appear unimportant.

SHAP values To explain an individual prediction $h(\mathbf{x})$, the SHAP method Lundberg and Lee (2017) borrows the Shapley value from cooperative game theory: the features are seen as players who cooperate to produce the prediction, and each feature receives its fair share of the "gain" $h(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{X})]$. Denoting by $F = \{1, \ldots, d\}$ the set of features and by $v_{\mathbf{x}}(A)$ the expected prediction when only the features of $A \subseteq F$ are known (*e.g.* $v_{\mathbf{x}}(A) = \mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{X}) \mid \mathbf{X}_A = \mathbf{x}_A]$), the contribution of the feature j is

$$\phi_j(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_{A \subseteq F \setminus \{j\}} \frac{|A|!\,(d - |A| - 1)!}{d!}\Big(v_{\mathbf{x}}(A \cup \{j\}) - v_{\mathbf{x}}(A)\Big),$$

i.e. the average, over all the orders in which the features can be added, of the marginal contribution of j. These contributions are additive: $h(\mathbf{x}) = \phi_0 + \sum_{j=1}^{d} \phi_j(\mathbf{x})$, with $\phi_0 = \mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{X})]$. The exact computation is exponential in d, so SHAP relies on approximations, and on an exact polynomial algorithm for tree ensembles. Averaging $|\phi_j(\mathbf{x})|$ over a dataset also gives a global importance measure.

Remark Explanations describe the *model*, not the world: a feature can be important for the model because it is correlated with the true cause, and an explanation does not imply causality. Moreover, different explanation methods may disagree, especially in the presence of correlated features.

11.8 Reproducibility and Reporting

A result that cannot be reproduced cannot be trusted. Reproducibility requires fixing the random seeds (of the splits, of the algorithms, of the resampling), recording the versions of the software and of the data, keeping the code of the whole pipeline (from the raw data to the figures), and saving the splits that were used.

Uncertainty of the results A performance measured on a finite test set is a random quantity, and it should always be reported with an estimate of its uncertainty: the standard deviation over the folds of a cross-validation or over several runs with different seeds, or a confidence interval. For the accuracy $\hat{p}$ measured on n independent test examples, the normal approximation of the binomial distribution gives the 95% confidence interval

$$\hat{p} \pm 1.96\sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})}{n}}.$$

Example 11.1. A model correctly classifies 850 of the $n = 1000$ examples of a test set, so $\hat{p} = 0.85$ and $\sqrt{0.85 \times 0.15/1000} \simeq 0.0113$. The 95% confidence interval is approximately [0.828, 0.872]. A second model reaching 0.86 on the same test set is therefore not obviously better: the difference is well within the uncertainty of each estimate. Since both models are evaluated on the same examples, a *paired* test, such as McNemar's test below, is needed to conclude.

Comparing two models To compare two classifiers A and B on the same test set, McNemar's test only looks at the examples on which they disagree: let n_{01} be the number of test examples misclassified by A but not by B, and n_{10} the number of examples misclassified by B but not by A. Under the null hypothesis that both classifiers have the same error rate, the statistic

$$\chi^2 = \frac{(|n_{01} - n_{10}| - 1)^2}{n_{01} + n_{10}}$$

approximately follows a χ^2 distribution with one degree of freedom, and the null hypothesis is rejected at the 5% level when $\chi^2 > 3.84$. Dietterich Dietterich (1998) showed that this test has a low type I error, and recommended it (or a 5×2 cross-validated t-test when the algorithms can be re-trained several times). On the contrary, a standard paired t-test on the scores of a k-fold cross-validation should be avoided: the training sets of the different folds overlap, so the scores are not independent and the variance is underestimated, which leads to too many false discoveries. To compare several algorithms over several datasets, Demšar Demšar (2006) recommends non-parametric tests based on ranks: the Wilcoxon signed-rank test for two algorithms, and the Friedman test followed by a post-hoc Nemenyi test for more than two.

Reporting A good report describes the data (origin, size, class proportions), the preprocessing, the splitting protocol, the performance measures and why they were chosen, the searched hyper-parameter ranges, the baselines, the results with their uncertainty, and the limitations of the study (possible biases of the data, conditions under which the model should not be used). Negative results, such as a sophisticated model that does not beat a simple baseline, are also informative and deserve to be reported.

Exercises

Exercise 11.1. **(Comprehension)** For each of the following protocols, say whether there is a data leakage, and if so, how to fix it. (a) To predict whether a customer will cancel their subscription next month, the feature "number of calls to the cancellation service during the last 60 days" is computed at the date of extraction of the database. (b) The missing values of a feature are replaced by its median over the whole dataset, which is then split into a training and a test set. (c) A dataset of 10 000 chest X-rays of 3 000 patients is split at random, image by image, into a training and a test set. (d) Several models are compared by 5-fold cross-validation on the training set, and the best one is evaluated once on the test set. (e) A stock price is predicted from the prices of the previous days, with a 10-fold cross-validation using shuffled folds.

Exercise 11.2. **(Computation)** A feature takes the values $2, 4, 4, 4, 5, 5, 7, 9$ on the training set. (a) Compute $\hat{\mu}$ and $\hat{s}$ (Definition 11.1) and the standardized value of a test example equal to 11. (b) Compute the min-max scaled value of the same test example. What do you notice? (c) Same question as (a) if, by mistake, the mean and the standard deviation are computed on the training set *and* the test example. Comment.

Exercise 11.3. **(Computation)** The training set of a fraud detection problem contains 8 transactions, described by a merchant (A, B or C) and labeled 1 (fraud) or 0:

merchant	A	A	A	A	B	B	B	C
label	1	0	0	0	1	1	0	1

(a) Give the one-hot encoding of the merchant. (b) Compute the target encoding of each merchant on the training set. Which value does it give to merchant C, and why is it dangerous? (c) Compute the *leave-one-out* target encoding, in which each transaction is encoded by the mean label of the *other* transactions of the same merchant (merchant C being encoded by the global mean). Show that, within merchant A, this encoding reveals the label. What does this suggest? (d) A smoothed encoding replaces the mean $\bar{y}_c$ of a modality c with n_c examples by $\dfrac{n_c\,\bar{y}_c + a\,\bar{y}}{n_c + a}$, where $\bar{y}$ is the global mean. Compute it with $a = 2$ and comment.

Exercise 11.4. **(Computation)** A model has two hyper-parameters, of which only the first one really matters, and the budget is 100 evaluations. (a) How many distinct values of the first hyper-parameter are tested by a 10×10 grid? By 100 random points drawn from a continuous distribution? (b) We call "good" the configurations whose validation score is in the top 5% of the search space (for the distribution used by the random search). What is the probability that at least one of n independent random configurations is good? Compute it for $n = 60$, and find the smallest n for which it exceeds 95%. (c) With a 5-fold cross-validation, how many models are learned for $n = 60$?

Exercise 11.5. **(Proof)** K candidate models have the same true performance s, and their validation scores are $\hat{s}_k = s + \sigma Z_k$, where $Z_1, \dots, Z_K$ are independent $\mathcal{N}(0,1)$ random variables. (a) For $K = 2$, show that $\mathbb{E}[\max(\hat{s}_1, \hat{s}_2)] = s + \sigma/\sqrt{\pi}$. *Hint:* $\max(a,b) = \frac{a+b}{2} + \frac{|a-b|}{2}$ and $\mathbb{E}\,|N| = \tau\sqrt{2/\pi}$ for $N \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \tau^2)$. (b) Show that, for any K and any $\lambda > 0$, $\mathbb{E}[\max_k Z_k] \le \frac{1}{\lambda} \ln \mathbb{E}\left[\sum_k e^{\lambda Z_k}\right]$, and deduce that $\mathbb{E}[\max_k \hat{s}_k] \le s + \sigma\sqrt{2 \ln K}$. *Hint:* use Jensen's inequality (Proposition 1.3) and $\mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda Z}] = e^{\lambda^2/2}$. (c) The scores are accuracies measured on 500 validation examples, with $s \approx 0.8$. Estimate σ, and the optimism of the selected score for $K = 2$ and for $K = 100$ (for which $\mathbb{E}[\max_k Z_k] \approx 2.51$).

Exercise 11.6. **(Proof)** We generalize Proposition 11.2 to a cost matrix in which correct predictions may also have a cost: c_{TP}, c_{FN}, c_{FP} and c_{TN}, with $c_{FN} > c_{TP}$ and $c_{FP} > c_{TN}$. (a) Show that the classifier minimizing the expected cost predicts 1 if and only if $\eta(\mathbf{x}) \ge \dfrac{c_{FP} - c_{TN}}{(c_{FP} - c_{TN}) + (c_{FN} - c_{TP})}$. (b) A bank checks manually every flagged transaction, at a cost of 5 euros, whether it is fraudulent or not; an undetected fraud costs 200 euros on average; a

legitimate transaction that is not flagged costs nothing. Compute the optimal threshold. (c) Four transactions have the calibrated probabilities of fraud 0.01, 0.03, 0.2 and 0.6. Which ones are flagged, and what is the expected cost of the decision for each of them?

Exercise 11.7. **(Proof)** Let $\pi = \mathbb{P}(Y = 1)$ and p_+, p_- be the densities of $\mathbf{X}$ given $Y = 1$ and $Y = -1$. A random resampling of each class (oversampling of the positives or undersampling of the negatives) changes the proportion of positives into π', but not p_+ and p_-. (a) Using Bayes' formula, show that $\dfrac{\eta(\mathbf{x})}{1-\eta(\mathbf{x})} = \dfrac{\pi\, p_+(\mathbf{x})}{(1-\pi)\, p_-(\mathbf{x})}$. Deduce that the probability $\eta'(\mathbf{x})$ estimated on the resampled data satisfies

$$\frac{\eta'(\mathbf{x})}{1-\eta'(\mathbf{x})} = \kappa \frac{\eta(\mathbf{x})}{1-\eta(\mathbf{x})}, \qquad \text{with} \quad \kappa = \frac{\pi'(1-\pi)}{(1-\pi')\,\pi}.$$

(b) The positives represent 1% of the data, and the training set has been resampled to be balanced. A model learned on it predicts $\eta'(\mathbf{x}) = 0.8$. What is the corrected probability $\eta(\mathbf{x})$? (c) Show that the threshold $1/2$ on η' corresponds to the threshold $1/(1+\kappa)$ on η. Using Proposition 11.2, interpret the classifier "balance the classes, then predict the most probable class" as a cost-sensitive classifier.

Exercise 11.8. **(Computation)** (a) A classifier correctly classifies 460 of the $n = 500$ examples of a test set. Give a 95% confidence interval for its accuracy using the normal approximation. (b) How many test examples are needed for the half-width of this interval to be at most 0.01, if the accuracy is around 0.9? (c) Using Hoeffding's inequality (Proposition 1.14 in Section 1), how many test examples guarantee that $|\hat{p} - p| \leq 0.01$ with probability at least 0.95, whatever p? Compare with (b) and explain the difference.

Exercise 11.9. **(Computation)** Two classifiers A and B are evaluated on the same 1000 test examples. (a) A misclassifies 30 examples that B classifies correctly, and B misclassifies 15 examples that A classifies correctly. Can we conclude, at the 5% level, that their error rates differ? (b) Same question with 12 and 6. (c) Why does McNemar's test ignore the examples on which both classifiers are right, or both are wrong?

Exercise 11.10. **(Computation)** Let X_1 and X_2 be independent $\mathcal{N}(0,1)$ features, and let the label be $Y = \mathbb{1}[X_1 > 0]$ (no noise). We use the accuracy as performance measure, on a very large validation set (so that empirical frequencies can be replaced by probabilities). (a) The model is $h(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbb{1}[x_1 > 0]$. Compute the permutation importances of X_1 and of X_2. (b) A third feature $X_3 = X_1$ (an exact copy) is added, and the learned model is $h'(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbb{1}[x_1 + x_3 > 0]$. Show that, after the permutation of X_1 only, the accuracy is 3/4. Deduce the permutation importances of X_1 and X_3, and comment.

Exercise 11.11. **(Proof)** Let $h(\mathbf{x}) = w_0 + \sum_{j=1}^{d} w_j x_j$ be a linear model, and assume that the features $X_1, \ldots, X_d$ are independent, with means $\mu_1, \ldots, \mu_d$. We use $v_{\mathbf{x}}(A) = \mathbb{E}[h(\mathbf{X}) \mid \mathbf{X}_A = \mathbf{x}_A]$. (a) Compute $v_{\mathbf{x}}(A)$ for any $A \subseteq F$. (b) For $d = 2$, write $\phi_1(\mathbf{x})$ explicitly (two terms) and show that $\phi_1(\mathbf{x}) = w_1(x_1 - \mu_1)$. (c) Show that, for any d, $\phi_j(\mathbf{x}) = w_j(x_j - \mu_j)$, and check the additivity property.

Exercise 11.12. **(Application)** A hospital wants to predict, at the discharge of a patient, whether they will be readmitted within 30 days. The database contains 50 000 stays of 20 000 patients between 2015 and 2023, and 8% of the stays are followed by a readmission. Among the available features are the age, the diagnoses, the length of the stay, the number of previous stays, and the "number of days until the next stay". (a) Which feature must be removed, and why? (b) How would you split the data into a training and a test set? Justify. (c) Which performance measure(s) would you use? What is the accuracy of the trivial classifier? (d) Describe a complete protocol to choose between a regularized logistic regression and a gradient boosting model, including the tuning of their hyper-parameters and of the decision threshold. (e) The final model reaches an AUC of 0.74 on the test set. What else should be reported?

Exercise 11.13. **(Python)** Simulate a dataset of 40 patients with 10 examples each: each patient

has a random "signature" $\mathbf{s}_p \in \mathbb{R}^5$ and a random label $y_p \in \{0, 1\}$, and each of their examples is $\mathbf{s}_p$ plus a small Gaussian noise, with the label y_p. The labels are thus unrelated to any general property of the features. Estimate the accuracy of a random forest by 5-fold cross-validation with (a) a random split of the examples, (b) a split by patient (`GroupKFold`). Explain the results.

Part IV

PAC-Bayesian Learning: a Theoretical Framework for Ensemble Methods

Most ensemble methods of Part III such as bagging, random forests, boosting, stacking, and even kernel machines with random features, output a *weighted majority vote*, that is, a probability distribution over a set of base classifiers. This last part presents *PAC-Bayesian theory*, a framework whose object of study is precisely such a distribution. It provides a natural language to (i) derive tight, often *non-vacuous*, generalization guarantees for ensembles, (ii) understand the role of the *diversity* of the voters, and (iii) design *self-bounding* learning algorithms, which minimize a generalization bound instead of an empirical risk and come with a risk certificate for free.

Section 12 explains why ensembles call for a dedicated theory and introduces the PAC-Bayesian principle; Section 13 gathers the mathematical tools (concentration inequalities, the Kullback–Leibler divergence and the change of measure inequality). Section 14 build the PAC-Bayesian bounds on the risk of the Gibbs classifier and discuss the choice of the prior and the posterior; 16 goes from the Gibbs classifier to the majority vote, where the diversity of the voters appears. Sections 17 and 18 turn the bounds into learning objectives (self-bounding learning), and Section 19 is a reading guide towards current research. The dependencies between these sections are shown in Fig. 107; a first reading can follow the path 12–13–14–16–17.

Accompanying material. Five Python notebooks, a tutorial sheet, a practical session in four sessions of three hours and a project accompany this part on the course webpage. For a first reading of the literature, we recommend Alquier (2024), Guedj (2019) and Langford (2005); the majority-vote and self-bounding points of view follow mainly Germain et al. (2015), Masegosa et al. (2020) and Viallard et al. (2021).

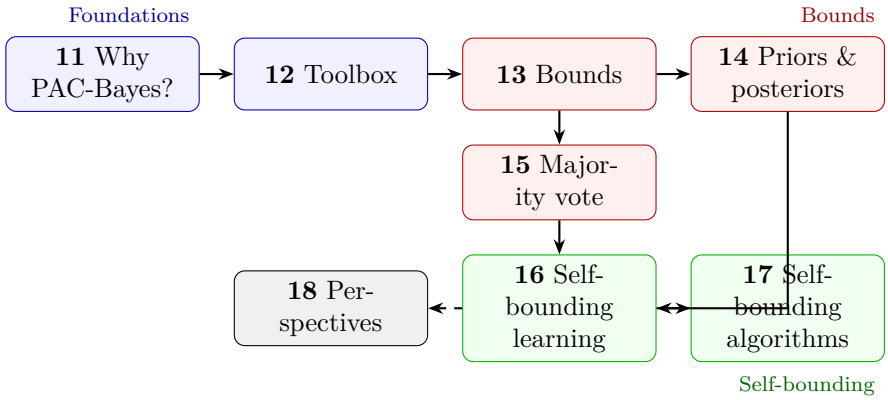


Figure 107: Dependencies between the sections of Part IV. Blue: foundations; red: PAC-Bayesian bounds; green: self-bounding learning.

Table 7: Notation of Part IV.

$\mathcal{X}$, $\mathcal{Y} = \{-1, +1\}$	input space, (binary) output space
$\mathcal{D}$	unknown data distribution on $\mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{Y}$
$S = \{(x_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m \sim \mathcal{D}^m$	learning sample of m i.i.d. examples
$\mathcal{H}$	set of *voters* (base classifiers) $h : \mathcal{X} \to \{-1, +1\}$ (or $[-1, 1]$)
ℓ	loss function, $\ell(h, (x, y)) \in [0, 1]$; by default the 0-1 loss $\mathbb{1}[h(x) \neq y]$
$R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)$, $\widehat{R}_S(h)$	true risk and empirical risk of h
$\mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$	set of probability distributions on $\mathcal{H}$
P, $Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$	*prior* (chosen before seeing S) and *posterior* (chosen after)
$\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$	Kullback–Leibler divergence $\mathbb{E}_{h\sim Q}\left[\ln \frac{Q(h)}{P(h)}\right]$
$\mathrm{kl}(q\|p)$, $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}$, $\underline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}$	binary KL divergence and its upper / lower inverses
G_Q, B_Q	Gibbs (stochastic) classifier and Q-weighted majority vote
$W_Q(x, y)$, $M_Q(x, y)$	weight of the erring voters and margin $1 - 2W_Q$
$e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$, $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$	joint error (tandem loss) and disagreement of the voters
$\delta \in (0, 1]$	confidence: bounds hold with probability $\geq 1 - \delta$ over S

12 Why PAC-Bayes for ensemble methods?

About this section

Guiding question. *Why is a vote of mediocre classifiers so good, and can we guarantee its accuracy without a test set?*

We start from where Part III stopped: averaging models reduces their variance, and the Rademacher bound controls the generalization of one model. We then move to classification, observe that all the ensemble methods of Part III: bagging, random forests, boosting, stacking, and even kernel machines, produce the same object, a probability distribution over base classifiers used to vote, and explain why the bounds seen so far say little about such votes. We finally introduce the three ingredients of PAC-Bayesian theory: a prior, a posterior, and a bound that holds for every posterior. A short history and a map of this part close the section.

12.1 Where we left Part III

Before introducing anything new, let us recall the two results of Parts II and III that motivate this part: why averaging models helps, and how we measured the generalization of a model. The notation is that of Section 10: a sample $S = \{(x_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ of m examples, models $h_1, \dots, h_T$, and their combination H_T.

Averaging reduces the variance. In regression, we observed that polynomials of high degree learned on different samples are very different from each other, whereas their average is stable (left panel of Fig. 108). The explanation is a short computation. Write $h_t(x) = f(x) + \varepsilon_t(x)$, where f is the target function and $\varepsilon_t(x)$ the error of the t-th model, and assume that the errors are centred, with the same variance σ^2 and the same correlation ρ between two different models. The squared error of the average $H_T = \frac{1}{T}\sum_t h_t$ is then

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathbb{E}\big[(H_T(x) - f(x))^2\big] &= \mathbb{E}\left[\Big(\frac{1}{T}\sum_{t=1}^{T}\varepsilon_t(x)\Big)^2\right] \\
&\quad\downarrow \text{ we develop the square} \\
&= \frac{1}{T^2}\sum_{t=1}^{T}\mathbb{E}\big[\varepsilon_t(x)^2\big] + \frac{1}{T^2}\sum_{t\neq t'}\mathbb{E}\big[\varepsilon_t(x)\varepsilon_{t'}(x)\big] \\
&\quad\downarrow \text{ } T \text{ variances } \sigma^2 \text{ and } T(T-1) \text{ covariances } \rho\sigma^2 \\
&= \frac{T\sigma^2 + T(T-1)\rho\sigma^2}{T^2} = \underbrace{\rho\,\sigma^2}_{\text{shared error}} + \underbrace{\frac{(1-\rho)\,\sigma^2}{T}}_{\text{averaged out}}.
\end{aligned} \tag{12.1}$$

When the errors are uncorrelated ($\rho = 0$), averaging T models divides the error of a single model by T: this is the computation of Section 10.2.1, and the reason why the bias–variance decomposition (Geman et al., 1992; Hastie et al., 2009) is the classical language of ensemble methods (Breiman, 1996b; Zhou, 2012). When they are correlated, only the part $(1-\rho)\sigma^2$ of the error that the models do *not* share is averaged out, and the error of the average cannot go below $\rho\sigma^2$, however many models we add (right panel of Fig. 108). Two lessons are worth keeping. First, the gain of an ensemble comes

from the *diversity* of its members: identical models ($\rho = 1$) gain nothing. This is why bagging and random forests inject randomness in the construction of the trees. Second, for the squared loss the average is never worse than its members on average, since by Jensen's inequality (Proposition 1.3) $\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_t \varepsilon_t\right)^2 \le \frac{1}{T}\sum_t \varepsilon_t^2$. The gap in this inequality, $\frac{1}{T}\sum_t(\varepsilon_t - \bar{\varepsilon})^2$, is the *ambiguity* of the ensemble (Krogh and Vedelsby, 1995); Wood et al. (2023) have recently shown that such exact bias–variance–*diversity* decompositions hold for other losses (cross-entropy, Poisson), and that diversity is a quantity to be traded off, not blindly maximized.

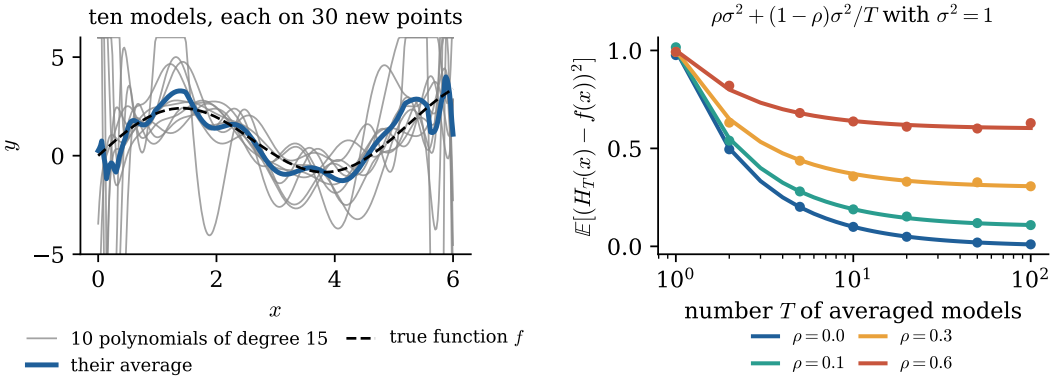


Figure 108: Averaging reduces the variance (regression). Left: ten polynomials of degree 15, each fitted on a new sample of 30 points, and their average; the experiment of Section 10.2.1. Right: error of the average of T models whose errors have variance $\sigma^2 = 1$ and correlation ρ; curves: formula (12.1), dots: simulation.

What changes in classification. In classification, the models are classifiers $h_t : \mathcal{X} \to \{-1, +1\}$ and they are combined by a vote, $H_T(x) = \text{sign}\left(\frac{1}{T}\sum_t h_t(x)\right)$. The computation above does not apply any more, because the 0-1 loss is not the squared loss, and the picture changes in two ways. The good news is that a vote can be *much* better than its voters: it only errs on a point when at least half of the voters err on it simultaneously. If the voters err independently with probability 0.3, the vote of 101 of them almost never errs (Fig. 109, left). The bad news is that this requires diverse voters even more than in regression: as soon as their errors are correlated, they pile up on the same points and the vote keeps a large part of the error of a single voter. The right panel of Fig. 109 shows why: the *average* fraction of erring voters is always 0.3, but only its *spread* decides how often it exceeds $\frac{1}{2}$. A vote can even be worse than its average voter — by a factor at most 2, as we will prove in Section 16.

How we measured generalization. Sections 6 and 10 also studied the gap between the empirical risk $R_S(h)$ of a model and its true risk $R(h)$. We decomposed the excess risk into an approximation error, due to the choice of the class $\mathcal{H}$, and an estimation error, and we bounded the latter with the *Rademacher complexity* of the class (Koltchinskii and Panchenko, 2000b; Bartlett and Mendelson, 2003): with probability at least $1 - \delta$, for all $h \in \mathcal{H}$, $R(h) \le R_S(h) + 2\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H}) + \sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)/(2m)}$ (Theorem 10.2). For boosting, we proved in Section 10.2.2 that the *training* error of AdaBoost decreases exponentially fast, $R_S(H_T) \le e^{-2\gamma^2 T}$ when every weak learner has an edge γ over random guessing (Freund and Schapire, 1997; Schapire and Freund, 2012). Section 10 ended on

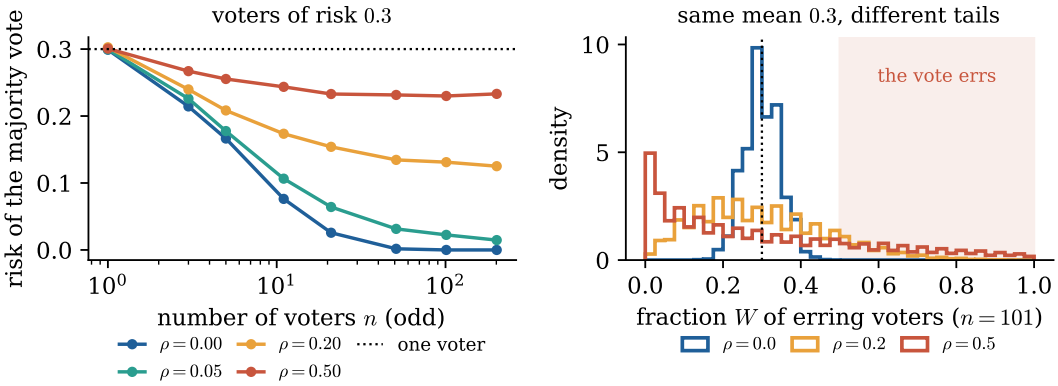


Figure 109: Votes of correlated voters (classification). Each voter errs with probability 0.3, and the errors of two voters are positively correlated (latent Gaussian model with correlation parameter ρ). Left: risk of the majority vote as the number of voters grows. Right: distribution of the fraction of erring voters on a random point, for 101 voters; the vote errs when this fraction exceeds $\frac{1}{2}$ (shaded area).

a remark: these tools explain why a *single* model generalizes, and why boosting fits the training data, but not why a combination of models generalizes better than its members. It mentioned PAC-Bayesian theory as the natural tool for ensembles. This part starts exactly there; Fig. 110 lists the notions of Part III that we are going to extend, and where.

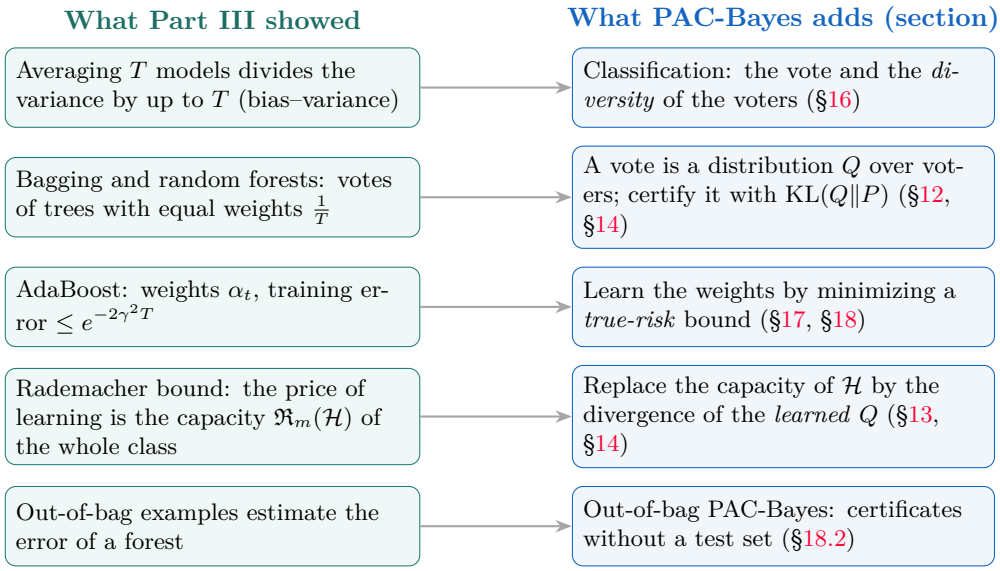


Figure 110: From Part III to Part IV: each notion of Part III (left) is extended by PAC-Bayesian theory in the section indicated on the right.

12.2 A puzzling experiment

Let us start with an experiment that will accompany us throughout this part. We train a random forest of 100 trees on the `digits` dataset of `scikit-learn`, where the task is to decide whether a handwritten digit is smaller than 5. We use 1257 examples for

training and keep 540 for testing. Taken one by one, the trees are mediocre: their test errors range from 14% to 25%, with an average of 19%. Yet the forest, which simply lets the 100 trees vote, errs on only 4.4% of the test digits. The vote is more than four times better than an average tree, and three times better than the best one (Fig. 111): the classification counterpart of the averaging effect recalled above.

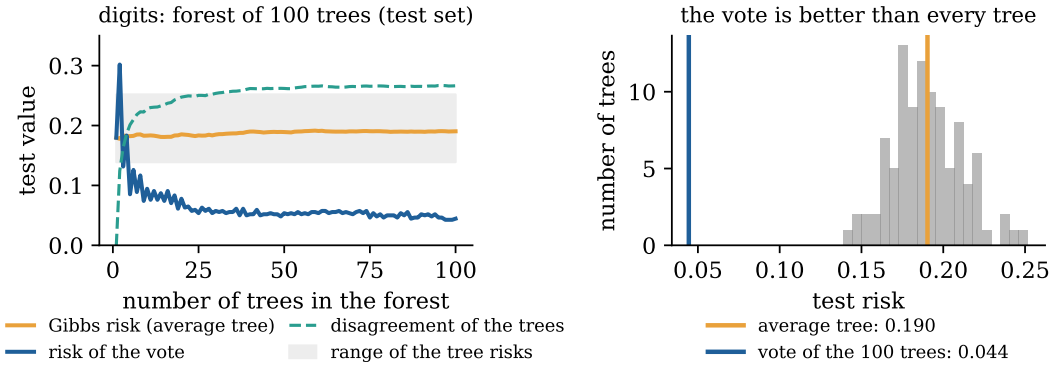


Figure 111: The running example. Left: test risk of the vote of the first n trees, average test risk of these trees (the *Gibbs risk*, see below) and their disagreement, as n grows. Right: the test risks of the 100 trees; the vote is better than every one of them.

This experiment raises two questions, which organize the whole course. The first one is *explanatory*: why is a vote of mediocre classifiers so much better than its members, and what property of the ensemble makes this possible? The second one is *practical*: could we have *guaranteed* that the forest is accurate without a test set, that is, from the training data alone? PAC-Bayesian theory answers both. To see why it is the right tool, we first need to notice that the forest is not an isolated case.

> **Running example** We will come back to this forest in every section. In Section 14 we certify the risk of an average tree, in Section 16 we certify the vote itself and see why its accuracy is linked to the diversity of the trees, and in Sections 17 and 18 we learn new weights for the trees by minimizing the certificates.

12.3 Ensemble methods produce majority votes

In Sections 10.2 and 10.3 we built several *ensemble* predictors from a family of base classifiers $h_1, \ldots, h_n$, which we will call *voters* from now on. The methods rely on very different ideas, but they all end up with the same kind of predictor.

In bagging (Breiman, 1996a), each tree h_t is learned on a bootstrap (Efron and Tibshirani, 1993) sample S_t of the learning sample S, and random forests (Breiman, 2001) add some randomness in the construction of each tree by drawing, at each split, a random subset of the features. The final prediction is obtained by letting the trees vote,

$$H(x) = \operatorname{sign}\left(\frac{1}{n}\sum_{t=1}^{n} h_t(x)\right),$$

a majority vote in which every tree has the same weight $\frac{1}{n}$.

Boosting looks different at first sight. AdaBoost (Freund and Schapire, 1997) builds the voters sequentially: at round t, the weak learner h_t is trained on a reweighted sample and receives the weight $\alpha_t = \frac{1}{2}\ln\frac{1-\varepsilon_t}{\varepsilon_t}$, which is non-negative as soon as its weighted error ε_t is smaller than $\frac{1}{2}$. But the final classifier can be written in two equivalent ways,

$$H(x) = \operatorname{sign}\Big(\sum_{t=1}^{n} \alpha_t h_t(x)\Big) = \operatorname{sign}\Big(\sum_{t=1}^{n} Q(h_t)\, h_t(x)\Big), \qquad \text{with} \qquad Q(h_t) = \frac{\alpha_t}{\sum_s \alpha_s},$$

because dividing the score by the positive constant $\sum_s \alpha_s$ does not change its sign. The normalized weights $Q(h_1), \dots, Q(h_n)$ are non-negative and sum to one. In other words, AdaBoost outputs a *probability distribution* over the weak learners, and predicts with the corresponding weighted majority vote. Figure 112 shows such a distribution on a simulated problem. Gradient boosting (Friedman, 2001) follows the same pattern with real-valued regressors, and stacking (Wolpert, 1992) with a linear meta-learner learns the weights of a vote on a held-out sample.

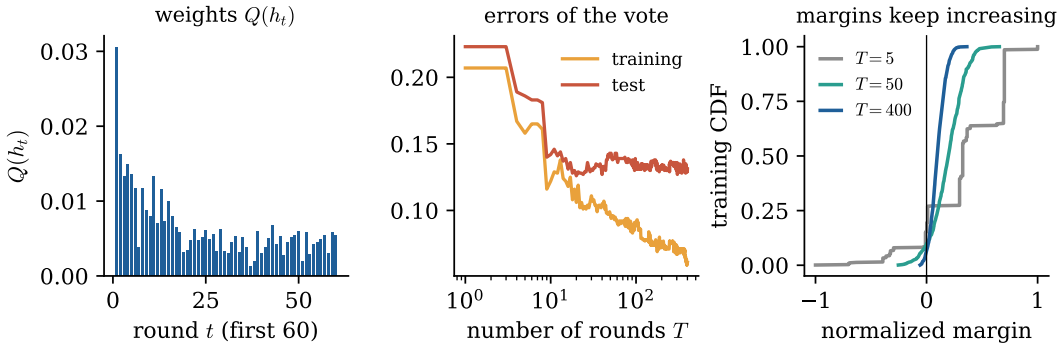


Figure 112: AdaBoost with decision stumps on a simulated problem (1000 training examples, 20 features). Left: the normalized weights $Q(h_t)$ of the first 60 stumps form a probability distribution over the weak learners. Middle: the training error of the vote goes to zero while the test error stabilizes. Right: even after the training error is small, the distribution of the normalized margins keeps moving to the right; this observation motivated the margin theory of boosting (Schapire et al., 1998), to which we come back in Section 16.9.

Even kernel methods fit in this picture. With random Fourier features (Rahimi and Recht, 2007), a kernel machine is approximated by $\operatorname{sign}\big(\sum_k \alpha_k \cos(\omega_k^\top x + b_k)\big)$, where the frequencies ω_k are drawn from a distribution determined by the kernel. This is a vote over an infinite family of voters indexed by ω (Letarte et al., 2019b), and it is precisely the model studied in the project of the first part of the course.

In all these cases, the learned predictor has the form

$$B_Q(x) = \operatorname{sign}\Big(\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}[h(x)]\Big), \qquad Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H}), \tag{12.2}$$

where $\mathcal{H}$ is a (finite or infinite) set of voters and Q a probability distribution on $\mathcal{H}$ (Fig. 113). Table 8 translates the notation of Part III into the notation of this part, which is the standard one of the PAC-Bayesian literature. The learning problem for ensembles can therefore be rephrased in a single sentence: *how should we choose a good distribution Q over the voters?* This is exactly the question addressed by PAC-Bayesian theory. Figure 114 shows, on a two-dimensional problem, the phenomenon of our puzzling experiment: the individual trees of a random forest are irregular and rather inaccurate, whereas their vote is smooth and accurate.

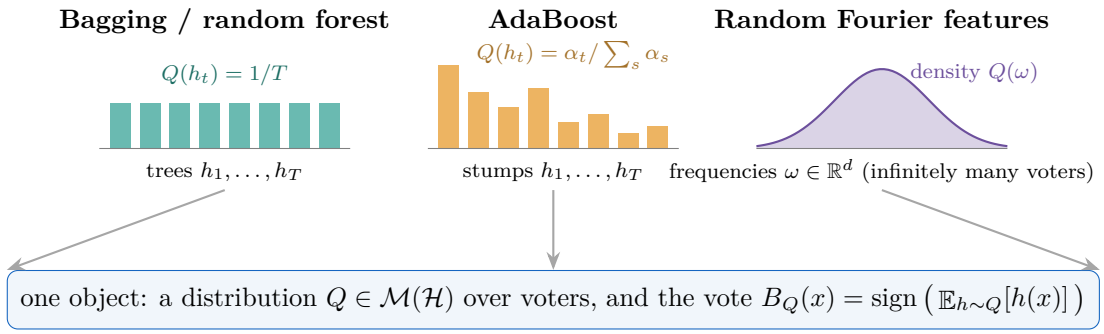


Figure 113: Three ensemble methods of Part III, one object. Bagging and random forests put the same weight on every tree, AdaBoost normalizes the weights α_t of its weak learners, and a kernel machine with random features draws its voters from a continuous distribution. In each case the predictor is the Q-weighted majority vote B_Q.

Table 8: From the notation of Part III to the notation of Part IV.

Part III	**Part IV**	**Comment**
models $h_1, \ldots, h_T$	voters $h \in \mathcal{H}$	$\mathcal{H}$ may be finite (n voters) or infinite
weights $\frac{1}{T}$ or $\frac{\alpha_t}{\sum_s \alpha_s}$	posterior $Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$	learned from the sample S
—	prior $P \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$	fixed *before* seeing S
combined model H_T	majority vote B_Q	$B_Q(x) = \text{sign}\, \mathbb{E}_{h\sim Q} h(x)$
average error of the models	Gibbs risk $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$	risk of a voter drawn from Q
$R(h)$, $R_S(h)$	$R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)$, $\widehat{R}_S(h)$	true and empirical risks
capacity $\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H})$	divergence $\text{KL}(Q\|P)$	price of learning
correlation of the errors	disagreement $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$, joint error $e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$	diversity (Section 16)

12.4 What classical bounds say about majority votes

Can the generalization bounds of Parts II and III answer our two questions? Let us write the Rademacher bound recalled in Section 12.1 with the notation of this part (Bartlett and Mendelson, 2002; Mohri et al., 2018): for a loss with values in $[0, 1]$, with probability at least $1 - \delta$ over the draw of $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$, simultaneously for all $h \in \mathcal{H}$,

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(h) \leq \widehat{R}_S(h) + 2\,\mathfrak{R}_m(\mathcal{H}) + \sqrt{\frac{\ln(1/\delta)}{2m}}. \tag{12.3}$$

Such a bound is called *uniform*: it holds for every hypothesis of the class, whatever the way it has been chosen, and the price to pay is a measure of the complexity of the whole class. There are two reasons why this is not satisfactory for ensembles.

The first one is good news in disguise: taking averages does not make a class more complex. The empirical Rademacher complexity of the convex hull $\text{conv}(\mathcal{H})$, that is of the set of all weighted averages of voters, is exactly the same as that of $\mathcal{H}$, because a linear function reaches its supremum over a convex set at one of its extreme points (Exercise 12.2). Schapire et al. (1998) and Koltchinskii and Panchenko (2002) exploited

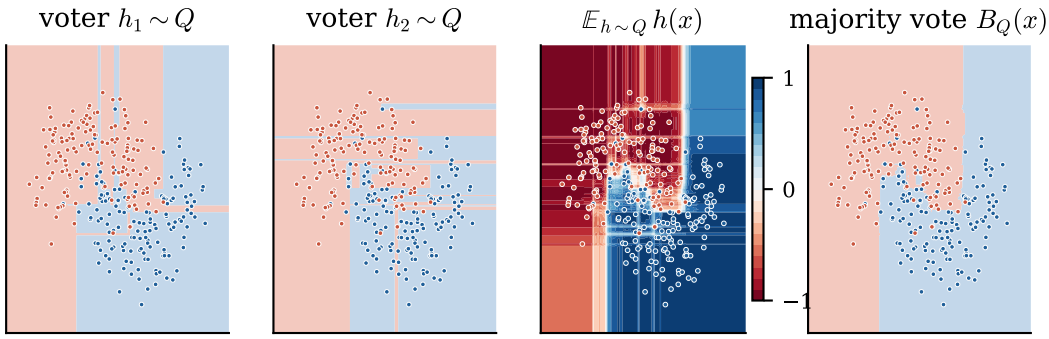


Figure 114: Two voters h_1, h_2 drawn from the posterior Q of a random forest (uniform over 200 randomized trees), the average vote $\mathbb{E}_{h\sim Q} h(x)$ and the majority vote B_Q on the `moons` dataset. Individual voters are very irregular; the vote is smoother and more accurate. Explaining, and certifying, this improvement is the purpose of this part.

this remark to derive *margin bounds* for voting classifiers that do not depend on the number of voters. This was the first explanation of the surprising behaviour of AdaBoost in Fig. 112, which does not overfit when more rounds are added. Unfortunately, for realistic sample sizes these bounds are almost always larger than one, and hence useless as guarantees.

The second reason is more fundamental: a uniform bound ignores *what has been learned*. Whether the forest puts all its weight on a few very good trees or spreads it over many diverse trees, the bound (12.3) pays the same price. Intuitively, a distribution Q that remains "close" to something we could have chosen *before* seeing the data should be cheaper than a distribution tuned very precisely on the sample. PAC-Bayesian theory turns this intuition into a theorem: the complexity of the class is replaced by a *divergence* between the learned distribution Q, called the *posterior*, and a reference distribution P fixed before seeing the data, called the *prior*.

12.5 The PAC-Bayesian principle

Figure 115 summarizes the setting. Before seeing the data, we fix a prior P over the voters, for instance the uniform distribution over the trees of a forest. A learning algorithm then looks at the sample and produces a posterior Q, which may depend on the data in any way we like. Finally, a bound compares the two, and certifies the predictor associated with Q.

Which predictor does a PAC-Bayesian bound certify? Its central object is not the vote but a randomized cousin of it, the *Gibbs classifier* G_Q: to predict the label of a point x, it draws a voter h at random according to Q and outputs $h(x)$. Since a new voter is drawn for each prediction, its risk is simply the average risk of the voters,

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}\left[R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)\right], \qquad \widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}\left[\widehat{R}_S(h)\right].$$

In our running example, the Gibbs classifier is "pick a tree at random and use it", and its test error is the 19% of an average tree. A typical PAC-Bayesian theorem (McAllester, 1999b, in the form of Maurer, 2004) then reads as follows: for any prior P that does

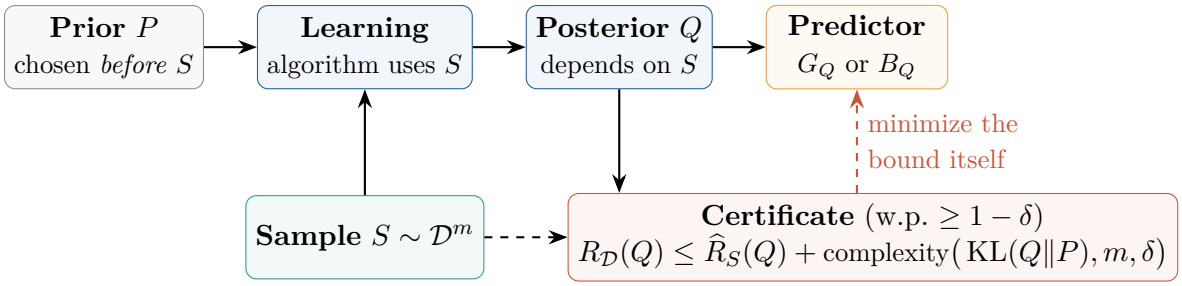


Figure 115: The PAC-Bayesian setting. The prior P encodes what we believe before seeing the data; the posterior Q may depend arbitrarily on S. The generalization bound holds *simultaneously for all posteriors*, so it can be used both as a certificate and as an objective to minimize (*self-bounding* learning, Section 17).

not depend on S, with probability at least $1-\delta$ over $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$,

$$\forall Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H}), \qquad \underbrace{R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)}_{\text{unknown}} \leq \underbrace{\widehat{R}_S(G_Q)}_{\text{computed on } S} + \sqrt{\frac{\underbrace{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)}_{\text{distance to the prior}} + \underbrace{\ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}}_{\text{confidence}}}{2m}}. \tag{12.4}$$

Let us read this statement slowly, because it contains the whole theory in a nutshell. On the left is the unknown quantity we care about, the true risk of the Gibbs classifier. On the right, the first term is its empirical risk, which we can compute. The second term is a price, which grows with the Kullback–Leibler divergence $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ between the posterior and the prior, and decreases with the sample size m. Three features make this statement very different from (12.3). First, the price depends on the *learned* distribution Q and on the prior, and not on the size of $\mathcal{H}$, which may even be infinite and uncountable. Second, the bound holds *for all posteriors simultaneously*: we are free to choose Q after having seen the data, and in particular to choose the posterior that minimizes the right-hand side. Third, every quantity on the right can be computed from the sample, so the bound is a genuine *risk certificate*: a number which, with high probability, is larger than the true risk of the predictor, and which can be reported next to it.

One difficulty remains: in practice we predict with the majority vote B_Q, not with the Gibbs classifier, and in our experiment the two differ enormously (4.4% against 19%). Section 16 is devoted to the relations between the two predictors. We will see that the gap between them is governed by the *disagreement* between the voters, that is by their diversity, which answers the explanatory question raised at the beginning of this section.

In a nutshell

PAC-Bayes = PAC + Bayes. From the PAC framework (Probably Approximately Correct, Valiant, 1984) it inherits the form of the guarantee: a bound on the true risk which holds with high probability over the sample, whatever the data distribution $\mathcal{D}$. From Bayesian statistics it borrows the vocabulary of priors and posteriors. But, unlike in Bayesian inference, the posterior is not required to be given by Bayes' rule, and the data are not assumed to be generated by a probabilistic model: the guarantee is purely frequentist.

12.6 A short history

The first PAC-Bayesian analyses are due to Shawe-Taylor and Williamson (1997) and to McAllester (1998, 1999b,a), who combined the PAC framework with Bayesian priors and thereby generalized the *Occam's razor* bound of Blumer et al. (1987), which we present in Section 13.4. The bound was then sharpened by using the binary Kullback–Leibler divergence (Seeger, 2002; Langford, 2005), and Maurer (2004) gave it the simple constant that we use today. Independently, Catoni (2007) (see also Audibert, 2004; Zhang, 2006) developed a very complete theory, emphasizing the role of the Gibbs posterior and the analogy with statistical physics. At the same time, Langford and Shawe-Taylor (2002) and McAllester (2003b) used PAC-Bayes to explain why large margins make support vector machines generalize.

The link with majority votes appeared early (McAllester, 1999a), but it became central with the work of Lacasse et al. (2006), who introduced the *C-bound*, and of Germain et al. (2009, 2015), who turned PAC-Bayesian bounds into learning algorithms such as MinCq (Roy et al., 2011). The field gained a new momentum in 2017, when Dziugaite and Roy (2017) obtained the first non-vacuous bounds for deep neural networks. Since then, a series of works has produced tight bounds for random forests (Lorenzen et al., 2019), second-order bounds for majority votes (Masegosa et al., 2020; Wu et al., 2021), and algorithms which minimize them directly (Viallard et al., 2021; Zantedeschi et al., 2021). Recent surveys are those of Guedj (2019), Alquier (2024) and Hellström et al. (2025). Figure 116 summarizes these milestones.

12.7 Organization of this part

The sections of this part follow the two questions of our puzzling experiment. The first two sections gather the foundations: after this introduction, Section 13 presents the mathematical tools — concentration inequalities, the Kullback–Leibler divergence and the change of measure inequality — and ends with the Occam bound, the ancestor of all PAC-Bayesian bounds. The next three sections build the certificates. Section 14 proves a general PAC-Bayesian theorem and derives from it the classical bounds of McAllester, Seeger, Maurer and Catoni; Section 15 discusses how to choose the posterior and the prior; Section 16 finally goes from the Gibbs classifier to the majority vote, where the diversity of the voters comes into play and where our first question receives its answer. The last two turn the certificates into learning objectives: Section 17 explains why a bound can be minimized without losing its validity, and Section 18 presents, and runs, the resulting algorithms for forests, boosting-like methods, linear classifiers, kernels and neural networks. Finally, Section 19 opens on current research.

To remember from Section 12

Ensemble methods learn a distribution Q over a set of voters and predict with the corresponding majority vote B_Q, which can be much more accurate than its voters. PAC-Bayesian bounds replace the complexity of the whole class by the divergence $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ between this distribution and a prior fixed before seeing the data, and they hold for all posteriors simultaneously. They certify the Gibbs classifier (a voter drawn at random) directly, the majority vote through the relations of Section 16, and they can themselves be used as learning objectives (Section 17).

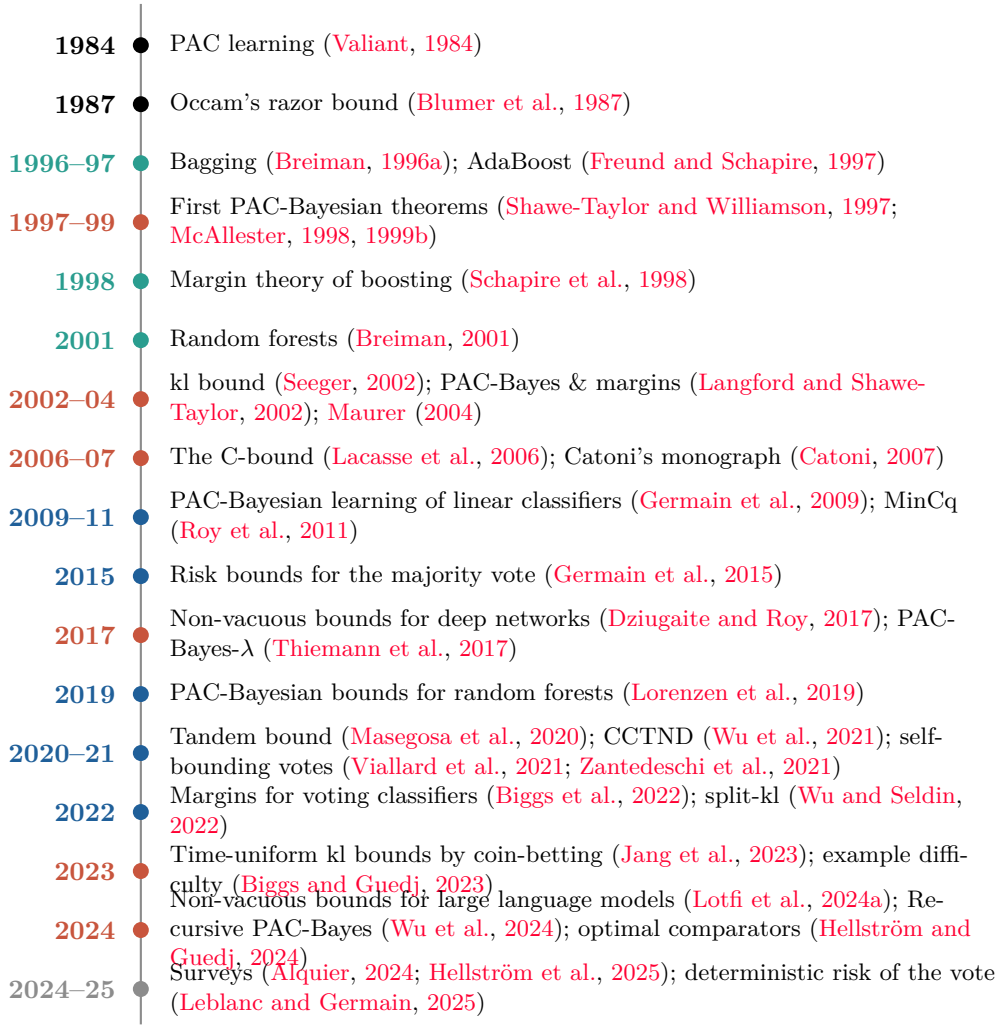


Figure 116: A few milestones. Black: learning theory; teal: ensemble methods; red: PAC-Bayesian bounds; blue: PAC-Bayes for majority votes; grey: surveys.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q12.1. Why is the output of AdaBoost a probability distribution over the weak learners?

Q12.2. In the running example, what are the test errors of the Gibbs classifier and of the majority vote?

Q12.3. What may the posterior depend on, and what may the prior not depend on?

Q12.4. Why is the Rademacher complexity of the convex hull of $\mathcal{H}$ not larger than that of $\mathcal{H}$?

Q12.5. T regression models have errors of variance $\sigma^2 = 1$ and pairwise correlation $\rho = 0.2$. What is the error of their average when $T \to \infty$?

Q12.6. True or false? A majority vote of voters that all have a risk of 0.3 always has a risk smaller than 0.3.

Q12.7. Five voters err independently with probability 0.3. What is the risk of their majority vote?

Q12.8. What is the Gibbs classifier G_Q, and why is its risk the average risk of the voters?

Q12.9. In (12.4), what happens to the complexity term when the sample size is multiplied by 4 (ignoring the slowly growing $\ln 2\sqrt{m}$)?

Q12.10. Give two reasons why a uniform (VC or Rademacher) bound is not satisfactory for ensembles.

Q12.11. True or false? A PAC-Bayesian bound assumes that the data are generated by a Bayesian model and that the posterior is computed by Bayes' rule.

Q12.12. Can a PAC-Bayesian bound be useful when $\mathcal{H}$ is uncountable, for instance the set of linear classifiers?

Q12.13. With the uniform prior on 100 trees, what does the posterior uniform on 10 of them cost, and what is the complexity term of (12.4) for $m = 1000$, $\delta = 0.05$?

Exercises

Exercise 12.1. **(Comprehension)** Write the predictors of bagging, of AdaBoost and of a kernel machine with random Fourier features in the form (12.2). In each case, what is the set of voters $\mathcal{H}$, and what is the distribution Q?

Exercise 12.2. **(Proof)** Show that the empirical Rademacher complexity of $\mathrm{conv}(\mathcal{H})$ equals the one of $\mathcal{H}$. *Hint:* for a fixed vector of signs σ, the function $f \mapsto \frac{1}{m}\sum_i \sigma_i f(x_i)$ is linear in f.

Exercise 12.3. **(Comprehension)** In Figure 112, the training error reaches its plateau after a few dozen rounds. Using the right panel, explain why a bound based on the empirical margin distribution can keep decreasing afterwards.

Exercise 12.4. **(Comprehension)** True or false? Justify in one or two sentences. (a) Since the vote of the running example is better than an average tree, the risk of a majority vote is always smaller than the risk of its Gibbs classifier, $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) \le R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$. (b) The Gibbs risk $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$ always lies between the smallest and the largest risk of the voters in the support of Q.

Exercise 12.5. **(Comprehension)** A student proposes the following trick: "since the bound (12.4) holds for any prior, I learn my posterior Q and then take $P = Q$, so that $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 0$ and the certificate is simply $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) + \sqrt{\ln(2\sqrt{m}/\delta)/(2m)}$." Explain what is wrong.

Exercise 12.6. **(Application)** AdaBoost produces three weak learners with weighted errors $\varepsilon_1 = 0.1$, $\varepsilon_2 = 0.2$ and $\varepsilon_3 = 0.3$. Compute their weights α_t and the normalized distribution Q. On a point x where $h_1(x) = +1$ and $h_2(x) = h_3(x) = -1$, what does the vote predict? Is the best weak learner always obeyed?

Exercise 12.7. **(Application)** Consider the bound (12.4) with $\delta = 0.05$ and $m = 1000$. Compute its complexity term for the uniform posterior $Q = P$, and for a Dirac posterior on one of $n = 100$ voters with the uniform prior (for which $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = \ln n$). How many examples are needed for the complexity term of the uniform posterior to be below 0.02?

Exercise 12.8. **(Proof)** Let $\mathcal{H} = \{h_1, \dots, h_n\}$ be finite and $Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$. Show that $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = \mathbb{E}_{(x,y)\sim\mathcal{D}}[W_Q(x,y)]$ with $W_Q(x,y) = \sum_t Q(h_t)\mathbb{1}[h_t(x) \neq y]$, and deduce that $\min_{t:Q(h_t)>0} R_{\mathcal{D}}(h_t) \le R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) \le \max_{t:Q(h_t)>0} R_{\mathcal{D}}(h_t)$.

Exercise 12.9. **(Proof)** For voters with values in $\{-1,+1\}$, show that $\mathbb{1}[h(x) \neq y] = \frac{1 - y\,h(x)}{2}$, deduce that the margin $M_Q(x,y) = y\,\mathbb{E}_{h\sim Q}[h(x)]$ equals $1 - 2W_Q(x,y)$, and show that if the vote B_Q errs on (x,y), then $W_Q(x,y) \ge \frac{1}{2}$ (whatever the convention chosen for $\mathrm{sign}(0)$).

Exercise 12.10. **(Proof)** Let $\varepsilon_1, \dots, \varepsilon_T$ be centred random variables with the same variance σ^2 and the same correlation ρ between two different ones. (a) Prove formula (12.1) for $\mathbb{E}\big[(\frac{1}{T}\sum_t \varepsilon_t)^2\big]$. (b) Deduce that $\rho \ge -\frac{1}{T-1}$. (c) Show that $\big(\frac{1}{T}\sum_t \varepsilon_t\big)^2 \le \frac{1}{T}\sum_t \varepsilon_t^2$ pointwise, and interpret this inequality for ensembles.

Exercise 12.11. **(Application)** In the setting of Figure 108 ($\sigma^2 = 1$), how many models must be averaged to divide the error of one model by 10 when $\rho = 0$? When $\rho = 0.3$, what is the smallest achievable error, and how many models are needed to be within 10% of it? Relate the answer to the random selection of features in random forests, which lowers the correlation between the trees.

Exercise 12.12. **(Proof)** (a) Using the random variable W_Q of Exercise 12.9 and Markov's inequality (Proposition 1.9 in Section 1), prove that $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) \le 2\,R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$. (b) Show that this inequality is tight: for every $r \in (0, \frac{1}{2}]$, build a distribution and two or three voters such that $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = r$ and $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = 2r$ (ties counted as errors). (c) What does this say about the vote of voters whose errors are concentrated on the same points?

Exercise 12.13. **(Computation)** Three voters are evaluated on five equally likely examples. The table gives $\mathbb{1}[h_t(x_i) \neq y_i]$ (1 = error):

	x_1	x_2	x_3	x_4	x_5
h_1	1	0	0	0	0
h_2	0	1	0	0	1
h_3	0	0	1	0	1

(a) Compute the risks of the voters and, for Q uniform, the values $W_Q(x_i, y_i)$, the margins, the Gibbs risk and the risk of the majority vote. (b) Same questions for $Q = (\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{4})$. (c) For which Q is the vote perfect on these five points?

Exercise 12.14. **(Python)** (a) For n independent voters that each err with probability $p = 0.3$, the vote errs when at least $\frac{n+1}{2}$ of them err (n odd). Compute its risk for $n \in \{1, 3, 5, 11, 21, 51, 101\}$ with `scipy.stats.binom`. (b) Train a `RandomForestClassifier` with 100 trees on the `digits` task of the running example (digit ≥ 5 or not, `test_size=0.3`, `random_state=0`), and compute the test risk of every tree, the Gibbs risk, the vector W_Q on the test points and the risk of the vote. Check that the latter equals the proportion of test points with $W_Q \geq \frac{1}{2}$. Is the vote as good as predicted by (a)?

13 Mathematical toolbox

About this section

Guiding question. *How can an error measured on a sample be turned into a guarantee on the true error, first for one classifier, then for many?*

We fix the formal setting (Gibbs classifier and majority vote), and we gather the probabilistic tools that are used over and over in PAC-Bayesian proofs: concentration inequalities for a single voter, stated with the binary Kullback-Leibler divergence, the Kullback-Leibler divergence between distributions over voters, and the change of measure inequality, which is the key step of every PAC-Bayesian bound. The section ends with the Occam bound, which already contains the main idea of PAC-Bayes.

The section climbs three steps. We first learn how to certify *one* classifier fixed in advance (concentration inequalities). We then introduce the tool that lets us move from a distribution fixed in advance to a distribution chosen with the data (the change of measure). Finally, combining the two in the simplest case gives the Occam bound, which certifies a classifier *chosen* among many. The next section will take the last step, from one chosen classifier to a chosen distribution over classifiers.

13.1 Setting

Before stating any bound, we must fix the objects that the bounds talk about: the data, the voters, their risks, and the two ways of combining voters. We consider binary classification. Examples (x, y) are drawn independently from an unknown distribution $\mathcal{D}$ on $\mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{Y}$ with $\mathcal{Y} = \{-1, +1\}$, and we observe a learning sample $S = \{(x_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m \sim \mathcal{D}^m$. We are given a set $\mathcal{H}$ of voters and a loss function $\ell : \mathcal{H} \times (\mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{Y}) \to [0, 1]$, which will be the 0-1 loss $\ell(h, (x, y)) = \mathbb{1}[h(x) \neq y]$ unless stated otherwise. The true risk and the empirical risk of a voter are

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(h) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(x,y)\sim\mathcal{D}} [\ell(h, (x, y))] \qquad \text{and} \qquad \widehat{R}_S(h) = \frac{1}{m} \sum_{i=1}^{m} \ell(h, (x_i, y_i)).$$

For voters with values in $\{-1, +1\}$ we will often use the identity $\mathbb{1}[h(x) \neq y] = \frac{1 - y\,h(x)}{2}$, which turns the 0-1 loss into a linear function of the prediction.

Definition 13.1: Gibbs classifier and majority vote

Let $Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$ be a distribution over $\mathcal{H}$. The **Gibbs classifier** G_Q predicts the label of x by drawing $h \sim Q$ and returning $h(x)$. Its true and empirical risks are

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q} [R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)], \qquad \widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q} \left[\widehat{R}_S(h)\right].$$

The **(Q-weighted) majority vote** is the deterministic classifier $B_Q(x) = \operatorname{sign}\left(\mathbb{E}_{h\sim Q}[h(x)]\right)$, with the convention $\operatorname{sign}(0) = -1$, so that a tie is counted as an error in the analysis. Its risk is $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = \mathbb{P}_{(x,y)\sim\mathcal{D}}(B_Q(x) \neq y)$.

The two predictors behave very differently. The Gibbs risk is *linear* in Q, which makes it easy to analyse, and it always lies between the risk of the best and the risk of

the worst voter. The risk of the majority vote is not linear in Q, and it can be much smaller than the Gibbs risk: in the running example of Section 12, the Gibbs risk of the forest is 19% while its vote only errs on 4.4% of the test points. A convenient way to relate the two is to exchange the expectations over the voters and over the data (Fubini's theorem):

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(x,y)\sim\mathcal{D}}[W_Q(x,y)]\,, \qquad \text{where} \qquad W_Q(x,y) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}[\mathbb{1}[h(x)\neq y]]$$

is the proportion, weighted by Q, of voters that err on (x,y). The random variable W_Q will be the main character of Section 16. For now, the important point is that the Gibbs risk is an average of the risks of single voters, so our first task is to control the risk of one voter.

13.2 Concentration inequalities

All generalization bounds rely on the same basic fact: for a *fixed* voter h, chosen before seeing the data, the empirical risk $\widehat{R}_S(h)$ is an average of m independent random variables with values in $[0,1]$ and mean $R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)$, hence it concentrates around $R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)$. The tools below quantify this concentration. They were introduced in Section 1; we recall them here in the form used by PAC-Bayesian proofs, with short proofs, starting with the simplest of all (Proposition 1.9).

Lemma 13.2: Markov's inequality

Let $Z \geq 0$ be a random variable and $a > 0$. Then $\mathbb{P}(Z \geq a) \leq \frac{\mathbb{E}Z}{a}$. Equivalently, for any $\delta \in (0,1]$, with probability at least $1-\delta$, $Z \leq \frac{\mathbb{E}Z}{\delta}$.

Proof. Since $Z \geq 0$, we have $a\mathbb{1}[Z \geq a] \leq Z$ pointwise (Fig. 117): the left-hand side is 0 when $Z < a$, and $a \leq Z$ otherwise. Taking expectations,

$$\begin{aligned} a\,\mathbb{P}(Z \geq a) &= \mathbb{E}\big[a\mathbb{1}[Z \geq a]\big] \\ &\quad\downarrow \text{ monotonicity of the expectation and } a\mathbb{1}[Z \geq a] \leq Z \\ &\leq \mathbb{E}Z. \end{aligned}$$

For the second form, apply the first one with $a = \mathbb{E}Z/\delta$. □

Markov's inequality looks weak, but it becomes remarkably powerful when it is applied to a well-chosen transformation of the variable of interest. Applied to the exponential $e^{\lambda(p-\hat{p})}$, it gives Hoeffding's inequality.

Lemma 13.3: Hoeffding's inequality (Hoeffding, 1963)

Let $Z_1, \ldots, Z_m$ be i.i.d. random variables in $[0,1]$ with mean p, and $\hat{p} = \frac{1}{m}\sum_i Z_i$. For any $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$, $\mathbb{E}\,e^{\lambda(p-\hat{p})} \leq e^{\lambda^2/(8m)}$, and, for $\varepsilon > 0$, $\mathbb{P}(p - \hat{p} \geq \varepsilon) \leq e^{-2m\varepsilon^2}$.

Proof. We use *Hoeffding's lemma* (Lemma 1.13 in Section 1): a random variable U with zero mean and values in an interval of length c satisfies $\mathbb{E}e^{\lambda U} \leq e^{\lambda^2 c^2/8}$ for every $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$

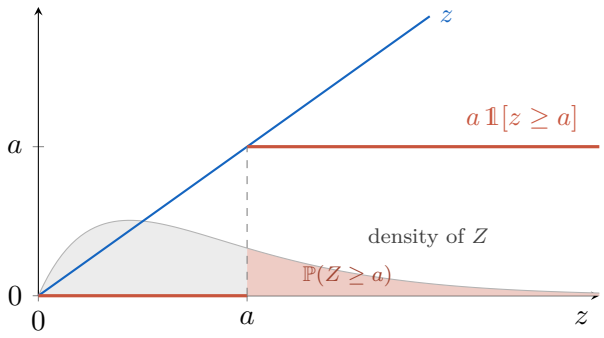


Figure 117: Why Markov's inequality holds: for a non-negative variable, the step $z \mapsto a\mathbb{1}[z \geq a]$ (red) lies below the identity $z \mapsto z$ (blue), so that $a\,\mathbb{P}(Z \geq a) \leq \mathbb{E}Z$. The shaded red area is the tail probability.

(see also Boucheron et al., 2013). The variables $U_i = \frac{p - Z_i}{m}$ are independent, centred, and take their values in an interval of length $\frac{1}{m}$, so that

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathbb{E}\, e^{\lambda(p-\hat{p})} &= \mathbb{E} \prod_{i=1}^{m} e^{\lambda U_i} \\
&\downarrow \text{ independence of } Z_1, \dots, Z_m \\
&= \prod_{i=1}^{m} \mathbb{E}\, e^{\lambda U_i} \\
&\downarrow \text{ Hoeffding's lemma with } c = \frac{1}{m} \\
&\leq \prod_{i=1}^{m} e^{\lambda^2/(8m^2)} = e^{\lambda^2/(8m)}.
\end{aligned}$$

For the tail, we apply Markov's inequality to the exponential (this is *Chernoff's method*): for every $\lambda > 0$,

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathbb{P}(p - \hat{p} \geq \varepsilon) &= \mathbb{P}\big(e^{\lambda(p-\hat{p})} \geq e^{\lambda\varepsilon}\big) \\
&\downarrow \text{ Markov's inequality} \\
&\leq e^{-\lambda\varepsilon}\, \mathbb{E}\, e^{\lambda(p-\hat{p})} \\
&\downarrow \text{ first part} \\
&\leq e^{-\lambda\varepsilon + \lambda^2/(8m)} \\
&\downarrow \text{ the exponent is minimal for } \lambda = 4m\varepsilon \\
&= e^{-2m\varepsilon^2}.
\end{aligned}$$

□

The tail bound is Proposition 1.14 of Section 1 for variables in $[0, 1]$. Inverting Hoeffding's inequality, the true risk of a fixed voter satisfies $R_{\mathcal{D}}(h) \leq \widehat{R}_S(h) + \sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)/(2m)}$ with probability at least $1 - \delta$. In words, the empirical risk underestimates the true risk by more than $\sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)/(2m)}$ with probability at most δ. This is already a certificate, but its width does not depend on the value of the risk, which is wasteful when the risk is small: a Bernoulli variable of mean 0.01 fluctuates much less than a Bernoulli variable of mean 0.5.

The sharpest statement for Bernoulli variables uses the **binary Kullback–**

Leibler divergence

$$\mathrm{kl}(q\|p) = q\ln\frac{q}{p} + (1-q)\ln\frac{1-q}{1-p}, \qquad q,p\in[0,1],$$

which is the Kullback–Leibler divergence between two Bernoulli distributions of parameters q and p (we met it in Example 1.6, as the exponent of Chernoff's bound, Proposition 1.12).

The binary kl has a very concrete meaning: it measures how *surprising* it is to observe a frequency q of errors when the true error rate is p. Indeed, the probability that m independent coin flips of bias p produce a frequency close to q behaves like $e^{-m\,\mathrm{kl}(q\|p)}$. This is Sanov's theorem for coins, and the next lemma makes one side of it precise. A small kl means that the observation is plausible under p, while a kl of ε means that it has a probability of order $e^{-m\varepsilon}$. Turning this around, the true risks p compatible with an observed empirical risk $\hat{q}$ are those for which $\mathrm{kl}(\hat{q}\|p)$ is small.

Lemma 13.4: Chernoff's bound and Maurer's lemma

Let $Z_1,\dots,Z_m$ be i.i.d. random variables in $[0,1]$ with mean p and average $\hat{p}$. Chernoff's bound states that, for $\varepsilon\in(0,p)$, $\mathbb{P}(\hat{p}\le p-\varepsilon)\le e^{-m\,\mathrm{kl}(p-\varepsilon\|p)}$. Maurer's lemma (Maurer, 2004) states that, for $m\ge 8$,

$$\mathbb{E}\Big[e^{m\,\mathrm{kl}(\hat{p}\|p)}\Big] \le \xi(m) := \sum_{k=0}^{m}\binom{m}{k}\Big(\frac{k}{m}\Big)^k\Big(1-\frac{k}{m}\Big)^{m-k}, \tag{13.1}$$

with $\sqrt{m}\le\xi(m)\le 2\sqrt{m}$; the first inequality in (13.1) is an equality when the Z_i are Bernoulli variables.

The two statements say the same thing in two different forms. Chernoff's bound controls a *tail*: a large deviation of the empirical mean is exponentially unlikely, at the rate given by the kl. Maurer's lemma controls an *exponential moment*: on average, $e^{m\,\mathrm{kl}(\hat{p}\|p)}$ is only of order $\sqrt{m}$, although it could a priori be as large as $e^{m\ln 2}$. The first form is the natural one for a single classifier; the second is the one that PAC-Bayesian proofs need, because an expectation can be averaged over voters, whereas a tail probability cannot.

Proof sketch. The key step in the second statement is that, for any convex function f on $[0,1]^m$, $\mathbb{E}f(Z_1,\dots,Z_m)\le\mathbb{E}f(B_1,\dots,B_m)$ where the B_i are i.i.d. Bernoulli(p) variables: a variable in $[0,1]$ is "less spread" than a Bernoulli variable with the same mean. Since $q\mapsto e^{m\,\mathrm{kl}(q\|p)}$ is convex, it suffices to treat the case $m\hat{p}\sim\mathrm{Bin}(m,p)$, for which

$$\mathbb{E}e^{m\,\mathrm{kl}(\hat{p}\|p)} = \sum_k\binom{m}{k}p^k(1-p)^{m-k}\Big(\frac{k/m}{p}\Big)^k\Big(\frac{1-k/m}{1-p}\Big)^{m-k} = \xi(m),$$

a quantity which, remarkably, does not depend on p; Stirling's formula gives the bounds on $\xi(m)$. □

Inverting the kl. Both statements bound the kl between the empirical and the true risk, whereas what we want is an explicit upper bound on the true risk. We therefore

Algorithm 12: Upper inversion of the binary kl by bisection

Input: empirical value $\hat{q} \in [0,1]$, budget $\varepsilon \geq 0$, tolerance τ

$a \leftarrow \hat{q}$, $b \leftarrow 1$;
while $b - a > \tau$ **do**
  $c \leftarrow (a+b)/2$;
  if $\mathrm{kl}(\hat{q}\|c) > \varepsilon$ **then** $b \leftarrow c$;
  else $a \leftarrow c$;

Output: b ; `// ` $\geq \overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(\hat{q},\varepsilon)$`, within` τ

need to invert the binary kl. For a fixed q, the function $p \mapsto \mathrm{kl}(q\|p)$ is convex, vanishes at $p = q$ and increases on $[q,1]$ (see Fig. 118). The inequality $\mathrm{kl}(\hat{q}\|p) \leq \varepsilon$ therefore defines an interval $[\underline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(\hat{q},\varepsilon), \overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(\hat{q},\varepsilon)]$ of admissible values of p, with

$$\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(\hat{q},\varepsilon) = \sup\{p \in [\hat{q},1] : \mathrm{kl}(\hat{q}\|p) \leq \varepsilon\}, \qquad \underline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(\hat{q},\varepsilon) = \inf\{p \in [0,\hat{q}] : \mathrm{kl}(\hat{q}\|p) \leq \varepsilon\}.$$

These quantities have no closed form, but since the function is monotone on each side of $\hat{q}$ they are computed to any precision by a few iterations of bisection (Algorithm 12). In the rest of this part, $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}$ will be our standard way of turning an empirical quantity into a certified upper bound.

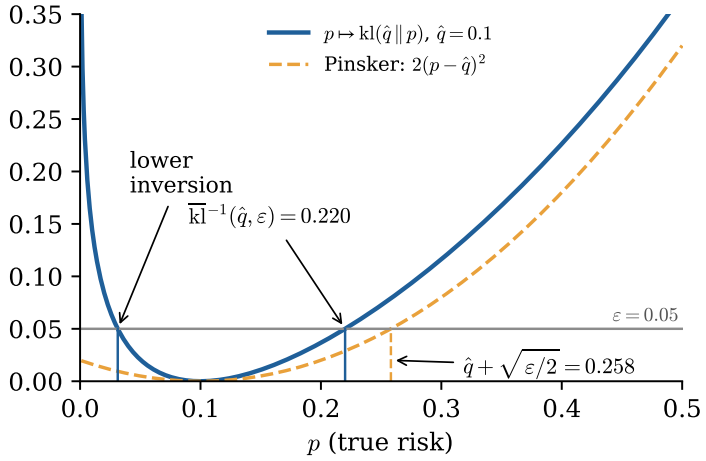


Figure 118: The function $p \mapsto \mathrm{kl}(\hat{q}\|p)$ for $\hat{q} = 0.1$. For $\varepsilon = 0.05$, the values of p compatible with $\mathrm{kl}(\hat{q}\|p) \leq \varepsilon$ form an interval whose upper end $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(\hat{q},\varepsilon) = 0.220$ is smaller than the Pinsker relaxation $\hat{q} + \sqrt{\varepsilon/2} = 0.258$.

Example 13.1 (Inverting the kl by hand). Let $\hat{q} = 0.1$ and $\varepsilon = 0.05$. We know that $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(0.1, 0.05) \geq 0.1$. Since $\mathrm{kl}(0.1\|0.2) \approx 0.037 < 0.05$ and $\mathrm{kl}(0.1\|0.25) \approx 0.072 > 0.05$, the answer lies in $[0.2, 0.25]$; the midpoint gives $\mathrm{kl}(0.1\|0.225) \approx 0.053 > 0.05$, so the answer is in $[0.2, 0.225]$, and so on. After twenty steps the interval has length 10^{-6} and we find $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(0.1, 0.05) \approx 0.220$.

Bisection gives numbers, but not formulas. To understand how kl-based bounds behave, and to derive bounds with a closed form, we also need explicit (if looser) upper bounds on $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}$; the next two inequalities provide them.

Lemma 13.5: Pinsker-type inequalities

For $q, p \in [0,1]$, $\mathrm{kl}(q\|p) \geq 2(q-p)^2$ (Pinsker's inequality), hence $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(q,\varepsilon) \leq q + \sqrt{\varepsilon/2}$. Moreover, if $q < p$, then $\mathrm{kl}(q\|p) \geq \frac{(p-q)^2}{2p}$ (refined Pinsker inequality), hence $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(q,\varepsilon) \leq q + \sqrt{2q\varepsilon} + 2\varepsilon$.

Figure 119 compares the binary kl with its two quadratic lower bounds. Pinsker's inequality recovers a Hoeffding-type width $\sqrt{\varepsilon/2}$. The refined inequality explains why it is so much better for small risks: when q is close to zero, the width of the confidence interval is of order ε instead of $\sqrt{\varepsilon}$, i.e. of order $1/m$ instead of $1/\sqrt{m}$ when $\varepsilon \propto 1/m$. This "fast rate" is visible on the left panel of Fig. 120: for an empirical risk of 1% and $m = 1000$ examples, the kl interval is four times narrower than the Hoeffding interval. The right panel checks by simulation that both intervals are valid: their failure frequency always stays below δ, and usually well below, as these inequalities are worst-case statements.

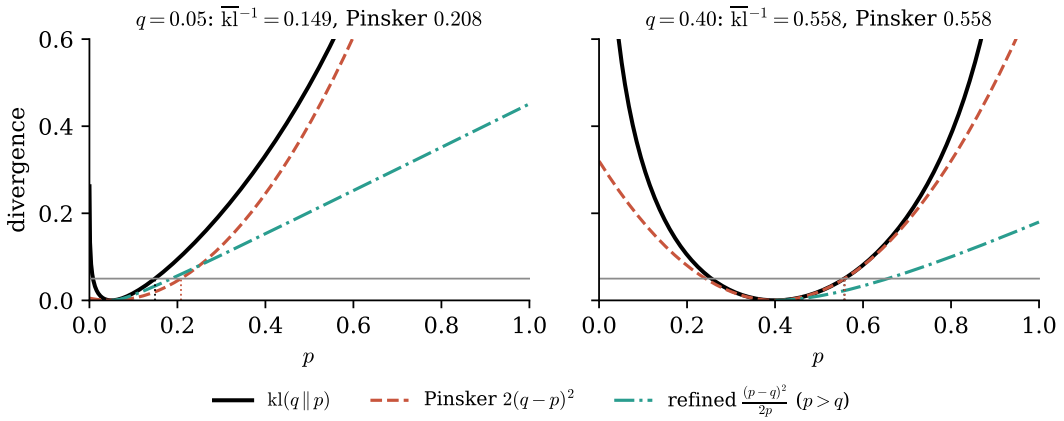


Figure 119: The binary kl $p \mapsto \mathrm{kl}(q\|p)$ (black) and its quadratic lower bounds, for $q = 0.05$ (left) and $q = 0.4$ (right). The admissible values of p are those below the horizontal line $\varepsilon = 0.05$. Near $q = 0$ the kl is much steeper than Pinsker's parabola, so its inverse $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}$ is much smaller than $q + \sqrt{\varepsilon/2}$; near $q = \frac{1}{2}$ the two almost coincide.

Running example Suppose that we had fixed the forest before seeing the 540 test digits, and that we use them only to certify it: this is the classical *test-set bound*. The vote errs on 4.4% of them; with $\delta = 0.05$, Hoeffding's inequality certifies a true risk below $0.044 + \sqrt{\ln 20/1080} = 0.097$, and the kl inversion below 0.069. For an average tree (19% of test errors), the two certificates are 0.243 and 0.234: the kl only makes a difference for small risks. These numbers will serve as a reference. Our goal is to obtain comparable guarantees *without* setting aside a test sample, from the training data alone.

Second moments. The inequalities above only use the fact that the variables are bounded. Majority votes will require a finer tool, which also uses the *variance* of a random variable, and not only its mean.

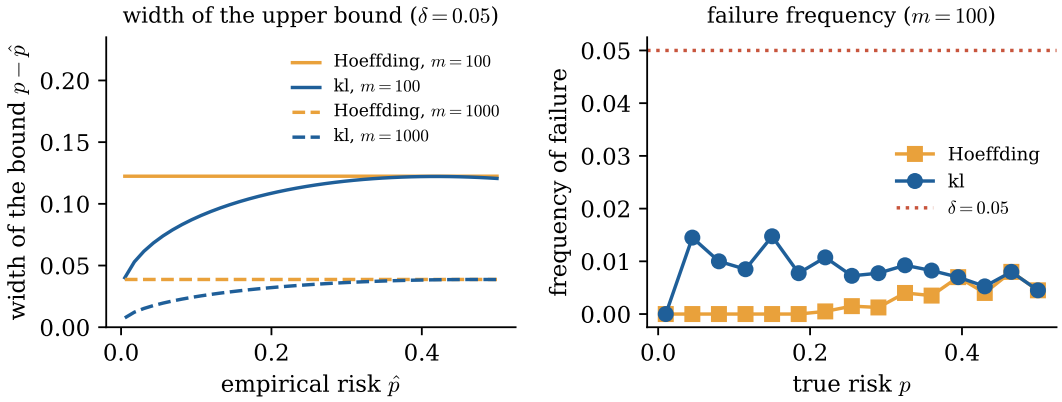


Figure 120: Left: width $p - \hat{p}$ of the upper confidence bound on the risk of a fixed voter given by Hoeffding's inequality (constant) and by the kl inversion, as a function of the empirical risk, for $m = 100$ and $m = 1000$. Right: frequency, over 4000 simulated samples of size 100, of the event "the true risk is above the bound"; both bounds are valid.

Lemma 13.6: Chebyshev–Cantelli inequality

Let Z be a random variable with mean μ and variance v. For every $a > 0$, $\mathbb{P}(Z - \mu \geq a) \leq \frac{v}{v+a^2}$ and $\mathbb{P}(Z - \mu \leq -a) \leq \frac{v}{v+a^2}$.

Proof. For any $t \geq 0$, $\{Z - \mu \geq a\} \subseteq \{(Z - \mu + t)^2 \geq (a+t)^2\}$, so by Markov's inequality $\mathbb{P}(Z - \mu \geq a) \leq \frac{\mathbb{E}(Z-\mu+t)^2}{(a+t)^2} = \frac{v+t^2}{(a+t)^2}$. The right-hand side is minimal for $t = v/a$, where it equals $\frac{v}{v+a^2}$. Applying the result to $-Z$ gives the lower tail. □

In words, a variable whose variance is small compared with a^2 rarely deviates from its mean by more than a, whatever its distribution. Note also the structure of the proof, which we will meet again in Section 16: we control a tail probability by the expectation of a well-chosen non-negative function, and then optimize over a free parameter of this function.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q13.1. Why is the kl confidence interval narrower than Hoeffding's when the empirical risk is small?

Q13.2. A non-negative random variable has mean 0.02. What can you say about $\mathbb{P}(Z \geq 0.2)$?

Q13.3. A classifier fixed in advance makes $\hat{p}$ errors on $m = 1000$ test points. What is the width of Hoeffding's upper confidence bound at level 95%?

Q13.4. Why do PAC-Bayesian proofs need Maurer's lemma, which bounds an exponential moment, rather than Chernoff's tail bound?

Q13.5. True or false? For all q and ε, $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(q, \varepsilon) \leq q + \sqrt{\varepsilon/2}$.

Q13.6. What is $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(0, \varepsilon)$?

13.3 The Kullback–Leibler divergence and the change of measure

Everything so far concerns a voter fixed *before* seeing the data. Learning is precisely the opposite: the algorithm looks at the sample and chooses. To account for this choice, PAC-Bayes compares the distribution Q that has been chosen with a distribution P that was fixed in advance. We need two things: a way to measure how far Q is from P, and a way to transfer statements that are true under P into statements under Q. The Kullback–Leibler divergence and the change of measure inequality provide exactly these two things.

Definition 13.7: Kullback–Leibler divergence

For $Q, P \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$ such that Q is absolutely continuous w.r.t. P,

$$\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}\left[\ln \frac{dQ}{dP}(h)\right] \quad \Big(= \sum_{h\in\mathcal{H}} Q(h) \ln \frac{Q(h)}{P(h)} \ \text{ if } \mathcal{H} \text{ is finite}\Big),$$

and $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = +\infty$ otherwise.

The KL divergence, also called relative entropy (Cover and Thomas, 2006), is always non-negative and it vanishes only when $Q = P$; this is Gibbs' inequality, a consequence of Jensen's inequality (Proposition 1.3) applied to the concave logarithm. It is not symmetric, and it is not a distance, but it behaves as a measure of how far the posterior has moved away from the prior. A few examples help to get a feeling for its values.

On a finite set of n voters with the uniform prior, it takes the simple form $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = \ln n - H(Q)$, where $H(Q) = -\sum_h Q(h) \ln Q(h)$ is the Shannon entropy of Q. The KL is then zero for the uniform posterior and maximal, equal to $\ln n$, for a Dirac on a single voter; if Q is uniform on k of the n voters, $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = \ln \frac{n}{k}$: concentrating on a tenth of the voters costs $\ln 10$ nats. For product distributions the KL divergence adds up, $\mathrm{KL}(Q_1 \otimes Q_2\|P_1 \otimes P_2) = \mathrm{KL}(Q_1\|P_1) + \mathrm{KL}(Q_2\|P_2)$; in particular $\mathrm{KL}(Q^2\|P^2) = 2\,\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ where $Q^2 = Q \otimes Q$ is the distribution of a pair of independent voters, an identity which will be used for majority votes. Finally, for Gaussian distributions with the same covariance, $\mathrm{KL}\left(\mathcal{N}(\mu_1, \sigma^2 I_d)\,\|\,\mathcal{N}(\mu_0, \sigma^2 I_d)\right) = \frac{\|\mu_1 - \mu_0\|^2}{2\sigma^2}$. These properties are proved in the tutorial sheet, and Fig. 121 gives an idea of the values taken by the KL divergence on these examples: a few nats already correspond to a posterior that has moved far away from the prior.

We now have a way to measure how far Q is from P; it remains to transfer statements from one to the other. The following inequality, the heart of every PAC-Bayesian proof, does exactly that. It allows us to replace an expectation under the data-dependent posterior Q by an expectation under the data-independent prior P, at the price of $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$.

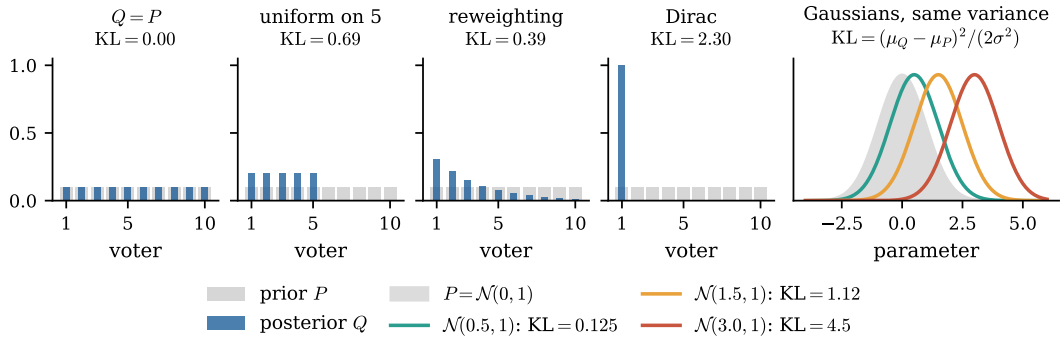


Figure 121: Orders of magnitude of $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$. Four posteriors (blue) on $n = 10$ voters with the uniform prior (grey): the uniform posterior costs nothing, the uniform distribution on half of the voters costs $\ln 2$, and the Dirac on one voter costs the maximal value $\ln 10$. Right: for Gaussians with the same variance, the KL grows like the squared distance between the means.

Lemma 13.8: Change of measure (Donsker and Varadhan, 1975; Csiszár, 1975)

For any measurable function $\phi : \mathcal{H} \to \mathbb{R}$ and any $P \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$,

$$\forall Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H}), \qquad \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}[\phi(h)] \;\le\; \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim P}\left[e^{\phi(h)}\right]. \tag{13.2}$$

Moreover, when $\mathbb{E}_P e^{\phi} < \infty$, equality holds for the *Gibbs distribution* $Q_\phi(h) = \frac{e^{\phi(h)}P(h)}{\mathbb{E}_P e^{\phi}}$, so that

$$\ln \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim P}\left[e^{\phi(h)}\right] = \sup_{Q\in\mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})} \left\{ \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}[\phi(h)] - \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) \right\}. \tag{13.3}$$

Proof. Assume $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) < \infty$ (otherwise there is nothing to prove) and let Q_ϕ be the Gibbs distribution. We compute the divergence between Q and Q_ϕ (written for a finite $\mathcal{H}$ to keep the notation light):

$$\begin{aligned} 0 \le \mathrm{KL}(Q\|Q_\phi) &= \sum_h Q(h) \ln \frac{Q(h)}{Q_\phi(h)} \\ &\downarrow \text{ definition of } Q_\phi\text{: } \ln Q_\phi(h) = \phi(h) + \ln P(h) - \ln \mathbb{E}_P e^{\phi} \\ &= \sum_h Q(h)\Big[\ln \frac{Q(h)}{P(h)} - \phi(h) + \ln \mathbb{E}_P e^{\phi} \Big] \\ &\downarrow \text{ linearity, and } \sum_h Q(h) = 1 \\ &= \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) - \mathbb{E}_Q \phi + \ln \mathbb{E}_P e^{\phi}. \end{aligned}$$

Rearranging gives (13.2), with equality if and only if $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|Q_\phi) = 0$, that is $Q = Q_\phi$. □

In plain words, the average of ϕ under *any* posterior is controlled by an exponential average under the prior, which does not depend on Q, plus a penalty that grows as Q moves away from P. Since the inequality holds for all Q at once, the posterior may be chosen after the fact. The proof shows even more than the inequality: the gap

in (13.2) is exactly $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|Q_\phi)$, the divergence between Q and the Gibbs distribution. Figure 122 illustrates this on a small example with 25 voters: along the segment joining an arbitrary posterior Q to Q_ϕ, the quantity $\mathbb{E}_Q\phi - \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ increases until it reaches the value $\ln \mathbb{E}_P e^\phi$ at Q_ϕ.

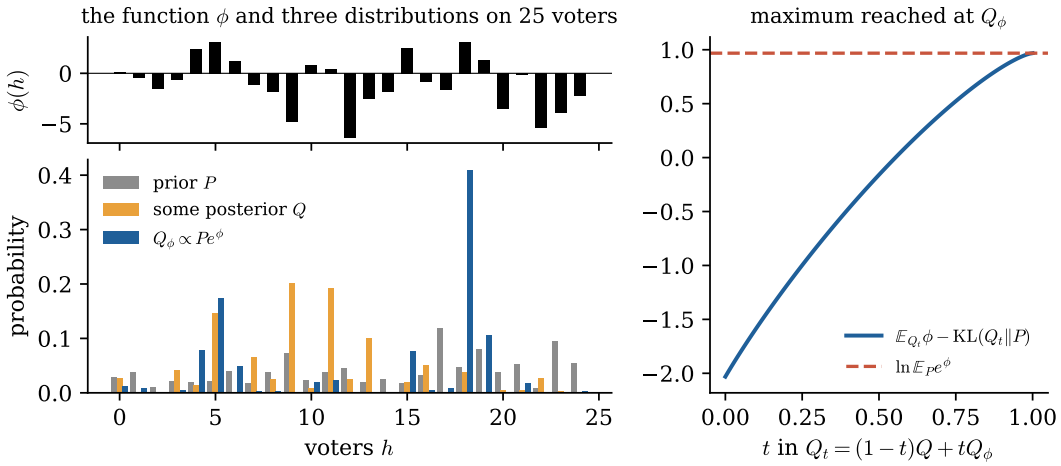


Figure 122: The change of measure on 25 voters. Left: a function ϕ (top), and three distributions (bottom): a prior P, an arbitrary posterior Q and the Gibbs distribution $Q_\phi \propto Pe^\phi$, which puts its mass on the voters where ϕ is large while remaining close to P. Right: value of $\mathbb{E}_{Q_t}\phi - \mathrm{KL}(Q_t\|P)$ along $Q_t = (1-t)Q + tQ_\phi$; it never exceeds $\ln \mathbb{E}_P e^\phi$ and reaches it at Q_ϕ.

In a nutshell

Equation (13.3) says that $\ln \mathbb{E}_P e^\phi$ is the maximal value of a "fit minus complexity" criterion $\mathbb{E}_Q\phi - \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$, and that the best posterior is obtained by *exponentially reweighting* the prior. This variational principle is the origin of the *Gibbs posterior* (Section 15.1) and of the link between PAC-Bayes and Bayesian inference.

Recent work: beyond the Kullback–Leibler divergence The change of measure is the only place where the KL divergence enters PAC-Bayes, and recent works replace it. Ohnishi and Honorio (2021) derive change of measure inequalities for f-divergences such as the χ^2 divergence, which only require the second moment of ϕ under the prior instead of its exponential moment, and thus apply to heavy-tailed losses. Lugosi and Neu (2022) show that any *strongly convex* function of the posterior can play the role of the KL, and Kuzborskij et al. (2024) build, from coin-betting arguments, a divergence that is never much larger than $\sqrt{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)\cdot \mathrm{TV}(Q,P)} + \mathrm{TV}(Q,P)$, where TV is the total variation distance; since $\mathrm{TV} \le 1$, their bounds improve on the KL ones precisely when the posterior is far from the prior. Section 19 returns to these alternatives.

13.4 Warm-up: the Occam bound

Before combining the two tools in full generality, let us see how far the concentration inequalities alone can take us when the learner selects one classifier among many. Consider a *countable* class $\mathcal{H}$ and a prior P on $\mathcal{H}$, which can be thought of as a "description

length": $\ln \frac{1}{P(h)}$ is the number of nats needed to describe h with a code adapted to P.

Theorem 13.9: Occam's razor bound (Blumer et al., 1987; Langford, 2005)

For any countable $\mathcal{H}$, any prior P with $P(h) > 0$ for all h, and any $\delta \in (0, 1]$, with probability at least $1 - \delta$ over $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$,

$$\forall h \in \mathcal{H}, \qquad R_{\mathcal{D}}(h) \le \overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}\Big(\widehat{R}_S(h), \frac{\ln \frac{1}{P(h)} + \ln \frac{1}{\delta}}{m}\Big),$$

$$\text{hence} \qquad R_{\mathcal{D}}(h) \le \widehat{R}_S(h) + \sqrt{\frac{\ln \frac{1}{P(h)} + \ln \frac{1}{\delta}}{2m}}.$$

Proof. For a fixed h, $m\widehat{R}_S(h)$ is a sum of m i.i.d. Bernoulli variables of mean $R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)$. By Chernoff's bound (lower tail of $\widehat{R}_S(h)$), the event

$$\{\widehat{R}_S(h) < R_{\mathcal{D}}(h) \text{ and } \mathrm{kl}(\widehat{R}_S(h) \| R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)) > \varepsilon_h\} = \{R_{\mathcal{D}}(h) > \overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(\widehat{R}_S(h), \varepsilon_h)\}$$

has probability at most $e^{-m\varepsilon_h} = \delta P(h)$ when $\varepsilon_h = \frac{1}{m} \ln \frac{1}{\delta P(h)}$. A union bound over $h \in \mathcal{H}$ gives a total failure probability at most $\sum_h \delta P(h) = \delta$. The second statement follows from Pinsker's inequality. □

The theorem certifies every hypothesis of the class at once, so it remains valid for the one the learner finally picks. Its proof shows how the prior works: it *distributes the confidence budget* δ over the hypotheses, each h receiving the share $\delta P(h)$. A hypothesis that was *a priori* likely is cheap, and an unlikely one is expensive. With the uniform prior on a finite class, $\ln \frac{1}{P(h)} = \ln |\mathcal{H}|$ and we recover the classical bound for finite classes of Section 6. As shown in Fig. 123, the price of a large finite class is surprisingly small: with $m = 1000$ examples and an empirical risk of 5%, going from 10 to 10^{12} candidate classifiers only moves the bound from about 0.08 to 0.12.

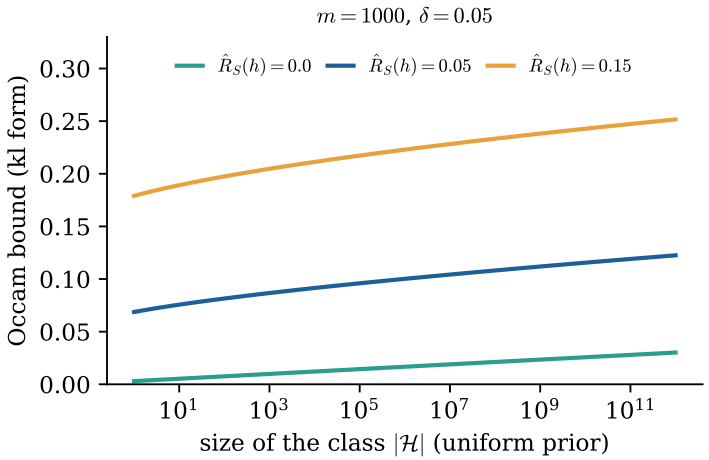


Figure 123: The Occam bound (kl form, $\delta = 0.05$, $m = 1000$) as a function of the size of the class, for three values of the empirical risk. The complexity only grows like $\ln |\mathcal{H}|$.

The Occam bound already has the PAC-Bayesian flavour, but it has two limits. It only certifies a *single* hypothesis — in the language of the next sections, a Dirac posterior, for which $\mathrm{KL}(\delta_h \| P) = \ln \frac{1}{P(h)}$ — and it is useless for uncountable classes, where $P(h) = 0$ for every h. PAC-Bayes removes both limits by considering *averages* of hypotheses: averaging over a posterior which puts a large mass around a good hypothesis costs much less than pinpointing this hypothesis exactly. Making this idea precise, with the change of measure in place of the union bound, is the purpose of the next section.

Recent work: Occam bounds for large language models The Occam bound has found a spectacular application to modern models, whose number of parameters is much larger than the number of examples. The idea is to choose as prior a *code*: $P(h) \propto 2^{-|h|}$, where $|h|$ is the length in bits of a compressed description of h, so that $\ln \frac{1}{P(h)}$ is the size of the compressed model. Lotfi et al. (2024a) compress large language models (low-rank adaptation in a random subspace, then quantization) and certify their next-token prediction with a bound of the form

$$R(h) \leq \widehat{R}_S(h) + \Delta \sqrt{\frac{\ln \frac{1}{P(h)} + \ln \frac{1}{\delta}}{2m}},$$

where Δ is the range of the (smoothed, hence bounded) log-loss; they obtain the first non-vacuous bounds for models of the size of GPT-2, and Lotfi et al. (2024b) extend them to LLaMA-2 models with up to 70 billion parameters by counting tokens, rather than documents, as data points (with a martingale argument, since tokens are not independent). In the same spirit, Akinwande et al. (2024) explain why prompt engineering for zero-shot image classifiers does not overfit: a prompt is a short sequence of words, and a language model provides a natural prior P on prompts. They report, for instance, a bound of 31.9% for a test error of 25.6% on ImageNet with handcrafted prompts.

To remember from Section 13

For a fixed voter, the empirical risk concentrates around the true risk; the binary kl gives the sharpest statement, and its inversion $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}$, computed by bisection, turns an empirical risk into a certified upper bound, with a fast rate when the risk is small. The change of measure inequality $\mathbb{E}_Q \phi \leq \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \mathbb{E}_P e^{\phi}$ transfers a statement about a data-independent prior to any posterior, at the price $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$, and it is an equality for the Gibbs distribution. The Occam bound is the special case of Dirac posteriors on a countable class; its price is $\ln \frac{1}{P(h)}$.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q13.7. What is $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ when P is uniform on n voters and Q is uniform on k of them?

Q13.8. For which posterior is the change of measure inequality an equality?

Q13.9. In the Occam bound, what plays the role of the complexity of the chosen hypothesis?

Q13.10. Is the KL divergence symmetric? Give a numerical example.

Q13.11. When is $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ infinite?

Q13.12. What is $\mathrm{KL}\left(\mathcal{N}(\mu_1, I_d)\|\mathcal{N}(\mu_0, I_d)\right)$ when $\|\mu_1 - \mu_0\| = 3$?

Q13.13. True or false? $\mathbb{E}_Q \phi \leq \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \mathbb{E}_P e^{\phi}$ only holds for posteriors that do not depend on the data.

Q13.14. In the proof of the Occam bound, what plays the role that the change of measure plays in PAC-Bayes?

Q13.15. Why is the Occam bound useless for an uncountable class such as linear classifiers with real weights?

Exercises

Exercise 13.1. **(Computation)** Compute $\mathrm{kl}(0.1\|0.2)$ and $\mathrm{kl}(0.2\|0.1)$. Is the binary kl symmetric?

Exercise 13.2. **(Proof)** Show that the Gibbs distribution Q_ϕ of Lemma 13.8 is the only posterior for which the change of measure is an equality.

Exercise 13.3. **(Application)** Using the Occam bound in Pinsker form, how many examples are needed to certify a risk below 0.15 for a classifier with empirical risk 0.1 chosen among 10^6 candidates, with $\delta = 0.05$ (uniform prior)?

Exercise 13.4. **(Proof)** Using Pinsker's inequality, show that the kl interval of Figure 120 is never wider than the Hoeffding interval. Determine numerically for which empirical risks it is at least twice narrower when $m = 1000$ and $\delta = 0.05$.

Exercise 13.5. **(Comprehension)** True or false? Justify briefly. (a) If P and Q are two distributions on a finite set of voters, $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ is finite. (b) If P is uniform on n voters, then $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) \le \ln n$ for every posterior Q. (c) In the Occam bound with the uniform prior, doubling the number of candidate classifiers doubles the complexity term $\ln \frac{1}{P(h)}$.

Exercise 13.6. **(Application)** Let P be uniform on $n = 4$ voters. Compute $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ for $Q = (\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{4}, 0)$, for $Q' = (0.7, 0.1, 0.1, 0.1)$ and for the Dirac δ_{h_1}, both from the definition and with the formula $\ln n - H(Q)$. Compute also $\mathrm{KL}(P\|Q')$ and $\mathrm{KL}(P\|Q)$, and comment.

Exercise 13.7. **(Application)** Check the two test-set certificates of the running example of this section: a vote with 4.4% of errors on 540 test points, certified by Hoeffding's inequality (0.097) and by the kl inversion (0.069) with $\delta = 0.05$. Recompute both certificates with $\delta = 0.01$, and comment on the cost of the extra confidence.

Exercise 13.8. **(Proof)** Prove Markov's inequality (Lemma 13.2) in detail, then deduce Chebyshev's inequality: for a random variable Z with mean μ and variance v, $\mathbb{P}(|Z - \mu| \ge a) \le \frac{v}{a^2}$ for every $a > 0$. Compare it with the one-sided Cantelli inequality (Lemma 13.6) when $a^2 = v$.

Exercise 13.9. **(Proof)** Admitting the bound on the moment generating function $\mathbb{E}\, e^{\lambda(p-\hat{p})} \le e^{\lambda^2/(8m)}$ (Lemma 13.3), prove the tail bound $\mathbb{P}(p - \hat{p} \ge \varepsilon) \le e^{-2m\varepsilon^2}$ by optimizing over $\lambda > 0$, and deduce that $p \le \hat{p} + \sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)/(2m)}$ with probability at least $1 - \delta$.

Exercise 13.10. **(Proof)** Let Q_1, P_1 be distributions on a finite set $\mathcal{H}_1$ and Q_2, P_2 distributions on a finite set $\mathcal{H}_2$, with P_1, P_2 positive. Show that $\mathrm{KL}(Q_1 \otimes Q_2\|P_1 \otimes P_2) = \mathrm{KL}(Q_1\|P_1) + \mathrm{KL}(Q_2\|P_2)$, and deduce that $\mathrm{KL}(Q^2\|P^2) = 2\,\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$, the identity used for the tandem bound. Show also that $\mathrm{KL}(\delta_h\|P) = \ln \frac{1}{P(h)}$ for a Dirac posterior.

Exercise 13.11. **(Computation)** Let $m = 100$ i.i.d. Bernoulli variables of mean $p = 0.1$ (the errors of a fixed classifier). (a) Compute exactly $\mathbb{P}(\hat{p} \le 0.02)$, the probability that the empirical risk is at most 0.02. (b) Compare with Chernoff's bound $e^{-m\,\mathrm{kl}(0.02\|0.1)}$ (Lemma 13.4, or Proposition 1.12 of Section 1) and with Hoeffding's bound $e^{-2m(0.08)^2}$. (c) Explain the difference.

Exercise 13.12. **(Proof)** Admitting the refined Pinsker inequality $\mathrm{kl}(q\|p) \ge \frac{(p-q)^2}{2p}$ for $q < p$ (proved in the appendix), show that $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(q, \varepsilon) \le q + \sqrt{2q\varepsilon} + 2\varepsilon$. Compare the three upper bounds $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(q, \varepsilon)$, $q + \sqrt{\varepsilon/2}$ and $q + \sqrt{2q\varepsilon} + 2\varepsilon$ for $(q, \varepsilon) = (0.1, 0.05)$ and $(0.01, 0.005)$.

Exercise 13.13. **(Python)** (a) Implement the binary kl and its upper inversion by bisection (Algorithm 12), and check that $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(0.1, 0.05) \approx 0.220$. (b) Compute Maurer's constant $\xi(m)$ of (13.1) for $m \in \{8, 100, 1000\}$, check that $\sqrt{m} \le \xi(m) \le 2\sqrt{m}$, and guess the limit of $\xi(m)/\sqrt{m}$.

Exercise 13.14. **(Proof)** Let $\mathcal{H}$ be finite, P positive on $\mathcal{H}$, and $\phi : \mathcal{H} \to \mathbb{R}$. (a) Give a second proof of the change of measure inequality (13.2): write $\mathbb{E}_Q \phi - \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = \mathbb{E}_Q \ln \frac{P\, e^\phi}{Q}$ (sum

over the support of Q) and apply Jensen's inequality. (b) Let $A \subseteq \mathcal{H}$ with $0 < P(A) < 1$ and $0 < Q(A) < 1$. Applying (13.2) to $\phi = t\,\mathbb{1}[h \in A]$ and optimizing over $t \in \mathbb{R}$, show that $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) \geq \mathrm{kl}\big(Q(A)\|P(A)\big)$. (c) P is uniform on 100 voters and Q puts a mass 0.9 on a set A of 5 voters. Give a lower bound on $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$, and a posterior that attains it.

Exercise 13.15. **(Application)** We learn decision trees, and we encode each tree by a binary string with a prefix-free code (no code word is the beginning of another one), so that $P(h) = 2^{-|h|}$ defines a sub-probability by Kraft's inequality $\sum_h 2^{-|h|} \leq 1$. (a) Why is a sub-probability enough in the proof of the Occam bound? (b) With $m = 2000$ examples and $\delta = 0.05$, a tree described with $|h| = 50$ bits has an empirical risk of 0.08. Compute the Occam bound in its kl and Pinsker forms. (c) A larger tree, described with 400 bits, has an empirical risk of 0.05. Which of the two trees has the better certificate (kl form)?

14 PAC-Bayesian generalization bounds

About this section

Guiding question. *How much can the true risk of a randomly drawn voter exceed its empirical risk, when the distribution of the voters has been chosen with the data?*

This section bounds the true risk of the Gibbs classifier G_Q. We first explain why a useful bound must hold simultaneously for all posteriors, then state and prove a general PAC-Bayesian theorem whose proof has only three steps (Jensen, change of measure, Markov). The classical bounds of McAllester, Seeger–Maurer and Catoni, and the PAC-Bayes-λ bound, are all obtained as corollaries, and we compare them numerically to learn how to read the different terms of a bound.

14.1 Why the bound must hold for all posteriors

Before stating any PAC-Bayesian bound, we must understand what kind of guarantee we need. A learning algorithm looks at the data before choosing its output. If we compute a confidence bound for the chosen predictor as if it had been fixed in advance, we forget this selection step, and the bound can be badly wrong. The experiment reported in Fig. 124 shows how badly. We draw 1000 classifiers that answer completely at random, so that each of them has a true risk of exactly 0.5, and we evaluate them on a sample of $m = 100$ examples. By chance alone, the best of them has an empirical risk of about 0.34 on average. If we now apply Hoeffding's inequality to this best classifier as if it were fixed, we obtain an "upper bound" which is below 0.5 in 99.8% of the runs, although it should fail in at most 5% of them. The Occam bound of Section 13.4, which pays $\ln 1000$ for the selection, fails in only 0.3% of the runs.

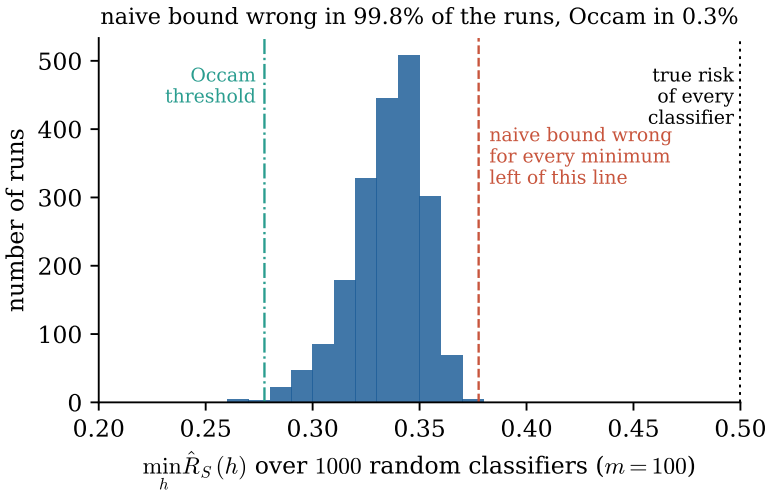


Figure 124: Selection bias. Distribution, over 2000 repetitions, of the smallest empirical risk among 1000 random classifiers of true risk 0.5, measured on $m = 100$ examples. A confidence bound computed for the selected classifier as if it had been fixed in advance is violated whenever the minimum falls to the left of the dashed red line, that is in almost every run; the Occam bound is only violated to the left of the dash-dotted line.

This is why all the bounds of this section are *uniform*: they hold, with probability at least $1 - \delta$, for all posteriors Q at the same time. The posterior can then be chosen

by any procedure that looks at the data — including the minimization of the bound itself — without invalidating the guarantee. The price of uniformity is the complexity term $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$, which plays the role that $\ln|\mathcal{H}|$ played in the Occam bound. The next subsection shows that this price is enough, with a single theorem.

14.2 A general PAC-Bayesian theorem

Rather than proving each classical bound separately, we prove one theorem that contains them all, in the form given by Germain et al. (2009) and Bégin et al. (2016). It is parametrized by a convex function Δ, which measures the discrepancy between an empirical risk and a true risk.

Theorem 14.1: General PAC-Bayesian theorem (Germain et al., 2009; Bégin et al., 2016)

Let $\Delta : [0,1]\times[0,1] \to \mathbb{R}$ be a *jointly convex* function. For any distribution $\mathcal{D}$ on $\mathcal{X}\times\mathcal{Y}$, any set of voters $\mathcal{H}$, any loss ℓ with values in $[0,1]$, any prior $P \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$ and any $\delta \in (0,1]$, with probability at least $1-\delta$ over $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$,

$$\forall Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H}), \quad \Delta\big(\widehat{R}_S(G_Q), R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)\big) \le \frac{1}{m}\left[\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln\frac{\mathcal{I}_\Delta(m)}{\delta}\right], \tag{14.1}$$

where $\mathcal{I}_\Delta(m) = \mathbb{E}_{S'\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\left[\mathbb{E}_{h\sim P}\left[e^{m\Delta\left(\widehat{R}_{S'}(h), R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)\right)}\right]\right]$.

In words, with high probability, and for every posterior at once, the gap between the empirical and the true Gibbs risk, measured by Δ, is at most a complexity per example: the KL divergence plus a confidence term, divided by m. Only $\mathcal{I}_\Delta(m)$ is left to compute, and it involves the prior alone.

Before the proof, let us describe its strategy. We want to control a quantity that involves the posterior Q, which depends on the data, and we only know how to control quantities that involve voters fixed in advance. The proof therefore moves the problem in three steps. First, it replaces the discrepancy of the *average* voter by the average discrepancy of the voters (Jensen). Second, it replaces the average under Q by an average under the prior P, at the price $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ (change of measure). Third, it controls the resulting quantity, which no longer involves Q, on average over the samples (Markov). The function Δ only matters in the last step, and each choice of Δ will give one of the classical bounds. Figure 125 summarizes this strategy; keep it in mind while reading the proof.

Proof. Fix a sample S and a posterior Q. The first two steps are deterministic inequalities:

$$m\,\Delta\big(\widehat{R}_S(G_Q), R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)\big) = m\,\Delta\Big(\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}\big[\widehat{R}_S(h)\big], \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}\big[R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)\big]\Big)$$

$$\downarrow \text{ Step 1: Jensen's inequality, } \Delta \text{ being jointly convex}$$

$$\le \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}\Big[m\,\Delta\big(\widehat{R}_S(h), R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)\big)\Big]$$

$$\downarrow \text{ Step 2: change of measure (Lemma 13.8) with } \phi = m\Delta(\widehat{R}_S, R_{\mathcal{D}})$$

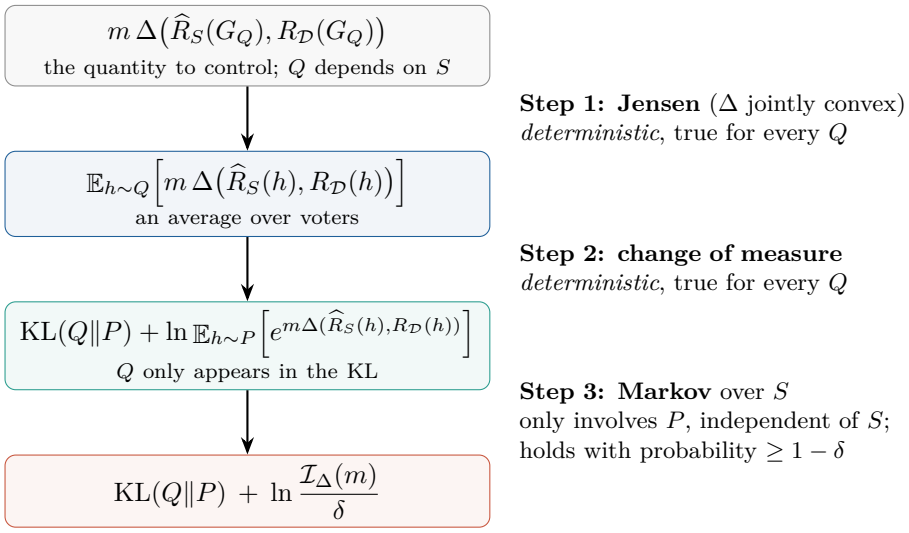


Figure 125: The three steps of the proof of Theorem 14.1. Only the last one is probabilistic, and it does not involve the posterior: this is why the bound holds simultaneously for all Q.

$$\leq \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \underbrace{\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim P}\Big[e^{m\Delta(\widehat{R}_S(h),R_{\mathcal{D}}(h))}\Big]}_{=:\,Z(S),\text{ free of }Q}.$$

The posterior has now disappeared from the last term, which only involves the prior: $Z(S)$ is a non-negative random variable that depends on the sample only. The third step bounds it with Markov's inequality (Lemma 13.2): with probability at least $1-\delta$ over S,

$$Z(S) \leq \frac{1}{\delta} \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S'\sim\mathcal{D}^m}[Z(S')]$$

$$\downarrow \text{ Fubini: } P \text{ does not depend on } S', \text{ the expectations can be exchanged}$$

$$= \frac{1}{\delta} \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim P}\Big[\mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{S'\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\Big[e^{m\Delta(\widehat{R}_{S'}(h),R_{\mathcal{D}}(h))}\Big]\Big] = \frac{\mathcal{I}_\Delta(m)}{\delta}.$$

On this event of probability at least $1-\delta$, inequality (14.1) holds for *every* Q, because the first two steps are deterministic and valid for all posteriors simultaneously. □

The structure of this proof deserves attention, because it explains most of what follows. The only probabilistic statement is made in the third step, and it only concerns the prior: this is where the prior must be independent of the sample, since we need to exchange $\mathbb{E}_{S'}$ and $\mathbb{E}_{h\sim P}$ with P fixed. The posterior, on the other hand, only appears in the deterministic steps, and it may depend on S in an arbitrary way. This asymmetry is what makes PAC-Bayesian bounds usable as learning objectives: we are free to minimize them over Q.

To obtain a usable bound, it remains to choose Δ so that $\mathcal{I}_\Delta(m)$ can be computed or bounded. For a *fixed* voter h, $m\widehat{R}_S(h)$ is a sum of m independent variables in $[0,1]$ with mean $R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)$, so the concentration results of Section 13 apply. Each of them yields one of the classical bounds, and the next subsection goes through them in turn: the kl form (the tightest), its relaxation by Pinsker's inequality (the most readable), Catoni's bound, and two linear bounds (the easiest to optimize).

14.3 The classical bounds

14.3.1 Seeger's bound (kl form)

The most natural choice is the binary kl itself, since Maurer's lemma tells us exactly how large its exponential moment is.

Corollary 14.2: Seeger (2002); Langford (2005), with the constant of Maurer (2004)

For $m \geq 8$, with probability at least $1-\delta$ over $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$, for all $Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$,

$$\operatorname{kl}\left(\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) \,\|\, R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)\right) \leq \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}}{m}, \tag{14.2}$$

that is, $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) \leq \overline{\operatorname{kl}}^{-1}\Big(\widehat{R}_S(G_Q),\ \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)+\ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}}{m}\Big)$.

Proof. Take $\Delta = \operatorname{kl}$, which is jointly convex. By Maurer's lemma (Lemma 13.4), for every fixed h, $\mathbb{E}_{S'} e^{m \operatorname{kl}(\widehat{R}_{S'}(h)\|R_{\mathcal{D}}(h))} \leq \xi(m) \leq 2\sqrt{m}$, hence $\mathcal{I}_{\operatorname{kl}}(m) \leq 2\sqrt{m}$. □

In plain words, the true Gibbs risk is at most the largest value that is still "plausible", in the sense of the kl, given the observed Gibbs risk and a budget equal to the complexity per example. Seeger's bound has no free parameter and no closed form, but it is computed in a few microseconds by the bisection of Algorithm 12. As the numerical comparison below will show, it is among the tightest bounds available, and it is the one we use by default to compute risk certificates. It inherits the fast rate of the kl: when the empirical risk is zero, it gives $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) \leq 1-e^{-\varepsilon} \leq \varepsilon$ with $\varepsilon = \frac{1}{m}[\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)+\ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}]$, a rate in $1/m$. Its only weakness is that it is implicit, which makes it hard to read; the next bound trades some tightness for readability.

Recent work: a certificate valid for all sample sizes Seeger's bound holds for a sample size m fixed in advance. If examples arrive one at a time and we want to stop as soon as the certificate is good enough, the bound must hold for all m simultaneously; a union bound over m with confidence $\delta/(m(m+1))$ costs about $2\ln m$ extra nats. Jang et al. (2023) obtain such *time-uniform* bounds by a coin-betting argument: the wealth of a gambler who bets on the deviations $\widehat{R}_S(h) - R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)$ is a non-negative supermartingale, and Ville's maximal inequality controls it at all times. One of their corollaries is exactly Seeger's bound, valid for all m at once and with the constant $2\sqrt{m}$ replaced by $\sqrt{\pi}\,\Gamma(m+1)/\Gamma(m+\frac{1}{2}) \approx \sqrt{\pi m}$: with probability at least $1-\delta$, for all $m \geq 1$ and all Q,

$$\operatorname{kl}\left(\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) \,\|\, R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)\right) \leq \frac{1}{m}\Big[\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \frac{\sqrt{\pi}\,\Gamma(m+1)}{\Gamma(m+\frac{1}{2})} + \ln \frac{1}{\delta}\Big].$$

Figure 126 shows that time uniformity is therefore free: the new constant is even slightly smaller than Maurer's. Related anytime-valid bounds based on supermartingales are due to Chugg et al. (2023) and, for heavy-tailed losses, to Haddouche and Guedj (2023).

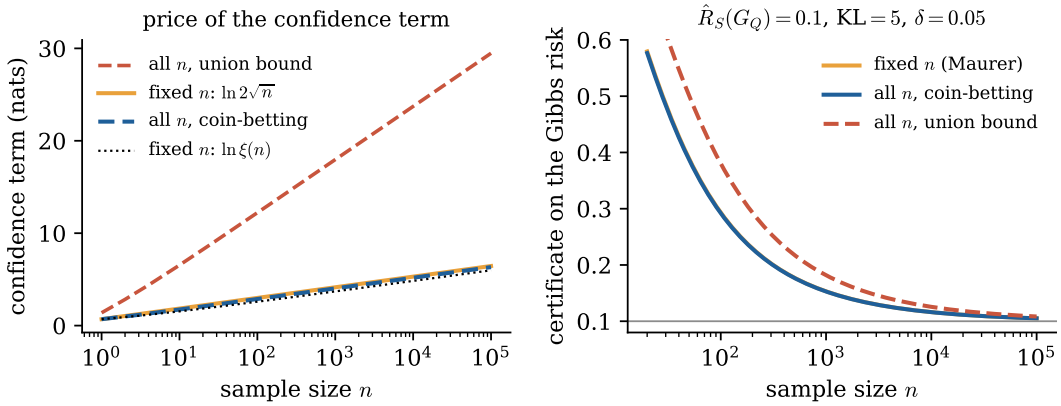


Figure 126: Time-uniform certificates. Left: confidence term of the kl bound for a fixed sample size (Maurer's $\ln 2\sqrt{n}$ and its exact value $\ln \xi(n)$), for all sample sizes at once by coin-betting (Jang et al., 2023), and by a union bound over n. Right: the resulting certificates for an empirical Gibbs risk of 0.1 and $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 5$; the fixed-n and coin-betting curves are indistinguishable.

14.3.2 McAllester's bound

Relaxing the kl with Pinsker's inequality gives the historical PAC-Bayesian bound, whose form is the easiest to interpret.

Corollary 14.3: McAllester (1999b, 2003a), in the form of Maurer (2004)

For $m \geq 8$, with probability at least $1-\delta$ over $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$, for all $Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$,

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) \leq \widehat{R}_S(G_Q) + \sqrt{\frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}}{2m}}. \tag{14.3}$$

Proof. Apply Pinsker's inequality $\mathrm{kl}(q\|p) \geq 2(q-p)^2$ to (14.2). □

McAllester's bound reads "true risk ≤ empirical risk + complexity",

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) \;\leq\; \underbrace{\widehat{R}_S(G_Q)}_{\text{fit to the data}} \;+\; \underbrace{\sqrt{\frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}}{2m}}}_{\text{price of choosing } Q \text{ with the data}},$$

where the complexity is a square root of the KL per example. It has the same structure as the VC or Rademacher bounds of Sections 6 and 10, the capacity of the class being replaced by the divergence of the chosen posterior from the prior. Its drawback is the $1/\sqrt{m}$ rate, which it keeps even when the empirical risk is zero; Seeger's bound is always at least as tight.

> **Historical note** The original bounds of McAllester (1998, 1999b) had slightly worse constants, with a numerator of the form $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \frac{1}{\delta} + O(\ln m)$ and a denominator $2m-1$. The kl form was introduced by Seeger (2002), see also Langford (2005), and the clean constant $\ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}$, valid for any loss in $[0,1]$, is due to Maurer (2004).

14.3.3 Catoni's bound

Can we avoid the $\ln 2\sqrt{m}$ term altogether? Catoni (2007) uses a different comparison function, for which the exponential moment is not bounded by $2\sqrt{m}$ but by 1, at the cost of a parameter that must be fixed in advance.

Corollary 14.4: Catoni (2007), see also Germain et al. (2009)

For any fixed $C > 0$, with probability at least $1-\delta$ over $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$, for all Q,

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) \le \frac{1}{1-e^{-C}} \left[1 - \exp\Big(-C\, \widehat{R}_S(G_Q) - \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \frac{1}{\delta}}{m} \Big) \right]. \tag{14.4}$$

Proof. Take $\Delta(q,p) = \mathcal{F}_C(p) - C\,q$ with $\mathcal{F}_C(p) = -\ln\big(1 - p(1-e^{-C})\big)$, which is convex. For a fixed h with risk $p = R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)$, the convexity of $u \mapsto e^{-Cu}$ on $[0,1]$ gives $e^{-Cu} \le 1 - u(1-e^{-C})$, hence, by independence of the examples, $\mathbb{E}_{S'} e^{-Cm\widehat{R}_{S'}(h)} \le \big(1 - p(1-e^{-C})\big)^m = e^{-m\mathcal{F}_C(p)}$. Therefore $\mathbb{E}_{S'} e^{m\Delta(\widehat{R}_{S'}(h),p)} \le 1$ and $\mathcal{I}_\Delta(m) \le 1$. Rearranging $\mathcal{F}_C(R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)) \le C\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) + \frac{1}{m}[\mathrm{KL} + \ln\frac{1}{\delta}]$ gives (14.4). □

The parameter C weighs the empirical risk against the complexity. It cannot be optimized after seeing the data for free, but the price is small. If we apply the bound with confidence δ/k to each value of a grid $C_1, \dots, C_k$ fixed in advance, a union bound shows that it holds for all of them simultaneously; the best value can then be chosen at a cost of only $\ln k$ in the numerator. With such a grid, Catoni's bound is numerically very close to Seeger's, and even marginally smaller when the KL is small, since it does not pay the $\ln 2\sqrt{m}$ term. Using $1 - e^{-x} \le x$, it also implies the *linear* bound $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) \le \frac{1}{1-e^{-C}}\big[C\,\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) + \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)+\ln(1/\delta)}{m}\big]$. Casado et al. (2024) recently showed how to optimize such a parameter *exactly*, without a grid, even for unbounded losses: their *PAC-Bayes-Chernoff* bound, $\mathbb{E}_Q R_{\mathcal{D}} \le \mathbb{E}_Q \widehat{R}_S + \inf_\lambda \big\{ \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)+\ln(m/\delta)}{\lambda(m-1)} + \frac{1}{\lambda}\mathbb{E}_Q \Lambda_h(\lambda) \big\}$, where Λ_h is the cumulant generating function of the loss of h, costs only a $\ln m$ term for the uniformity in λ, as in Cramér–Chernoff's classical bound.

14.3.4 Linear bounds and the PAC-Bayes-λ bound

The last two bounds of this section are *linear* in $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q)$ and in $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$. This is a weakness as far as tightness is concerned, but a great strength for learning: minimizing a linear combination of the empirical risk and of the KL over Q has an explicit solution, the Gibbs posterior of Section 15.1.

Corollary 14.5: Hoeffding-based bound (Catoni, 2007; Alquier, 2024)

For any fixed $\lambda > 0$, with probability at least $1-\delta$ over $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$, for all Q,

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) \le \widehat{R}_S(G_Q) + \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln\frac{1}{\delta}}{\lambda m} + \frac{\lambda}{8}. \tag{14.5}$$

Proof. Take $\Delta(q,p) = \lambda(p-q)$, which is linear, hence convex. By Hoeffding's lemma (Lemma 13.3) applied with parameter λm, $\mathbb{E}_{S'} e^{\lambda m(R_{\mathcal{D}}(h) - \widehat{R}_{S'}(h))} \le e^{\lambda^2 m/8}$, so that $\frac{1}{m}\ln \mathcal{I}_\Delta(m) \le \lambda^2/8$. Divide by λ. □

The bound reads "empirical risk + complexity/λ + $\lambda/8$": a large λ makes the KL cheap but increases the last term, and a small λ does the opposite. The Hoeffding-based bound is the favourite of the statistical literature on PAC-Bayes (Alquier, 2024), because it leads to clean oracle inequalities. Its parameter λ must again be fixed in advance. The next bound, obtained by relaxing Seeger's bound in a clever way, does not have this limitation.

Corollary 14.6: PAC-Bayes-λ bound (Thiemann et al., 2017)

With probability at least $1-\delta$ over $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$, for all $Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$ and all $\lambda \in (0,2)$ *simultaneously*,

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) \le \frac{\widehat{R}_S(G_Q)}{1-\frac{\lambda}{2}} + \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln\frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}}{\lambda(1-\frac{\lambda}{2})m}. \tag{14.6}$$

Proof. Let $\hat{q} = \widehat{R}_S(G_Q)$, $p = R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$ and $\varepsilon = \frac{1}{m}[\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln\frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}]$. On the event of Corollary 14.2, if $p > \hat{q}$, the refined Pinsker inequality gives $(p-\hat{q})^2 \le 2p\,\varepsilon$, that is $p - \hat{q} \le \sqrt{2p\varepsilon}$. For any $\lambda > 0$, $\sqrt{2p\varepsilon} = \sqrt{\lambda p \cdot \frac{2\varepsilon}{\lambda}} \le \frac{\lambda p}{2} + \frac{\varepsilon}{\lambda}$ by the inequality between arithmetic and geometric means. Hence $p(1-\frac{\lambda}{2}) \le \hat{q} + \frac{\varepsilon}{\lambda}$. Since this is a deterministic consequence of (14.2), it holds for all λ at once. □

The PAC-Bayes-λ bound keeps the linear structure of the previous one, but it is a deterministic consequence of Seeger's bound. Because it holds for all λ simultaneously, λ can be optimized freely, at no cost. For a fixed Q, the optimal value is

$$\lambda^\star = \frac{2}{\sqrt{\frac{2m\widehat{R}_S(G_Q)}{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)+\ln\frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}} + 1} + 1}, \tag{14.7}$$

and for this value the PAC-Bayes-λ bound is smaller than the relaxation $\hat{q} + \sqrt{2\hat{q}\varepsilon} + 2\varepsilon$ of Seeger's bound given by Lemma 13.5, but larger than Seeger's bound itself, from which it is derived. Thiemann et al. (2017) show moreover that (14.6) is jointly quasiconvex in (Q,λ) under mild conditions, which is the basis of the alternating minimization algorithm of Section 18.2.2.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q14.1. Which step of the proof of Theorem 14.1 requires the prior to be independent of the sample?

Q14.2. Why may the posterior depend on the data without invalidating the bound?

Q14.3. Which bound has a rate in $1/m$ when the empirical risk is zero, McAllester's or Seeger's?

Q14.4. Why can λ be optimized freely in the PAC-Bayes-λ bound, but not in the Hoeffding-based bound?

Q14.5. With $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0$, $m = 1000$ and $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta} = 10$ nats, what does Seeger's bound give?

14.4 Reading and comparing the bounds

We now have five bounds; to choose among them, we must learn to read them. All these bounds share the same anatomy. The unknown true risk is bounded by a function of two quantities: the empirical risk of the posterior, which measures how well it fits the data, and the complexity per example $\frac{1}{m}[\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}]$, which measures how far the posterior has moved away from the prior. The first term decreases when Q concentrates on good voters, the second increases at the same time, and the bounds only differ in the way these two ingredients are combined. The confidence term is almost negligible: dividing δ by ten only adds $\ln 10 \approx 2.3$ nats to the numerator.

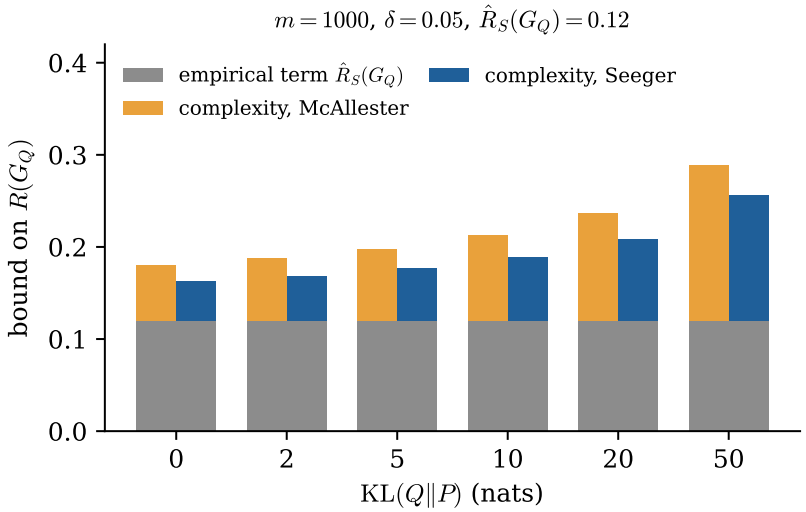


Figure 127: Decomposition of McAllester's and Seeger's bounds into the empirical term (grey) and the complexity term, for $m = 1000$, $\delta = 0.05$ and $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0.12$, as the KL divergence grows.

Figure 127 and Table 9 make this concrete. We fix $m = 1000$, $\delta = 0.05$ and an empirical Gibbs risk of 0.12, and we let the KL divergence grow from 0 to 50 nats. With $\mathrm{KL} = 0$, the complexity per example is only 0.007, and all bounds lie between 0.16 and 0.18. The complexity term of McAllester's bound is already 0.06, half the empirical risk, while Seeger's bound adds only 0.04: the square root of Pinsker's inequality is expensive when the risk is far from $1/2$.

As the KL grows, all bounds deteriorate, but slowly: 50 nats, which is the cost of a posterior putting all its mass on one voter among $e^{50} \approx 5 \times 10^{21}$, still leaves a non-trivial certificate of 0.26. Catoni's bound optimized on a grid and Seeger's bound are almost indistinguishable, the former being slightly smaller for small KL. The PAC-Bayes-λ bound, finally, is tighter than McAllester's bound when the KL is small but not when it is large.

Table 9: Values of the bounds for $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0.12$, $m = 1000$, $\delta = 0.05$. Catoni's bound is optimized on a grid of 30 values of C with a union bound.

$\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$	$\frac{1}{m}[\mathrm{KL} + \ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}]$	McAllester	PAC-Bayes-λ	Catoni (grid)	Seeger
0	0.0071	0.180	0.169	0.160	0.162
2	0.0091	0.188	0.177	0.166	0.168
5	0.0121	0.198	0.187	0.175	0.177
10	0.0171	0.213	0.204	0.187	0.189
20	0.0271	0.236	0.232	0.207	0.209
50	0.0571	0.289	0.307	0.256	0.256

Figure 128 takes the point of view of the user who wants a certificate of a given quality. For an empirical Gibbs risk of 0.1, a certificate below 0.15 requires about 640 examples when the posterior is equal to the prior, 1100 when $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 5$ and more than 5000 when $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 50$: the KL divergence is literally paid in examples, and the right panel shows that, beyond a few nats, the price is roughly linear, each nat costing about a hundred examples.

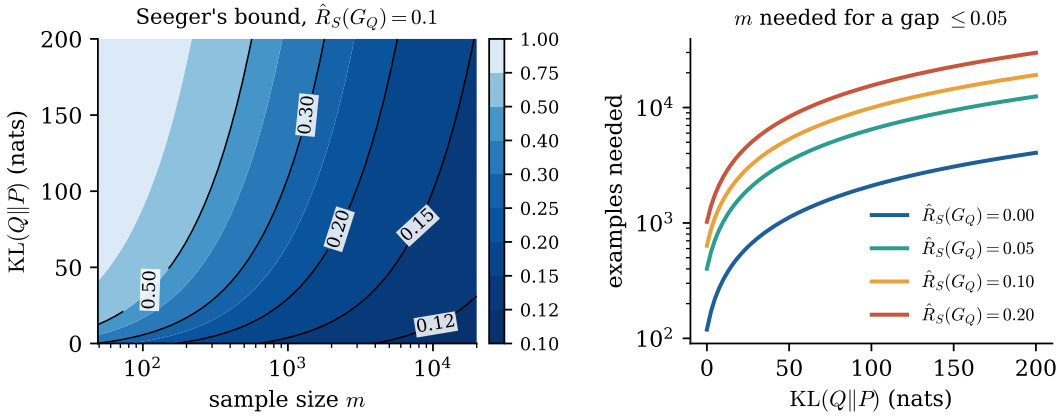


Figure 128: Left: Seeger's bound for $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0.1$ and $\delta = 0.05$, as a function of the sample size and of the KL divergence (level lines at 0.12, 0.15, 0.2, 0.3 and 0.5). Right: number of examples needed for the certificate to exceed the empirical Gibbs risk by at most 0.05.

Figure 129 shows the same comparison from two other angles. As a function of the sample size, the difference between the kl-based bounds and McAllester's bound is most visible when the empirical risk is zero: the former decrease like $1/m$, the latter like $1/\sqrt{m}$. As a function of the empirical risk, the bounds coincide near $1/2$ and separate when the risk is small, which is precisely the regime of good classifiers.

The following table summarizes the section. The first column gives the comparison function used in Theorem 14.1, and the second the bound on its exponential moment that makes the theorem explicit.

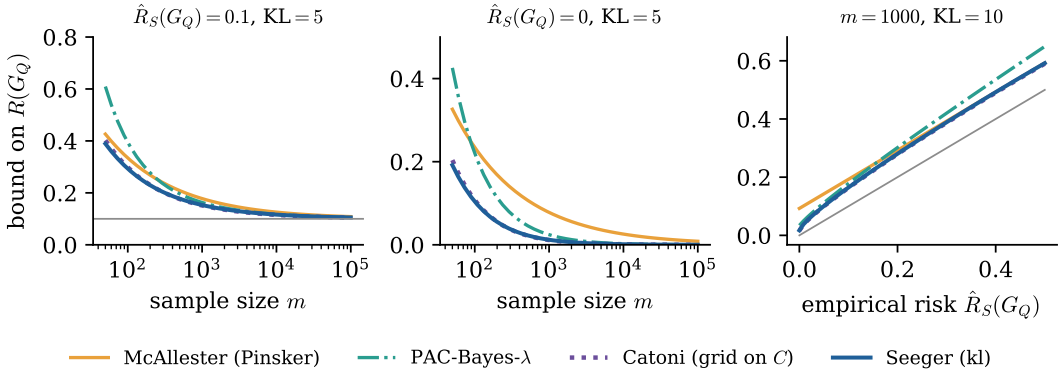


Figure 129: Comparison of the bounds for $\delta = 0.05$. Left: as a function of m, for $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0.1$ and $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 5$. Middle: same with $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0$: the kl-based bounds (Seeger, and Catoni and PAC-Bayes-λ which approximate it) decrease in $1/m$ whereas McAllester's bound decreases in $1/\sqrt{m}$. Right: as a function of the empirical risk for $m = 1000$ and $\mathrm{KL} = 10$.

Bound	$\Delta(q,p)$	$\ln \mathcal{I}_\Delta(m) \leq$	Main features
Seeger (14.2)	$\mathrm{kl}(q\|p)$	$\ln 2\sqrt{m}$	among the tightest; implicit
McAllester (14.3)	$2(q-p)^2$	$\ln 2\sqrt{m}$	readable; slow rate $1/\sqrt{m}$
Catoni (14.4)	$\mathcal{F}_C(p) - Cq$	0	tight on a grid of C
Hoeffding (14.5)	$\lambda(p-q)$	$\lambda^2 m/8$	linear; λ fixed in advance
PAC-Bayes-λ (14.6)	(from Seeger)	$\ln 2\sqrt{m}$	linear, all λ at once

Recent work: which comparator is the best? Theorem 14.1 leaves the choice of the comparison function Δ open. Hellström and Guedj (2024) answer the question: if the loss is dominated (in the sense of its moment generating function) by a family of distributions of mean p, the best convex comparator, up to the logarithmic term $\ln \mathcal{I}_\Delta(m)$, is the *Cramér function* of this family, $\Delta^\star(q,p) = \sup_t \{tq - \ln \mathbb{E} e^{tZ_p}\}$, the convex conjugate of the cumulant generating function of the variable Z_p of mean p. For losses in $[0,1]$, dominated by Bernoulli variables, $\Delta^\star = \mathrm{kl}$: Seeger's bound is optimal among all the bounds of this table. For Gaussian losses of variance σ^2 the optimal comparator is $(q-p)^2/(2\sigma^2)$, and for Poisson losses $p - q + q\ln\frac{q}{p}$. Lugosi and Neu (2023) propose another unifying view, in which a generalization bound is the *regret* of an online learner playing against the sample; the exponential weights algorithm then gives back the linear bound (14.5).

Example 14.1 (Three posteriors on the same ensemble). Consider an ensemble of $n = 100$ voters with the uniform prior P, $m = 1000$ training examples and $\delta = 0.05$, so that $\ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta} = \ln(1264.9) \approx 7.14$. Suppose first that Q is uniform over the 10 voters with the smallest empirical risk, and that its empirical Gibbs risk is 0.12. The divergence is $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = \ln \frac{100}{10} \approx 2.30$, so that $\varepsilon = \frac{2.30+7.14}{1000} \approx 0.0094$. McAllester's bound gives $0.12 + \sqrt{0.0094/2} \approx 0.189$, the PAC-Bayes-$\lambda$ bound (with $\lambda^\star \approx 0.33$) gives 0.178, and Seeger's bound gives $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(0.12, 0.0094) \approx 0.169$. If instead we keep $Q = P$, the KL vanishes but the Gibbs risk is larger, say 0.20, and Seeger's bound gives 0.251. At the

other extreme, the Dirac on the best voter, with empirical risk 0.10, costs $\mathrm{KL} = \ln 100 \approx 4.61$ and Seeger's bound gives 0.152: this is the Occam bound.

In this example, the best *Gibbs* certificate is thus obtained by the Dirac, because $\ln 100$ nats is a small price for $m = 1000$ examples. But the Gibbs risk is not the end of the story: the *majority vote* of the 10 best voters can be much more accurate than any of them, and certifying it requires spread-out posteriors, as we will see in Section 16. In general, the best trade-off between empirical risk and KL is given by the Gibbs posterior of Section 15.1.

Running example Let us certify the Gibbs classifier of our forest, that is a tree drawn at random, with the uniform prior and the uniform posterior, so that $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 0$. We need examples that the trees have not seen; for now, let us admit that each tree may be evaluated on the examples left out of its bootstrap sample (its *out-of-bag* examples), a construction justified in Section 18.2. The average out-of-bag error of the trees is 0.174, computed with at least 747 examples per tree. With $\delta = 0.05$, the complexity per example is $\ln(2\sqrt{747}/0.05)/747 = 0.0094$, McAllester's bound gives 0.243 and Seeger's bound 0.230. The test Gibbs risk, which the bound did not see, is 0.190: the certificate is valid and only four points above. The difficulty is elsewhere: the vote has a test risk of 0.044, and nothing in this section says anything about it. This is the object of Section 16.

Remark (Bernstein-type bounds) When the variance of the loss is small, the kl bound can be further improved by PAC-Bayes-Bernstein inequalities, which involve an empirical variance term (Tolstikhin and Seldin, 2013; Mhammedi et al., 2019). The same idea is used for majority votes in Section 16.8 (Wu et al., 2021).

To remember from Section 14

A generalization bound for a data-dependent predictor must be uniform, otherwise the selection bias makes it meaningless. All the classical PAC-Bayesian bounds follow from Theorem 14.1, whose only probabilistic step uses the independence between the prior and the sample; the posterior can therefore depend on the data arbitrarily. The complexity term is $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)/m$: a posterior close to the prior is cheap. Seeger's kl bound and Catoni's bound optimized on a grid are the tightest, McAllester's bound is the easiest to read, and linear bounds such as PAC-Bayes-λ are the easiest to minimize.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q14.6. Why must a generalization bound for a learned predictor hold uniformly over the predictors (or posteriors)?

Q14.7. What is $\mathcal{I}_\Delta(m)$ in Theorem 14.1, and why can it be computed without knowing the posterior?

Q14.8. Where is the joint convexity of Δ used?

Q14.9. Catoni's bound has no $\ln 2\sqrt{m}$ term. What is the price?

Q14.10. How much does it cost to go from a confidence of 95% to 99.5%?

Q14.11. True or false? The PAC-Bayes-λ bound at $\lambda^\star$ is tighter than Seeger's bound.

Q14.12. A posterior has $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 50$ nats. What does this correspond to for a finite ensemble with a uniform prior?

Q14.13. With $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 0$, $m = 1000$ and $\delta = 0.05$, what is the complexity term of McAllester's bound?

Exercises

Exercise 14.1. **(Proof)** Starting from Theorem 14.1 with $\Delta(q,p) = 2(q-p)^2$, prove McAllester's bound directly, without going through Seeger's bound.

Exercise 14.2. **(Computation)** For $m = 500$, $\delta = 0.05$, $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0.05$ and $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) \in \{0, 5, 20\}$, compute McAllester's and Seeger's bounds, and compare with Table 9.

Exercise 14.3. **(Computation)** Using the linear form of Catoni's bound given after Corollary 14.4, find the value of C that minimizes it when $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0.12$, $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 5$, $m = 1000$ and $\delta = 0.05$, and compare the result with Table 9.

Exercise 14.4. **(Python)** Reproduce the experiment of Figure 124 for $m \in \{100, 1000, 10000\}$ (1000 random classifiers of true risk 0.5, 1000 repetitions). Show that the failure frequency of the naive bound does not go to zero when m grows, and explain why by comparing $\sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)/(2m)}$ with the typical deviation of the minimum of 1000 empirical risks.

Exercise 14.5. **(Comprehension)** In the proof of Theorem 14.1, which step uses the joint convexity of Δ, which step uses the independence of the prior from the sample, and which step is the only probabilistic one? Why does the bound hold for all posteriors although Markov's inequality is applied only once?

Exercise 14.6. **(Comprehension)** True or false? Justify briefly. (a) For the same $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q)$, $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$, m and δ, Seeger's bound is never larger than McAllester's bound. (b) Doubling the sample size m halves the complexity term of McAllester's bound. (c) In Catoni's bound, the parameter C may be chosen after seeing the data, since the bound holds for all posteriors. (d) Dividing δ by 10 adds about 2.3 nats to the numerator of the complexity term.

Exercise 14.7. **(Application)** An ensemble of $n = 50$ voters has a uniform prior. With $m = 500$ examples and $\delta = 0.05$, the posterior Q uniform over the 5 best voters has an empirical Gibbs risk of 0.08. Compute $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ and the complexity per example $\varepsilon = \frac{1}{m}[\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln\frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}]$, then McAllester's bound, the PAC-Bayes-λ bound at $\lambda^\star$, Seeger's bound (with `pbtools`), and Catoni's bound for $C \in \{0.5, 1, 2\}$. Which value of C is legitimate to report?

Exercise 14.8. **(Application)** A posterior has zero empirical Gibbs risk on $m = 200$ examples, with $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 3$ and $\delta = 0.05$. Compute Seeger's bound (using its closed form $1 - e^{-\varepsilon}$ when $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0$, see Exercise 14.11) and McAllester's bound. How many examples does each of them need to certify a Gibbs risk below 0.05 (with the same KL)?

Exercise 14.9. **(Proof)** Show that the binary kl is *jointly* convex in $(q,p) \in [0,1] \times (0,1)$, as required by Theorem 14.1. *Hint:* for $a > 0$, $b > 0$, write $a \ln\frac{a}{b} = a\, f\left(\frac{b}{a}\right)$ with the convex function $f(u) = -\ln u$, and show that the perspective $(a,b) \mapsto a\, f(b/a)$ of a convex function is jointly convex.

Exercise 14.10. **(Proof)** Show that, for fixed $\hat{q} > 0$ and $\varepsilon > 0$, the function $\lambda \mapsto \frac{\hat{q}}{1-\lambda/2} + \frac{\varepsilon}{\lambda(1-\lambda/2)}$ is minimized on $(0,2)$ at $\lambda^\star = 2/\left(\sqrt{1 + 2\hat{q}/\varepsilon} + 1\right)$, which is (14.7), and that its minimal value is $\left(\sqrt{\hat{q} + \varepsilon/2} + \sqrt{\varepsilon/2}\right)^2$.

Exercise 14.11. **(Proof)** Show that $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(0,\varepsilon) = 1 - e^{-\varepsilon} \le \varepsilon$. Deduce the form of Seeger's bound when the empirical Gibbs risk is zero, and its rate in m.

Exercise 14.12. **(Computation)** Consider the Hoeffding-based bound (14.5) with $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0.12$, $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 5$, $m = 1000$ and $\delta = 0.05$. (a) Find the value $\lambda^\star$ that minimizes the right-hand side, and the minimal value. (b) Why can this value not be reported as a certificate? (c) Using a grid of $k = 10$ values of λ fixed in advance, what is the smallest certificate one can hope for? Compare with Table 9.

Exercise 14.13. **(Python)** Using the four functions `bound_mcallester`, `bound_lambda`,

`bound_catoni_grid`, `bound_seeger` of the module `pbtools.py` of the course (or your own implementation), reproduce the row $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 10$ of Table 9. Then plot the four bounds as functions of $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) \in [0, 100]$ for $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0.02$ and $m = 1000$. Which bound is the worst for small risks?

Exercise 14.14. **(Application)** We come back to the running example of this section: 100 trees, uniform prior, each tree evaluated on at least $m = 747$ out-of-bag examples, $\delta = 0.05$ (we admit, as in the text, that the bounds apply with the out-of-bag risks in place of $\widehat{R}_S$). (a) For the uniform posterior, the average out-of-bag error is 0.174. Compute the complexity per example and the McAllester and Seeger certificates. (b) Suppose that the uniform posterior on the 10 trees with the smallest out-of-bag errors has an out-of-bag Gibbs risk of 0.150. Compute $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ and the two certificates. (c) Suppose that the best tree alone has an out-of-bag error of 0.130. Compute Seeger's certificate for the Dirac posterior. (d) Which posterior gives the best certificate? Which one would you deploy as a majority vote, and why is this question not answered by this section?

15 Posteriors, priors and the computation of the bounds

About this section

Guiding question. *Since the bounds hold for every prior and every posterior, which ones should we choose, and how do we evaluate the bound in practice?*

The bounds of Section 14 hold for any prior and any posterior. This section explains how to choose them. We show that the posterior minimizing a linear bound is the Gibbs posterior, a soft selection of the good voters that also contains Bayesian inference as a special case, and we run it on a real dataset. We then discuss the choice of the prior, which is the main lever to obtain tight certificates, and we measure on an experiment how to split the data between the prior and the bound. We finally explain how to compute a bound when the Gibbs risk has no closed form, and how PAC-Bayes can say something about deterministic predictors.

15.1 The optimal posterior: Gibbs posterior and Bayesian inference

A bound that holds for every posterior invites an obvious question: which posterior makes it smallest? For linear bounds the answer is explicit. The bounds (14.5) and (14.6) depend on Q only through the objective

$$\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) + \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)}{\lambda m} = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}\Big[\widehat{R}_S(h)\Big] + \frac{1}{\lambda m}\,\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P), \tag{15.1}$$

which balances the fit of the posterior to the data against its distance to the prior; the parameter λ plays the role of an inverse temperature. We already know how to minimize such an objective: this is exactly the variational formula (13.3) of Section 13.

Proposition 15.1: Gibbs posterior (Catoni, 2007; Zhang, 2006)

The minimizer over $\mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$ of (15.1) is the **Gibbs posterior**

$$Q_\lambda(h) = \frac{P(h)\, e^{-\lambda m \widehat{R}_S(h)}}{\mathbb{E}_{h'\sim P}\Big[e^{-\lambda m \widehat{R}_S(h')}\Big]}, \tag{15.2}$$

and the minimal value is $-\frac{1}{\lambda m}\ln \mathbb{E}_{h\sim P}\, e^{-\lambda m \widehat{R}_S(h)}$.

Proof. Multiplying the objective by $-\lambda m < 0$ turns the minimization into a maximization, to which the variational formula applies:

$$\begin{aligned}\min_Q \Big\{\mathbb{E}_Q \widehat{R}_S + \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)}{\lambda m}\Big\} &= -\frac{1}{\lambda m}\max_Q \Big\{\mathbb{E}_Q\big[-\lambda m \widehat{R}_S\big] - \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)\Big\} \\ &\qquad \downarrow \text{ variational formula (13.3) with } \phi = -\lambda m \widehat{R}_S \\ &= -\frac{1}{\lambda m}\ln \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim P}\Big[e^{-\lambda m \widehat{R}_S(h)}\Big],\end{aligned}$$

and the maximum is attained at the Gibbs distribution $Q_\phi \propto P\, e^{\phi} = P\, e^{-\lambda m \widehat{R}_S}$, which is Q_λ. □

In words, the Gibbs posterior starts from the prior and reweights it exponentially according to the empirical risk: a voter that makes k more training errors than another sees its relative weight divided by $e^{\lambda k}$. The temperature controls how sharp this selection is. When $\lambda \to 0$, the posterior stays equal to the prior: there is no complexity to pay, but nothing is learned. When $\lambda \to \infty$, the posterior concentrates on the empirical risk minimizers; for a finite class with the uniform prior, its KL tends to $\ln |\mathcal{H}|$ minus the logarithm of the number of minimizers, and we recover the Occam bound. Figure 130 shows this transition on a family of threshold classifiers $h_\theta(x) = \text{sign}(x - \theta)$ with a Gaussian prior on θ: as λ grows, the posterior moves from the prior towards the interval of thresholds that minimize the empirical risk.

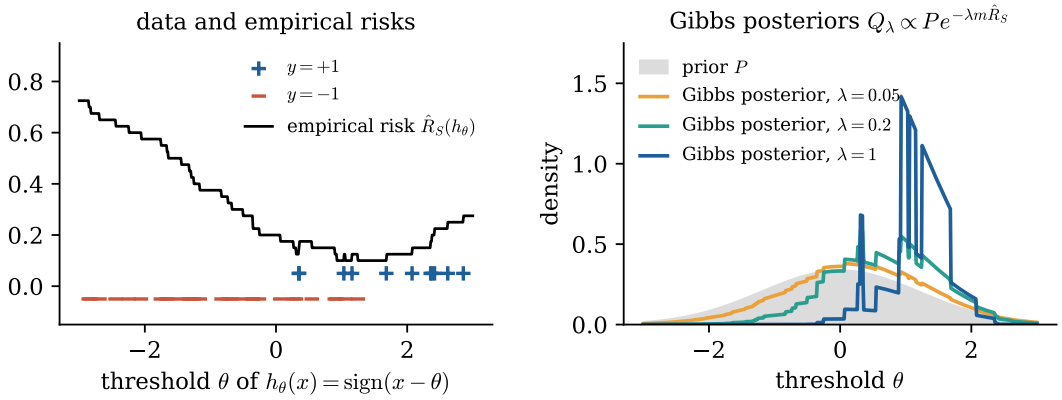


Figure 130: Gibbs posteriors on a family of threshold classifiers $h_\theta(x) = \text{sign}(x - \theta)$ with a Gaussian prior on θ. As λ increases, the posterior concentrates on the empirical risk minimizers; for small λ it stays close to the prior.

Example 15.1 (The Gibbs posterior on decision stumps). Let us see the temperature at work on the `breast cancer` dataset. We build 300 decision stumps (one feature, one threshold, one orientation). Their thresholds are the quantiles of the features computed on 100 examples that are then set aside, so that the set of voters, and hence the uniform prior, is independent of the $m = 120$ examples on which the bound is computed. We then compute Q_λ for 80 values of λ between 10^{-3} and 10^2, and Seeger's bound for each of them.

The right panel of Fig. 131 shows the trade-off. For small λ, the posterior is uniform, its empirical Gibbs risk is 0.5 (each stump comes with its opposite), and the bound is vacuous. As λ grows, the empirical risk drops quickly while the KL increases slowly. The bound reaches its minimum 0.256 for $\lambda \approx 1.3$, where the empirical Gibbs risk is 0.084 and $\text{KL}(Q_\lambda \| P) = 5.5$ nats; the Gibbs risk measured on the 349 test examples is 0.114, well below the certificate. Beyond this point, the KL keeps increasing towards $\ln 300 \approx 5.7$ while the empirical risk no longer decreases.

With only $m = 120$ examples, a certificate of 0.256 may seem loose. It is however a *guarantee*, valid with probability 0.95 and obtained without any test set. The example also shows that the Gibbs posterior is essentially as good as the best stump in terms of certificate, while being more stable. What it certifies, though, is a stump drawn at random; we will see in Section 16 how to certify the *vote* of these stumps instead.

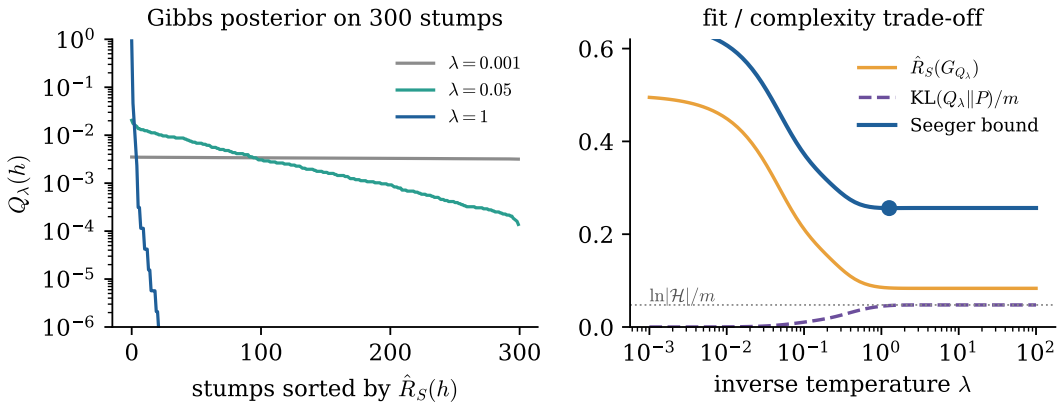


Figure 131: Gibbs posterior over 300 decision stumps on the `breast cancer` dataset (thresholds at quantiles computed on 100 separate examples, uniform prior, bound computed on $m = 120$ other examples). Left: posterior weights for three temperatures. Right: as λ grows, the empirical Gibbs risk decreases while $\mathrm{KL}(Q_\lambda \| P)$ increases, up to $\ln|\mathcal{H}|$ (Occam); Seeger's bound is minimized for an intermediate temperature.

> **Running example** The same recipe applies to the 100 trees of our forest, with their out-of-bag errors in place of the empirical risks. Choosing the temperature by the procedure of Section 18.2.2, the Gibbs posterior lowers Seeger's certificate on the Gibbs risk from 0.230 (uniform weights) to 0.193. This looks like progress, but there is a catch, which we will only understand in Section 16: the Gibbs posterior puts almost all its weight on the two best trees, and the test risk of the *vote* jumps from 0.044 to 0.150. A better Gibbs classifier does not always make a better vote.

Link with Bayesian inference. The Gibbs posterior is not only an algorithmic device: it contains Bayesian inference as a special case. Take a probabilistic model $p(y \,|\, x, \theta)$ indexed by $\theta \in \mathcal{H}$, and the (unbounded) negative log-likelihood loss $\ell(\theta, (x, y)) = -\ln p(y \,|\, x, \theta)$. For $\lambda = 1$, the Gibbs posterior is

$$Q_1(\theta) \propto P(\theta)\, e^{-\sum_{i=1}^m \ell(\theta,(x_i,y_i))} = P(\theta) \prod_{i=1}^m p(y_i \,|\, x_i, \theta),$$

which is exactly the Bayesian posterior. Germain et al. (2016) exploited this correspondence to obtain PAC-Bayesian guarantees for Bayesian inference, and to show that minimizing the bound amounts to maximizing the *marginal likelihood* $\mathbb{E}_{\theta\sim P} \prod_i p(y_i|x_i,\theta)$, which justifies model selection by the evidence. Since the log-loss is unbounded, the bound requires additional assumptions on the tails of the loss (sub-Gaussian or sub-gamma). Other values of λ give *tempered*, or "generalized", posteriors, and Alquier et al. (2016) study variational approximations of Gibbs posteriors when they cannot be computed exactly.

The formulas coincide, but the two frameworks read them differently. In the Bayesian view the prior encodes beliefs and the posterior is the result of conditioning, whereas in PAC-Bayes the prior is a reference measure, the posterior is any distribution we like, and the guarantee does not require the model to be correct.

In a nutshell

PAC-Bayes explains *why* averaging with exponential weights is a good idea: it is the optimal way to trade empirical risk against a KL penalty. In a finite ensemble (Section 18), the Gibbs posterior simply assigns to each voter a weight proportional to $P(h)\, e^{-\lambda m \widehat{R}_S(h)}$, a soft version of "keep the best voters".

15.2 Choosing the prior

The Gibbs posterior tells us how to choose Q once P is given. But the prior matters just as much, since the whole complexity term is measured relative to it. The only rule is that the prior must not depend on the sample used to evaluate the bound; otherwise it can be anything. Since the bound pays $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$, it is tight only if the prior already puts mass where the posterior will be. Much of the art of PAC-Bayes thus consists in finding priors that are independent of the sample and yet well informed. We review the main strategies, from the most naive to the most data-efficient.

The simplest priors are *data-independent*: the uniform distribution on a finite set of voters, a Gaussian $\mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2 I)$ on the weights of linear classifiers or neural networks, or the Fourier transform of a kernel for random features (Letarte et al., 2019b). Their parameters, such as the scale σ, can be selected on a grid at the price of a union bound. They are often too vague, however: nothing tells them in which region of $\mathcal{H}$ the good hypotheses lie.

To make the prior better informed without breaking the rules, a more effective strategy is to learn the prior on a part of the data that is not used in the bound (Ambroladze et al., 2006; Parrado-Hernández et al., 2012). The sample is split into $S = S_{\text{prior}} \cup S_{\text{bound}}$; the prior is learned on S_{prior}, for instance a Gaussian centred at an SVM trained on it, and the bound is computed on S_{bound} only, with $m = |S_{\text{bound}}|$. This is the approach behind the tightest certificates known for neural networks (Dziugaite and Roy, 2017; Pérez-Ortiz et al., 2021). The split involves a trade-off: a larger S_{prior} gives a better prior, hence a smaller KL, but it leaves fewer examples to compute the bound. Figure 132 shows the first effect on Gaussian posteriors over linear classifiers: the posterior is the same in both panels, but measured from a prior centred at the origin it costs 4.66 nats, and measured from a prior centred at a classifier learned on S_{prior} it costs only 0.21 nat. How should we balance the two effects?

Example 15.2 (How much data for the prior?). We measure this trade-off on `breast cancer` (Fig. 134). A fraction of the data is used to build a set of 200 shallow decision trees on bootstrap samples. The uniform distribution over these trees plays the role of the prior, which is legitimate since it only depends on S_{prior}. The remaining examples are split into a sample S_{bound} (70%), on which we minimize Seeger's bound over Gibbs posteriors, and a test sample (30%).

When only 5% of the data are used for the prior, the trees are weak, but the bound is computed on 378 examples and the certificate is 0.142. Increasing the fraction to 10–30% improves the trees (the test Gibbs risk decreases from 0.080 to 0.067) and the certificate stays around 0.135. Beyond 50%, the trees keep improving but the bound is computed on too few examples: with 85% of the data for the prior, only 60 examples remain, and the certificate degrades to 0.225 although the voters are the best ones. On this dataset, a fifth to a third of the data for the prior is a good compromise. The best

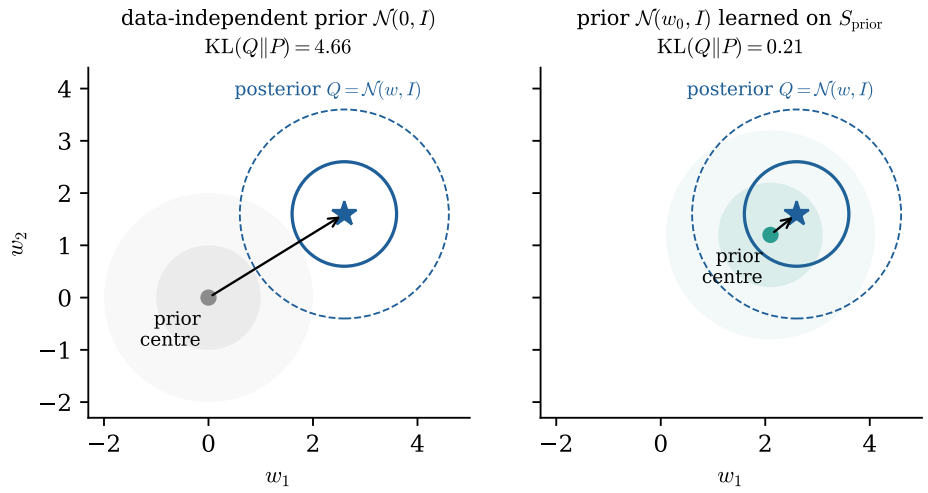


Figure 132: The same posterior $Q = \mathcal{N}(w, I)$ on linear classifiers (blue, circles at one and two standard deviations) measured against two priors. The KL divergence only depends on the distance between the centres, so a prior centred at a classifier w_0 learned on separate data makes it twenty times smaller.

proportion depends on the problem; like any hyperparameter of the certificate, it must be fixed in advance or selected on a grid with a union bound.

Recent work: using the data twice, recursively Dziugaite et al. (2021) studied this trade-off in general: the best prior that does not depend on the data (the "oracle" prior $\mathbb{E}_S[Q_S]$) can leave the bound vacuous, whereas spending a fraction α of the sample on the prior and computing the kl bound on the rest, $\mathrm{kl}\left(\widehat{R}_{S\setminus S_\alpha}(G_Q) \,\|\, R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)\right) \leq \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P(S_\alpha)) + \ln(2\sqrt{(1-\alpha)m}/\delta)}{(1-\alpha)m}$, can make it non-vacuous. The drawback is that the examples of S_α no longer contribute to the confidence. Wu et al. (2024) remove it with *Recursive PAC-Bayes*. The sample is split into chunks $S_1, \ldots, S_T$, and the posterior π_t learned on $S_1 \cup \cdots \cup S_t$ becomes the prior of the next step. The key is the decomposition, for $\gamma_t \in (0, 1)$,

$$\mathbb{E}_{\pi_t}[R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)] = \underbrace{\mathbb{E}_{\pi_t}\left[R_{\mathcal{D}}(h) - \gamma_t \, \mathbb{E}_{\pi_{t-1}} R_{\mathcal{D}}(h')\right]}_{\text{excess loss, certified on } S_t \cup \cdots \cup S_T} + \gamma_t \underbrace{\mathbb{E}_{\pi_{t-1}}[R_{\mathcal{D}}(h')]}_{\text{bounded at step } t-1},$$

which gives a recursive certificate $B_t(\pi_t) = \mathcal{E}_t(\pi_t, \gamma_t) + \gamma_t B_{t-1}(\pi_{t-1})$ (Fig. 133). Each chunk is used to learn a prior *and* to certify, and the excess loss, which takes four values, is bounded with the split-kl inequality of Section 16.8. On MNIST, the certificate on the Gibbs risk of a stochastic network goes from 0.457 with a data-independent prior and 0.408 with a data-dependent prior to 0.158 with $T = 8$ steps.

Any split, however well chosen, sacrifices part of the sample. Two further ideas avoid this waste altogether. In bagging, each voter is trained on a subsample and can be evaluated on its out-of-bag examples; this *split construction* lets every example serve both for building some voters and for evaluating the others (Thiemann et al., 2017; Lorenzen et al., 2019), and it is the backbone of the self-bounding algorithms of Section 18.2. Finally, the prior may depend on the distribution $\mathcal{D}$ without depending

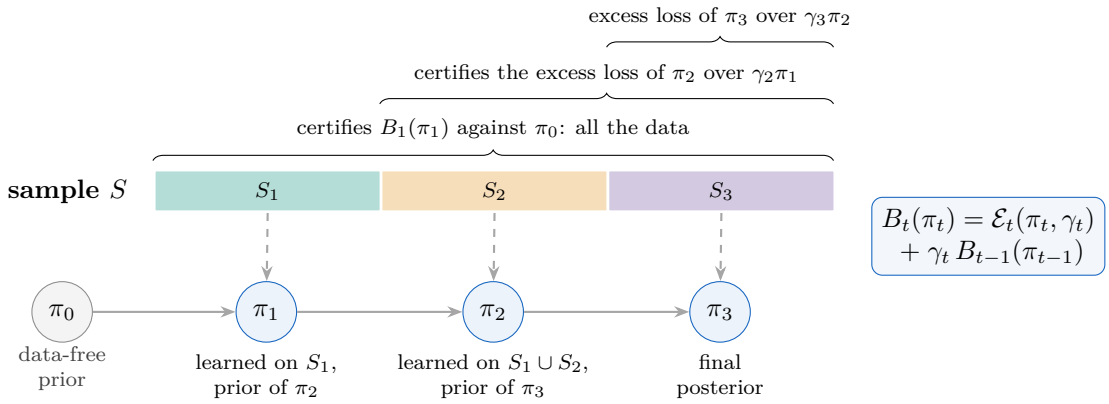


Figure 133: Recursive PAC-Bayes (Wu et al., 2024) with $T = 3$ chunks. Each posterior is the prior of the next one; the first term is certified with all the data against a data-free prior, and each subsequent excess loss with the chunks that were not used to learn the previous prior.

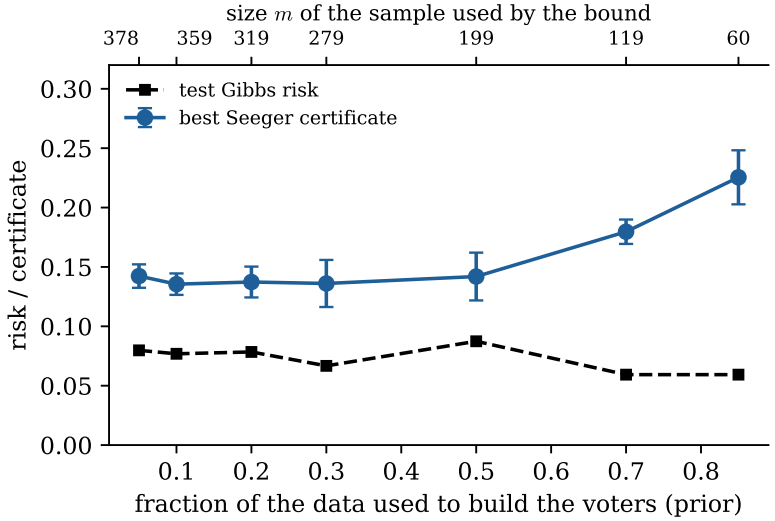


Figure 134: Splitting the data between the construction of the voters (prior) and the computation of the bound, on `breast cancer` (mean and standard deviation over 5 splits; m is the size of the sample used by the bound).

on the sample, for instance $P \propto e^{-\beta R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)}$; the bound then involves unknown quantities which can be controlled (Catoni, 2007). Dziugaite and Roy (2018) go one step further and learn the prior from S itself, using differential privacy to limit how much it depends on each example.

Once the prior and the posterior are chosen, one practical step remains: evaluating the bound numerically.

15.3 Computing the bound in practice

A certificate is only useful if we can compute it. When $\mathcal{H}$ is a finite ensemble of n voters, $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = \sum_h Q(h)\widehat{R}_S(h)$ and $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ are finite sums, and computing a bound only requires one kl inversion. When $\mathcal{H}$ is infinite, for instance with a Gaussian posterior

on the weights of a neural network, the empirical Gibbs risk is an integral that may not have a closed form. Langford and Caruana (2001) and Dziugaite and Roy (2017) estimate it by Monte Carlo: they draw $h_1, \dots, h_N \sim Q$ independently and apply a second kl inversion. This is legitimate because, conditionally on S, the $\widehat{R}_S(h_j)$ are i.i.d. variables in $[0,1]$ with mean $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q)$. With probability at least $1-\delta'$ over the draws,

$$\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) \le \overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}\Big(\frac{1}{N}\sum_{j=1}^{N}\widehat{R}_S(h_j),\ \frac{\ln(2/\delta')}{N}\Big),$$

and plugging this upper bound into Seeger's bound gives a certificate valid with probability at least $1-\delta-\delta'$. In other words, sampling costs us a little confidence and a slightly larger bound, but never the validity of the certificate.

Example 15.3 (Certifying a Gaussian posterior by sampling). How large is this extra cost? We take a linear classifier $\mathbf{w}$ learned by a linear SVM on `breast cancer` ($m = 398$ training examples, standardized features), rescaled to $\|\mathbf{w}\| = 8$, and the posterior $Q = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}, I)$ with prior $P = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, I)$, so that $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = \|\mathbf{w}\|^2/2 = 32$. For this family, the empirical Gibbs risk has a closed form (Section 18.4), equal to 0.076, and Seeger's bound gives 0.245. Figure 135 shows the certificate obtained when the Gibbs risk is instead estimated from N sampled classifiers, with $\delta = \delta' = 0.025$. With $N = 100$ samples, the certificate is 0.375, and it reaches 0.26 for $N = 10^4$: the price of the Monte Carlo estimation decreases quickly with N, and a few thousand samples are enough in practice.

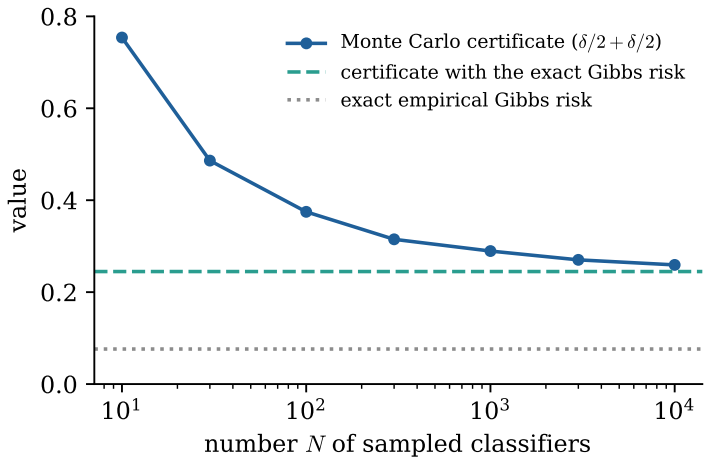


Figure 135: Certificate of a Gaussian posterior on linear classifiers (`breast cancer`), when the empirical Gibbs risk is computed exactly (dashed) or estimated with N sampled classifiers and a second kl inversion.

15.4 From stochastic to deterministic predictors

Everything so far certifies a *stochastic* predictor. A PAC-Bayesian bound controls the *average* risk of a randomly drawn voter, whereas in practice we usually deploy a single deterministic predictor. There are three ways to bridge this gap. The first one, which is the object of Section 16, is to bound the risk of the majority vote B_Q using the

Gibbs risk and second-order quantities describing the correlations between voters. The second one exploits a margin: if Q is concentrated around a hypothesis h with a large margin, then h and the Gibbs classifier make similar predictions, and the bound on the latter transfers to the former up to a margin term (Langford and Shawe-Taylor, 2002; McAllester, 2003b; Biggs et al., 2022). The third one consists in *disintegrated* bounds, which hold with high probability for a single hypothesis $h \sim Q$ drawn once, rather than on average over Q (Blanchard and Fleuret, 2007; Rivasplata et al., 2020; Viallard et al., 2024b); we come back to them in Section 19. For ensemble methods the first route is the natural one, and it is the subject of the next section.

Recent work: Gibbs distributions for any complexity measure Viallard et al. (2024a) combine the last route with the Gibbs posterior. For any complexity measure $\mu(h, S)$ chosen by the user (a norm of the weights, a sharpness measure…), they draw a *single* hypothesis from $\rho_S(h) \propto e^{-\mu(h,S)}$ and prove a disintegrated bound: with the uniform prior on a bounded $\mathcal{H}$ and a loss in $[0,1]$, with probability at least $1-\delta$ over S, $h' \sim P$ and $h \sim \rho_S$, $\mathrm{kl}\left(\widehat{R}_S(h) \,\|\, R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)\right) \leq \frac{1}{m}\left[\mu(h', S) - \mu(h, S) + \ln \frac{8\sqrt{m}}{\delta^2}\right]$. The complexity measure thus enters the bound directly, in place of a KL divergence.

To remember from Section 15

Linear bounds are minimized by the Gibbs posterior $Q_\lambda \propto P\, e^{-\lambda m \widehat{R}_S}$, a soft selection of the good voters whose temperature trades fit against complexity, and which contains the Bayesian posterior as a special case. The prior is the main lever for tight bounds: it can be learned from data, provided those data are not used by the bound, and on our example a fifth to a third of the sample was a good investment. When the Gibbs risk is not computable exactly, a Monte Carlo estimate and a second kl inversion give a valid certificate at a small extra cost.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q15.1. What happens to the Gibbs posterior when $\lambda \to 0$, and when $\lambda \to \infty$?

Q15.2. Why can a prior learned on part of the data be legitimate, and on which part must the bound then be computed?

Q15.3. Why does a Monte Carlo estimate of the Gibbs risk require a second kl inversion?

Q15.4. Name three ways to obtain a guarantee for a deterministic predictor from a PAC-Bayesian bound.

Q15.5. With the uniform prior and $\lambda = 0.5$, voter h makes 2 more training errors than voter h'. What is $Q_\lambda(h)/Q_\lambda(h')$?

Q15.6. True or false? The Gibbs posterior minimizes Seeger's bound.

Q15.7. Is it legitimate to choose the temperature λ of the Gibbs posterior by minimizing Seeger's bound on the training sample?

Q15.8. For a probabilistic model and the log-loss, which posterior is the Gibbs posterior with $\lambda = 1$?

Q15.9. A Gaussian posterior $\mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}, I)$ is compared with the prior $\mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, I)$ and with a prior $\mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}_0, I)$ learned on separate data. What are the two KL divergences if $\|\mathbf{w}\| = 8$ and $\|\mathbf{w} - \mathbf{w}_0\| = 1$?

Q15.10. What is the trade-off when choosing the fraction of the data used to learn the prior?

Q15.11. May the prior depend on the data distribution $\mathcal{D}$?

Q15.12. In the Monte Carlo example, the certificate is 0.375 with $N = 100$ sampled classifiers and 0.26 with $N = 10^4$, against 0.245 with the exact Gibbs risk. Why does it improve with N?

Exercises

Exercise 15.1. **(Proof)** For a finite class and a uniform prior, show that $\mathrm{KL}(Q_\lambda \| P) \to \ln \frac{|\mathcal{H}|}{k}$ when $\lambda \to \infty$, where k is the number of empirical risk minimizers. What is the limit when $\lambda \to 0$?

Exercise 15.2. **(Comprehension)** Explain why using the same sample to learn the centre of a Gaussian prior and to compute the empirical term of the bound is not allowed. What happens if we do it anyway?

Exercise 15.3. **(Application)** In the Monte Carlo certificate, the total confidence budget $\delta = 0.05$ is split into $\delta - \delta'$ for Seeger's bound and δ' for the Monte Carlo inversion. Take the setting of the example on the Gaussian posterior ($m = 398$, $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 32$) and assume that the Monte Carlo average of the empirical risks is 0.076. How should δ' be chosen to minimize the final bound when $N = 100$? when $N = 10^4$?

Exercise 15.4. **(Comprehension)** (a) What is the Gibbs posterior Q_λ when all the voters have the same empirical risk? (b) With the uniform prior, voter h makes 3 more training errors than voter h'; what is the ratio $Q_\lambda(h)/Q_\lambda(h')$? (c) True or false: a prior $P \propto e^{-\beta R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)}$, which depends on $\mathcal{D}$, is forbidden.

Exercise 15.5. **(Application)** Four voters have empirical risks 0.10, 0.12, 0.15 and 0.30 on $m = 100$ examples, and the prior is uniform. For $\lambda \in \{0.1, 0.5, 2\}$, compute the Gibbs posterior Q_λ, its empirical Gibbs risk, $\mathrm{KL}(Q_\lambda\|P)$ and Seeger's bound with $\delta = 0.05$. For $\lambda = 0.5$, check numerically that the objective (15.1) at Q_λ equals $-\frac{1}{\lambda m} \ln \mathbb{E}_{h\sim P} e^{-\lambda m \widehat{R}_S(h)}$. Compare with the bounds of the uniform posterior and of the Dirac on the best voter.

Exercise 15.6. **(Application)** A practitioner has 500 examples and 100 voters. Option A uses the 500 examples for the bound with a data-independent uniform prior; the best posterior found has an empirical Gibbs risk of 0.15 and $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 2$. Option B learns a prior on 150 examples and computes the bound on the remaining 350; the best posterior has an empirical Gibbs risk of 0.10 and $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 1$. Compare Seeger's bounds ($\delta = 0.05$). Can the practitioner compute both and report the smaller one?

Exercise 15.7. **(Application)** In the setting of the Gaussian posterior example ($m = 398$, $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 32$), suppose that $N = 1000$ classifiers sampled from Q have an average empirical risk of 0.08. With $\delta = \delta' = 0.025$, compute the Monte Carlo upper bound on $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q)$ and the final certificate. Compare with the certificate that would be obtained if $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0.08$ were known exactly.

Exercise 15.8. **(Proof)** Prove the formula $\mathrm{KL}\left(\mathcal{N}(\mu_1, \sigma^2 I_d) \,\|\, \mathcal{N}(\mu_0, \sigma^2 I_d)\right) = \frac{\|\mu_1 - \mu_0\|^2}{2\sigma^2}$, and deduce $\mathrm{KL}(Q_{\mathbf{w}}\|P) = \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{w}\|^2$ for $Q_{\mathbf{w}} = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}, I_d)$ and $P = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, I_d)$.

Exercise 15.9. **(Proof)** Let P be a prior on a finite set of parameters θ and $\ell(\theta, (x, y)) = -\ln p(y \,|\, x, \theta)$. Using Proposition 15.1 with $\lambda = 1$, show that the Bayesian posterior minimizes $\mathbb{E}_{\theta\sim Q} \sum_i \ell(\theta, (x_i, y_i)) + \mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ over Q, and that the minimal value is minus the log marginal likelihood $-\ln \mathbb{E}_{\theta\sim P} \prod_i p(y_i \,|\, x_i, \theta)$.

Exercise 15.10. **(Proof)** Fix $\lambda > 0$, a countable class $\mathcal{H}$ and a prior P with $P(h) > 0$ for all h. (a) Show that, at the Gibbs posterior, the right-hand side of the Hoeffding-based bound (14.5) equals $-\frac{1}{\lambda m} \ln \mathbb{E}_{h\sim P} e^{-\lambda m \widehat{R}_S(h)} + \frac{\ln(1/\delta)}{\lambda m} + \frac{\lambda}{8}$. (b) Deduce that it is at most $\min_{h\in\mathcal{H}} \left\{ \widehat{R}_S(h) + \frac{\ln \frac{1}{P(h)} + \ln \frac{1}{\delta}}{\lambda m} \right\} + \frac{\lambda}{8}$. (c) Interpret: what does the Gibbs posterior gain over the best Occam-type certificate?

Exercise 15.11. **(Application)** We certify Gaussian posteriors $Q = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}, I)$ on linear classifiers, with 498 examples and $\delta = 0.05$. (a) With the prior $P = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, I)$, all 498 examples are used for learning and $m = 398$ of them for the bound (the other 100 are kept aside). The posterior

has $\|\mathbf{w}\| = 8$ and an empirical Gibbs risk of 0.08 on the 398 examples. Compute $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ and Seeger's bound. (b) The 100 examples kept aside are now used to learn $\mathbf{w}_0$, and the prior is $P = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}_0, I)$; the posterior is learned on all the data, $\|\mathbf{w} - \mathbf{w}_0\| = 2$, and its empirical Gibbs risk on the 398 other examples is still 0.08. Compute the new certificate. On which examples must the empirical Gibbs risk be computed, and why? (c) The variance σ^2 of the prior and of the posterior is chosen among 10 values fixed in advance. What is the cost? (d) Could the 100 examples be used both to learn $\mathbf{w}_0$ and in the bound?

Exercise 15.12. **(Proof)** Justify the Monte Carlo certificate: show that if, with probability at least $1-\delta$ over S, Seeger's bound holds for all Q, and if, for every fixed S, with probability at least $1-\delta'$ over the draws $h_1, \dots, h_N \sim Q$, $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) \le \overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}\big(\frac{1}{N}\sum_j \widehat{R}_S(h_j), \frac{\ln(2/\delta')}{N}\big)$, then the plug-in certificate holds with probability at least $1-\delta-\delta'$ over $(S, h_1, \dots, h_N)$. Why is the $\ln(2/\delta')$ conservative here?

Exercise 15.13. **(Python)** Reproduce the example on decision stumps (Figure 131): build 300 stumps whose thresholds are the quantiles $0.2, 0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.8$ of each feature of `breast cancer` computed on 100 examples set aside, with the two orientations; compute their empirical risks on $m = 120$ other examples; for 80 values of λ in $[10^{-3}, 10^{2}]$ compute the Gibbs posterior, its KL and Seeger's bound. Report the best bound, the corresponding λ, and the test Gibbs risk. Is it legitimate to choose λ by minimizing the bound?

16 From the Gibbs classifier to the majority vote

About this section

Guiding question. *Why is the vote better than its voters, and how can we certify the vote itself rather than a voter drawn at random?*

The bounds of Section 14 concern the Gibbs classifier, whose risk is the risk of an average voter. Ensemble methods, however, predict with the majority vote, whose whole point is to be better than the average voter. This section relates the two. We show that the risk of the vote is a tail probability of the proportion of erring voters, and we control this tail with moments, which leads to the first-order bound, the tandem bound and the C-bound. We compare them with Condorcet's jury theorem and on random forests, prove which one is the tightest in which regime, and show how PAC-Bayes estimates each of them from data.

Throughout this section, the voters take values in $\{-1, +1\}$ and we use the 0-1 loss.

16.1 Two random variables that describe the vote

To compare the vote with its voters, we need a common language. A single random variable will do: on each example, the proportion of voters that err. For an example (x, y), let

$$W_Q(x,y) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}[\mathbb{1}[h(x) \neq y]] \in [0,1],$$
$$M_Q(x,y) = y \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{h\sim Q}[h(x)] = 1 - 2W_Q(x,y) \in [-1,1].$$

The variable W_Q is the Q-weight of the voters that make a mistake on (x, y), and M_Q is the *margin* of the vote, already met in Section 12 for AdaBoost. The vote errs exactly when at least half of the weight is on the wrong side, so that, with our convention for ties,

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = \mathbb{P}_{(x,y)\sim\mathcal{D}}(M_Q(x,y) \leq 0) = \mathbb{P}_{(x,y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\Big(W_Q(x,y) \geq \tfrac{1}{2}\Big), \tag{16.1}$$

whereas the Gibbs risk is its expectation, $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = \mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{D}} W_Q$ (Fig. 136). In other words, the risk of the majority vote is a *tail probability* of the random variable W_Q, and the Gibbs risk is its *first moment*. All the bounds of this section control this tail with moments of W_Q, exactly as Markov's, Chebyshev's and Cantelli's inequalities control the tail of a random variable with its first two moments.

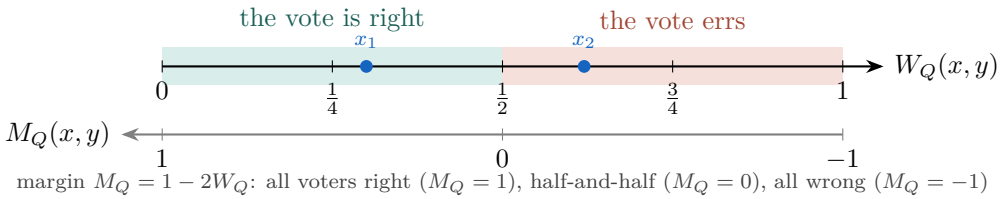


Figure 136: On an example (x, y), the vote errs if and only if the weight $W_Q(x, y)$ of the erring voters is at least $\frac{1}{2}$, that is if and only if the margin $M_Q(x, y) = 1 - 2W_Q(x, y)$ is non-positive. The example x_1 is correctly classified by the vote although 30% of the voters err on it; x_2 is misclassified. [code: `figures/tikz/wq_line.tex`]

Figure 137 shows the distribution of W_Q for a random forest of 200 trees on the `digits` dataset (digits 0–4 against 5–9). This forest is larger than the one of our running example and is evaluated on a different split, hence the slightly different values. Most test points are classified correctly by a large majority of trees, so that the histogram is concentrated near zero; its mean, the Gibbs risk, is 0.164. Only the points in the red area, where at least half of the trees err, are misclassified by the vote, and they represent 3.5% of the test sample. The vote is thus almost five times more accurate than an average tree, and a good bound on the vote must be able to see this. Let us check how far each moment inequality can go, starting with the crudest one.

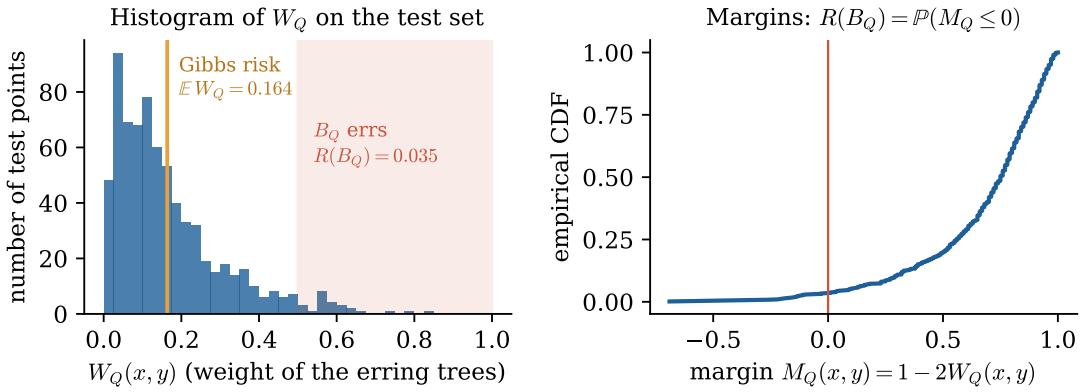


Figure 137: Random forest of 200 trees on `digits` (classes 0–4 vs 5–9). Left: histogram of W_Q on the test set; the Gibbs risk is the mean of this distribution (0.164), while the majority vote only errs when $W_Q \geq 1/2$ (red area, 3.5% of the points). Right: distribution of the margins $M_Q = 1 - 2W_Q$.

16.2 The first-order bound

Since we already know how to bound the Gibbs risk, the first moment of W_Q, the simplest idea is to turn it into a bound on the tail with Markov's inequality.

Proposition 16.1: First-order bound (folklore, e.g. Langford and Shawe-Taylor, 2002)

For any $Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$, $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) \leq 2\, R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$.

Proof. The variable W_Q is non-negative, so

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = \mathbb{P}(W_Q \geq \tfrac{1}{2})$$

$$\downarrow \text{ Markov's inequality (Lemma 13.2) with } a = \frac{1}{2}$$

$$\leq \frac{\mathbb{E}W_Q}{1/2} = 2R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q). \qquad \square$$

In words, the vote is never worse than twice an average voter: whatever the ensemble, voting cannot go badly wrong. Combined with Seeger's bound, the first-order

bound gives a first PAC-Bayesian certificate for the majority vote: with probability at least $1-\delta$ over $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$, for all Q,

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) \le 2\,\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}\Big(\widehat{R}_S(G_Q), \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}}{m}\Big). \tag{16.2}$$

The factor 2 cannot be improved in general: if W_Q only takes the values 0 and $\frac{1}{2}$, the vote errs on every example where $W_Q = \frac{1}{2}$ and the inequality is an equality. But this worst case is precisely the one where voting is useless, and the first-order bound completely ignores the benefit of the vote. Figure 138 makes the point with three ensembles that have the *same* Gibbs risk 0.3: depending on how the errors of the voters are distributed over the examples, the risk of the vote can be 0, 0.3, or almost 0.6. The Gibbs risk alone cannot distinguish these situations, so any bound that only uses it must cover the worst one.

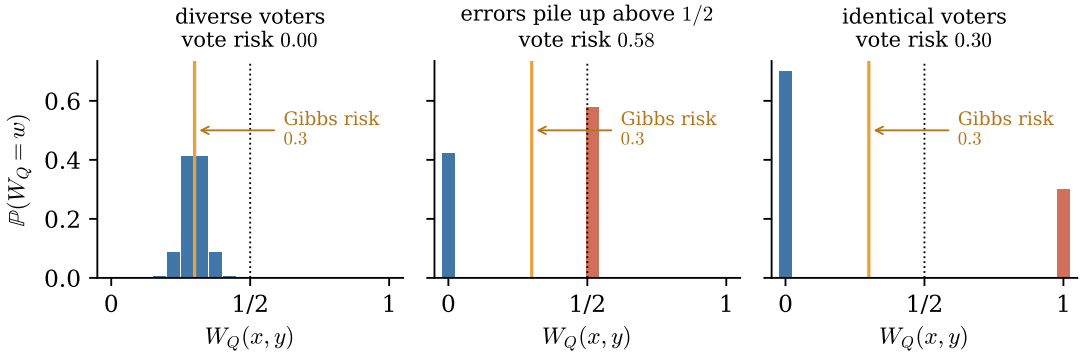


Figure 138: Three distributions of W_Q with the same mean, i.e. the same Gibbs risk 0.3 (orange line). Left: the voters are diverse and their errors never pile up, so the vote is always right. Middle: the errors pile up just above $\frac{1}{2}$ on 58% of the examples, so the vote errs there; this is the worst case of Markov's inequality. Right: identical voters, the vote is as good as one voter.

On the forest of Fig. 137, the first-order bound gives 0.327, twice the risk of an average tree, for a vote whose risk is ten times smaller (0.035). Worse, as we will see in Section 18.2.2, *minimizing* this bound pushes Q towards the few best voters and destroys the diversity of the ensemble. To do better, we must understand where the benefit of voting comes from.

16.3 Condorcet's jury theorem

To understand what a good bound on the vote should capture, consider the most favourable situation, known since Condorcet (1785): the voters err *independently*.

Example 16.1 (Condorcet's jury theorem). Let Q be uniform over $n = 2k+1$ voters that err independently, each with probability $p < 1/2$. Then $nW_Q \sim \mathrm{Bin}(n, p)$, the Gibbs risk is p and $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = \mathbb{P}(\mathrm{Bin}(n,p) \ge k+1)$, which tends to 0 exponentially fast when $n \to \infty$. With $n = 3$ and $p = 0.3$, $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = 3p^2(1-p) + p^3 = 0.216$; with $n = 25$, it is already 0.017, and with $n = 101$ it is about 10^{-5}.

The left panel of Fig. 139 plots this risk together with the bounds of this section. The first-order bound stays at $2p = 0.6$ whatever the number of voters. The tandem

bound, introduced below, improves on it but converges to $4p^2 = 0.36$. Only the C-bound follows the risk of the vote down to zero, at the rate $1/n$.

Independence is of course unrealistic. In the right panel, the 25 voters copy the errors of a common "leader" with probability c and err independently otherwise, so that c measures the correlation of their errors. When c increases, the vote loses its advantage, its risk goes from 0.018 to 0.30, and all the bounds deteriorate; for strongly correlated voters, the first-order bound becomes the best of the three. The rest of this section explains these observations.

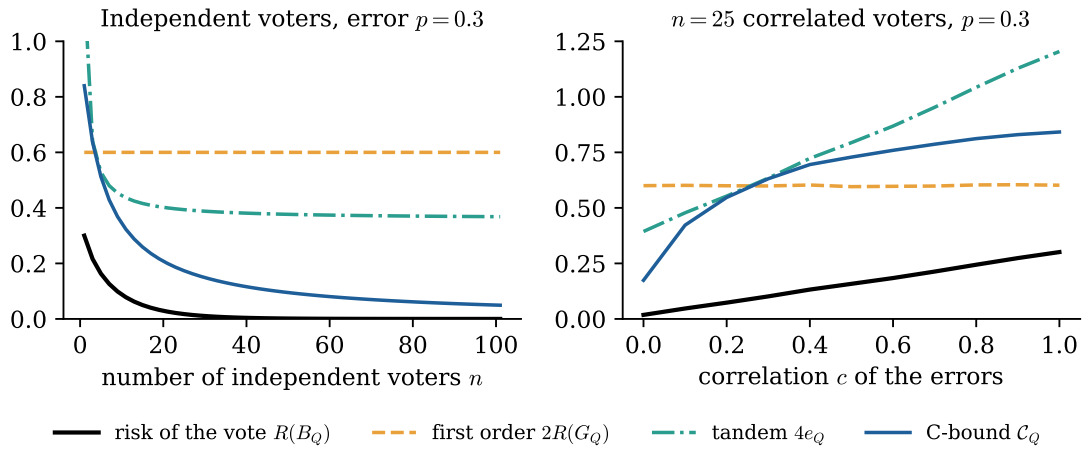


Figure 139: Risk of the majority vote and oracle bounds for voters of individual error $p = 0.3$. Left: independent errors, as a function of the number of voters. Right: 25 voters whose errors are correlated (each voter copies the errors of a common leader with probability c); 20 000 simulated examples.

16.4 Second-order quantities: joint error and disagreement

Condorcet's example contains the key idea: what makes a vote good is not only the quality of each voter, but the fact that the voters do not all make their mistakes on the same examples. A single voter cannot tell us this; we need to look at *pairs* of voters $(h, h') \sim Q^2 = Q \otimes Q$ drawn independently from the posterior.

Definition 16.2: Joint error and disagreement

The **joint error** (or *tandem loss*) and the **disagreement** of Q are

$$e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(h,h')\sim Q^2} \Big[\mathbb{P}_{(x,y)\sim\mathcal{D}}\big(h(x) \neq y \ \wedge \ h'(x) \neq y\big)\Big] = \mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{D}}[W_Q^2],$$

$$d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) = \mathop{\mathbb{E}}_{(h,h')\sim Q^2} \big[\mathbb{P}_{x\sim\mathcal{D}_{\mathcal{X}}}\big(h(x) \neq h'(x)\big)\big] = \mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{D}}[2W_Q(1 - W_Q)],$$

and their empirical counterparts $\widehat{e}_S(Q)$, $\widehat{d}_S(Q)$ are defined on S.

Figure 140 shows the four outcomes of a pair of voters. The expressions in terms of W_Q follow from Fubini's theorem: for a fixed example (x, y), two independent draws $h, h' \sim Q$ both err with probability W_Q^2, and exactly one of them errs with probability

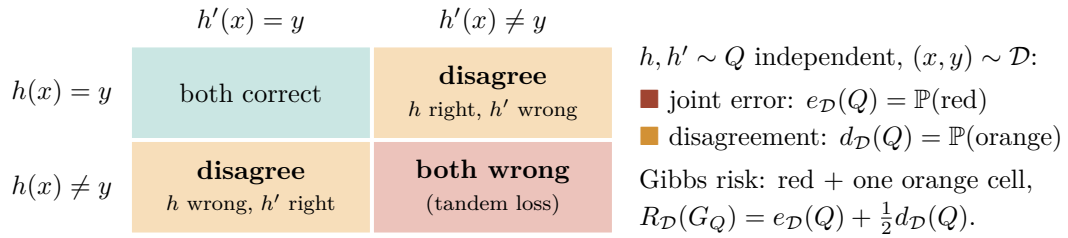


Figure 140: The four possible outcomes of two voters h, h' on an example. The joint error $e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ is the probability of the red cell and the disagreement $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ the probability of the two orange cells, when h, h' are drawn independently from Q and (x, y) from $\mathcal{D}$.

$2W_Q(1 - W_Q)$, which, for binary voters, is exactly the probability that they disagree. The joint error is therefore the second moment of W_Q, and the Gibbs risk, the joint error and the disagreement are linked by a simple identity.

Proposition 16.3: Decomposition of the Gibbs risk

For any Q,

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) + \tfrac{1}{2} d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q), \qquad \text{and} \qquad 0 \leq d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) \leq 2R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)(1 - R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)).$$

Proof. Pointwise, $W_Q = W_Q^2 + \frac{1}{2} \cdot 2W_Q(1 - W_Q)$; taking expectations gives the identity. For the inequality,

$$\begin{aligned} d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) &= 2\big(R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) - e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)\big) \\ &\quad \downarrow \text{ Jensen: } e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) = \mathbb{E}W_Q^2 \geq (\mathbb{E}W_Q)^2 = R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)^2 \\ &\leq 2\big(R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) - R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)^2\big) = 2R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)(1 - R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)). \end{aligned}$$

□

This decomposition says that, for a fixed Gibbs risk, a larger disagreement means a smaller joint error: the voters make their mistakes on *different* examples, which is exactly what makes a vote effective. On the forest of Fig. 137, the disagreement is 0.236 and the joint error is only 0.0457. Note also that the disagreement does not depend on the labels: it can be estimated on unlabeled data, which are often more plentiful, an observation exploited in semi-supervised learning and domain adaptation (Germain et al., 2020). With these second-order quantities in hand, we can revisit Markov's inequality.

16.5 The tandem bound

The first-order bound was loose because it only used the mean of W_Q. Applying Markov's inequality to W_Q^2 instead of W_Q gives a bound based on the second moment, which sees the joint errors.

Theorem 16.4: Tandem (second-order) bound (Masegosa et al., 2020)

For any $Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$, $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) \leq 4\, e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$.

Proof.

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = \mathbb{P}(W_Q \geq \tfrac{1}{2}) = \mathbb{P}(W_Q^2 \geq \tfrac{1}{4})$$

$$\downarrow \text{ Markov's inequality applied to the non-negative variable } W_Q^2$$

$$\leq \frac{\mathbb{E}W_Q^2}{1/4} = 4e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q). \qquad \square$$

In words, wherever the vote errs, at least half of the weight is on the wrong side, so two voters drawn independently from Q both err there with probability at least $\frac{1}{4}$; the frequency of such joint errors therefore controls the risk of the vote. On the forest of Fig. 137, the tandem bound is $4 \times 0.0457 = 0.183$, almost twice smaller than the first-order bound. By Proposition 16.3, $4e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) = 2R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) - 2(d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) - R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q))$, so the tandem bound improves on the first-order bound exactly when $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) \geq R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$, that is when the ensemble is diverse enough. In the worst case of identical voters, $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) = 0$ and the tandem bound is twice the first-order bound.

To turn the tandem bound into a certificate, note that the joint error is the Gibbs risk of the *pair voter* $(h, h') \mapsto$ "both err" under the posterior Q^2 on $\mathcal{H}^2$. Applying Seeger's bound on $\mathcal{H}^2$ with prior P^2, and using $\mathrm{KL}(Q^2 \| P^2) = 2\,\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$, we obtain the following corollary.

Corollary 16.5: PAC-Bayesian tandem bound (Masegosa et al., 2020)

With probability at least $1-\delta$ over $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$, for all $Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$,

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) \leq 4\,\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}\Big(\widehat{e}_S(Q),\ \frac{2\,\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln\frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}}{m}\Big). \tag{16.3}$$

The price of the second-order information is a doubled KL term, and a factor 4 instead of 2 in front of the kl inversion. The tandem certificate therefore pays off when the ensemble is diverse and the sample is large enough for the complexity term to be small.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q16.1. Express the risk of the majority vote and the Gibbs risk in terms of the random variable W_Q.

Q16.2. Why does the first-order bound ignore the benefit of voting?

Q16.3. True or false? If every voter of the ensemble has a risk of 0.3, the majority vote has a risk of at most 0.3.

Q16.4. In Condorcet's model with $n = 3$ independent voters of error $p = 0.3$, what is the risk of the vote? Why is it smaller than p?

Q16.5. Which second-order quantity of an ensemble can be estimated without labels, and why?

Q16.6. Why is the KL term doubled in the PAC-Bayesian tandem bound?

16.6 The C-bound

The first-order bound uses the first moment of W_Q, the tandem bound its second moment. Using both at once should do better, and this is what the C-bound achieves through the Chebyshev–Cantelli inequality (Lemma 13.6).

Theorem 16.6: C-bound (Lacasse et al., 2006; Germain et al., 2015)

For any Q such that $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) < \frac{1}{2}$ (equivalently $\mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{D}} M_Q > 0$),

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) \leq \mathcal{C}_Q := 1 - \frac{\left(\mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{D}} M_Q\right)^2}{\mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{D}} M_Q^2} = 1 - \frac{\left(1 - 2R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)\right)^2}{1 - 2d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)}. \tag{16.4}$$

Proof. Let $\mu = \mathbb{E} M_Q > 0$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = \mathbb{P}(M_Q \leq 0) &= \mathbb{P}(M_Q - \mu \leq -\mu) \\ &\downarrow \text{ Cantelli's inequality (Lemma 13.6) with } a = \mu \\ &\leq \frac{\operatorname{Var} M_Q}{\operatorname{Var} M_Q + \mu^2} \\ &\downarrow \text{ König–Huygens: } \operatorname{Var} M_Q = \mathbb{E} M_Q^2 - \mu^2 \\ &= \frac{\mathbb{E} M_Q^2 - \mu^2}{\mathbb{E} M_Q^2} = 1 - \frac{(\mathbb{E} M_Q)^2}{\mathbb{E} M_Q^2}. \end{aligned}$$

Finally, $\mathbb{E} M_Q = 1 - 2\mathbb{E} W_Q = 1 - 2R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$ and $\mathbb{E} M_Q^2 = \mathbb{E}(1 - 2W_Q)^2 = 1 - 4\mathbb{E} W_Q + 4\mathbb{E} W_Q^2 = 1 - 2d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ by Proposition 16.3. □

The first expression of the C-bound has a nice interpretation: it is small when the margin is large on average and has a small variance, i.e. when the vote is correct with a comfortable and stable majority. The second expression, in terms of the Gibbs risk and the disagreement, makes the classical intuition on ensembles precise; Fig. 141 shows its landscape. For a fixed Gibbs risk, the C-bound decreases when the disagreement increases: *a good vote needs voters that are individually better than random and that disagree*. This is exactly what bagging and random forests try to achieve by randomizing the training of the trees, and what Breiman (2001) described with the *strength* and the *correlation* of the trees; in regression, the same idea is the *ambiguity decomposition* of Krogh and Vedelsby (1995), and Kuncheva and Whitaker (2003) and Brown et al. (2005) review the many measures of diversity proposed for classifier ensembles. On the forest of Fig. 137, the C-bound is 0.143 (with the unrounded values of the Gibbs risk and of the disagreement), the smallest of the three bounds. Is this always the case? The next subsection answers precisely.

16.7 Which bound is the tightest?

The three oracle bounds only depend on the pair $(R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q), d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q))$, since $4e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) = 4R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) - 2d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$. They can therefore be compared once and for all, and the comparison turns out to be remarkably simple.

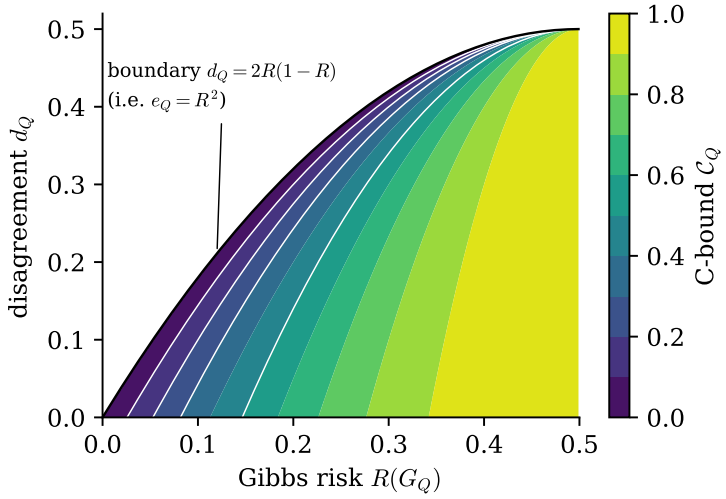


Figure 141: Value of the C-bound as a function of the Gibbs risk and the disagreement, on the feasible domain $d_{\mathcal{D}} \leq 2R(1-R)$. For a fixed Gibbs risk, increasing the disagreement decreases the bound: the C-bound formalizes the *strength–diversity* trade-off of ensemble methods (Breiman, 2001).

Proposition 16.7: Comparison of the oracle bounds

Let $R = R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) < \frac{1}{2}$ and $d = d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$. Then the C-bound is never larger than the tandem bound, $\mathcal{C}_Q \leq 4e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$, and

$$d \geq R \implies \mathcal{C}_Q \leq 4e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) \leq 2R, \qquad d \leq R \implies 2R \leq \mathcal{C}_Q \leq 4e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q).$$

The three bounds are equal on the line $d = R$.

Proof. The inequality $\mathcal{C}_Q \leq 4e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ follows from Theorem 16.8 below: the tandem bound is the member $\mu = 0$ of a family whose minimum is the C-bound. We have seen that $4e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) \leq 2R$ if and only if $d \geq R$. For the C-bound, since $1 - 2R > 0$ and $1 - 2d > 0$,

$$\mathcal{C}_Q \leq 2R \iff \frac{(1-2R)^2}{1-2d} \geq 1 - 2R \iff 1 - 2R \geq 1 - 2d \iff d \geq R.$$

On the line $d = R$, all three expressions equal $2R$. □

In plain words: when two random voters disagree more often than an average voter errs, the C-bound is the best of the three; otherwise, the simple first-order bound wins. Figure 142 draws the two regions.

The proposition explains the observations made on Condorcet's example: independent voters have a large disagreement, $d = 2p(1-p)(1-1/n)$, which exceeds p as soon as $n \geq 5$ when $p = 0.3$, so that the C-bound is the best; strongly correlated voters rarely disagree, and the first-order bound becomes the best. The proposition also shows that, as *oracle* quantities, the C-bound dominates the tandem bound. The situation changes once the bounds have to be *estimated* from data: the tandem bound needs a single kl inversion on one quantity, while the C-bound needs two, and the ratio in its

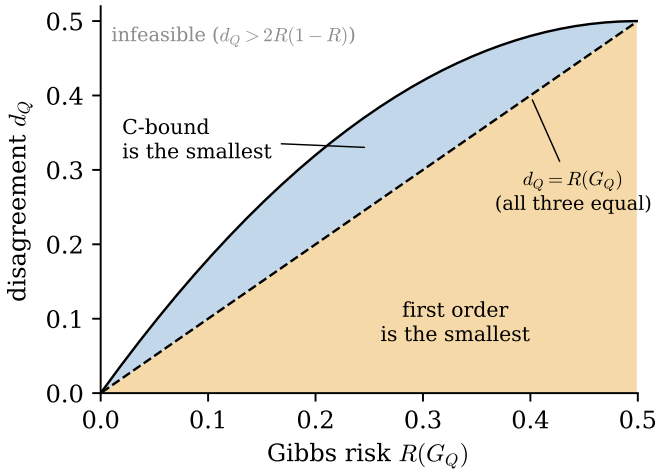


Figure 142: The smallest of the three oracle bounds in the plane (Gibbs risk, disagreement). Above the line $d_Q = R(G_Q)$, the C-bound is the smallest; below, the first-order bound is. The tandem bound is never strictly the smallest.

definition amplifies the estimation errors. In practice the two certificates are often close, as we will see in Section 18.

PAC-Bayesian C-bound. Let us see how the C-bound is estimated. Since $\mathcal{C}_Q$ is increasing in $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$ on $[0, \frac{1}{2})$ and decreasing in $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$, an upper bound on the first and a lower bound on the second give an upper bound on $\mathcal{C}_Q$. With a union bound (confidence $\delta/2$ for each), with probability at least $1-\delta$, for all Q,

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) \le 1 - \frac{\big(1-2\,\overline{r}\big)^2}{1-2\,\underline{d}}, \qquad \text{with} \tag{16.5}$$

$$\overline{r} = \overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}\Big(\widehat{R}_S(G_Q), \tfrac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)+\ln\frac{4\sqrt{m}}{\delta}}{m}\Big), \qquad \underline{d} = \underline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}\Big(\widehat{d}_S(Q), \tfrac{2\,\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)+\ln\frac{4\sqrt{m'}}{\delta}}{m'}\Big),$$

provided $\overline{r} < \frac{1}{2}$, where m' is the number of (possibly unlabeled) examples used to estimate the disagreement. Lacasse et al. (2006) and Germain et al. (2015) give tighter versions that bound the pair $(R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q), d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q))$ jointly, and Viallard et al. (2021) derive C-bounds that can be minimized directly by gradient descent. Note that Vignault et al. (2023) corrected one of the results of Germain et al. (2015) on the variance of the margin (their Proposition 15), and showed that when the labels are noisy the C-bound cannot be made arbitrarily small, even for a very diverse ensemble.

16.8 A unifying view: the Chebyshev–Cantelli family

We have met three bounds, each obtained from $\mathbb{P}(W_Q \ge \frac{1}{2})$ with a moment inequality. Are they really different objects? Wu et al. (2021) noticed that the last two belong to a single parametric family.

Theorem 16.8: Parametric second-order bound (Wu et al., 2021)

For any Q and any $\mu < \frac{1}{2}$,

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) \leq \frac{\mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{D}}[(W_Q - \mu)^2]}{\left(\frac{1}{2} - \mu\right)^2} = \frac{e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) - 2\mu R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) + \mu^2}{\left(\frac{1}{2} - \mu\right)^2}. \tag{16.6}$$

For $\mu = 0$ it is the tandem bound, and, when $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) < \frac{1}{2}$, its minimum over $\mu < \frac{1}{2}$ is reached at $\mu^\star = \frac{R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)/2 - e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)}{1/2 - R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)}$ and equals the C-bound $\mathcal{C}_Q$.

Proof. For $\mu < \frac{1}{2}$, $\{W_Q \geq \frac{1}{2}\} \subseteq \{(W_Q - \mu)^2 \geq (\frac{1}{2} - \mu)^2\}$; apply Markov's inequality. The minimization over μ is left as an exercise (Exercise 16.3); it reproduces the classical proof of Cantelli's inequality. □

In words, instead of measuring how far W_Q is from 0, as the tandem bound does, we measure how far it is from a well-chosen centre μ; the best centre gives back the C-bound. Figure 143 draws this family on a random forest of 100 trees trained on a simulated problem, for which the Gibbs risk is 0.247, the disagreement 0.314 and the joint error 0.090. The curve starts from the tandem bound 0.359 at $\mu = 0$, decreases to the C-bound 0.310 at $\mu^\star = 0.13$, and blows up when μ approaches $\frac{1}{2}$. The vote itself has a risk of 0.083: even the best member of the family is loose, which is the price of using only two moments of W_Q.

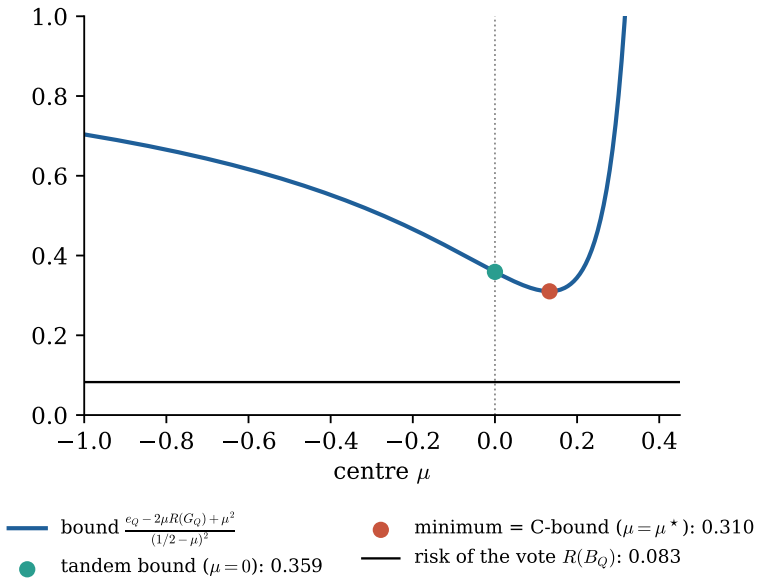


Figure 143: The Chebyshev–Cantelli family (16.6) as a function of μ, for a random forest of 100 trees on a simulated problem (oracle values computed on the test sample).

If the minimum is the C-bound, why keep the whole family? The interest of the parametric form is statistical. The quantity $\mathbb{E}(W_Q - \mu)^2$ has a small variance when μ is well chosen, and it can be estimated with a PAC-Bayes-Bennett inequality that exploits this small variance. The resulting *CCPBB* bound was the tightest of the bounds of this section in the experiments of Wu et al. (2021) when enough data are available. Related

refinements exploit the fact that the excess losses involved take only three values (split-kl inequality, Wu and Seldin, 2022).

Recent work: the split-kl inequality The quantities met in this section, such as $(W_Q - \mu)^2$ estimated through pairs of voters, or the excess losses of Section 15.2, are not Bernoulli variables but take a few values, and their variance is often small. The kl inequality, optimal for Bernoulli variables, cannot see this. Wu and Seldin (2022) split a variable $Z \in [a, b]$ around a fixed μ into its positive and negative parts, $Z = \mu + (Z-\mu)_+ - (Z-\mu)_-$, and apply a kl inequality to each part: with probability at least $1-\delta$,

$$\mathbb{E}Z \le \mu + (b-\mu)\,\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}\Big(\frac{\hat{p}^+}{b-\mu}, \frac{\ln\frac{2}{\delta}}{n}\Big) - (\mu-a)\,\underline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}\Big(\frac{\hat{p}^-}{\mu-a}, \frac{\ln\frac{2}{\delta}}{n}\Big),$$

where $\hat{p}^\pm$ are the empirical means of the two parts; the PAC-Bayesian version replaces $\ln\frac{2}{\delta}$ by $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln\frac{4\sqrt{n}}{\delta}$. For a ternary variable $Z \in \{-1, 0, 1\}$ which is zero most of the time, the gain over the kl inequality applied to $(Z+1)/2$ is a factor of about two (Fig. 144). This inequality is the basis of the tightest second-order certificates for majority votes (Wu and Seldin, 2022) and of the Recursive PAC-Bayes of Section 15.2. Biggs and Guedj (2023) follow a related idea: they subtract from the loss of each example a reference loss computed online on the previous examples, which gives low-variance, signed losses, and a kl-type inequality adapted to them.

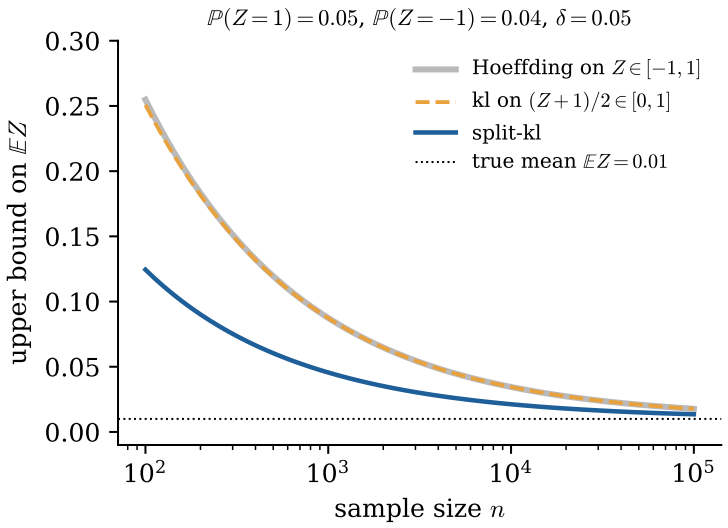


Figure 144: Upper bounds on the mean of a ternary variable $Z \in \{-1, 0, 1\}$ with mean 0.01 and small variance, as a function of the sample size (empirical frequencies equal to the true ones). Hoeffding's and the kl inequality applied to $(Z+1)/2$ almost coincide; the split-kl inequality is about twice tighter.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q16.7. In which regime is the first-order bound smaller than the C-bound?

Q16.8. Compute the three oracle bounds for $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = 0.2$ and $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) = 0.3$.

Q16.9. Why does the C-bound require $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) < \frac{1}{2}$?

Q16.10. True or false? Since the C-bound is never larger than the tandem bound, the PAC-Bayesian C-bound always gives a better certificate than the PAC-Bayesian tandem bound.

Q16.11. What is the role of the parameter μ in the Chebyshev–Cantelli family, and which value gives the tandem bound?

16.9 Margins and boosting

All the bounds so far summarize the margin distribution by one or two moments. The *margin theory* of boosting (Schapire et al., 1998), which we met in Fig. 112, uses the whole distribution instead, and Equation (16.1) is the bridge between the two viewpoints. For any $\theta > 0$, $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = \mathbb{P}(M_Q \leq 0) \leq \mathbb{P}(M_Q \leq \theta)$, and the classical margin bound for a finite class of voters states that, with probability at least $1 - \delta$,

$$\mathbb{P}_{\mathcal{D}}(M_Q \leq 0) \leq \mathbb{P}_S(M_Q \leq \theta) + O\left(\sqrt{\frac{\ln|\mathcal{H}|\,\ln m}{m\,\theta^2} + \frac{\ln(1/\delta)}{m}}\right).$$

This explains why AdaBoost may keep improving after its training error has reached zero: it keeps increasing the margins, and the empirical term $\mathbb{P}_S(M_Q \leq \theta)$ decreases for every θ.

A PAC-Bayesian proof of such bounds is obtained by approximating B_Q by a vote of N voters drawn from Q (Langford and Shawe-Taylor, 2002; McAllester, 2003b), and Biggs et al. (2022) sharpened margin bounds for voting classifiers using Dirichlet posteriors. The C-bound can be read as a margin bound that uses the first two moments of the margin distribution instead of its whole empirical distribution function. Outside PAC-Bayes, Høgsgaard Møller and Larsen (2025) recently removed a superfluous $\ln m$ factor from the classical margin bound, obtaining an almost optimal margin bound for voting classifiers.

Recent work: bounding the vote itself, exactly All the bounds of this section go from the Gibbs risk to the risk of the vote through an inequality. Leblanc and Germain (2025) propose an *identity* instead. For a fixed deterministic classifier h, for instance $h = B_Q$, let $b^Q(h)$ be the Gibbs risk restricted to the examples on which h is right, and $c^Q(h)$ the Gibbs risk restricted to the examples on which h errs. Since the Gibbs risk is the average of these two conditional risks, $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = (1 - R_{\mathcal{D}}(h))\,b^Q(h) + R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)\,c^Q(h)$, hence

$$R_{\mathcal{D}}(h) = \frac{R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) - b^Q(h)}{c^Q(h) - b^Q(h)} \qquad \text{when } c^Q(h) \neq b^Q(h).$$

For the majority vote, $c^Q(B_Q) \geq \frac{1}{2}$ since the vote errs only where half of the

voters err, and $b^Q(B_Q) \leq \frac{1}{2}$. Bounding each of the three quantities with a PAC-Bayes-kl bound gives a certificate for the vote which, according to the authors, can be up to twice tighter than the usual alternatives.

16.10 Back to the running example

We now have all the tools to return to the two questions raised by our forest in Section 12.

Running example We can now answer the first question of Section 12. On the test sample, the trees of our forest have a Gibbs risk of 0.190 and a disagreement of 0.266: two trees drawn at random disagree on more than a quarter of the digits, and they both err on only 5.7% of them. Since the disagreement exceeds the Gibbs risk, Proposition 16.7 tells us that the C-bound is the smallest oracle bound, and indeed the first-order bound is 0.381, the tandem bound 0.229 and the C-bound 0.179, for a vote whose risk is 0.044. The vote is good *because the trees are diverse*: they are individually mediocre, but their errors are spread over different digits.
The second question, certifying the vote without a test set, receives a more modest answer. Estimating the three quantities on the out-of-bag examples (as in the running example of Section 14), with $\delta = 0.05$, gives the certificates 0.460 (first order), 0.387 (tandem) and 0.559 (C-bound). They are valid, but far from the test risk: the factor 4 of the tandem bound and the doubled KL term are expensive, and the C-bound suffers from its two kl inversions. Improving these certificates by *learning* the weights of the trees is the program of Sections 17 and 18.

16.11 Summary and illustration on random forests

To close the section, Fig. 145 puts all the pieces together on random forests of 100 trees, where we vary the number of features tried at each split (`max_features`), the main diversity parameter of the algorithm. With a single feature per split, the trees are weak (Gibbs risk 0.30) but very diverse (disagreement 0.38); with all 20 features, they are stronger (Gibbs risk 0.17) but much more similar (disagreement 0.19). The risk of the vote is smallest in between, around 4 to 8 features, where it reaches 0.077.

The first-order bound only sees the strength of the trees and decreases monotonically, from 0.60 to 0.34, missing the optimum. The tandem bound and the C-bound see both strength and diversity: they are minimal at 8 features, close to the best vote, with values 0.29 and 0.28. Since the disagreement always exceeds the Gibbs risk in this experiment, Proposition 16.7 predicts the order C-bound $\leq$ tandem $\leq$ first order, which is what we observe.

The following table summarizes the bounds of the section: which moment of W_Q they use, and how PAC-Bayes estimates them.

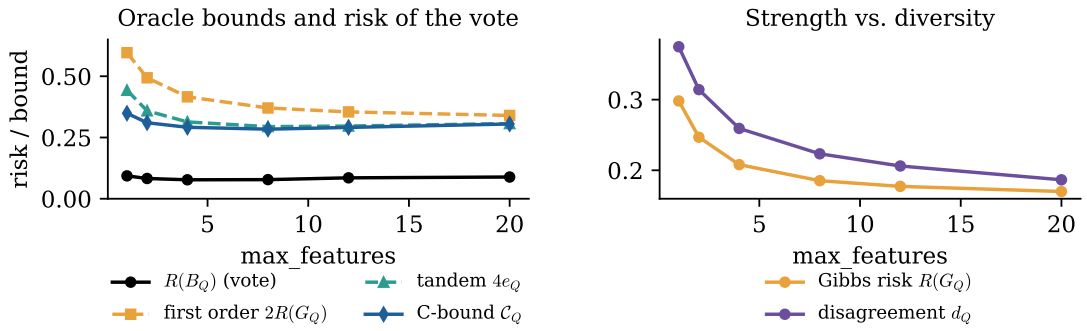


Figure 145: Random forests of 100 trees on a simulated problem, for an increasing number of features tried at each split (`max_features`). Left: oracle values of the bounds computed on a large test sample. Right: stronger trees (small Gibbs risk) are also less diverse (small disagreement). The C-bound and the tandem bound track the risk of the vote much better than the first-order bound.

Bound	Oracle form	Moment used	PAC-Bayesian estimation
First order	$2R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$	$\mathbb{E}W_Q$	Seeger on $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q)$, KL
Tandem	$4e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$	$\mathbb{E}W_Q^2$	Seeger on $\widehat{e}_S(Q)$, 2 KL
C-bound	$1-\frac{(1-2R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q))^2}{1-2d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)}$	$\mathbb{E}W_Q$, $\mathbb{E}W_Q^2$	two kl inversions
Chebyshev–Cantelli	$\frac{e_{\mathcal{D}}-2\mu R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)+\mu^2}{(1/2-\mu)^2}$	$\mathbb{E}(W_Q-\mu)^2$	PAC-Bayes-Bennett

To remember from Section 16

The risk of a vote is the tail probability $\mathbb{P}(W_Q \geq \frac{1}{2})$ of the proportion of erring voters, whereas the Gibbs risk is its mean. The average quality of the voters is not enough to control this tail: one also needs to know how their errors are correlated, which is measured by the disagreement, through the identity $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) + \frac{1}{2}d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$. The first-order bound $2R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$ ignores the correlations, the tandem bound $4e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ and the C-bound take them into account, and the C-bound, which is the minimum of the Chebyshev–Cantelli family, is the smallest as soon as $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) \geq R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$. PAC-Bayes estimates the second-order quantities on pairs of voters, with a doubled KL term.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q16.12. Why can AdaBoost keep improving its test error after its training error has reached zero?

Q16.13. What do the three oracle bounds become when all the voters are identical?

Q16.14. In the identity of Leblanc and Germain (2025), why is $c^Q(B_Q) \geq \frac{1}{2}$?

Q16.15. In the running example, the C-bound is the smallest oracle bound but the largest certificate. Why?

Q16.16. True or false? Increasing the diversity of an ensemble always decreases the risk of its vote.

Exercises

Exercise 16.1. **(Computation)** Give an example of three voters and a distribution on three points for which $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = 0$ while $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = \frac{1}{3}$. Compute the three oracle bounds.

Exercise 16.2. **(Proof)** Show that the C-bound is always smaller than 1 when $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) < \frac{1}{2}$, and that it equals $4R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)(1 - R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q))$ when $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) = 0$. Compare with the first-order bound.

Exercise 16.3. **(Proof)** ($\star$) Prove that the minimum over $\mu < \frac{1}{2}$ of the Chebyshev–Cantelli family (16.6) is reached at $\mu^\star = \frac{R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)/2 - e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)}{1/2 - R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)}$ and equals the C-bound (assume $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) < \frac{1}{2}$).

Exercise 16.4. **(Computation)** In Condorcet's model with n independent voters of error $p < \frac{1}{2}$, compute $e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ and $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$, and show that the C-bound decreases like $1/n$ while the tandem bound tends to $4p^2$.

Exercise 16.5. **(Comprehension)** True or false? Justify briefly. (a) If $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) < \frac{1}{2}$, then $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) < \frac{1}{2}$. (b) If $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) = 0$, all the voters in the support of Q make the same predictions on almost every x. (c) Estimating the joint error $e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ requires labels, but estimating the disagreement $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ does not. (d) For a fixed Gibbs risk, the tandem bound decreases when the disagreement increases.

Exercise 16.6. **(Application)** Three voters are evaluated on five equally likely examples $z_1, \dots, z_5$. Voter h_1 errs only on z_1, h_2 errs on z_2 and z_4, and h_3 errs on z_2 and z_3; the posterior is $Q = (0.4, 0.35, 0.25)$. Compute $W_Q(z_j)$ and $M_Q(z_j)$ for each example, the risk of the vote, the Gibbs risk, $e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ and $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ (check the identity of Proposition 16.3), and the three oracle bounds. Which one is the smallest, and is this consistent with Proposition 16.7?

Exercise 16.7. **(Application)** In Condorcet's model with $n = 5$ independent voters of error $p = 0.3$, compute the exact risk of the vote, $e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$, $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ and the three oracle bounds. Check the regime predicted by Proposition 16.7.

Exercise 16.8. **(Application)** A posterior with $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 1$ has an empirical Gibbs risk 0.15 on $m = 1000$ labelled examples and an empirical disagreement 0.25 on $m' = 1000$ examples. With $\delta = 0.05$, compute $\overline{r}$, $\underline{d}$ and the PAC-Bayesian C-bound (16.5), the first-order certificate (16.2) and the tandem certificate (16.3) (the empirical joint error follows from Proposition 16.3, assuming the disagreement was measured on the same 1000 labelled examples). Compare with the value of the C-bound computed at the empirical values. What changes if $m' = 10\,000$ unlabeled examples are available?

Exercise 16.9. **(Proof)** For voters with values in $\{-1, +1\}$ and a fixed example (x, y), show that $\mathbb{P}_{(h,h')\sim Q^2}\big(h(x) \neq h'(x)\big) = 2W_Q(x,y)\big(1 - W_Q(x,y)\big)$. Deduce that $\mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{D}} M_Q^2 = 1 - 2d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ and $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) + \frac{1}{2} d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$.

Exercise 16.10. **(Proof)** In Condorcet's model with $n = 2k+1$ independent voters of error $p < \frac{1}{2}$, use Hoeffding's inequality (Proposition 1.14 in Section 1) to show that $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) \leq e^{-2n(1/2-p)^2}$. Evaluate this bound for $p = 0.3$ and $n \in \{5, 25, 101\}$, and compare it with the exact risks and with the C-bound.

Exercise 16.11. **(Application)** Consider three ensembles with the same Gibbs risk 0.3, described by the distribution of W_Q over the examples (compare with Figure 138): (i) $W_Q = 0.3$ on every example; (ii) $W_Q = 0.52$ with probability $\frac{0.3}{0.52}$ and $W_Q = 0$ otherwise; (iii) $W_Q = 1$ with probability 0.3 and $W_Q = 0$ otherwise. For each of them, compute the risk of the vote, the joint error, the disagreement, and the three oracle bounds $2R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$, $4e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ and $\mathcal{C}_Q$. Which bound is the best in each case, and is this consistent with Proposition 16.7?

Exercise 16.12. **(Proof)** This exercise studies when the bounds of this section are tight. (a) Show that $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = 2R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$ if and only if $W_Q \in \{0, \frac{1}{2}\}$ almost surely. (b) Show that

the tandem bound is an equality under the same condition. (c) Compute the C-bound when $W_Q = \frac{1}{2}$ with probability q and $W_Q = 0$ otherwise. (d) Build an ensemble of two voters and a distribution on which this situation occurs, and comment.

Exercise 16.13. **(Computation)** We use the identity of Leblanc and Germain (2025) (Recent work box "bounding the vote itself, exactly"). (a) An ensemble has a Gibbs risk 0.2; restricted to the examples where the vote is right, the Gibbs risk is $b = 0.15$, and restricted to those where it errs, $c = 0.65$. Compute $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q)$. (b) Show that $\frac{R-b}{c-b}$ is increasing in R and decreasing in b and in c (for $b \leq R < c$). Deduce an upper bound on $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q)$ from an upper bound $\overline{R} = 0.25$ on the Gibbs risk, a lower bound $\underline{b} = 0.12$ and a lower bound $\underline{c} = 0.55$. Compare with the first-order bound computed with $\overline{R}$. (c) Show that, with exact values, this identity never gives more than the first-order bound.

Exercise 16.14. **(Application)** A random forest has, on a large test sample, a Gibbs risk 0.247, a disagreement 0.314 and a risk of the vote 0.083 (Figure 143). (a) Compute the joint error and check that it is consistent with the value 0.090 given in the text. Compute the first-order and tandem bounds. (b) Compute $\mu^\star$ and the minimal value of the Chebyshev–Cantelli family; check that it is the C-bound. (c) Compute the member $\mu = -\frac{1}{2}$ of the family. Why does the family blow up when $\mu \to \frac{1}{2}$? (d) Which of the three oracle bounds is the smallest, and could you have predicted it without computing the bounds?

Exercise 16.15. **(Python)** Train a `RandomForestClassifier` of 100 trees on `digits` (classes 0–4 against 5–9, 30% test split, `random_state=0`). Using the predictions of the individual trees (`rf.estimators_`), compute on the test set the variable W_Q for the uniform posterior, the risk of the majority vote, the Gibbs risk, the joint error and the disagreement. Check the identity of Proposition 16.3 and compute the three oracle bounds.

17 Self-bounding learning

About this section

Guiding question. *If a bound holds for every posterior, why not choose the posterior that makes it smallest, and what does this change to the certificate?*

Up to now, PAC-Bayesian bounds were used after learning, to certify a posterior produced by some algorithm. This section reverses the roles: since the bounds hold for all posteriors, we can minimize *them, and obtain a predictor together with its own risk certificate. We explain why this is legitimate, what may and may not depend on the data, how this approach compares with the classical hold-out certificate, and which optimization tools are used by all self-bounding algorithms. Each point is illustrated by running the algorithms on random forests.*

The bounds of Sections 14 to 16 have a remarkable property: they hold *simultaneously for all posteriors*. So far we have used them to evaluate a posterior produced by another algorithm, such as the uniform weights of a random forest; in our running example, the uniform forest received a tandem certificate of 0.387. But nothing prevents us from choosing the posterior *because* its bound is small. Instead of minimizing an empirical risk and then trying to certify the result, we can directly minimize the bound: the algorithm then outputs a predictor *and* a guarantee on its risk. This idea goes back to Freund (1998) and Langford and Blum (2003), who coined the term *self-bounding learning algorithm*. PAC-Bayes turned it into a general and practical methodology (Germain et al., 2009, 2015; Thiemann et al., 2017; Masegosa et al., 2020; Viallard et al., 2021; Pérez-Ortiz et al., 2021).

17.1 From empirical risk minimization to bound minimization

To see what self-bounding learning changes, let us first recall how we usually learn and evaluate a model. In Section 7, learning followed a three-step pipeline. A model is learned by minimizing a regularized empirical risk on a training sample, its hyperparameters are tuned by cross-validation, and it is finally evaluated on a test sample that was never used before. The test error is an *estimate* of the true risk, which a concentration inequality turns into a *guarantee* (the test-set bound of Section 17.4). This last step has a cost: the examples of the test sample do not contribute to learning.

A self-bounding algorithm merges the three steps into one. Suppose that we have a PAC-Bayesian bound of the form

$$\mathbb{P}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\Big(\forall Q \in \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H}), \quad R_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) \le \mathcal{B}(Q,S,\delta)\Big) \ge 1-\delta,$$

where $R_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ denotes the risk we want to control (the Gibbs risk, or the risk of the vote) and $\mathcal{B}(Q,S,\delta)$ is a quantity that can be computed from the sample. The algorithm learns

$$Q_S \in \operatorname*{arg\,min}_{Q\in\mathcal{Q}} \mathcal{B}(Q,S,\delta), \qquad \text{and returns the certificate} \qquad \mathcal{B}(Q_S,S,\delta), \tag{17.1}$$

where $\mathcal{Q} \subseteq \mathcal{M}(\mathcal{H})$ is the family of posteriors in which we search, for instance all distributions on a finite set of voters, or Gaussian distributions on the weights of a model.

Definition 17.1: Self-bounding learning algorithm

A *self-bounding learning algorithm* is a procedure which, given a sample $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$ and a confidence level $\delta \in (0, 1]$, returns a predictor f_S and a number $\mathcal{B}_S \in [0, 1]$, both computed from S only, such that

$$\mathbb{P}_{S\sim\mathcal{D}^m}\Big(R_{\mathcal{D}}(f_S) \le \mathcal{B}_S\Big) \ge 1 - \delta.$$

The number $\mathcal{B}_S$ is called the *risk certificate* of f_S.

In plain words, a self-bounding algorithm hands us two things computed from the same data: a predictor, and a number that we can trust, with high probability, as an upper bound on its true risk. Many algorithms of this course fit this definition: the Gibbs posterior Q_λ of Section 15.1 with its Seeger certificate, the forest weighted by Algorithm 14 with its first-order certificate, or PBGD with Catoni's bound (Section 18.4). A random forest with uniform weights, returned together with its out-of-bag tandem certificate, is also self-bounding in the sense of the definition; the certificate is simply not used to learn. One question must be settled before we go further: if the posterior is chosen by looking at its own bound, is that bound still trustworthy?

17.2 Why the certificate remains valid

The following result is almost trivial, but it is the reason why the whole approach works, so it deserves to be stated carefully.

Theorem 17.2: Validity of self-bounding certificates

Let $\mathcal{B}$ be such that $\mathbb{P}_S(\forall Q \in \mathcal{Q},\ R_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) \le \mathcal{B}(Q, S, \delta)) \ge 1 - \delta$. Let $S \mapsto Q_S \in \mathcal{Q}$ be *any* learning rule (deterministic, or using a source of randomness independent of the data). Then

$$\mathbb{P}_S\Big(R_{\mathcal{D}}(Q_S) \le \mathcal{B}(Q_S, S, \delta)\Big) \ge 1 - \delta.$$

In particular this holds for Q_S minimizing $\mathcal{B}(\cdot, S, \delta)$ or any other objective, and for any stopping time of an iterative optimizer.

Proof. Let $E = \{S : \forall Q \in \mathcal{Q},\ R_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) \le \mathcal{B}(Q, S, \delta)\}$. For every $S \in E$, the inequality holds in particular for the posterior Q_S. Hence $\{S : R_{\mathcal{D}}(Q_S) \le \mathcal{B}(Q_S, S, \delta)\} \supseteq E$ and its probability is at least $\mathbb{P}(E) \ge 1 - \delta$. If Q_S also depends on an independent random seed ξ, apply the argument conditionally on ξ and integrate. □

In words: since the bad event does not depend on which posterior we pick, no way of picking one, however clever or data-driven, can make us fall into it. The key is the quantifier "for all Q" inside the probability. A bound which only holds for a *fixed* predictor, such as Hoeffding's inequality for a fixed h or a test-set bound, does not remain valid if the predictor is chosen by looking at the data used in the bound.

We saw in Fig. 124 how badly such a bound fails: after selecting the best of 1000 random classifiers, the naive Hoeffding bound was wrong in 99.8% of the runs. The

Occam bound remained valid because it pays $\ln \frac{1}{P(h)} = \ln 1000$, which is exactly the price of having *selected* h with the data. PAC-Bayes extends this accounting to any soft selection: the price of choosing a posterior Q with the data is $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$. Because the price is already included in the bound, we are allowed to choose Q in any way we like, and in particular by minimizing the bound. This freedom concerns the posterior only, and the next subsection makes precise where it stops.

17.3 What may depend on the data?

Theorem 17.2 allows the posterior to depend arbitrarily on S. Everything else in the bound — the prior, the confidence level δ, the form of the bound and its internal parameters — must be fixed before seeing the sample used in the bound. When we nevertheless want to choose one of these ingredients with the data, we pay for it with a union bound, as the following proposition shows.

Proposition 17.3: Combining several bounds

Let $\mathcal{B}_1, \dots, \mathcal{B}_K$ be K bounds (they may use different priors, different parameters, different forms, or even different sets of voters), each valid in the sense that for every δ', $\mathbb{P}_S(\forall Q,\ R_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) \le \mathcal{B}_k(Q, S, \delta')) \ge 1 - \delta'$. Let $\pi_1, \dots, \pi_K > 0$ with $\sum_k \pi_k = 1$. Then

$$\mathbb{P}_S\Big(\forall k,\ \forall Q,\quad R_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) \le \mathcal{B}_k(Q, S, \pi_k \delta)\Big) \ge 1 - \delta.$$

Consequently, $\min_k \mathcal{B}_k(Q_S, S, \pi_k\delta)$ is a valid certificate for any learning rule Q_S, and the index k may be chosen with the data.

Proof. The probability that at least one of the K events fails is at most $\sum_k \pi_k \delta = \delta$ (union bound). □

In other words, we may try several bounds and keep the best one, provided we share the confidence budget δ among them in advance. With $\pi_k = \frac{1}{K}$, choosing among K candidates amounts to replacing δ by δ/K, that is to adding $\ln K$ to the numerator of the complexity term. This is a very small price for a moderate K: choosing among ten candidates costs 2.3 nats, the same as dividing δ by ten. With a countable family, one can take $\pi_k = \frac{6}{\pi^2 k^2}$, which costs $2\ln k + \ln \frac{\pi^2}{6}$ for the k-th candidate.

The line between what is free and what must be paid for is subtle, so the table below gathers the most common cases. The underlying rule is simple to state. A parameter is free when it only indexes a family of *posteriors*, all compared with the same prior in the same bound: the parameter C of PBGD, for instance, selects a weight vector $\mathbf{w}$, hence a posterior $Q_{\mathbf{w}}$, and Seeger's bound holds for all of them at once. A parameter is not free when it changes the *probabilistic event* on which the bound holds: the parameter C of Catoni's bound changes the function Δ of Theorem 14.1, and each value gives a different event.

Free (no correction)	**Union bound** ($\delta \to \delta/K$)	**Forbidden**
the posterior Q and the algorithm producing it; the temperature of a Gibbs posterior; λ in the PAC-Bayes-λ bound; C in PBGD; the learning rate, initialization and number of iterations (early stopping on the bound)	C in Catoni's bound; λ in the Hoeffding-type bound; the variance of a Gaussian prior chosen on a grid; the choice among first-order / tandem / C-bound; the choice among K ensembles built with different hyperparameters	a prior learned on the examples used in the bound; choosing δ after seeing the bound; repeating the experiment with many seeds and reporting the best certificate (unless all of them are accounted for)

Self-bounding model selection. Because a choice among K candidates costs only $\ln K$, Proposition 17.3 offers a principled alternative to cross-validation. We build K candidate models, for instance forests with different tree depths, learn a posterior for each of them by minimizing its bound computed with δ/K, and keep the candidate with the smallest certificate. The selected model comes with a valid certificate, and no example was set aside for validation.

Example 17.1 (Choosing the depth of the trees with the certificate). On `digits`, we build six forests of 100 trees, with maximal depths 1, 2, 3, 5, 8 and unlimited, each tree being trained on a bootstrap sample of half the training set. For each forest, the posterior minimizes the out-of-bag tandem bound of Section 18.2, computed with $\delta/6$. Figure 146 reports the certificates and the test risks over five random splits. The certificate decreases steadily with the depth, from 0.96 for stumps to 0.375 for unpruned trees, and so does the test risk of the vote, from 0.19 to 0.031. The certificate thus selects the unpruned trees, which is also the best choice for the test risk, and the price of the selection ($\ln 6 \approx 1.8$ nats) is invisible at this scale. (These values are averaged over five stratified splits, which explains the small differences with the single split used in Section 18.) In general, the certificate remains a pessimistic proxy for the test risk: when two candidates are close, it may select a slightly sub-optimal one.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q17.1. Why does minimizing a PAC-Bayesian bound not invalidate the certificate of the minimizer?

Q17.2. Is the temperature of a Gibbs posterior a free parameter? And the parameter C of Catoni's bound?

Q17.3. What is the price of choosing the best of K candidate models with their certificates?

Q17.4. Give the order of magnitude of this price for $K = 20$ candidates and $m = 1000$ examples.

Q17.5. True or false? Hoeffding's inequality for a fixed classifier remains valid for the classifier that minimizes the empirical risk among 1000 candidates, if it is applied to the same sample.

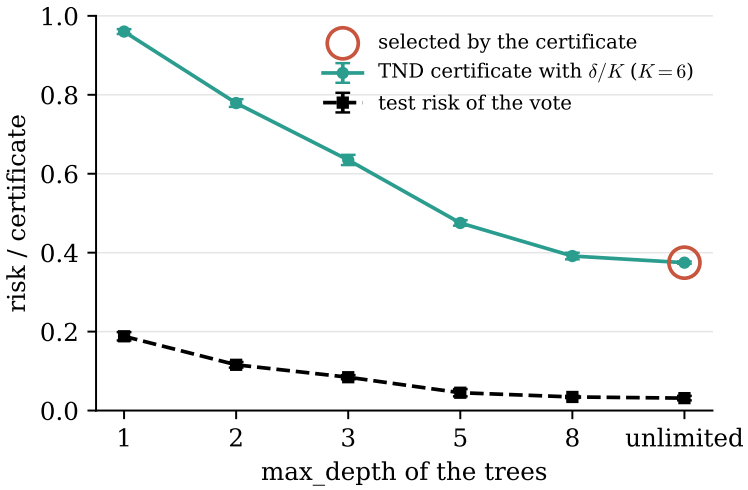


Figure 146: Self-bounding model selection. Six forests (100 trees, bootstrap samples of size $m/2$) with increasing tree depth are learned on `digits`; for each of them the posterior minimizes the tandem bound and the certificate is computed with $\delta/6$ (Proposition 17.3). The certificate decreases with the depth like the test risk; here it selects the model with the best test risk (means and standard deviations over 5 splits).

17.4 Self-bounding versus hold-out

A self-bounding certificate is only interesting if it compares well with the simplest alternative. This natural competitor is the *test-set bound* (Langford, 2005), which certifies a predictor with an independent sample.

Proposition 17.4: Test-set bound

Let f be a predictor learned on S_1 and $T \sim \mathcal{D}^n$ a sample independent of S_1. Then, with probability at least $1-\delta$ over T, $R_{\mathcal{D}}(f) \leq \overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}\left(\widehat{R}_T(f), \frac{\ln(1/\delta)}{n}\right)$.

Proof. Conditionally on S_1, f is fixed and $n\widehat{R}_T(f) \sim \mathrm{Bin}(n, R_{\mathcal{D}}(f))$; apply Chernoff's bound (Lemma 13.4). Equivalently, it is the Occam bound with a single hypothesis ($P = \delta_f$, $\mathrm{KL} = 0$). □

The test-set bound certifies *any* predictor, in particular the majority vote itself, with no factor 2 or 4 and no KL term, so it is very tight. Its drawback is that the n test examples do not contribute to learning. Self-bounding learning makes the opposite trade-off: all the data serve both to learn and to certify, but the certificate relies on a PAC-Bayesian bound, which is looser. Figure 147 compares how the two approaches, and the intermediate one of data-dependent priors (Section 15.2), use the m examples. Which trade-off wins is an empirical question, which the next example examines.

Example 17.2 (Which approach gives the better vote, and the better certificate?). We compare the two approaches on a simulated problem, for sample sizes m from 200 to 4000 (Fig. 148). The self-bounding approach builds a forest of 100 trees on the m examples and minimizes its out-of-bag tandem bound; the hold-out approach builds the same forest on 70% of the examples and computes the test-set bound of its vote

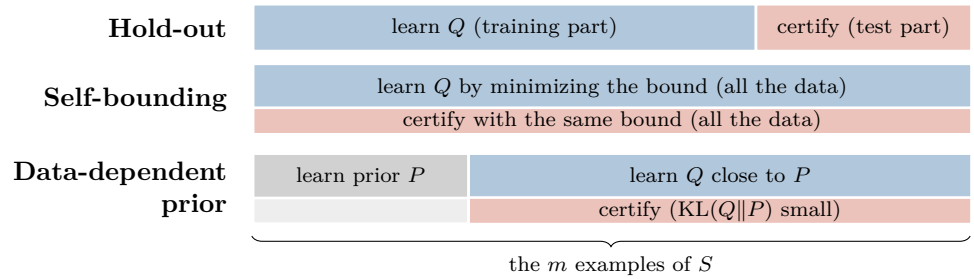


Figure 147: Three ways of using the sample. The hold-out approach learns on one part and certifies on the other; the self-bounding approach uses every example twice, to learn and to certify, which is legitimate because the bound holds for all posteriors; a data-dependent prior sits in between, the examples used for the prior being excluded from the bound.

on the remaining 30%. As expected, using all the data gives a better vote for every m: with $m = 1000$, its test risk is 0.099 against 0.110. But the hold-out certificate is much tighter: 0.17 against 0.63 for $m = 1000$, and 0.10 against 0.39 for $m = 4000$. For majority votes, the factor 4 of the tandem bound and the second-order KL term cost more than the examples withheld by the hold-out.

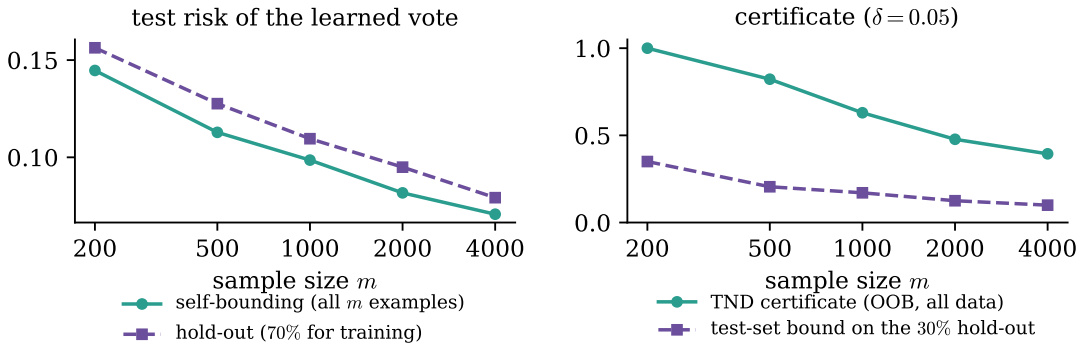


Figure 148: Self-bounding (forest learned on the m examples, posterior minimizing the OOB tandem bound, TND certificate) versus hold-out (forest learned on 70% of the examples, test-set bound on the remaining 30%), on a simulated problem, as a function of m (average over 3 repetitions). Using all the data gives a better vote (left), but for majority votes the hold-out certificate remains much tighter (right).

This experiment should be read honestly. If the only goal is to report a tight guarantee on a fixed vote, the hold-out is hard to beat. The value of self-bounding learning lies elsewhere: it uses all the data, it provides a learning objective with a guarantee, and it makes model selection almost free.

The gap in tightness is also specific to majority votes, where the passage from the Gibbs risk to the vote costs a constant factor; for stochastic neural networks, self-bounding certificates with data-dependent priors are tight enough to be informative, for instance on MNIST (Pérez-Ortiz et al., 2021). The following table summarizes the comparison.

	Hold-out (test-set bound)	Self-bounding (PAC-Bayes)
Data used to learn	part of the sample	the whole sample
Predictor certified	any (vote, deep net…)	a posterior (Gibbs, vote via Section 16)
Tightness	excellent: a single kl inversion, no KL term	depends on the KL and on the Gibbs-to-vote relation
Guides learning?	no	yes: the certificate is the objective
Model selection	needs another split	free or $\ln K$ (Proposition 17.3)

Best of both worlds: data-dependent priors. We do not have to choose between the two approaches: they can be combined. We split $S = S_1 \cup S_2$, use S_1 to learn a *prior* P_{S_1} (a Gaussian centred on a network trained on S_1, or voters built on S_1), and compute the PAC-Bayesian bound on S_2.

Proposition 17.5: Self-bounding with a data-dependent prior

Let P_{S_1} be a prior learned on S_1 and $\mathcal{B}$ a PAC-Bayesian bound computed on $S_2 \sim \mathcal{D}^{m_2}$, independent of S_1. Then, with probability at least $1-\delta$ over (S_1, S_2), for all posteriors Q — including posteriors learned on the whole sample $S_1 \cup S_2$ — we have $R_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) \leq \mathcal{B}(Q, S_2, P_{S_1}, \delta)$.

Proof. Conditionally on S_1, the prior is fixed and S_2 is an i.i.d. sample, so the bound holds with probability at least $1-\delta$ over S_2, for all Q simultaneously. Integrate over S_1. □

Put simply, the prior may look at S_1 as long as the bound only looks at S_2. Only the *empirical term* of the bound must be computed on S_2; the posterior itself may use all the data. This is the strategy behind the tightest certificates for neural networks (Dziugaite and Roy, 2017; Pérez-Ortiz et al., 2021) and SVMs (Ambroladze et al., 2006; Parrado-Hernández et al., 2012), and we measured its trade-off in Fig. 134.

The two approaches of this subsection appear as the two ends of this spectrum. The Recursive PAC-Bayes of Wu et al. (2024), presented in Section 15.2, narrows the gap further by letting every example serve both to build a prior and to certify. The test-set bound is the extreme case where the posterior is a Dirac on the prior (KL = 0), and a pure self-bounding algorithm is the other extreme ($S_1 = \emptyset$). The out-of-bag construction of Section 18.2 can be seen as a clever way to obtain a data-dependent prior without splitting the sample once and for all.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q17.6. Give one advantage of the hold-out certificate and one advantage of the self-bounding certificate.

Q17.7. In Proposition 17.5, may the posterior use the examples of S_1? And the prior those of S_2?

Q17.8. Why is the test-set bound a special case of a PAC-Bayesian bound?

17.5 Anatomy of a self-bounding algorithm

We now know what is allowed; it remains to turn these rules into algorithms. Fortunately, all the self-bounding algorithms of this course follow the same template, summarized in Fig. 149 and Algorithm 13. The first decision is how to organize the data: which examples build the voters or the prior, and which ones are used in the bound. The prior is then fixed, independently of the examples of the bound. The third step chooses an objective, which may be the bound itself or a relaxation that is easier to optimize, and the fourth step minimizes it with one of the tools of Section 17.6. Finally, the tightest valid bound is computed for the posterior that was found.

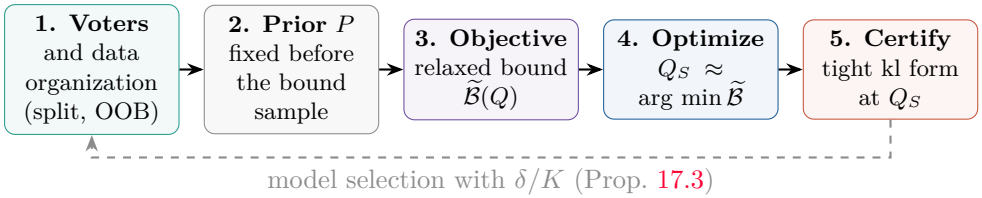


Figure 149: The five ingredients of a self-bounding algorithm.

Algorithm 13: Generic self-bounding learning

Input: sample S, confidence δ, family of posteriors $\{Q_\theta\}$

1 Organize the data: which examples build the voters / the prior, which ones are used in the bound;

2 Fix the prior P (independent of the examples used in the bound);

3 Choose a *relaxed* objective $\widetilde{\mathcal{B}}(\theta) \geq$ (or $\approx$) the bound, easy to optimize;

4 $\theta_S \leftarrow$ approximately minimize $\widetilde{\mathcal{B}}(\theta)$ (closed form, alternating or gradient-based);

5 Compute the *tight* certificate $\mathcal{B}(Q_{\theta_S}, S, \delta)$ with the kl inversion (Monte Carlo if needed);

Output: Q_{θ_S} and its certificate

Two features of this template are worth stressing. First, the objective need not be the certificate. By Theorem 17.2, the certificate is valid whatever the way Q_S was obtained, so we may optimize a convenient relaxation (McAllester's bound, the PAC-Bayes-λ bound, a surrogate loss) and report the tightest valid bound at the end; if we report the minimum of several bounds, Proposition 17.3 applies. Second, the optimizer need not find the global minimum: every posterior is certified, and a poor optimizer only yields a looser certificate, never a wrong one. Step 4 is therefore a matter of efficiency rather than validity, and the next subsection reviews the tools available for it.

17.6 Optimization toolbox

The right optimizer depends on the shape of the objective. We go from the easiest case, where the minimizer is explicit, to the most general one, where we differentiate through the kl inversion itself.

17.6.1 Closed form: linear objectives and the Gibbs posterior

When the objective is linear in the empirical term and in the KL, $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) + \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)}{\lambda m}$, as for Hoeffding-type or PAC-Bayes-λ bounds, Proposition 15.1 gives the minimizer in closed form, $Q_\lambda(h) \propto P(h)e^{-\lambda m \widehat{R}_S(h)}$. The only remaining parameter is the temperature, which is free since it indexes posteriors: we can scan a grid of values of λ and keep the best certificate, as in Fig. 131.

17.6.2 Alternating minimization

When the temperature is not scanned but optimized, a closed form is available in each variable separately. The PAC-Bayes-λ bound (14.6) is minimized in Q by the Gibbs posterior when λ is fixed, and in λ by the closed form (14.7) when Q is fixed. Alternating the two steps (Algorithm 14) converges to the global minimum under the conditions of Thiemann et al. (2017); we will see in Table 10 that a few iterations suffice in practice.

17.6.3 Gradient-based minimization

For richer objectives, such as second-order bounds, C-bounds or bounds on neural networks, we use gradient descent on a parametrization of the posterior. For a finite set of voters, the simplest parametrization is the softmax $\rho = \mathrm{softmax}(\theta)$, $\rho_t = e^{\theta_t} / \sum_s e^{\theta_s}$, which removes the simplex constraint. If $g = \nabla_\rho \mathcal{B}$ is the gradient with respect to the weights, the chain rule gives

$$\nabla_\theta \mathcal{B} = \rho \odot (g - (\rho^\top g)\mathbf{1}), \qquad \text{with, for the KL term,} \qquad \nabla_\rho \,\mathrm{KL}(\rho\|\pi) = \ln \frac{\rho}{\pi} + \mathbf{1}. \quad (17.2)$$

For Gaussian posteriors $Q = \mathcal{N}(\boldsymbol{\mu}, \mathrm{diag}(\boldsymbol{\sigma}^2))$ on the parameters $\mathbf{w}$ of a model, the KL to a Gaussian prior is explicit, and the expected loss is differentiated with the *reparametrization trick*: writing $\mathbf{w} = \boldsymbol{\mu} + \boldsymbol{\sigma} \odot \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}$ with $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$, we have $\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\mu},\boldsymbol{\sigma}} \mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{w}\sim Q} \ell(\mathbf{w}) = \mathbb{E}_{\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}} \nabla_{\boldsymbol{\mu},\boldsymbol{\sigma}} \ell(\boldsymbol{\mu} + \boldsymbol{\sigma} \odot \boldsymbol{\varepsilon})$, which is estimated with a few samples of $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}$ (Dziugaite and Roy, 2017; Pérez-Ortiz et al., 2021).

In both cases a difficulty remains: the 0-1 loss is not differentiable. Either the Gibbs risk has a smooth closed form, as the probit loss of linear classifiers (Eq. (18.5)), or the 0-1 loss is replaced during learning by a bounded surrogate such as a clipped cross-entropy. The final certificate is always computed with the 0-1 loss.

17.6.4 Differentiating through the kl inversion

The tightest bounds are expressed with $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}$, which has no closed form. It can nevertheless be differentiated, which allows us to minimize Seeger-type certificates directly (Reeb et al., 2018; Viallard et al., 2021).

Proposition 17.6: Derivatives of the kl inversion

Let $q \in (0,1)$, $\varepsilon > 0$ and $p = \overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(q,\varepsilon)$ (or $p = \underline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(q,\varepsilon)$), so that $\mathrm{kl}(q\|p) = \varepsilon$ and $p \neq q$. Then

$$\frac{\partial p}{\partial q} = \frac{p(1-p)}{p-q}\,\ln\frac{p(1-q)}{q(1-p)}, \qquad \frac{\partial p}{\partial \varepsilon} = \frac{p(1-p)}{p-q}.$$

Proof. Let $F(q,p) = \mathrm{kl}(q\|p) - \varepsilon$. We have $F_q = \partial_q \mathrm{kl}(q\|p) = \ln\frac{q(1-p)}{p(1-q)}$ and $F_p = \partial_p \mathrm{kl}(q\|p) = \frac{p-q}{p(1-p)} \neq 0$. By the implicit function theorem, p is a differentiable function of (q,ε) with $\frac{\partial p}{\partial q} = -\frac{F_q}{F_p}$ and $\frac{\partial p}{\partial \varepsilon} = \frac{1}{F_p}$. □

So, although $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}$ has no closed form, its gradient only requires the value p that we compute anyway. As expected, $\frac{\partial p}{\partial \varepsilon}$ is positive for the upper inversion and negative for the lower one. These derivatives also tell us how sensitive a certificate is to its ingredients. At $\hat{q} = 0.1$ and $\varepsilon = 0.05$, where $p \approx 0.220$, we find $\frac{\partial p}{\partial \varepsilon} \approx 1.43$: with $m = 1000$ examples, one more nat of KL increases ε by 0.001 and the certificate by about 0.0014.

For the tandem certificate of a finite ensemble, $\mathcal{B}_{\mathrm{TND}}(\rho) = 4\,\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(\rho^\top \widehat{\mathbf{L}}\rho,\, \varepsilon(\rho))$ with $\varepsilon(\rho) = \frac{2\,\mathrm{KL}(\rho\|\pi) + \ln(2\sqrt{n_0}/\delta)}{n_0}$, where n_0 is the number of examples on which the tandem losses are computed, the chain rule gives

$$\nabla_\rho \mathcal{B}_{\mathrm{TND}} = 4\Big[\frac{\partial p}{\partial q}\,2\widehat{\mathbf{L}}\rho + \frac{\partial p}{\partial \varepsilon}\,\frac{2}{n}\Big(\ln\frac{\rho}{\pi} + \mathbf{1}\Big)\Big], \tag{17.3}$$

to be combined with (17.2). The function `certificate_and_grad` of `pbtools.py` implements this formula.

Example 17.3 (Watching a self-bounding algorithm learn). Figure 150 runs this gradient descent (Adam, 400 iterations, softmax parametrization, uniform initialization) on the out-of-bag first-order and tandem certificates of a forest of 100 trees on `digits`, and records the certificate, the test risk of the vote and the effective number of trees $1/\sum_t \rho_t^2$ along the iterations. The first-order certificate decreases from 0.46 to 0.39, but it achieves this by concentrating the posterior on fewer and fewer trees: after 200 iterations, fewer than two trees carry the whole weight, and the test risk of the vote jumps from 0.044 to 0.15. The tandem certificate decreases from 0.39 to 0.36 while keeping an effective number of about 48 trees, and the vote remains as accurate as the uniform forest. This is the phenomenon announced in Section 16 and analysed in Section 18.2.2: an objective that ignores the correlations between voters destroys the diversity that makes the vote work.

17.6.5 Relaxations of Seeger's bound used as objectives

Differentiating through $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}$ is not always convenient. When a differentiable closed form is preferred, one of the following upper bounds on $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(\hat{q},\varepsilon)$ can be minimized instead (Pérez-Ortiz et al., 2021). All of them follow from the Pinsker-type inequalities of Lemma 13.5. The PAC-Bayes-λ bound, optimized in λ, coincides with the "quadratic" bound, but its linear form is more convenient for alternating minimization.

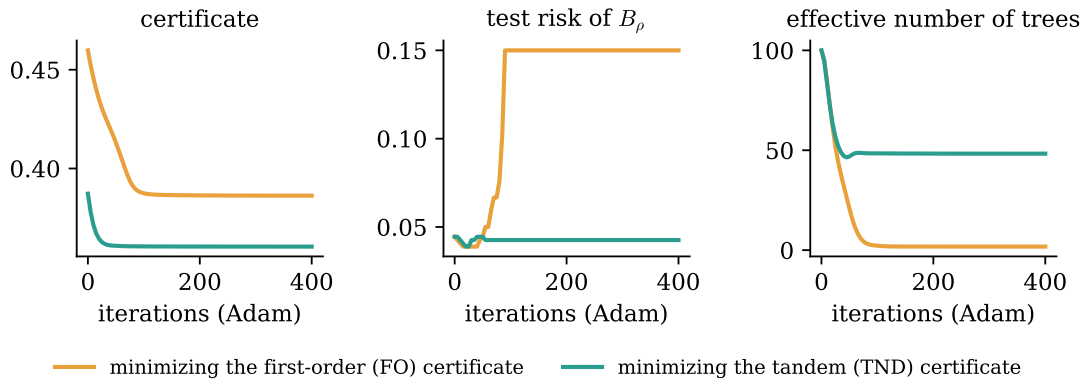


Figure 150: Direct minimization (Adam, softmax parametrization, gradient of Proposition 17.6) of the OOB first-order and tandem certificates of a forest of 100 trees on `digits`. Left: value of the certificate; middle: test risk of the vote; right: effective number of trees.

Name	Objective	Comment
McAllester ("classic")	$\hat{q} + \sqrt{\varepsilon/2}$	simplest, loose when $\hat{q}$ is small
PAC-Bayes-λ	$\frac{\hat{q}}{1-\lambda/2} + \frac{\varepsilon}{\lambda(1-\lambda/2)}$	linear; quadratic at $\lambda^\star$
"Quadratic"	$\left(\sqrt{\hat{q} + \varepsilon/2} + \sqrt{\varepsilon/2}\right)^2$	from $(p-\hat{q})^2 \le 2p\varepsilon$
Seeger (kl)	$\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(\hat{q}, \varepsilon)$	tightest; gradient by Prop. 17.6

Recent work: new ways to minimize a certificate Three recent directions address the optimization of PAC-Bayesian objectives. Clerico et al. (2022) avoid the surrogate loss for stochastic neural networks: with a Gaussian distribution on the weights of the last layer, the output of the network is Gaussian conditionally on the hidden layer, so that the expected 0-1 loss has a closed, differentiable form (a probit, as in PBGD), and Seeger's bound itself can be minimized. Picard-Weibel et al. (2024) address models whose empirical risk is expensive to evaluate: they replace $\widehat{R}_S$ by its projection on a low-dimensional family of functions under the current posterior, for which the Gibbs posterior of Section 15.1 has a closed form, and iterate; the minimizer of the Catoni-type objective is a fixed point of the resulting algorithm. Viallard et al. (2023) replace the KL divergence by the Wasserstein distance between the posterior and priors learned on parts of the data; for Lipschitz losses the resulting bound, of the form $\mathbb{E}_Q[R_{\mathcal{D}} - \widehat{R}_S] \lesssim \sum_i \frac{2|S_i|L}{m} W(Q, P_i) + \sqrt{\ln(K/\delta)/m}$, remains finite for deterministic (Dirac) posteriors and can be minimized by gradient descent.

17.7 Pitfalls and good practice

Self-bounding learning is simple, but its guarantees are only as good as the care with which the rules of Section 17.3 are applied. Three mistakes are particularly common.

Pitfall: a prior that has seen the data Building the voters on the whole sample and then using a uniform prior over them, with empirical risks computed on the same sample, is *not* valid: the voters, hence the prior, depend on the examples of the bound. Use a split, or the out-of-bag construction of Section 18.2.

Pitfall: hidden selections Trying several bounds, several priors or several random seeds and reporting the best certificate is a selection with the data, which must be accounted for with Proposition 17.3.

Pitfall: certifying the wrong predictor A bound on the Gibbs risk is not a bound on the risk of the vote (use Section 16), nor on the risk of a single network drawn from the posterior (use disintegrated bounds). State precisely what is certified.

Turning these warnings around, we obtain a short checklist. In practice, a sound self-bounding experiment starts by deciding what is certified: a Gibbs classifier, a majority vote or a deterministic model. The prior is then fixed before looking at the examples used in the bound, and every choice made with the data is accounted for, at the price of $\ln K$ for K candidates. A convenient relaxation can be optimized, but the reported certificate should be the tight kl form. For majority votes of diverse voters, second-order bounds should be preferred. Finally, a certificate should always be reported with its ingredients (empirical term, KL, m, δ) and next to the test error, since a bound is a guarantee and not an estimate.

To remember from Section 17

A PAC-Bayesian bound holds for all posteriors: minimizing it is legitimate and yields a predictor together with its risk certificate (Theorem 17.2). The posterior, and anything that only indexes posteriors, may depend freely on the data; the prior, δ and the parameters of the bound may not, and a choice among K candidates costs $\ln K$. Hold-out certificates are tighter for majority votes, but self-bounding learning uses all the data, makes the certificate a learning objective and makes model selection almost free; data-dependent priors interpolate between the two. The generic recipe is always the same: organize the data, fix the prior, optimize a relaxed bound (closed form, alternating minimization, or gradient through the kl inversion), and certify with the kl form.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q17.9. Why may a self-bounding algorithm stop its optimizer at any iteration?

Q17.10. What is the sign of $\partial p/\partial \varepsilon$ for $p = \overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(q, \varepsilon)$, and what does it mean in practice?

Q17.11. Why should the reported certificate be the kl form, even if a relaxation was minimized?

Q17.12. Why do we optimize the weights of an ensemble through $\rho = \mathrm{softmax}(\theta)$?

Q17.13. What is wrong with building the trees on the whole sample and using a uniform prior over them, with empirical risks computed on the same sample?

Q17.14. True or false? A self-bounding certificate is a good estimate of the test error.

Exercises

Exercise 17.1. **(Python)** Reproduce the experiment of Figure 124: draw 1000 random classifiers (each of them has true risk $\frac{1}{2}$, so that its empirical risk on $m = 100$ examples is a $\mathrm{Bin}(100, \frac{1}{2})/100$ variable), select the one with the smallest empirical risk, and repeat 1000 times. How often is the "fixed-h" Hoeffding bound ($\delta = 0.05$) violated for the selected classifier? And the Occam bound? What happens to the Occam bound with 10^6 classifiers?

Exercise 17.2. **(Comprehension)** Show that the value of λ minimizing the Hoeffding-type bound (14.5) depends on $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$, and explain why using it directly is forbidden, whereas using $\lambda^\star$ in the PAC-Bayes-λ bound is allowed.

Exercise 17.3. **(Computation)** Using Proposition 17.6, compute $\partial p/\partial q$ at $\hat{q} = 0.1$, $\varepsilon = 0.05$ (with $p \approx 0.220$, see Figure 118). Which ingredient of the certificate is it more profitable to decrease: the empirical risk by 0.01, or the KL by 5 nats with $m = 1000$?

Exercise 17.4. **(Proof)** ($\star$) Derive the "quadratic" relaxation of the table of Section 17.6 from the refined Pinsker inequality. Writing $a = \sqrt{\varepsilon/2}$, show that it is smaller than McAllester's bound iff $2a + 2\sqrt{\hat{q} + a^2} \leq 1$; in particular, for small ε it is the case as soon as $\hat{q} < \frac{1}{4}$.

Exercise 17.5. **(Comprehension)** For each of the following practices, say whether it is free, requires a union bound, or is forbidden, with a one-sentence justification. (a) Stopping the gradient descent on the certificate when the certificate stops decreasing. (b) Choosing the scale σ_0 of a Gaussian prior among 5 values after computing the five certificates. (c) Computing the certificate with $\delta = 0.01$, reporting it with a 99% claim if it is below a target value, and otherwise reporting the certificate computed with $\delta = 0.05$ with a 95% claim. (d) Choosing the temperature of a Gibbs posterior by cross-validation on the sample used in the bound.

Exercise 17.6. **(Comprehension)** True or false? Justify briefly. (a) A self-bounding certificate is an unbiased estimate of the true risk of the learned predictor. (b) If the optimizer of a self-bounding algorithm is stuck in a poor local minimum, the reported certificate may be wrong. (c) A test-set bound remains valid if the test set is also used to choose among several predictors.

Exercise 17.7. **(Application)** In the model-selection example, the tandem certificates are computed with $\delta/6$. For a forest with an OOB empirical joint error $\widehat{e}_S(Q) = 0.05$, $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 2$ and $n_0 = 423$, compute the tandem certificate (16.3) with $\delta = 0.05$, with $\delta/6$, and with $\delta/100$. With a countable family and $\pi_k = \frac{6}{\pi^2 k^2}$, what is the extra cost, in nats, for the candidates $k = 1$ and $k = 10$?

Exercise 17.8. **(Application)** With $m = 1000$ examples, the hold-out approach trains a forest on 700 examples and its vote errs on 30 of the 300 remaining ones. The self-bounding approach trains a forest on the 1000 examples and obtains an OOB empirical joint error of 0.06 with $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 1.5$ and $n_0 = 370$. With $\delta = 0.05$, compute the test-set bound (Proposition 17.4) and the tandem certificate. Below which value of the empirical joint error would the tandem certificate beat the hold-out one? What is the tandem certificate when $\widehat{e}_S(Q) = 0$?

Exercise 17.9. **(Proof)** Prove Proposition 17.3 in detail: write the failure event of each bound, apply the union bound, and explain why the certificate $\min_k \mathcal{B}_k(Q_S, S, \pi_k\delta)$ is valid for any learning rule and any data-dependent choice of k. Check that $\pi_k = \frac{6}{\pi^2 k^2}$, $k \geq 1$, is a valid choice of weights.

Exercise 17.10. **(Proof)** Let $\rho = \mathrm{softmax}(\theta)$ with $\theta \in \mathbb{R}^n$. Show that $\frac{\partial \rho_s}{\partial \theta_t} = \rho_s(\mathbb{1}[s = t] - \rho_t)$, deduce the formula (17.2) for $\nabla_\theta \mathcal{B}$, and show that the components of $\nabla_\theta \mathcal{B}$ sum to zero. Interpret this last fact.

Exercise 17.11. **(Python)** Implement the upper kl inversion $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(q, \varepsilon)$ by bisection, and check the formulas of Proposition 17.6 by finite differences at $q = 0.1$, $\varepsilon = 0.05$.

Exercise 17.12. **(Computation)** Compute the four objectives of the table of Section 17.6

(McAllester, PAC-Bayes-λ at $\lambda^\star$, quadratic, Seeger) for $(\hat{q}, \varepsilon) = (0.1, 0.05)$ and for $(\hat{q}, \varepsilon) = (0.02, 0.01)$. Comment.

Exercise 17.13. **(Proof)** Let $\hat{q} \geq 0$, $\varepsilon > 0$, $a = \sqrt{\varepsilon/2}$, $A = \sqrt{\hat{q} + a^2}$ and $B = (A + a)^2$. Show that for all $\lambda \in (0, 2)$, $\frac{\hat{q}}{1-\lambda/2} + \frac{\varepsilon}{\lambda(1-\lambda/2)} \geq B$, with equality for $\lambda = \frac{2a}{A+a}$. In other words, the PAC-Bayes-λ bound optimized in λ is exactly the quadratic bound. (Hint: set $t = \lambda/2$ and study a polynomial of degree two in t.)

Exercise 17.14. **(Application)** We have $m = 2000$ examples and $\delta = 0.05$, and we want to certify a stochastic classifier. (a) With a data-independent Gaussian prior, the learned posterior has an empirical Gibbs risk 0.08 on the 2000 examples and $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 40$. Compute Seeger's certificate. (b) With a prior centred on a model trained on S_1 (1000 examples), the posterior has an empirical Gibbs risk 0.08 on S_2 (1000 examples) and $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P_{S_1}) = 3$. Compute the certificate given by Proposition 17.5. (c) A deterministic predictor trained on 1000 examples errs on 8% of 1000 held-out examples. Compute its test-set bound. (d) Comment.

18 Self-bounding algorithms for ensembles and beyond

About this section

Guiding question. *How do we learn the weights of a forest, of a vote of boosted voters, of a linear classifier or of a neural network by minimizing a certificate?*

This section applies the recipe of Section 17 to the ensemble methods of the course, and then to linear classifiers, kernels and neural networks. For each algorithm we specify the five ingredients of Algorithm 13: the voters and the organization of the data, the prior, the objective, the optimizer and the certificate. The central tool for bagging is the out-of-bag construction, which lets every example serve both to build some voters and to certify the others. We run the algorithms on real data and look at what they learn, including when they fail.

18.1 Warm-up: a finite ensemble with an independent sample

Before tackling bagging, where voters and bound share the same data, we start with the simplest situation, the one of the decision stumps of Fig. 131. A set of n voters is built on a sample S_1, for instance trees learned on bootstrap samples of S_1, or stumps whose thresholds are chosen on S_1. A second sample S_2 of size m is used to compute the empirical risks $\widehat{R}_{S_2}(h_t)$, and the prior is uniform over the n voters, which is legitimate since it only depends on S_1.

The remaining ingredients follow the toolbox of Section 17.6. The objective can be the PAC-Bayes-λ bound, minimized by the Gibbs posterior $\rho_t \propto e^{-\lambda m \widehat{R}_{S_2}(h_t)}$; the temperature λ can be scanned on a grid, since it only indexes posteriors, or optimized by alternating with the closed-form $\lambda^\star$ (Algorithm 14 below). The certificate is Seeger's bound on S_2 for the Gibbs classifier, or one of the bounds of Section 16 for the vote, the tandem losses being computed on S_2.

On `breast cancer`, with $n = 300$ stumps and $m = 120$ examples in S_2, we obtained in Section 15 a Seeger certificate of 0.256 for a test Gibbs risk of 0.114. The certificate would be exactly the same if λ had been chosen by cross-validation, or by any other method: every choice of λ is certified. The drawback of this construction is that the examples of S_1 only serve to build the voters, and those of S_2 only to weight and certify them. Can every example play both roles? The bagging construction below shows that it can.

18.2 Bagging and random forests: out-of-bag PAC-Bayes

18.2.1 The split construction

The prior must not depend on the data used to evaluate the bound. With bagging this looks problematic, since every tree is learned from S. Yet each tree h_t is learned on a bootstrap sample S_t only, and the *out-of-bag* (OOB) examples $T_t = S \setminus S_t$ were not used to build it: from the point of view of h_t, T_t is a fresh test sample (Fig. 151). The idea of Thiemann et al. (2017) is to use the *indices* of the trees as hypotheses, with a prior on the indices fixed in advance, and to evaluate each tree on its own OOB sample.

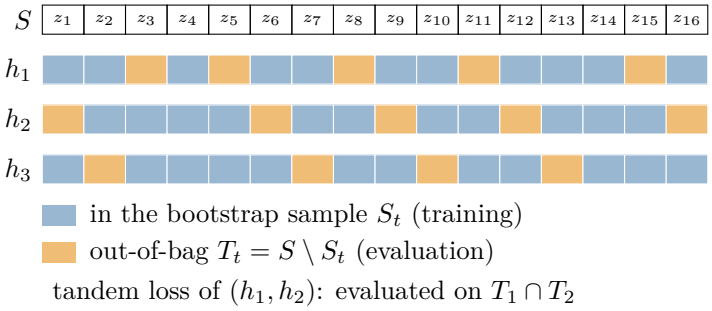


Figure 151: Out-of-bag construction. Each tree is trained on its bootstrap sample (blue) and its loss is estimated on its OOB sample (orange), which is independent of the tree. The joint error of two trees is estimated on the examples that are out-of-bag for both.

Theorem 18.1: PAC-Bayes with a split construction (Thiemann et al., 2017; Lorenzen et al., 2019)

Let $h_1, \dots, h_n$ be voters, h_t being learned on $S_t \subset S$ by any procedure, and let $T_t = S \setminus S_t$ with $|T_t| \geq n_0$ for all t. Let $\widehat{L}_t = \frac{1}{|T_t|} \sum_{(x,y)\in T_t} \mathbb{1}[h_t(x) \neq y]$ be the OOB loss of h_t and π a distribution on $\{1, \dots, n\}$ fixed in advance (e.g. uniform). Then, with probability at least $1 - \delta$ over $S \sim \mathcal{D}^m$ (and the randomness of the bootstrap), for all $\rho \in \mathcal{M}(\{1, \dots, n\})$,

$$\operatorname{kl}\Big(\sum_t \rho_t \widehat{L}_t \,\Big\|\, \sum_t \rho_t R_{\mathcal{D}}(h_t)\Big) \leq \frac{\operatorname{KL}(\rho\|\pi) + \ln \frac{2\sqrt{n_0}}{\delta}}{n_0}. \tag{18.1}$$

The same holds for the tandem losses $\widehat{L}_{tt'}$ computed on $T_t \cap T_{t'}$, with $\operatorname{KL}(\rho^2\|\pi^2) = 2\operatorname{KL}(\rho\|\pi)$ and $n_0 \leq \min_{t,t'} |T_t \cap T_{t'}|$.

Proof sketch. We follow the proof of Theorem 14.1, the "hypotheses" being the indices t, on which π is a legitimate data-independent prior. Only the third step changes: for each t, conditionally on S_t the voter h_t is fixed and T_t is an i.i.d. sample independent of it, so Maurer's lemma gives $\mathbb{E}\, e^{|T_t|\operatorname{kl}(\widehat{L}_t\|R_{\mathcal{D}}(h_t))} \leq 2\sqrt{|T_t|}$. Since $|T_t| \geq n_0$, Jensen's inequality yields $\mathbb{E}\, e^{n_0 \operatorname{kl}(\widehat{L}_t\|R_{\mathcal{D}}(h_t))} \leq (2\sqrt{|T_t|})^{n_0/|T_t|} \leq 2\sqrt{n_0}$. □

In plain words, each tree is graded only on examples it has never seen, and the bound behaves as if we had an independent sample of size n_0; the posterior over trees is then free, exactly as in Section 17. The price is that the certificate is computed with the size n_0 of the *smallest* OOB set, so it is important to make these sets large. With the standard bootstrap, each OOB set contains about $(1 - 1/m)^m \approx e^{-1} \approx 37\%$ of the sample, and the intersection of two OOB sets about $e^{-2} \approx 14\%$. Drawing bootstrap samples of size $m/2$ instead of m raises these proportions to about $e^{-1/2} \approx 61\%$ and $e^{-1} \approx 37\%$, at the price of slightly weaker trees; this is the choice made in the figures and notebooks of this course.

On the `digits` experiments below, the sizes are $m = 1257$, $n_1 = 747$, $n_2 = 423$: the first-order bound is computed with n_1 examples and the tandem bound with n_2 examples, instead of the m training examples.

18.2.2 Minimizing the first-order bound

With the OOB losses in hand, the most natural first attempt is to minimize the first-order bound. With the PAC-Bayes-λ form (14.6) of the bound, the optimal posterior for a fixed λ is the Gibbs posterior on the OOB losses (Proposition 15.1), and the optimal λ for a fixed posterior is given by (14.7). This suggests an alternating minimization, in which each step solves one half of the problem exactly.

Algorithm 14: PAC-Bayes-λ minimization for a forest (Thiemann et al., 2017)

Input: OOB losses $\widehat{L}_1, \dots, \widehat{L}_n$, prior π, n_0, δ

$\lambda \leftarrow 1$;

repeat

  $\rho_t \leftarrow \dfrac{\pi_t \, e^{-\lambda n_0 \widehat{L}_t}}{\sum_s \pi_s \, e^{-\lambda n_0 \widehat{L}_s}}$ for $t = 1, \dots, n$;

  $\lambda \leftarrow \dfrac{2}{\sqrt{2n_0 \, \rho^\top \widehat{L} / \big(\mathrm{KL}(\rho \| \pi) + \ln \frac{2\sqrt{n_0}}{\delta} \big) + 1} + 1}$;

until *convergence of* λ;

Output: ρ and the certificate $2\,\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}\big(\rho^\top \widehat{L}, \frac{\mathrm{KL}(\rho\|\pi) + \ln(2\sqrt{n_0}/\delta)}{n_0}\big)$ on $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_\rho)$

Thiemann et al. (2017) proved that, under mild conditions, the PAC-Bayes-λ bound is strongly quasiconvex and that this procedure converges to its global minimum. Table 10 follows it on a forest of 100 trees on `digits`. Starting from $\lambda = 1$, the first Gibbs posterior already has an empirical Gibbs risk of 0.128 and a KL of 4.2 nats; λ then drops to 0.37 and is stable after three iterations, and the bound on the Gibbs risk goes from 0.207 to 0.206. The algorithm is fast and does exactly what it promises: it produces an excellent bound on the *Gibbs* risk.

The last column of the table tells a different story: the test risk of the vote is 0.150, whereas the uniform forest had a test risk of 0.044. As observed by Lorenzen et al. (2019) and Masegosa et al. (2020), the vote learned by minimizing a first-order bound is often much *worse* than the uniform vote. The Gibbs posterior concentrates on the few trees with the smallest OOB loss; the left panel of Fig. 152 shows that it gives essentially all its weight to two trees. These trees are good individually, but a vote of two trees is not a forest, and the benefit of voting disappears. This is a direct consequence of the first-order nature of the bound, which only sees the average quality of the voters and ignores the correlations of their errors. To protect the vote, the objective must see these correlations.

18.2.3 Minimizing the tandem bound

The tandem bound sees exactly what the first-order bound misses, since its empirical term counts the errors made jointly by pairs of voters. Combined with the PAC-Bayes-λ relaxation, the tandem bound (16.3) gives the objective

$$\mathcal{B}_{\mathrm{TND}}(\rho, \lambda) = 4 \left[\frac{\rho^\top \widehat{\mathbf{L}} \rho}{1 - \frac{\lambda}{2}} + \frac{2\,\mathrm{KL}(\rho\|\pi) + \ln \frac{2\sqrt{n_0}}{\delta}}{\lambda(1 - \frac{\lambda}{2}) n_0} \right], \qquad \widehat{\mathbf{L}} = (\widehat{L}_{tt'})_{t,t'}, \tag{18.2}$$

Table 10: Iterations of Algorithm 14 on a forest of 100 trees on `digits` ($\delta = 0.05$). On row k, ρ is the Gibbs posterior for the value of λ shown, and the PB-λ bound is evaluated at the updated value of λ (the one of row $k+1$). The last column is the test risk of the majority vote B_ρ; the uniform forest has a test risk of 0.044. Later iterations are identical.

iter.	λ	$\rho^\top \widehat{L}$	$\mathrm{KL}(\rho\|\pi)$	PB-λ bound on $R(G_\rho)$	FO cert.	test $R(B_\rho)$
1	1.0000	0.1283	4.18	0.2070	0.3866	0.150
2	0.3802	0.1293	3.76	0.2064	0.3863	0.150
3	0.3735	0.1294	3.74	0.2064	0.3863	0.150
4	0.3732	0.1294	3.74	0.2064	0.3863	0.150
5	0.3732	0.1294	3.74	0.2064	0.3863	0.150

which is quadratic in ρ, plus the convex KL term. It has no closed-form minimizer, but it is easily minimized by gradient descent on the softmax parametrization $\rho = \mathrm{softmax}(\theta)$, alternated with the closed-form update of λ (Masegosa et al., 2020). The gradient with respect to ρ is

$$\nabla_\rho \mathcal{B}_{\mathrm{TND}} = 4\left[\frac{2\widehat{\mathbf{L}}\rho}{1-\frac{\lambda}{2}} + \frac{2\big(\ln\frac{\rho}{\pi} + \mathbf{1}\big)}{\lambda(1-\frac{\lambda}{2})n_0}\right], \tag{18.3}$$

to be combined with (17.2).

Algorithm 15: Tandem bound minimization for a forest (Masegosa et al., 2020)

Input: OOB tandem losses $\widehat{\mathbf{L}}$ (on OOB intersections), prior π, $n_0 = \min_{t,t'} |T_t \cap T_{t'}|$, δ

$\theta \leftarrow \ln \pi$, $\lambda \leftarrow 1$;

repeat

  $\theta \leftarrow$ minimize $\mathcal{B}_{\mathrm{TND}}(\mathrm{softmax}(\theta), \lambda)$ with L-BFGS, using (18.3) and (17.2);

  $\rho \leftarrow \mathrm{softmax}(\theta)$;

  $\lambda \leftarrow \dfrac{2}{\sqrt{2n_0\,\rho^\top\widehat{\mathbf{L}}\rho/\big(2\,\mathrm{KL}(\rho\|\pi) + \ln\frac{2\sqrt{n_0}}{\delta}\big) + 1} + 1}$;

until *convergence of* λ *(or a maximal number of rounds)*;

Output: ρ and the certificate $4\,\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}\big(\rho^\top\widehat{\mathbf{L}}\rho, \frac{2\,\mathrm{KL}(\rho\|\pi)+\ln(2\sqrt{n_0}/\delta)}{n_0}\big)$ on $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_\rho)$

In words, the quadratic term $\rho^\top\widehat{\mathbf{L}}\rho$ penalizes pairs of voters that err *together*, so the optimal posterior has no reason to concentrate on a few similar trees: diversity is rewarded instead of ignored. Alternatively, the kl-form certificate itself can be minimized with the gradient (17.3) of Section 17.6; the dynamics of this approach were shown in Fig. 150.

18.2.4 Comparing the learned posteriors

We can now put the two algorithms side by side, together with the uniform weights and a C-bound minimizer. Table 11 and Fig. 152 compare, on the same forest, four posteriors: the uniform one, the minimizers of the first-order and of the tandem bounds, and the minimizer of the PAC-Bayesian C-bound (16.5), obtained by a direct numerical minimization. The first-order posterior has the smallest Gibbs risk and the smallest

Table 11: Four posteriors on the same forest of 100 trees on `digits`: test risks of the vote and of the Gibbs classifier, the three OOB certificates on the risk of the vote ($\delta = 0.05$), and the effective number of trees $1/\sum_t \rho_t^2$.

posterior	$R(B_\rho)$	$R(G_\rho)$	FO cert.	TND cert.	C-bound cert.	eff. trees
uniform	0.044	0.190	0.460	0.387	0.559	100.0
FO-optimized	0.150	0.158	0.386	0.666	0.596	2.0
TND-optimized	0.043	0.183	0.436	0.361	0.538	58.1
C-bound-optimized	0.048	0.176	0.419	0.369	0.531	30.8

first-order certificate, but it keeps two effective trees and its vote is three times worse than the others.

The tandem posterior keeps an effective number of 58 trees, spread over the good and the average trees (right panel of Fig. 152): its vote is as good as the uniform one (0.043), and it has the smallest certificate of all, 0.361. The C-bound posterior is in between, with 31 effective trees and a vote of comparable quality, but its certificate (0.531) is looser than the tandem certificate, because it needs two kl inversions and a ratio. This illustrates the remark following Proposition 16.7: the C-bound is the best *oracle* bound, but not necessarily the best *certificate*.

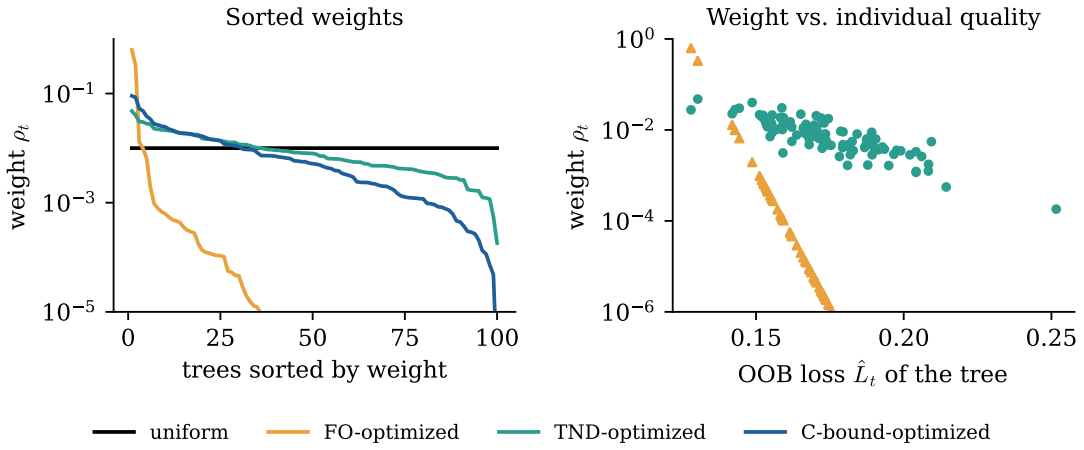


Figure 152: Weights learned on a forest of 100 trees on `digits`. Left: sorted weights of the four posteriors (log scale). Right: weight of each tree as a function of its OOB loss for the first-order and tandem posteriors: the first-order posterior is a hard selection of the two best trees, the tandem posterior a soft one.

Is this behaviour specific to `digits`? Figure 153 repeats the comparison between the uniform, first-order and tandem posteriors on four datasets. The picture is consistent: minimizing the first-order bound always improves the first-order certificate, but it degrades the vote on all four datasets, sometimes severely (from 0.044 to 0.150 on `digits`, from 0.074 to 0.184 on the simulated data). Minimizing the tandem bound never degrades the vote and always yields the best tandem certificate. The certificates remain far from the test risks — this is the price of certifying a vote with a second-order Markov inequality and a doubled KL — but they are valid and obtained without any test data.

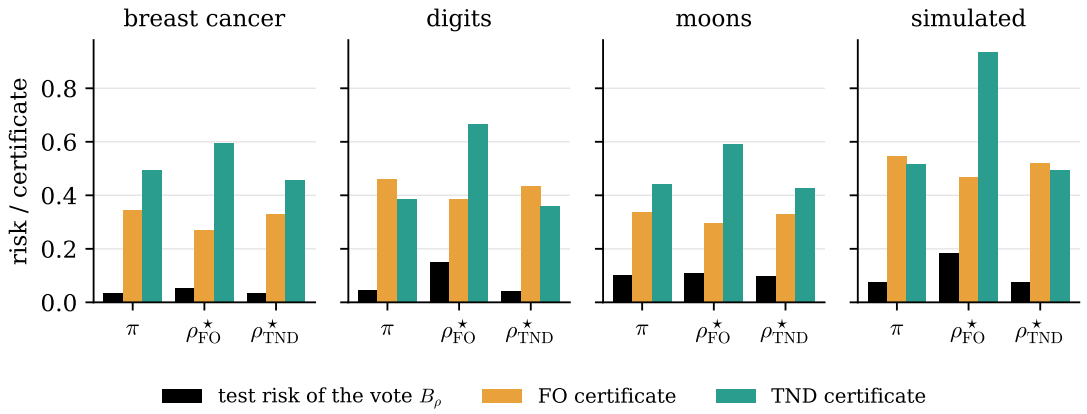


Figure 153: Forests of 100 trees (bootstrap samples of size $m/2$), on four datasets. For the uniform posterior, the posterior minimizing the first-order (FO) bound, and the posterior minimizing the tandem (TND) bound, we report the test risk of the majority vote and the two OOB certificates ($\delta = 0.05$). Generated with `pbtools.py` (notebook 4).

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q18.1. Why can each tree of a bagged forest be evaluated on its out-of-bag examples without breaking the bound?

Q18.2. Why does minimizing the first-order bound degrade the vote?

Q18.3. With bootstrap samples of size m, which fraction of the sample is out-of-bag for one tree, and for two trees? And with bootstrap samples of size $m/2$?

Q18.4. Why is the OOB certificate computed with the size n_0 of the *smallest* OOB set?

Q18.5. Why does the tandem objective not concentrate the posterior on a few trees?

18.3 Boosting-like algorithms: learning the weights of a vote

Bagging builds its voters independently and only asks us to weight them. Boosting builds them sequentially and learns their weights at the same time; we now see how the PAC-Bayesian viewpoint, and in particular the C-bound, shapes algorithms of this kind.

18.3.1 AdaBoost from the PAC-Bayesian viewpoint

AdaBoost greedily minimizes the exponential loss $\frac{1}{m}\sum_i e^{-y_i f(x_i)}$ of $f = \sum_t \alpha_t h_t$, an upper bound on the training error of the vote (Freund and Schapire, 1997). In PAC-Bayesian terms, it learns a posterior $Q \propto (\alpha_t)_t$ whose margins M_Q on S are large, the normalized margins being $y_i f(x_i)/\|\alpha\|_1$; this is the explanation of Schapire et al. (1998), illustrated in Fig. 112. But nothing in AdaBoost controls the divergence $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ or the disagreement of the voters. The algorithms of this subsection instead learn the weights of a set of voters, possibly produced by boosting, by minimizing a C-bound.

18.3.2 MinCq: minimizing the C-bound

The C-bound rewards votes whose margin is large on average and varies little. Recall that $\mathcal{C}_Q = 1 - \frac{(\mathbb{E}M_Q)^2}{\mathbb{E}M_Q^2}$. For a fixed value μ of the first moment of the margin, minimizing the C-bound amounts to minimizing its second moment. Roy et al. (2011) and Germain et al. (2015) proposed the algorithm

$$\textbf{MinCq:} \qquad \min_{Q} \ \widehat{\mathbb{E}}_S[M_Q^2] \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \widehat{\mathbb{E}}_S[M_Q] = \mu, \quad Q \text{ quasi-uniform}, \tag{18.4}$$

where $\mathcal{H}$ is *self-complemented* ($h \in \mathcal{H} \Rightarrow -h \in \mathcal{H}$) and a *quasi-uniform* posterior satisfies $Q(h) + Q(-h) = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{H}|/2}$. Since M_Q is linear in Q, $\widehat{\mathbb{E}}_S[M_Q^2]$ is a quadratic form in the weights and (18.4) is a quadratic program.

The restriction to quasi-uniform posteriors is the key trick. On the one hand, it does not reduce the set of votes that can be expressed, since any vote can be represented by a quasi-uniform posterior with the same predictions. On the other hand, PAC-Bayesian bounds hold for quasi-uniform posteriors *without the KL term* (Germain et al., 2015), so that the empirical C-bound itself is controlled.

The hyperparameter μ, the targeted first moment of the margin, plays the role of a regularization parameter and is selected by cross-validation. MinCq has been extended to incorporate prior knowledge on the weights (P-MinCq, Bellet et al., 2014) and to a column-generation algorithm that adds voters one at a time (CqBoost, Roy et al., 2016).

18.3.3 CB-Boost: greedy C-bound minimization

MinCq weights a fixed set of voters. To grow the vote one voter at a time, as AdaBoost does, Bauvin et al. (2020) proposed CB-Boost, a boosting-like algorithm that builds the vote greedily by minimizing the empirical C-bound. At each round, it adds a voter and chooses its weight so as to decrease the empirical C-bound; since this quantity is a ratio of two quadratic functions of the weights, the optimal weight of the new voter has a closed form, which makes each round as cheap as a round of AdaBoost. The empirical C-bound decreases at each iteration, and the final vote can be certified with a PAC-Bayesian C-bound.

18.3.4 Direct minimization of PAC-Bayesian C-bounds

MinCq and CB-Boost minimize the *empirical* C-bound and certify afterwards. A fully self-bounding alternative is to minimize the certificate itself: Viallard et al. (2021) proposed to minimize by (stochastic) gradient descent the *PAC-Bayesian* C-bounds themselves, that is the right-hand side of (16.5) and tighter joint versions, over the posterior $\rho = \mathrm{softmax}(\theta)$. The C-bound (16.5) is a composition of $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}$ (for the Gibbs risk), $\underline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}$ (for the disagreement) and a smooth function, so its gradient follows from Proposition 17.6 and the chain rule: with $\bar{r} = \overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(\rho^\top \widehat{L}, \varepsilon_1)$, $\underline{d} = \underline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(\rho^\top \widehat{D}\rho, \varepsilon_2)$ and $\mathcal{C} = 1 - \frac{(1-2\bar{r})^2}{1-2\underline{d}}$,

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{C}}{\partial \bar{r}} = \frac{4(1-2\bar{r})}{1-2\underline{d}}, \qquad \frac{\partial \mathcal{C}}{\partial \underline{d}} = -\frac{2(1-2\bar{r})^2}{(1-2\underline{d})^2}.$$

The learned vote comes with its certificate by construction.

Zantedeschi et al. (2021) go one step further and consider *stochastic majority votes*, whose weights are themselves drawn from a Dirichlet posterior. For such votes the expected risk can be computed, or tightly approximated, and bounded directly, which avoids the loose Gibbs-to-vote relations of Section 16.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q18.6. What does the parameter μ of MinCq control?

Q18.7. Why does MinCq restrict itself to quasi-uniform posteriors?

Q18.8. What is the main difference between MinCq and CB-Boost?

18.4 Linear classifiers and kernel methods

The recipe is not limited to finite ensembles. Linear classifiers are the natural next step: they are the one case where every term of the bound can be written explicitly.

18.4.1 Gaussian posteriors on linear classifiers

Consider linear voters $h_{\mathbf{v}}(x) = \operatorname{sign}(\langle \mathbf{v}, x\rangle)$, $\mathbf{v} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, a prior $P = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, I_d)$ and posteriors $Q_{\mathbf{w}} = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}, I_d)$. By symmetry of the Gaussian around $\mathbf{w}$, the majority vote is

$$B_{Q_{\mathbf{w}}}(x) = \operatorname{sign}\left(\mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{v}} \operatorname{sign}\langle \mathbf{v}, x\rangle\right) = \operatorname{sign}\langle \mathbf{w}, x\rangle :$$

the vote of an infinite number of linear classifiers is the linear classifier $\mathbf{w}$ itself. For $\mathbf{v} \sim Q_{\mathbf{w}}$, the random variable $y\langle \mathbf{v}, x\rangle$ is Gaussian with mean $y\langle \mathbf{w}, x\rangle$ and variance $\|x\|^2$, so the empirical Gibbs risk is

$$\widehat{R}_S(G_{Q_{\mathbf{w}}}) = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m} \Phi\Big(-\frac{y_i\langle \mathbf{w}, x_i\rangle}{\|x_i\|}\Big), \tag{18.5}$$

where Φ is the standard Gaussian cumulative distribution function: the 0-1 loss is replaced by a smooth *probit* loss of the normalized margin. The right panel of Fig. 154 explains where it comes from: a classifier $\mathbf{v}$ drawn around $\mathbf{w}$ errs on x when it falls on the wrong side of the hyperplane orthogonal to x, which happens with probability $\Phi(-y\langle \mathbf{w}, x\rangle/\|x\|)$. The left panel compares this loss with the 0-1 loss and with the hinge loss of the SVM: it is a smoothed 0-1 loss, which stays bounded for badly misclassified points.

Finally, the complexity is $\mathrm{KL}(Q_{\mathbf{w}}\|P) = \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{w}\|^2$. Figure 155 shows the resulting trade-off. Multiplying $\mathbf{w}$ by a constant does not change the vote, but it makes the sampled classifiers agree more with it: the Gibbs risk decreases towards the risk of the vote, while the KL grows quadratically.

Plugging these quantities into Catoni's bound (14.4) and removing the monotone transformation gives the objective of the algorithm PBGD (Germain et al., 2009):

$$\min_{\mathbf{w}\in\mathbb{R}^d} F(\mathbf{w}) = C\sum_{i=1}^{m} \Phi\Big(-\frac{y_i\langle \mathbf{w}, x_i\rangle}{\|x_i\|}\Big) + \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{w}\|^2. \tag{18.6}$$

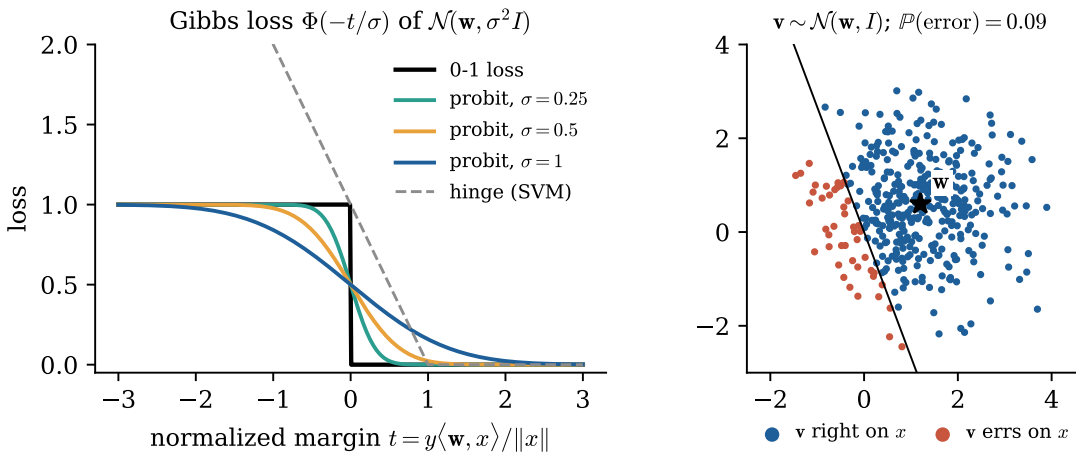


Figure 154: The probit loss. Left: loss of the Gibbs classifier of $\mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}, \sigma^2 I)$ as a function of the normalized margin $t = y\langle \mathbf{w}, x\rangle / \|x\|$, for three values of σ (this part uses $\sigma = 1$), compared with the 0-1 and hinge losses. Right: 400 classifiers $\mathbf{v} \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}, I)$ in the plane; those on the wrong side of the line $\langle \mathbf{v}, x\rangle = 0$ (red) err on x.

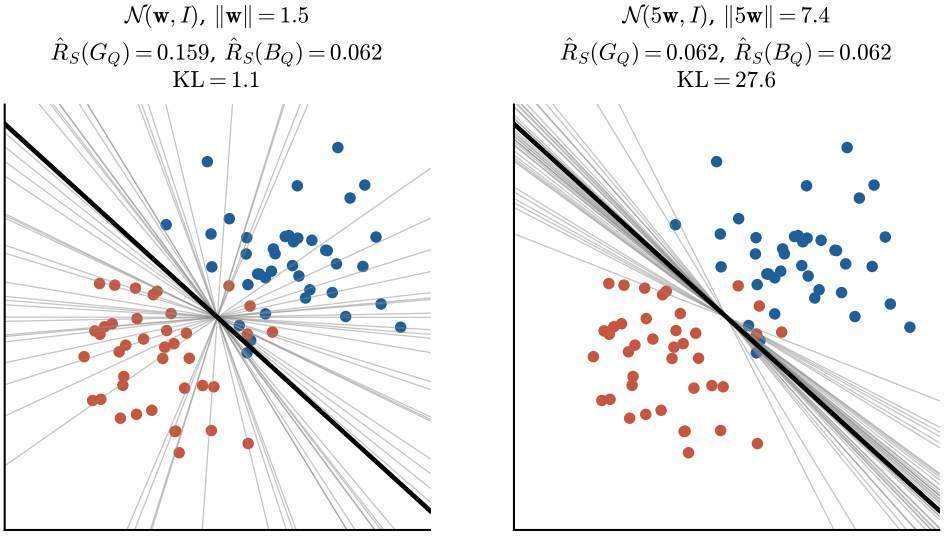


Figure 155: Gaussian posterior $\mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}, I)$ over linear classifiers: 40 sampled hyperplanes (grey) and the majority vote $\operatorname{sign}\langle \mathbf{w}, x\rangle$ (black). Multiplying $\mathbf{w}$ by 5 does not change the vote but makes the sampled voters agree with it: the Gibbs risk decreases while the KL grows quadratically.

It is instructive to compare it with the soft-margin SVM, $\min_{\mathbf{w}} C\sum_i \max(0, 1 - y_i\langle \mathbf{w}, x_i\rangle) + \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{w}\|^2$. PAC-Bayes *explains* the SVM objective: the regularization is the KL to the prior, the loss is a surrogate of the Gibbs risk, and the norm of $\mathbf{w}$ plays the role of the inverse of a margin (Langford and Shawe-Taylor, 2002; McAllester, 2003b). The two objectives differ mainly in the loss, and this difference has a practical consequence. The objective (18.6) is not convex; its gradient is

$$\nabla F(\mathbf{w}) = -C\sum_{i=1}^{m} \varphi\Big(\frac{y_i\langle \mathbf{w}, x_i\rangle}{\|x_i\|}\Big)\frac{y_i x_i}{\|x_i\|} + \mathbf{w},$$

where φ is the standard Gaussian density. Each example pushes $\mathbf{w}$ in its direction, with a weight that is maximal for points close to the decision boundary and vanishes for points with a large margin, positive or negative: unlike the hinge loss, badly misclassified points are eventually ignored, which makes PBGD robust to label noise. It is optimized by gradient descent with several restarts, and has a kernelized version (Germain et al., 2009).

Example 18.1 (PBGD selects its own regularization). As a self-bounding algorithm, PBGD has an important advantage: the parameter C only indexes posteriors, so it can be chosen by minimizing the certificate itself, without cross-validation. Figure 156 runs PBGD on a two-dimensional problem with $m = 200$ examples and 8% of flipped labels, for 25 values of C between 10^{-2} and 10^2, and computes Seeger's bound for each solution. For small C, $\mathbf{w}$ is short ($\|\mathbf{w}\| = 0.41$ for $C = 0.01$), the sampled classifiers are almost random and the certificate is 0.54. For large C, the Gibbs risk approaches the training error of the vote but the KL explodes ($\|\mathbf{w}\| = 13.6$ for $C = 100$), and the certificate climbs back to 0.58. The best certificate, 0.28, is reached for $C = 1$, with $\|\mathbf{w}\| = 3.5$, an empirical Gibbs risk of 0.133 and a training error of the vote of 0.110. The right panel shows the hyperplanes learned with a small C, with the C selected by the certificate, and with the largest C; no validation sample was used to choose among them.

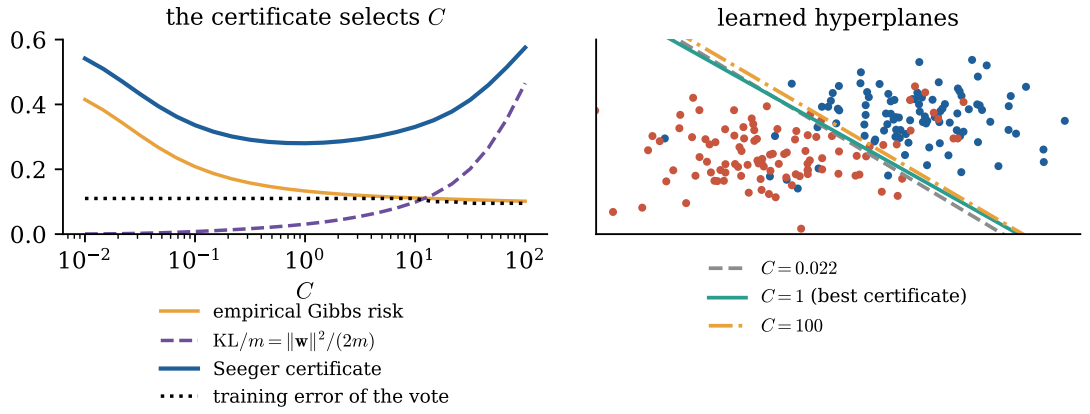


Figure 156: PBGD on a two-dimensional problem ($m = 200$, 8% label noise). Left: empirical Gibbs risk, complexity $\|\mathbf{w}\|^2/(2m)$ and Seeger certificate as functions of C. Right: hyperplanes learned for three values of C.

Data-dependent Gaussian priors, centred on an SVM learned on part of the data, give some of the tightest bounds for SVMs (Ambroladze et al., 2006; Parrado-Hernández et al., 2012). The prior need not be Gaussian, however: a kernel can itself be read as a prior over voters.

18.4.2 Kernels as priors: random Fourier features

For a shift-invariant kernel $k(x, x') = k(x - x')$, Bochner's theorem gives $k(x - x') = \mathbb{E}_{\omega \sim p} \cos\left(\omega^\top (x - x')\right)$, where p is the Fourier transform of k (Rahimi and Recht, 2007). Letarte et al. (2019b) interpret this identity as a *majority vote*: the voters are the functions $h_\omega(x, x') = \cos(\omega^\top (x - x'))$ and the kernel is their vote under the *prior* p. Learning a kernel adapted to the task then amounts to learning a *posterior* over frequencies. With N frequencies $\omega_1, \dots, \omega_N$ drawn from p, the pseudo-posterior $Q(\omega_j) \propto e^{-\beta \widehat{L}_S(h_{\omega_j})}$ is exactly a Gibbs posterior, and a PAC-Bayesian bound certifies the learned kernel. This is closely related to the boosting-with-random-Fourier-features algorithm studied in the project of the course.

Example 18.2 (Random Fourier voters on the two moons). A simpler variant uses the random features directly as voters, $h_{\omega,b}(x) = \operatorname{sign} \cos(\omega^\top x + b)$, with $\omega \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 2\gamma I)$ and $b \sim \mathcal{U}[0, 2\pi]$, together with their opposites. Figure 157 shows one such voter on the two moons dataset, and the vote of 4000 of them under Gibbs posteriors at three temperatures, learned on 900 examples. Under the uniform prior the vote is undecided, since each voter comes with its opposite. A very small tilt of the prior ($\lambda = 0.001$, KL $= 0.005$ nats) already gives a smooth decision boundary with a test risk of 0.067: the vote then behaves like a kernel classifier. Larger values of λ (lower temperatures) concentrate the posterior on fewer frequencies and give more irregular boundaries, with test risks of 0.11 ($\lambda = 0.02$) and 0.13 ($\lambda = 0.5$). Note that the best vote corresponds to a posterior whose empirical Gibbs risk is 0.49: the Gibbs certificate is vacuous, while the vote is excellent. This is an extreme instance of the gap studied in Section 16, and a reminder that votes must be certified with second-order bounds.

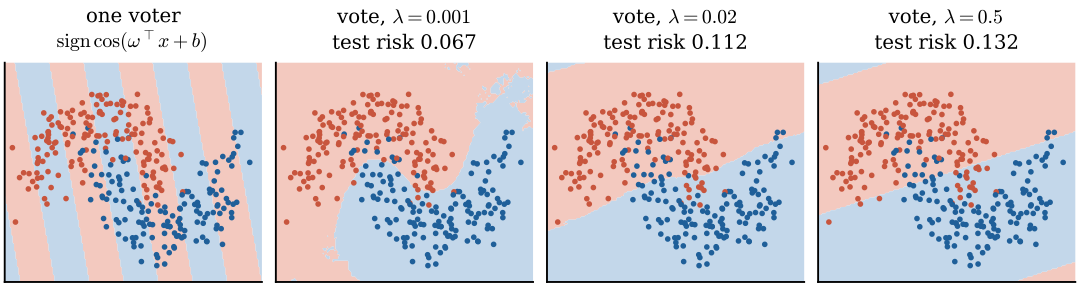


Figure 157: Random Fourier voters on the two moons. Left: one voter. Right: the majority vote under Gibbs posteriors at three temperatures (test risks in the titles).

18.5 Beyond ensembles: stochastic neural networks and Gaussian processes

The Gaussian posteriors used for linear classifiers carry over to models with many more continuous parameters, and the same recipe applies. For a neural network with weights $\mathbf{w} \in \mathbb{R}^D$, consider a Gaussian posterior $Q = \mathcal{N}(\boldsymbol{\mu}, \operatorname{diag}(\boldsymbol{\sigma}^2))$ and a Gaussian prior $P = \mathcal{N}(\boldsymbol{\mu}_0, \sigma_0^2 I)$; drawing a network from Q at each prediction defines a *stochastic neural network*. The centre $\boldsymbol{\mu}_0$ of the prior is the random initialization of the network or, much better, a network trained on a part S_1 of the data (Proposition 17.5); the scale σ_0 is chosen on a grid with a union bound. As for linear classifiers, the KL divergence

has the closed form

$$\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = \frac{1}{2}\sum_{j=1}^{D}\Big(\frac{\sigma_j^2 + (\mu_j - \mu_{0,j})^2}{\sigma_0^2} - 1 + \ln\frac{\sigma_0^2}{\sigma_j^2}\Big).$$

The objective is one of the relaxations of Seeger's bound of Section 17.6, in which the 0-1 loss is replaced by a bounded surrogate, for instance the cross-entropy clipped to $[0, \ell_{\max}]$ and rescaled to $[0,1]$, and it is minimized by stochastic gradient descent on $(\boldsymbol{\mu}, \ln \boldsymbol{\sigma})$ with the reparametrization trick (see McAllester, 2013 for the related case of dropout, and Letarte et al., 2019a for networks with binary activations). The certificate, finally, uses the 0-1 loss: the empirical Gibbs risk is estimated with N networks sampled from Q, bounded by a first kl inversion, and plugged into Seeger's bound, as in Fig. 135.

Dziugaite and Roy (2017) obtained in this way the first *non-vacuous* bounds for over-parametrized networks on MNIST, and Pérez-Ortiz et al. (2021) showed that such PAC-Bayesian training yields networks with competitive accuracy together with tight certificates. Reeb et al. (2018) applied the same principle to learn the hyperparameters of Gaussian processes by minimizing a PAC-Bayesian bound, and Lotfi et al. (2022) obtained non-vacuous bounds for large models with compression-based priors. This line of work now reaches large language models (Lotfi et al., 2024a,b), see the Recent work box of Section 13.4. For networks with binary activations, Fortier-Dubois et al. (2023) compute exactly the output of an *aggregation* of stochastic networks, that is a majority vote over their weights, by propagating probabilities over the hidden representations, and minimize a PAC-Bayesian bound on it. Finally, *deep ensembles* (Lakshminarayanan et al., 2017) are majority votes of networks, to which the second-order bounds of Section 16 and the algorithms of this section apply.

18.6 The running example, one last time

Before summarizing the algorithms, let us step back and look at the whole journey of our running example.

> **Running example** Let us gather what we have learned about our forest of 100 trees on `digits`. Its vote errs on 4.4% of the test digits, while a tree drawn at random errs on 19% of them; Section 16 explained the gap by the diversity of the trees, whose disagreement (0.27) exceeds their Gibbs risk. Setting aside the 540 test digits certified the vote at 0.069 (Section 13). Without any test set, the out-of-bag tandem bound certified the uniform vote at 0.387 (Section 16), and learning the weights by minimizing this bound lowered the certificate to 0.361 while keeping the vote as accurate (0.043). Minimizing the first-order bound instead gave the best certificate on the Gibbs risk, but destroyed the vote (0.150). Three lessons summarize the course: the diversity of the voters is what makes a vote work; a certificate for a vote must see this diversity, which requires second-order quantities; and a certificate that sees it can safely be used as a learning objective.

18.7 Summary

The following table summarizes the algorithms of this section with the five ingredients of the self-bounding recipe.

Algorithm	Posterior	Objective	Optimizer	Certifies
Gibbs posterior	finite, any	linear bound	closed form	Gibbs, vote
PB-λ (Thiemann et al., 2017)	finite (OOB)	PAC-Bayes-λ	alternating	Gibbs
TND (Masegosa et al., 2020)	finite (OOB)	tandem-λ	L-BFGS + λ	vote
MinCq (Roy et al., 2011)	quasi-uniform	empirical C-bound	QP	vote
CB-Boost (Bauvin et al., 2020)	greedy	empirical C-bound	closed-form steps	vote
Self-bounding C-bound (Viallard et al., 2021)	finite	PAC-Bayesian C-bound	gradient (kl inv.)	vote
StocMV (Zantedeschi et al., 2021)	Dirichlet	bound on stochastic vote	gradient	stochastic vote
PBGD (Germain et al., 2009)	Gaussian, linear	Catoni	gradient	Gibbs, vote
PBB (Pérez-Ortiz et al., 2021)	Gaussian, NN	Seeger relaxations	SGD, reparam.	Gibbs

To remember from Section 18

To certify an ensemble, each voter must be evaluated on examples it has not seen: an independent sample, or its out-of-bag examples (Theorem 18.1). Minimizing a first-order bound gives an excellent bound on the Gibbs risk but concentrates the weights on a few voters and destroys the diversity of the vote; second-order objectives such as the tandem bound keep it, and give the best certificates for votes. The C-bound leads to a family of algorithms (MinCq, CB-Boost, direct minimization) which explicitly trade the strength of the voters against their disagreement. The same recipe gives PAC-Bayesian versions of SVMs (PBGD, which selects its own regularization), of kernel learning and of stochastic neural networks, where data-dependent priors are the key ingredient.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q18.9. In PBGD, which quantity plays the role of the regularization of the SVM?

Q18.10. Why is the majority vote of the posterior $\mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}, I)$ over linear classifiers the linear classifier $\text{sign}\langle \mathbf{w}, x\rangle$?

Q18.11. Why is PBGD more robust to label noise than the SVM?

Q18.12. In the random Fourier example, the best vote has a test risk of 0.067 but an empirical Gibbs risk of 0.49. What does this tell us?

Q18.13. Why are data-dependent priors essential for stochastic neural networks?

Q18.14. True or false? The second-order bounds of Section 16 can be applied to a deep ensemble of independently trained networks, with a uniform prior, using their errors on the training set.

Exercises

Exercise 18.1. **(Computation)** Derive the gradient (18.3) of the tandem objective (18.2), and check it numerically with finite differences.

Exercise 18.2. **(Comprehension)** Explain why the uniform prior over the trees of a random forest would *not* be a valid prior if the empirical losses were computed on the whole training sample.

Exercise 18.3. **(Proof)** In PBGD, show that when all the training points have a large normalized margin, the gradient of the loss term vanishes, and interpret the resulting value of $\|\mathbf{w}\|$ at the optimum.

Exercise 18.4. **(Python)** With `pbtools.py` (as in the function `fig_fo_iterations_and_weights` of `make_figures.py`), compute the test Gibbs risk and the test disagreement of the C-bound posterior of Table 11 and check whether the condition $d \geq R$ of Proposition 16.7 holds. Why is its certificate nevertheless larger than the tandem certificate?

Exercise 18.5. **(Computation)** ($\star$) For a stochastic network with $D = 10^5$ weights, $\sigma_j = \sigma_0 = 0.03$ and $\|\boldsymbol{\mu} - \boldsymbol{\mu}_0\| = 3$, compute $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$. How many examples are needed for the complexity term $\mathrm{KL}\,/m$ to be below 0.01? What does this suggest about data-dependent priors?

Exercise 18.6. **(Comprehension)** True or false? Justify briefly. (a) The OOB bound is invalid because every training example has been used to build some of the trees. (b) Adding trees to a forest with the uniform posterior increases $\mathrm{KL}(\rho\|\pi)$. (c) In PBGD, the parameter C must be selected by cross-validation, since the bound cannot be used to choose it. (d) The first-order posterior of Table 11 has a small Gibbs risk, hence necessarily a good vote.

Exercise 18.7. **(Application)** For the `digits` forest ($m = 1257$), compute the expected fraction and number of examples that are out-of-bag for one tree, and for two given trees, when the bootstrap samples have size m and when they have size $\lfloor m/2 \rfloor = 628$. Compare with the values $n_1 = 747$ and $n_2 = 423$ used in this part, and explain the difference.

Exercise 18.8. **(Application)** Run Algorithm 14 by hand (with a calculator or `pbtools`) on $n = 4$ trees with OOB losses $\widehat{L} = (0.15, 0.17, 0.20, 0.25)$, uniform prior, $n_0 = 700$ and $\delta = 0.05$: compute ρ for $\lambda = 1$, the updated λ, and ρ again. Compare the final first-order certificate with the one of the uniform posterior, and comment on the weights.

Exercise 18.9. **(Application)** For a Gaussian posterior $Q_{\mathbf{w}} = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}, I_d)$ with $\|\mathbf{w}\| = 2$, three training points have normalized margins $y_i\langle \mathbf{w}, x_i\rangle / \|x_i\|$ equal to 2, 0.5 and -1. Compute the empirical Gibbs risk (18.5), the training error of the vote and $\mathrm{KL}(Q_{\mathbf{w}}\|P)$. Redo the computation for $3\mathbf{w}$, and relate the result to Figure 155.

Exercise 18.10. **(Proof)** Let $Q_{\mathbf{w}} = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{w}, I_d)$ over linear voters $h_{\mathbf{v}}(x) = \mathrm{sign}\langle \mathbf{v}, x\rangle$, and $x \neq 0$. Show that $\mathbb{P}_{\mathbf{v}\sim Q_{\mathbf{w}}}\big(y\langle \mathbf{v}, x\rangle \leq 0\big) = \Phi\big(-y\langle \mathbf{w}, x\rangle / \|x\|\big)$, and deduce that the majority vote is $B_{Q_{\mathbf{w}}}(x) = \mathrm{sign}\langle \mathbf{w}, x\rangle$ (up to the tie $\langle \mathbf{w}, x\rangle = 0$) and the formula (18.5).

Exercise 18.11. **(Python)** Simulate 100 bootstrap samples of size 628 drawn from $m = 1257$ indices. Compute the average and the minimum of the OOB sizes $|T_t|$, and the average and the minimum of the sizes $|T_t \cap T_{t'}|$ over the pairs $t \neq t'$. Compare with $n_1 = 747$ and $n_2 = 423$.

Exercise 18.12. **(Proof)** Let $\mathcal{H} = \{h_1, \ldots, h_N, -h_1, \ldots, -h_N\}$ be self-complemented ($|\mathcal{H}| = 2N$). (a) Show that under the uniform posterior, $M_Q(x, y) = 0$ for every (x, y) and the Gibbs risk is exactly $\frac{1}{2}$. (b) Let $\alpha \in \mathbb{R}_+^N \setminus \{0\}$ and $f = \sum_j \alpha_j h_j$. Build a quasi-uniform posterior Q ($Q(h) + Q(-h) = \frac{1}{N}$) whose vote is $\mathrm{sign}\, f$. (c) Relate (a) to the random Fourier example of Figure 157.

Exercise 18.13. **(Computation)** Derive the partial derivatives of $\mathcal{C} = 1 - \frac{(1-2\bar{r})^2}{1-2\underline{d}}$ given in the paragraph on the direct minimization of PAC-Bayesian C-bounds, and evaluate $\mathcal{C}$ and its

derivatives at $\bar{r} = 0.2$, $\underline{d} = 0.3$. Which is more costly: an increase of 0.01 of $\bar{r}$ or a decrease of 0.01 of $\underline{d}$?

Exercise 18.14. **(Proof)** (a) Show that $\mathrm{KL}\left(\mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2) \,\|\, \mathcal{N}(\mu_0, \sigma_0^2)\right) = \frac{1}{2}\left(\frac{\sigma^2+(\mu-\mu_0)^2}{\sigma_0^2} - 1 + \ln\frac{\sigma_0^2}{\sigma^2}\right)$. (b) Deduce the formula of $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$ for the diagonal Gaussians of stochastic neural networks, and $\mathrm{KL}(Q_{\mathbf{w}}\|P) = \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{w}\|^2$ for PBGD. (c) For $D = 2$, $\boldsymbol{\mu} = (1, 0)$, $\boldsymbol{\sigma} = (0.5, 1)$, $\boldsymbol{\mu}_0 = 0$, $\sigma_0 = 1$, compute $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$.

19 Further topics and recent advances

About this section

Guiding question. *Where does PAC-Bayes go beyond this course?*

This last section is a reading guide. It briefly presents some active research directions: unbounded losses and dependent data, other divergences, information-theoretic bounds, disintegrated bounds, domain adaptation, with pointers to the literature. It is a good starting point for the research part of the project.

Figure 158 gives a map of the directions discussed below.

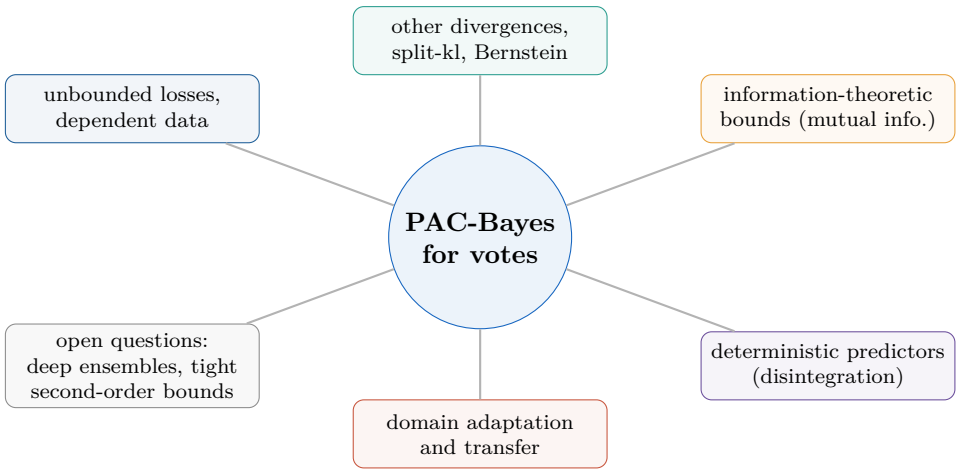


Figure 158: Some research directions around PAC-Bayesian bounds for majority votes, presented in this section.

19.1 Beyond bounded losses and i.i.d. data

All the bounds of this course assume a loss with values in $[0,1]$ and i.i.d. data. The boundedness enters the proofs at a single place: the control of the exponential moment $\mathcal{I}_\Delta(m)$ in the third step of Theorem 14.1. For unbounded losses, such as the squared loss or the log-loss, this term must be controlled through assumptions on the tails of the loss (sub-Gaussian, sub-exponential, or bounded moments). This is the route followed by Alquier et al. (2016) and Germain et al. (2016), whose analysis of Bayesian inference we met in Section 15, and by Haddouche et al. (2021) for losses whose range depends on the hypothesis; Alquier and Guedj (2018) relax both the boundedness and the independence assumptions, at the price of weaker rates. More recently, Rodríguez-Gálvez et al. (2024) and Chugg et al. (2023) gave unified treatments, the latter based on nonnegative supermartingales, which also yield *anytime-valid* bounds, holding simultaneously for all sample sizes. This property matters in online learning and sequential decision-making, where the number of observations is not fixed in advance. Martingale techniques similarly extend PAC-Bayes to dependent data and to reinforcement learning (Seldin et al., 2012; Chugg et al., 2023). Among the most recent results, Haddouche and Guedj (2023) only assume bounded second moments of the loss, and the PAC-Bayes-Chernoff bounds of Casado et al. (2024) optimize the free parameter of Catoni-type bounds exactly for unbounded losses (Section 14).

19.2 Other divergences and tighter inequalities

The KL divergence is not an intrinsic feature of PAC-Bayes: it comes from the change of measure (13.2). Other changes of measure, based for instance on Hölder's inequality, yield bounds involving other divergences, such as Rényi divergences (Bégin et al., 2016), which offer different trade-offs between the complexity term and the confidence term. Recent works go further: f-divergences (Ohnishi and Honorio, 2021), any strongly convex regularizer (Lugosi and Neu, 2022), divergences derived from coin-betting that can be much smaller than the KL (Kuzborskij et al., 2024), or the Wasserstein distance, which gives bounds for deterministic predictors (Viallard et al., 2023). Hellström and Guedj (2024) show that, on the concentration side, the kl comparator is optimal for bounded losses, and Jang et al. (2023) obtain time-uniform versions of the kl bound at no cost. On the concentration side, the kl inequality is optimal for Bernoulli variables but not for losses with a small variance, and Bernstein-type inequalities exploit this variance (Tolstikhin and Seldin, 2013; Mhammedi et al., 2019). For majority votes, the relevant excess losses take only three values, and the split-kl inequality of Wu and Seldin (2022) exploits this structure. On the prior side, data-dependent priors remain one of the most effective levers (Parrado-Hernández et al., 2012; Dziugaite and Roy, 2018; Pérez-Ortiz et al., 2021), as we saw in Fig. 134.

19.3 Information-theoretic generalization bounds

PAC-Bayesian bounds control, with high probability, the average risk under a posterior that depends on the sample. A closely related family of results bounds the *expected* generalization gap of a randomized algorithm by the *mutual information* $I(S;h)$ between the sample and the output of the algorithm (Xu and Raginsky, 2017). The connection is direct: averaging a PAC-Bayesian bound over S and choosing as prior the average posterior $P = \mathbb{E}_S Q_S$, which is the best data-independent prior in expectation, turns $\mathbb{E}_S \operatorname{KL}(Q_S \| P)$ into $I(S;h)$. The monograph of Hellström et al. (2025) presents both points of view in a unified way.

19.4 Deterministic predictors: disintegration

A recurring limitation of this course is that PAC-Bayes certifies a *randomized* predictor, and we had to work to transfer the guarantee to the majority vote. Disintegrated bounds (Blanchard and Fleuret, 2007; Rivasplata et al., 2020) take another route: they hold with high probability over the joint draw of the sample and of a *single* hypothesis $h \sim Q_S$, so that the one model that is actually deployed is certified. Viallard et al. (2024b) give a general framework and practical algorithms for such bounds. Applied to majority votes whose weights are drawn once from a distribution, as in the stochastic votes of Section 18, this approach certifies the vote that is actually used. Viallard et al. (2024a) use this framework to turn any complexity measure into a generalization bound, by sampling from a Gibbs distribution built on it, and Leblanc and Germain (2025) bound the risk of a deterministic majority vote through an exact identity (Section 16.9).

19.5 Domain adaptation and transfer

When the training distribution (the source) differs from the test distribution (the target), the risk of a majority vote on the target can be related to its risk on the source and

to a *divergence between the two domains*. PAC-Bayes is particularly well suited to this problem because the disagreement $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ can be computed on *unlabeled* target data. Germain et al. (2013, 2020) define a domain divergence as the difference between the disagreements of the voters on the source and on the target, and derive PAC-Bayesian domain adaptation bounds together with algorithms that minimize them. Similar ideas are used for multi-view learning and for fairness constraints. Sicilia et al. (2022) extended these bounds to multiclass learners.

19.6 Beyond classification: compression, meta-learning, generative models

PAC-Bayes keeps being extended to new settings. *Sample compression*, the other classical route to non-vacuous bounds, is close to the Occam bound of Section 13.4: a predictor that can be reconstructed from a few training examples is certified on the others. Bazinet et al. (2025) extend sample compression bounds to real-valued losses, with the kl comparator as the tightest choice for losses in $[0,1]$, and certify random forests and neural networks trained with a compression procedure. In *meta-learning*, where the prior itself is learned from many related tasks, Riou et al. (2025) show that a Bernstein-type condition always holds at the level of tasks, so that learning the prior costs $O(1/T)$ instead of $O(1/\sqrt{T})$ with T tasks. Finally, PAC-Bayesian bounds now certify *generative* models: Mbacke et al. (2023) bound the distance between the data distribution and the distribution produced by adversarial generative networks.

19.7 Open questions

Several questions raised in this course remain open. The first concerns the relation between tightness and learning. The tightest certificates, such as the kl bounds or the CCPBB bound, are not always the best learning objectives: we saw that minimizing the first-order bound gives an excellent bound on the Gibbs risk and a poor vote. Understanding which bound should be minimized to obtain the best *predictor*, and not only the best certificate, is largely open. The second concerns scale. How should priors be designed for boosted ensembles with thousands of trees, or for ensembles of large neural networks, so that the bounds remain non-vacuous? Compression-based priors (Lotfi et al., 2022) give a partial answer. The third concerns diversity. Second-order bounds formalize the role of diversity in a vote, and one may hope to design ensemble algorithms that optimize the strength–diversity trade-off explicitly, with guarantees, beyond the implicit randomization of random forests. The diversity of deep ensembles is studied from this point of view by Masegosa (2020) and Ortega et al. (2022); see also the surveys on diversity in ensemble learning (Kuncheva and Whitaker, 2003; Brown et al., 2005).

Further reading

For a first contact with PAC-Bayes, the tutorial of Langford (2005) remains an excellent entry point, and the surveys of Guedj (2019) and Alquier (2024) cover the more recent developments, the latter from a statistical perspective. For majority votes, the main references are Germain et al. (2015) for the C-bound, Masegosa et al. (2020) for the tandem bound, Wu et al. (2021) for the Chebyshev–Cantelli family and Viallard et al.

(2021) for self-bounding algorithms. The monograph of Catoni (2007) and the recent monograph of Hellström et al. (2025) are more advanced.

Check your understanding

Short questions to test yourself; the answers are in Appendix A (click on the number of a question to see its answer).

Q19.1. Where does the boundedness of the loss enter the proofs of the PAC-Bayesian bounds of this course?

Q19.2. What is an anytime-valid bound, and why is it useful?

Q19.3. Where does the KL divergence come from in PAC-Bayes, and can it be replaced?

Q19.4. How are PAC-Bayesian bounds related to mutual-information bounds?

Q19.5. What does a disintegrated bound certify that a classical PAC-Bayesian bound does not?

Q19.6. Why is PAC-Bayes well suited to domain adaptation for majority votes?

Q19.7. True or false? The tightest certificate is always obtained by minimizing the tightest bound, and it also gives the best predictor.

Exercises

Exercise 19.1. **(Comprehension)** A practitioner collects examples one at a time, recomputes Seeger's bound with $\delta = 0.05$ after each new example, and stops as soon as the certificate is below a target. Explain why the reported certificate is not guaranteed to hold with probability 0.95. Show that applying the bound for sample size m with confidence $\delta_m = \frac{\delta}{m(m+1)}$ gives a bound valid simultaneously for all $m \geq 8$, and compute the extra cost in nats and the resulting Seeger bound for $m = 1000$, $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0.1$, $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 5$, $\delta = 0.05$.

Exercise 19.2. **(Proof)** Let $\mathcal{H}$ be finite, $S \mapsto Q_S$ a learning rule, and write $\bar{Q} = \mathbb{E}_S Q_S$ for the average posterior. Show that, for any prior P, $\mathbb{E}_S \mathrm{KL}(Q_S\|P) = \mathbb{E}_S \mathrm{KL}(Q_S\|\bar{Q}) + \mathrm{KL}(\bar{Q}\|P)$. Deduce that $\bar{Q}$ minimizes $\mathbb{E}_S \mathrm{KL}(Q_S\|P)$ over data-independent priors, and that the minimum equals the mutual information $I(S;h)$ between the sample and a hypothesis $h \sim Q_S$.

Exercise 19.3. **(Comprehension)** Explain why the disagreement $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$ of a vote can be estimated on unlabeled target examples, whereas its Gibbs risk and its joint error cannot. Suppose that the disagreement measured on unlabeled target data is 0.30 and that the target joint error is (somehow) known to be 0.05: compute the target Gibbs risk and the oracle C-bound on the target risk of the vote.

Exercise 19.4. **(Comprehension)** A certificate $\mathcal{B}$ holds for the Gibbs risk $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$ with probability at least $1-\delta$. A single network $h \sim Q$ is drawn once and deployed. Is $R_{\mathcal{D}}(h) \leq \mathcal{B}$ guaranteed with high probability? Using Markov's inequality over $h \sim Q$, show that $R_{\mathcal{D}}(h) \leq \mathcal{B}/\eta$ with probability at least $1-\delta-\eta$, and compute this guarantee for $\mathcal{B} = 0.05$ and $\eta = 0.1$. What do disintegrated bounds improve?

Exercise 19.5. **(Computation)** An algorithm always outputs one of $K = 4$ classifiers (a Dirac posterior $Q_S = \delta_{h_S}$). Over the random draw of S, it outputs h_1 with probability 0.7 and each of h_2, h_3, h_4 with probability 0.1. (a) Compute $\mathrm{KL}(Q_S\|P)$ for the uniform prior, and for the prior $\bar{Q} = (0.7, 0.1, 0.1, 0.1)$. (b) Compute $\mathbb{E}_S \mathrm{KL}(Q_S\|P)$ in both cases and check the identity of Exercise 19.2. What is $I(S;h)$? (c) Show that, in general, $I(S;h) \leq \ln K$ for a finite class.

Exercise 19.6. **(Python)** Simulate the situation of Exercise 19.1 with a fixed classifier whose losses are i.i.d. Bernoulli(0.5) and the Hoeffding test-set bound $\widehat{R}_n + \sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)/(2n)}$, $\delta = 0.05$, computed after each example for $n = 10, \ldots, 2000$. Over 2000 repetitions, estimate the probability that the bound fails at $n = 2000$, the probability that it fails for at least one n, and the same probability when δ is replaced by $\delta_n = \frac{\delta}{n(n+1)}$.

A Answers to the "Check your understanding" questions

The number of each answer is a link back to its question.

Section 1 Probability Essentials and Concentration Inequalities

Q1.1. False. The equality only says that X and Y are uncorrelated. For X uniform on $\{-1, 0, 1\}$ and $Y = X^2$, $\mathbb{E}[XY] = \mathbb{E}[X^3] = 0 = \mathbb{E}[X]\,\mathbb{E}[Y]$, but Y is a function of X: $\mathbb{P}(X = 0, Y = 1) = 0 \neq \mathbb{P}(X = 0)\,\mathbb{P}(Y = 1) = \frac{2}{9}$.

Q1.2. The number of errors is $\mathrm{Bin}(400, 0.2)$, so the test error $\widehat{p}$ has expectation $p = 0.2$ and variance $p(1-p)/m = 0.16/400 = 4 \times 10^{-4}$, i.e. a standard deviation of 0.02: two percentage points.

Q1.3. A pmf value is the probability $\mathbb{P}(X = x) \leq 1$. A density value is not a probability: only its integrals over intervals are. A density only has to be nonnegative with a total integral equal to 1, so it can be large on a short interval, e.g. $f = 10$ on $[0, 0.1]$ for $\mathcal{U}([0, 0.1])$.

Q1.4. The square root is concave, so $\mathbb{E}[\sqrt{Z}] \leq \sqrt{\mathbb{E}[Z]}$; the exponential is convex, so $e^{\mathbb{E}[X]} \leq \mathbb{E}[e^X]$. Both inequalities are equalities when the variable is almost surely constant.

Q1.5. The training error is not: h_S depends on S, and the training error is typically too optimistic, $\mathbb{E}[\mathcal{R}_S(h_S)] < \mathbb{E}[\mathcal{R}(h_S)]$. The error on a test set T independent of S is unbiased: conditionally on S, h_S is fixed and the test losses are i.i.d. with mean $\mathcal{R}(h_S)$, so $\mathbb{E}[\mathcal{R}_T(h_S) \mid S] = \mathcal{R}(h_S)$.

Q1.6. The law of large numbers says that $\bar{X}_m \to \mu$ (almost surely), without any speed. The central limit theorem describes the size and the shape of the fluctuations: $\bar{X}_m - \mu$ is approximately $\mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2/m)$, so it is of order $\sigma/\sqrt{m}$. Both are asymptotic.

Q1.7. The number of errors is $\mathrm{Bin}(100, 0.01)$, which is very skewed: it equals 0 with probability $0.99^{100} \approx 0.37$, and the mean $mp = 1$ is too small for the Gaussian approximation to be accurate. In particular, when no error is observed, the estimated variance is 0 and the CLT interval reduces to $\{0\}$, which does not contain p.

Q1.8. False. The "$m \geq 30$" rule of thumb is not a theorem: the central limit theorem only gives a limit, and the quality of the approximation for a given m depends on the distribution (it is poor for skewed distributions, see Fig. 4). The probability can be noticeably larger than 0.05.

Q1.9. Markov's inequality applied to X only uses the mean and gives a $1/t$ decay. Applied to the increasing function $e^{\lambda X}$, it uses all the moments of X through the MGF, and the free parameter λ can be optimized for each t; for bounded or Gaussian variables this gives a decay in e^{-ct^2}.

Q1.10. $\sqrt{\ln(2/0.05)/(2 \times 500)} = \sqrt{3.689/1000} \approx 0.061$, i.e. about 6 percentage points.

Q1.11. The sample size $\ln(2/\delta)/(2\varepsilon^2)$ is multiplied by 4 when ε is halved. Replacing δ by $\delta/10$ only adds $\ln 10/(2\varepsilon^2) \approx 1.15/\varepsilon^2$ examples, e.g. from 738 to 1198 for $\varepsilon = 0.05$ and $\delta = 0.05$.

Q1.12. False. They must be independent and bounded, $X_i \in [a_i, b_i]$, but they can have different distributions and different means; the inequality controls $S_m - \mathbb{E}[S_m]$, and the ranges enter through $\sum_i (b_i - a_i)^2$.

Q1.13. Hoeffding's inequality is valid for a hypothesis fixed before seeing S. h_S is chosen because its empirical risk is small, which favours the hypotheses whose empirical risk happens to underestimate their true risk. A bound valid simultaneously for all $h \in \mathcal{H}$ (with probability $1 - \delta$) holds in particular for h_S, whatever the way it was chosen.

Q1.14. The half-width $\sqrt{(\ln K + \ln(2/\delta))/(2m)}$ goes from $\sqrt{(6.91 + 3.69)/20000} \approx 0.023$ to $\sqrt{(13.82 + 3.69)/20000} \approx 0.030$: multiplying the number of hypotheses by 1000 only increases the width by about 30%, because the dependence is in $\sqrt{\ln K}$.

Q1.15. When the variance σ^2 is much smaller than the squared range, $(b-a)^2/4$. For the 0-1 loss of a classifier with a small error rate p, $\sigma^2 = p(1-p) \approx p$: for $p = 0.01$, $m = 1000$, $\delta = 0.05$, the one-sided deviation is about 0.0097 with Bernstein against 0.0387 with Hoeffding.

Q1.16. Changing one coordinate changes the maximum by at most 1, so $c_i = 1$ and McDiarmid gives $\mathbb{P}(f - \mathbb{E}\, f \geq \varepsilon) \leq e^{-2\varepsilon^2/m}$, which is useless for $\varepsilon \leq 1$. McDiarmid is efficient only when every single variable has a small influence, like $1/m$ for averages.

Section 2 Linear Algebra and Convexity

Q2.1. No. It is not absolutely homogeneous, since $\|\lambda\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 = \lambda^2 \|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 \neq |\lambda| \|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2$ when $|\lambda| \neq 0, 1$ and $\mathbf{x} \neq \mathbf{0}$, and it does not satisfy the triangle inequality: with $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{y} = \mathbf{e}_1$, $\|\mathbf{x}+\mathbf{y}\|_2^2 = 4 > 2 = \|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 + \|\mathbf{y}\|_2^2$. It is, however, a convex function.

Q2.2. Onto $(1,0)^T$: $\frac{\langle \mathbf{x},\mathbf{y}\rangle}{\|\mathbf{y}\|_2^2}\mathbf{y} = 2\,(1,0)^T = (2,0)^T$. Onto $(1,1)^T$: $\frac{2+3}{2}(1,1)^T = \frac{5}{2}(1,1)^T = (2.5, 2.5)^T$; indeed $\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{p} = (-0.5, 0.5)^T$ is orthogonal to $(1,1)^T$.

Q2.3. False: the inequality goes the other way. For $\mathbf{x} = (1,1)^T$, $\|\mathbf{x}\|_1 = 2 > \sqrt{2} = \|\mathbf{x}\|_2$. The correct chain is $\|\mathbf{x}\|_\infty \leq \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \leq \|\mathbf{x}\|_1 \leq \sqrt{d}\, \|\mathbf{x}\|_2$ (Exercise 2.3): the L_1 unit ball is the smallest one.

Q2.4. $\|\mathbf{I}_d\|_F = \sqrt{\mathrm{Tr}\,(\mathbf{I}_d)} = \sqrt{d}$. For $\mathbf{x}\mathbf{y}^T$, whose entries are $x_i y_j$, $\left\|\mathbf{x}\mathbf{y}^T\right\|_F^2 = \sum_{i,j} x_i^2 y_j^2 = \|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 \|\mathbf{y}\|_2^2$, so $\left\|\mathbf{x}\mathbf{y}^T\right\|_F = \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \|\mathbf{y}\|_2$.

Q2.5. $f(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_j x_j^2$, so $\partial f/\partial x_i = 2x_i$, *i.e.* $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}) = 2\mathbf{x}$, and $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{x}) = 2\mathbf{I}_d$ for every $\mathbf{x}$ (the second derivatives are 2 on the diagonal and 0 elsewhere).

Q2.6. $f(1,2) = 2$ and $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}) = (2x_1x_2,\ x_1^2)^T = (4,1)^T$ at $(1,2)$, so $f(1.01, 2) \approx 2 + \langle (4,1)^T, (0.01, 0)^T \rangle = 2.04$. The exact value is $1.0201 \times 2 = 2.0402$: the error, 0.0002, is of order h^2 with $h = 0.01$.

Q2.7. The direction of steepest descent is $-\nabla f(1,1)/\|\nabla f(1,1)\|_2$ with $\nabla f(1,1) = (2,6)^T$, *i.e.* $-(1,3)^T/\sqrt{10}$. It is *not* the direction $-(1,1)^T/\sqrt{2}$ of the minimizer: the gradient is orthogonal to the elliptic level set through $(1,1)$, not aimed at its centre. This is why gradient descent zigzags on elongated level sets (Section 3).

Q2.8. The union is not convex in general: $[0,1] \cup [2,3]$ contains 1 and 2 but not 1.5. The intersection always is: if $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in C_1 \cap C_2$, the segment joining them lies in C_1 and in C_2, by convexity of each set.

Q2.9. No: it contains $(1,1)$ and $(-1,-1)$ but not their midpoint $(0,0)$. Its part $\{x_1 > 0,\ x_1 x_2 \geq 1\}$ is convex, however: it is the epigraph of the convex function $x \mapsto 1/x$ on $]0, +\infty[$ (see Proposition 2.4).

Q2.10. The unit square $[0,1]^2$: $(\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2})$ lies inside and is not a vertex. Its writing is not unique: $(\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}) = \frac{1}{2}(0,0) + \frac{1}{2}(1,1) = \frac{1}{2}(1,0) + \frac{1}{2}(0,1) = \frac{1}{4}\big((0,0) + (1,0) + (0,1) + (1,1)\big)$.

Q2.11. Yes, f is convex: it is a norm on $\mathbb{R}$, or the maximum of the two linear functions x and $-x$ (Proposition 2.5). But f is not differentiable at 0, so neither Proposition 2.6 nor Proposition 2.7 applies on $\mathbb{R}$: use the definition or Proposition 2.5.

Q2.12. It is a global minimizer: by Proposition 2.6, $f(\mathbf{v}) \geq f(\mathbf{u}^\star) + \langle \mathbf{0}, \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{u}^\star \rangle = f(\mathbf{u}^\star)$ for all $\mathbf{v}$. It need not be unique: a constant function, or the quadratic form of the middle panel of Figure 17, has a whole set of minimizers. Uniqueness holds if f is strictly convex.

Q2.13. Yes, although it has negative entries: its eigenvalues are 1 (eigenvector $(1,1)^T$) and 3 (eigenvector $(1,-1)^T$), both positive. Equivalently, $\mathbf{z}^T\mathbf{A}\mathbf{z} = 2z_1^2 - 2z_1z_2 + 2z_2^2 = z_1^2 + z_2^2 + (z_1 - z_2)^2 > 0$ for $\mathbf{z} \neq \mathbf{0}$.

Q2.14. $f''(x) = e^x > 0$, so f is (strictly) convex. Since $f'(x) = e^x - 1$ vanishes only at $x = 0$, the first-order condition shows that 0 is the unique global minimizer, with $f(0) = 1$. In particular $e^x \geq 1 + x$ for all x: the exponential lies above its tangent at 0.

Q2.15. Then f is not convex. If $\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u})\mathbf{z} = \mu\mathbf{z}$ with $\mu < 0$ and $\mathbf{z} \neq \mathbf{0}$, the restriction $g(t) = f(\mathbf{u} + t\mathbf{z})$ satisfies $g''(0) = \mathbf{z}^T\nabla^2 f(\mathbf{u})\mathbf{z} = \mu\|\mathbf{z}\|_2^2 < 0$, so g is not convex near 0, and neither is f (Proposition 2.3). One negative eigenvalue at one point is enough.

Q2.16. True. If $f(u) < f(v)$ for some u, v, write v as a convex combination of u and of $w_t = u + t(v - u)$, $t > 1$: $v = (1 - \frac{1}{t})u + \frac{1}{t}w_t$. Convexity gives $f(v) \leq (1 - \frac{1}{t})f(u) + \frac{1}{t}f(w_t)$, *i.e.* $f(w_t) \geq f(u) + t\big(f(v) - f(u)\big) \to +\infty$ as $t \to +\infty$, a contradiction. A nonconstant convex function on $\mathbb{R}$ thus grows at least linearly on one side.

Section 3 Unconstrained and Smooth Convex Optimization

Q3.1. No: $f(\mathbf{x}) = x_1^2 - x_2^2$ has a critical point at $\mathbf{0}$, which is a saddle point; its Hessian $\mathrm{diag}(2, -2)$ has eigenvalues of both signs (Figure 21).

Q3.2. The Hessian is $\begin{pmatrix} 2 & -4 \\ -4 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$, with eigenvalues 6 and -2: $\mathbf{0}$ is a saddle point (along $x_1 = x_2$, $f = -2x_1^2$ decreases; along $x_1 = -x_2$, $f = 6x_1^2$ increases).

Q3.3. That it is inconclusive when the Hessian is only semidefinite: 0 is a global minimum of x^4, a global maximum of $-x^4$, and neither for x^3. Higher-order terms decide.

Q3.4. False: $f(x) = x^3$ has the unique critical point 0, which is not even a local minimum, and f has no minimum at all. The statement becomes true for a convex function that has a critical point.

Q3.5. By the first-order characterization of convexity (Proposition 2.6), $f(\mathbf{v}) \geq f(\mathbf{u}) + \langle\nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{u}\rangle = f(\mathbf{u})$ for all $\mathbf{v}$ as soon as $\nabla f(\mathbf{u}) = \mathbf{0}$.

Q3.6. When $\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}$ is invertible, *i.e.* when $\mathbf{X}$ has rank d (linearly independent columns). The Hessian $2\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X}$ is then positive definite and $\boldsymbol{\theta}^\star = (\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{X})^{-1}\mathbf{X}^T\mathbf{y}$. Otherwise there are infinitely many minimizers.

Q3.7. False: Euler's equation $\mathbf{X}^T(\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{y}) = \mathbf{0}$ is nonlinear in $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ (the probabilities p_i depend on $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ through the sigmoid), so it must be solved iteratively, *e.g.* by gradient descent or Newton's method.

Q3.8. By Cauchy–Schwarz, among the directions $\mathbf{d}$ of a given norm, $\langle\nabla f(\mathbf{u}), \mathbf{d}\rangle$, which drives the first-order decrease of $f(\mathbf{u} - \rho\mathbf{d})$, is maximal for $\mathbf{d}$ proportional to $\nabla f(\mathbf{u})$.

Q3.9. $L = 10$ and $\rho > 2/L = 0.2$: the component u_2 is multiplied by $1 - 10\rho = -2$ at each step, so the algorithm diverges (while u_1 is multiplied by 0.7).

Q3.10. $\rho = 2/(\alpha + L) = 2/11$: the two components are multiplied by $1 - 2/11 = 9/11$ and $1 - 20/11 = -9/11$, so the error is multiplied by $(\kappa - 1)/(\kappa + 1) = 9/11 \approx 0.82$ at each iteration (Exercise 3.4).

Q3.11. The derivative of $\rho \mapsto f(\mathbf{u}_k - \rho\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k))$ vanishes at ρ_k, and this derivative is $-\langle\nabla f(\mathbf{u}_{k+1}), \nabla f(\mathbf{u}_k)\rangle$.

Q3.12. For a strictly convex φ, the graph lies strictly above its tangent at 0, so $\varphi(\rho) \leq \varphi(0) + \rho\varphi'(0)$ never holds for $\rho > 0$: with $c = 1$ no step would be accepted. With $c < 1$, all small enough steps are accepted.

Q3.13. Newton: one, whatever the condition number. Gradient descent: in general infinitely many, with a number of iterations to reach a given accuracy roughly proportional to κ.

Q3.14. False: for $f(x) = \sqrt{1 + x^2}$, $x_{k+1} = -x_k^3$, which diverges as soon as $|x_0| > 1$. Convergence is only local; damping with a line search fixes this.

Q3.15. Gradient descent: its steps are 100 times larger (L is multiplied by 100), so a step that worked may now diverge. Newton's method is unaffected, since $(100\nabla^2 f)^{-1}(100\nabla f) = (\nabla^2 f)^{-1}\nabla f$.

Q3.16. It only uses gradients and costs $\mathcal{O}(d^2)$ per iteration, instead of computing the Hessian and solving a linear system in $\mathcal{O}(d^3)$; L-BFGS even reduces the memory to $\mathcal{O}(d)$.

Section 4 Constrained and Smooth Convex Optimization

Q4.1. The set $\{h = 0\}$ of a convex but nonaffine function is in general not convex (*e.g.* the circle $\|\mathbf{x}\|_2^2 - 1 = 0$), whereas $\{\mathbf{a}^T\mathbf{x} = b\}$ is a hyperplane, hence convex.

Q4.2. No: the constraint reads $g(\mathbf{x}) = 1 - \|\mathbf{x}\|_2 \leq 0$ with g concave, and the feasible set (outside of the open unit ball) is not convex. Every point of the unit sphere is a solution: the minimizer is not unique.

Q4.3. Stationarity gives $\mathbf{x} = -\mu(1,1)$, and the constraint gives $\mu^\star = -1$, so $\mathbf{x}^\star = (1,1)$, at distance $\sqrt{2} = |b|/\|\mathbf{a}\|_2$ from the origin, as in the minimum-norm example.

Q4.4. False in general: $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star) = -\sum_j \mu_j^\star \nabla h_j(\mathbf{x}^\star)$ is only orthogonal to the feasible set. In the previous question, $\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star) = (1,1) \neq \mathbf{0}$.

Q4.5. The dual function is a pointwise infimum of affine functions of $(\boldsymbol{\lambda}, \boldsymbol{\mu})$, hence concave, and the constraint $\boldsymbol{\lambda} \geq \mathbf{0}$ is convex: we maximize a concave function on a convex set.

Q4.6. By weak duality, $3.0 \leq d^\star \leq p^\star \leq 3.2$: the point $\mathbf{x}$ is at most 0.2 above the optimal value. The dual pair is a certificate of accuracy.

Q4.7. False: a constraint qualification is needed. For $\min x$ s.t. $x^2 \leq 0$, the solution $x^\star = 0$ admits no multiplier ($1 + 2\lambda \times 0 = 0$ is impossible); Slater's condition fails.

Q4.8. By complementary slackness, if $\lambda_i^\star > 0$ the constraint is active, $g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star) = 0$ (in the SVM, the example is a support vector). If $g_i(\mathbf{x}^\star) < 0$, then $\lambda_i^\star = 0$ and removing the constraint does not change the solution.

Q4.9. Keeping only the largest component, $2 - \tau = 1$ gives $\tau = 1$, and $0.5 \leq \tau$, $0 \leq \tau$: the projection is $(1, 0, 0)$, a sparse vector.

Q4.10. $\mathbf{z}/\|\mathbf{z}\|_2 = (0.6, 0.8)$ for the ball; $(1, 1)$ for the box. The two projections differ, although both sets contain the same point $(0.6, 0.8)$.

Q4.11. Clipping each coordinate gives $(1, 0)$.

Q4.12. Because the gradient does not vanish at a solution on the boundary of $\mathcal{C}$ (Figure 30); we monitor $\|\mathbf{x}_{k+1} - \mathbf{x}_k\|_2$ instead, which vanishes exactly at the fixed points.

Q4.13. False in general: the iterates of gradient descent may temporarily leave $\mathcal{C}$ (*e.g.* with a large step that overshoots), and the projection then modifies them. Both sequences have the same limit, though, and coincide as long as the gradient steps stay in $\mathcal{C}$.

Q4.14. It is equivalent to $\langle \rho\nabla f(\mathbf{x}^\star), \mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}^\star\rangle \geq 0$ for all $\mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{C}$, and dividing by $\rho > 0$ gives the optimality condition (4.2), which does not depend on ρ.

Q4.15. One gradient evaluation plus a projection by sorting, in $\mathcal{O}(n \ln n)$ operations; the projection is cheap, so the method is well suited to learning the weights of a vote.

Section 5 Introduction

Q5.1. T: playing chess (choosing a move in each position); P: proportion of games won against a given set of opponents (or an Elo rating); E: games already played, *e.g.* against itself, as in Samuel's checkers program.

Q5.2. False. Mitchell's definition requires the performance to *improve with experience*; a program with fixed hand-written rules does not change when more data become available, however good it is.

Q5.3. Not necessarily: more *good* data generally helps, but noisy or unrepresentative data may not, and training "too much" on the same data can even degrade the performance on new data (over-fitting, Section 6).

Q5.4. Because "improving" only makes sense with respect to a criterion: a spam filter may improve its proportion of correctly sorted emails while sending more legitimate emails to the spam folder. Changing P may change which program is considered to learn best.

Q5.5. T: predict whether a user will like a movie (or rank the movies for this user); P: proportion of correct predictions, or proportion of recommended movies that are actually watched; E: the past ratings and viewing histories of the users.

Q5.6. The first one is a regression task, since the output is a real number ($y \in \mathbb{R}$); the second one is a binary classification task ($y \in \{\text{rain}, \text{no rain}\}$, encoded for instance as $\{-1, +1\}$).

Q5.7. $d = 3 \times 64 \times 64 = 12\,288$: one value per pixel and per color channel (R, G and B).

Q5.8. Unsupervised learning, more precisely clustering: no label (no "correct group") is available, and the groups must be discovered from the distribution of the data only.

Q5.9. Because this distribution is unknown: we only have access to a finite sample drawn from it. The error on the distribution can only be estimated (on data that were not used for training) or bounded, which is the subject of Section 6.

Q5.10. False. We observe a finite sample $\{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^m$ drawn from the distribution, not the distribution itself; supervision only means that each observed input comes with its output.

Q5.11. The labels are used only during the training phase, by the learning algorithm, to select the model h. In the prediction phase, the model only needs the feature vector $\mathbf{x}$ of the new input: its label is precisely what we want to predict.

Q5.12. They change with the lighting conditions (brightness), with the viewing angle and with the distance to the camera (apparent size), although the object is the same; the same cat can thus be represented by very different vectors. Good features should be invariant to such nuisance factors.

Q5.13. No. The positive class is, by convention, the class of interest, the one we want to detect (spam, fraud, disease), even if it is an undesirable event.

Q5.14. False. PCA only uses the inputs $\mathbf{x}_i$ (it diagonalizes their covariance matrix) and never uses a label: it is an unsupervised dimension reduction method.

Q5.15. A distribution shift: the habits of the fraudsters (and of the customers) have changed, so that the new data no longer follow the distribution of the training data. The model should be monitored and retrained on recent data.

Q5.16. In reinforcement learning there is no fixed dataset of correct answers: the data are generated by the interaction of the agent with its environment, and the agent only receives a reward (or a punishment), which says how good an action was, not which action was the correct one.

Section 6 Statistical Learning Theory

Q6.1. The 0-1 loss is piecewise constant, hence neither convex nor differentiable, and minimizing the empirical 0-1 risk is NP-hard in general. A convex surrogate leads to a convex problem that can be solved efficiently; the hinge loss $\max(0, 1 - yh(\mathbf{x}))$ is moreover an upper bound on the 0-1 loss.

Q6.2. The errors are 0, 0.5 and -0.5. Squared loss: $(0+0.25+0.25)/3 = 1/6 \approx 0.167$. Absolute loss: $(0 + 0.5 + 0.5)/3 = 1/3 \approx 0.333$.

Q6.3. False. Unbiasedness holds for a hypothesis fixed *before* seeing S. The hypothesis $h_S^\star$ is chosen on S precisely because its empirical risk is small, so its training error is optimistic on average: $\mathbb{E}[\mathcal{R}_S^\ell(h_S^\star)] \leq \mathbb{E}[\mathcal{R}_S^\ell(h_\mathcal{H})] = \mathcal{R}^\ell(h_\mathcal{H}) \leq \mathbb{E}[\mathcal{R}^\ell(h_S^\star)]$, where $h_\mathcal{H}$ is the best hypothesis of $\mathcal{H}$ (Figure 42).

Q6.4. When $\mathcal{H}$ grows, the approximation error decreases (or stays the same) and the estimation error typically increases. The approximation error does not depend on m, whereas the estimation error typically decreases when m grows.

Q6.5. A polynomial of degree d has $d + 1$ coefficients; when $d + 1$ approaches the number m of points, the polynomial can (almost) interpolate the data, noise included. It then oscillates wildly between the training points, so that its error on new points becomes very large although its training error is close to 0.

Q6.6. Because it is an expectation with respect to the distribution $\mathcal{D}$, which is unknown. We use the empirical risk, *i.e.* the average loss on the sample S, which is an unbiased estimate of the true risk for a fixed hypothesis.

Q6.7. No: $h_S^\star$ is chosen on S to have a small empirical risk, so its training error is typically optimistic (Figure 42). This is why we need bounds that hold uniformly over $\mathcal{H}$, or an independent test set.

Q6.8. When $\lambda \to 0$, we recover plain empirical risk minimization over a large class, with a risk of over-fitting. When $\lambda \to \infty$, the parameters are forced towards $\mathbf{0}$ and the model becomes (almost) constant: under-fitting.

Q6.9. $\varepsilon = \sqrt{\ln(2/\delta)/(2m)} = \sqrt{\ln 40/2000} \approx \sqrt{3.69/2000} \approx 0.043$: with probability at least 95%, the true risk is within 4.3 points of the empirical risk.

Q6.10. The deviation term behaves as $1/\sqrt{m}$, so m must be multiplied by 4. Doubling $\ln|\mathcal{H}|$ means squaring $|\mathcal{H}|$, *i.e.* going from 10^3 to 10^6 hypotheses: multiplying $|\mathcal{H}|$ by 1000.

Q6.11. True: ε increases with $\ln(1/\delta)$, so it decreases when δ increases. But the guarantee then holds with a smaller probability $1 - \delta$: precision and confidence must be traded off.

Q6.12. Hoeffding's inequality for variables with range K reads $2e^{-2m\varepsilon^2/K^2}$, so the deviation term is multiplied by K: $\mathcal{R}^\ell(h) \leq \mathcal{R}_S^\ell(h) + K\sqrt{(\ln|\mathcal{H}| + \ln(2/\delta))/(2m)}$.

Q6.13. $d + 1 = 6$, the number of parameters (five weights and a bias).

Q6.14. The first part is true. The second part is false: one must show that *no* set of 4 points can be shattered. For linear classifiers in $\mathbb{R}^2$, four collinear points or the XOR configuration are not shattered, but this is not enough on its own: one must also check the other configurations (a point inside the triangle formed by the other three, or four points in convex position).

Q6.15. On the stability constant β of the algorithm (and on the bound K on the loss); for regularized convex problems, β behaves as $1/\lambda$ (it is $\sigma^2\kappa^2/\lambda$ in the example of the section).

Q6.16. Because it only concerns the hypothesis actually returned by the algorithm: the dependence between $\boldsymbol{\theta}_S$ and S is controlled through stability (replacing one example changes the loss by at most β/m), which implies that the gap $\mathcal{R}^\ell(\boldsymbol{\theta}_S) - \mathcal{R}_S^\ell(\boldsymbol{\theta}_S)$ satisfies the bounded-differences condition of McDiarmid's inequality.

Section 7 Learning Procedure

Q7.1. The selected configuration would be the one that is best on these particular examples, partly by chance: the test score of the selected model would then over-estimate its generalization

performance (see Proposition 11.1), and the test set would in fact have been used as a validation set.

Q7.2. A new model, learned on the whole training set with $\lambda_{i_{\max}}$; none of the 10 models learned during the cross-validation is used.

Q7.3. Over-fitting (high variance): the model fits the learning set much better than new data. One can regularize more, choose a simpler model (*e.g.* a shallower tree), collect more data or use an ensemble method such as bagging.

Q7.4. The means and variances are computed with the validation folds, which therefore influence the model: it is a (usually mild) data leakage. The scaler must be fitted on the learning folds only, *e.g.* by putting it in a pipeline with the model.

Q7.5. $4 \times 3 = 12$ candidate values, each requiring 5 models, *i.e.* 60 models, plus one final model learned on the whole training set with the selected values: 61 models.

Q7.6. False. Its estimate is almost unbiased, but it requires m trainings and its variance can be large, because the m learned models are almost identical and their errors strongly correlated. In practice, $k = 5$ or $k = 10$ is a better trade-off.

Q7.7. Hardly: the gap between the two curves is small and the validation curve no longer increases, so the model under-fits (high bias). One should rather use a more flexible model or better features.

Q7.8. Because it is the maximum of many noisy estimates: the selected configuration is partly the one that was lucky on these folds, so its score is optimistic (Proposition 11.1). The performance must be measured on data that played no role in the selection: a test set or the outer loop of a nested cross-validation.

Q7.9. Accuracy 0.99, Recall 0 and balanced accuracy $(0 + 1)/2 = 0.5$: the balanced accuracy reveals that the classifier is no better than a random guess.

Q7.10. An AUC of 0.5 means that the scores rank a positive example above a negative one only half of the time, as a random ranking does. With very rare positives, even a small False Positive Rate produces many more false alarms than true detections, so that the Precision is low; the AUC, which does not depend on the class proportions, hides this.

Q7.11. $MSE = (4+4+0+0)/4 = 2$, $RMSE = \sqrt{2} \approx 1.41$ and $MAE = (2+2+0+0)/4 = 1$.

Q7.12. False. $R^2 = 1 - MSE_h/MSE_{\bar{y}}$ is negative as soon as the model makes larger squared errors than the constant predictor $\bar{y}$, which can happen on new data (*e.g.* with an over-fitted model). It is only guaranteed to be non-negative on the training set of a least-squares model with an intercept.

Q7.13. Accuracy $= 970/1000 = 0.97$, Recall $= 40/50 = 0.8$, Precision $= 40/60 \approx 0.667$ and $F_1 = 2TP/(2TP + FN + FP) = 80/110 \approx 0.727$.

Q7.14. True: as a harmonic mean, F_1 lies between $\min(\text{Precision}, \text{Recall})$ and $\max(\text{Precision}, \text{Recall})$. It is moreover smaller than their arithmetic mean and closer to the smaller of the two, so a model cannot get a good F_1 with only one of them high.

Q7.15. From $F_\beta = (1 + \beta^2)PR/(\beta^2 P + R)$, with P the Precision and R the Recall: $F_\beta \to P$ when $\beta \to 0$ and $F_\beta \to R$ when $\beta \to +\infty$.

Q7.16. With exp, an increasing function, the ranking of the examples is unchanged, so the ROC curve and the AUC are unchanged. With $-f$, the ranking is reversed: every correctly ranked pair becomes badly ranked, so the AUC becomes $1 - \text{AUC}$ (the curve is reflected through the point $(1/2, 1/2)$).

Section 8 Supervised Algorithms

Q8.1. It is 0 (each training point is its own nearest neighbor, unless two identical inputs have different labels), which says nothing about the test error: the training error of k-NN must not be used to choose k; a validation set or a cross-validation must be used instead.

Q8.2. With two classes and an odd k, the majority vote can never be tied. With an even k, a 2-2 tie must be broken by an arbitrary convention (smallest label, random choice, or the label of the nearest neighbor), which makes the rule less natural.

Q8.3. The edge is $0.1^{1/5} \simeq 0.63$: the "neighborhood" must cover about 63% of the range of every feature to contain only 10% of the points, so it is no longer local. This is the curse of dimensionality, already visible in dimension 5.

Q8.4. The examples correctly classified strictly outside the margin, *i.e.* with $y_i(\langle \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{x}_i \rangle + b) > 1$ (case i) of the KKT analysis). Since $\mathbf{w} = \sum_i \alpha_i y_i \mathbf{x}_i$, they do not contribute to $\mathbf{w}$, and removing them from the training set does not change the solution.

Q8.5. $\gamma = 2/\left\|\mathbf{w}\right\|_2 = 2/\sqrt{9+16} = 2/5 = 0.4$.

Q8.6. False. A larger C penalizes the slack variables more heavily, so the solution tolerates fewer margin violations, at the price of a larger $\left\|\mathbf{w}\right\|_2$, *i.e.* a narrower margin $2/\left\|\mathbf{w}\right\|_2$. It is a small C that favors a wide margin.

Q8.7. The kernel $K(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}')$ is then close to 0 as soon as $\mathbf{x} \neq \mathbf{x}'$: the similarity becomes very local, the boundary wraps around individual training points, most points become support vectors and the model overfits (zero training error, poor test error).

Q8.8. The constrained form minimizes the loss over a ball. The L_1 ball has corners on the axes, where the level sets of the loss typically touch it first, so that some coordinates are exactly 0; the L_2 ball is smooth, so the contact point generally has all its coordinates nonzero (Figure 67).

Q8.9. $Pr(y = 1 \mid \mathbf{x}) = 1/(1 + e^{-\ln 3}) = 1/(1 + 1/3) = 3/4$, and the odds are $Pr(y = 1 \mid \mathbf{x})/Pr(y = 0 \mid \mathbf{x}) = e^{\ln 3} = 3$ ("3 to 1").

Q8.10. With $d = 784$ features and an offset, each vector has $d+1 = 785$ coordinates: $(q-1)(d+1) = 9 \times 785 = 7065$ parameters with a reference class, and $q(d+1) = 7850$ for the softmax version (which is over-parameterized, since the probabilities are invariant to a common shift of the vectors).

Q8.11. The 0-1 loss is neither convex nor continuous in the parameters, and minimizing the empirical 0-1 risk is computationally hard (NP-hard in general, even for linear classifiers). Convex surrogates which upper bound it (hinge, logistic, exponential) can be minimized efficiently, and making them small also makes the 0-1 risk small.

Q8.12. Decision trees: a split $x_j \leq s$ only depends on the order of the values of feature j, which any increasing transformation (in particular standardization or min-max scaling) preserves; the threshold is simply transformed accordingly.

Q8.13. When $\lambda \to +\infty$, all the weights tend to 1, so $h(\mathbf{x})$ tends to the global mean $\frac{1}{m}\sum_i y_i$ (underfitting). When $\lambda \to 0$, the weight of the closest training point dominates all the others exponentially, so $h(\mathbf{x})$ tends to the output of the nearest neighbor of $\mathbf{x}$ (if it is unique): we recover the 1-NN regression rule (overfitting).

Q8.14. $G_N = 1 - 3 \times (1/3)^2 = 2/3$. Yes: $1 - \sum_j p_j^2$ is maximal under $\sum_j p_j = 1$ when all the p_j are equal, and the maximum for L classes is $1 - 1/L$.

Q8.15. The error is 0.2 before the split and $0.5 \times 0 + 0.5 \times 0.4 = 0.2$ after: the error criterion sees no improvement, although a pure node has been created. The Gini gain is $0.32 - 0.5 \times 0.48 = 0.08 > 0$: as a strictly concave function of the proportions, the Gini impurity (or the entropy) rewards splits that increase purity even when the majority classes do not change.

Q8.16. The k-NN rule and kernel regression (the whole training set), and the kernel SVM (the support vectors only). Linear and logistic regression, the linear SVM (through $\mathbf{w}$ and b) and decision trees (through their rules) only store a fixed set of parameters.

Section 9 Neural Networks

Q9.1. False. It stops at the first hyperplane that separates the training set, which depends on the initialization and on the order in which the examples are visited. Novikoff's theorem only bounds the number of updates by R^2/γ^2; maximizing the margin is the job of the SVM.

Q9.2. By Theorem 9.1, at most $R^2/\gamma^2 = 4/0.01 = 400$ updates, whatever the dimension d, the number of examples m and the learning rate α.

Q9.3. A perceptron is a linear classifier, and no line separates the two classes of the **XOR** dataset (Fig. 74). The hidden layer computes a new representation $(x_1 \vee x_2,\, x_1 \wedge x_2)$ of the data, in which the two classes become linearly separable, so that a single output perceptron suffices.

Q9.4. $20 \times (10+1) + 20 \times (20+1) + 3 \times (20+1) = 220 + 420 + 63 = 703$ parameters.

Q9.5. An affine function $\mathbf{x} \mapsto \mathbf{W}\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{b}$ (Proposition 9.2): it has exactly the expressive power of a linear model, whatever its depth and width. Non-linear activations are needed for depth to be useful.

Q9.6. Both are equal, by invariance to the addition of a constant: $(e^1, e^2, e^3)/(e^1 + e^2 + e^3) \approx (0.090,\ 0.245,\ 0.665)$. Computing e^{103} directly may overflow in single precision, which is why we subtract $\max_k z_k$ first.

Q9.7. False. The universal approximation theorem is an existence result with a possibly huge number of hidden units, and it says nothing about learning or generalization. Some functions require exponentially fewer units with a deep network, and deep networks learn hierarchical representations that generalize better in practice.

Q9.8. The loss is $-\ln p_2 = -\ln 0.2 \approx 1.61$ and, by Proposition 9.4, $\nabla_{\mathbf{z}} \ell = \mathbf{p} - \mathbf{e}_2 = (0.7,\ -0.8,\ 0.1)$: the score of the true class is pushed up, the others down, proportionally to their probabilities.

Q9.9. Backpropagation costs a forward and a backward pass, about $3P = 3 \times 10^6$ operations per example. Finite differences require one forward pass per parameter, about $P^2 = 10^{12}$ operations: backpropagation is roughly 300 000 times cheaper.

Q9.10. All the units of a layer would compute the same function and receive the same gradient, so they would remain identical during the whole training (if all the weights are equal to 0, the errors $\boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell)} = \sigma'_\ell(\mathbf{a}^{(\ell)}) \odot (\mathbf{W}^{(\ell+1)\top} \boldsymbol{\delta}^{(\ell+1)})$ of the hidden layers are even exactly zero, so that only the last layer learns). Random initialization breaks this symmetry.

Q9.11. They are multiplied by $1/(1-p) = 1.25$, so that their expectation is unchanged. At test time, all units are kept and nothing else is done.

Q9.12. The variance is $2/n_{\text{in}} = 2/512 \approx 0.0039$, so the standard deviation is $\sqrt{2/512} = 1/16 = 0.0625$.

Q9.13. $(3 \times 3 \times 32 + 1) \times 64 = 18\,496$ parameters. This number does not depend on the size of the images, thanks to weight sharing; only the size of the output feature maps does.

Q9.14. The convolution gives $n' = 32 - 5 + 1 = 28$, and the pooling divides it by 2: the output is 14×14 (per filter).

Q9.15. Its cell state is updated additively, $\mathbf{c}_t = \mathbf{f}_t \odot \mathbf{c}_{t-1} + \mathbf{i}_t \odot \tilde{\mathbf{c}}_t$, so that $\partial \mathbf{c}_t / \partial \mathbf{c}_{t-1}$ contains the term $\text{diag}(\mathbf{f}_t)$ instead of a product $\text{diag}(\tanh')\mathbf{W}$. When the forget gate is close to 1, the gradient flows through many time steps without shrinking, as in a residual connection.

Q9.16. For a fixed generator, the optimal discriminator is $D^*(\mathbf{x}) = p_{\text{data}}(\mathbf{x})/(p_{\text{data}}(\mathbf{x}) + p_G(\mathbf{x}))$. If $p_G = p_{\text{data}}$, then $D^*(\mathbf{x}) = 1/2$ everywhere: the discriminator can do no better than a coin toss.

Section 10 Advanced Supervised Algorithms

Q10.1. By Proposition 10.1, $\mathbb{E}[(y - h(\mathbf{x}))^2] = 0.3^2 + 0.16 + 0.25 = 0.09 + 0.16 + 0.25 = 0.5$. The squared bias (0.09) and the variance (0.16) depend on the algorithm and can be reduced; the noise term (0.25) is the Bayes error: no predictor can remove it.

Q10.2. The hypothesis $h_{\mathcal{H}}$ is fixed and does not depend on S: $\mathcal{R}_S(h_{\mathcal{H}})$ is an average of m *i.i.d.* variables with mean $\mathcal{R}(h_{\mathcal{H}})$ (see Proposition 1.14 in Section 1). The hypothesis h is chosen using S, so the losses $\ell(h(\mathbf{x}_i), y_i)$ are no longer independent variables with mean $\mathcal{R}(h)$: we have to take a supremum over $\mathcal{H}$, which is precisely where the Rademacher complexity comes in.

Q10.3. Both the complexity term $2C/\sqrt{m}$ and the confidence term $\sqrt{\log(1/\delta)/(2m)}$ scale as $1/\sqrt{m}$: multiplying m by 4 divides the guaranteed gap by 2. Dividing it by 10 requires 100 times more data.

Q10.4. The variance: the model is very sensitive to its training sample (it over-fits), while its bias is small. Bagging, or a random forest if the model is a deep tree, is designed precisely to reduce the variance while keeping the bias almost unchanged.

Q10.5. A given example is never drawn in m draws with probability $(1 - 1/m)^m \to e^{-1} \simeq 0.37$. Hence about $1 - e^{-1} \simeq 63\%$ of the distinct examples appear in the bootstrap sample (some of them several times), and the remaining 37% are out-of-bag.

Q10.6. To decorrelate the trees. For T models with variance σ^2 and pairwise correlation ρ, the variance of their average is $\rho\sigma^2 + (1 - \rho)\sigma^2/T$: adding trees only kills the second term, and only a smaller ρ decreases the first one. Trees grown on bootstrap samples of the same dataset look alike, since they all split first on the most informative features.

Q10.7. False. Adding trees only reduces the Monte Carlo variability of the average: the test error decreases and reaches a plateau (Figure 96). Over-fitting in a forest is controlled by the depth of the trees, by p' and by m', not by T. This is the opposite of boosting, where T must be chosen by early stopping.

Q10.8. If $\varepsilon_t = 1/2$, then $\alpha_t = \frac{1}{2}\ln 1 = 0$: h_t is no better than random guessing and is ignored in the vote (the weights of the examples do not change either, since $Z_t = 1$). If $\varepsilon_t < 1/2$, the weights of the misclassified examples are multiplied by $e^{\alpha_t}/Z_t = \sqrt{(1 - \varepsilon_t)/\varepsilon_t} \,/\, \big(2\sqrt{\varepsilon_t(1 - \varepsilon_t)}\big) = 1/(2\varepsilon_t) > 1$, *e.g.* by 5 when $\varepsilon_t = 0.1$.

Q10.9. It is not useless: $-h_t$ has a weighted error of 0.2. AdaBoost computes $\alpha_t = \frac{1}{2}\ln(0.2/0.8) = -\ln 2 < 0$, so that $\alpha_t h_t = (\ln 2)(-h_t)$: the classifier is used with its predictions reversed, and $Z_t = 2\sqrt{0.8 \times 0.2} = 0.8 < 1$ still decreases the bound. Only $\varepsilon_t = 1/2$ carries no information.

Q10.10. These predictions are over-optimistic (a deep tree or a 1-NN classifier has a zero training error). The meta-model would give a large weight to the base learners that best memorize the data, which are not the ones that generalize best. It must be trained on predictions made on examples that the base learners have not seen: a validation set or, better, the out-of-fold predictions of the Super Learner.

Q10.11. Since $-\partial\ell/\partial H = y - H$, the pseudo-residuals are the ordinary residuals $y_i - H_{t-1}(\mathbf{x}_i)$. No: unlike bagging, each round decreases the training loss, and boosting eventually fits the noise; T is chosen by early stopping on a validation set, together with the learning rate ν (Figure 101).

Q10.12. We get $1 - 0.9 = 0.1$ and $1 - 0.1 = 0.9$. The second example, which is misclassified, has a pseudo-residual 9 times larger, and drives the least-squares fit of the next weak learner. As

AdaBoost, gradient boosting focuses on the badly predicted examples, but the pseudo-residuals of the logistic loss are bounded by 1, whereas the weights of AdaBoost can grow exponentially.

Q10.13. Here $g(\mathbf{x}_i) = \hat{y}_i^{(t-1)} - y_i$ and $h(\mathbf{x}_i) = 1$, so that, by (10.6), the value of the leaf is $\sum_i (y_i - \hat{y}_i^{(t-1)})/(|I_j| + \lambda)$: $6/3 = 2$ (the mean residual) for $\lambda = 0$, and $6/4 = 1.5$ for $\lambda = 1$. The regularization shrinks the leaf values towards 0, all the more as the leaf contains few examples.

Q10.14. We have $d_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = |x_1 - x_1'|$: it is a pseudo-distance, but not a distance, since two distinct points with the same first coordinate are at distance 0 ($\mathbf{M}$ is PSD but singular). One can take $\mathbf{L} = (1 \;\; 0) \in \mathbb{R}^{1\times 2}$: the metric projects the data onto the first axis and discards the second feature.

Q10.15. False. Standardization amounts to using the Mahalanobis distance with $\mathbf{M} = \mathrm{diag}(1/s_1^2, \ldots, 1/s_d^2)$: it solves the scale problem, but it does not use the labels, so a noisy feature receives the same importance as an informative one. A supervised method such as LMNN can shrink the irrelevant directions (down to 0 when $\mathbf{M}$ is singular).

Q10.16. Optimizing over $\mathbf{L}$ removes the PSD constraint, hence the eigenvalue decomposition (of cost $O(d^3)$) needed by the projection at each iteration, and a rectangular $\mathbf{L} \in \mathbb{R}^{r\times d}$ directly performs a dimensionality reduction. But the objective, which is convex (piecewise linear) in $\mathbf{M}$, becomes a non-convex function of $\mathbf{L}$, since $d^2_{\mathbf{M}}(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') = \|\mathbf{L}(\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{x}')\|_2^2$ is quadratic in $\mathbf{L}$ and appears with a minus sign in the push term: we lose the guarantee of reaching a global minimum.

Section 11 Applications and Learning in Practice

Q11.1. 5 binary features (or 4 if one modality is dropped as a reference, which avoids a redundant column in a linear model with an intercept). The encoding $1, \ldots, 5$ introduces an order and distances between the modalities (modality 5 would be "five times" modality 1), which are meaningless for a nominal feature.

Q11.2. False. The splits of a decision tree only depend on the order of the values of each feature, which is not changed by an increasing affine transformation. Standardization matters for distance-based methods, gradient-based methods and penalized models.

Q11.3. The mean of the target over this single example is 1: the encoded feature reveals the label of the example, so the model learns "this feature equal to 1 means fraud" on the training set, which does not generalize. Target encodings must be computed out-of-fold (and smoothed towards the global mean for rare modalities).

Q11.4. Because the fact that a value is missing can itself be informative (values are often not missing at random, *e.g.* a field left empty by a fraudster); after imputation by the mean or the median, this information would be lost.

Section 12 Why PAC-Bayes for ensemble methods?

Q12.1. Its weights $\alpha_t = \frac{1}{2} \ln \frac{1-\varepsilon_t}{\varepsilon_t}$ are non-negative as soon as the weak learners are better than random ($\varepsilon_t \leq \frac{1}{2}$), and dividing them by their positive sum does not change the sign of the vote; the normalized weights $Q(h_t) = \alpha_t / \sum_s \alpha_s$ are non-negative and sum to one.

Q12.2. About 19% for the Gibbs classifier (a tree drawn at random, i.e. the average test error of the trees) and 4.4% for the vote of the 100 trees.

Q12.3. The posterior may depend on the sample in any way (it is typically the output of the learning algorithm). The prior must be fixed before seeing the sample used in the bound: it must not depend on it.

Q12.4. For a fixed sign vector, the correlation $\frac{1}{m} \sum_i \sigma_i f(x_i)$ is linear in f, so its supremum over weighted averages of voters is reached at a single voter (Exercise 12.2).

Q12.5. By (12.1), $\rho\sigma^2 + (1-\rho)\sigma^2/T \to \rho\sigma^2 = 0.2$: only the non-shared part of the error is averaged out.

Q12.6. False. If the errors fall on the same points the vote keeps them, and it can even be worse than its voters, up to a factor 2 (Section 16). The vote gains only when the errors are spread over different points (Fig. 109).

Q12.7. The vote errs when at least 3 voters err: $\mathbb{P}(\mathrm{Bin}(5, 0.3) \geq 3) = 10(0.3)^3(0.7)^2 + 5(0.3)^4(0.7) + (0.3)^5 \approx 0.163$.

Q12.8. It predicts by drawing a new voter $h \sim Q$ for each input and returning $h(x)$. Its error probability is therefore $\mathbb{E}_{h\sim Q} R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)$, a Q-weighted average of the risks of the voters.

Q12.9. It is divided by 2, since it decreases as $1/\sqrt{m}$.

Q12.10. Margin bounds for votes, although independent of the number of voters, are almost always larger than one for realistic sample sizes; and a uniform bound pays the complexity of the whole class whatever has been learned, ignoring whether Q stays close to a choice that could have been made before seeing the data.

Q12.11. False. The guarantee is frequentist: it holds for any data distribution $\mathcal{D}$ and for any posterior, which need not be the Bayesian one; only the vocabulary (prior, posterior) is borrowed from Bayesian statistics.

Q12.12. Yes: the price is $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$, which is finite for many pairs of continuous distributions (e.g. two Gaussians), whereas the cardinality of $\mathcal{H}$ never appears.

Q12.13. $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = \ln \frac{100}{10} \approx 2.30$, and $\ln \frac{2\sqrt{1000}}{0.05} \approx 7.14$, so the complexity term is $\sqrt{(2.30 + 7.14)/2000} \approx 0.069$.

Section 13 Mathematical toolbox

Q13.1. Because the variance $p(1-p)$ of a Bernoulli variable is small when its mean is small, and the kl adapts to it, whereas Hoeffding's inequality pays for the worst-case variance $\frac{1}{4}$. By the refined Pinsker inequality, the width of the kl interval is of order ε instead of $\sqrt{\varepsilon}$ when $\hat{q}$ is close to 0, i.e. of order $1/m$ instead of $1/\sqrt{m}$.

Q13.2. By Markov's inequality, $\mathbb{P}(Z \geq 0.2) \leq 0.02/0.2 = 0.1$, whatever the distribution of Z.

Q13.3. $\sqrt{\ln(1/0.05)/2000} = \sqrt{2.996/2000} \approx 0.039$, whatever the value of $\hat{p}$.

Q13.4. An expectation can be averaged over voters drawn from the prior and exchanged with the expectation over the sample (Fubini), whereas a tail probability for each voter cannot be combined in this way without a union bound. Maurer's lemma gives $\mathbb{E}e^{m\,\mathrm{kl}(\hat{p}\|p)} \leq 2\sqrt{m}$ for every fixed voter, hence also on average over P.

Q13.5. True: by Pinsker's inequality, $\mathrm{kl}(q\|p) \leq \varepsilon$ implies $2(p-q)^2 \leq \varepsilon$ (Lemma 13.5).

Q13.6. $\mathrm{kl}(0\|p) = -\ln(1-p)$, so $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(0, \varepsilon) = 1 - e^{-\varepsilon} \leq \varepsilon$: with no observed error, the certificate is of order ε (fast rate).

Q13.7. $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = \sum_{h\in \mathrm{supp}\, Q} \frac{1}{k} \ln \frac{1/k}{1/n} = \ln \frac{n}{k}$ (for instance $\ln 10 \approx 2.3$ nats for a tenth of the voters).

Q13.8. For the Gibbs distribution $Q_\phi \propto Pe^{\phi}$, and only for it: the gap in (13.2) is exactly $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|Q_\phi)$.

Q13.9. Its description length $\ln \frac{1}{P(h)}$ under the prior, which is also $\mathrm{KL}(\delta_h\|P)$, the divergence of the Dirac posterior. With the uniform prior it is $\ln|\mathcal{H}|$.

Q13.10. No: $\mathrm{kl}(0.1\|0.2) \approx 0.037$ while $\mathrm{kl}(0.2\|0.1) \approx 0.044$; and with P uniform on 4 voters and $Q = (\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{4}, 0)$, $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = \frac{1}{2}\ln 2$ is finite whereas $\mathrm{KL}(P\|Q) = +\infty$.

Q13.11. When Q is not absolutely continuous with respect to P, for instance when Q puts mass on voters to which the prior gives probability zero. A prior must therefore cover every region where the posterior may want to go.

Q13.12. $\frac{\|\mu_1-\mu_0\|^2}{2} = 4.5$ nats, whatever the dimension d.

Q13.13. False. It is a deterministic inequality, valid for every Q simultaneously; this is precisely why the posterior may be chosen after seeing the data. Only P has to be fixed in advance, for the probabilistic step that controls $\ln \mathbb{E}_P e^{\phi}$.

Q13.14. A union bound over the countable class, with the confidence budget δ split into shares $\delta P(h)$.

Q13.15. Any probability on an uncountable set gives probability zero to all but countably many hypotheses, so $\ln \frac{1}{P(h)} = +\infty$ for most of them (and for all of them if P has a density). PAC-Bayes avoids this by averaging over posteriors with a density.

Section 14 PAC-Bayesian generalization bounds

Q14.1. The third step, where Markov's inequality is applied to $Z(S) = \mathbb{E}_{h\sim P} e^{m\Delta(\widehat{R}_S(h), R_{\mathcal{D}}(h))}$ and the expectations over the sample and over the prior are exchanged: this exchange, and the bound on $\mathcal{I}_\Delta(m)$ voter by voter, require P to be fixed before S is drawn.

Q14.2. Because the posterior only appears in the first two steps, which are deterministic inequalities valid for every Q; the single probabilistic event of the proof does not depend on Q.

Q14.3. Seeger's bound: for $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) = 0$ it equals $1 - e^{-\varepsilon} \le \varepsilon$ with $\varepsilon = \frac{1}{m}[\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) + \ln \frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}]$, whereas McAllester's bound is $\sqrt{\varepsilon/2}$, of order $1/\sqrt{m}$ (up to logarithms).

Q14.4. The PAC-Bayes-λ bound is a deterministic consequence of Seeger's bound, true for all λ on the same event, whereas in the Hoeffding-based bound λ defines the function Δ, hence the event of probability $1-\delta$: each λ gives a different event, and a data-dependent choice requires a union bound over a grid.

Q14.5. $\varepsilon = 0.01$ and $\overline{\mathrm{kl}}^{-1}(0, 0.01) = 1 - e^{-0.01} \approx 0.00995$, whereas McAllester's bound gives $\sqrt{0.005} \approx 0.071$.

Q14.6. Because the learner chooses its output after looking at the data. A bound valid for one predictor fixed in advance, applied to the selected one, ignores the selection: in Fig. 124 the best of 1000 random classifiers looks much better than it is, and the naive bound fails in 99.8% of the runs.

Q14.7. $\mathcal{I}_\Delta(m) = \mathbb{E}_{S'}\mathbb{E}_{h\sim P} e^{m\Delta(\widehat{R}_{S'}(h), R_{\mathcal{D}}(h))}$ is an exponential moment of the deviation of voters drawn from the prior; it only involves P and voters fixed in advance, so it can be bounded voter by voter with a concentration inequality (e.g. $\le 2\sqrt{m}$ for $\Delta = \mathrm{kl}$).

Q14.8. In the first step (Jensen's inequality), to bound Δ evaluated at the averages $(\widehat{R}_S(G_Q), R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q))$ by the Q-average of $\Delta(\widehat{R}_S(h), R_{\mathcal{D}}(h))$.

Q14.9. A parameter C that must be fixed before seeing the data; choosing it in a grid of k values fixed in advance costs $\ln k$ nats through a union bound.

Q14.10. Dividing δ by 10 adds $\ln 10 \approx 2.3$ nats to the numerator of the complexity term, which is small compared with typical KL values.

Q14.11. False. It is derived from Seeger's bound by relaxations (refined Pinsker, then the arithmetic-geometric inequality), so it is always at least as large; its advantage is its linear form, convenient for optimization.

Q14.12. To concentrating all the mass on one voter among $e^{50} \approx 5 \times 10^{21}$, or uniformly on a fraction e^{-50} of them.

Q14.13. $\sqrt{\ln(2\sqrt{1000}/0.05)/2000} = \sqrt{7.14/2000} \approx 0.060$, which is the first row of Table 9 $(0.180 - 0.12)$.

Section 15 Posteriors, priors and the computation of the bounds

Q15.1. When $\lambda \to 0$ it tends to the prior: nothing is learned and the KL vanishes. When $\lambda \to \infty$ it concentrates on the empirical risk minimizers (uniformly, for a uniform prior on a finite class), and its KL tends to $\ln \frac{|\mathcal{H}|}{k}$ with k the number of minimizers: we recover the Occam bound.

Q15.2. Conditionally on the part S_{prior} used to learn it, the prior is fixed, which is all the proof needs. The bound must then be computed on the other part $S \setminus S_{\text{prior}}$ only, with $m = |S \setminus S_{\text{prior}}|$.

Q15.3. Because the estimate $\frac{1}{N}\sum_j \widehat{R}_S(h_j)$ is itself random: its deviation from the exact empirical Gibbs risk must be controlled (Chernoff's bound for the N i.i.d. draws), at the price of a second confidence level δ'; the certificate then holds with probability $1 - \delta - \delta'$.

Q15.4. Bounding the risk of the majority vote through the Gibbs risk and second-order quantities (Section 16); margin arguments, when Q is concentrated around a hypothesis with a large margin; disintegrated bounds, which hold for a single hypothesis drawn once from Q.

Q15.5. $e^{-\lambda \times 2} = e^{-1} \approx 0.37$: each extra training error multiplies the relative weight by $e^{-\lambda}$.

Q15.6. False in general. It minimizes the *linear* objective $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q) + \frac{\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)}{\lambda m}$, hence the linear bounds; Seeger's bound is a non-linear function of $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q)$ and $\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P)$. In practice one minimizes Seeger's bound over the family $(Q_\lambda)_\lambda$, which gives a very good, but not always optimal, posterior.

Q15.7. Yes, without any correction: λ only indexes posteriors, and Seeger's bound holds for all posteriors simultaneously. (By contrast, the parameter λ of the Hoeffding-based bound enters the probabilistic event and must be fixed in advance or chosen in a grid with a union bound.)

Q15.8. The Bayesian posterior $Q_1(\theta) \propto P(\theta)\prod_i p(y_i|x_i,\theta)$, and the minimal value of the objective is minus the log marginal likelihood divided by m. The guarantee, however, requires extra assumptions since the log-loss is unbounded.

Q15.9. $\frac{8^2}{2} = 32$ nats and $\frac{1}{2}$ nat: the KL only depends on the distance between the centres.

Q15.10. A larger fraction gives better voters or a better-centred prior, hence a smaller empirical risk or KL, but leaves fewer examples for the bound, whose complexity per example $\frac{1}{m}[\mathrm{KL} + \ln\frac{2\sqrt{m}}{\delta}]$ grows. On the example of Fig. 134, a fifth to a third of the data was a good compromise.

Q15.11. Yes: only independence from the sample S used by the bound is required. A distribution-dependent prior such as $P \propto e^{-\beta R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)}$ is legitimate, but the resulting bound contains unknown quantities which must be bounded further.

Q15.12. The width of the Monte Carlo confidence interval on $\widehat{R}_S(G_Q)$ shrinks with N (its budget is $\ln(2/\delta')/N$), so the plug-in upper bound approaches the exact empirical Gibbs risk; only the halved confidence level remains as a (small) price.

Section 16 From the Gibbs classifier to the majority vote

Q16.1. $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = \mathbb{P}_{\mathcal{D}}(W_Q \geq \frac{1}{2})$, a tail probability, and $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = \mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{D}} W_Q$, the first moment of W_Q (Equation (16.1)).

Q16.2. It only uses the mean of W_Q, which does not tell whether the errors of the voters fall on the same examples or on different ones. For a given Gibbs risk, the vote can be perfect or almost twice as bad as an average voter (Fig. 138), and the bound must cover the worst case.

Q16.3. False. The Gibbs risk is then 0.3 whatever Q, and the first-order bound only guarantees $R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) \leq 0.6$; this value is reached when $W_Q \in \{0, \frac{1}{2}\}$ (ties counted as errors), and the middle panel of Fig. 138 gives a vote of risk 0.58.

Q16.4. $\mathbb{P}(\mathrm{Bin}(3, 0.3) \geq 2) = 3(0.3)^2(0.7) + (0.3)^3 = 0.216 < 0.3$. The vote only errs when at least two voters err at the same time, and independence makes such coincidences rarer than individual errors.

Q16.5. The disagreement $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) = \mathbb{E}\,\mathbb{P}_x(h(x) \neq h'(x))$: whether two voters disagree on x does not depend on y. The joint error needs to know whether both voters err, hence the label.

Q16.6. The joint error is the Gibbs risk of the posterior $Q^2 = Q \otimes Q$ on pairs of voters, compared with the prior P^2, and $\mathrm{KL}(Q^2 \| P^2) = 2\,\mathrm{KL}(Q \| P)$ because the KL divergence is additive for product distributions.

Q16.7. When $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) < R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$, i.e. when the disagreement is smaller than the Gibbs risk: the voters are strongly correlated and the second-order information does not help (Proposition 16.7).

Q16.8. First order: 0.4. Joint error: $e_{\mathcal{D}} = 0.2 - 0.15 = 0.05$, so the tandem bound is 0.2. C-bound: $1 - \frac{0.6^2}{1-0.6} = 1 - 0.9 = 0.1$. Since $d \geq R$, the order $\mathcal{C}_Q \leq 4e_{\mathcal{D}} \leq 2R$ is the one predicted by Proposition 16.7.

Q16.9. It applies Cantelli's inequality to the margin with $a = \mathbb{E}M_Q = 1 - 2R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$, which must be positive. If $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) \geq \frac{1}{2}$, the average margin is non-positive and nothing prevents the vote from erring on more than half of the examples.

Q16.10. False. The comparison holds for the oracle quantities. Estimated from data, the C-bound needs two kl inversions (with a union bound) and a ratio that amplifies their errors; on the running example its certificate (0.559) is worse than the tandem certificate (0.387).

Q16.11. μ is the centre around which the deviation of W_Q is measured, through $\mathbb{E}(W_Q - \mu)^2$. The value $\mu = 0$ gives the tandem bound, and the optimal value $\mu^\star = \frac{R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)/2 - e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)}{1/2 - R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)}$ gives the C-bound.

Q16.12. Because it keeps increasing the margins M_Q of the training examples. The margin bound involves $\mathbb{P}_S(M_Q \leq \theta)$ for $\theta > 0$, which keeps decreasing even when $\mathbb{P}_S(M_Q \leq 0) = 0$.

Q16.13. Then $W_Q \in \{0, 1\}$, $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) = 0$, $e_{\mathcal{D}}(Q) = R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q) = R_{\mathcal{D}}(B_Q) = R$. The bounds are $2R$, $4R$ and $\mathcal{C}_Q = 4R(1 - R)$: all are loose, and the first-order bound is the best of the three, as predicted since $d = 0 \leq R$.

Q16.14. $c^Q(B_Q)$ is the average of W_Q over the examples on which the vote errs, and the vote errs only where $W_Q \geq \frac{1}{2}$.

Q16.15. The oracle comparison uses the exact values of $R_{\mathcal{D}}(G_Q)$ and $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$. The certificate replaces them by an upper and a lower confidence bound, each at level $\delta/2$, and the C-bound is very sensitive to both (it is a ratio in which $1 - 2\underline{d}$ can be small), so the estimation errors are amplified.

Q16.16. False. Diversity helps for a *fixed* Gibbs risk, but in practice more diversity is usually obtained with weaker voters; in Fig. 145, the risk of the vote is minimal for an intermediate value of `max_features`, not for the most diverse forest.

Section 17 Self-bounding learning

Q17.1. Because the bound holds on an event that does not depend on the posterior: on this event, it holds for all Q simultaneously, in particular for the minimizer (Theorem 17.2).

Q17.2. The temperature is free, since it only indexes posteriors that are all covered by the same bound. C in Catoni's bound is not, since it changes the comparison function, hence the probabilistic event; it must be chosen on a grid fixed in advance, with a union bound.

Q17.3. Each certificate is computed with δ/K instead of δ, i.e. $\ln K$ is added to the numerator of the complexity term (Proposition 17.3).

Q17.4. $\ln 20 \approx 3.0$ nats, so the complexity term ε increases by 0.003; near $\hat{q} = 0.1$ and $\varepsilon = 0.05$, this increases a Seeger certificate by about $1.43 \times 0.003 \approx 0.004$ (Proposition 17.6).

Q17.5. False. The minimizer depends on the sample, which biases its empirical risk downwards: in Fig. 124 the naive bound fails in almost all the runs. A union bound over the 1000 candidates (the Occam bound) restores validity at the price of $\ln 1000$.

Q17.6. The hold-out certificate is tighter (no KL term, no factor between the Gibbs risk and the vote) and applies to any predictor. The self-bounding certificate uses all the data for learning, provides a learning objective with a guarantee and makes model selection almost free.

Q17.7. The posterior may use the whole sample $S_1 \cup S_2$, since the bound holds for all posteriors. The prior must not depend on S_2, the sample on which the empirical term is computed.

Q17.8. It is the Occam (or Seeger-type) bound with the prior and the posterior both equal to the Dirac mass on the fixed predictor f: the KL term vanishes and only $\ln \frac{1}{\delta}$ remains.

Q17.9. Every posterior is certified by the bound (Theorem 17.2), including the one reached after any number of iterations, even if the stopping time depends on the data. A poor optimization only gives a looser certificate, never a wrong one.

Q17.10. Positive: $\frac{p(1-p)}{p-q} > 0$ since $p > q$. Any increase of the complexity term (more KL, fewer examples, smaller δ) increases the certificate; at $\hat{q} = 0.1$, $\varepsilon = 0.05$, one more nat of KL with $m = 1000$ costs about 0.0014.

Q17.11. The relaxations (McAllester, PAC-Bayes-λ, quadratic) are upper bounds on the kl form, which is the tightest valid bound for the posterior found; since the certificate is valid whatever the optimized objective, we lose nothing by reporting the kl form.

Q17.12. The softmax maps any $\theta \in \mathbb{R}^n$ to a probability vector with positive weights, which removes the simplex constraint, keeps the KL term finite and allows an unconstrained gradient method.

Q17.13. The prior is a distribution over trees that were built with the examples of the bound, so it depends on the data; moreover the empirical risks of the trees on their own training examples are strongly biased (often zero). The bound is not valid; one must use a split or the out-of-bag construction.

Q17.14. False. It is a high-probability *upper bound*, systematically larger than the true risk (for majority votes, often several times larger); it should be reported next to the test error, not instead of it.

Section 18 Self-bounding algorithms for ensembles and beyond

Q18.1. Conditionally on its bootstrap sample, a tree is fixed and its out-of-bag examples form an i.i.d. sample independent of it; the prior is put on the indices of the trees, which are fixed in advance (Theorem 18.1).

Q18.2. The bound ignores the correlations of the errors: it concentrates the weights on the few trees with the smallest OOB loss, which are similar, and the vote loses its diversity (two effective trees in Table 11).

Q18.3. $(1 - \frac{1}{m})^m \approx e^{-1} \approx 0.37$ and $(1 - \frac{1}{m})^{2m} \approx e^{-2} \approx 0.14$; with size $m/2$, $e^{-1/2} \approx 0.61$ and $e^{-1} \approx 0.37$.

Q18.4. The proof needs a common exponent n_0 for all voters: Maurer's lemma bounds $\mathbb{E}e^{|T_t|\,\mathrm{kl}}$ for each tree, and Jensen's inequality transfers it to $\mathbb{E}e^{n_0\,\mathrm{kl}}$ only when $n_0 \leq |T_t|$ for every t.

Q18.5. Its empirical term $\rho^\top \widehat{\mathbf{L}}\rho$ is quadratic: putting a lot of weight on two similar trees pays for their joint errors, while spreading the weight over trees that err on different examples decreases it. Diversity is rewarded.

Q18.6. The targeted first moment of the margin, $\widehat{\mathbb{E}}_S M_Q = \mu$; it trades the strength of the vote against the variance of its margin and acts as a regularization parameter.

Q18.7. Any vote can be represented by a quasi-uniform posterior with the same predictions, so nothing is lost, and the PAC-Bayesian bounds hold for such posteriors without the KL term, so the empirical C-bound itself is controlled.

Q18.8. MinCq weights a fixed set of voters by solving a quadratic program; CB-Boost builds the vote greedily, adding one voter per round with a closed-form optimal weight that decreases the empirical C-bound.

Q18.9. The KL divergence $\mathrm{KL}(Q_{\mathbf{w}}\|P) = \frac{1}{2}\|\mathbf{w}\|^2$ between the Gaussian posterior and the standard Gaussian prior.

Q18.10. A sampled classifier $\mathbf{v}$ is right on x with probability $\Phi(\langle \mathbf{w}, x\rangle / \|x\|)$, which is above $\frac{1}{2}$ exactly when $\langle \mathbf{w}, x\rangle > 0$: the majority of the voters agrees with $\mathrm{sign}\langle \mathbf{w}, x\rangle$.

Q18.11. The probit loss is bounded and its derivative φ vanishes for large negative margins: badly misclassified points (often mislabelled) are eventually ignored, whereas the hinge loss gives them a constant pull.

Q18.12. That the Gibbs risk can be useless to certify a vote: individually, the voters are almost random, but their errors are spread so that the vote is excellent. Only bounds that see the correlations of the errors (second-order bounds) can certify such a vote.

Q18.13. With a prior centred on the random initialization, the distance $\|\boldsymbol{\mu} - \boldsymbol{\mu}_0\|$ is large compared with σ_0 and the KL is huge (thousands of nats). Centring the prior on a network trained on part of the data makes it close to the posterior, hence a small KL.

Q18.14. False: a deep ensemble is a majority vote, but the networks were trained on the training set; the empirical losses must be computed on examples that the networks did not see (a held-out sample, or out-of-bag examples if each network is trained on a subsample).

Section 19 Further topics and recent advances

Q19.1. Only in the control of the exponential moment $\mathcal{I}_\Delta(m)$ in the third step of the proof of Theorem 14.1 (through Hoeffding's lemma or Maurer's lemma). For unbounded losses, this step requires assumptions on the tails of the loss.

Q19.2. A bound that holds with probability $1-\delta$ simultaneously for all sample sizes m. It remains valid if the data are collected sequentially and the experimenter decides when to stop by looking at the bound, which is the situation of online learning and sequential decision-making.

Q19.3. From the change of measure (Donsker–Varadhan) inequality (13.2). Other changes of measure give other divergences: Rényi or f-divergences, strongly convex regularizers, coin-betting divergences, or the Wasserstein distance.

Q19.4. Averaging a PAC-Bayesian bound over the sample and taking as prior the average posterior $\mathbb{E}_S Q_S$, the best data-independent prior in expectation, turns $\mathbb{E}_S \mathrm{KL}(Q_S\|P)$ into the mutual information $I(S;h)$ between the sample and the output of the algorithm.

Q19.5. The risk of the single hypothesis $h \sim Q_S$ that is actually drawn and deployed, with high probability over the joint draw of S and h, instead of the average risk $\mathbb{E}_{h\sim Q_S} R_{\mathcal{D}}(h)$ of the randomized predictor.

Q19.6. Because the disagreement $d_{\mathcal{D}}(Q)$, which together with the Gibbs risk controls the vote, can be computed on unlabeled target examples; the difference of disagreements between source and target then measures the divergence between the domains.

Q19.7. False. Minimizing the first-order bound gives an excellent certificate on the Gibbs risk and a poor vote (Section 18); which bound to minimize to obtain the best predictor, and not only the best certificate, is an open question.

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